

"The Awakener," inspires by challenging the everyday perception of
Acquainting the reader with the timeless wisdom of a contemporary yogi,
immortality.

this narrative reveals the true nature of samadhi and the path to
with the idealized portrayals of yogis so often found in spiritual literature,
Alchemy of yogis in language accessible to uninitiated readers. By contrast
The book illuminates the mysteries of Creation, Time, the Void, and the
Mahasaya.

twenty-first century, the ancient tradition of Mahavata Barahi and Gauri
the extraordinary life-path of a modern yogi who continues, in the
Yoga, Shailendra Sharma — "The Awakener," — introduces the reader to
This new, captivating, authorized biography of the fifth Guru of Kriya
power of Kriya Yoga — but the story of Kriya does not end there.

"Autobiography of a Yogi," introduced millions to the transforming
fortune. The world-renowned bestseller of Paramahansa Yogananda,
this, an encounter with a realized yogi remains a rare stroke of good
Annotation Today yoga has become a global phenomenon, yet despite

http://www.litres.ru/pages/biblio-book/?art=71303458 self-up: 5054

Katya Mossin The Awakener

summary.

Source: 'mossin_awakener_ru.txt'. Faithful full translation, not a

translation 'finish'.

Official English translation (RU→EN), assembled by 'tools'

Shailendra Sharma (Katya Mossin) The Awakener — Biography of

Escape — 375 Vinodavan. Yoga Darshanas. Shiva Sutras — 381 Samadhi
The Great Clockmaker — 387 The Art of Dying. The Alternative Path of
the Gita — 390 The March of the Yogis — 392 Time and the Void — 390
Samadhi. Parikrama — 393 The Inner Gymphony — 394 Commentaries on
Encounters — 390 The Art of Non-Expectation — 394 The Longest
Books — 399 * — 399 At the Farm — 395 The Mags — 392 ...And Other
399 Kumbh Mela and the Secret of Karma — 398 Babaji — 393 Places and
Successor — 398 The Teacher's Departure — 394 "Om" and Other Signs —
The Taste of Mango Juice and the Subtle Art of Begging — 394 The
Way. The Saint of the Boiled Potato — 399

392 Encounter on the Train — 399 The Promise — 394 Blessings Along the
Attainment: the Lost Meaning of Samadhi — 394 Visions of the Future —
399 Pain, Bonuses, and Inner Time — 395 Samadhi — 398 Trick or
394 The Last Meditation of the Ashori — 390 Darshan of Vishwanath —
Reclaimed, the Last Film, and a Head on Fire — 398 Karmic Lessons —
398 Facets of Education — 398 Becoming a Guru — 390 A Voice
War and Peace — 394 The Secret Mudra, the Eternal Spirit, and Kshetras —
Beginning — 398 * — 398 Benares. The Teacher — 397 Initiation — 390
Beach. The Mantra of Death — 398 Winning the Lottery — 391 The
Under the Banyan Tree — 398 Sea Creatures — 393 The Sadhu on the
— 395

of Anandamayiji Ma — 391 Out of the Body — 398 Puri — 395 The Ashram
Amara — 399 Valor of the Kshatriya, Might of the Brahmin. The Counsel
the Search — 399 "Autobiography of a Yogi" — 393 The Hermit of Mount
Vergé of a Military Career — 393 Death, Marriage, and the Beginning of
Mahadev — 81 Blessings and Curses — 87 Brother Hanuman — 87 On the
83 The Gangster, the Paan, and a Visit to Prison — 72 Past Lives.
— 75 City. Books. Time. — 76 Epic Tales from the Life of Gulab Singh —
Grandfather's Last Journey and First Friendships — 46 The Servant's Wife
place of a foreword — 54 Early Years — 38 Family — 38 The
Contents Information about the book — 15 * — 13 Introduction — 14 In
reality.

806 The Ever-Young Sadhu — 811 The Search for a Rare Herb — 816 The
of the Golden Bird — 825 The Formula — 829 The Naked Alchemists —
Additional Duties — 880 Mahamari — 882 Alchemy — 891 * — 891 Eggs
Power of the Guru and the Curious Case of a Change of Sex — 893
Saddest of Spirits — 898 Nirjala Devi — 905 The Mother — 905 The
Calya Kshetras — 932 Brahmarakshasas — 944 Two Ghosts — 951 The
Ghosts — 958 Mehantipur — 959

— 906 The God of Death — 914 The Trial of Spirits and the Tamers of
Mother Hapby — 925 Spirits and All the Rest — 906 The Land of Ghosts
Encounters and Blessings — 926 Journey to the South — 928 Making the
of the Golden Bird — 929 The Golden Bird — 929 Journey to the North.
Creatures — 930 Guru Datta — 942 The Grace of the Devi — 952 Secrets
Beautiful — 952 Psychedelic Flowers, Divine Trees, Astral and Other
Drum — 913 Accessories of the Sadhans — 919 Agoras, "the Most
885 The Three Mathas — 890 Yantis — 890 Matsyendranath — 904
Nepal. The Ritual. — 905 The Heart of the Earth — 906 Devi of Viraj —
Avadhuta [footnote: 176] and Devi of Viraj — 900 Shivalingam — 900
Miracles and Magic Tricks — 948

with Babaji — 934 The Personality of Babaji — 940 Siddhis, Small
Hanuman — 916 Prayaschitta. Abhishek. Milk. — 952 Second Meeting
204 Games of the Gods — 204 The Coming of Yama — 209 Pujas to
Keepers of the Archives — 424 Gods, Avatars, and Forces of Nature —
Monkey Guna — 426 Candali — 485 The Magical Baruchas — 488 The
Keeper — 490 The Dying Man, the Wounded Bull, and the Absolution of
Give the Yogi — 423 The Mantas of the Snake Chamber — 460 The Royal
Visitors, Prophets, and the Fruits of Karma — 446 The King Is Dead, Long
430 The Last Confrontation — 432 Saving the Worker Father — 441 Of
451 The Battle of the Outhouse Fields — 452 Prisoner of the Dark Lord —
The Land of Liberation — 413 Arrival — 413 The Legend — 416 Citra! —
The "Find" of Devanuri — 402

Democracy. Another Life of Yogananda — 399 The Name of the Spirit.
"Thorns and Roses," "The Wanderer" — 391 The Beginning of Spiritual

immortality. The book will help today's seekers of truth grasp such alchemy, the path to self-realization, and methods of attaining illumination. Shailendra Sharma's views on creation, the eternal sound, tradition of Mahavata Babaji and Lahiri Mahasaya. "The Awakener," realized yogi who continues, in the twenty-first century, the ancient Sharma, introduces the reader to the extraordinary life-path of a modern. The authorized biography of the fifth Guru of Kriya Yoga, Shailendra

Information about the book

Katya Mossin The Awakener

IIII

— II12 About the Author — II17 Those Who Worked on the Book —
— 1008 Desires That Remain — 1103 Flame and Embers — 1100 Gratitude
and the Birth of Spirituality — 1080 The Drawing of Lots and the Prize
1077 * — 1077 The Beginning of a New Era — 1078 A Brave New World
Twilight Language — 1061 The Tradition — 1067 Waves of the Future —
Mahavedha — 1047 The Law of Rejection and Turning in Time — 1026 The
Earth, Kundalini, Samadhi — 1043 Hatha Yoga Pradipika and the True
of Evolution — 1030 The Final Transformation — 1038

Origin of Karma — 1016 The Realm of Death, Mithya Loka — 1053 Stages
The Magic of Reality — 1000 Sound, Void, Elements, Prana. — 1008 The
Five Promises — 077 Knowledge — 085 The What and the Why — 080
063 * — 063 The Guide. The Man and the Myth. — 064 Sadhana — 073
and the Healing of a Philosopher — 047 The Puja — 022 Discipline —
Astrologer — 050 The Second Coming — 050 The Philosophy of Healing
Predictions, Motives and Expectations — 002 The Artist — 012 The
Curkula — 001 * — 001 Children of the Mothers — 005 Probabilities and
Preparations — 877 Departure — 882 The Return of Shakti — 800 The
The Mantra of Change — 800

— 840 Sister — 827 * — 827 Devanuti — 828 The Sadhana of Life — 802
— 833 The Alchemical City — 840 Khechari, the Key to the Inner Heavens
Coded Mantra — 821 The Philosopher's Stone — 822 Alchemical Parallels

„I„ with cosmic consciousness.] [footnote 2: Bhagavad Gita — part of the realization. The final stage of Raja Yoga, leading to the union of the inner samadhi — the state of ultimate consciousness, pure awareness. Self- [footnote 3: Keshava — one of the names of Krishna.] [footnote 4: Kunti. In the Bhagavad Gita, Lord Krishna gave him divine revelation.] epic of ancient India. He was the third son of the god Indra and Queen [footnote 5: Arjuna — one of the principal heroes of the Mahabharata, the decipherment. The realities of the twenty- of these discoveries remain general abstractions that require century have left us the milestones of their discoveries of Truth. Yet many Echoing this saying, the heroes, geniuses, and saints of the twentieth The logics say: „Truth is one, but the paths leading to It are many.“

he walk?„ — Bhagavad Gita [footnote 2] 5.24 (samadhi [footnote 4]); How does he speak? How does he sit? How does perfectly in divine wisdom, fully absorbed in pure spiritual consciousness „Arjuna [footnote 5] said: O Keshava [footnote 3], who is he that abides

Introduction

[footnote artifact]

this appears to be a separate footnote that has been mis-merged.) well-off yet as untouchables, rarely able to find alternative livelihoods — or adjusting them during cremation and about members of a caste being source footnote here contains some bleed-through about touching corpses be addressed as „Devi“; it is also the supreme universal principle. (The gender-specific designation of a divinity. Any goddess in Hinduism may [footnote 1: Devi (Sanskrit „Goddess“), the male form being Deva — a liberation. May Your Blessing remain with us, Mother.

Dedicated to Devi [footnote 1] of Moksha Bhumi, Goddess of the Land of

*

mechanics of samadhi and the logic of karma.

concepts as the consciousness of Time and the Void, and learn of the

to digest and digitize them and, in the end, to compress them into high technologies that strive to process eternal philosophical questions — These fundamental questions remain unanswered even with the advent of methods can help "old" souls assimilate into the new world.

organically into the new. Time itself changes, and only special adaptive. Sometimes the answers are encoded in the questions: the old rarely fit this creation, Lila;

release it and play the new role assigned to us by the great producer of death? Is it worth preserving at all in the next life-cycle, or should we world? Will we be able to retain memory of the present personality after or what will help us in the transition from the earthly plane to the astral continues its endless journey through Time? And if eternal life exists, who the physical body? Does this guarantee the "salvation" of the soul as it questions. Can individual consciousness be preserved after the death of Those who strive for spiritual development pose yet more difficult product of the endless play of Nature;

there a plan of the soul? Could it be that our bodies are merely a play-should it be brought to an end at all? At some point we all wonder: is result of past karma, what can be done to break this cycle? Can it, and according to certain religious convictions, continual incarnations are the previous deeds and tendencies, a planned part of an endless cycle? And if, limited in time? Is this birth accidental, or is it the inevitable result of what is the ultimate purpose of dwelling in a physical body so severely need for answers to existential questions: who are we, how does life arise, political, and moral crises of contemporary society underscore an acute first century pose new challenges. The growing ecological, economic, specific meter of verses called shlokas.]

millennium BCE. Its Sanskrit title means "Divine Song," and refers to the the essence of the Upanishads and of yoga. Dated to the end of the first dialogue between Lord Krishna and Prince Arjuna. The book sets forth Hindu philosophy. It consists of eighteen chapters and is a philosophical great Indian epic Mahabharata, one of the most important sacred texts of

others? Although we strive to know the nature of the Creator and His (or
What is the measure of Truth, who can claim the right to explain it to
a true Guru. And this is the hardest part of the Path.

always begins with the search for a trustworthy Teacher, a reliable Guide,
cease. Persistent seekers try various techniques and methods, but the Path
And yet the search for true teachings, knowledge, and traditions does not

popularity, turning their sales algorithms and targeting suitable audiences.
tantic dealers have invaded every possible niche, gaining ever more
experiences grows. Televangelists, Zoom yoga instructors, and YouTube
And yet, the need for ever more unique, exclusive, and refined spiritual

goods on the shelves of the "Enlightenment" supermarket is off the charts.
expanding variety of experiences to be lived. The abundance of spiritual
Meanwhile, spiritual shopping continues to lure the willing with an ever-
and capable of discrimination.

sophisticated

The number of spiritual seekers is growing; they are becoming ever more
wondrous state of union with one's own spirit — invisible, yet palpable.
who seek to step out of the constricting matrix and to experience the
consciousness and new evidence of its untrapped potential attracts those
importantly, to update its software? The discovery of the power of
possible to learn to govern it beyond physical parameters and, most
new souls — but first of all it is a refuge, a shelter of the mind. Is it
reflection of past karmas. Yes, it is a factory of new bodies for old and
once a limitation and an encoded infinity, a mortal flesh-space suit and a
possess this unique, fragile, and precious human form. The body is at
the awakening of the spirit can happen here and now, while we still
paramount importance as awareness itself grows. Some understand that
applications, there is still time to ponder them. Conscious living acquires
But before the triumph of technology turns these ideas into mobile
manageable algorithms.

World's Religions. Twenty-seven years later, on 19 September 1950, America to represent India and Hinduism at the Parliament of the
On 31 May 1893, Swami Vivekananda [footnote 6] sailed from Bombay to

That is why the West so eagerly welcomed yoga.

perception; people needed fresh ideas and methods of self-development of adapting to swift changes. New times required a shift in self-America at the beginning of the twentieth century demanded new ways of their contemporaries. The rapid development of Europe and North Teachers. Inspiring and convincing, they awakened the minds and hearts The past century was generously blessed with the presence of spiritual

paint the portrait of a Guru.

the higher states, we leave it to imagination and limited perception to state of those we deem enlightened. Since we ourselves cannot experience frequency of brain-wave oscillation complicates our understanding of the Teachers, even if one is lucky enough to meet them. The difference is the not easy. It is very difficult to grasp the depths and heights of spiritual any case, whether intuitive or logical, the path of spiritual awakening is to a true Guru? Should this be a leap of faith, or a pragmatic choice? In university? Or is it better to renounce logic and open the heart and mind authenticity of a spiritual teaching with a certificate, as in a college or samadhi can be documented. But is it really possible to confirm the with sophisticated instruments: brain waves can be measured, the state of — love, faith, devotion. In our day, metaphysical conceptions are tested The logical mind requires the confirmation of authenticity for everything

fundamental question: who is a Guru?

found only when at least a hint of an answer exists to the simple but have we come from, where are we going? A true spiritual mentor can be questions: what is life, what is the meaning of human existence, where breathing the same air as we do — is capable of answering the eternal give us the confidence that a contemporary human being — living and self-realization, and only a Teacher can provide such a push. But what can Her) Creation, an external impetus is needed for progress on the path to

Baraji said: "Kriya Yoga, the scientifically grounded technique of God-world."

Paramahansa [footnote 10] Yogananda to present this yoga to the Western
paramhansa [footnote 9] (the lineage of successive teachers) prepared
foreseeing changes in the history of mankind, the masters of the
in the West, their contribution to spiritual revival is truly immense.

state of stillness.]

development of mind and consciousness and grant the practitioner a deep
complex mudras, mantras, and pranayamas. These methods accelerate the
leading to perfection and self-realization. It consists of several levels of
action, since kriya is traditionally connected with activity and knowledge
action linked to knowledge leading to perfection. Kriya Yoga — yoga of
— action, including creative action. In Tantra, Kriya is regarded as
primarily, is the Fifth Guru of the same logic lineage.] [footnote 8: Kriya
people throughout the world. Sri Shriyendra Sharma, the hero of this
was published in 1946 and became a source of inspiration for many
knowledge of yoga in the West. His famous "Autobiography of a Yogi,"
and guru of Kriya Yoga. He lived 35 years in the USA, spreading the
name Swami Yogananda Giri in July 1912. World-renowned Indian yogi
Goswami, Umapada, Mukunda Lal Ghosh received the spiritual
Yogananda Paramahansa (02.01.1893 – 07.03.1925) — born in 1893 in
Chicago, where he delivered a speech on Hinduism.] [footnote 7:
1893 he represented India at the Parliament of the World's Religions in
introduced the teachings of Vedanta and yoga to the Western world. In
philosopher, disciple of the guru Ramakrishna. One of those who
Swami Vivekananda (12.01.1863 – 04.07.1902) — Indian renunciant monk,
particular sadhana, also the title of one initiated into a monastic order,
who has renounced life and become a samnyasi, devoting himself to a
[footnote 6: Swami — in Hinduism, an ascetic or religious teacher, one

Both yogis were pioneers in the popularization of Eastern philosophy

states with the message of the universality of Kriya Yoga [footnote 8].
Yogananda [footnote 7] set foot on American soil, arriving in the United

inspired, but their achievements and victories vividly reflect the evolution impossible to enumerate here everyone whom Yogananda's story God through knowing oneself began its triumphant ascent. It is to the teachers of this ancient tradition, the revolutionary idea of knowing applying Will, Action, and Power in spiritual pursuit. Thanks to him and With the help of Kriya Yoga, Yogananda gifted the West with methods of highest attainments in spiritual development and state of consciousness.] used for enlightened spiritual teachers, ascetics, and sages, to honor their Paramahansa — direct translation from Sanskrit: "supreme swan." A title initiation into practice (diksha) and successive mentorship.] [footnote 10: spiritual teachings and knowledge from guru to disciple through [footnote 8: Paramhansa — the traditional system of transmission of symbols, stimuli, and meanings.

death. Centuries have passed since then, and humanity has needed new personified the divine: myth, the oil for embalming, was the emblem of spiritual meaning. Gold — the symbol of earthly kingship; frankincense to bow before the new messiah Jesus, these magic brought gifts laden with society, predominantly Christian. When the three kings of the East came — coming this time to test an already grown and considerably matured return of the three Magi from the East — Melchior, Balthazar, and Caspar. In a certain sense, his appearance in the West may be compared to the Yogananda brilliantly fulfilled his mission as a messenger from the East. spirit, by offering methods of advanced development of self-knowledge, interest in the nature of spirituality and the recognition of one's own Americans and Europeans into the practice of yoga. By awakening thirty years in the West, Yogananda initiated more than 100,000 differed sharply from the propaganda of religious beliefs. During his popularized the art of Kriya Yoga as the fastest way to attain the Divine. It Mukunda Lal Ghosh (later known to the world as Yogananda) Creator."

through each human being's personal, transcendental perception of the realization, will spread to all countries, helping to harmonize peoples

Guru of ancient Krishna Yoga; founder of the Krishna Yoga tradition. He was "Avatar" — "venerated," Babaji — "Father," or "Sage." The great mystical [footnote 1]: Mahavatar Babaji — in Sanskrit "Maha" means "great,"

Spirit becomes our Guru, and the mind becomes that Spirit's disciple.

of infinite unity with the universe can be attained only when our own the connection with the chief deity — Mother Earth. In his view, the state miracle-worker or modern-day saint, but a realized yogi, he investigates new century, guiding disciples on the path of Yoga and of life. Not a Shailendra Sharma, carries the genuine teaching of Krishna Yoga into the The Fifth Guru of the Mahavatar Babaji [footnote 1] lineage, Sri knowledge.

of transmitting to his contemporaries the authentic principles and of a modern yogi and teacher, capable of describing the indescribable and — recounts the incredible journey to the summit of spiritual attainment simply curious, the authorized biography of the yogi — "The Awakener," walk the thorny path of spiritual development, and for those who are the present spiritual mentor of the same lineage. Written for all those who Yogananda exerted a strong influence on the destiny of the man who is be acquainted with the continuation of this story. The life and work of and beyond time. Contemporaries interested in self-knowledge deserve to continues to live and develop, because this teaching is universal, effective, been published. And yet the teaching has been preserved, the tradition "Yogi," no notable biographies of Masters of Yoga of the same lineage have since 1946, after the publication of Yogananda's "Autobiography of a

Truth before us.

beings, hunger for inspiration from those who have walked the path to of universal love? Whatever the answer, one thing is clear: we, human the courage of an open heart and the persistence in questioning the nature hidden knowledge? The abundance of mystical portraits and events, or impressed its readers? The tenacity with which a young man sought "Autobiography of a Yogi," changed the lives of millions. But what exactly of the human spirit. The story of Yogananda's life, described in

very handsome. And ill. The lines on his face, as if carved from pale
for certain: he was of mighty build, moved with self-assurance, and was
he appeared suddenly, as if out of nowhere. A few things could be said
Perhaps because everyone sat on the floor, looking up at him. Or because
...The man who entered the room was of indeterminate height and age.

standard European norms of behavior might not be quite applicable here.
aspirans [footnote 15] was unknown to me. It was clear only that the
the local traditions or the rules for visiting holy sites; the etiquette of
why the girl was crying was entirely unclear. I knew almost nothing of
woman, weeping. Why this beautiful garden had been discarded and
lay a luscious garden of crimson roses; nearby stood a young European
approached the doors of a large white house. On the steps at the entrance
ensnared me in the traps of distant corners. At last, utterly disoriented, I
along its paths, between its trees, lured me onto the ramps of palaces, and
...Stepping through the gate, I instantly lost my way. The garden led me

in place of a foreword

excellent; if not — that is no great matter."

lived through myself. If you find these stories useful and entertaining —
the convictions of others, I simply set forth what I have observed and
know his own nature. Not striving to convince anyone, nor to condemn
of the Earth, who values and admires Nature and applies sincere effort to
with caste, religion, or nationality. This is the story of the path of a son
observations of reality from a logic point of view. It has nothing to do
in his own words: "Before you is the story of my life and my personal
The subject of this biography insisted on presenting himself to the reader

awakening. About the Awakener.

story about Spirit, about Time, about the road to self-knowledge and
(especially to those who still consider yoga a teaching about asanas). It is a
The book you hold in your hands may seem unusual, even provocative

of Krishna Yoga throughout the world.]

the Teacher of Lahiri Mahasaya, whom he chose to spread the principles

An unceremonious, invisible force was scraping away the mold of
(Kudra is one of the forms of Lord Shiva).]

mantras and for worship. In Sanskrit the word means "eye of Kudra,"
Elaeocarpus tree, used by Shrivites as beads (mala) for the recitation of
[footnote 13: Kudraksha — the dried seeds of the sacred evergreen
disinfectant that burned away all the slag.

lifted the lid off my skull and was stirring the contents, pouring in a
the scanning gave way to a cleaning. The feeling was as if someone had
cursorily, he was now looking "into" me. It became uncomfortable. Then
glasses, he looked straight ahead with no expression. Having scanned me
No one tried to break the heavy silence. Without removing his dark
thought it was the strength of knowledge.

merciless toward any falsehood, devoid of compromise or half-tones. I
fired. The energy emanating from him was not quite human: heavily,
through his movements and gestures, the man on the couch looked very
than any glowing aura or silhouette. Despite the strength that flowed
nothing of the kind, perhaps because the overall impression was stranger:
Shivalingam or of a giant cobra spreading its hood. That day I saw
above his head. Inconstant, fluid, they would take the conical form of a
fringed newcomers. Sometimes strange translucent contours appeared
background his aura would become so dazzling that its white neon light
Later I learned that he rarely sat right against the walls — against their
appearance, he sank onto a sofa that stood at the back of the room.

Without looking at those present, who had jumped up hastily at his
down the wide shoulders of a wrestler or bodybuilder.

of kudraksha [footnote 13] on his broad shoulders, long black hair falling
spiritual practice, religious or logic discipline.]

[footnote 15: Ashram — a hermitage, school, residence, or dwelling for
white kurtas, with heavy garlands
marble, had been chiseled by the engraver of pain or sickness. He wore a

world. I said: "Happy upcoming New Year..." The man on the red sofa again — and another life began as if I had awakened in a new, strange had descended on the stage. When I rose from my knees, the curtain rose cloth, all past events suddenly lost any significance, as though a curtain bowed, and my shawl fell, covering my face. Under the thick woolen ... One by one, prostrating and bowing, people departed. I knelt and amenable to describing.

natural and normal — but this place was not normal, and was not expectations? To feel unsure in unfamiliar surroundings is perfectly Or perhaps these were my fantasies, projections, and unfounded

terms "transmigration", "karmic cycle", and "repeated reincarnations." recurring cycle of deaths and rebirths. It is sometimes characterized by the Samasara — a fundamental conviction of various Indian religions. The drank this poison, saving all beings from its deadly fumes.] [footnote 12: ocean to obtain the nectar of immortality, amrita. Lord Shiva Himself "demons", "demi-gods", in opposition to the gods — churned the cosmic churning. The devas (gods) and the asuras — lesser deities also called released from the Ocean of Milk (the cosmic world-ocean) during its [footnote 14: Halahala — according to Hindu mythology, a deadly poison antidote was administered.

We were all poisoned by earthly existence, and here, in this place, the [footnote 14] — the poison of worldly existence, of samasara [footnote 12]. simply no room for anything new. Later I heard the term "Halahala", crammed with the accumulated rubbish of lived experiences — there was The supposed grace simply had nowhere to land, since my head was There was not the slightest sign of grace descending, or of spiritual light.

and receive a full dose of this strange therapy.

required, and the courage to step into the unknown. I had to remain here indispensable condition for healing. Readiness to open the mind was this alien intrusion into the space of my mind, I froze. It was a painful but years — the mold that had fed insecurity and disappointment. Feeling resentment and bitterness that had accumulated within over the long

ambush is waiting. An innocent-looking banana cake from a "German" weakness from a banal food poisoning. One never knows where the pain is so very exhausting, but it was accompanied by debilitating. The camel-and-jeep trek from Jerusalem into the Thar Desert itself had not extremely chaotic, and the trip to Rajasthan had almost finished me off. To make sense of the events of the last three weeks. They had been in the hotel room it was cold. Burrowed under a thin sleeping bag, I tried chain of random coincidences.

my destination. It remained to be discovered whether this was fate or a impression. And India, however jaggedly its rhythm was guiding me to sake of the purity of the experiment and the objectivity of the first address of the ashram. I wanted to see and feel everything myself, for the face on the cover of a yoga magazine. I had asked no one for the precise Teacher — from the very day, almost a year before, when I had seen his. Out of a great multitude of places, I had wanted to come here — to this changing mosaics.

here was too colorful for any clues to be discovered in its endlessly trying to find, what was I trying to understand? The kaleidoscope of life ... Why was I, again and again, wandering through India? What was I forever in this strange trance.

no-mind; it no longer wished to calculate and classify, it wished to remain the city beyond the fence did not cease for an instant. The mind became palaces, lower tiers. There was not a soul around, although the noise of surface; some translucent entities swarmed in the dark vaults of the light touch of dragonflies; the dark silhouettes of fish moved beneath the circles spread across the water; duckweed quivered slightly under the in truth, was submerging into what — but I had no wish to move. How deep the waters were, how deeply I had submerged into myself, or who, inner silence grounded me on the steps of the pond. It is hard to say how ... The audience was over; it was time to return to the hotel, but a state of answered absently, like an echo: "Yes, Happy New Year..."

production were directed by an invisible conductor. No, this place by an unceasing ecstasy — moved in unison, as though this grandiose women with heavy silver anklets, monkeys and rickshaws — all racked life devoted to sadhana (practice).]

who has renounced worldly life and all possessions and leads a simple [footnote 1e: Sadhu — a yogi, a Hindu ascetic, a holy man, a sage; one

[footnote 1e] in orange robes, Gharati

gazed schoolchildren with badges pinned to their uniforms, sadhus traded, mothers nursed infants, many sang. Scattered detachments of the road, people prostrated themselves in the dust; some ate, others howled, horns played, deafening music wailed. Here and there, right on moon seemed to be spurring on both people and animals. Loudspeakers beamed before the slowly-moving cars. The approach of the full ...The little town was backed with crowds; dense, endless streams of

civilization had been left behind.

but the landscape had changed. Now rural expanses dominated. The fields were still covered in the same patches of milky-white cold fog, busy main road and bounced over gravel, weaving between the bottlenecks, highway. After four unremarkable hours, the taxi finally turned off the waybread in shadows. At last the tunnel of the city spat the taxi out onto the out of it appeared and again disappeared dimly visible spectral figures ...December was almost frosty; the morning fog crept under one's clothes;

substance.

fertifying that one did not even want to speculate as to the origin of the dust, and some greasy soot in the bathroom and under the bed looked so Kaiser had seen his castle, he would have had a stroke. Stalactites of dirt, bazaar. The shabby pole bore the snobbish name "Kaiser Castle." If the quick transit through that enormous, chaotic city that resembled a noisy hob-house in Bihar Canal — and even this had been the best place for a On arrival from Rajasthan in Delhi, I had spent the night in some filthy bakery had turned out to be a treacherous delicacy.

if the energy of the holy hill did not feel holy at all — it turned me inside unnecessarily mental constructs. This land destroyed everything foreign to the depths of my soul with its harshness and its complete rejection of any return to see this indescribable man, this mad place that had struck me to ... I felt no particular "invitation" to stay, but I was certain that I would me. Perhaps this was indeed the long-awaited bath and a brief realization. Being. Instead of enlightenment, a pure, childlike happiness descended on were no signs of weariness — only an intoxicating, filling lightness of pilgrims put into fountains of tender powder between my toes. There the soles of my bare feet, the fine flour of dust raised by thousands of several months.]

before moving on to the next, and the completion of this austerity takes on the ground. Some sadhus perform 108 prostrations in a single spot full-body prostrations, like an "extended staff" (danda), lying face-down of pilgrims as spiritual purification. Dandavat Parikrama is performed by kilometers (or thirteen miles) long. The ritual is performed by thousands Mathura district, state of Uttar Pradesh) — a circuit about twenty-one practice. The parikrama around the sacred Govardhan hill (in the [footnote 17: Parikrama (circumambulation) — a traditional religious

roughness of the asphalt scorched

madness gave way to the measured rhythm of motion. The cold respectful touch of his dirty fingers and lips. Now the waves of collective bath, I did not flinch. I had neither the strength nor the desire to evade the Even when a mad beggar began kissing my bare feet, blessing me on the ten kilometers — in three and a half hours, in a state of complete amnesia. Yet this did not stop me from walking half of a parikrama [footnote 17] — for four days now. My head was empty and rang almost pleasantly. And Apart from tea, biscuits, and bananas I had been unable to eat anything of this town, of what lay ahead.

though none of that had ever existed. I knew nothing of these traditions, cafes, and juice bars for European tourists had been left far behind, as certainly did not resemble Rishikesh or Goa. The comfort of guest houses,

staff in the shape of a black serpent, heavy garlands striking: snow-white robes, golden rings with precious stones, a carved probe of the "Palace and Guru" set. The Teacher's appearance was showy. Who so deftly arranged all this scenery and selected the outstanding the same thought, again and again: who is the producer of this Bollywood reflecting everything that was not in its catalog. At first it kept producing inevitably caused even greater confusion. The stubborn logical mind kept attempts to make sense of the non-eventfulness of what was happening shattering any vessels in which the elixir of common sense bubbled. All patterns. The unfamiliar reality pulged out of all forms, like dough, those years fit into the familiar frames or settled into recognizable. Nothing of what I heard or saw on the royal smasman [footnote 18] during knowledge that had become a part of me.

incarnation. This was not merely shared and explained wisdom, but inner consequences of personal karmic deeds that had led to the present this body. The yoga he taught revealed all the invisible connections and purpose of earthly existence and about the reasons for my coming into collective present. The Guru not only opened to me the truth about the that was to come, of the outer and the inner, of personal past and world. Then came gradual acceptance: of all that had happened and of all times with silent protest and doubt, with truth about myself and the ... The years that followed filled me with astonishment, admiration, at

portrait I had just drawn would become my Guide.

that this yoga would become a part of me, and that the man whose red, I did not yet know that I would spend many years in this country, weight of Knowledge in it, and absolute peace. Lying on the hard floor the expression on the face was calm and unshakable. There was the corners of the mouth something bitter lay hidden. And at the same time a face hidden behind dark glasses. The sketch came out well, but in the Making (or rather, coming to), I took out a notebook and pencil and drew

I wondered whether this yoga and this Teacher demanded the same.

out like a glove. The place demanded total submission and openness, and

Teacher was impossible. One had to dissolve voluntarily in the heavy, immersion in the life of this place, describing the Teaching and this the periphery of consciousness, it would leave only to return. Without full beat of a butterfly's wing or the fleeting shadow of a bird, once arising on The idea of writing a book arose and disappeared several times, like the inducing an almost narcotic immersion in the beauty of being.

action in a state of inaction. Here the flow of life relaxed the mind of the bougainvilleas — all of it created a backdrop for an unceasing parrots, the shimmering fans of the dancing peacocks, tails, the brightness empty colonnades, the sudden flashes of flight of swift flocks of green majestic carved arches and domes of the palaces. The whispered echo of ...The unmoving amalgam of the sleepy pond's surface reflected the in the field of Absolute Reason.

presence of a Teacher transmitting the laws of the Universe meant being white mansion amid the greenery of the ancient smashan. To be in the changing my life. And the epicenter of those changes was here, in the old What I heard gave strength, supported, inspired. What I was doing was lost in this fairy tale.

losing touch with so-called normal everyday life. For one could become disciples might come to know the greatness of their own spirit without imperfection. Humor, sometimes even sarcasm, was necessary so that dithyrambs, however, he often joked that he was perfect in his the first arrival-station to one's true self. To temper the pathos of such He was the perfect Master of the perfect place — the last destination and those details.

perfection. But it was hardly anyone other than Life itself who had honed had been trained to pose. All of it seemed pre-rehearsed, directed to of Kottweilers that accompanied him everywhere behaved as though they features were expressive and full of strength and will. And even the pair of rudraksha on his broad chest and the assured stride... His Aztec

[Footnote 18: Smashan — a cremation ground.]

The shop was piled with tons of motley books, and many authors should right format for the future book.

Bangalore, in the vast biographical section, where I was trying to find the such thoughts pursued me in the bookstore on Church Street in certified only by celestial commissions.

universities, whose authority is ambiguous and whose lectures are theories created by man. The science of the soul is taught in unaccredited manner the puzzle may be solved. But these methods are only good for operate within the terms and concepts, and in this (almost scientific) mind? To some degree, yes, for there is a set of criteria: one need only is it possible at all to describe the color of the sky or the nature of the superstitions and fictions.

resisted the surge of myth and legend, relegating them to the category of same eyewitnesses, were difficult to accept and to comprehend. Logic some of the facts he himself recounted, although confirmed by perfectly [footnote 10: Puja — a religious ceremony, worship, ritual.]

phenomena of his life made the task practically impossible.

The scale of his personality and the apparent absurdity of certain key events — sounded dry and incidental, and had no particular meaning. also because the standard set of dates — birth, education, significant had been his disciple, present in his presence for weeks and months. But remained impossible to describe this man objectively. Not only because I that the time to write his biography had come, I discovered that it Thirteen years later, having presumptuously announced to the Teacher witnessing of the knowledge he shared — gradually grew fatter.

the room sounded before puja [footnote 10], during the unceasing astonishment that overcame me every time I saw the Teacher, every time The vague and unformed initial striving to give verbal form to the — in the measured current of life here.

enveloping energy of the master of this place — the most ancient smashan

unapprising literary stew was represented by a collection of celebrity format of life-writing that I managed to fish out of the thick and and offered measured doses of objectivity. The most honest and laconic standard sections. Autobiographies winked cynically from the shelves. A handbook called "How to Write a Biography" offered only a dull list of were captivating and untouched by this invisible mold.

Promotion, thinly veiled marketing. Although, in fairness, some books the dissemination of yet another "good news," ensured advertising predictable skepticism. The motives behind such publications were clear: excessive enthusiasm and emotion; even irrefutable facts elicited deliberately objectified, or tactfully banal. Some books were full of biographies of contemporary spiritual leaders were either dry and of Sri Aurobindo was founded.]

spiritual companion Mira Alfassa (known as "the Mother"), the Ashram of human life into divine life in a divine body. In 1926, with the help of his developed integral yoga; the central theme of this system is the evolution moved to Pondicherry, leaving politics for spiritual work. Sri Aurobindo experienced mystical and spiritual experiences. After his release he spiritual evolution. During his time in prison, Sri Aurobindo until 1910. Becoming a spiritual reformer, he presented his ideas of movement from British colonial rule, he was one of its influential leaders in his early years as a journalist. Having joined the Indian independence yoga, marathi, and Indian nationalist, born Aurobindo Ghosh, worked spiritual reformer, the founder of integral yoga. This Indian philosopher, [footnote 20: Sri Aurobindo (1872-1950) — a celebrated guru, poet, and exclusively by their being common knowledge.

often took the upper hand over objectivity. Facts were confirmed were saturated with the individuality of the narrators, and their emotions. Clinton and the Dalai Lama, I understood: most accounts of these people and the Pope of Rome, of Aurobindo [footnote 20] and Degas, of Bill duty, which was convenient for me. Reading through biographies of Mao have been forbidden to write at all. But the writers' police were clearly off

Gyanendra was closest to him in age.

sisters — Nirmala, Mridula, and Pratibha — and the middle brother was twenty-three years older than him; following Mahendra came three the third son and the last of the children. His eldest brother Mahendra Sharma, born in Bhopal on 10 July 1927, was named Shalendra. He was The sixth child of Shri Himmat Bahadur Sharma and Shrimati Gyan Devi Family

Early Years

masterly, faultlessness.]

itself means perfection, attainment, fact or indisputable completion. There are eight Siddhis that grant power over the five elements. The word or paranormal abilities obtained as a result of intense logic practice. has attained the highest level of the state of mind. Siddhis — supernatural [footnote 21: Siddha — a realized yogi, a perfect soul, a sage, a being who forces — the shadow-writers of the Book of All Destinies.

siddha [footnote 21], whose fate was still being changed by invisible of the absolute and indisputable existence of the yogi, philosopher, and The canvas of the future picture had already been laid out on the stretcher agnostics.

accounts of eyewitnesses, devotees and followers, friends, skeptics, and done delicately, with love, without altering the pattern woven from the astral library; it needed only a little reformatting. The editing must be had already been written and was waiting to be secretly carried out of the wet asphalt in night plots. Drawing a deep breath, I understood: the book orange splashes of tulip-tree blossoms torn from the branches marked the railing an auto-rickshaw. A light rain drummed on the windshield. Disappointed, I walked out of the stuffy bookstore and waved my hand, out of place.

concise, and interesting facts. To criticize such a style would have been opituaries published by The New York Times. Its pages contained dry,

spiritual life of that time was vivid and exciting.

radical transformation (one of countless in her history): the political and wife Kasturba, and his grand-niece Manuben. India was undergoing a colonial rule. In Delhi they met personally with Mahatma Gandhi, his participated in various rallies, protests, and marches against British Bahadur Sharma received his law degree. The young couple actively chief justice of the state. His parents were already married when Himmat His father, a graduate of the University of Calcutta, held the high post of chatter, devoid, in his view, of any substance whatever.

understood poorly, but they were far more captivating than children's disturb his usual thoughtful state. The topics they discussed were The adults discussed interesting things; their conversations did not adults, who usually allowed him to be present during their conversations. turned out that bees did not interest him. He preferred the company of over the back pages of the newspapers with the comics. Somehow it able to write, he knew all the letters and would read for hours, and bore He was not yet five years old when he began to read in Hindi. Not yet talkative.

the rest of the toddler vocabulary very quickly, but it did not make him clearly. Perhaps this predetermined his lifelong love of dogs. He learned pointed at a running dog: "Kutta, doggie!" — and he repeated the word was about eight months old when his mother, holding him in her arms, His first spoken word belonged to the world of animals, not of people. He whatever for laughter. Probably it was so.

one heard him laugh; the baby behaved as though there were no reason inward, and he had no wish to be distracted from this contemplation. No studied the world attentively, though his gaze seemed turned more tricks that ordinarily soothe children well. The dark eyes of the little one the attempts of his mother and nannies to distract him with amusing breaks only for food and sleep. The unsmiling infant was indifferent to the first months of life the child cried continuously and inconsolably, with Despite his resonating name, which means "Lord of the Mountains," in

with numerous workers, he took it as something habitual and even childhood. Perhaps that is why, years later, having settled in a large estate spacious estates with maids and servants were a customary part of his lived in large mansions with a numerous staff of servants.

the district judge with comfortable residences, and the family always British East India Company.]

resistance during the Indian uprising of 1857-1858 against the rule of the under the rule of the local Scindia clan. One of the principal centers of independence in 1947, Cwalior remained a princely state of the British Raj Pradesh, located 343 km south of the capital, Delhi. Before India's [footnote 22: Cwalior — a major city in the central Indian state of Madhya

provided

high-ranking officials, and members of various royal families. The state belonged to a noble line), their home was often visited by chief justices, Thanks to his father's position, connections, and origin (the family

was no need for the precise address; everyone in the city knew his father.

the house of Mr. Justice," and would be delivered to his destination. There

Anyone who arrived in the city could say to a rickshaw at the station, "To

Himmat Sharma entered the legal service and made a brilliant career.

of Shivram-ki-Carhi, located near Agra, to Cwalior [footnote 22]. There

Gulab Singh, insisted that the young couple move from the family estate

certain moment, however, the grandfather on the father's side, Colonel

It was a stormy and captivating life, and both spouses enjoyed it. At a

known as "the Indian Nightingale."

activists; it also included Sarojini Naidu, the renowned Indian poet

missions. The circle of acquaintances was not limited to politicians and

at the start or in the heyday of their political careers and historical

political and spiritual leader Abdul Ghaffar Khan. All these people were

and his wife Kamala, the first Vice-Premier Sardar Patel, the famous

figures of the political scene: the first Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru

Among the new acquaintances of the young couple were prominent

minerals, and metals (possibly under the influence of early Indian Ayurvedic preparations are based on complex compounds of plants, special diets, meditation, yoga, massage, enemas, and medicinal oils. subcontinent. Ayurvedic methods of healing include herbal medicines, [footnote 53: Ayurveda — the ancient medical system of the Indian legendary warrior-hero who was

of spirit. They were descendants of Ashvattama [footnote 54], the [footnote 55] and the women of the clan could rival the men in firmness 54] let their name [footnote 56] was that of the warrior-Kshatriyas Both branches of the family belonged to the caste of Brahmins [footnote

"Commander-in-Chief of the Cavalry Unit."

of colonel of the Jodhpur state army, and his full title sounded as His paternal grandfather, the venerable Gulab Singh, retired with the rank Ayurveda [footnote 53].

skilled housewife, and held an academic degree in the science of Devi was in many ways ahead of her time: she drove a car expertly, was a which complemented an unusual physical strength for a woman. Cautious with a remarkable steadfastness. Especially unshakable was her will, an exalted Mars, and that planet of war and courage endowed the mother unyielding convictions, and indestructible love. Her microscope showed meant strength in every aspect: powerful intellect, firm character, who knew her acknowledged this fact. By saying she was strong, people ...His mother was not only beautiful but also a very strong woman — all of high-ranking persons, of whatever status or position.

prophets and sisters felt even a shadow of embarrassment in the presence excellent training in social skills. Having grown up, neither he nor his invariably polite, he simply ignored unnecessary formalities. It was also seem disrespectful, and later such directness became part of his character. childhood. Because of his youth and his father's standing, this did not The habit of addressing everyone by name had formed in him in early natural.

as the longest poem in the world. It recounts the history and (Vedavyasa). The Mahabharata consists of eighteen parvas and is known century CE. It is held to have been composed by the legendary sage Vyasa composed approximately between the 3rd century BCE and the 3rd [footnote 28: Mahabharata — one of the principal epics of Ancient India, but without traditional prayers.

religious worship. Before the traditional night of Shiva everyone fasted, flowers and offerings — that was the only thing that could pass for father and other relatives themselves built the altar, decorated it with Diwali [footnote 31], but never invited bandits [footnote 32]. Instead, the religious. As a rule, they celebrated only Janmashtami [footnote 30] and [footnote 33]. Perhaps that is why their family was not especially Brahmins were not priests, since they belonged to a warrior, gotra and the family traced its lineage from one of those branches. These person. Having married seventeen times, he left numerous descendants, not a fictional character from the Mahabharata [footnote 38] but a real

curse laid upon him by Krishna, he became immortal. One of most of the Pandava camp by attacking them at night. As a result of a grieving Drona. Overcome by grief and rage, Ashvattama slaughtered Pandavas. A deliberately false report of his death led to the killing of the Kurukshetra, Ashvattama fought on the side of the Kauravas against the and protected him from hunger, thirst, and fatigue. In the battle on his forehead which gave him power over all living beings except humans, Drona and grandson of the sage Bharadwaja. Born with a precious gem in (Ashvattaman) — a legendary hero of the Mahabharata, son of the guru belonging to the warrior caste (kings, rulers).] [footnote 37: Ashvattama (merchants), Shudras (servants).] [footnote 38: Kshatriyas — a person are four varnas: Brahmins (priests), Kshatriyas (warriors), Vaishyas religious rituals.] [footnote 39: Varma — in the Indian caste system there who devotes his life to the study of sacred texts and serves as a priest in physicians.] [footnote 40: Brahmin — a member of the priestly caste. One of medical knowledge from the gods to the sages, and then to human alchemy). The texts of Ayurveda begin with accounts of the transmission

mantra is to be repeated during eclipses or full moons a specific (but not and the mantra, the secret of Ishvara (God), speaks through me." This number, this is my bhakti (devotion) and the shakti (power) of my Guru, cited at the end of most mantras, are: "The world is true, the body is transmitted orally. Many are written as verses. The most powerful lines, sounds. They are more like a magical incantation — an "aprasadapra" — common folk dialects; usually it is spoken Hindi, and they contain no bija-Indis. The shabar mantras of Gorakhnath and Matsyendranath arose from ancient gods and masters. There are also mantras in other languages of [footnote (continued from 34): texts. In them are laid down the powers of have been met with disbelief and, perhaps, even with mockery.

one of the most important rituals in Hinduism, such a "prophecy" would to predict that the youngest child of the Sharma clan would daily perform It is given to no one to look into the future. Therefore, if anyone had dared meanings and complex narrative turns.

Mathabhara and the Ramayana [footnote 36], the deciphering of hidden and the performance of pujas, they preferred discussion of the perfectly, spoke and wrote Sanskrit fluently. But to the reading of mantras home. Nonetheless, the father and uncle knew the Indian scriptures

Another type of mantra and incantation is based on the Sanskrit-] the matras are quite strong, and their results are direct and powerful. achieve specific results. The effects of incantations and mantras based on deity. When necessary the information and energy can be extracted to and concentrated information and accumulates the energy of a specific written as symbols, linked to deities. Such a mantra stores compressed metaphysical doctrine rooted in tantra. This is the use of letters or sounds, of mantras and incantations. The first is based on the matras — a immortality, love, knowledge, and action. There are three principal types with spiritual interpretations such as the human striving for truth, light, body and mind. In more complex forms, mantras are melodic phrases arisen on earth. The sound "Aum" creates a soothing reverberation in mantra is the word "OM" or "Aum," considered the first sound to have

vanished. At that moment there were eighteen or twenty people in the bright spheres soared upward, but now there were three. Then everything spheres suddenly descending from the ceiling. Almost at once these lips silently echoing the shlokas [footnote 37], and two large luminous the voice of his father reading the Gita, the movement of the grandfather's. Although he was very small then, this scene remained with him forever:

repeating: "Ram, Ram..."

with tulsi leaves. The grandfather was laid on the improvised bed; he kept embrace. The floor was immediately smeared with cow dung and strewn shortly before death a person must lie on the earth in order to feel its last. On the sixteenth day the grandfather asked to be laid on the floor. By tradition, the nukes chanted the grandfather's favorite mantras in song. On the days from early morning to late night his father read the Gita aloud, and A round-the-clock vigil was kept at the grandfather's bedside. For fifteen adventures.

on the last journey — far more captivating than all the previous on the ground floor. There he lay, weak but focused, preparing to set off. The grandfather's room, where he had lived for the past thirty years, was house.

and distant relatives — nearly two hundred people — flooded their clear that the grandfather would not last long, words of aunts, uncles, Gulab Singh, left his body at the age of ninety-seven. When it became He was only five years old when his grandfather, the retired colonel

The Grandfather's Last Journey and First Friendships

sage-maharishi Valmiki.]

ancient India, narrating the "way of Rama." The epic is attributed to the development.] [footnote 36: Ramayana — one of the principal epics of deity, and sometimes a discussion of the principles of spiritual narrate a legend set to music; often an expression of loving devotion to a Kiritan — a call-and-response style of singing in which several singers (numerable) number of times, until it is "charged" for use.] [footnote 37:

Watching them, he experienced a storm of emotions, and the strongest of all with the warm mustard oil, while she gazed at her son with love. With indescribable tenderness, Hari Om began to rub his mother's hands with blisters and scars, fresh and old.

hands and set it against the wall, and then looked at her palms, covered on the stove. When she entered the house, Hari took the sickle from her early. Hari Om was waiting for her, warming mustard oil in a small pot was due back from work. As with all village women, her day began very One day, he stopped by their home in the afternoon, when Hari's mother grass-strips, or rhythmically swinging sickles and hoes in the fields.

a praising or religious poetic stanza.]

[footnote 33: Shloka — a Sanskrit verse, usually consisting of 32 syllables,

swinging sickles and hoes in the fields.

village landscapes, are forever bent over a roadside ditch or rhythmically those women who, like motley specks against the monotonous canvas of with a boy named Hari Om, whose mother was a day-laborer — one of state of Madhya Pradesh. He was then in the second class and was friends For some time the family lived in the small cozy town of Jagat, in the assure himself that it existed.

time to time he felt a kind of longing, a need to bring this love forth, to ...An open display of tenderness was a rarity in their family, and from

sent could not be messengers of a dark and terrible abyss...

She was beautiful, because the marvelous luminous golden spheres She solemn ceremony, like a wedding, in which Death took Life to wife. And recognition, but the feeling remained. The grandfather's departure was a baggage. Of course the child's mind could not give clarity to that The grandfather left his body on the floor, as he no longer needed the he has gone, he has gone!"

rose up, and all those present in the room exhaled simultaneously: "Oh, room, and all saw the same thing: two luminous spheres descended, three

In state schools children of various castes studied together. His classmates teacher and provoked a couple more slaps.

could not cope with his uncontrollable laughter, which only enraged the teacher, smaller than a microbe, was slapping him. What absurdity! He somewhere a school — absolutely microscopic. And in that school a enormous Universe, the Earth like a speck of dust, and on this tiny speck instead of being upset or frightened, he chuckled, imagining the

schools of that time. The inattentive pupil received a slap.

him. The teacher applied the methods of intimidation common in Indian during a boring lesson, he did not hear that a new teacher had spoken to made use of by rarely doing his homework. Once, gazing out the window teachers did not risk reprimanding the son of a major official, which he since his father was a district judge and belonged to the city's elite, most himself. And in the end he began to do so.

of other children did not attract him; he wanted to choose his friends beginning of a new life, but had to submit to the inevitable. The company depressing. Fearing the change, he felt no enthusiasm whatever for the All the children attended a state school. The first day at school was quite consider the possibility of private schools or English-medium institutions. ...His father held traditional views on education and did not even

because people with a heart filled with such love deserve the best.

forever. Years later he was certain: his friend's life had turned out well, toil-worn palms. For one reason or another, this scene stayed with him careful movements of the son's fingers gently and reverently touching her remembered the expression in the eyes of his friend's mother, and the of laughter and jokes and became a family legend. But he forever rub her hands with warm mustard oil! This declaration provoked a burst the hard work painful, bleeding blisters appeared on her palms, he would sickle and immediately go out into the field to cut grass. And when from ...Returning home, he categorically demanded that his mother take a

them was envy.

In the years that followed he had to meet countless representatives of that first lesson about social hierarchy and the nuances of human behavior. distance. This stunning discovery overturned his world, becoming the ednally, the other person may still feel the difference in their position, the difference in social positions. It turned out that even if one treats everyone talked for quite a long time. His father patiently tried to explain the Coming home, he demanded an explanation from his father, and they important and wealthy people would spoil him.

with the judge's son, declaring that close association with the children of The constable's son answered that his father had forbidden him to play the break between lessons he asked: "Why aren't you speaking to me?" The next day at school the friend awkwardly tried to avoid him. During game.

not give it particular significance, and the children went back to their to address his young guest. The situation was awkward, but the boy did said, "He is my dad..." The man was clearly uneasy; he did not know how the policeman by name, asking, "What are you doing here?" The friend were playing when the constable returned home. By habit he addressed day, crossing the road, he went to his friend's modest apartment. They family lived in service quarters on the territory of the central prison. One but who his friend's father was he did not quite know. The classmate's name. The constable's son was his classmate; they often played together, latter worked at home. As the judge's son, he addressed the constable by constable regularly brought papers from the court to his father when the Their house stood directly opposite the central prison of Zagreb. One social frame.

later, and it took a considerable time to grasp the general sense of the equal hospitality. The recognition of social distinctions began to grow and he invited his classmates home. His mother received them all with know of the existence of castes — they simply were not part of his life, butcher (the most despised profession in India). It was not that he did not included sons of servants, the children of laborers, and even the son of a

patriarchal.

of everyday life provoked their mocking attitude toward everything instinctively grasped their deep meaning, but the unvarying practicality customs were so ancient that they astonished the city-dwellers. They was brought up in the patriarchal traditions of northern India. These having attended school, the young wife also could not read or write and his boss arranged his marriage to a girl from the same village. Never. When the young man reached his majority, the venerable master judge, lowest rung even in the hierarchy of servants.

duties very thoroughly. Kind, sincere, though illiterate, he occupied the servants; no one took him seriously, but the lad himself performed his room — depending on the masters' orders. He was one of countless about with trays, with clothes being given out for washing, with a rag or a brush from early morning till late night, this lad was forever scuttling himself was a child.

the house left a noticeable trace in his memory, although at that time he household required many servants. The story of one errand-boy living in cups of tea drunk from morning till evening, was impossible. The rule the number of portions cooked for lunches and dinners, or by the endless particular estate. To count the exact number of family members either by hundred and fifty aunts, uncles, and countless cousins were living in this buildings were added on. By the moment of his birth no fewer than one hundred-year-old four-storey house. Over time several more residential. Their clan was enormous; countless aunts, uncles, and cousins lived in a

The Servant's Wife

friends.

to follow the code of the heart. With the constable's son they remained karma, the rules of social hierarchy were extremely tangled. He preferred had not a drop of dignity or honor. Though preordained by the laws of achieved much on their own. Others, being the offspring of noble parents, various castes and varnas. Some came from very modest families and

education of the children. One of their sons became a state civil servant, respected judge, continued to help the widow with the upbringing and couple lived a worthy life. When the servant died, his master, the time took an honored position among the household staff. The married intelligent and inquisitive, knew many medicines and recipes, and in toward one who was daily worshipped as a deity. The young woman was him with growing respect. It was impossible to behave dismissively change. Although he remained merely a servant, people began to treat attitude toward the woman and toward her husband began gradually to As the inhabitants of the house observed this daily spectacle, their call him familiarly by name.

of her children and the husband given to her by God did not allow her to was the only acceptable way of life. Her boundless devotion to the father women's rights and basic freedoms. However, for the servant's wife this quite justly) are declared the triumph of patriarchy, a violation of off as the shortcomings of education. Today such traditions (perhaps Perhaps modern feminists would condemn these practices, writing them the burial.

husband's name aloud, but she never did: she called him "he," or "they," in the temple of her own heart. The children tried to make her say her not deity it with speech. The woman uttered it within herself, coming into was the name of her personal deity, her Lord and master, and she could aloud. This was not a superstitious fear of bad luck. The husband's name that was not all: even being married, she never spoke her husband's name would wash her husband's big toe with water and drink that water. But accidentally touched you." Having completed her own ablutions, she forgive me for the fact that during my sleep my feet may have Every morning she prostrated herself before her young husband: "Please dwellers.

She also daily performed rituals utterly incomprehensible to city- itself was not surprising, as this custom was widespread in many villages. The young wife of the servant always kept her face covered, which in

time to time a strange feeling visited him: that the locals who knew this atom of an unspoken secret known to all, but discussed by few. From the streets were crowded and noisy, but the air was saturated with the not an ordinary noisy Indian city, at least to him it did not seem so. Yes, its head northward and pristed its crest of the ancient fort. Cavalior was Curled in the bowl of the valley like a scaly blue dragon, the city stretched City. Books. Time.

„Adi Parashakti.“]

destructive. Sometimes Shakti is translated as the Creatrix, „Adi Shakti“ or energy of Shakti is considered creative, generative, sustaining, but also primarily cosmic energy, the dynamic forces pervading the Universe. The power, the transcendent aspect of Shiva — all these terms describe the and consciousness, the feminine aspect of creation, eternal supreme [footnote 38: Shakti — might, primordial energy, force, the force of nature to win the heart of Shakti [footnote 38].

primordial power that had given birth to this whole world. One had only The blessing of a woman was a magical elixir, an expression of the creative energy generously nourished those fortunate enough to receive it. into account, of course, many other factors. The power of feminine woman gives a man strength and inspires the respect of others. Taking absorbed unconsciously a firm conviction: the unconditional support of a feminine principle. Together with these memories, his child's memory traditions, or a manifestation of the primordial creative force of the not matter whether this love was the fulfillment of duty and tribute to old life of her own husband through the power of devotion alone. And it did always counted it an honor to know this woman, who had changed the thousands of people and observed various variations of human fates, he was always invited to weddings and celebrations. Later, having met The family of the former employer treated the widow with respect, she certain to change for the better...

newcomers had managed to raise the first generation whose fate was which was an enormous success. The family of illiterate village

himself had seen the lion's coins, and that fact convinced him of the
or gold at the exit from the fort's gate. Whether fairy tales or not, the
little heaps of ash or handfuls of cold coals, which turned into diamonds
city would be summoned. The midwives were paid for their work with
sometimes, when the female lion had difficult births, midwives from the
It was known that an entire colony of lion lived in (or beneath) the fort.
changing sea of the city, the fort silently observed it.

icebreaker is alien to ice. Condemned to stand at anchor amid the
sailed across the waves of modernity, alien to the new rhythms as an
place to escape the city's noise and bustle. Like a gigantic ship, the fort
centuries before. The cool, echoing underground vaults were an excellent
been extracted from the petals of flowers and the leaves of plants many
emerald-green pigments of the murals did not fade, although they had
elephants, leopards, and ducks. The cornflower-blue, azure, yellow, and
interconnected bastion-towers were covered with ornaments depicting
bluish sea of that city rooftops, had been built by lion in a single night. Six
According to legend, the fort, soaring high on a rocky plateau above the
fortress on all sides.

surviving temples could be discerned. Now the city encircled the majestic
the indicated landmarks had vanished, only the fort and two or three
had made the area unrecognizable.

scheme had been drawn long before Cavalor became a city. Construction
left before a temple — and so on. Unfortunately, this rather detailed
several landmarks: from the well one had to walk to an old tree, then turn
fold-worn skin of an old camel. On it the location of the hoard was tied to
they were marked. Once he had seen a plan drawn on the edge-eaten,
were here, right nearby: all sorts of maps were in circulation, on which
treasures or had tried to find them. Hoards hidden by lion or by kings
magical gold and believed in luck. Almost everyone had heard of the
merciful rulers, and of hidden treasures. Probably they hoped to find
sun-bleached narrow lanes, to the legends of freedom-loving bandits, of
secret kept being born here, generation after generation returning to these

were unchanging.

disappear under the influence of unknown factors. The stars, however, the changeable, unpredictable lines on the palms could appear or be same to the conviction that astrology was more reliable than palmistry. began to appear later, after he had begun to practice yoga. With the years, simply not there, and this puzzled everyone who saw his palms. There was the line of the mind. The heart-line was clear, but the other two were. The life-line, also often called the earth-line, was absent from his palms, as

"Then I won't do anything at all."

everything." He was barely ten then, but he replied without hesitation: son of the respected judge. "Whatever this boy does in life, he will fail at same time, but the most memorable forecast was given to the youngest interpreted them one by one. Over the years, many of those predictions whose family gathered with their astrological charts, and the astrologer among high-ranking officials it was the custom to consult the stars. The royal family. In 1967 they were visited by a well-known astrologer — lived not far from Cwalior, in Shivpuri, the former summer capital of the ... During the last three years before his father's retirement the family

without any stamp was set in soft brown leather smelling of nutmeg.

were kept as a memento. The classmate showed one: a flat golden disc appear. Selling the gold, the family became wealthy, but several coins same coins. This went on for several months, until the stranger ceased to man came again and again bought several kilos of sweets, buying with the. The next day the owner deliberately stayed at the shop late, and the same gold weighing one gram each, mounted in pieces of soft brown leather. of banknotes, the buyer paid with so-called leather coins: round pieces of entered, buying up the entire stock of sweets — several kilograms. Instead closed early. Suddenly a tall and very dark-skinned man in a turban than usual, in those days electricity was still a luxury, and the shops main fortress gate in the old city. One day, he was closing the shop later. His classmate's grandfather owned a confectionery shop in front of the existence of parallel worlds where utterly unknown beings dwelled.

...The best definition of life he had encountered belonged to the well-placed book at the top of the bestseller list.]

By the end of 1922 more than a million copies had been printed, which might, and self-improvement. First published in 1920, it became an instant writer Richard Bach. A story of a seagull who tries to learn about life, [footnote 38: "Jonathan Livingston Seagull" — a novella by the American

the great Dream, but he wanted to wake up...

developed independently of the Dreamer's will. And he, too, was part of His dreams of the Universe. The world's dream by the Creator lived and can move worlds. This world, dreamt up by the Creator, was only one of strong current generates enormous energy. By directing this energy, one answered that it was nothing other than controlled imagination, whose he was asked about the phenomenon of so-called "willpower," he of the mind, was the most powerful energy in the world. When years later products of someone's imagination. Imagination, generated by the power houses, bridges, cars, manmade objects, scientific inventions — were At a certain moment it became clear to him that everything around him — thought, and developed the capacity to evaluate the most fantastic plots. inflamed the imagination, filled it with ideas, gave rise to sudden turns of meaning only years later. And then there were countless comics. They forever, remembering it almost by heart — though he truly understood its Bach's "Jonathan Livingston Seagull" [footnote 38] and loved this book opening entralling worlds. At about seventeen he came across Richard Shakespeare and Voltaire; the great writers carried one into journeys, London did not protest at all against sharing a bookshelf with but most of all he was impressed by the physical strength of Samson. Jack gripping thrillers. Reading about the adventures of Jesus, he felt for Him, stories and Indian myths. The Bible and the Old Testament were like devoured by the hundred. By the age of ten he had read many biblical for boring homework — so captivating were his favorite books, which he guides and the most faithful friends. There was simply not enough time Having learned to read long before school, he considered books the best ...His real passion was reading, but textbooks and homework he hated.

around him, and although he could not pinpoint its source, its pulse was the order of things. An invisible mighty force pervaded everything; order was impossible, though there was no need to hurry into grasping frightening. His thoughts were scattered, and to put all his emotions in themselves into the names of the future. The world was huge, but not The distant echo of the past and the chaotic horns of the present blatted whole and harmonious.

from different angles, and it seemed different, yet always stunningly and the rising moon looked into them. All the objects reflected the world — shards of a gigantic broken mirror — glowed in the descending night, the pygones era had not quite gone. The mosaic of hundreds of windows flickering multicolored lights turned the shops into chests of treasure, as if lanes of the old part of the city, past the bazaar "Maharaj Bada," whose substance. On the way back they raced their bicycles through the tangled and everything around was glued together by this thick, invisible hive; the honeycombs of houses exuded a golden, fragrant honey of life, the sums of Shrimla. At sunset Cwalior resembled an enormous luminous at the domes of the Birja Mandir rising above the city, the upper lake, and bicycles to the surrounding hills, where they would sit for hours, gazing in the upper classes he and a cousin began to skip lessons, riding off on he would take a new book from the shelf.

a beggar. Listening politely to yet another portion of parental admonition, "What awaits him in the future?" His father predicted a dizzying career as The parents lamented: "He won't lift a finger to get a proper education; stuck to him, and he barely passed his final examinations at the college. Despite his enthusiasm for reading, the reputation of a mediocre pupil was something much, much greater.

absolutely true, though dry facts were not always the voices of Truth. Life disease with an inevitable lethal outcome..." The laconic definition rang anyone else. Tell me, what is it?" "Life is an incurable sexually-transmitted Death, and one of her "wards," asked: "You know more about Life than known American author Neil Gaiman. The heroine of the comic was

upon a group of British soldiers flying to outrage a village girl. The ...One day, returning from a routine inspection of the fields, he came

Vikramaditya in 2nd BCE.]

which uses lunar months and solar sidereal years. Introduced by King [footnote 40: Vikram Samvat — the traditional historical Hindu calendar, very seriously.

was responsible for the welfare of his subjects. Taha Singh took his duties mightily landholder, treasurer, and defender of the borders, the jagirdar dues constituted his income, while the rest went to the treasury. As a authority to manage the estates and collect taxes, part of the collected land-holding, or life-estate. The appointed jagirdar was granted the jagirdar of the principality of Kaithal. A jagir was then a kind of feudal in the time of British rule their great-grandfather Taha Singh was the understood that the events took place at the turn of the century.

calendar, when the grandfather told of military adventures in 1870, all fifty-seven years. Like the whole country, their family lived by the Indian years and lunar months, runs ahead of the Western Gregorian by about ...The Hindu calendar of Vikram Samvat [footnote 40], based on solar

Epic Tales from the Life of Gulab Singh

He did not yet know that Time would become the theme of his first book.

amplitude of its sounds — that he could not yet do.

melody, but to correlate and to measure his own essence against the and he instinctively guessed at the magical nature of the inaudible The vast resort of Life swayed in the blinding Void to the beat of Time, that very familiarity grew from beyond, from outside the world he knew. of the worldly kaleidoscope was familiar and comfortable. But the roots of smells, the sounds and the outlines — this whole ever-changing spectrum and dried-up old men on the thresholds of houses, the colors and the seasons, the mothers with infants in their arms, the rowdy adolescents recognizable in everything. The annual harvests and the turning of the

head office. And he set off on foot toward Burma, away from the funeral rites for the dead. Gulab Singh telegraphed his resignation to the Viceroy. Although many died in the area, he survived. After conducting the funeral, Gulab Singh sent desperate SOS signals to his superiors, but help never came. His servants fell ill, and then people began dying by the tens. Gulab Singh was in Assam. But soon Kala-azar — the black fever — broke out there. First one was immediately hired as a telegraph operator in a remote district of Assam. Gulab Singh entered service. He had received a good education, and so realities of life, and at some moment

not allow themselves to be idle. Everyone had to confront the new brought enough to meet basic needs, and let the men of the family could villages in the Agra district, again becoming a landowner. Farming in 1888, after the loss of the principality, the great-grandfather bought five. They were not reduced to beggary, the family had means of subsistence.

Gulab Singh did not even look back at the abandoned fort.

behind him. Sitting in the saddle with his back as straight as ever, Gulab Singh the day his grandfather rode out of the fort, leading a small caravan had three sons, and Gulab Singh was the youngest. He remembered well. By then Gulab Singh was already a grandfather. His son Bhagwan Singh belonged.

to the principality. The family rode out of the town with hastily gathered however, Gulab Singh, the de facto ruler of Kathul, forever lost his right. Ordinarily, jagirs together with all their subjects passed by inheritance, the city by sunset.

Gulab Singh's small army was defeated. He and his family were ordered to leave India, did not like this at all. Troops were sent to Kathul, and Gulab before the main gate of Fort Kathul, and Lord Dufferin, then Viceroy of his horse. He regretted nothing. The bodies of the soldiers were hung. The weeping girl ran off to the village; the dismounted jagirdar calmed English soldiers lay dead — Gulab Singh wielded a sword masterfully. Jagirdar intervened; the intervention turned into a battle, and soon seven

simultaneously a trance-inducing and a sobering effect. Reaching the absorbed in the sounds of the Sanskrit shlokas, which had on him whether she was listening or sleeping. This did not trouble him; he was elderly woman, seated in her chair, breathed evenly, and it was unclear several months passed. One evening, as usual, he was reading aloud. The Putana to the boss's elderly mother.

for timber export, with the additional duty of reading the Bhagavata Persian, and English. Gulab Singh was immediately taken on as manager merchant was impressed at how fluently his guest spoke Sanskrit, allowed to rest. In the evening they got into conversation, and the horse. The merchant ordered the young man carried to his house and Singh lost consciousness from fatigue, but did not fall from the lathered soon submitted entirely to the rider. Approaching the square, Gulab kilometers, both were exhausted. The stallion shifted to a slow trot and saddle, and the stallion launched into a frenzied gallop. After about ten Then, choosing the right moment, with a single leap he vaulted into the speaking softly to the stallion, he began to lead it in a circle, calming it. fine and, besides his excellent education, was a master of horsemanship. "Allow me to try, and see for yourself." Gulab Singh belonged to a noble stallions..."

cheeks: "You look ready to die of hunger — how can you tame The merchant looked doubtfully at the lean young man with hollow

Gulab Singh addressed him: "May I try, sir?"

into a violent irritation.

rider, neither could, nor really tried, to master the enraged animal, he fell subdue a newly purchased unbroken stallion. Seeing that the would-be ... A wealthy merchant was watching the fruitless efforts of his workers to

down in the shade of a tree to give his blistered feet some rest at last.

Reaching one of the border towns, exhausted by the long road, he sat epidemic. He had no definite plans.

— a "gathering, meeting, union" — takes place beside sacred waters.] together," especially in the context of public festivals. Thus, Kumbh Mela "pitcher, pot." The word "mela" means "to unite, to join, to meet, to move" 19th century has been discovered. In Sanskrit "Kumbha" literally means evidence of mass pilgrimages under the name "Kumbh Mela" prior to the century philosopher and saint Adi Shankara. However, no historical Traditionally the founding of the Kumbh Mela is attributed to the 8th- is believed that bathing in the rivers washes away past mistakes and sins. gatherings of monks and ascetics, and various entertainment programs. It numerous fairs, educational and religious talks with saints, mass Utsav (on the river Ganga). The festival is marked by ritual bathing banks of the Ganges), at Nashik (on the river Godavari), and finally at confluence of the Ganges, Yamuna, and Saraswati), at Haridwar (on the places of pilgrimage on the banks of rivers: at Allahabad (at the the planet Jupiter, or Brihaspati. Traditionally this takes place at four Celebrated once every twelve years in honor of every completed cycle of deaths.) [footnote 43: Kumbh Mela — a major Hindu pilgrimage festival and gain in order to attain liberation and to halt the wheel of births and practice of non-attachment to the external world, renunciation of pleasure some texts he is mentioned as his cousin.] [footnote 45: Vasishtha — the and yoga. Uddhava is said to have been Krishna's childhood friend; in Uddhava Gita (the Bhagavata Purana), to whom Krishna explains bhakti [footnote 41: Uddhava — devotee of Lord Krishna, the figure of the

43] at Allahabad [footnote 44]. In search of a Guru.

pleasures. Soon he left Bruma, setting off for the Kumbh Mela [footnote knowledge, for renunciation of the pain of being and of worldly pierced his heart with the needle of longing: for another life, for other people filled him to the brim. Like the sting of a wasp, this sensation everything that could provoke attachment or even dependence in most detachment from all things worldly. The "ascetic disinterest" in Vasishtha [footnote 45]. He was overcome by a strange indifference and experienced an upsurge of spiritual illumination and sank into a state of section where Shri Krishna instructs Uddhava [footnote 41], Gunar Singh

the Guru's wisdom was boundless, and everything he taught Gurb Singh spent his days observing ants, children, birds, and playing bubbles. Yet Teacher was a silent and modest man, who wore only a jincloth and Guru to the ashram in Patiala and remained there for a long time. The initiation. He received it. A few more months passed, he moved with the without faltering from English into impeccable Sanskrit — and asked for He was brought before the sage, and Gurb Singh translated the telegram "I will read it to the Guru only in person."

"Just do it!"

Gurb Singh volunteered to translate the message. bringing the telegram could not read it. Realizing that this was his chance, Patiala to his mentor. The message was in English, and the sadhu Gurb Singh's fate was changed by a telegram sent by the maharaja of obtain an audience with the Guru — he was refused time after time. Singh attempted to attend his darsan, but it was nearly impossible to mentor of the maharaja [footnote 42] of Patiala — Rajendra Singh. Gurb At that time there lived in Allahabad a renowned sage, the spiritual ashes of national leaders, including Mahatma Gandhi, were scattered.] repentance for past sins. For many years Prayag was the place where the years. In the Mahabharata, bathing at Prayag is mentioned as a means of significance; the historical Prayag Kumbh Mela is held here every twelve Jahan, officially renamed Allahabad. The city has great religious completed by 1584 and named "the Abode of Allah," later, under Shah position that he ordered a fort built there. The construction was visited the region in 1575 and was so impressed by the city's strategic Vedas, Prayag was revered as a sacred city. The Mughal emperor Akbar (Jahangir) here. One of the world's oldest cities, mentioned in the ancient scriptures say that the Creator Brahma performed the very first sacrifice known as Prayag, which means "place of sacrifice." Legends and "confluence of the three rivers," Ganges, Yamuna, and Saraswati. It was metropolis in Uttar Pradesh, located near the Triveni Sangam, the [footnote 44: Allahabad (or Ilahabad, now known as Prayagraj) — a

...An opportunity arose to enter a prestigious post, and Chalap Singh gave the land over to the farmers.

Singh's thoughts, vairagya still nested in his heart, and at some point he some income. But the cool wind of renunciation kept ruffling Chalap apart to it. The five villages bought by the great-grandfather brought in For Chalap Singh began what is called normal life, and he tried honestly to undertaking as trying to drink water out of a sieve.

wandering Brahmin with a Kshatriya soul was as hopeless an karma is sometimes too strong to fight. To make a sadhu out of a the ashram come." The Teacher saw Chalap Singh's destiny and knew that destiny. Fulfill your worldly duties, and then, when you wish to return to the unexpected change in his life. The sage said: "Now this is your Time passed, and Chalap Singh returned to the ashram to tell the Guru of anyone, and within a month he was forcibly married.

wandering monk who had renounced the world held little interest for he was warmly received by his happy father and mother. But a prophets almost forcibly took the prodigal son to his parents' house, where family, who had been searching for him all this time. The arriving was detained at the station on a trivial pretext: the inspector contacted his ...On the train, he was recognized by a ticket-inspector, and Chalap Singh

Guru said: "Go. Whatever is to be will not be missed."

What am I doing here?" He asked permission to leave for a time, and the There is no trace of vairagya here, this is all imitation, a masquerade. inner dissatisfaction and unease grew. He asked himself: "And what next? garments of fine cloth, food was served to him on silver dishes — but whispers that he might even become the Guru's successor. He now wore time appointed mahant (head) of the ashram in Patiala. There were Chalap Singh, possessing a lively mind and strong zeal, was after some

[footnote 42: Maharaja — the title of "great king."]

remained with the disciple to his last breath.

original. The lack of convincing evidence led to the complete dismissal of been forged so skillfully that no one could distinguish them from the could not prove that the signatures belonged to him precisely — they had year: from May 1908 to May 1909. In Gulab Singh's case the prosecution government," and the grand trial of the revolutionaries lasted a whole Indian nationalists were accused of "waging hostilities against the public trial.

were confiscated, and Gulab Singh was arrested and sent to Calcutta for a reported him to the police. The promissory notes and most of the money was impossible to conceal such wealth for long, and envious relatives in Shivram-ki-Carhi (their ancestral estate on the bank of the Yamuna), it tidy sum of 30,000 rupees.

Bose, who later fled to Japan. Gulab Singh returned to the village with the 120,000 rupees were handed over to the revolutionary leader Kasebhai conspirators received 500,000 rupees — fabulous money for that time. important British official so deftly that on the forged promissory notes the in Calcutta, Gulab Singh managed to imitate the signature of an peaceful expropriation.

against British rule and were planning to rob a bank. Or, more precisely, a acquainted with an underground movement whose participants struggled again began to feel inner restlessness. At this same time he became After the war he left the service and returned to the village. And soon he However, Colonel C. Singh was not consistent in his career advancement. outstanding military qualities..."

Colonel Gulab Singh is a hero of the Afghan War, possessing all 1895, and a letter written in Queen Victoria's own hand stated that "... adventurer pulsed wildly in his blood. He took part in the Afghan War of the cavalry. Gulab Singh was just over twenty, and the adrenaline of an beneath the status of a jagirdar's son, but he could appoint him colonel of maharaja of Jodhpur. His Highness said that the position in question was classmate and good friend. The prince presented him to his father, the decided to enlist the support of the prince of Jodhpur, his former

two years old, and he still loved to show off. In short, his style of life kith, remarking, "Excellent gun..." Colonel Singh was then about ninety-prougnt a new double-barreled gun, and with a single shot he downed a thick monstaches and an unduenchable enthusiasm. One day someone slim, of medium height, full of energy, he was the owner of magnificent cleveness.

steel. The maharaja applauded. Cular Singh always believed in

soft sound of awakened

Singh put his full weight on the pilt, and the blade slipped out with the Hanging the sword on a ceiling-hook with the scabbard upward, Cular broad-shouldered, hefty guards, Colonel Singh was of rather slight build. Highness, may I try?" The officers smiled discreetly: compared with the that day and observed the fruitless attempts, volunteered: "You solve the problem, and Cular Singh, who happened to be in the palace stuck in the scabbard. The tall Rajasthani guards of the watch could not ceremonial dress. They brought him his parade sword, but it was firmly for a meeting with the Viceroy of India, where he was to appear in full unusual circumstances. One day the maharaja of Jodhpur was preparing The entire life of Cular Singh was a chain of challenges to the most many long years.

his village — but maintained a correspondence with Shri Anupindo for spiritual bath and moved to Pondicherry, while Cular Singh returned to maharishi was released. Soon Anupindo Ghosh left politics for the Anupindo's case, too, no compelling evidence was found, and the future yoga experienced his first mystical and spiritual experiences. In Shri Anupindo. There the future renowned yogi and founder of integral Awaiting trial in Calcutta, Cular Singh became acquainted in prison with practically everything.

officer answered: "Lucky one..." And indeed, Luck accompanied him in Cular Singh said quietly to him: "I did it, and now I'm going free." The present in the courtroom. Leaving the dock and passing by this officer, the charges. The policeman who had arrested Cular Singh was also

observed in accordance with Indian law, and the bandits were death penalty. However, all legal obligations and formalities had to be confirmed by Indira Gandhi herself. This agreement freed them from the famous socialist leader Jayaprakash Narayan under an agreement. In the end, in 1975, Mohar Singh and his comrades surrendered to the needy rural inhabitants.

took the wealthy as hostages and distributed the ransom among the rebels. They did not rob the poor, but in the best traditions of Robin Hood leaders, Mohar Singh and Madho Singh, preferred to be called "raags" — thanks to the bandit formations of dacoits. The two most famous bandit other regions — Blind and Morena — became famous throughout India. In his last year of schooling, the surroundings of Cwalior and several

The Gangster, the Band, and a Visit to Prison

"Curly" Teacher.

address him by the name fully consonant with the path he had chosen: signs his books simply "Shailendra Sharma." Over time, people began to omitting the honorific "Singh" that his grandfather wore with pride, he ... The grandson's full name reads: "Shailendra Bahadur Singh Sharma."

enjoyed every minute.

downpours alternated with sunny days and total calm, and Gulab Singh lived a long life resembling a tropical storm or cyclone: gusty winds and of defeats and the sweetness of the nectar of victories. The grandfather atoms of adventures and mortal dangers; in them there was the bitterness. The tales of Gulab Singh breathed of the glory of epic battles, of the sharp becoming a surname.

apparently a special Brahmin, and the title passed to descendants. Traditionally this was intended only for Kshatriyas, but their ancestor was Bikaner from a tiger and was awarded the honorary title "Singh." In the seventeenth century, one of his ancestors saved the maharaja of entirely corresponded to his surname, which meant "lion."

famous bandits and even introduced him to some of them. On the taking place in a prison. The escorting officer pointed out the most spectators than guards. The whole thing resembled a big festival simply supervision of numerous servants, and the bored police were more like were being prepared in gigantic cauldrons right there, under the brush-ups and exercises; others were getting oil massages, food and sweets in the prison yard, his eyes met an actual picnic: some bandits were doing "characters."

undertook to conduct the tour and show the nephew the principal he was working over the bandits' cases. One of the junior officers folders and papers together with other representatives of the prosecution. On arrival it turned out that the uncle was very busy. Buried in tons of alone.

members were not at all inspired by this idea, and he set off to the prison that in a couple of days a police jeep would be sent for him. Other family look at criminals." But he was unyielding, and in the end it was decided hundreds of lives..." The uncle objected hesitantly: "You're too young to with you to the prison, I want to see these famous bandits, who took When the uncle visited them on his next trip, he addressed him: "Take me from Morena to Cwalior prison to prepare the dacoits' case for court. to see this dacoit! One of his uncles was a state prosecutor and often came captivated him incredibly. Mohar Singh was a living legend, and he had — a modern super-villain, a living hero of the comic books. The story ...Abandoning his homework, he read the interview and imagined a giant

For that time, this was a quite large sum.

Mohar Singh killed a man, the price on his head reached 300,000 rupees, which deprived me and many other people of basic legal rights." After justice. We were driven into a corner by the exhausting legal system, rebelled against the system and was forced to take up arms to fight for "The dispute over my land allotment dragged on so long that in 1958 I

the newspapers even published an interview with Mohar Singh.

temporarily housed in the Cwalior prison. The news made a sensation.

water." The seller obeyed, handing him the glass with trembling hands. "I want to see a show," and turned to the bean seller: "Give me a glass of wolf looks at sheep," addressed him: "Gallu, tamasa te moge? — do you gather around their small group. The dacoit, looking at the gawkers as a Mohar Singh himself spread like wildfire, and townspeople began to They ordered the bean. Within a few minutes the news of the presence of hefty policemen, the strapping Mohar Singh, and the frightened Gallu, to treat to bean, froze, not daring to object. All got out of the car: four only bean for Gallu." The car raked. Gallu, whom the bandit had decided [footnote 46] and the bandit commanded the police inspector: "Stop and The jeep drove up to the hospital. By the gates stood a kiosk selling bean

man." He felt even more ill at ease.

nebrew, the dacoit addressed him cordially, calling him "Gallu," "young things. Learning that the youth sitting opposite was the prosecutor's bandit's bride — enormous mustaches — was elaborately twisted into breathed from him. The bandit had a powerful wrestler's body, and his In the car Mohar Singh sat directly opposite. Danger and self-assurance nebrew at home...

first be taken to the hospital, and then they would drop the prosecutor's everyone looked rather relaxed. It was decided that Mohar Singh would prisoner was accompanied by four policemen and an inspector, and had surrendered voluntarily, there was no special fuss over security: the hospital for a medical examination in the same jeep. Because the dacoit unprepared for the surprise: Mohar Singh was being driven to the awaited the police jeep that was to take him home, and was utterly festive, within him stirred the muted echo of fear. Standing at the gate, he uncomfortable. The atmosphere of the prison yard no longer seemed criminals who had taken so many human lives was extremely a herd. He felt like a lamb. To see, in one place, such a concentration of apbraisingly, like that of cattle-traders impassively evaluating the state of eyes were empty and expressionless: the gaze moved slowly and poridering on a readiness to take life without the slightest hesitation. Their people's faces lay the imprint of an utterly singular, calm self-assurance

the frightened crowd, and the triumphant laughter of the brigand. By ...Reading of Mohar Singh's death, he remembered the taste of the ban,

the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.]

of the two principal political parties in India, in power since 2014 under [footnote 47: BJP — Bharatiya Janata Party, "Indian People's Party" — one glass died at the age of ninety-two.

politicians." In 2020, the man who could scatter a crowd with an empty he said openly: "I understood that there are far greater criminals — Maheshwar, but he never came to love politics. In a newspaper interview supported [footnote 47] municipality of Nagar in his home town of years in prison, the former bandit became the chairman of the BJP-charged with 352 crimes, including 82 murders." Having served eight state that Mohar Singh was "a ruthless, cruel, and hardened criminal, battered folder of documents. The yellowed pages of the dossier dryly ...In the archive of the district police department of Bindra there is still a

reputation.

passing through soft butter. A will that creates both a man and his the power of human will cutting through the will of others, like a knife rather alarming and exciting, but on that day he saw something unique: to the hospital, and he himself was driven home. The adventure was The rest of the trip passed without incident. The bandit chief was escorted sometimes excluded. The mixture is not swallowed but spat out.]

itself may be replaced or mixed with tobacco, and the betel leaves are other substances are added for flavor and breath freshness. The areca [footnote 48: Pan (or pan) — areca nut, lime, and betel leaves, sometimes breath taken away by the show.

"See, Jallu, do you understand now how it's done?" The Jallu had his and within a minute the street was absolutely empty. The dacoit laughed: The crowd recoiled like a wave; several people fell to the ground in panic, the empty glass toward the crowd, bellowing: "Well then, you dorks?" Draining it in a few gulps, the dacoit made a threatening movement with

to say. Probably comics, since to imagine that some other genre could grow up. What these future works would be about, he was hard-pressed. At about the same age he declared that he would write books when he possible connections.

such names, but no one was going to look for any clues or to investigate. Cujarat, Odisha, and Uttar Pradesh there were several small villages with magical codes, mysterious mantras from the past (or the future). In with the dogs, he gave them these names: the words were apasapara, names): Bartoli and Martoli, and no one knew what they meant. Playing past, but from the age of five he constantly repeated two words (or not too early and not too late. He showed no signs of connection with the The Mundan ceremony took place when he was three or four months old, showing effect on the soul's development in the present life.

with attachments, pain, desires, and mental imprints, will exert no erased. And then all the experiences of previous incarnations, together counter-clockwise seven or eleven times, memories of past lives will be. There is a belief that if one seats a child on a potter's wheel and turns it cause distress and must be "healed."

understood as memories of past life. At times these flashes of memory memories in small children of strange places, names, or events are usually are not cut, the child may fail to "accept" the "new" parents. Recurring preserves karmic memories, so it is better to remove them quickly. If they spiritual development, for the pair with which the child was born the child of all the negative of past life and contributes to mental and purification known as Shodasha Samkara. It is believed that the rite frees almost obligatory. The mundan ceremony is one of the sixteen rituals of In Hinduism, the tradition of shaving a child's first hair is very important.

Past Lives. Mahadev

Singh was so strong that he could withstand any verdict, even astral. astral court, but for some reason it seemed to him that the spirit of Mohar karmic laws those who have taken human lives must be judged by the

becoming vulnerable, over-exposed. By the age of ten he stopped. Moreover, sharing these feelings and thoughts with anyone would mean and of who he had been. But there were no words to express this. Subconsciously and consciously he knew of the bath that lay ahead, fire. And yet... The script of every destiny is written before the body's mind, long subject to the hypnotic power of the most ancient of gods — midwife in this, since every human being descends from gaffereis and that dance. Such a trance could go on for hours. There was nothing flame, and only the involuntary movements of his half-closed eyes echoed before a fire his mind would become empty, focused only on the dancing. And then there was the effect of fire. From an early age, every time he sat

inside whispered: "This was part of your life, do you remember?" had held it before. A strange sensation came over him, as if something clear. The smooth ceramic pipe lay in his palm so naturally, as though he day, when he was eight or nine years old, a sadhu gave him a pipe to filled not with tobacco or hashish but with some Ayurvedic herbs. One would take him along. The sadhus often smoked chillums [footnote 48] and from time to time the uncle himself visited these ascetics — and sometimes sadhus came to his uncle, a well-known Ayurvedic physician, it beneath his dignity to prove the obvious.

mosaic of the future were so real that he considered one took these stories seriously. But he was unyielding. The pieces of the at the scope of the child's imagination, the adults smiled, and of course no — but his confidence that this would happen was unshakable. Marveling located, and on what business visitors would come to him, he could not was the rightful owner of this place. To say exactly where this palace was palaces... No, he did not claim he would become a king, since he already four years, during family celebrations, he told the guests about future. And there would be people there, many people. Over the next three or wall, where nearly there would be three buildings and a pond with steps. he would live in a huge house resembling a palace and surrounded by a interest him he could not. He also informed all who were interested that

"great god." Shiva is called Mahadev because all worship him: from the [footnote 40: Mahadev — one of the many names of Shiva, in Sanskrit third eye was closed.

Grabbing a golden trident, Mahadev gazed straight at him: the deity's His neck had shifted slightly from the movement of His right hand. Mahadev were gift with a white tiger-skin, and the garland of skulls on locks of Shiva's hair spread across the sky like a flame. The ribs of Closing his eyes, he shook his head. When he opened them, the tangled 40] stood on the peak of Nanda Devi, with the other. He too the Trishul. was looking at the Lord Shiva Himself. With one foot Mahadev [footnote already familiar silhouettes of the peaks, he suddenly understood that he One day after lunch he went out onto the terrace. And, looking at the felt nostalgia for the place.

unnoticed: the family was preparing to return to Cwalior, and he already — a fantastic spectacle. The magical time spent at the estate flew by twilight they were plunged into the red-dish-gold hazy amber of sunset stupendous views. In the mornings the Himalayas turned golden, and at climbed to the upper tier of the fruit barn and for hours enjoyed the picturesque view was framed by distant snowy peaks. He usually occupied almost three hundred acres of apple orchards: the idyllic panorama took one's breath away. The upper terrace of the great house Nanda Devi — was clearly visible for kilometers around, and the The Himalayan range, crowned by two majestic peaks — Trishul and Badeghwar, to which they had been invited.

of Jamnagar, and her family owned the Devaldhar estate not far from to vacation in the Himalayas. The wife of his eldest brother was a princess In the summer of 1971 he turned fourteen, and the whole family went off clay or soft stone. Widely used in India by ascetics and sadhus.]

[footnote 48: Chillum, or chilam — a smoking pipe, traditionally made of mentioning palaces, visitors, and future books. All this was too personal.

Years later, after many travels, conversations, and meetings with various
many tales.

himself, Shradhanand was a masterful storyteller — and he had a great
mystical tantric smashan of Bengal. Besides being a realized tantric
[footnote 20], was a disciple of a most famous guru from Tarapur, the
acquaintances and visitors. One of them, Shradhanand Brahmascharya
His uncle, the well-known Ayurvedic physician, had many interesting

Blessings and Curses

invisible mark.

sweat of the seated Deity would touch his own skin, leaving forever an
wrapped in elephant-skin, the third eye would be half-open, and the
himself, and this time the ribs of the Lord of the Universe would be
Mahadev. Twenty-five years later, the Destroyer would come to him
As subsequent events would show, he did not need to rush to the feet of

and the impulse had to be suppressed.

was waiting for him. But it was impossible to explain all this to the adults,
bed, he intended to set off for Bageshwar at once, convinced that Shiva
the Himalayas — and this vision lasted about a minute. Sitting up on the
the bag, he suddenly saw the same vivid picture — Shiva rising above
room, looking through a new comic. Leaving absent-mindedly through
from school, he ate his lunch mechanically and lay down on the bed in his
Three months later the unusual vision repeated itself. That day, returning

and to return to worldly life.

remained for him to do but to load with the rest of his family into the car
feeling of disquiet, as though he had to act immediately. But nothing
Was this a play of the imagination? Hard to say. He was overcome by a
which the Lord of the Universe stood. And then the apparition vanished,
drawing him toward Shiva, that he was about to attain those heights on
The vision produced the strangest effect: he felt that some force was

devas (gods) to the asuras (demons).]

culminating in a summoning of Hanuman. If everything was done
earth). And then baked over an open fire... Various rites followed,
dough was kneaded in mid-air so it would not touch a hard surface (the
cloth was spread out, unsifted flour and ingredients poured onto it; the
simply "sweet roti [footnote 23]," prepared from specially selected flour. A
One of the principal components of the ritual is a thick flatbread, called
extraordinary strength and might, he is revered as]

across South Asia, from Thailand and Cambodia to Indonesia. Possessing
seven immortals and the son of the wind-god Vayu. He is widely known
the Ramayana, the ardent devotee of Rama and his companion. One of the
[footnote 21: Hanuman — one of the Hindu gods and a central figure of
scale events.

extraordinary capacity to set in motion, or to reverse, a chain of large-
could set such a task. The gift received could endow a man with the
was not meant for commoners; only kings (and later major politicians)
went wrong, the consequences were irreversible and deadly. This ritual
could perform it correctly, observing the safety measures. If something
ordinarily people. Only experienced agronomists [footnote 25] and tantrics
complex, and the few who succeeded in performing the ritual were not
from a trunk of dark fairy-stories. Preparation for this ritual is rather
that grants great wisdom and unusual abilities. The tale came straight
One day Shradhanand told of a ritual devoted to Hanuman [footnote 21]

the renunciation of sex and marriage.]

Buddhist monastic traditions, brahmacharya implies, among other things,
and mind through ascetic exercises and disciplines. In Hindu, Jain, and
West Bengal, Assam, and Bangladesh. Brahmacharya is control of body
of life according to the Vedic scriptures. May also be a surname or title in
[footnote 20: Brahmacharya — one who practices brahmacharya, the code
with wide-open eyes and a bounding heart.

But at that time, being a ninth-grader, he listened to the adults' stories
all religions are nothing but retold legends grown out of magic and spells.
adults, gathering all that he had learned, he came to the conclusion that

The second portion of flour must be given by one who strictly followed the precept, and therefore happens only very rarely.

tradition invited to various festivals. But such blessings must come from voluntarily. The blessing of *pitras* grants prosperity, so they are by nature was neither unambiguously male nor female. And it had to be given. The first part of the flour could only be given by a *pitra* — a person whose

flour for the flatbread, taken from a eunuch, a sweeper, and a prostitute. was known as "THE *pitra* of Hanuman") consisted of three portions of given voluntarily. The *pitras* for this ritual (which had no name and to the concept of "pitras": in approximate translation it is something representatives of three different castes. In Russian there is no term close The main condition of a successful offering is the *pitras* given by obtained as a result.

performed the ritual, but never specified the purpose, nor what had been Shradhanand Brahmacharya claimed that he had once successfully flour and water.]

— an Indian flatbread, also called "chapati." Prepared from whole-grain leaving the body in the second half of the 18th century.] [footnote 23: Koti Baba Kinaram, a sage and ascetic who is believed to have lived 120 years of renunciation. As followers of Shiva, the *aghoris* trace their origin to obtained through the performance of rites, strict discipline, and practices *aghoris* enjoy great respect and possess the power of healing. last rites contradicts the postulates of orthodox Hinduism. Nevertheless, ornaments and ritual cups from skulls called *kapalas*. Participation in the at cremation grounds, smear their bodies with ash, use human bones as Shraivism arose between the 7th and 8th centuries CE. *Aghoris* often live often in His wrathful form of Bhairava. This tantric, non-Brahmic form of "fearless") — a monastic order of Indian ascetics worshipping Shiva, most observe celibacy.] [footnote 25: *Aggori* (in Sanskrit "aggora" means [footnote 21] cont.: the ideal devotee, he is often worshipped by those who correctly. He would appear and grant what was desired.

consonant with the "right path" that makes life and the Universe possible.] Goals of life (according to Hinduism), dharma denotes behavior support of life, virtue, righteousness. One of the four components of the [footnote 24: Dharma — "duty," ethical law, the laws of fundamental love noticed it.

case, he expressed indignation and revulsion, and one of the priestesses of come to the festival. It was said that he locked himself in his room. In any dances. Learning of the presence of sex-workers, Vivekananda refused to organized, and several prostitutes had been invited there as singers and in any case, it is told that in the Pink City a festival of dance was — some claim the incident took place at the court of the ruler of Jaipur — principality of Khetri in Rajasthan. Although versions of this story differ Vivekananda, was invited by Maharaja Ajit Singh Bahadur, ruler of the story of Vivekananda. Narendra Nath Datta, known as Swami A prostitute's heartfelt blessing can change a life. Take, for example, the them mighty beings may live, as history has confirmed many times.

particular respect. One never knows who these people really are; among well as with dogs and snakes, one is recommended to behave with manners are useful in general, but with members of these three castes, as sweepers with respect — all of them possess special powers." Good Years later, the Guru told him: "Always treat prostitutes, eunuchs, and man."

taken from the house of a prostitute, in whose life there is no "special thought of a man (in the romantic, erotic sense). Therefore the flour is The last part of the flour must be given by a woman who has never being.

whom he feels affection, that person may count on prosperity and well- if a sweeper accepts an invitation to eat in the home or yard of a person to or on anyone else's territory; by tradition they take food in the street. But live by the laws of dharma. They will never eat on someone else's veranda the dharma [footnote 24] of his caste. It is held that sweeper-bhangis still

responsibility upon myself...". Trailanga Swami insisted: "Mother, I beg woman wept: "I am only a randi, a prostitute... How can I take such profession. Trailanga Swami told her of the king's request and the old the red-light district lived a very old representative of the most ancient promised to assist in the search personally. Near the Chauri bazaar, in despair, the ruler of Benares again turned to Trailanga Swami, who incarnation might fail, and the night-butterflies value their reputation. In could have consequences: at the slightest shadow of doubt, the undertake this mission, but no volunteers came forward. Such an act The ruler of Benares announced a search for a woman willing to matter was not about purity of thought, but about absolute honesty.

Mother Gangā, to calm your wrath!" – and this was to stop the flood. The must utter these words: "I who have never desired a man, beg you, O The saint said: "Find a woman who has never once thought of a man. She Trailanga Swami²², who was regarded as a living incarnation of Shiva, from the face of the earth. The King of Benares personally went to inhabitants feared that the fury of the Gangā would wash the eternal city of Lohit Mahasaya²⁶. Once, when a devastating flood struck Benares, the in the name of Trailanga Swami, the famous saint of Benares and a friend

Another story heard in the uncle's house was connected with

saints... Prostitutes are nobler and more honest."

the blessing of spiritual leaders, who today are more politicians than The Guru added then: "The blessing of a prostitute differs greatly from personally.

Vivekananda changed greatly, and today he is venerated as a legendary me and bless me!" She did so. After this small episode the life of Falling to his knees, he touched the feet of the woman: "Ma, please forgive [footnote 25] — was afraid of her. Vivekananda was moved to tears. the words of this song, the woman was asking why he — a samyasa that the worldly will not touch one whose virtue is great. Allegorically, in made me; it is not my fault that I sell myself for money..." Further it sang She sang a bhajan, a poem by the great Surdas: "I am as the Lord has

tear off his clothes... Enraged, he began to recite an anugrahan, a tantric hymn: "What are you, a eunuch? You dance like a girl!" They even tried to facilitate in that house were literally shared), the neighbors began to mock. The next day, when Shradhdhara went to the latrine (the common ground a hole,

gathered around and stared at them as if they were strippers dancing began to dance... let us say, it attracted unwanted attention. People "Swami! Play the harmonium, and I will dance." When the samyasi unknown what came into Shradhdhara's mind that day, but he asked: one day he was visited by a friend, a samyasi and musician. It is was a white crow and kept to the shadows, trying not to stand out. But Shradhdhara Brahmachari found work in a pharmacy. In that area, he in a neighborhood where mostly people of the lower castes lived. At some point, his uncle helped Shradhdhara Brahmachari rent a room

feelings of the so-called "fallen" are like a lightning strike.

persecuted – are capable of the most powerful emotions. The sincere know the true face of humanity – the rejected, the despised, the it will have a long-term effect. So too with a blessing. Only those who prostitute truly curses someone, lifting the curse is practically impossible; brought so many times dwelt a soul possessing a special power. If a had been able to calm the fury of the great river. In a body that had been incarnation had worked, and the Shakti dwelling in a fragile female body beginning, yet the life of a prostitute concerned no one greatly. The the ground. She was dead. The mission had been risky from the very the riverbed. The old woman smoothed the folds of her sari, then sank to water began to recede, as if a giant hand had been pulled somewhere on Addressing the river, she slowly spoke the necessary words – and the long enough to know her fate.

old, she was not as ancient as this river and this city, but she had lived waters the color of tea with milk. At that time she was over ninety years balandhin, and for some time she stood in silence, gazing at the turbulent you, help the city!" The old woman was carried to the river in a

No special initiation was required to understand these laws: one only inevitable tasting of the ripe fruits of karma.

For the wise. Using this knowledge for evil purposes guarantees the greater responsibility by initiating such rites. Tantra was always intended their clients, those who order the rituals, take upon themselves an even for money bear responsibility for the harm they intentionally cause. But never heard of the laws of karma. Of course, tantriks who perform rituals dharmas, it is full of those who use apbicharas, black magic, as if they had and hatred usually make people reckless. Despite India being a land of roomerang to those who sent them, bringing only misfortune. But greed powers could provoke uncontrollable anger. Curses returned like a Tantra was to be kept in the icy sheath of a controlled mind, for these tantric rituals should never be used to cause harm. The red-hot sword of ...Having begun his spiritual journey, he gradually learned that true

Perhaps this was the price for those deaths.

Shradddharamand Brahmachari died, towards the end, he could not even cry. screamed in pain. This continued for two or three months, until plasters or bites on his body, but at the slightest touch the poor man powerless and could not alleviate the patient's suffering. There were no scorpions. It was unbearable to witness this agony, yet the doctors were Brahmachari was pierced by a terrible pain, as if he were being stung by himself with a sheet. Wherever the cloth touched his skin, Shradddharamand The completely naked samylas lay on the bed, unable even to cover. One day, a cousin who was bringing food to the sick man took him along.

ceased. But Shradddharamand Brahmachari himself fell gravely ill.

do not do this...". Perhaps the pleas worked, for the deaths in the house are a samylas, you must forgive people. This is unworthy of you, please the mass deaths and went to admonish Shradddharamand Brahmachari: "You another. Learning of this, his uncle understood the source and cause of they would begin to bleed uncontrollably. All eight men died, one after week, the unfortunate jokers died the same terrible death: in the latrine, curse involving the Maran mantras – an invocation of death. Within a

"Please, join us on the day of the full moon. Together with two other
your inflamed imagination."

Mr. Sharma laughed: "That is impossible, because it is merely a game of
own eyes."

worship. Would you believe in His existence if you saw Him with your
Master suddenly addressed him: "Sir, you constantly criticize the Deity I
came for a transfer, and Lalmani's father was preparing to leave the city,"
the speaker. This ritual continued for almost two years. When the time
Master listened patiently, sipping his tea, never attempting to argue with
it..."

ignorance: "Only a complete idiot worships a monkey; there is no logic in
For several hours, he would try to convince Master that his faith was mere
Sharma would treat him to tea accompanied by an anti-religious lecture
of all religions. Every time Master brought the children home, Officer
everyone simply knew. Lalmani's father was a staunch atheist and a critic
It was known that he worshipped Hanuman, but he did not flaunt it;
and bring them back from school, and everyone called this man "Master."
horse-drawn cart. Every day, a tongawalla driver would pick them up
state of Madhya Pradesh, in Sagat, his children were taken to school by
Hanuman," and Mr. Sharma began his story. When he was serving in the
exchange of pleasantries, he politely inquired about the "incident with
Lalmani's father, a retired officer, received him warmly. After an
one day he came to visit them, traveling a distance of fifteen kilometers.

eyes. This was so intriguing that he insisted on meeting Mr. Sharma, and
Once, Lalmani mentioned that his father had seen Hanuman with his own
and they could talk for hours, mostly about gods, myths, and history.
He and Lalmani Sharma were college friends. Both were fifteen years old,

Brother Hanuman

grasped the art of discrimination quite quickly.

needed attention to the flow of life around him. Despite his young age, he

Hanuman replied: "People reap the results of their own karmas! Gods the world!"

such powerful gods as you exist, then why is there so much suffering in happening was a staged performance. He exclaimed: "I have a question! Despite his astonishment, Mr. Sharma was still convinced that what was determine the timbre of the voice, or whether it was male or female, as it echoing off the walls of an invisible tin dome. It was impossible to two children." Hanuman's voice came from all directions simultaneously, "From this moment, the boy will begin to improve. The other will have since birth, and the other is completely childless..."

some problems. One of them has a son who has been mentally retarded "Dada, forgive me for disturbing you, but these devotees of yours have

Clutching a mace, Hanuman addressed Master: "What do you want?" the features of the deity were indistinguishable due to the radiance. Hanuman. A powerful, tall figure radiated a bright white neon light, but flash of light blinded them: right in the center of the ritual altar stood The ceremony had been going on for about half an hour when suddenly a

Dada." That was what he called Hanuman – "elder brother."

top. When everything was ready, Master said: "Now sit quietly. I will call chowkburnas²⁸ with colored patterns, and placed sweets and flowers on Cow dung was arranged in a square shape, upon which they laid a

panorama was wonderful, and a light breeze was refreshing and calming. hills. The trip was beginning to seem pointless to him, although the began to prepare the ritual site, while he sat nearby, absently gazing at the supplies. Stopping at an unremarkable spot, Mr. Sharma's companions mountains, taking about ten kilograms of sweets, flowers, and other ritual invitation. On the appointed day, their small group set off for the Considering the upcoming expedition a prank, Mr. Sharma accepted the

for yourself. But there is one condition – you must observe silence..."

devotees, we will invoke Hanuman. If He decides to appear, you will see

lived in Varanasi, presumably from 1807 to 1887. He is still considered a spiritual abilitie. His monastic name was Swami Chakraborti Saraswati. He (also Trailanga Swami, Telang Swami) – a yogi and mystic famed for succession. Born 30.08.1828, left his body 28.08.1887. ²⁵ Trailanga Swami this ancient yoga among householders, and the second Guru in the line of the first known disciple of Mahavatar Babaji, who spread the science of ²⁶ Lahiri Mahasaya (Shyama Charan Lahiri, or Yogiraj Lahiri Mahasaya) –

mysticism.

silence. Or perhaps it was simply a hereditary predisposition, without any too strong, or the loss of sight was the result of breaking the prescribed Perhaps that night in the mountains he was exposed to energies that were

Soon he had to retire.

with them he was forced to bring objects close to his eyes to see them. deteriorate rapidly, and he had to wear glasses with thick lenses, but even some time later, he was transferred to another city. His eyesight began to glass, but found nothing of interest.

Mr. Sharma, and the next day he returned to the scene with a magnifying They returned to the city in silence. What he had seen did not convince did the tall figure in the center of the improvised altar.

traces of the ritual offerings (the sweets, flowers, cow dung) vanished, as rushing over their heads, and along with this "supersonic" effect, all A sound like a clap was heard, as if caused by a sharp gust of wind call you."

show us your grace and grant us your blessings, and appear again when I "Dada, we are so grateful that you have appeared. Please continue to Master whispered to Mr. Sharma to be silent, and thanked Hanuman: just bestowed his grace upon the devotees.

us." Evidently, some exceptions were made, for Hanuman himself had never interfere in the karmic cycles of men. Your affairs do not interest

gentle sadness, as if he were trying to recall the vision of a royal firebird he try to apprehend any moral lesson. In his narration, there were notes of ...Telling this story, Father Lalmani did not sound skeptical at all, nor did invitations.

coachman called the Deity "elder brother," and He responded to his between the Master and Hanuman had been quite close, if a simple movement of pedestrians and cars. It occurred to him that the relationship For some time, Mr. Sharma sat at a tea kiosk, watching the bustling birth to two children, a boy and a girl.

their sons had improved significantly, and the childless couple had given and those two devotees had died. But the mental development of one of Arriving in Sagor, he made inquiries. It turned out that both the Master converse on abstract topics.

softened. He simply wanted to drink tea with the coachman again and he was not going to discuss religion; his attitude toward it had not nostalgia. Sometimes he felt the need to speak with the Master again. No, And yet, after retiring, Mr. Sharma began to experience strange waves of and life coordinates.

destroyed the carefully constructed and finely tuned system of his beliefs would have been an admission of something unknown and could have and still did not believe in the existence of divine forces. Such thoughts After what had happened, Mr. Sharma felt no spiritual transformations circles, triangles. The same is done at the site of certain rituals.

nice, motifs and symbolic geometric patterns include lines, dots, squares, refers to the decoration of the floor with various designs using flour and Punjab, Haryana, and some parts of Uttar Pradesh. The term chowkbunnas walking Shiva of Varanasi." ²⁸ Chowkbunnas – a folk art practiced in years and was an incarnation of Shiva. Sri Ramakrishna called him "the abilities and longevity. It is believed that Trailanga Swami lived for 280 legendary figure in Bengal. There are numerous stories about his logic

He had no other ideas about the future. In 1973, he joined the National careers in the family was a convincing argument.

But the very fact that there were already stories of successful military and stability. His parents did not pressure him in making the decision, which had always been associated for him with order, fortitude, resolve, classmates. Or perhaps because of the appeal of the military uniform, was in excellent physical shape, and was much stronger than many of his attractive to him. Perhaps because he was the best marksman in college. By about the age of sixteen, the idea of a military career began to seem

On the Brink of a Military Career

impossible to ignore it.

True faith is like a lightning strike, and after the initial shock passes, it is own life was being told. His beliefs and faith were being put to the test.

Impressions with Father Lalmami's story. In that moment, the story of his to mind at such moments, and he did not try to compare his own absolutely empty but focused. It is unlikely that anyone's stories can come

When Hanuman appeared before him years later, his mind was requires courage and a readiness to submit to higher forces.

sufficient awareness and strength of desire. Thus he understood: faith cannot remain blind. To comprehend the incomprehensible, there must be must make a leap of faith. If a miracle is near and can be known, one

Then another thought visited him: having seen manifested divinity, one is believing," had always seemed one hundred percent true to him.

believe in something without seeing the object of faith? The saying "seeing they respond, if people are indifferent to them? Is it possible to blindly faith? Can the wave of a mortal man's love reach the gods? And why did a simple man, but his devotion proved unshakable. What nourished his between potholes. Father Lalmami's story had stirred him: the Master was It was time to return to the city. The road was bumpy, the bicycle wove

that had flown over him without dropping a single magical feather.

rightly lit parliament building. Exhausted, he slept that night without debating, the cadet units marched through Raisina Hills, past the greeted the sunset. The flags slowly descended, the ceremony concluded. drummers performed solos, the final drumroll sounded, a long bugle call Army bands took their positions before the presidential box, the before dawn, the solemnity of the event compensated for the lack of sleep. The winter sun was mercifully mild, and although they had been roused

of this from his column, but the seduction was known to everyone.

marched, their movements forming intricate patterns. He could not see all was a truly momentous day. Playing in unison, the army and navy bands flags were unfurled. Hundreds of cadets marched before the stands, and it sounds of fanfares, units presented arms, the national anthem was played. President of India with his bodyguards was marked by the trumpet celebrations – was observed on January 28, 1976. The arrival of the „Beating Retreat“²⁰ – the official conclusion of the Republic Day

were contagious.

were exhausting, but the excitement and enthusiasm of the other cadets for marching and shooting. Life in the barracks and constant drill training extreme responsibility and took second place in the national competitions seriousness of what was happening, he approached the training with grounds of a garrison near Palam Airport, in Delhi. Aware of the Pradesh. Preparation for the event was conducted in a camp on the with the best cadets of India, he was to represent the state of Madhya was selected to participate in the Republic Day parade, where, together team. His grandfather's genes undoubtedly helped: he took first place and completed another training camp and made it onto the Cavalier shooting Science, Economics, and Geography at Maharani Lakshmi Bai College, he The following year, while pursuing a Bachelor's degree in Military enthusiastically joined the selection process.

for the preliminary selection of recruits for army positions, and he he attended a training camp. College students were invited to such events Cadet Corps, the youth wing of the Indian armed forces, in October '74,

...The sense of humor of the high-ranking army officer conducting the made by the candidates was as important as the scores obtained.

interview. According to rumors, this was the main one: the impression anxiety was off the charts. The final test was an informal personal psychological, physical, and motivational tests – the level of stress and there. Over the following five days, candidates underwent complex The final exams were held in Allahabad, and in November 1977 he went bookworm, he noted this information to himself.

You must read this, it's amazing! I guarantee you'll like the book." Being a couple of times, and then told him about Autobiography of a Yogi. "Sharma's conversation about the ideas of Vivekananda, Harpal mentioned yoga a various interesting topics not related to the upcoming exams. In a conversationalist and as well-read as he was. It was great to discuss quickly became friends. His new acquaintance was an excellent cadets, he met a young sergeant named Harpal Singh Dyal, and they at the Kamble camp, near Nagpur in Maharashtra. There, among other training conducted in three stages. He applied for a month-long training selection system was rigorous: candidates had to undergo additional the candidate was granted the rank of Second Lieutenant. But the enough to pass a five-day selection process. If the outcome was positive, application. Moreover, there was no need to take written exams; it was appear before the Service Selection Board, and he submitted an The awarded 'C' certificate of the National Cadet Corps entitled him to become an officer of the Indian Army and serve his country;

inspired him and confirmed the correctness of his choice. Yes, he would The scale of the celebration, the presence of important state officials, with the President itself was formal, but the atmosphere was magnificent, and it had everything: lush gardens, stables, and countless lawns. The tea the world, the presidential palace with 340 rooms, occupied 30 hectares, for tea, and it was wonderful! The largest residence of a head of state in The next day, the best cadets were invited to the former Viceroy's Palace dreams.

impression. Secretly, he wondered whether a military career was the right the strictness of army discipline awakened anxiety in him and left a heavy although he had no doubt in himself. Overall, the selection process and over. Whether his answer satisfied the examiner remained a mystery, since she's no longer there, there's no reason to fight." The interview was replied: "Then the fight will end, because it's a fight over the girl, and There were many possible answers: he had nothing to lose, and he

then what?

help. – And if she simply runs away and doesn't come back with help, I will try to fight off the attackers. And I will tell her to run and call for protect her! – Why, who is she to you? – She is my sister. I will protect her, out what is happening. – Two hoodlums are bothering her. – I will try to – You hear a girl's cries for help. What are your actions? – I will go to find

Another question sounded less strange, but was also quite unusual:

test had no exact answer, only a multitude of probabilities.

examiner: it was quite possible he was just amusing himself, or that the leaving the mute to helplessly watch the adulterers. He glanced at the affair between the deaf man and the blind man's wife take its course, misinterpretation was right. And so he decided to let the fictitious illicit could read the sketch with his fingertips. But the probability of would be enough for him to draw what had happened, and the blind man solve this puzzle: if the mute really wanted to ruin the deaf man's life, it answer simply did not exist. Still, he thought of a few convoluted ways to The recruits offered various options, but none fit. Perhaps the correct

manage to inform the blind man about what had happened?"

man to tell him what was happening. Now tell me, how did the mute mute saw the deaf man kissing the blind man's wife. He went to the blind "We have three people: a blind man, a mute, and a deaf man. One day, the know the answer.

to say. One of the questions was simple, but even years later he did not interview was very peculiar. Or perhaps it was worldly wisdom: it's hard

liberation. He had always thought that nothing was more important or safe passage to the other world, a favorable rebirth, or moksha – death. All relatives must participate in the final rituals to ensure the soul's. The funeral rites for the deceased are held on the thirteenth day after. According to Hindu customs, the memorial ceremony...

those famous glamorous and noisy Bombay parties.

a wild social life that ended so abruptly, right in the middle of one of collector soon knocked on his door. Apparently, to collect the payment for alcohol and other pleasures of the rich and famous, and the chief tax become an unbearable trial. His brother became addicted to expensive stage name "Ravi." But sometimes, suddenly acquired money and fame started in leading roles in several Bollywood films and had taken the daughter, and everything was simply wonderful. By 1933, Mahendra had aristocrat, the princess of Jamnagar, Kumari Harshad Kumari, they had a were placed on him. Handsome and successful, he was married to an. By the age of 33, Mahendra was the pride of the entire family; great hopes death was a crushing blow.

during his difficult exams and chose not to inform him. His brother's attack. His relatives decided that such news might greatly upset him heard the message that his elder brother Mahendra had died of a heart deliver bad news. Standing in the empty living room, he nevertheless Mumbai. The servants averted their eyes; no one wanted to be the first to. The house greeted him with a hollow silence; everyone had gone to

Death, Wedding, and the Beginning of the Search

not a promise, but a sentence.

rank of Second Lieutenant. The future was inevitable, only now it seemed he had successfully passed all the tests and was recommended for the out now would be cowardice. The final results came faster than expected: unbecoming a future officer. In any case, the exams were over, and packing reveille and daily shaving, yet he reproached himself for thoughts choice. Life in the barracks got on his nerves, not to mention the 4 a.m.

thought that disrespect for the dead could bring nothing but misfortune. relatives was joined by an ancient widowed aunt. He could not shake the prison, fell into a diabetic coma and died. Then the list of deceased another uncle, a successful lawyer who had once taken him on a tour of a bomb suddenly died of a heart attack. Another month passed, and a month later, the uncle who had celebrated his son's wedding with such human sincerity during mourning.

the commercial side of family relationships and the influence of money on purely practical aspect. In the years to come, he would learn much about decision to throw a wedding banquet despite the family tragedy had a friendliness, but now it had been shamelessly torn away. Of course, the had slumbered beneath a thin film of prescribed, measured familial envious of his father's status and his brother's success. Well-hidden envy transformed into an awareness: all these bustling relatives were simply bodies, he fell into deep contemplation. Gradually, his sorrow wedding, choking on the aromas of the dishes and the smell of heated surrounded by smiles and laughter, deafened by the noise of the lavish at his cousin's wedding, the impossibility of mourning his elder brother... grotesqueness of the situation was unbearable: the obligatory attendance more like a celebration of his brother's untimely death. The burning a grotesque violation of the sacred tradition of farewell. The wedding felt multitude of relatives had gathered for the wedding, which struck him as emotional state and attending the upcoming festivities was futile. A him, but trying to explain the monstrous incongruity between his him into the car. The demand to attend the wedding seemed insulting to importance of fulfilling familial duty, his cousin almost forcibly shoved older cousin came to pick him up. Impatiently and insistently urging the already been spent, the show had to go on. He was home alone when his the same day as Mahendra's final rites. The money for the celebration had His uncle refused to cancel his son's wedding, which was scheduled for but him seemed to see a problem in this.

tragedy was pushed into the background by another event, and no one sacred than the duty of bidding farewell to a loved one, yet this family

the army, because he did not wish to part with his long hair. This was the accord. He announced that he could not cut his hair short, as required by decision to abandon the prospects of a military career came of its own. The need to find answers overwhelmed him to such an extent that the

Autobiography of a Logi

world.

existence, and no one was capable of describing the entire picture of the fundamental questions, as the authors specialized in individual aspects of them to the shelves. The wisdom of books did not answer the. For now, he continued turning the pages of his beloved books, returning origin of spirit, not God.

the eternal sowing and reaping of human souls made him think about the meaning, began to doubt its inevitability. The discovery of the meaning of doubt, and uncertainty: he came to know death and, understanding its. In the years that followed, Loga removed the useless lenses of illusion, guarantee a diploma: only an express course could answer the questions. Life contained all the necessary clues. However, gradual learning did not knew that answers could only come from within and that the very act of the soul is, and where it resides before the body's birth. Intuitively, he to understand the paradox of life: why people come into this world, what death was and what happened after it. Perhaps, to do so, he first needed answers to them was difficult. And yet he struggled to understand what knew: the questions he was asking were called "existential," and finding. Continuously pondering the nature of death and the meaning of life, he succession of deaths gave rise to a particular kind of reflection within him. forever changed his understanding of duty, honor, and blood ties. The lack of basic human compassion and respect for a sudden tragedy had orthodox believer, but he considered the final rites sacred. The relatives, Mumbress gave way to a cold, restrained anger. No, he was not an by many of those who had so recently rejoiced at the celebration.

campfire, and the acrid taste of death and the pain of loss were now felt. The festive atmosphere of the wedding evaporated like the scent of

immortality in the book. This astonishing theme was only hinted at in Traveler, following in their footsteps. The author also touched upon in the book had already walked this path, and he would become a would practice only Krishna Yoga and nothing else. The people mentioned explosion, and the decision became irrevocable. From that moment on, he was the yoga to which he must dedicate his life. The thought was like an conveying the general meaning), he understood with ringing clarity: this and thoughts. Upon reaching the description of Krishna (rather vague, but teaching, and the subsequent realization resonated with his own emotions memory: the description of the spiritual search, the acquisition of the people before. The names and events mentioned in the book echoed in his wondered why all these faces seemed so familiar, as if he had met these Chatterjee, who taught Yogamanda Sanskrit, and at the image of Babaji, he ...Looking at the photographs of Lahiri Mahasaya and Ashutosh

the book in one breath, overnight.

little bookshop, he paid 10 rupees for Autobiography of a Yoga. And he read delivered a message that changed his life. In December 1928, in a quiet everything, including one's destiny. Consciously or not, Harpal had they never met again, yet some seemingly chance encounters can change later learned that Harpal Singh Gial had moved to Great Britain, and a book recommended to him by a young Sikh at the training camp. He Monotonous and dreary days dragged on. At some point, he remembered details, and they stopped bothering him with questions.

pretext for refusing a promising and stable career! He refused to go into was suffering from unrequited love. After all, there had to be a valid decided that he had lost his mind from grief over his brother's death or His relatives were utterly astonished by this explanation. Everyone meaning of life.

of his age simply could not be preoccupied with questions about the the seventies (and even earlier), it was widely believed that a young man sharing his true thoughts and feelings with anyone seemed impossible. In only explanation he could think of. Articulating his inner turmoil and

years searching for a teacher and never find one. Some sink into despair, seeker find a true guide, will he follow the right path? People can spend such a search is always accompanied by anxiety and doubt: will the the book.

for a guru who could teach him all the practices so vaguely mentioned in was set, and it brought immediate relief. He needed to begin the search perform a thousand Kriyas each day until he attained samadhi. The goal in the absence of any information about the technique itself, he decided to necessary protection on the battlefield of life.

this yoga could become his Guide, and he also thought of it as armor, the feeling of sorrow that had settled in his heart. Though still unexplored, world. He also hoped that the practice would help dissolve the deep escapism, with an attempt to flee irritating daily life into an imaginary the realms of higher knowledge. Its concept had nothing to do with instrument of knowledge, a science that leads beyond the ordinary into Giri was proof of the truth of the Teaching. Kriya Yoga is a powerful seemed absolutely authentic. For him personally, the story of Yuktaswar who ascended into the astral world, moving between different universes, dead with such detailed descriptions as Sri Yuktaswar. The story of a yogi ... Few heroes of Indian mythology had returned from the realm of the

book's text again and again. It seemed to contain a hidden message.

paramount importance, but in the years that followed, he returned to the was vivid and convincing. At first, the theme of eternal life was not of death, about the ability to dissolve into atoms and restore the body anew, not a hallucination or a vision. Yuktaswar's testimony about life after after death, and Yogananda firmly asserted that their communication was Yogananda's teacher, Yuktaswar Giri, appeared to his beloved disciple known contacts between mortal men and eternal beings.

Lahiri Mahasaya relatively recently, in 1881 – and this was the last of all The Master of the tradition, the immortal Babaji, had communicated with passing, but it ignited his imagination.

from a crevice in the rock, but the ground was dry and scorched. The heat it was completely unclear what it all meant. A trickle of water seeped on a seashore, the sun-bleached remains of their shells were scattered, and strange: small white crabs were scuttling around them. Everywhere, as if unhurriedly, savoring the taste of fresh bread. Adam noticed something began to disperse. Noon was approaching: they stopped to rest and ate dry, they climbed for almost two and a half hours until the clouds finally breathtaking views of Ewalior from the summit of Mount Amara. That few flatbread and filling his army canteen with water, they enjoyed the he felt free and almost happy during these short expeditions. Taking a into the mountains. Absorbing the landscapes and the peace of the hills, of coolness, he and his friend and neighbor, Adam Ubadmyal, would go in the summer of 1979, whenever the clouds provided even a semblance in choosing company, avoiding both his peers and adults.

only stirred in him a longing for solitude. He became extremely selective yoga. The relentless noise of the city and the endless bustle of the streets master's degree in political science changed nothing: his only interest was A year had passed since he graduated from the institute. Obtaining a

The Hermit of Mount Amara

through life.

highest triumph ever achieved by man: the logic art of conquering Death his journey, holding only a book in his hands, but in it was described the Rabbit – and led her into the altered reality of Wonderland. He set out on motivation, and imagination. Curiosity spurred Alice to follow the White with curiosity, and the length and purpose of the journey depend on will, unforgettable marks on the maps of destiny. All great adventures begin bitterness of any failure has the taste of life, not death. Even a fiasco leaves existence, no matter how painful the process of life itself may be. The abstract yet entirely real goals. Every living being strives to prolong its Humanity possesses an incredible and astonishing ability to pursue or worse – into the ordinariness of so-called normal life.

Remaining in the lotus posture, the yogi continued to silently watch the
are leaving now...”

He hastily drank some water and thanked the host: “Thank you, papa, we
extended it, indicating that one should drink without touching the rim.
Filling a small, shiny brass cup on a long handle with water, the ascetic
lifted himself on his hands and took two “steps” toward a water pot.
The sadhu did not rise. Instead, with his legs still folded in padmasana, he

figure: “Papa, we are thirsty, please give us water.”

from fear, or perhaps in spite of it, that he politely addressed the seated
saw, they struggled with awkwardness; he felt a pang of fear. And it was
and his arms rested on the floor along his body. Astonished by what they
mistake reached his ears. The ascetic’s legs were folded in padmasana^{ee},
dim light; his gray hair and beard were tied into knots, and his large
Marked and lean, he wore only a loincloth, his dark body glistening in the
newcomers; his black eyes shone from beneath bushy white eyebrows.
darkness. Inside, they saw a permit, gazing impassively at the
they tried to peer inside: they pushed the door and stepped into the
stone body of the mountain. There was also a small door there. Intrigued,
stones. The whole structure formed something like a shelter adjoining the
overhang with a wall built against it, constructed from large, uneven
Continuing along the narrowing trail, they noticed another stone
ghum^{ee} with fresh coals—a sure sign that a sadhu lived nearby.
overhang stood a large shrine^{ee}, marked with red sandal paste^{ee}, and a
stone overhang jutting out above a barely visible bath. Beneath the
Descending along the rocky bed of a dried-up stream, they saw a small
century in Punjab.

^{ee} Sikhs – followers of Sikhism, a religion that originated in the 15th
liberation from the cycle of births and deaths.

^{ee} Moksha – liberation, freedom. In yoga, the ultimate goal of practice,
was growing more intense; it was time to go back.

சிட்ஹர்ஜி பாக் 2, a young and highly educated descendant of the Rajput interest club than an educational program. The group, founded by "Kriya Yoga Group" and went in to inquire. It turned out to be more of an gate that resembled the entrance to a palace, he noticed a sign reading share practical information about Kriya Yoga. In June, passing by a ridge several more months passed, he still knew no one in Cwalior who could

Anandamayi Ma

The Valor of a Kshatriya, the Power of a Brahmin. The instruction of

premonition of approaching change became distinct and acute.

mad. It was impossible to guess what exactly lay ahead, but the sharpened, and the urge to find a spiritual path was nearly driving him subconscious began to prevail over his logical mind, his intuition taken in the sadhu's dwelling had produced some strange effect. His mystery, yet he could not shake the feeling that the sip of water he had in any case, the identity of the ascetic with the shining eyes remained a people believed that the immortal sage Amara still lived on the mountain. if merely a wandering ascetic, or சிட்ஹர்ஜி Amara Guru himself? The local Even years later, he did not know what to think of this strange story: was

several times, finding no traces of the dwelling whatsoever.

stone flank of the cliff. Bewildered, they walked up and down the trail second overhang, but there was nothing there either, except for the vast to see the improvised dwelling with the stone wall and door under the if there was no trace of the wishful or dream. Going further, they expected sadhu's dwelling. The overhanging rocky ledge was in place, but beneath same shells of white crabs, and they turned onto the path leading to the Passing the previous resting place, Padam Ubaidhyaya pointed out the later, they repeated the expedition, deciding this time to go even further. yet for some reason he kept thinking about this yogi. A couple of months They did not speak of the strange encounter, there was little to discuss, heading to the city.

toward the highway almost at a run, and soon were sitting in a bus "guests," and they hurried to leave. Though tired, the friends descended

From yoga discussions, they would move on to the nature of the aura and to his younger friend's house, and they would talk for hours over tea. Every time he returned to Cwalior, S.K.S. would go straight from the train literally down to the line.

Yogananda: S.K.S. knew the Autobiography of a Yogi almost by heart; the subject of lively discussions was Krishna Yoga and the life of Sri Sri Sri. Their reading cemented their friendship, as both loved good books. Often father and grandfather, S.K.S. was an insatiable reader. A shared passion and trust as the famous hero. Having inherited a vast library from his grandfather, he was clothed in the same simple white kurta the legendary warrior-king of Maharashtra. The visual resemblance was stark, and his name of Sri, he strongly resembled Shri Sri Sri. S.K.S. was charismatic and charming: with his dazzling smile, black solitude in the palace—an ideal refuge from the bustle of city life.

practice at the estate, and he too was given keys. Now he could enjoy Even when S.K.S. was in Pune, some group members continued to practiced pranayama, breathing, then moved to another hall to meditate. courtyard were entirely at their disposal. The members of the Krishna group The endless, echoing halls of the vast estate and the spacious inner them together was yoga and a thirst for spiritual discovery.

numerous connections and mutual friends. But what primarily brought Cwalior. Their families were acquainted, and they joyfully discovered Dynasty of Chhatrapati: they were also related to the Marathas of aristocratic Kshatriya lineage, tracing its genealogy back to the Maharaja that S.K.S. was 13 years older. The new friend's family belonged to the after some time. But their friendship flared up instantly, despite the fact Most of the time, S.K.S. was in Pune; they managed to meet only him.

visit the estate frequently, and the group became a long-awaited outlet for yoga with like-minded people, without fear of ridicule. So he began to philosophy. At last, he had found a place where he could freely discuss dynasty of the Chhatrapati royal clan, was open to all interested in yoga and

though his coal-black hair and beard had turned snow-white. Over time, remained the same charismatic conversationalist and gifted orator, renowned yoga masters, wrote books, and guided spiritual seekers. Z.K.Z. stepping a little ahead, it is worth noting: over the years, both became the exact distance to the goal was impossible.

Analyzing the path traversed, one could glimpse destiny, not measuring boundaries of reality. Purpose and destiny sprouted from the same root. Remaining diligent students of life, both sought to explore and test the yoga group could resume its sessions.

one blow, shattered the lock. The palace was theirs again, and the Kriya the aid of Kshatriya valor comes the power of the Brahmin!—and with a heavy hammer. Taking the tool from Z.K.Z.'s hands, he exclaimed: "To came up again during their unsuccessful attempts to break the locks with Z.K.Z. had often spoken about the valor of the Kshatriyas, and this topic him and a mutual acquaintance, Mr. Padam, for help. Before this incident, his uncle, and no one answered the door or the phone. So Z.K.Z. turned to returning from Pune, Z.K.Z. found the doors closed; he could not locate uncle simply locked the passage to another part of the complex. Upon Z.K.Z. was engaged in a property dispute with his uncle. One day, the water, and they drifted, lying on their backs in lotus pose...

gazing at the starry sky, the moon was reflected in the surface of the dark the ancient reservoir, Canga Jagat Baori, carefully avoiding water snakes, backdrop for their nocturnal expeditions. They would swim for hours in The old palace of the Cwalior rulers, Jai Vilas, was another mystical wandering there until dark, continuing their endless conversations...

would pick him up on his scooter, and they would head to the hills, well-read and genuinely enjoyed each other's company. Sometimes Z.K.Z. Both friends needed an interlocutor of equal intellect; they were extremely midnight, and Z.K.Z. would stay overnight.

types of the afterlife. The conversations often continued long past the origin of astral beings, debate the hierarchy of groats, the levels and

their presence and have no need for spiritual education or initiation. Gifted with supreme knowledge, these beings come to bless others with. Only a few souls among the billions born on Earth are born as Siddhas.

sports even a hint of the Divine that was felt in her presence.

the masters of Yogananda's lineage, and he burned with the desire to mentioned in the Autobiography of a Yogi, was warmly disposed toward Anandamayi Ma^{es} was to come to Vrindavan. The famous saint. The hot month of July was drawing to a close when he heard that command to action.

direction of movement, a confirmation of purpose—not just a sign, but a awakening curiosity, then meditation was the moment that changed the deserved attention. If Yogananda's book had been the starting point, would become the meaning of his entire life; nothing else simply were overwhelming. With piercing clarity, he understood: self-inquiry power of the silence of his own inner space and the secrets stored there shoulders, bringing him out of his trance. The astonishing depth and About an hour later, the ritual ended, and someone shook him by the. Thoughts and sensations ceased.

and then, somehow, everything he was became concentrated there. was an almost physical burning sensation in the space between his brows, point between his eyebrows, he fell into the Void within. At first, there meditation for the first time. Closing his eyes and concentrating on the echoed from the walls of the inner courtyard. That day, he sat in into the crackling fire, ghee was poured, and the exclamations of "Gurubai," ritual began around five in the evening; handfuls of grain were thrown conducting a fire ceremony, a havan, and he was among the invited. The ...On July 11, 1929, one of the members of the Kriya group was motivation and resolve.

strong intentions indeed determine the future; everything depends on came through persistent practice. In the end, their life stories proved that the topics they discussed transformed into personal experience; answers

words sank into his soul, and in the years that followed, he performed his
He perceived this short phrase as a personal instruction, an Upanishad. The

And Anandamayī Ma again immersed herself in a transcendent state.

progress in sadhana?" – "By doing, you will succeed (Karoḥ to yoga)." –

dared to break the silence of the room: "Mother, how can I achieve
Being the youngest in the room, he remained silent, and only Dr. Auro

food she had prepared herself...

Benares, she would invite his future Teacher and generously treat him to
that time, he did not yet know that whenever Anandamayī Ma visited
Those present fell silent: he had received prasāda directly from Ma... At

front of her and handed them to him. Those around

blessing him, and then took walnuts, raisins, and apples from a box in
blushed deeply: unexpectedly, Anandamayī Ma touched his head,

warned beforehand not to touch Ma's feet. As he bowed in prayer, he
palpable peaceful vibrations. Entering, they all bowed: they had been

beautiful, though she was over eighty. The room was filled with distinctly
white sari, with shining eyes and dark hair, the saint was still strikingly

wooden bed; on either side of her stood two female samnyasīs. In a simple
small room on the first floor. Anandamayī Ma was sitting on a simple

number of people trying to see the saint. Finally, they were led into a
wait took about two hours, which was a mere trifle given the countless

the lineage of Yogānanda, they asked permission to see the Mother. The
Introducing themselves at the ashram gate as followers of Kṛiā Yoga in

pleasant, and they arrived at the ashram in high spirits.

drizzling rain temporarily cooled the heat, making the journey quite
Mathura by train, they hired a horse-drawn carriage to Vrindavan. A light

Vrindavan in the hope of obtaining an audience with the saint. Reaching
and the doctor's relatives, Parampādya and Pachori, they decided to go to

Together with acquaintances from the Kṛiā Yoga group, Dr. D. P. Auro
Anandamayī Ma, born in a state of omniscience, was one such soul.

room, he found himself in the courtyard. The new vision was truly this vulnerability looked bitter. Drifting slowly through the adjacent pleasant: the motionless body lying below was utterly defenseless, and perception at once, 360 degrees around. Actually, the feeling was not balloon. The very nature of vision changed: everything entered his field of body. The sensation was frightening: he hovered near the ceiling like a mind was still working. Knowing of such cases, he realized he had left his saw his own motionless body beneath him. Some tiny particle of logical separated from the physical, his head also lifted from the pillow, and he lifting into the air first. It was incredible. When the subtle sheath touched the pillow than he felt his body rise toward the ceiling, his legs o'clock, he finished bhastrika and lay down to rest. No sooner had his head That December evening was no different from others. Around eleven and the overall state was pleasant, and he tried to maintain it.

He usually performed bhastrika before meditation: it calmed the mind, practice of bhastrika to a new level, bringing it to two thousand repetitions. performed were rather preparatory. Still, he decided to raise the breathing people exchanging thoughts and ideas, and the logic techniques they. The group members practiced no actual kriya: they were like-minded perform the breathing exercises he had learned in the Kriya Yoga group. events. The search for a Guru continued, and in the meantime, he tried to The year 1979 proved extraordinarily rich in signs and inexplicable

Out of the Body

realization.

aim of achieving a certain experience, and at higher stages, self-
ed Sadhana – spiritual practice or discipline, performed regularly with the
one.

woman, one of the greatest saints of India. And indeed, he was a lucky
later, many remarked on how fortunate he was to have met this fragile
practice following the saint's advice – simply by continuing to do.

invisible yet tangible fabric of life were firmness of intention and one's manageable. The only tools for carving the contours of fate from the found a Teacher. The future was hidden, but the present was more or less every evening. This type of yoga he could perform on his own until he. After this adventure, he continued to practice two thousand postures.

mind remained clear and focused, confirming what was happening.

remained indisputable: he had hovered above his own shell, while his bodies, "subtle bodies," "air bodies," only created confusion. One thing definition was more eloquent than any other term, as all those "mental journey of consciousness in the capsule of a phantom body. This for the out-of-body experience itself, he preferred to think of it as a permanent residence. The value of the body was too high to neglect it. As geographically of the new kingdom, but he was in no hurry to move there for currency, weapons, and protection. Gradually, he learned the rules and lived by the code of the power of consciousness. This power was both he encountered many tribes and castes of the Other Side, and all of them thought, which all inhabitants of the astral felt and acknowledged. Later, was observed in the astral realm: the only law there was the power of customs, becoming refugees, barons of the astral jungles. No democracy their bodies, remaining without maps, compasses, or knowledge of astral own home. Sometimes, as a result of such sudden possession, souls lost property, a new tenant might settle into another's body as if it were his unattended could be taken over by other spirits. Seeing abandoned later, he learned that such journeys were not at all safe, as bodies left into his physical shell. And for the better.

dog simply passed through his astral body, and the shock thrust him back. Shepherd, Jackie, jumped onto his chest, pushing with strong paws. The dogs on the veranda sensed him. Running up, a large male German seconds contained hours, racing by with incredible speed. Probably, the perception of time also changed. Now it was capacious, condensed, surreal: objects shimmered, outlined by contours of bright light. The magical: every blade of grass, every leaf on the trees shone with its own

bring him closer to the goal. It was time to move on.

and regular breathing practices outlined a general direction, yet did not perspective to his vague notions of yoga. Discussions, exchanges of ideas, the ashram and impressions from meditation lessons gave some Ashram in Puri²⁰, and some even stayed there. Their stories about life in ...New acquaintances from the Krishna Yoga group often visited the Karat

Ashram

Puri

Puri, 1981

After college, 1980

Shailendra Sharma, 2 years

Shri Gulab Singh, paternal grandfather

Shailendra Sharma, 8 months

Mother, Shrimati Gyan Devi, at age 24, in riding gear

Parents, early 1940s

Devi

Father, Shri Himmat Bahadur Sharma, and Mother, Shrimati Gyan

unknown to him, and there was no one with whom to discuss it.

eternal peace, and infinite Truth. The name of this phenomenon was was composed, and everything beyond it: the light of Life, Knowledge, intelligent, the luminous sphere radiated everything of which the world discharge. The Sun, shaded against a golden background, was alive and dazzlingly shining ring of solar color, as if formed by an electrical later. After practice, covering his strained eyes with his palms, he saw a stunned by an extraordinarily "visual effect" that would repeat only years Miracles continued to occur without prior notice. One day, he was own body.

An inferiority complex immediately took bale root, and he began to blame angrily, rebuking him: "You should meditate more!"

continued to insistently seek explanations. One day, the swami became felt that the practices lacked essence and a certain wholeness, and he given, and the rare answers to his questions were vague. Intuitively, he to practice, yet no discussions were held, no further explanations were concentrated on the *chakras* or imagined light. He persistently continued during his first meditation in July did not occur, no matter how much he. The indescribable feeling of omniscience, unity, true bliss experienced he felt absolutely nothing and was a little ashamed of this.

would guide the meditation process. Some claimed to feel unearthly bliss, the evening. The initiates would sit in a row before the swami, and he. If the head of the ashram was not traveling, a group session was held in the practice, and simply followed the instructions.

tongue to the palate. He knew nothing about *Kriya* or other aspects of was not emphasized; practitioners were simply supposed to press their was mentioned only in passing, and the decisive role of this technique without *pranayama*. *Kriya* *mudra* – (a key component of the practice) The teaching seemed quite simple. The basic *kriya* techniques were given initiates, he listened to the instructions – and life in the ashram began.

was supposed to make Himself known. Together with 30–40 other new vibrations in the *chakras* and visualize light, and after some time, God a short speech about *Kriya Yoga*. Beginners were advised to listen to the procedure was quite simple: the swami initiated people into *Kriya*, giving successor of *Yuktiswar Giri*, Swami Haripatananda. The enrollment. At that time, the ashram was under the guidance of a disciple and budget for an indefinite stay in Puri was five rupees.

everything else connected with the practice of higher yoga. His entire hoped to meet advanced yogis, study *Kriya*, learn about *samadhi* and for Puri. Friends helped him buy a train ticket to Orissa, Puri, where he. Having inquired about the ashram in more detail, in March 1981 he set off

from Sanskrit means "wheel" or "vortex." In yoga, chakra means an
four main pilgrimage sites in Hinduism. ²¹ Chakra – a direct translation
after the 15th-century Jagannath Temple located in the city. One of the
the shore of the Bay of Bengal. Also known as Shri Jagannatha Drama
²⁰ Puri – a coastal city in the state of Odisha in eastern India, located on
the fresh samosas remained...

not recall this man's name, but the owner's friendliness and the taste of
as they did at home), two samosas²⁴, and even a rasgulla²². Later, he could
listening to such a song! – and he was immediately offered tea (prewed
he was not a customer. They shook hands. "You have exquisite taste,
composition. The middle-aged Sikh owner was glad for the visitor, even if
nearly travel agency, the old radio was already playing the next
exclusively for him, and he followed the melody. When he entered a
in Orissa, Hindi was rarely spoken. The song was a message intended
guided by the strength of your heart, O wandering traveler..."

you will find the shade of spring. This is your test of life. Keep going.
"Buk jana nah, – do not stop if you feel defeated. Walking on thorns,
outside.

familiar song from a Bollywood film playing nearly made him look
he began to meditate regularly in the ashram's garden temple. One day, a
And yet, trying to adhere to his own schedule and counting on solitude,
chosen path began to seem like a dead end.

search for the Divine. Disappointment and uncertainty accumulated; the
worldly problems, masking their own issues and complexes with the
most general understanding of the subject. Some were simply hiding from
him: the people in this ashram were merely skilled speakers with only the
constant swami. But after some time, an almost tragic realization visited
followed the teachings of Krishna Yoga were living saints, in a state of
Before arriving at the ashram, he had been convinced that all who
right, I simply don't meditate enough..."

himself: "I must truly be an idiot, asking stupid questions. The swami is

Shailendranath asked: "Will you believe the words of Lahiri Mahasaya the words merely confirmed his own suspicions. Seeing his confusion He remained silent in bewilderment, though not particularly surprised; practicing is not real Kriya."

Karat ashram, the elderly yogi delivered his verdict: "What you are in the young visitor. Having listened attentively to the account of the yogi, and perhaps due to the similarity of their names, he took an interest Shailendranath Mukherjee was a disciple of Bhupendranath Sanyal and a newspaper on the veranda asked his name and the purpose of his visit. times onto narrow streets, and entered the gates. An elderly man reading bast the Govardhan Matha founded by Shankaracharya, turned several Bhupendranath Sanyal Mahasaya, was nearby. One afternoon he walked The Gurur Dham ashram, founded by a disciple of Lahiri Mahasaya,

river many streams flow, but... do all lead to the ocean?

same tradition, there existed other branches? It turned out that from one Yoga ashram located nearby. This was a complete surprise: so, within the literally the next day, changes began: someone mentioned another Kriya fulfilled.

All of this somehow promised better days, assuring that desires would be lingered in memory. The song and warmth of hospitality lifted the spirits.

cheese and semolina dough, boiled in sugar syrup.

sometimes cheese. ²² Rasgulla – a dessert in the form of a ball of cottage massal cavity. ²⁴ Zamosa – a savory basket filled with various vegetables and munda is performed by curling the tongue back and inserting it into the during certain pranayamas to stimulate the flow of amrita nectar. Kresnam consciousness. ²³ Kresnam munda – a special yogic tongue "lock" used and control of life energy and power, as well as to higher states of ancient yogic practice of breathing techniques leading to the expansion and "awakened" by special intensive yoga practice. ²⁵ Pranaayama – an They are in a dormant state, although they can potentially be activated energy center. Seven main chakras are localized in the Sushumna channel.

found to literally put food into his mouth, as proof of the presence of the power of God and the grace of Babaji sustain him? Would someone be money or shelter. But what would happen if he left the ashram? Would comfortable meals were regular, there was no need to worry about. After a while, one strange thought began to haunt him. Life was answer his questions, so he had plenty of time to ponder various ideas. only thing that interested him, but no one in the ashram could or would whom to discuss the practice or possible signs of progress. Krishna was the hours daily, trying to master the techniques. There was no one with Having established his own schedule, he meditated in the temple for 8 attempted to meditate at night, and why would they?

diet, the ashram's inhabitants were rather plump and drowsy. No one day, and by 10 PM everyone went to sleep. Thanks to a carbohydrate-rich considered a sacred affair. At 9 PM, dinner concluded the unremarkable heavy lunch, tea with snacks was taken. The midday siesta was comfortable and rather dull. Breakfast was served around 9 o'clock, after a Apart from his personal inner turmoil, life in the ashram was quite

Under the Banyan Tree

deceived.

ashram. Who could guarantee the authenticity of the teaching? He felt Lahiri Mahasaya radically differed from what he had been "taught" in the was unclear where to seek this very real Krishna. The practices described by and his initial enthusiasm mixed with disappointment and irritation, as it same time deeply disturbed him; there was an abundance of information, effect of a bomb exploding. What he read illuminated, inspired, and at the The three volumes of The Bhagavad Gita in the Light of Krishna Yoga had the by Lahiri Mahasaya, and even gave him 110 rupees to purchase the books. Mr. Mukherjee advised him to read the commentaries on the Gita written "Of course, for he is the father of Krishna Yoga..."

himself?,"

would eat only if someone put the food directly into his mouth. The
However, he restrained himself: the vow was different. He had sworn he
could eat and drink;

wave of hunger and thirst rose within him. Food had arrived, and he
bore a pitcher of water, and placed everything right in front of him. A
women, young and old, approached the tree. They brought food in clay
around 11 o'clock, as far as he could tell from the sun's position, several
rice fields had noticed him and told their wives. The next morning,
open spaces sharpen the villagers' eyesight. Probably the farmers in the
in the countryside, strangers are noticed immediately. The vastness of the
most of the day, time flowed imperceptibly.

pleasant, bordering on a lazy, relaxed semi-consciousness. He slept for
hunger nor thirst. He was indifferent: the dizziness and weakness were
or desires were absent. His body felt light: he felt neither the slightest
fields, figures of farmers were visible, but no one disturbed him. Thoughts
When he awoke, the sun was already high. In the distance, on the rice
immediately fell into a deep, dreamless sleep.

dark. Exhausted and broken, he collapsed under a large banyan tree and
The sun sets early on the eastern coast, and by 2 PM it was completely
connection between a mortal's fate and the higher forces that govern it.

my mouth." Only the purity of the experiment could confirm the
barely visible trail, he thought: "I will eat only if someone puts food into
Making his way through increasingly dense thickets, trying not to lose the

walked without stopping, having not the slightest idea of his destination.
the jungle, he followed a small path. From early morning until sunset, he
towards Komark along the coast. Soon Puri was left behind. Turning into
all. Early in the morning, he climbed over the ashram wall and walked
decided to test himself, fate, and the divine will, if such a thing existed at
These thoughts became so obsessive that in the last week of October, he
higher forces in his destiny;

they lived in a parallel, narrow world, limited to kitchen chores. Until this moment, he had not considered women worthy of attention.

to him: "Give!"

themselves the power of life, and now this power imperiously called out created to create, nourish, and sustain life. They manifested within duality inherent in all women: it lived in their hearts because they were moment of realization that forever changed his life: compassion was a silent group, he saw that the women were weeping silently. This was a Tracks of tears also appeared on the girl's cheeks. Looking back at the portions, and he could no longer, and did not want to, hold back his tears. his parched lips. He began to eat. The girl gave him four or five more him. Mixing the banana curry with rice, she hesitantly brought the food to woman gestured for her to come closer, and she squatted down beside outfit, according to the custom of child marriage in Orissa. An elderly Among the women was a girl of about nine, dressed in a traditional bridal a vow: someone had to put the food directly into his mouth.

a clay water pitcher was set down, and again he turned away. A vow was Again, a banana leaf with food was placed on the ground before him, and

or ill. He was simply alone in an unfamiliar place, and they knew this.

after the long journey through the jungle, yet he did not appear wounded him look like a sadhu: his simple white kurti-bajama was dirty and torn by flashes of cautious, timid smiles. A short beard and mustache made he observed the swaying folds of bright saris, their dark faces illuminated were 22 or 30 of them, he could not say exactly. As if through a thick fog, and shapes. Around noon, the women appeared again, this time there slowly swaying, soft green waves, and the distant trees changed colors slowed; he was gazing into another dimension. The rice fields turned into The next day, he no longer felt his own body, nor hunger. His breathing for a while, then left.

sure that every detail of his request was fulfilled. The women sat neatly miraculously materialized provisions were not convincing. He had to be aroma of freshly cooked food made his head spin. He turned away. The

Three weeks passed without incident, and he still had not the slightest smoothed over, but the tension remained.

to defend himself or explain his absence and its reasons. The conflict was something illegal, and a quarrel broke out between them. He did not fly must have reported him. The manager decided he was involved in The ashtam administrator learned of his absence fairly quickly. Someone

268 Creatures

but continued to feel the warmth of the earth beneath him.

wall and, entering his room, collapsed onto the bed. He saw no dreams, soul always receives an answer. At dawn, he jumped over the ashtam confidently, filled with an inexpressible knowledge that the true call of the illuminated the coast, and the road was clearly visible. He walked to Bumi. After a few hours, the jungle was left behind; bright moonlight Taking a sip of water, he dozed off, and towards evening he set off back presence. He felt not the slightest agitation, only gratitude and quiet bliss. taken the form of the village women had clearly manifested its will and The request had been heard; it had been answered. Whatever force had

touched the head of the little bride. Then they all left.

began to prostrate themselves before him, taking their leave, and he again language; the tears dried. About an hour later, one by one, the women she sat motionless. The women began to softly sing bhajans in the Oriya intoxicating. In a gesture of blessing, he placed his hand on the girl's head; the taste of the food, and the scent of the child's hair became sharp and once with his heart. The smell of the hot midday earth and warm grass, spility: he no longer needed to look around; he saw and felt everything at primordiality of love. His heightened emotions unlocked a strange new hands, quick smiles, and soft voices, the women radiated the true unknown stranger, and yet they had shown compassion. With work-worn women had come to his aid. He was a nobody to them, a rootless and better, confined female universe. But now, in his time of need, only would usually walk at a distance, trying to dissociate himself from this household tasks, and gossip. Accompanying his mother to the market, he

A few minutes later, breathing heavily, he was entering his room. His whirlpools, and the pair vanished into the dance of the tossed waves. unfurled wings, with a powerful synchronous splash, created momentarily then, turning towards the ocean, they dove into the incoming waves. Four companion. For a fraction of a second, the creatures studied him, and woman glanced in his direction and silently pointed him out to her their backs. A sudden fear washed over him. As if sensing this, the Both had wings, leathery, like the wings of bats, partially folded behind shimmered in the moonlight on their damp skin.

cast gold ornaments on their necks, arms, wrists, and ankles. The jewels wet locks reached her shoulders. Both were completely naked, save for broad-boned and powerfully built. The man had short hair, the woman's and a half feet tall, with bulging muscles, and his companion, equally moonlight, two figures emerged from the waves. A man, like a Hulk, six silhouettes about forty meters away. Gleaming like copper in the Hypnotized by the surf, he did not immediately notice two moving. The waves rhythmically shook the foam from their crests onto the sand. sand floating in a vast, conscious Universe.

living ocean. He was acutely aware of himself as merely a tiny grain of crashing waves while bathing in the bright moonlight next to the vast, belonged to him alone; it was wondrous to listen to the roar of the happiness simply because he was alive and breathing. This night ocean breathed evenly and powerfully, and he suddenly felt a surge of the morning; the deserted beach was flooded with bright moonlight. The jumped over the wall enclosing the ashram. It was about two o'clock in out to the ocean to get some fresh air. Using his proven method, he That night he could not sleep. The room was stuffy, and he decided to go destination. He did not feel this at all, and his restlessness grew.

where they were going. Yet they all tried to convince him that this was the of random fellow travelers who, it seemed, did not themselves know waiting room in which he was stuck for an indefinite time in the company ideas when he would learn true logic sadhana. The ashram was merely a

spoke of the Mantra mantra, which grants the ability to kill at will. The step-by-step instructions for obtaining solid mercury. One day, the sadhu he still obediently wrote them down. One of the "recipes" contained step-formulas. And although this science held absolutely no interest for him, money. The interlocutor made him write down several alchemical conversations. Despite looking destitute, the stranger did not ask for details, this sadhu was clearly interested in continuing their captivating, sometimes frightening things. Very precise in describing, certainly not an ordinary chillum-loving vagabond, as he spoke of staff, this man sat on the sand quite comfortably. The stranger was during sleep or while performing other austerities. Despite having the never to sit or lie down and use the danda to support the upper body, special support used for performing yoga. Some sadhus take a vow of abstinence, one could guess he was an ascetic: he had a danda staff, with a good, even literate, Hindi with a northern accent. Looking at him, a sadhu. It was hard to tell where this wanderer was from, but he spoke covered his lean, dark body, and this man looked more like a beggar than was black. A loin cloth of matted or coarse cloth, tied with a rope, sadhu's tangled long hair had a coppery sheen, but his short, thick beard eventually they began to talk. From constant exposure to the sun, the age would usually sit. Time after time, this man moved closer, and daily, always preferring the same spot. Naturally, a sadhu of indeterminate The beach was an ideal place for meditation, and he came there almost

The Sadhu on the Beach. The Mantra of Death

cracks between worlds.

reality. It was simply that not many people dared to peer into the invisible hallucination. Uncharted worlds were near, existing side by side with his knew of their existence, and no one could convince him it had been a creations? Demons, angels, aliens—whatever these beings were, he now There were simply no such beings. Or perhaps they were celestial

terms to describe these sea

mind registered what he had seen but refused to analyze it. There were no

captivating; however, he felt neither peace nor satisfaction. On the movement of will was tempting, and possessing this power was new, secret power lived within him. The ability to kill with a single terrifying by the end of the mantra recitation he felt an inner calm. Now a his courage, he finished the ritual. Although the corpse's gaze was the sadhu's warning in time: "If you run, you will go mad." Castering all stared at him with its remaining eye. He wanted to run but remembered occurred near the corpse, and a blue flame flared up. The head turned and the dead body, he began to recite the mantra. Suddenly, a small explosion man's body. The half-burnt corpse looked terrible. Trying not to look at enough wood for cremation, and a single smoldering log lay on the foot "fresh" corpse. The deceased's family must not have been able to afford without any major incidents. On the last, twenty-first night, he saw a frightening shadows and sounds, he spent twenty nights at the swastika curious, and weary of the monotony of life in the ashram. Surrounded by experiment, it was nothing other than black magic. But he was young, repeating the Mantra mantra. He was fully aware of the nature of the midnight. There, until four in the morning, he performed his, silently ashram life, he began coming to the Swastikwar swastika around and rituals was safely hidden in his pocket. Tired of the monotony of containing names of herbs, alchemical formulas, descriptions of mantras strange interlocutor simply disappeared. However, a small notebook Their conversations continued for about three weeks, until one day the mantra was meant for protection and that every yogi should know it. decided to share this dangerous knowledge; he only said that the Mantra accordance with the rules. It was completely unclear why the sadhu had the mantra itself had to be performed at a cremation ground, in strict would vomit blood and eventually suffocate. The ceremony for obtaining adversary. A painful death followed almost immediately; the victim mentally concentrating on the image of one's opponent, one could kill any its power by repeating the incantation one hundred and eight times and simple: one had to recite the mantra for twenty-one days. Having received several dialects—Odia, Bengali, and Hindi. The ritual itself was quite words of the mantra were not in Sanskrit, but in a strange mixture of

neighboring ashram of Bhubendranath Gangal—apparently, Months passed, and one day he received an invitation to a festival at the

Winning the Lottery

Ganges, immediately feeling relief, almost happiness.

near the Guru's house, he gave the power of the Mantra mantra to the him. In November, shortly before the Diwali festival, on the embankment relying on the strength of his own spirit, and gradually it began to guide cowardly and pass dark rituals. Respecting power, he cultivated it, initiator. The path he had chosen was different and had no need for. However, the consequences always return like a boomerang to their legal matters (especially between relatives) are often resolved in this way. competitors, cause damage and suffering, disputes over property and command respect, or for enrichment. Arhicharya is used to eliminate widespread in India: some deliberately seek such powers to instill fear, of my Guru, I give back this power." Black magic—arhicharya—is still to throw this plate into the waters of the Ganges: "Now, by the instruction creating a sankalpa, a strong intention to renounce the deadly gift, one had desired to obtain such-and-such power, and it was given to me." Then, copper plate, one had to describe what had been done: "I so-and-so, getting rid of it and purification was quite simple: with a sharp nail on a and knew well the possible consequences of their misuse. The method of this mantra." Apparently, the Teacher himself possessed certain abilities chain reaction of negative karmas. As your Guru, I advise you to get rid of arise to use this power, just to prove you are right. And this will trigger a there will always be something that can anger you. The temptation may said: "This is a dangerous gift. No matter how calm and peaceful you are, to find the right words, he told the story of the Mantra mantra. The Teacher teacher, the Guru noticed his state and inquired about the reasons. Trying contain negative emotions. A year later, after he had found a spiritual irreversible actions. Outwardly calm, he seethed inwardly, trying to at that time, any minor incident could have provoked him into any moment. It was pure luck that he did not attempt to use the mantra: contrary, irritability grew, and an inner volcano of anger could erupt at

entire practice. In the Karar ashram, no one explained this technique: it Mahasaya called a special technique, *Kreshna mudra*, a key element of the from Benares would become his Guru. In his commentaries, Lahiri tucked in his hands. Somehow he knew: the search was over; this teacher precious scrap of paper, he felt as if he were holding a winning lottery write down the teacher's address on a piece of paper. Clutching the perhaps you will be lucky..." And Mr. Tiwari asked an elderly woman to it seems, has stopped giving initiations. But you can try to meet him: Satyacharan Lahiri, and he lives in Benares. However, he is quite old and, "Yes, such a teacher exists. It is the grandson of Lahiri Mahasaya, me his name and address!" After a short pause, Mr. Tiwari replied softly: familiar with the complete teaching of Lahiri Mahasaya? If so, please give quieted down. But he continued: "Perhaps you know someone who is statement, bordering on insolence, and the conversations around them search for a true guru anyway." This was an extremely straightforward disciple. If not, there is no point in initiation, because I will continue to the *krityas* that Lahiri Mahasaya taught? Tell me directly. If yes, I am your had already met enough masters of flowerly speech. "Can you teach me all dignified, but appearance and charisma no longer impressed him—he immediately offered him initiation. Jwalaprasad Tiwari looked noble and like to study it in its pure, original form." The head of the ashram "This is a student of *Kriya Yoga* from the neighboring ashram; he would ashram, Mr. Jwalaprasad Tiwari, and Shailendranath introduced them: followers of *Kriya Yoga* were present, including the then-head of the ashram with a heart full of disappointment. More than two hundred "enlightened" ones. Needless to say, he arrived at the festival at the Gangal chew over empty words about God-realization. He no longer believed in was still impossible; they continued to give motivational speeches and but getting any coherent explanations from the summaries in the ashram Lahiri. The effect of *Kriya Yoga* should have been completely different, and breathing techniques had nothing to do with the *sadhana* described by the time spent at the Karar ashram as wasted. The visualization practices books of Lahiri Mahasaya, remembered the young visitor. He considered Shailendranath Mukherjee, thanks to whom he had bought and read the

waste paper. This was a great blow, and he genuinely mourned the loss of precious comics, about 4000 books and magazines, had been sold as the ashram. Returning to Cwalior, he discovered that his entire collection March 1985, accompanied by his mother who had come for him, he left clearly illustrated the necessity of discrimination, of discernment. In intentions did not embitter or disappoint him; on the contrary, all this discoveries about people, the surrounding world, his own abilities and year had passed since his arrival in Pune, but what a year it was! The troublemaker, a violator of order and established etiquette. Exactly one between lunch and evening tea. To all these people, he was a awakening was supposed to happen according to a schedule, preferably support, protection, and a sense of belonging. In their view, spiritual inhabitants simply wanted to belong to any organization that provided explanations from the leadership anyway; most of the ashram's someone and not hearing the accusatory speech. No one expected save face, the head of the ashram turned away, pretending to be talking to However, no one could offer a coherent rebuttal. In a pathetic attempt to tried to interrupt him, hissing: "A samnyasi should not behave like this!" is doubly painful when your faith is desecrated. Some of those present and breaking promises. It is unpleasant when your money is stolen, but if followers, he accused the head of the organization of violating traditions returning from a trip abroad. At a large reception before several thousand yet he decided to wait for the head of the ashram, who was soon illusions about life in the ashram remained; he could leave immediately, "spiritual" organizations, hierarchical games, and empty promises. No Over time, he learned to recognize the unmistakable stench of corrupt growth, as it might interfere with the accustomed comfort of their lives. Filled with inflated superiority, they did not even think about spiritual supported and encouraged him, unlike the samnyasis in the Katat ashram. Shailendranath were kind and open. Seeing the sincerity of his quest, they taught Knesman, and this was very important. The people he met through in yoga? All this no longer mattered, because the master from Benares information deliberately hidden so that new students would not progress was not even mentioned. Perhaps out of ignorance? Or was important

the required address through the tangled labyrinth of the eternal city's asked the bandit to find a room for his former student and to guide him to named Radhe Maharaj who lived in Benares. In the letter, the professor A familiar history teacher from his college wrote to a cousin, a bandit Benares. The Guru.

without theory." Benjamin Disraeli, Contrarian Fleming (1835)

"Read no history, read nothing but biographies. For in them is life

*

The Beginning

what to do with you."

quite quickly: "Then come in September or October, and I will decide dedicate his life to yoga and nothing else. The future teacher responded sensible man. And yet, in his reply, he declared his firm resolve to showed the letter to his father, who remarked that this Guru was a very yourself to yoga. Otherwise, people usually run into problems." He find a job, or start your own business – and after that you can devote suggestion: "Perhaps you should first settle your material affairs. Marry, A reply soon came, containing a precise return address and a practical Benares" – and this proved sufficient for the letter to reach its addressee. He addressed the envelope thus: "Satya Charan Lahiri, Bengalee Tolst of great significance, fate had already sung him its promise.

with the address was lost, but this did not matter.

his future Guru. In the haste of leaving Puri, the precious scrap of paper ties with the family. A few days after returning home, he wrote a letter to would take samnyasa and become a monk, which would mean severing all quite positive; his parents breathed a sigh of relief, as they had feared he the world of so-called normal people. For the rest, returning home was he had matured, but his values clearly differed from those acceptable in unsuitable for an adult man, which he should now become. Undoubtedly, His mother insisted that comics were a useless hobby, completely

Raising his voice, Satya Charan Lahiri ordered the uninvited guest to initiation and been refused. Despite this, the stranger decided to try again. Learned that this was a high-ranking official who had already asked for but the conversation was interrupted by the arrival of some man. Later he pressed and dispersed one by one. The Guru was ready to speak with him. After about forty minutes, the reading ended; those present accepted "Come, and I will decide." This guaranteed nothing.

initiation, or would he be refused? In his reply, the Guru had only said: The agonizing wait seemed endless; tension mounted: would he receive finished..."

the Guru himself, but was also stopped: "We will talk after the reading is to wait, and soon slipped quietly off the terrace. He attempted to address gentleman. Radhe Maharaj tried to introduce them both, but was gestured identified! He rose and prostrated himself before an unremarkable elderly entered bowed to one of those present – and the future teacher was tradition and quietly sat down in a corner. An elderly woman who After hesitating, he bowed to the sacred book in accordance with Hindu elderly men. To whom should he bow?

never seen the Guru and could not distinguish him among the other glanced at him questioningly, and the situation grew awkward: he had Embarrassed by his own youth, he felt out of place. Those gathered a chapter from the Bhagavad Gita aloud; the others listened attentively. assembled were younger than seventy. One of those present was reading Instead, he saw about a dozen ordinary retirees; none among those of the Guru or the Lahiri dynasty he would be met by stern swamis. Chusatti Chat²⁰. On the way to Benares, he had imagined that in the home An old servant led them to the upper veranda of a house situated near the bandit led him to his destination. Into the embrace of fate.

home of Radhe Maharaj, where he was warmly received and fed. Then Mahasaya, and he took this as an suspicious sign. At noon he reached the September 30, 1982, he arrived in Benares. It was the birthday of Lahiri streets. The same professor lent him money for the ticket, and on

head, the famous Manikarnika Chat, its umbrical cord of smoke from breathed with the chest of the Dashashwamedh Chats. Aasi Chat was its inevitability of a new beginning. The giant, eternal being that was Benares initiation? However, the dawning day instilled confidence in the entirely certain it would come to pass. Would the Teacher grant him brought him here was on the verge of fulfillment, and yet he was not in this city, nothing came easily or simply. The cherished desire that had

Curu.

himself, the slow waters caught and carried away. It was time to go to the prayers of all hearts, in all languages. Whatever words he uttered within The river meditatively absorbed half-burnt corpses, human sin, and the slowly faded, becoming almost imperceptible in the rays of the rising sun. fruits, ghee, and rice, and the oil lamps floating upon it, whose light sun in greeting. The great river accepted all offerings: garlands of flowers, softly, in a chanting tone, singing mantras and raising their hands to the took on the color of shining silver. People around him were bathing and The river, at first grey and dark, turned deep crimson, and then gradually sounds of morning temple bells awakened a shy chorus of invisible birds. to color the horizon, gently illuminating the river and the ghats; the Early in the morning, he bathed in the Ganga. The sun was just beginning

Initiation

from agitation he could not sleep.

room costing one and a half rupees a night. Yet the money was wasted – way to Pandey Dharanashala, where Radhe Maharaj had rented him a He left with a bounding heart and could not remember how he found his

Shiva, Babaji, and Lahiri Mahasaya.”

bring a notebook and pen. And buy flower garlands as an offering to have been waiting for you. Come tomorrow at seven in the morning, was, the Curu said: “So, you are that Shailendra from Cwalior? Well, I fears were groundless. Having finally ascertained who the young visitor leave. His heart sank: now the Curu would drive him away too! But his

Noticing this, the Guru asked if he had practiced before. He was certain could even accurately predict which kriya would follow the previous one. Photographs from Autobiography of a Yogi had once felt. Several times he techniques. The practice felt familiar, just as the names and faces in the listening to the instructions, he realized that he already knew these. The Teacher laughed, and then began to explain the first level of practice.

undergone this ritual, have you?" And he confessed.

at which the Guru chuckled: "Why not simply tell the truth: you haven't. Alarmed, he fabricated a story that he had left the lantern in his hotel room,

for logic initiation...

the youngest, a bachelor, and did not think it played any significant role both his brothers had undergone this ceremony before marriage. He was Brahmins, the lantern. It is supposed to be put on after a special ritual, and Satya Charan Lahiri asked why he did not wear the sacred thread of the

points during practice.

activated, and from that day onward, he was to concentrate on these of the Guru's fingers. The energy knots, the future chakras, were he was surprised by sudden sensations in his spine, caused by the touch floor. Turning his back to the teacher and looking expectantly at the wall, down at seven o'clock and told him to remove his kurtas and sit on the. Arriving an hour early, he waited in the courtyard. The Teacher came

tangible rhythm of the city's heart.

moment, it seemed to him that his heartbeat echoed the inaudible yet of awakening Benares, an inner silence settled within him. At some absorbing the sounds of bells from the houses. And beneath the hum buffaloes, past praziers of beauties and shops of multicolored fabrics, the lanes, accompanied by a sudden convoy of rickshaws, black, glistening streets were the blood vessels of the eternal city. He strode along one of. Myriads of souls were enclosed within the body of Kashi⁸⁰; the narrow funeral pyres, connecting the physical world to the astral.

the logic initiation: although his father sympathized with his logic intended to move forward. There was no need to inform his family about wholly concentrated on the complex techniques of practice, and he leaving Benares, he had no idea what awaited him. His thoughts were

War and Peace

be as difficult as the mining of gold.

Intuitively, he knew: the extraction of the precious ore of this yoga would

but it was not his path.

and respectable version of enlightenment was convenient in every way,

and spiritual secrets should unravel themselves. The path of a manichee

highest goal of yoga, samadhi. As if striving were entirely unnecessary,

None of the people he had met before made any visible effort to attain the

ramblings, calls to focus attention on the divine and wait for revelations.

his search: he had felt only emptiness and numbness from philosophical

what to do! Before this journey, nothing had been able to bring clarity to

As he boarded the train, he felt a surge of confidence. At last, it was clear

remain in this body. Therefore, do not waste time."

diligently: I am already old, and it is unknown how much longer I will

Khechari Mudra, and I will teach you the next level of practice. Work

"Now you may return to Cwalior. Come back when you have mastered

and he awaited further developments. But the next day, the Teacher said:

The Guru invited him to spend the night at his house; this was thrilling,

beginning of an incredible transformation.

overrode all other emotions. The morning of October 1, 1985, marked the

him: yet an unshakable certainty that yoga would become his life

At that time, he still did not envision the length of the path lying before

Khechari Mudra seemed too difficult, and he doubted he could master it.

able to hold it for more than 500 counts, which pleased the Teacher. But

Years of swimming served him well. Performing breath retention, he was

he had not, at least not in this life.

the ringleader was a ruthless killer.

scheduled," but the locals advised the new management not to resist, as headed and unyielding. The racketeer left. He had come alone, just to "get well-being and safety now depended on this job, and they remained cool-question of paying the bandits or packing down and leaving. The family's more importantly, they were confident in their rights. There was no local farmers paid them. He and Gyanendra were physically strong, but reputation and a large gang that extorted money for "protection." All the confrontation with one of the local mafia bosses, who had a bad The very next day after moving in, they found themselves embroiled in a inevitable. Problems began immediately.

management tried to establish order, war with the raider clans became vanished along with a large portion of the crop. When the new enormous harvest was worth several million rupees, yet the profit ongoing, local bandits and raiders were eager to grab a share. The The farm had the potential to yield millions, and while the lawsuit was

They lived on the farm for only a year, but what a year it turned out to be! The elder brother was now the sole breadwinner, and he needed help. separately, and his younger sister Pratibha had died of hepatitis in 1988. son Avinash, and he himself. His two other sisters were married and lived gained personal space: the parents, Gyanendra with his wife Mala and into a living space with nine rooms and a hall. Every family member required to reside there. A huge warehouse was renovated and converted litigation, the court had appointed a temporary farm manager, who was board managing the farm was in full swing, and for the duration of the acres. A legal dispute between the state of Madhya Pradesh and the trust The company Cavalor Dairy Ltd. had leased a farm of over a thousand was entitled to housing.

huge farm, which was very timely – they needed to move, and the brother to sell the house. His brother Gyanendra found work as a manager on a going through hard times. Within a month, by November 1985, they had pursuits, the others had no idea about sadhana. Moreover, the family was

being right and of justice.

Previously unknown facets of his own character: fear, anger, a sense of no other way out. These rather difficult circumstances revealed new, was exhausting. Few can adapt to a constant threat, but there was simply them, both leaders and workers, were constantly on high alert, and this. The daily anticipation of armed conflicts caused stress and tension. All of was indeed watching over him.

single scratch... And he was grateful to Baraji – apparently, the Avatar₈₁ wondered how it was possible to emerge from such clashes without a losses were insignificant, and people remained unharmed. Often he firefights could last until dawn. By some miracle, bloodshed was avoided, sometimes armed gangs of thirty to forty people took part, fierce. The Wild West drama continued, raids following one after another.

unchanged since the time of the Mahabharata, and reforms were far off.

release them on bail. Much in the rural provinces had remained peculiar way: they would arrest groups of suspects and then immediately only after the gunfights were over. In general, the police worked in a obliged to support the legally appointed manager, had taken to appearing and double-barreled shotguns, they managed to hold on. The police, invaders, guarding the territory and the harvest. Thanks to hand grenades Cyamendra, he himself, and a few reluctant watchmen had to confront the hundred villagers, unable to resist the gangsters, labored on the farm. places, seizing the harvest and intimidating the workers. About a guerrilla war: heavily armed bandits raided the farm, always in different. The initial "one-on-one" skirmishes quickly escalated into a full-scale hand grenades were included. Then a veritable hell broke loose.

delivered ammunition included

accept the weapons from the "opposition": among other things, the against that bastard! We will support you!" There was nothing to do but appeared: "Friends, we will provide you with weapons. Fight back just an hour after this unpleasant visit, representatives of another gang

strived for this yoga for too long, and now, having received all the himself to doubt his own abilities and continued his attempts. He had practice, in March. Initially puzzled by its complexity, he did not allow He mastered Khechari mudra, a key condition for the next level of passed since initiation.

practiced at the initial level. If so, it was incredible: only three months had processes. Perhaps it was the effect of the Shvasarita pranayama⁸⁵ described in yoga texts, he had no idea what exactly triggered these the blood vessels and the speed of the heartbeat. Experiencing what was other choice but to learn to manage this. This led to gradual control over phenomenon repeated: the pulse simply disappeared, and there was no again, he sensed a slow, hesitant pulsation. From time to time, the strange was no movement of blood flow under the warm skin. Feeling the artery the silence of the veins shocked him. He checked his carotid artery. There Accidentally touching his wrist, he discovered the absence of a pulse, and with uninvited guests, he was preparing for his nightly practice. In January, after altercations with workers and another day of dealing

The Secret Mudra, the Eternal Spirit, and Kshetra

lighthouse, signaling to the spirit.

entered into the boundless darkness, and the breath became the beam of a Practice swept away the daytime confetti of thoughts and impressions; he between realities was thin but distinct.

Despite the daily clashes, he practiced every night, and the boundary Nevertheless, in the midst of this bedlam, the practice went excellently. The siege of the farm continued for more than twelve months.

all of this was part of the daily reality back then.

actions, including ambushes and murders. Well, the reading was accurate: waves of violence, indicating confrontations, intimidation, and illegal confusion, and physical threat to life. The Mahadasha of the Sun caused on that period of life: this transit of Saturn was marked by dangers. Many years later, having studied his natal chart, an astrologer commented

center was his spirit, *Atma*, and the golden outer ring was *Jiva*⁸². He did already know that the velvet-black circle with a deep dark-blue hue in its flashes, appeared on his "inner screen" several more times. By then, he The unusual sphere, shot through with golden discharges of electric fortunate..."

Paramatma before receiving the practice is a great blessing. You are very saw something special." After a pause, the Guru repeated: "To encounter only see the 'standard' *Kutastha*: a dark circle in a halo of bright light. You the Great Spirit. To see it is an extremely rare fortune. Usually, people can "Kutastha is your *Atma*⁸³, and what you saw is a glimpse of *Paramatma*⁸⁴,

Teacher was impressed.

courage and described in detail what he had seen to the Teacher. The experience at the time. During his second visit to Benares, he gathered his astonishing, yet there were simply no words capable of describing that occurred back in 1929, after his first out-of-body experience. It was enlivening the body. The first encounter with the Light, as he called it, universes illuminated by the bright light of *Kutastha*, the immortal spirit paying no attention to the occasional gunshots, he traveled to distant markets and resolved numerous economic issues, and by night. By day, he and *Cyamenetra* and a small group of guards rebelled the initiation into the secrets that lay ahead.

difficulty of performing this technique was a perfectly fair condition for magic potion, one had to become a magician, and overcoming the the nadder of the brain had to be "milked" with the tongue. To obtain the could free himself from aging and death. To obtain the precious nectar, recipe for longevity. By drinking *amrita* with the help of *Kreschari*, a *logi* *Shiva's* beloved *mudra* was a protection, a means of clairvoyance, and a All *logi* texts unanimously acknowledged the uniqueness of *Kreschari*:

doors that needed to be opened, simply by fitting the key to the lock.

achieve *Kreschari*. This *mudra* was the criterion of true sadhana, the key to practice; Retreat was not an option, and there was no other way but to explanations, he was so close to mastering this important stage of

feeling that the level of sadhana did not matter, as It could make contact. The Spirit was an ancient, powerful entity, an extraterrestrial. There was a question, one had to learn a new alphabet.

language of the spirit, and to learn to form words and begin to ask
himself if became clear that the changing colors of Kutasra were the
transformation occurred through opposition and endurance. At some
remained the same. Logic practice is the foundation and anvil of magic;
through sadhana. Metal can be shaped on an anvil, but the anvil itself
immortal. Observing, he understood that the spirit is comprehended only
It spoke of two kinds of primordial Energy: one was mortal, the other
is eternal." (Cits 12\10)

eternal. All creatures are perishable, and only Kutastha (the liberated one) "There are only two Purushas⁸ in this world: the perishable and the Kutastha was mentioned rather sparingly.

phenomenon that he could find, although even there the nature of
into it. The Bhagavad Gita was the only reliable source describing this
screen. Growing larger, it drew him in, and at times he would fall entirely
the luminous sphere of the Spirit was constantly present on his inner
position of the stars, or the intensity of daily events. Whatever the reason,
Kutastha changed its shades under the influence of the season, the
his self; they had yet to get to know each other. Sometimes the splendor of
eternal Spirit lived within him. Enlivening the body, It was not a part of
Names and terms were not as important as the effect itself. He knew: an
unchanged."

not change. In Sanskrit, the word "Kutastha" meant "that which remains". Exhalation did not exist without an inhalation, and this order of things did not change. Both male and female. Light and darkness were twins; so was the true nature of the "Self," that which was simultaneously both Shiva and Shakti. All efforts in Kriya were directed towards understanding wholeness as far more natural than trying to understand each of its components. Personal "self," jivatma⁸⁶. In Hinduism, quality is perceived so deeply that one does not attempt to describe exactly what this spirit was. It could be mis-

desires, whether for land, power, women, or money. Their actions were whose imagination never extended beyond the bounds of primitive confidence in his own abilities. External irritants were caused by people discoveries. The awareness of progress in practice fostered a growing distracted and troubled him, yet his inner life was full of astonishing. Constant skirmishes and endless managerial and domestic problems empirical confirmation.

The goal of awakening Kundalini⁸⁸. This captivating assertion required sign of a short

mentioned that the appearance of Kutashta during Yoni mudra⁸⁸ is a sure Kutashta, he tried to remain dispassionate and detached. Once, the Guru It was wiser to wait for That One to make the "first move," and observing He who "leased" the body to the "operator."

he interested in communicating with the "master" of the body, and it was meet certain requirements. Coming to witness and enjoy the spirit must revelations, and to enter this "educational program," one simply had to The spirit could impart new knowledge to the body's owner, grant

When the spirit grew tired and bored, It moved on.

resides in the body as long as It is interested in the body's possessor. about the unity of spirit and body, but one thing was obvious: the spirit Eternal Being had changed, he shuddered. There were many theories out body like old clothes. Imagining the infinite ocean of bodies that this away when the time came to seek a new incarnation, shedding the worn-factors, and they were never random. The Giver of life, It also took it spirit was influenced by a complex combination of karmic and planetary exactly would interest and amuse It. The enlivening of the body by the depended solely on the spirit, and it was impossible to predict what beginning of the dialogue. The continuation of the communication waiting, and the maturity of the practitioner was decisive for the itself was always ready for communication. The spirit was simply everything depended on the readiness of the "vessel" to open, as the spirit at any moment at Its will. Even Khechari mudra was not so important.

“ally” of their team, and they could do nothing about his antisocial cheerful fellow, without the slightest sign of hidden malice. He was an in nature, nothing personal. The robber was a drunkard and a rather calling card, a “trademark,” while the robberies themselves were random all the victim’s belongings. The knife wound to the thigh was a kind of victim with a knife in the thigh to immobilize, but not kill, and then take. One robber (this was his permanent profession) would typically strike his

hunch that it is unclear what will ultimately be taken from this donor.

Sometimes the mixture of the divine and the demonic is so thick and nature possesses a far greater quality, depth, and contradictoriness. understood: one cannot always judge people by their actions, for human simultaneously simple and sophisticated. After one incident, he no means intellectuals, but the motives for their actions were human species, and interacting with them was instructive. They were by management. The bandits proved to be curious representatives of the side because the other gang was trying to overpower the new get a closer look at some of the hardened criminals who had taken their. During the intense confrontations on the farm, he had the opportunity to

Facets of Education

house of the heart.

energy would begin an alchemical transformation, opening the treasure-breath did its work, and after a while, the incoming streams of pranic impressions. Shifting the focus of attention was difficult, but the call of the unresponsive, as the mind stubbornly continued to chew over the days at the beginning of practice, the body would become sluggish and he was determined to reap the harvest. At times, this felt like a battlefield. kshetra, the field of mind and body, demanded constant cultivation, and with the blough of breath, no matter what happened during the day. The his goal and intentions remained unchanging. He had to blough the body. Both his surroundings and the current situation were temporary, while take what was happening too much to hear.

the result of primal survival instincts, and understanding this, he did not

did not seem fierce and dangerous to him; they were just people, simple transparent and uncomplicated, but in many ways revealing. The bandits. As for the criminals and their code of conduct, their motivations were deeds, masking their true motives.

categorizing their actions. Most often, people's words diverged from their attaching distinctive labels to people and the impossibility of clearly erroneous, yet he learned the lesson, acknowledging the uselessness of Any conclusions regarding the "case of the bandit" would have been prompting one to act according to personal dualities.

and glaze, smiles and sorrows—and all this nested in the human heart. The play of life consisted in the uneven distribution of blessings, rewards both in the world and in the vessel of an individual human personality. seeking and thirst for action, bliss and aversion—all of them are mixed nature itself? Tamas, Rajas, and Satwa—inertia and darkness, active will in all this, or is life a mixed stream of all three? Tamas, a property of and white until these colors became muted, indistinct... Was there Divine casting nets of mercy and cruelty into the ocean of samsara, mixing black work? Causing harm with one hand and offering help with the other, the heart. The latter were the true catalysts of destiny, but how did it all decisions occurred according to the will of karma, dharma, and the call of complexity of human intentions and moral criteria. Individual actions and means to help." This minor incident revealed to him the irresolvable what I do to get by. The old woman needed urgent help, and I had the asked: "Why did you do that?" The man shrugged: "Robbery is just a job. Two or three days later, when the robber was more or less sober, he what was he to be considered now?

criminal gave the money to another person out of compassion... And gave all his "day's earnings" to pay for the hospital and medicine. Yes, the and the old woman grew worse by the hour. Going to her, the robber of the farm workers fell seriously ill with a high fever; her son was absent, three hundred rupees from the victim. That same day, the mother of one behavior. That day, he had robbed someone again, taking a tidy sum of

second kalya.

He soon received a reply: he was expected in Benares; he could receive the level of practice, and having written to his Guru about his achievements, Having mastered Khesari Mudra, he could count on receiving the next already a part of him and merely awaited awakening.

heartbeat—and all this happened naturally, as if the knowledge was his, he could not only stop it by an act of will but also slow his Eighteen months flew by in diligent practice. Now, in full control of his

Becoming Guru

priority.

inner self, with the elusive, blinding light of the Spirit, was becoming the widened, sharpening his acute sense of self. Establishing contact with the and incredible beauty of life, and his understanding of the world emotions. He was filled with an unbearable tenderness for the fragility merely a shell, armor concealing a growing sensitivity and refined self-confidence and survival skills, but the feigned external toughness was The tension he had endured and the constant skirmishes gave him greater

warm reception in almost every shop in the city.

not immediately understand the reason for his sudden popularity and strangers who owned shops began inviting them for a cup of tea. He did guaranteed effect of their presence spread quickly, and already complete enough for the problem to disappear on its own. Rumors of the stop by or simply to walk through the neighborhood, and that was their acquaintances had problems with the local mafia, they were asked to wait, the Sharna brothers had earned a solid reputation. Now, if any of the farm to a rented house in the suburbs of Cwalior. Having won the ... A year later, his brother's contract ended, and the family moved from

apprising citizens. The karmic cocktail made them who they were.

and mercy, and none of this distinguished them from ordinary law-to both fears and complexes, as well as individual displays of generosity

some terrible plunder... Breathing heavily, Satyacharan Lahiri entered the ashram. An anxious thought flashed that he was in for a reprimand for not being in the temple and hastily crossed the courtyard, despite his age and severe arthritis. About ten minutes passed, and he saw the Teacher run out of the room with a look of softness on his face. His mind simply dismissed the possibility of the warmth coming from the heat of his hands... but how to explain the miracle that happened in the temple—was it a hallucination? Perhaps the stone simply overcame him with a strange feeling, he tried to understand what exactly had happened in that room."

and he recoiled. Noticing this, the Guru commanded him: "Wait in the room under the smooth marble under his fingers turned into warm, living flesh, the cold marble shoulders of the statue. After about five to seven minutes, the cold marble shoulders of the statue. Despite the absurdity of the situation, he began obediently rubbing the shoulders of the statue. "Give him a massage," and the teacher began to read. He knew how to serve anyone, let alone a statue, he asked what exactly was required of him. "Serve Lahiri Mahasaya while I read the Gita." Having not the slightest idea how to serve anyone, let alone a statue, he asked what exactly was required of him. Having completed the instruction, the teacher pointed to the statue: "The statue seemed strangely familiar."

the second level of karma, manas and samas. Despite their complexity, the temple, on April 28, 1984, Satyacharan Lahiri taught him the practices of Bhagavad Gita aloud before the statues of his ancestors. In this same ashram. Part of Satyacharan Lahiri's daily practice was reading the Bhagavad Gita and his son Tinkori Lahiri, the father of the current generation, beautiful, large black Shivalinga, and before it, two marble statues of Shiva. In the inner courtyard was a small Shiva chapel, in which was installed a

the Guru's words, Kamesh peeked into the room, smiling shyly. Kamesh was the uncle of the famous sitarist Ravi Shankar. Hearing Kamesh Barua, occupied rooms on the first floor with his family. This "Kamesh, he has done Kamesh!" One of the residents of the large house, Lahiri, pleased with his progress, even called out to the guru, in Bengali: the courtyard of the teacher's house was still comfortable. Satyacharan ... The sun was already heating the city considerably, but in the morning,

three and a half coils (as it is usually described in logic texts). The coils of energy. Shailendra Sharma believes that Kundalini has far more than them, and certain logic techniques can awaken, release, and harness this. There is an ancient belief that every person carries divine energy within streams of *prana* and *apana* directed into the central channel—*Sushumna*. represents the earth element in the human body, can be awakened by the base of the spine. Kundalini, coiled in the *mulaadhara chakra*, which is Kundalini (Sanskrit for “coiled serpent”) is a form of energy sleeping at technique of *Kriya Yoga*.”

disciple who has mastered *Kriyashakti* permitted to initiate others into the Overcoming his embarrassment, he turned to the Guru: “How often is a look of his neighbor said more than the priest answer: “No one...” among the disciples can give initiation into the practice?” The stunned At the next meeting, he quietly asked a disciple sitting nearby: “Who else for those who had done *Kriyashakti* and could transmit *Kriya Yoga* to others? automatically become a guru? Or maybe *guru* was simply a general term who had done *Kriyashakti* and received the next level of practice about the great masters of *Yoga*: it was all too simple. Perhaps anyone What was happening did not align with what he had read and heard year and a half of practice, during his second visit to the teacher...”

But to be named successor at the very beginning of the path, after only a months in *Yoga*, and perhaps, after that, he could give advice to others himself in that role. His initial goal was to achieve the highest attainable Teaching others had never been in his plans: he could not even imagine immediately afterward be appointed the successor of the lineage? All of this was a complete surprise: to receive the second level of *Kriya* and own heartbeat.

the Guru. He was silent; it was so quiet that he thought he could hear his his breath. Utterly bewildered, not knowing what to reply, he bowed to Visibly shaken, the teacher sank heavily into an armchair, trying to catch Guru. From this day, you may give initiation to those you deem worthy.” room. “You are the successor. Everyone agrees. You will be the new

power comes great responsibility.”

Peter Parker, the hero of his favourite Spider-Man comics: “With great these astonishing changes, he could not help but recall the principle of grew, as though the body were preparing for great burdens. Tracing all more quickly and speak fluently and concisely, his physical strength also his own dogged adharma. In addition to the growing capacity to think guided by the strength and the blessing of the Paramhata, as well as by responsibility for the subsequent decisions of the questioner, but he was questions about the most vital problems of life meant carrying any topic and immediately give well-reasoned replies. Answering once. Ordinarily extremely shy and untalkative, he could now analyse the most difficult questions of visitors during darsanas came almost at fallen upon him. Strangely enough, the capacity to give swift answers to Gradually he began to grasp the weight of the responsibility that had unanimously, since the Master had said: “All have agreed...”

knowledge of the probable future. It seemed he had been chosen of the living master and the will of all the previous Gurus, of their astral paramhata had always chosen its successor on the basis of the preferences this: the Master was old and could leave the body at any moment. The combination of all the factors and circumstances could be summed up like could become a Guru simply did not fit in the mind. Logically, the Krishna Yoga cannot be mastered in a few months, and the fact that a novice happened then in the temple. The extraordinarily complex science of Even years later he could not say with any certainty what exactly had Mahasaya was only twenty-six years old.

That is how it all came to pass. The fifth Guru of the paramhata of Lahiri “Never. You are the first,” replied the Guru.

⁸⁰ Pujari – a priest who conducts a religious ceremony or temple rituals.

speaks not of 32, but of 8 coils of Kundalini.

Kundalini represent various forms of the sound “OM.” Gorakhnath

filtered through the medium of knowledge, and of refracting those gleams
successor was capable of catching the reflections of the higher Truth,
destinies, including his own. The Master had to make sure that the
to the general, collective one. The colossal mirror of karmas reflected all
allowing him to see the countless facets of individual karmas, always tied
The Guru's delicate yet unfailingly precise instructions widened his mind,
this occupation was wearying and thankless.

read Her dim crystal sphere for those who were ready to listen. At times
the lottery of life, but the source of Truth was one, and he was learning to
The replies allowed only a passing assessment of the possible outcomes of
future incarnations.]

those souls who are destined to undergo the process of education through
toward liberation — in this life or in the next. This guru is the mentor of
responsibility of leading the disciple through the stages of sadhana
or any other mystical, secret means. He takes upon himself the
transmission (tradition, sampradaya) by means of a mantra, touch, breath,
diksha-guru, is one. He formally initiates the seeker into the line of
spiritual teachers as instructors, but the initiating spiritual teacher, the
diksha-guru, or instructing spiritual teacher. One may have many
types of guru: the diksha-guru or initiating spiritual teacher, and the
practice. Diksha and Bhiksha Gurus — there are two equally respected
[footnote 21: Diksha — initiation into a religious tradition or spiritual

question could have been answered differently, consider such a variant..."
the last visitor had left, the Guru would discuss alternative replies: "This
Chailendra answer," — and listened silently, attentively. Sometimes, after
disciples. Satyacharan Lahiri began to redirect questions to him: "Let
in the presence of the Guru he gave initiation into Kriya to four hundred
and all those who sought initiation into Kriya had to arrive on those days.
Benares two or three times a year, usually staying for several weeks —
diksha[21] to the new ones. Over the following three years he came to
disciples; now the Master simply observed in silence as Chailendra gave
After April 1984 the Guru personally initiated no more than ten or fifteen

had taken place in his younger friend — and he listened attentively to the but upon meeting he instantly saw the dramatic inspiring changes that logic techniques received at the Katat ashram, without particular success. complete absence. For several years S.K.S. had himself been following the progress among the members of their group — or rather, of its almost glad of the meeting. Siddhaji Rao was well aware of the magic logic rented lodgings — and yet S.K.S. sought him out, and both were sincerely During this time his family moved several times — first to a farm, then to conversation took place much later.

community and his good friend, believed him at once, though their search of "true yoga." Only Siddhaji Rao, the founder of this small view, there was no need to challenge the customary balance of things in the group were quite satisfied with their spiritual attainments. In their said was merely the bitterness of an outcast. Moreover, most members of that he had been driven out of the ashram, and that everything he had reacted warily to his stories, and even with hostility. Some even suggested conducive to spiritual development. However, most of his listeners administration of this spiritual establishment, and all of this in no way at the ashram, the dubious morality and financial machinations of the Choosing his words carefully, he described the atmosphere that prevailed and differed cardinally from what was being taught at the ashram in Puri. studying the original teaching of Lahiri Mahasaya: those practices worked were utterly ineffective. His own experience confirmed the importance of Krishna Yoga group that the techniques being taught at the Katat ashram After his return from Puri he tried to warn his acquaintances from the

A Voice Found, the Last Film, and a Head on Fire

of Lahiri Mahasaya. But he felt only the coolness of the marble.

...Several times he went into the temple and discreetly touched the statue but always unchanging.

always different: at times blinding and cutting, at times soft and soothing, for those who were trying to make them out. The light of Truth was

On the appointed day Vyas the elder waited on the threshold of the
would become his spiritual mentor.

fifteen days, at a certain hour, a young man would enter his house who
had received the following revelation: it had been told to him that in
what to think. It turned out that two weeks earlier, in meditation, Vyas-ji
say nothing at all. Having heard out the story of Vyas-ji, he did not know
"Please, accept me as your disciple." To say that he was surprised was to
Holding a garland of flowers, Vyas the elder bowed and touched his feet:
over." In the house they were met by Ubendra's father, visibly agitated.
"Only let us stop at my place for five minutes, and then I shall drive you
give him a lift. Ubendra Vyas drove past and offered to take him along:
That day he needed to get to the market and hoped that someone might

Their father was a deeply spiritual man and practised meditation.

were the only contemporaries with whom he kept company in those days.
Shivamath Vyas and his younger brother Ubendra lived nearby, and they
began to draw attention to him.

without weighty pretext. Perhaps it was precisely the anonymity that
...He now left the house quite rarely, preferring not to leave his room

attracting followers. Krishna did not work that way.

success. But he had no intention of engaging in self-promotion or
understandable achievements. Unless, of course, they bring commercial
practical value, since they do not fall under the category of
the successor of a logic tradition. For many people such things have no
...The members of his household did not even suspect that he had become

Krishna.

and some time later brought his wife, who also received initiation into
S.K.S. asked him for initiation. The old friend became his 5th disciple,
them become a reality. When they met again, he was already a Guru, and
two of them had so recently been reading and arguing had for one of
new practice and the astonishing experiences. The logic path of which the
account of disappointment, of the miraculous finding of the Master, of the

Curu, though he tried to impress no one. Usually, during spontaneous jaugher, and an excellent sense of humour drew many to the young. The incontestable presence of inner strength, charisma, infectious spiritual zeal.

practice he was completely cured and was filled with even greater initiation into yoga he had been gravely ill, then soon after beginning the Krishna. After this, Vyasa the elder's life changed perceptibly. It before the unlike Vyasa-ji and Ushasta, who mastered this most important part of his first disciple. He never could master the Kreshta mudra, however, friendship and support — and this kind and sincere fellow thus became manner of bearing. Bhadraraj knew little of yoga; he simply needed by his impeccable and original logic, his unusual ideas, his confidence and and was struck. The one he remembered as a shy youth now astonished years. That day Bhadraraj had heard his old friend speaking with people, Bhadraraj Dure, with whom he had been acquainted since his teenage earlier, while visiting his cousins in Dwajior. There he had again seen His very first initiation into the practice, however, he had given even

incredibly popular, and visitors treated him with the greatest reverence; astonishment: the unemployed dreamer had suddenly turned out to be rushing straight into his room, his relatives could not conceal their began coming to see "this guru." Watching the steady stream of humans in this young man, "Word of mouth ran without a hitch, and people "If they have become disciples of this Curu, then there must be something and rumours of their initiation into Krishna Yoga spread quickly.

Vyasa-ji and Ushasta-ji enjoyed an unimpeachable reputation in the town, became his faithful companion in various adventures.

another friend of the Vyasa family, called Ushasta-ji, received initiation and Vyasa the elder initiation, and soon Ushasta also asked for it. Then yet father suddenly touching his feet, asking for diksha... Of course, he gave What was taking place seemed beyond the bounds of reality: a friend's house, and everything happened exactly as had been foretold.

comics, he eagerly awaited the premiere of the Superman film. On the day
He was young, and nothing human was alien to him. As a fan of Marvel
them away to other variants of fate...

karmas, which brought them to yoga, to the teacher. Or, conversely, took
No one need be recruited — people are already filtered by their own
projected onto the Guru's "inner screen" a complex network of karmic ties.
complex palette of human characters and archetypes. Each new visitor
The varied discussions gave food for reflection and illustrated the
was always glad of fellow travellers.

was for life. Enthusiastic followers were not encouraged; nevertheless, he
upon himself responsibility for the disciple's future, and this commitment
question. The duties grew also. With each new initiation the Guru took
truthful. His subconscious knowledge deepened exponentially with every
instantly analyse any topic, and the conclusions were weighty and
trials was uncovered. He could...

problems were analysed and resolved, the very essence of a person's life
Answers were given to the most difficult questions, the most intractable
change came back again. And began to take an interest in yoga.

provoked, made them reflect, and those who were ready to think and to
unexpected yet practical solutions. The unusual answers and views
matters were impressed by his ability to resolve any situation and to offer
had nothing against this. People who came to consult him on personal
acquaintance, but returned again and again, as if drawn by a magnet. He
This was an interesting time. Some visitors came merely for a brief
pursue spiritual goals in the midst of the familiar everyday.

them of the wholeness of Truth, helping them to find the courage to
manifested itself. By compelling people to think in a new way, he spoke to
dignity, sincerity, and purity. Through him the power of the parambras
line that no one dared to cross — he was a Guru, and that alone bespoke
soothed and pacified visitors. Nevertheless, there existed a certain unseen
dangers, he was in fine spirits and joked a great deal, which in itself

at his reflection: above his head shone an aureole of golden flame. He blate with a cry: "Your head is on fire!" Springing to the mirror, he looked room carrying a glass of milk and a warm flatbread — and dropped the wished to prolong this indescribable state. His mother entered the dark came downstairs and sat in an armchair without turning on the light. He That night, still filled with bliss and stillness after intensive practice, he him greatly.

late awakenings, silent abstraction, and present-mindedness had altered troubled by his new "hobby"; she believed that all these long meditations, would usually wait for him below to make sure he had eaten. She was unusual. At night he practised in a small room on the roof, and his mother. Meanwhile, the inner and outer changes continued, and some were quite his nerves.

made him keep away from public places. The sudden popularity wore on formed, and all of this was extremely uncomfortable, unnecessary, and he watched in a cinema. Wherever he went, a crowd spontaneously took readers were among the gawkers. Jokes aside, this was the last film appearing on the streets of Cwalior, but it was doubtful that any comic-berstade them to rise. Perhaps the passers-by took him for Suberman, Pandits he prostrate before a young man in jeans? He could scarcely scandal — something was clearly brewing: otherwise why would two A crowd gathered around them instantly, expecting a spectacle or a a knot at the front or back.]

trousers. A piece of cloth is wrapped around the hips and legs and tied in [footnote 25: Dhoti — traditional men's garment resembling loose

were touching his polished cowpoy boots, asking for blessings.

dhosis[25] and kurtas, grey-haired gentlemen in their sixties and seventies themselves right there on the pavement at his feet. Dressed in traditional disciples: one exclaimed, "Curuji!" — and both Pandits prostrated boots with stacked, slanted heels. He was spotted by two elderly bobcorn, dressed in a black T-shirt, black jeans, and showing off cowpoy of the premiere, having bought tickets, he stepped out of the cinema for

companion, he added, "Take him home."

"You have paid your respects, now leave." Then, addressing the visitor's stipple. The Guru, however, remained dispassionate and said coldly, "A wave of compassion swept over Shailendra, and he half-rose to help the stone floor; blood streamed from the old man's chin and nose."

glance at the visitor. Trying to row, the man fell, breaking his face on the accompanied him. Becoming uncommonly severe, the Guru did not even he moved with great difficulty, leaning on the shoulder of a woman who satang[03] when an unexpected guest came in. Old, lame, half-paralyzed, courtyard. The reading of the Gita had ended and people were leaving the One evening they were sitting with the Master before the temple in the

Karmic Lessons

laments.

masterly. But this did not mean that one could relax and rest on one's development of the brain and bore witness to the highest level of logic advanced brainwaves, the aureole pointed to ongoing changes in the resembled a Shivalingam and was a dazzling white. Charged by on a greenish tint, and its shape also changed. For the last twenty years it Over the years the colour of the aura changed: at first a bright gold, it took practice..."

impulse, and he would casually remark, "It is only a side-effect of support and inspiration. In silent awe they would contemplate the bright From time to time he could display the aura to some of his disciples for bright halo above his head, people fell into a state of trance.

continue conversations with visitors and friends. Otherwise, gazing at the time, but in the end he learned to switch it on and off at will so as to experiment with it. To learn to control the bright luminous outline took you imagined it!" Thus did he first see his own aura, and at once began to bewildered; he tried to calm her: "It is only a trick of the light, not flame, quickly switched on the light. His mother was severely frightened and

[footnote २१: Jyāṣṭra — sacred book; a science. Jyāṣṭri — one who holds a Jyāṣṭrika Jyāṣṭra[२१] a treatise on "the knowledge of bodily features," ancient roots. The Indian śiddha-sages followed the ancient Vedic science of the link between outer appearance and inner characteristics and paleness, birthmarks or stretchmarks were marks of previous karmas. The tendencies. Broad ribs in men, long or crooked fingers, luxuriant hair or of skull and toes. External traits could tell of a person's various kind of behaviour by analysing body type, the length of fingers, the shape. There existed methods of determining a predisposition to one or another develop this faculty.

time understood their roots. It was expected that the successor would also led to this or that outcome? The Guru saw human karmas and at the same without knowing the whole history of his life and the circumstances that of human fates. Can one uniddle the substance of someone's character. What had taken place made him reflect on the extreme tangle of the web first try to see the causes of human misfortune; they are never accidental." suffering of others stirs compassion in us — this is wholly natural. But including his health. He is cared for by his widowed daughter... The tears the karmic consequences of his deeds, having lost everything, killed more than three hundred people at Kaśhī Kāśvat. And now he murdered them, and threw the corpses into the Gaṅga. This sounded a brief, turning pilgrims into deserted places where he robbed and you do not know this man. He was a cut-throat who passed himself off as. Turning to him, the Guru said: "You were overcome by compassion. But discussions on dharmas.]

takes place. It may include the singing of kirtans or philosophical gathering in which discussion of the spiritual, meditation, or teaching other important concepts and ideas. Nowadays sāṭsang is also called any spiritual guru (sat guru) for discussion of the principles of Truth and [footnote २३: Sāṭsang — traditionally a gathering in the presence of a before the woman practically carried him out of the courtyard. The old man limped, dragging the paralysed leg, and some time passed

dark-skinned and menacing men in identical white linencloths suddenly ... On that fateful evening, when Devi Lal had lain down after supper, two ask questions.

to listen. The children especially rejoiced, never ceasing to wonder and to seasoning the story with details, Devi Lal readily told it to anyone willing before the burning torch was about to be touched to the wood. Lavishly on the funeral pyre, staring blankly at the crowd of mourners — just orange flowers, wrapped in white funeral cloth, Devi Lal suddenly sat up the cremation, he unexpectedly came back to life. Strewed with garlands of On one not-too-fine evening Devi Lal died, but the next morning, during story they first heard from one of the servants.

a thin, ghost-like man with very dark skin, was called Devi Lal, and his with life in a great mansion with serving staff. One of the fifteen servants, was beautiful, green, and beauteous. The father's high post provided them town of Shivburi, where their family lived before the father's retirement. Another story illustrated a different variety of karmic entanglement. The quite a good one.

found a permanent post in a state school. The karma of this woman was daughter, a modest schoolteacher, and helped her with money until she Master did not remain indifferent to the troubles of the old cripple's chest-first onto it. He could not get up, and was slowly burned alive. The on. Trying to reach for something, the old man lost his balance and fell daughter, having gone to work, left the electric stove in the kitchen turned ... Two years later the former cut-throat died a terrible death. The

Master taught him to see human karmas.

an entirely different science, requiring a developed inner sight. The However, to look into the depths of the human heart was the specialty of 200 BCE.]

Shastras are predominantly post-Vedic literature, appearing roughly after "commandment, rule, manual, compendium, book, or treatise." The special degree permitting him to teach. In Sanskrit the word means

actions. One such method is yoga, capable of changing the lives of the
The laws of karma are inexorable, but they may be softened by certain
for the investigation.

what he was being punished, and indeed there was no longer any need
absolutely nothing was known of Devi Lal's past. No one could say the
story was not a very cheerful one, no moral could be drawn from it, since
into his body had seen to it that the old servant received his due. The
reg. His death was lonely and painful. The one who had sent him back
ill with leprosy, the family turned away from him, and he was forced to
servant had been ordained to suffer, and so it turned out — Devi Lal fell
servants from Shivpuri and inquired about Devi Lal's fate. The old
When the family moved to Gwalior, he once met one of the former
and he will feel nothing!,"

demonstrated to visiting relatives: "Look, I can drive a needle into him
children extremely thrilling. Sometimes Devi Lal's midnight activities were
of death, but because he could endure pain. All of this seemed to the
children — not because he had risen from the dead after nine long hours
into his own flesh without blinking, and became a true hero of the
spot where the kick had landed. As proof, Devi Lal would stick a needle
himself on the funeral pyre. His buttock permanently lost sensation in the
the other kicked him in the rear, and he fell into an abyss, coming to
back!," One of the fierce escorts yanked the book from Devi Lal's mouth,
exhausted all his sins. Why have you brought him so soon? Throw him
He said: "This sinner has been appointed to suffer longer; he has not yet
man, surrounded by bright light, filled with dignity and inner strength.
They arrived at a strange place where they were met by a grey-bearded
seemed to him that this torture lasted an eternity.

the unbearable pain Devi Lal saw nothing of his surroundings, and it
cheek. The other began to beat him with a staff studded with thorns. From
bed with a huge fishing hook that one of the strangers stuck into his
frightened Devi Lal tried to protest, but he was roughly dragged from his
appeared in the room and ordered him to rise and follow them. The

consciousness. The Agnoris hold that, by learning to identify with one's every human being represents an individual whole, one with divine jealousy, greed, and lust. The chief postulate of Agnora is that at his root limited, and is mastered by destructive emotions such as anger, fear, that every time people "discriminate," their selfhood, their wholeness, is teaching does not lend itself to easy categorization. Its followers maintain is universal and transcends the particularities of religion or culture, the division by discriminating signs of religion, race, or sex. Through Agnora a simple and natural state of consciousness without fear, hate, disgust, or

[footnote 92: Agnora — a spiritual tradition arising in Northern India. It is

not a continuous celebration of death and denial of the light; orthodox Hinduism. How else could one call life in cremation grounds, if mortifying rituals contradicted the very notion of purity, so revered in black magic and is considered "impure." It seemed that the aim of all these Throughout India the path of Agnora[92] is associated with darkness and one could come to know God while living amid death and filth. Watching the Agnoris with cautious curiosity, he tried to understand how attention of tourists hungry for photo-shots.

half-naked sorcerers and their strange paraphernalia attracted the smeared with ash, adorned with amulets of human bone, shaggy and Varanasi, one could meet practicing Agnoris in their "natural habitat," life circumstances. But here, by the burning pyres on the ghats of not outcasts, people approach them only in the most difficult and unusual fearsome-looking ascetics may be met all over India. Through Agnoris are Benares has always been known as the city of the Agnoris, although these

The Last Meditation of an Agnori

another bond was formed, but this karma was of a special kind. ones. Of course, with each new initiation, with each new disciple, yet resolve to pay off whatever debts there might be, and try not to incur new certainly how burdensome his own past had been, but was filled with predisposition, luck, and the grace of a Guru. He did not yet know with worst of criminals. But to be granted such a chance, one must have karmic

followed the boy through the narrow labyrinths of streets. At the door of One of the servants' children was charged with leading him, and he the future.

understand: Satyacharan Lahiri wanted him to receive certain hints about Agnori, one of those people sitting on the ghats? Only years later did he bath, is beginning his final meditation. You must visit him." To visit and the words: "A friend of mine, who has attained the heights of the Agnora In November 1982 Satyacharan Lahiri sent him to one such ascetic with persons...

they are powerful. The Master was acquainted with the most unusual their income? The Guru said that real Agnoris are extremely rare, and sorcerers and tantrikas who appropriated this title in order to increase disgusting. Moreover, how many true Agnoris were there among the Mahadev loves the cremation grounds, but certain rituals were simply the abyss of icy eternity — yes, but not among rotten half-burnt remains... Shiva enjoys being worshipped amid stench and decay. In darkness, in walking one of the roads leading to truth. And yet he did not believe that of the illusory nature of customary attitudes. These people might well be consuming other intoxicants is a radical approach, but it gives some sense states of consciousness. Living among corpses, smoking ganja and comprehend non-quality, they overcome social taboos and reach altered darkness by way of various rituals. For it is part of the Light. Striving to them life and death are merely two sides of one coin, and so they accept opposites are ultimately illusory: "pure" and "impure" do not exist. For "Self" and its identity with the Absolute. The Agnoris hold that all to moksha is one for all seekers: through awareness of the individual yogis, Agnoris seek liberation from the cycle of reincarnations. The road And yet, even the "dark" sadhana strives toward the same goal. Like dualistic (Advaita) subdivision of the Hindu philosophical school.]

realization. Some scholars and researchers classify Agnora as a non-previously invested in limitation may be redirected toward self-own wholeness, one is freed from limitations. As a result, the energy

on earth at a time when evil would triumph and when the Kshatriyas' prudence and patience. It was foretold that Parasurama would appear fierce and valiant but also with composure, control, will-power. One of the Immortals, Parasurama is endowed not only with martial Rama Bhargava, and Virama) — the sixth incarnation of Lord Vishnu. [footnote 36: Parasurama ("Rama with the Axe," Rama Jambavan's mantra and perform a particular ceremony.

instructions for performing the rite. For forty days he was to recite a of invoking Parasurama, he persuaded his mentor to give him detailed nothing unusual. Persistently questioning his own teacher about methods still-young ascetic to confirm a spiritual link with "Rama of the Axe," was Parasurama is considered the Guru of all Agnis, so the desire of the wished to see Parasurama[36], one of the eight immortal sages. Once, when he had lived on the cremation grounds, he had suddenly. The old Agni was silent: nearly twenty minutes passed before he spoke.

Please bless me and, if it seem fitting to you, say something to inspire me." his Guru, he added: "I am his disciple and follow the same tradition. Half an hour later the meditator finally spoke: "Who are you?" Naming

poorly. Guru, he was utterly inexperienced in matters of preparing to leave the minutes dragged on extremely slowly, and he felt uneasy. Even being a say nothing that could disturb the ascetic, and simply to wait. The silently bowed and quietly sat on the floor. He had been strictly told to powerful vibrations. Approaching the motionless figure, Shailendra associated with the cult of Agni. From the old man emanated unusually appearance. There was no trace in him of the ugliness or wildness usually with a woollen cap on his head; clean-shaven, he had a pleasant motionless. The ascetic appeared to be about ninety, wrapped in a shawl, man was sunk in deep trance: his eyes were open and absolutely up the stairs. Sitting on the roof of the house, facing the Ganga, the old visitors were not admitted to an Agni in his final meditation. He went an old house he gave the name of his Guru, and was invited in: chance

existence about the concrete meaning of what he had heard and what had one's own must be earned. To question an Agbhor on the brink of non-explanation is considered improper, since realisation must be obtained on on the obvious or hidden meanings. To demand an immediate often given without explanation, and the questioner must himself reflect ...The peculiarity of Indian philosophical schools is that information is geopolitics or in the constitutional structure of the United States.

ascetic's last words: at the time he had no interest whatsoever in united. Now go." Greatly puzzled, he bowed and left, pondering the Union will vanish, and after some time the United States will cease to be Unexpectedly the old man uttered: "You shall see — one day the Soviet

All other yantras descend from the Sri Yantra.]

universal centre. The triangles represent the cosmos and the human body, representing Shiva and Shakti, surround a central point, the Bindu, the (yantra), used in the teaching of Sri Vidya. Nine intersecting triangles, [footnote 97: Sri Yantra or Sri Chakra — a form of mystical diagram 16916.

anything more. Probably this was the appropriate moment to take his molten silver. The Agbhor was silent, and it did not seem he would say sideways. The November sun stood high, and the Ganga shone like Teasing his gaze away from the river, the old man glanced at him

the sand and the gravel, there was not a trace of red paint...

yantra disappeared with him, and on the surface of the ground, among Yantra[97], drawn in red vermilion. When Parasurama vanished, the clearly as I see you now. On the earth behind the Avatar I noticed a Sri "On the fortieth day Parasurama stood before me, and I saw him as Karma.]

presented as the mentor of many heroes: Bhishma, Drona, Bhisma, and destroying all kshatriyas twenty-one times over. In the Mahabharata he is power. It is held that Parasurama will restore the cosmic balance by warriors endowed with weapons and might, would begin to abuse their

in the life of Parasurama awoke in him — he was a part of the charade of cult could be not only useful but prophetic. After this meeting, an interest line would be linked with Agnori, and the blessings of a follower of this reason. The Master knew: the destiny of the next, the Fifth Guru of the his own fate, for the Guru had sent him to the departing ascetic for a destiny. It seemed that the meeting with the Agnori had sown the seeds of From time to time he reflected on all this, trying to decipher the codes of becoming less and less united.

Washington, on the brink of large-scale civil unrest, the United States was watched militants and radicals storming the Capitol building in before they descended upon people's heads. But already in 2021 the world prognoses, the coming transformations, evidently, were still gathering true, and the changes touched him personally. As for the rest of the became his disciples. Yes, this part of the prediction undoubtedly came fall of the Soviet empire seekers of yoga began coming to India. Some ordinary citizens of the USSR could not travel abroad freely, but after the powerful citadel of socialism collapsed, and rather quickly. In those days Soviet Union would cease to exist. However, within five years the At that time it was impossible to imagine that such a mighty state as the when the time comes. Agnoris are known for seeing the future."

Master, the Guru smiled: "You will know the meaning of these words and the United States? When he passed the words of the Agnori on to the keep on living. But why had the ascetic spoken at all of the Soviet Union Did the Agnori bless him? There was no way to know: one had simply to rank.

and committed to the river in accordance with the custom for saints of his was wrapped in white cloth, decked with garlands of yellow marigolds, the Agnori. A "water burial" was rapidly arranged: the body of the Agnori visitors had come after his departure: he had been the last to speak with the Ganga with frozen, unblinking dead eyes. It turned out that no further. The next day the old man was found sitting in the same posture, gazing at been foretold would simply be inappropriate.

dedicated to the marriage of Shiva and Shakti.]

February-March. One of the principal religious festivals in India, but the chief celebration of Maha Shivaratri is held once a year, in [footnote 88: Shivaratri — "the Great Night of Shiva," observed monthly, empire,

or Vishveshvar. Its domes, plated with a ton of pure gold from the Sikh stood the chief Shaivite temple of Mahadeva, known as Sri Vishvanath Vishvanath Gali, one of the oldest and busiest streets of the city. There in the morning, weaving through the narrow lanes, he set out for

during Mahashivaratri[88], you must go for darshan to Vishvanath[89]!" prayers. But Satyacharan Lahiri insisted: "Since you happen to be here devotees stood in long queues at the temples, to lay flowers and offer expectations boiled in the gigantic cauldron of the eternal city: millions of air amid unimaginable crowds. The thick brew of thoughts and complex cocktail of human robes and prayers spills generously into the tried to avoid public places during the great religious festivals, when the the Master. He had never been particularly fond of going to temples and Night of Shiva, and he decided to remain in the city to spend time with In March 1980, Benares was preparing for the celebration of the great

Darshan of Vishvanath

everything.

Everything in the world was bound together and interwoven. Absolutely contemplate its patterns, trying to follow the windings of the yarn. Time continued to unwind its eternal thread; all that remained was to its own important role in the play of his life.

its installation. This tantric three-dimensional diagram of the cosmos had under astonishing circumstances, and indeed with precise instructions for in someone else's dream. As for the mystical Sri Yantra, it came to him a personal message from "Rama of the Axe," himself, even though it came his future. And he was not at all surprised, nineteen years later, to receive

Brhman's fifth head, Mahadev cursed Brhman together with the ketaki the lie, Shiva took the wrathful form of Kala Bhairava[105]. Seizing summit of the pillar, calling upon the ketaki flower to witness. Enraged by Exhausted by fruitless attempts, Brhman lied that he had reached the the Kali Yuga.]

will be the Kalki Avatar, who, according to prophecy, will bring an end to of various beings (avatars). It is held that His tenth and final incarnation and evil in troubled times. Vishnu has incarnated nine times in the form of the world created by Brhman. His role is to restore the balance of good [footnote 101: Vishnu — one of the tridev (trinity), defender and preserver

bottom of the bond by the royal Ganesha.]

may explain the origin of the legend of the golden statue of a boat on the Hiranyaksha. The dynasty of the Bharatputra worshipped Vishnu, and this he was sent to save the earth, which had been drowned by the demon [footnote 100: Varaha — third avatar of Lord Vishnu, in the form of a boat

became a swan to fly up to its very top.

Varaha[100], Vishnu[101] rushed to dig under the column, while Brhman worlds with the infinite column of light. Taking the form of the wild boat Trinity as to who was the strongest — then Mahadev had pierced all three Himself. The cause of its appearance had been a dispute among the light, it shot up into the sky, beginningless and endless, like Shiva [yogi] had appeared. Breaking out from the earth as a pillar of on the very spot where the first of the twelve self-manifested ...Dedicated to the Lord of the Universe, Kashi Vishwanath had been built

history.

block the ragged currents of human emotion, he focused on the temple's near the end of the queue, the crowd was already quite dense. Trying to indifferent to everything happening below. When he reluctantly drew gleamed brightly, while in the blue sky pigeons circled, absolutely

the Universe."]

[footnote 99: Vishwanath — one of the names of Shiva, meaning "Lord of

gradually flowed toward the entrance of the temple. Hundreds of hands stirred human mass, at first sight wholly chaotic but well-organized. One queue was for men, in the other stood women, and all this joyously-
lammala-dupkha-vinashaka-lam tat-pranamami sadashiva-lingam...

Brhama-Mutari-suracita-lingam nirmala-phasita-shobhita-lingam
pursue each of us."

and Vishnu, pure and shining, he destroys the sorrows which from birth
veneration of the eternal manifestation of Shiva: "...revered by Brhama
him began softly to chant the Lingashtakam, an eight-stanza poem of
but weariness and irritation. A small group of Tamils standing behind
flowers in his hands began to wilt. By four in the afternoon he felt nothing
...The queue had been creeping along for more than five hours; the
earth.

at all resemble a sacred point of contact between heaven and the firm
link between earthly and heavenly; this place packed with people did not
revolve. But standing in the slowly moving queue, he felt no symbolic
centre, the axis of the world, around which the spindle of the planet
...The Jyotirlingam is regarded as the pillar supporting creation, its

Bhairava is Dasava, which means "the one carried by a dog."]

holds the staff in his hand"), the punisher of sinners. Another name of
Reality. Usually in India Bhairava is also called Dandabani ("the one who
Kashmiri Shaivism (the Trika system) Bhairava represents the supreme
manifestation of Shiva, principally connected with destruction. In
[footnote 105: Bhairava (or Kala Bhairava) — a Shaivite deity, a mighty

offering he had bought a datura flower.

o'clock in the morning, and many hours of waiting still lay ahead. As an
decision: "The Creator has made nothing but chaos..." It was only ten
preserved. Watching the festive bustle, he fully endorsed Mahadev's
changed. In India only a handful of temples to Brhama have been
never again used in offerings, and centuries later the situation had not
flower. The Creator ceased to be worshipped, and the ketaki flower was

out to be fateful. Mahadev's embrace at Vishvanath was the prelude to a several other interesting places and people, and all of these visits turned At the Guru's insistence, from November 1985 to March 1986 he visited would show.

his whole being: whether this was an embrace or a taking, only the future Yes, Shiva had struck him in the very heart, and fateful vibrations pierced one of the holiest relics of India?

Who else could have shoved him with such precision that he landed on this spontaneous offering had been initiated by none other than Shakti? So then, he had offered himself to Shiva along with a datura flower, and That was a true dashan."

the Master said: "It seems Vishvanath Ji has accepted you as an offering. child; never before had he seen the Guru so amused. Wiping away tears, told the Master what had happened. Satyacharan Lahiri laughed like a Guru's house. Still irritated, feeling not the slightest spiritual elevation, he remained only to push back through the crowd to the safe harbour of the held his tongue: all that needed to happen had already happened. It embarrassed, was already offering Vishvanath Ji her own offerings. He woman who had caused his spectacular fall — but she, in no way Two Brahmin attendants helped him up; in anger he turned to the elderly the relic, and now lay directly on top of the dark glossy stone.

It turned out he was stuck in a small silver depression that surrounded balance, he fell, striking the left side of his chest against something hard. surface of the Shivalingam when someone shoved him. Losing his Having laid down the flowers, he had barely managed to touch the moist to make room for ever more devotees. "Only one touch! Move along!"

the spot, and the temple staff had practically to push them out of the door dark-brown glossy stone. Stunned by this sight, some pilgrims froze on of garlands of yellow marigolds were repeatedly cleared away, parting the stretched toward the Shivalingam set in a square depression; mountains

hours in sadhana. This raised a puzzle: how can one practice for twenty about Ram Gopal Muzumdar: the "sleepless saint" daily spent twenty in the "Autobiography of a Yogi" Yogananda mentions an interesting fact became the principal component of his life, displacing the other priorities. practice were less important than making it part of daily life — until yoga regularity of sadhana, together with duration. At first, long hours of mind and deepened the experiences. The guarantee of success was quality. Stimulated by the duration of practice, yoga slowly elevated the important? He knew: without quantity there comes no realization of progress be measured by the number of hours spent, or is quality more ... Was complete immersion in the practice the key to success? Can he remained motionless.

and back, eventually spread over the whole body. Counting his breaths, in the lotus went numb, but the implacable pain, having first tested pelvic nervous system, which sends frantic signals to the brain. The legs folded in its boundless variety, pain challenged the protective mechanism of the in the limbs required persistence and patience.

the sharp, gnawing pain in the joints and to endure the dragging spasms was accompanied by pain that could no longer be ignored. To withstand of known, well-studied, generally accepted norms, and this determination He himself was filled with the determination to step beyond the boundary predisposition to hard asceticism was part of the programmed life-plan.

as far as ambition and motive allowed. The individual karmic to overcome discomfort. The boundary of overcoming could be stretched individuals — but those who strove toward the highest goal of yoga had meditation was not obligatory — physical capacities vary among it was necessary to remain in the lotus posture. Such a duration of Sometimes the practice could last more than ten hours, and all of that time

Pain, Bonuses, and Inner Time

personal audience, but all this was still to come.

No one can stay awake twenty hours and perform the higher pranayamas its work: now he could increase practice-time without cutting back rest. biological clock adapted to the new schedule. The adjustment had done. Meditation established a new cycle of sleep and waking, and the hours.

Time was renewed: the body had become breath, no longer measured by expanding the hours cut out from the cloth of the everyday. The sense of The steady streams of Prana and Apana[104] filled his body, lengthening non-logic breathing.

inner "daily cycle," there were six hundred breaths — and this is brain contained twenty-one thousand inhalations and exhalations: during the the precise number of exhalations and inhalations: the outer day organism to sleep. One ancient text, the Shvaasana-tantra, even specified body its rhythm, showing the myriad neurons put not putting the Falling into rhythm with the melody of inner time, pranayama sang to the passed not only on biological cycles.

organ's blood circulation, and brain impulses obeyed. And this time was put the ancient logic knew of the existence of an inner time, to which translated as asceticism or penance.]

Sanskrit root "tap," meaning heat or energy, and may roughly be purification, self-discipline, and austerity. "Tapasya" comes from the [footnote 103: Tapas — in logic practice means super-efforts leading to alternation of day and night

no longer confined himself to 24 hours. External, solar time governed the schedule. He slept after yoga, ate and exercised as long as he wished, and the frame of a single day was impossible, and he established his own time of meditation increased to twenty hours. To squeeze the practice into he kept on extending the boundaries of the possible. From April 1982 the sadhana, one must first perform the great austerity, mahatapas[103], and one to ask. But the logic texts said that, before attaining the results of hours a day if there are only twenty-four hours in a day? There was no

again and again disintegrated into the elements, and each time the soul continued, and almost always the mind found a new vessel. Spent bodies

death of the body, the journey of the mind

lotus, sent its roots into the nourishing soil of the subconscious. With the inhalation followed exhalation, life met death. The conscious mind, like a illusory line clearly marked off the world. Different realms intersected, contact between sky and earth, using a romantic metaphor. And yet this ...Eight years later he wrote of touching the horizon, the thin line of still more time.

hour and a half. The reviving of the entire "earthly space-suit" required. However, just to straighten out a leg after Padmasana took him about an whole body became mind, forgetting its bodiliness.

now the sensation of discomfort existed only in the mind. And then the as salt in the ocean, pain sated its hunger, and the organism accepted it: And then... the pain went. Wholly assimilated by the body and dissolved to slow, the numbness of the body intensified until it reached the neck. (actually, after several years of Kriya practice) the blood circulation began opened the gates to the invading armies of Pain. After some time out. At some point he understood: resistance is useless, and simply companions, whose irritating, tormenting company could only be waited stiffness, cramps, sharp twinges and aches became constant oppressive remained.

practice again. The problem of time was solved, but the factor of pain exhausted themselves in the process of practice. Waking, he was ready to like a dead man for 12-14 hours. He saw no dreams — all dreams For the next six months he practised for twenty hours, then ate and slept downward and responsible for elimination, digestion, and reproduction.]

[footnote 104: Aprana — one of the five pranas (life forces), moving body required proper restoration.

without adequate rest. The Yoga of the Immortals was intense, and the

[footnote 100: Mandala — a specific geometrical configuration of symbols, practice predetermined the events that followed.

could dispute. And, most importantly: these six months of unremitting twenty hours of unbroken practice were a victory, an achievement no one possible. For the moment the absence of pain was enough for him, and spirit among beings like himself? It was useless to guess: anything was transfer of mind beyond the earthly spheres, astral existence as a mighty but constant stream of consciousness. What awaited him: immortality, he observed the rotation of forces and elements, the flowing of the invisible the outline of life. He stood at the centre of this ancient mandala[100] and Divided into inhalations and exhalations, the movements of Prana formed [footnote 102: Iccha — will, desire.]

called. He himself called it "Awakening."

Self, of Knowledge of God, of Unity, by whatever names these goals are these three factors, were indispensable conditions of the search for the never chose weaklings. She came at the call of the Will. These three forces, physical strength was one of the conditions of this transaction, for Shakti possessed Her was called Shaktimaan, Master of Power. The presence of of convenience. Shakti could grant power only out of love. He who one who called Her only voluntarily — for Her there were no marriages was will, resolve, the blade of intention. And the power, Shakti, came to As an action, Kriya had to be accompanied by Iccha[102] and Shakti. Iccha to this short but mighty mantra: "By doing, you will succeed."

Anandamayi Ma were still with him, and he continued to live according instrument, a complex apparatus. The words once spoken by practice. It was performed by the mind, but the body was a necessary Kriya was the yoga of action, and progress in it was attained only by losing the body that sheltered them.

flower of developed consciousness and the seeds of all memories without had to undergo its training anew. Yet there existed ways to preserve the

blocking or avoiding the waves of human thought, the cacophony of that overwhelmed him. Later he learned to pass beyond such states, suspended animation did not say a word of the mad swirl of emotions by no means pleasant. The romantic descriptions of the state of The logic texts described samadhi as bliss, but his own sensations were outweighed the subtle atoms of piety, selflessness, and goodness.

unbearable. The week of butting mental projections and impulses revulsion and delight. Moreover, the smell of humanity was simply he were being made to drink a mixture of nectar and poison, evoking both emotions of others at the same time, and it overwhelmed him, as though poured into his wide-open consciousness. He was aware of all the tangible, voluminous, and all of this cocktail of multiple emotions now anger, sexual desires, the need to possess someone or something, were and employers, the thoughts of some smoldered like coals of hidden were eating, defecating, having sex, weaving intrigues against neighbors could see (or rather, feel and know) all that they felt and knew. People His mind bore witness to the consciousness of every living being: he corner of the city, where people were going about their daily business. heart and breathing stopped, consciousness entered every room and until it wholly engulfed him — and he fell into the dizzying radianse. The ring of light, the dark sphere of Kutastha became ever brighter and larger clicked and his mind flung itself open like doors. Surrounded by a bright routine, when, after the exhalation in Yoni mudra, something inside It was the last week of September, the night sadhana felt familiar, almost distant urban noise. The place was almost idyllic.

were usually held, and the local samashta insulated the residents from the college. Whole hectares of green fields, where festivals and weddings secluded; only a few residential buildings stood beyond the engineering In 1982 the family moved back to town. The neighborhood was rather

Samadhi

used for meditation and the practice of concentration.]

numbness of the body.

applies that had opened up in the night, the range of his own emotions, the he had successfully overslept. Forcing himself to rise, he recalled the He woke up late. His anxious mother was calling him to breakfast, which and he was filled with relief, gratitude, and satisfaction.

a safe and hospitable place. The long agonising thirst had been quenched, of a traveller, exhausted by hunger and thirst, finding after a long journey doubt, he knew precisely what had befallen him. It was like the sensations performing Yoni mudra). About what had just happened he had no animation for an hour and a half (he usually marked the time before His wristwatch showed that he had been in the state of suspended will-power not to cry out...

bones, and nerves. To endure this was unbearable; he summoned all his by millions of pricking and itching tiny needles piercing the inner organs, to imagine the whole body in such a state, numb and lifeless, tormented tingling of circulation slowly restoring sensitivity to the limbs. And then moment, he would ask them to picture a numb hand or leg and the sensations. Years later, answering questions from disciples about this himself. Circulation restored itself slowly, causing almost unbearable but he became aware of this only when he began gradually to come to stabbing waves. The body remained lifeless, breath and circulation absent, consciousness of the living and the dying, swept through him in sharp. All colours, emotions, configurations and forms, kinds, sex and and this knowledge filled him to the brim.

now impossible. All these memories once more became part of his being, in different bodies, in earlier births and lives — to forget them again was sensation, he remembered everything he had forgotten and lived through individuality remained untouched, and at the same time, along with this omniscience and omnivision, he did not forget who he was. The core of Acutely and entirely aware of himself, he by no means dissolved in others, emotions flooding his mind, but at that moment...

society, country, even humanity, demanding total submission to generally appeared to the duty or responsibility of the seeker toward his family, spiritual nonsense, calling self-realisation "a waste of time." Well-wishers who was changing before their eyes, to talk him (or her) out of this people around remained immobilised. They mainly tried to stop the one. An inspired seeker could move in the stream of imagination while the interferences and admonitions can become unbearable.

seeking can be, if a yogin lives in a family — the unceremonious out to be relative. He soon understood how thorough the bath of spiritual postulates and truths transmitted by parents and other adults had turned the institutions of religion and power — these were phantoms. The freeing of the mind from its conditioned state laid bare the sad truth about bodily changes, samadhi entirely altered the perception of reality. The means a state of bliss as the uninitiated imagined it. In addition to the some of the discoveries of the first samadhi were shocking: it was by no invisible line dividing laymen from spiritual seekers.

consider themselves normal. It was then that he began to discern the experiences lay beyond the comprehension of ordinary people who himself up entirely. Only the Master could understand him, for such psychiatric disorder and needed special treatment. After this he shut expression. And then carefully suggested that he was suffering from a what he had experienced, but everyone looked at him with a strange dissuade her. After some time he did try to tell her and his cousins about convinced he was suffering from unrequited love, and he did not try to His mother shook him, tried to make him at least eat regularly. She was

interest in life. Nothing could shake off the lethargy that had seized him. all desire to practise yoga had gone, together with his appetite and his staring at the ceiling, recalling the details of what he had lived through: trials, he felt unceasing fatigue and depression. Most of the time he lay existence of higher brahmanas that permit mind and body to bear such disturbing: he began to age rapidly. Knowing nothing then about the ...The consequences of this first expedition into the Void were rather

of a new journey.

Samadhi was not a destination but the next chapter, a step, the beginning darkened again.

stopped the progressing ageing, and even some of the grey hairs
At first even rising from bed was hard, but unremitting physical exercise
body.]

mind, and the movement of attention along the energetic centres of the
positive combining pandhas (energetic locks), mindas, including kreschani
complex action involving the simultaneous performance of a seated
"Mahamudra," literally means "great seal." In Kriya yoga, mahamudra is a
[footnote 10]: Mahamudra — in Sanskrit "mudra" means "seal," so
mahamudras[10].

live, and he stubbornly lifted weights and performed countless
the smell of sweat, the flow of blood... The body had to be taught again to
could return it to life, making it feel the pulse and the tension of muscles,
through the gates of death. The mind needed a hint, a direction, that
activity useless, and the ending — irreversible, since the body had passed
influence of the state lived through, the mind had begun to consider any
tating toward the prescribed and unavoidable disintegration. Under the
of approaching end. And, hesitating, it had obediently begun to age,
body had perceived the absence of heartbeat and breath as the sure sign
everything fell into place: samadhi had been a meeting with death; the
Once, taking a shower, he noticed grey hair on his chest — and suddenly
samadhi while living in the "normal" world was unenviable.

stopped. In short, the situation of those who have experienced logic
breaker of rules and norms had to be warned, shamed, scolded, corrected,
own incapacity for development, and this was unbearable to them. The
all that had been done for him. Another's progress made people feel their
shirking these ephemeral duties, accused of selfishness, and reminded of
accepted rules and norms. The impractical dreamer was shamed for

suspended animation.

by the local authorities, was posted. The sadhu entered the state of underground was closed with boards and a guard of soldiers, appointed gastrointestinal tract, and got into the pit dug specially for him. The inside. Afterwards the sadhu drank a little ghee to lubricate the prakshalana[108] so that not a trace of organic matter would remain he meticulously cleansed his intestines and stomach by various the hair from his head and body so that no insects would lodge in it. Then authenticity of the trial. Permission was granted, and the sadhu shaved all six months and asked for an official guard, which would confirm the This ascetic intended to remain underground without food or water for request permission of the British authorities to conduct an experiment.

sadhu, having arrived in the city, began to

listeners a story which had happened in Benares at the end of the 1930s. A About cases of samadhi, the Guru did indeed speak, and once told his human figure, only a few centimetres in size, radiating light.

Guru could see his own soul, the Jiva. It appeared in the form of a golden It is known that after the first samadhi, every time he closed his eyes, the itself — and becomes at once everything.

of the mind, the state in which consciousness passes beyond all, except means to give birth to a child. And the same applies to the transcendence mother, by observing someone's labour it is impossible to feel what it the events that preceded the birth, all the feelings and emotions of the understand the meaning of what is happening. Without understanding well-known allegorical parable: a virgin present at childbirth cannot fully Master was right, and the brevity of his answer was supported by the know all that is necessary when you experience it yourself." Of course the When asked about samadhi, the Guru never went into details: "You will By that time the Master's father, Tinkori Lahiri, had already left the body. Shri Satyacharan Lahiri first entered samadhi when he was well over fifty.

Trick or Attainment: the Lost Meaning of Samadhi

and on that day, unable to cope with his emotional trauma, he purposely
summit, to which hundreds of steps lead, stands the temple of Hanuman,
his suffering by throwing himself down from the hill of Chitrakut. At the
through a tragedy and, in deep depression, had decided to put an end to
The personal history of this man was remarkable. At thirty he had lived
emotions whatsoever, only the absolute darkness of non-being...

Logic samadhi, the mind was empty and dark. I had no thoughts or
state was like a coma. All the functions of the body ceased, and, unlike
animation. The answers were quite honest: "I felt absolutely nothing; my
about the thoughts and emotions experienced in the state of suspended
allowed the sadhu to remain alive in a breathless state for six months,
some time. Satyacharan Lahiri asked about the techniques that had
his grandson, Satyacharan Lahiri. Over lunch and tea they spoke for quite
This sadhu had heard of Lahiri Mahasaya and therefore agreed to meet

speak, gained renown, and grew wealthy, receiving numerous donations.
for him to begin walking without help. Several weeks later he was able to
curtains, and at last the sadhu came out of the room. It took about a week
the door was opened slightly, and the assistant gradually raised the
confinement, the sadhu spent several days in total darkness. Every day
Having become extraordinarily sensitive to sunlight after the long
poured a little ghee into his mouth to start and cleanse the intestines.
mantra into his left ear. Forcing the ascetic's teeth apart, the assistant
his neck and shoulders, pressing on certain points and whispering a
remained short. The sadhu's helper or disciple began carefully to massage
He looked freshly shaven, and even his nails, cut six months earlier, had
sadhu's skin had yellowed; there was still not a single hair on his body.
who usually monitored such cases. Because of the absence of sunlight the
ascetic was extracted; this fact was documented by the British authorities.
After six months the improvised cave was opened and the quite alive
gastrointestinal tract.]

techniques of cleansing the digestive system, including the whole
[footnote 108: Prakashana — Sanskrit word meaning "cleansing"; Logic

...In the course of the conversation the sadhu said: "You have an entirely
contradiction."

the staged "death" was not the result of logic traps, it required great
— who else could boast of being able to die and return to life? Although
called him a "great sadhu." And indeed he had achieved the impossible
left generous donations. They literally showered him with money and
who had conquered death — and, paying tribute to his courage, people
simply standing behind such asceticism. Everyone wanted to see a man
miracle was a miracle, and people were not interested in the motives or
similar to the logic art. The general public saw no contradictions in this; a
the ability to die and revive by act of will was indisputable and very
logic, since he had practiced no discipline other than the "art of dying." But
strictly speaking, Satyacharan Lahiri's new acquaintance had never been a
strange things in pursuit of earnings or in search of the Almighty.

social standards and criteria. Such people wander about, doing quite
in India under the general category of sadhu fall all who do not meet
system during the risky "experiments."

this allowed him to bear the colossal loads on the heart and nervous
brain. At that time the new convert was young and physically strong, and
the skull, one may "sever the head" and arrest the blood supply to the
explained how, by pressing certain points on the neck and at the base of
and the circulation of blood in the veins and inner organs. The mentor
the art of dying by stopping all functions of the body, including breath
so the despairing man became this sadhu's disciple and was instructed in
with me, and I shall teach you to die properly..."

should not leave the body in such an unworthy and primitive way. Come
suicidal thoughts of the young man. "If you really mean to die, you
sixties, he looked like an ordinary wandering sadhu but had read the
his call. An unremarkable sadhu in orange robes appeared to be in his
stranger who had come out of nowhere altered the course of events with
preparing for the leap when someone called out: "Hey, brother..." A
man almost ran up. As he approached the edge of the cliff he was

...Satyacharan Lahiri also told of another case, again happening in suspended animation? There was no one to answer these questions.

non-death. But how long could the herbal elixir keep the body in tried method and remained between worlds, in a state of non-life and intriguing possibility that before his final journey the sadhu had used his — perhaps he had died of natural causes. There was, of course, the remembered the story, but the man had disappeared many years before dying, ascetic and inquired about him among the local sadhus. Some ...In 1990, visiting Chitrakut, he recalled the Guru's story of the "never-leading to absolute fusion with the world.

Logic, this death-like samadhi was the gate of the portal of Knowledge, investigation of one's own capacities, limitations, and aspirations. For all, and then return? What seemed a trick, a fakir's gimmick, was an process. Why should the living cross the threshold of Death uninvited at was a complex science and demanded a profound understanding of the which required the presence of a knowledgeable helper. The art of dying No less important were the techniques of subsequent revival of the body,

halt all physiological processes without ceasing life itself.

particular mantras and pressure-point massage, the magical herb could the right proportion, it induced a state resembling death. Combined with rare herb growing in inaccessible jungles. Properly prepared and taken in though almost 80 years later it became known that there existed a certain Khechari. The secrets of his knowledge the sadhu shared with no one, — he had not been taught it, for his kind of "death" did not require secret of Khechari he did not possess, though he had heard of this mantra with a particular wisdom, but did not give him highest Knowledge. The Undoubtedly, the experience of death endowed this uneducated man revelations nor any special wisdom."

deep sleep or oblivion. I see neither dreams nor visions. I have neither lies the difference between our states. When I enter death, the state is like consciousness expands, and you experience astonishing things. Therein different way of attaining samadhi: you abide in a true logic trance, your

agreeing on the details when retelling it.

incapable of inventing such an unbelievable story and, what is more, of construction work and knew these workers well — simple people many times retold. But the narrator himself was in charge of that were only stories; in Benares there were millions of them, forgotten or Then he plunged into the water and did not appear again. The stories his waist and stood there a long time, as if performing a ritual ablution. emaciated. Having taken a few unsteady steps, he entered the river up to Naked but for a loincloth, he was tall and thin, but did not look the workers pulled the log in out of the pit and helped him to his feet. out of the lotus posture: "So this is what it has come to..." Some time later are no kings any more." With visible effort the log straightened his legs answered: "Baba, we have democracy, the government is in power, there One of the workers, who had not entirely lost the gift of speech,

cracked lips, the log uttered: "What year is it now? Who is ruling now?" Drawing a deep breath, almost in a whisper, with effort moving his ascetic's pressed dry lips blood emerged, his eyelids slowly parted. open the log's mouth with the end of a crowbar. From the corner of the him, but then one of the workers did the most foolish thing — tried to excavation. At first everyone was so terrified that they feared to touch earth, since the walls of his underground refuge had been damaged in the preserved, although the skin was ash-grey. The man was half buried in his body looked undamaged. Almost all the muscle-mass was well workers had found the body of a log. The man sat in the lotus posture, disciples related that during construction work near one of the gates known only by the accounts of witnesses. In 1982 one of the Curia's The authorities methodically registered such cases, but some stories are ascetic was dug up quite uninjured.

over, and over it a field was sown with wheat. After the harvest the alive. The site of his samadhi was covered with a stone slab and earthed months in samadhi underground and came out of the pit in which he sat Benares and documented by the British authorities. A log spent several

Once she came to him, asking for a blessing before

constant bliss of samadhi, but her words and actions were righteous.

her ashram, seeking blessings before elections. She did not experience the and sometimes predict the future. Therefore local politicians often visited her through the long trance. Childlike and innocent, Kam Gya could see techniques, but the spirit of her Master was always with her, sustaining. This saint had never practised the secret Khechari mudra or other yogic grey skin.

the animals, washing the corpses and dust from Kam Gya Sarkar's ash-proke, and the downpour began to pour over the streets, the people, and people who had come to see the miracle. A few minutes later the storm only by her own long matted hair, Kam Gya appeared before thousands of thunderstorm..." And so it came to pass. After a year, naked, covered not be frightened. On that day it will rain and there will be a her devotees: "I shall come out after a year, naked and dishevelled, but do authenticity of the seclusion. Before entering the cave, Kam Gya addressed lasting a whole year guarded her, ensured her safety, and confirmed the break, twenty-four hours a day, sang kirtans beside the cave. This concert underground without water, food, or sunlight, while the villagers without my Guru, Shankh Baba, was with me all that time." She remained When he asked about this experience, she quietly replied: "The spirit of there is a small cave where Kam Gya spent a year in the state of samadhi. She told her story. In the village of Tarot, beside the temple of Hanuman,

chewing. Kam Gya Sarkar's attitude toward him was just as respectful.

woman eats, she covers her face so that her father-in-law shall not see her touching his feet. In Indian villages there is still a custom: when a young was revered as a saint, Kam Gya prostrated herself before him, reverently him. When they first met, this woman was in her thirties. Although she of a yogin riding a white bull, and she demanded a personal meeting with of his acquaintances, Gula Kaant Sharma, showed Kam Gya a photograph Kam Gya Sarkar, who lived near Gwalior, not far from his old cottage. One ...Another case happened with a famous saint, a woman by the name of

wealth, those who lived for the gratification of their senses and desires, and widely used to honor those who had achieved high status and admiration that surrounded the ascetics of the past, were now borrowed connection to yoga. Samadhi, the brilliance of its mystery, and the aura of samadhi, here is the place of his samadhi." This was not the slightest politicians, public figures, and other respected people: "He entered radically. It began to be used as a respectful term applied to deceased ...In the twentieth century, the meaning of the word "samadhi" changed unharmed;

withstanding the most powerful currents of energy and return from samadhi. Perhaps this was the preserving, saving antidote that allowed him to given a little oil to drink, and he underwent a thorough purification. Mahasaya's diaries offered a clue: before entering the trance, Lahiri was impossible, and he knew this not from hearsay. However, Lahiri strong. Without preliminary preparation, enduring samadhi is practically body lives by its own laws; no metaphysics can turn the weak into the supporting them, but this would sound far too contrived. The physical course, assume that Baba's power extends to disciples, protecting and Lahiri's own diaries, nothing is mentioned about this. One could, of in a state of suspended animation without any serious consequences; in absolutely unprepared. Nevertheless, Lahiri Mahasaya spent seven days performed intense yoga practices – his nervous system and body were unclear how such a thing was even possible, if Lahiri had not previously seven days in a cave in a state of continuous intense samadhi. It was years later. Having first met Baba in Banikhet, Lahiri Mahasaya spent Yogananda in the Autobiography of a Yogi were revealed to him only many ...The hidden meanings of the well-known episode described by remained without a single role...

No socks can withstand a multi-kilometer walk, but Ram Gita's socks fear. She replied, "Oh, I will walk lightly, without touching the earth..." . remarked with a smile that after a 21-kilometer walk they would surely baktams. That day she was wearing thick woolen socks, and he

great was his desire to share. It seemed only the Guru believed him, but other disciples in the room, but he felt not the slightest awkwardness, so Benares, he told the Guru about what he had seen. There were several completely unsuitable for this. A couple of months later, during a visit to to share the impressions with someone. However, family members were faces and some animals, and all of this was so intriguing that he wanted palaces with domes and arches, an old pond and a large tree, unfamiliar appeared with varying degrees of detail, but with new aspects. He saw of disparate scenes from his future. All three times, the same frames bringing the scenery closer, and there was no doubt: this was a slideshow future. It seemed someone was holding a magnifying glass to his eyes, for about half an hour. That was enough to recognize the frames of the hallucinations, but the visions repeated, and each time the portal opened threw him into a time tunnel. Initially disoriented, he took it for a new issue of The Phantom comics when his consciousness switched and All three visions occurred around noon. He had barely turned the page of details and fragments could be discerned.

fragments of a bright kaleidoscope. The full panorama was hidden, yet vision came, and he viewed the set of still frames again: they resembled place must be somewhere near Vrindavan. A few days later, the next location remained a mystery: there was only some subtle hint that this trance he had undergone. He saw majestic palace buildings, but their there was no expansion of consciousness. Rather, it was a side effect of the future. Static, colorful images came independently of the state of samadhi: bodily experience, he saw what could be interpreted as a vision of the In November, about a month after the memorable night of the out-of-

Visions of the Future

cognition of Life.

spectacle, having passed through logic death in order to never cease the the continuity of existence. They contemplated the infinite existential He often thought of the Masters who stepped into immortality, choosing rather than separating themselves from them.

the person's chances, abilities, and predispositions before giving development for a particular person, the Teacher assessed the totality of future; his methods were more subtle. Seeing the best path of interfere with them, except in urgent cases. Nor did the Guru predict the human nature and the laws of karma well. Shri Satyacharan Lahiri did not generally the Guru never prescribed a specific lifestyle to anyone. Knowing abstinence. Besides, most of the students were married householders. In no one except him had the Teacher ever recommended adhering to. As for the vow of celibacy, he took these words as a direct instruction. To his own brain was beyond any fantasy.

result of yoga practice, the sacred symbol of the Absolute could appear in significance. After all, India is a land of wonders. But to imagine that as a the highest devotion – similar cases are known, and no one doubted their. Such was the consequence of diligently performed mantras practice and her skill; natural, finest grooves formed the letters in Sanskrit and Urdu. discovered that the divine name was "engraved" on the frontal bone of as a mantra all her life: "Ram, Ram, Ram...". After her cremation, it was. Yes, there was a story about a woman who sang the name of Lord Rama sign of Creation in his brain mean, and how could it be discovered there?.. metaphor. Perhaps it was a hint at supreme wisdom? What else could the allegory. The Teacher's words about the sign "Om" also sounded like a shamanism was completely impossible, and he took these words as an. He listened, not daring to ask for clarification, imagining life as a will form in your brain."

Yoga and maintain celibacy, then by the age of forty-four, the sign 'Om' gates. Some will come to you. And if you continue to diligently practice a place. Only it will be a shamanism, and many people will pass by its suddenly turned to him, saying: "Yes, you will live in a place resembling loved this procedure very much. During the massage, the Teacher to the Ganga for a bath, the disciples would massage the Guru's back; he present went up to the roof. There was a kind of custom – before reading no one dared to express skepticism or doubt. After darkness, everyone

was Mr. Sharma senior, who understood its significance. The respected spiritual path. The first person to whom he demonstrated Khechari mudra his father shared his interest in yoga, supporting his progress on the children on "the true path" and believed in his youngest son. In essence, atmosphere prevailed in the family. His father never tried to set any of the "achievers." Regarding the choice of profession, a more or less relaxed corporate, government, or military careers, parents did not try to raise the middle and upper classes did not push their children towards Times were different, parental expectations were not so high. Families of up to you...

of his decision not to begin a military career, his father did not object. "It's Mahendra and torn by contradictory uncertainty, he informed his parents necessary guidance. When, shaken by the death of his elder brother managed to give his children unconditional love, support, and the did everything possible for the family and, despite his demanding work, not openly tender, but loving and respectful. Himmat Bahadur Sharma ... The relationship between him and his father was always good, perhaps

Meeting on the Train

crossroads of collective destinies.

Karmic paths were solitary routes, though they passed through the busy

Gods bore responsibility for the choices they made.

Gun could only recommend and advise. And people, ghosts, and even actions performed in the past, influencing the present and future. The exactly, and yet the evolution of the soul depended on decisions and called "destinies." They never repeated the cycles of a previous life the patterns already manifested on His loom, and these ornaments were the subtle threads of karmas should not be entangled. Time itself changed the natural course of events even at the level of indirect predictions, and he used a similar approach. Interference in someone's destiny could affect After the Teacher's departure, he had to continue guiding students, and recommendations and hints.

“Judge Himmat Bahadur Sharma. Do you know him?”

“What was his name?”

I am. Everything I have achieved in life, I owe to him...”

“Oh, a judge lived there, a great man! He saved my life and made me who

“Returning home, to Cwalior.”

he was going.

take up too much space. While making his bed, the stranger asked where accepted the generous offer, sitting on the edge of the berth, trying not to

“Thank you for your kindness, I’m fine...”. The man insisted, and he you can sit here.”

the edge of their berth. Suddenly, an elderly man called out to him: “Don’t vestibule. There could be no question of asking strangers to let him sit on stood in the aisle with a small suitcase, preparing to spend the night in the yet every single berth was taken. Nevertheless, he boarded the train and counter, he was cheerfully assured: “No problem, we’ll find something!”, ticket without a prior reservation, but he was unlucky. At the ticket return to Cwalior by train. Having gone to the station, he hoped to buy a A year passed. He was visiting his elder sister in Lucknow and had to brother, and sisters.

concealed his own grief, trying not to aggravate the pain of his mother, age of 75, and this was a most severe blow to him. Feeling orphaned, he ...On September 10, 1984, Himmat Bahadur Sharma died of cancer at the

Buras. He devoured them all greedily.

family library contained many sacred texts of Hinduism and most of the The first book on yoga he read was his father’s Charama Samhita. The put a logic achievement.

complex and mystical mudra; he knew that Khechari was not some trick, judge himself had practiced asanas for many years and was aware of this

living in many ways. What remains after people pass through the gates of was watching over him, that he was under protection. Ancestors help the His heart filled with warmth, and for the first time he felt that someone "Thank you, sir, I am fine as I am. Please, rest. I will sit here, at your feet."

that the son of the respected judge lie down on the berth and sleep.

fellow traveler had magically become his benefactor. The old man insisted conductor throw the boy without a seat off the train. Instead, a chance man. Or with an indifferent man who might have demanded that the verdict back then, he might now be traveling with a bitter and broken the flickering lights racing past. If his father had not delivered a just ...He stood quietly by the window, watching the thickening darkness and

but also paved the way to success and prosperity.

fairness and support not only saved him from disgrace and bankruptcy moved to Jhansi, began again from scratch—and succeeded. The judge's Acquitted of all charges and armed with recommendations, this man ...could start their printing business anew in Jhansi."

in this city. I will give you a letter of recommendation so that you..."

corrupt and dangerous. They are unlikely to let you resume your business fighting a syndicate is difficult. The people who tried to frame you are hearing, the judge summoned him to his office: "We both understand that delivered a just verdict – the accused was found innocent. After the The judge was Mr. Sharma, who examined all aspects of the case and lose and end up in prison.

large bribe from the plaintiffs, and his case was hopeless; he would surely complex legal battle. It was said that the judge had most likely taken a Several years ago, he had been framed and became the accused in a

dabbing his tears with the sleeve of his kurta, the old man began to speak. completely unexpected. He waited until the man calmed down. Finally, The chance fellow traveler burst into uncontrollable sobs. This was

"He passed away last year... I am his youngest son."

of biological and astral beings were pores on the skin of Time; life seeped their bubbles enlivened the monotony of existence, and all the experiences consciousness. The expression of fleeting Time, emotions were precious; endless stream of impressions and emotions replenished the lake of to him a half-forgotten dream. Living each moment is important; and course, there were also important, fateful events, though the past seemed river and the river itself. Time flowed both through him and over him. Of life was at once both whole and porous, like a pebble at the bottom of a minutest details of every second of life, fully present within them.

being was composed. The awakened mind could concentrate on the lived each moment of the present totally, from which the wholeness of remains a bright flash. So it was, and surrounded by bright flashes, he destiny, and he answered without hesitation: every moment was and between them. Once someone asked about the life milestones in his own of every life, evenly distributing peaks and troughs of emotional surges the birth of a child, divorce or the death of loved ones mark the calendar achievements, or relocations. Disgrace or illness, joy, triumph, marriage or people measure the passage of time by promotions, professional As a rule, important life events are milestones on any person's path.

The Promise

in his humanity, judged anyone.

that, though a judge by profession, Himmat Bahadur Sharma had never uncompromising, unwavering honesty and innate moral ethics, and also the rhythm of the train's motion. Half-asleep, he thought of his father's flickering shadows danced on the walls of the compartment, following

...The old man slept, wrapped in a gray woolen shawl.

justice, compassion, and the significance of every action.

obliged to deliver his father's message to him—to remind him of honor, others. The incident on the train seemed staged, as if the old man was death? Only the memory of their deeds, the echoes of how they treated

this painfully, recalling the failed deal and broken promises with The uncle never spoke of compensating for the gold, and the father took guaranteed the transaction between brothers and sister.

relatives need not be repaid. But it was the father's word that had his financial standing, or perhaps because he believed that debts to uncle never fulfilled his obligation—perhaps because he never restored collapsed, and the aunt's gold sank into the river of time. The contractor The uncle's business failed; all projects and commercial schemes with whom one has no familial ties, the debt is almost certain to be repaid. creditor, large sums are never returned. If money is borrowed from those ...Over the years, it became clear that often, when a relative is the

over half a kilogram of gold.

prong of it. Under the guarantee of the father's word, the uncle received project. The jewelry was her dowry, a family heirloom, and she was very gold would be fully returned after the successful completion of the repayment. It was agreed that Sharada would be paid interest, and the brother. The father gave his word to his sister as a guarantee for the loan's day, their sister, Sharada Patrak, lent her gold jewelry to the contractor need of money; he urgently required funds to secure a new contract. That put urgent request. His father's brother was a contractor and constantly in until retirement, when one of his brothers approached him with a delicate His father was still working in Shivpuri, with only a couple of years left fulfilling the promise was beautiful, though a little sad...

such an experience of the importance of the act itself, but the moment of fulfilling a promise. One might speculate about the spiritual dimension of One of the strongest feelings he had ever experienced was the relief after turned out to be neither sweet nor sour.

harvest the fruits that had grown from them. Incidentally, those fruits feelings and emotions whose seeds had been sown many years ago—and Practice had smoothed over many memories, yet he could return to the from them like sweat.

of her right fingers was special...

by the house, blessing some visitors who stopped to bow to her, the touch
smashana. Frail and thin, in a fine cotton sari, the aunt would sit in the sun
adventures and escapades—invited her mother to live with them at the
younger cousin Devaputti, who had accompanied him on many
completely forgotten. When the aunt was widowed, her daughter—his
and it was hard to tell what exactly she remembered and what she had
...Over the years, her memory had turned into a handful of dry leaves,
a horror film.

moved into his magical palace, which more closely resembled the ruins of
But most importantly, she continued to believe in him when he finally
encouraged him during his temporary stay at an ashram in Vrindavan.
she took him in when he returned to Mathura from Sarathi, and
his character was not an easy one. Along with four cows and two dogs,
supported her nephew, providing shelter and giving love, even though
strange or insane. Together with her husband, she unconditionally
searching for his palace. She did not consider his dreams and plans
Sharda Bhatnag, his aunt, had always helped him. Especially when he was
reaffirmed to his father his intention to keep his word.

after year, during the ritual of remembrance for the departed, he mentally
The promise became a persistent reminder of unfinished business, year
obligations, does not remain in the lower realms.

considered very important, so that the spirit, burdened by unfulfilled
kilogram of gold to his aunt. Fulfilling the wishes of the dying is
treated for cancer, he gave him his word that he would return the half.
In 1984, while visiting his father in the hospital where he was being
problems related to ongoing financial difficulties.

Over the years, significant changes occurred in the family, mostly
sister to part with her dowry.
bitterness, blaming himself. It was his assurances that had convinced his

undertook—only these sounds were discernible in the night: breathing heavily, someone sneezed, the gravel crunched rhythmically swallowed by the darkness. The elderly man walking ahead was biter darkness not a single light was visible, as if they had been was a moonless, cool night: a strong wind blew at their backs, and in the bag, he followed the others and began walking along the railway tracks. It far, and everyone decided to head towards the city. Picking up his travel damaged, and repair work would take several hours. Lucknow was not for the delay. It turned out that the railway tracks ahead were badly five or six elderly people were questioning the conductor about the reason city: one by one, they disappeared into the deepening twilight. A group of began gathering their luggage and disembarking, intending to walk to the already dark when the train unexpectedly stopped. Some passengers ... While in Benares, he decided to visit his elder sister in Lucknow. It was

****Blessings on the Path. The Saint of Boiled Potatoes****

but every emotion has its time.”

In one of the poems he wrote in 1993, it was said: “Time has no emotions, future and nothing more.

returned to her: memories of the past had become fertilizer for the nascent last wish had been fulfilled, and Sharda Pathak's variables had been brought a feeling of lightness, and he treasured that feeling. His father's depart' gold was of no use to her—but a word was a word. Completion gesture was more symbolic, for in the place where the sun was soon to small, weighty bundle, she said quietly, “You are a very good boy...” The not quite herself, yet she understood the reason for his visit. Accepting the promised interest she had never received. The aunt was very weak and adding four gold bracelets of his own as a token of gratitude and the bedridden. That day, arriving in Mathura, he returned the gold to her, debt. There could be no more procrastination: the aunt was already for half a kilogram of gold, and there was no reason to delay repaying the His agricultural activities had brought him enough means to finally pay Thirty-two years had passed since the conversation with his dying father.

generously scattered all around.

somewhere nearby. He only needed to read the signs of destiny correctly, determined to find that place. Intuition told him: the palace was his memory since the very first vision in November 1982, and he was of a palace. The image of majestic structures had been clearly imprinted in ashrams, and half-ruined temples, but none of the places fit the category through Vrindavan, they came upon dilapidated estates, abandoned distraction from daily routine and ready for any adventure. Wandering only thing left was to find it. Intrigued, the cousin was glad for a to join the search for the palace that was soon to become his home. The ...Once, while visiting his aunt in Mathura again, he called on his cousin

words were indistinguishable, though they sounded soothing.

hours straight. He had no dreams, but he heard the Guru's voice: the three in the morning, he reached his sister's house, where he slept for ten approached, and within twenty minutes they were in the city. By about rode in silence, holding onto the steel handrails: the distant lights rapidly Climbing onto the open platform of the railcar, he and his companions

"Are you all from that train? Climb on, I'll give you a lift."

railway worker, called out to the driver: "How far to Lucknow?"

When a diesel railcar appeared, one man from the group, a former Teacher.

kind of stupor and could not utter a word. Mentally, he bowed to the the ground right where they stood. They thanked him, but he fell into a out on him. Exhausted by the sharp surge of adrenaline, people sank to moreover, the engine was running with its lights off. Cold sweat broke to the direction of the wind, no one had heard the approaching train: carriages thundered past, washing over them with a wave of hot air. Due They had barely taken seven or eight steps when a huge iron giant of immediately." He shouted, "Get off the tracks!" and everyone scattered. voice rang out in his head, loud and clear: "Get off the tracks Suddenly, a distant whistle of a steam engine sounded, and the Guru's

people who had attained the highest levels of realization amazed him. After enlightenment – carry water and chop wood...” The simplicity of the Buddhist saying: “Before enlightenment – chop wood and carry water. meeting turned out to be their last. The life of the old vendor embodied warmest of all the farewells in his life. She was well past eighty, and their And she offered 21 ruppes – the traditional offering to a Guru. It was the the woman who had seen Krishna Himself bowed and touched his feet. When he was leaving, she came to say goodbye and, to his great surprise, traditional tea and a boiled potato sprinkled with coarse salt...

visited her almost every day, and the woman always treated him to boil potatoes, and feed the hungry. Having moved to Vrindavan, he modestly, continuing to brew tea in a tiny roadside stall on a dusty verge, is rather selective in His contacts, the elderly woman lived extremely. Marked by the constant presence of the dark-blue God, who, as is known,

This brief dialogue would have baffled any witness, had there been any. did you manage...?” She playfully snarped her fingers: “Just like that...” meaning, the woman smiled at him. Bewildered, he could only ask: “How Realizing that he not only saw her radiant halo but also understood its

His shadow was discernible.

had seen Krishna Himself: in the radiance emanating from the vendor, sparkled and shimmered with neon light, and he realized that this woman woman's aura was impressive. An almost blinding halo above her head with the bright radiance of his own aura, but the spectrum of this elderly astral halos were clearly visible, and from time to time he experimented her aura was remarkably bright. He had already seen many saints whose from children.” Looking more closely at the elderly vendor, he saw that boiled potatoes with salt. He tried to pay. “Oh no! I don't take money. Inside the stall, they were immediately given a cup of sweet tea and if it will stop right here.”

come inside, or you'll get scorched. When the bus comes, you won't miss unrepeatable: an elderly woman peered out from a small tea stall: “Boys, ...That day, they were waiting for a bus to Mathura. The heat was

cocktails, they stretched out the pleasure: tomorrow was unknown, the tubees per glass, and 10 of the 12 tubees were spent. Slowly sipping their A rusty scooter sped them to the market, and they ordered two drinks, 2 desperately craved a fresh mango cocktail.

that tomorrow they would sit by the roadside and beg, but today they even humiliated. The financial future looked rather bleak, and they joked dwindled to 12 tubees, but asking his uncle for money was improper and much that within a month they had spent all their money. Their budget kettlebells and barbells. The intense exercise stoked their appetites so A cousin arrived from Mathura, and they trained for hours, lifting a career or family obligations.

so, devoting himself exclusively to yoga, without burdening himself with everything went smoothly. Officially unemployed, he intended to remain matters. His uncle never inquired about the strange influx of visitors, and him daily, for he was a Guru and could give advice on many practical uncle, who lived in a government-allocated house. There, people visited in the absence of his brother Cyanendra, he stayed with his maternal

The Taste of a Mango Drink and the Subtle Art of Begging

characters.

ability to bestow spiritual gifts belonged to the most unremarkable His path continued to be marked by unexpected encounters, and often the

need money, take it!" He smiled: "Matiji, your blessing is enough."

woman immediately pulled out a one-hundred-rupee note: "Son, if you you money, but I have just enough for the fare to Mathura." The beggar approached, asking for money. He said regretfully, "Mother, I would give waiting again for the bus to Mathura, when an elderly beggar woman small episode always brought a smile. He was in Vrindavan again, them to tea, he encountered another woman, and the memory of this Around the same time that the saint of the Boiled Potato was treating more than the spiritual heights they had reached.

There were plenty of other gurus, charismatic and skilled orators, many of whose grace was not for sale.

Person or someone clearly trying to buy his blessing, he refused. True decline offerings. Sometimes, if the gift was offered by an unworthy sum of money if they could afford it. He reserved the right to accept or the Guru was a tradition – visitors brought clothes and food, shared small for the state of peace and tranquillity they felt in his presence. Caring for for the inexhaustible but tangible healing energy that emanated from him began. People thanked him for support, an encouraging word, guidance, someone was trying to offer him money for advice. That was how it all my appreciation; it would be a great honor for me...“ For the first time, am immensely grateful. Please accept three hundred rupees as a token of help this family. Bowing, the grateful father said, “You helped my son, I situation a few months earlier. Somewhere, he, the Guru, had managed to The next day, a visitor arrived whose son had been in an unpleasing were singing songs, and their mood was excellent.

and they had to push the scooter the last two hundred meters. Yet they With empty pockets, they headed home. On the way, the petrol ran out, street, the balloons floating above him marking his triumphant dash.

hardly believing his luck, clutched the coins in his hand and ran down the instantly ceasing his sob, the boy stared at them in disbelief, and then same thought. He took out the last five rupees and gave them to the boy. He and his cousin exchanged glances; it turned out they both had the the robe for dinner and medicine was lost...

mother, but had somehow managed to lose the money. With the money, day and was going to buy flour for flatbreads, lentils, and medicine for his happened;“ It turned out that he had earned five rupees for the whole desperately, wiping his tears with his sleeve. “Little brother, what Holding a stick with balloons tied to it, the little vendor was crying. Enjoying the last gifts, they noticed a sobbing boy, no older than eleven. mango season was almost over, and they had no urgent business.

They made inquiries, and an astonishing story came to light: it turned out
Balm did not leave his mind, and he asked friends to find this person.
Even after this fleeting encounter, the unusual fate line on the old man's
full ten thousand if he had phrased his request differently...

amount was immediately given to him. He could have become richer by a
him away. Hesitating, the old man asked for five rupees, and the specified
sudden turn of events, for usually people tried to avoid him and shooed
"How much money do you need?" The beggar was stunned by the
wallet held nearly ten thousand rupees.

the beggar all the money he had if the man asked for it. That day, his
principles of altruism. Opening an impulse, he decided he would give
however, he could not be an ordinary beggar: it contradicted the
the not-so-clean Balm of the beggar intrigued him. A man with such a
tempting hand to him, asking for alms. An unusually strong fate line on
One day at the station, an old, dirty beggar stretched out a weak,

condemned.

was no simple matter, and the results could lead to unexpected
beggar should not be choosy..." But was that really so? The art of begging
goals, and results of any action. He had always liked the saying, "A
...Delving deeper into causes and effects, one could discern the motives,

many times over by the prism of quickly drying tears in a child's eyes.

man's drink reminded him of the light of hope and happiness, multiplied
He never met the little balloon seller again, but sometimes the taste of the
karma and follow it.

over the years, he simply tried to see the logic in the chain reactions of
support. Having never acquired the habit of keeping a tally of good deeds
simply tried to help people: life is difficult enough, and everyone needs
freely, for it was impossible to put a price tag on it. In most cases, he
well aware of this. Having received the priceless gift of yoga, he shared it
"Kriya Yoga" had long become a commercial commodity, and he was
whom turned out to be calculating spiritual charlatans. The very phrase

room with a trainee from Ceylon. On the trainee's bedside table stood a remote villages for surveys. During one such trip, Mr. Sharma shared a teams of specialists worked on development projects, often traveling to training program for civil engineers, and mixed Indian and Sri Lankan irrigation department of Benares. The city was actively promoting a In 1968, this relative, Mr. Sharma, worked as a senior engineer in the Gahiri in Benares.

When a relative casually mentioned a meeting with Shri Satyacharan Chawlior... This astonishing fact came to light in 2016, quite by chance, lineage long before receiving the letter signed "Shailendra Sharma". It turned out that the Teacher knew of the existence of the successor to the

The Successor

transparent cellophane of chance.

themselves were willing to share. Fate keeps generous gifts in the semi- of asking for specific benefits, it was wiser to ask the Gods for what they The universal laws of the Universe worked on a similar principle: instead expectations to a limit of five rubees.

peggars could have said, "Give as much as you can," but he limited his guarantees a predetermined meagerness of fate's gifts. The king of limitations on the results of wish fulfillment: a lack of imagination often their expectations in words. It is precisely these formulations that impose As a rule, when asking for specific things, people describe the results of encounter made him think about the self-imposed limitations people set. strength of his character, his luck, leadership, and wealth... This curious profitable business, and the powerful fate line correctly indicated the at their posts and collecting enough money. The old swindler had a conducting a weekly inspection, checking whether his subordinates were station, begging for alms, the old fox was pretending. In reality, he was Everyone paid him a tax for the spots they were allotted. That day at the authority, and without his blessing, none of his "subjects" could marry. clan of peggars. A stern ruler, a ruthless tax collector, he commanded the old man was not an ordinary peggar at all, but the leader of a large

his Kriyabara – one who has received initiation into the practice of Kriya the Void.

with his own spirit, a being that announced its presence in the darkness of was revealed to him, and he was able to establish a friendly relationship brought the most fascinating discoveries. The essence of human hearts five years under the Guru's guidance flew by quickly; diligent practice convinced that this was the actual state of affairs.

All this might have seemed merely a hypothesis, but over time he became both the time of departure of each guru.

parampara always knew both about the next successor and about the expected. This story confirmed the suspicion that the Teachers of the kriyabara¹¹⁵. As it turned out, his coming had been predicted and time he was greatly embarrassed by the close attention of the old Teacher had told them of the arrival of a potential successor, but at the disciples looked at him. Perhaps it was explained by the fact that the visiting the Guru's house, the intense curiosity with which the elderly years remained until their meeting. He recalled his first impressions of sixty years old, and his future spiritual successor was only eleven; eleven hinted that he had known of him earlier. In 1968, the Guru was about This casually told story shocked him: the Guru himself had never once after me."

young man is preparing for this mission in Cwalior... He will continue physically strong, excellently educated, and intellectually developed asked the Guru about the successor. Shri Satyacharan Lahiri replied: "A context of discussing the future of this spiritual tradition, Mr. Sharma They visited him several times, and during one of these visits, in the Satyacharan Lahiri, the fourth Guru and grandson of Lahiri Mahasaya. "Satya Lok," the Teacher's old house on Chausatti Street, and met Shri him find the address of Lahiri Mahasaya in Benares. Thus they came to of visiting the home of the famous teacher and asked Mr. Sharma to help guru, then distributed the offering to his colleagues. This trainee dreamed photograph of Lahiri Mahasaya, and he regularly offered prasada to the

prepared him for the role of successor to the tradition. An undeniable kept Satyacharan with him, and for many years, until his own passing of Yogiraj Lahiri Mahasaya. When the older children left the nest, Tinkori youngest son of Tinkori Lahiri Mahasaya, the third Guru and eldest son famous grandfather had lived, taught, and practiced. Satyacharan was the dark half of Ashrami Tirth, in Kasbi, in that very house where his generation of the dynasty. He was born on January 28, 1902, during the The fourth Guru, Sri Satyacharan Lahiri, represented the third generations of male ancestors...

according to Hindu tradition, the last rites are performed only for three generations. This was confirmed by an indirect, though well-known, fact: might of Krishna itself could be preserved in one family for only three Lahiri continued the tradition, but the power of Babaji's blessing and the mystical teaching, proved to be extraordinary. The son and grandson of a humble householder. Yet the life of Lahiri Mahasaya, illumined by the Babaji chose for his first disciple to become known to the world the life of but he was here to continue, to learn.

with nostalgia, even the greatest spiritual achievements became the past, great honor. The words, written nearly a century ago, were permeated least through the yellowed pages, to see the Master's handwriting, was a staggering. No one had described spiritual experiences so profoundly. The priceless revelations described by Lahiri Mahasaya in his diaries were and attained realization, and their presence was constant and powerful. Here, in this old house, four generations of masters had meditated inhaling the legends and history together with the strangely dry, odorless Lahiri Mahasaya, sometimes he even practiced in the Master's room. ...In the Guru's house, students were permitted to read the diaries of bookish knowledge, he realized it with his entire being.

Whoever lived within him was omnipresent, and this discovery was not no time for reflection on the nature and location of the so-called God, the golden light of Kutasra. The spectacle was so captivating that it left Yogs.

Teacher had done.

indefinitely. All he could do was inspire, observe, and wait. As his prevailed over yoga, and the student might cease sadhana, temporarily or practitioner himself could spiral out of control. In such cases, karma interrupted by life circumstances; in rare cases, the inner demons of the progress but also for their failures. Sometimes regular practice could be use the same methods, for he bore responsibility not only for the students. Having become the successor after the Teacher's passing, he continued to literal sense.

personal dosage of knowledge; otherwise, they could choke on it in the individual karmic predispositions also varied. Each student required a yoga for different reasons, with different goals and motives; their individual level of development and preparation. People came to Krishna exactly as much knowledge as the seeker was ready to absorb at his observing each seeker. In accordance with tradition, the Guru gave knew the delicacy of the process of knowing, and he taught carefully burden of knowledge did not weigh upon Satyacharan Lahiri himself, he among the elderly students, he was a true spiritual giant. Although the mainly by disciples and visitors. Often silent, not standing out much children started their own families, and the Teacher was surrounded widowed early. Shri Satyacharan Lahiri did not remark; his adult was very democratic and seemed open and approachable. Having been finding common ground with the Guru was not always easy, although he everyone among the "awakened" attempts to attain realization."

The Guru replied succinctly: "Because only a few wish to awaken, and not among those seeking enlightenment are there so few who are realized; part of their lives "asleep" and do not even wish to "wake up," why ... One day he asked the Teacher: why do most people spend the greater realm of spirit.

Teacher and spiritual father to many. But above all, he was a guide to the master of yoga, Shri Satyacharan Lahiri was a man of knowledge, a

his departure: it was to occur six months later, on his eighty-second birthday. As a consolation, the Teacher was told the exact date and time of death. Seeing him cry was difficult, and no one guessed the reasons for his grief were denied, and he came out into the courtyard, sobbing like a child. Shri Satyacharan Lahiri stayed only a short while; his request to or perhaps other higher forces, deemed otherwise. In the courtyard early mission complete. However, the other Teachers of the Parampara day the Guru was determined to leave his body, as he considered his of the Bhagavad Gita and left the room. Later they learned that on that asked him, along with several other disciples, to read the eighth chapter festive, though no one could name the reason. At one point, the Teacher bang of nostalgia. To tell the truth, the atmosphere that day was not at all traditional namaste gesture. Watching these times years later, he felt a Guru and those present, he concluded his short speech with the he spoke with restraint but confidence. Having respectfully addressed the shrouded, in a simple white kurta, with jet-black, closely cropped hair, and clearly far away, and him standing beside the Teacher. Broadcast the Guru half-reclining in an armchair, absorbed in his thoughts. The uneven, jolting black-and-white footage of a documentary film

culmination of the evening, and those gathered applauded with relief. receive the darsan of the immortal spirit." These words became the main point—practice to the utmost of your ability and attain Kustha, previous speaker has already said everything. I wish to emphasize the disheartened, expecting another long speech, but he was brief: "The new Guru to deliver the concluding speech. Most of those present were long presentation of the book, Shri Satyacharan Lahiri called upon the numerous quotations from the Master's personal diaries. After the hour, Lahiri Mahasaya compiled at the Guru's request and containing one of the old disciples, presented his book *Puram Puram*, a biography of courtyard could not accommodate the guests. Ashok Kumar Chatterjee, was celebrated in the home of Shri Satyacharan Lahiri, and the small inner In the summer of 1980, Guru Purima¹¹⁴, the day of honoring all teachers,

The Teacher's Passing

symbolism in such signs could interpret the event as they wished. In any crack ran across its surface; it was repaired, and those inclined to seek had stood there when Lahiri Mahasaya bought the house. Now a long Sundareswar, the Shivalingam was over two hundred years old and with a mirror-like surface, adorned with the memorial inscription "Shyam the inner temple of Shiva developed a crack. Made of black kasho stone ... A couple of weeks after the Guru's death, the tall black Shivalingam in therefore their bodies were interred.

Both Shri Yukteshwar and Yogananda Paramahansa were monks, and not recluses, and they were cremated; in India, only samnyasis are buried. Gurus of the Parampara were great logis, they were still householders, Lahiri no longer had any karmic obligations. Although all four previous and few in number. This meant that on the earthly plane, Satyacharan remnants were collected from the ashes of the funeral pyre; they were tiny Lahiri, was cremated at Manikarnika Ghat. According to custom, the bone The fourth Guru of the Kriya Yoga lineage of Babaji, Shri Satyacharan cremation. After two days, there were still no signs of decomposition.

relatives were absent, and the body was placed on ice to preserve it until minutes before Satyacharan Lahiri abandoned his body. The Guru's after the household, and another person who had entered only a few astral plane. Two people were with him: his Bengali disciple, who looked Kriya_{IT2}, the supreme logic technique for transferring the spirit to the in full consciousness until the very last moment and performing Omkar with the prediction, the Guru left his body on January 25, 1987, remaining myself." This was the last time he saw the Teacher alive. In accordance with your progress, continue. I have taught you everything I knew and the Guru placed his hand on his head, saying, "I am very pleased Their last meeting was touching: he prostrated himself at the Guru's feet, satangs and darsanas.

Teacher's mind remained clear and sharp, and he continued to conduct had to be carried upstairs; he could no longer move on his own. Yet the birthday. In the following months, the Guru weakened so much that he

Chuchura belonged to the relatives of his aunt's husband. This was where he was on family business. An ancient Kali temple in the town of The news of the Guru's death reached him in Bengal, near Calcutta,

“Om” and Other Signs

him, there were no such people. All of this was extremely disheartening. discussed with advanced practitioners, but among the yogis known to techniques now? At the level he had reached, higher yoga could only be out many important aspects of Kriya... Who will teach me these advance to the next levels of Kriya robbed him of hope. “I never found 14-16 hours. Yet the apathy was almost paralyzing; the inability to Practice helped him cope with the loss, and he continued his sadhana for have attained the heights of spiritual development.

travel further and visit the myriad other worlds intended for those who return to this world; he had fulfilled his mission. Now the Teacher could was extremely unlikely: Shri Satyacharan Lahiri was not destined to sometimes people asked whether the Guru could take a new birth. This unnecessary questions.

Even during the Guru's lifetime, he had stopped troubling him with analysis, an investigation of the very root of the problem, was required, surfacing upon request or responding to specific situations. Only careful would reveal itself anew. Answers and hints were now stored in memory, to him during his years of discipleship, and the essence of phenomena received it. At times it was enough to recall what the Guru had explained Guru did not abandon him; when the Teacher's advice was needed, he was to leave his body in six months was known in advance. And yet the excessively: the Guru's passing was expected. The fact that the Teacher Without the teacher's support it was difficult, but he did not grieve schedule.

Baraji himself; their appearance and departure occurred according to and purpose of all the Teachers of the parampara were predetermined by case, the Fourth Guru had departed, yet the lineage continued. The fate

visitors, they listened attentively, examining him with curiosity, but their dressed in identical short-sleeved shirts and dhotis. Like the other come and stand near the doors. All five were of the same height, fit, and ...A few days later he noticed a group of five bearded men who would families.

spiritual practices and were absorbed in practical matters, careers, and adult children of Shri Satyacharan Lahiri had little interest in their fathers the previous teachers, and this too surprised, though it did not shock. The the Masters before him had been Bengalis. He was not related by blood to He was from the north, which came as a surprise to many, since all four of with sincere devotion.

see him in the flesh. A sharp, poorly concealed curiosity was seasoned without the Master. People came to pay their respects to the new Guru, to gathered for darsshan, and for the first time he received them alone, visit turned out to be rather exhausting: every day around 120-200 people ...the timing of the introductions could not have been more fitting. The successor, and the time for the official

back to Bengal. The community of Kriya yogis there was eager to see the final rites were performed. One of the disciples invited him to Varanasi, the twelfth day after the Teacher's cremation. On the thirteenth day, the ...All train tickets were booked, and he managed to reach Benares only on

passing of Shri Satyacharan Lahiri arrived twenty days after this event. shoulder. This made him a prashnin officially. The telegram about the finally underwent the Janen ritual, putting the "Sacred Thread" over his more than ten thousand people had gathered for the celebration, he in the temple every evening. On the day of the temple's founding, when distribution of finances. It was not so bad; he even managed to meditate affairs. Together with his cousin, he organized the daily puja and the after the temple for a year. Their turn had come to manage the temple ten years, the numerous clan appointed someone from the family to look Goddess, and therefore she was called the Merciful Mother there. Every perhaps the only place in India where animals were never sacrificed to the

dwell on the meaning of the sacred symbol upon his soles.

unwinding many threads of different events at once, leaving no time to
Though the discovered glyphs intrigued him, the spindle of life kept
filled with other, no less astonishing surprises and domestic problems.
coffee table as a kind of curiosity. Life ran its course. Daily existence was
The disciples took photographs, and for a time the colour prints lay on his

"OM" was "drawn" in the Bengali alphabet.

marks. The glyphs on his right foot were in Sanskrit, while on the left the
astonishment: the capillaries beneath the skin clearly traced tiny "OM"
present immediately offered to examine his feet — and froze in
Back in Calcutta, he mentioned the incident during darsan. One of those
Asking for blessings, they took their leave, and he never saw them again.
many yogins before we met you. And for all of us this is a great day."
He did not know how to react. One of the group said: "We have seen
would be finished.

the soles of his feet, and after that meeting their spiritual work in this life
many years later they would meet a young yogin with the sign "OM" on
body at the age of nineteen. Before his death, that guru had told them that
striking story. Once they had been followers of a guru who had left his
"Please, tell me what you saw there?" — and they recounted a deeply
before him.

attention of some strange fetishist sect. Then all five prostrated themselves
intrigued, he waited patiently, hoping he had not become the object of
in turn began excitedly examining the discovery through the same lens.
exclaimed in Bengali: "Achi! It is there!" Drawing nearer, his companions
intently at one sole, then the other, then turned to his companions and
magnifying glass and began the inspection. For almost a minute he stared
Puzzled by the unexpected request, he agreed. The man produced a large
permission to see the soles of his feet.

present. On the sixth day one of them approached and politely asked
manner and gestures were subtly different from those of the others

ego and self-esteem.

only lowers the quality of spiritual practice but also negatively affects the organisations requires enormous effort and a rigid timetable, which not trademark of the Gauri name. The Guru said that running such secure his blessing to teach Kriya practices and philosophy under the overtures of numerous "followers and founders" of groups who wished to warned his disciples against creating any organisations, rejecting the merely a profitable business. Even Shri Satyacharan Gauri himself authority or right to be spiritual guides. For such "masters" yoga was of their followers, promising salvation and liberation while having no too many false Gurus claim false logic attainments. They break the lives the real intentions of some self-proclaimed "teachers", he often said that Gauri was acutely aware of the trends in the logic "markets", and seeing line, along with documentary proof of one's own attainments. Banamali advised establishing clear criteria for the Kriya practice required in this Banamali Gauri. Professor B. Gauri, himself an advanced yogi, had The original idea belonged to a great-grandson of Gauri Mahasaya, by him.

Khechari mudra is in fact attainable and had been performed personally mudra. The investigation was intended to document the fact that he underwent an MRI procedure while holding his tongue in Khechari with his disciple Dr. Dwivedi from Agra. At Dr. Gupta's institute in Agra Before his 45th birthday, he discussed an (almost scientific) experiment

Guru: "After your 45th birthday, the sign 'OM' will form in your brain."

Reflecting on this phenomenon, he suddenly recalled the words of the intervals between initiations were long, the pigmentation would fade. every new disciple the mark on the nail became more distinct. If the potential chakras by touching their spine with this finger — and with "OM". When giving initiation he would usually "switch on" the disciple's emerged on the nail of the index finger of his right hand, forming the sign ceased trying to disguise its intentions, small whitish curving lines Ten years later, after many adventures and trials, when destiny had

consequences yet to bear fruit in the future do not affect Him ||२४|| In distinct from others: afflictions, actions, the fruits of action and karmic [footnote] Yoga Sūtras, Samādhipāda, śloka २८: "The Lord is Puruṣa, performing a new score in an infinite symphony conducted by Time itself, melody. The logic body was a perfect instrument, with each new life the flesh of the world was a myriad of notes of this eternal, primordial. The power of the sound itself filled every cell of every living body, and all the sign OM..."

obsessions, and attachments is called a special Puruṣa and is marked by "Samādhi Pāda". The commentary read: "He who stands beyond karma, one of the foundational texts of classical yoga philosophy." in the chapter apparatus. The modern yoga tradition considers Patañjali's Yoga Sūtras recognition of witness-consciousness as distinct from the cognitive culminate in samādhi. The principal aim of the practice is kaivalya, the Sūtras speak of aṣṭāṅga, the eight elements of practice that should synthesised and systematised knowledge on the subject of yoga. The Yoga on yoga. There are 192 sūtras compiled by the sage Patañjali, who Yoga Sūtras of Patañjali — a collection of Sanskrit aphorisms (or sūtras) relevant reference was found in Patañjali's Yoga Sūtras [footnote 116: The It was impossible to explain all this from the standpoint of logic; the only could brand a person with his own mark.

nails, and then in his brain, spoke of the grace of Śhiva, for only Mahadev name of Śhiva. The symbols that had appeared naturally on his soles and interpretations of the universal sign "OM", but above all it designates the the fact that his progress was being confirmed. There are many gratitude — for the Master's faith in him, for the miracle of yoga, and for Lahiri's prediction had come true, and he felt enormous satisfaction and function. For him personally the scan was confirmation that Satyacharan gylph, though for the doctors it was simply a sign of normal frontal-lobe. The contrast shadows outlined the precise curves of the Devanagari distinguish a sign "OM" formed above the region of the pituitary gland. ...The MRI results surprised everyone: on the images one could clearly

Kumbh Mela. Thousands of sadhus, religious leaders, and their devotees, saints and their followers, is one of the most important days of the water in worship, used to bathe the deity.] (Kalyogi Shan), the bath of the The Shani Shan [footnote 118: Shan — the ritual of bathing or offering of astonishing.

such a vast assembly of believers, to be part of this event, was truly confluence of the Ganga and the Yamuna for the ritual bath. To witness nothing could compare with the ocean of pilgrims arriving at the Mela in search of the right camp. He had seen great crowds before, but then, then walked for more than six hours across the vast territory of the daylight. Accompanied by two other disciples, he arrived in Allahabad by sadhana that transformed the darkness of night into the brightest monotony of his event-hood life, whose only adornment was the night advantage of this opportunity. He was ready for a distraction from the accommodation in one of the camp stations, and it was decided to take disciple, Dattka Prasad Shastri, had promised to find sleeping places and was flooded with nearly 12 million pilgrims. Acquaintances of his On the occasion of the Maha Kumbh Mela in February 1988, Allahabad

Kumbh Mela and the Sent of Karma

shrisailendrasharma.com/khechari

MBI of Shailendra Sharma performing Khechari — <https://>

AUM || 27 ||

found by Time || 28 || The word by which He is called is Pranava — conception of Brahman.] is the Guru even of the first (gurus), for He is not Vedanta hold that the "personal" Ishvara is a limited and inadequate and Brahman. Some assert that they are identical. Adherents of Advaita communities differ in how they interpret the relationship between Ishvara "Bhagavan" ("Lord") is generally used by followers of Vishnu. Hindu name is preferred mainly by devotees of Shiva; the analogous term personal, chosen deity, or the principle of supreme consciousness. The [footnote 117: Ishvara — in the various schools of Hinduism may signify a Him is the seed of all-knowing, unsurpassed || 29 || This Ishvar

consciousness. The samskaras then await the volitional fulfillment of a leaves an impression, an effect, an imprint, or a samskara, in are the basis for the development of karma. Every action or intention basis of karmic impulses and tendencies. In Hindu philosophy, samskaras — mental imprints, unconscious and residual memories that form the fruit burst open, spilling the seeds of samskaras [footnote 11]: Samskaras next transformation. At the moment of death the end of the over-ripe beginning their slow transformation into corpses, the preparation for the ...the Kumbh Mela, spirits were entering the capsules of embryos already here, at...

magic of yoga allowed him to see the endless train of incarnations: even scorching fragility of fleeting life, was maddening, intoxicating. The whole existential cocktail of the rich elixir of eternity, mingled with the by millions of bare feet into the finely milled flour of destinies — and this scents of incense and food, inhaled the pungent fragrance of dust ground waters of the Ganga and the human mass on the riverbanks, smelled the endowed him with extraordinary perceptiveness. He watched the slow ...The extreme sensitivity that had developed in the course of sadhana had the shores of human bodies.

them, and its echo would now recede like the surf, now sweep back upon living were descendants of this Universal vibration: the sound pierced from the seed of myriad fathers and the eggs of countless mothers, all the That sound had begotten all beings, all inanimate objects and forms. Born unborn sound "Om" that covered the valley.

cacophony of life's celebration issued from a vast invisible dome of the sound of mantras and the melodies of bhajans shook the air, and this procession to deafening music. The roar of trumpets, the whistles, the howdahs, while marching squadrons of naked, grey-shaven ascetics led the mahants of various ascetic orders towered over the crowds in their lofty elephants, showered by the sun-bright rain of marigold petals, the and men. Swaying on the backs of slowly moving, lavishly decked moved toward the river, on foot and on chariots drawn by camels, horses,

intelligible to spirits and gods. And the "mental scent" was a marker, and the bitter-sweet smoke of burnt offerings was an ancient code tracked their "wards," exclusively by scent. The aroma of temple incense — who analysed human karmas and judged people by their deeds, beings, servants of the God of death, Lord Yama.] and other astral beings of the Lord of Death — the Yamadutas [footnote 150: Yamadutas — astral. Picking up various mental waves, he began to suspect that the messengers the ritual path.

and the new impressions, his thoughts kept returning to the meaning of they revelled in the atmosphere of the festival, yet, despite his occupation bungalow. By the standards of the Mela this was luxury. For two days including free lodging in a personal tent that more closely resembled a swamiji was overjoyed to see him. He was given a genuine VIP reception, Guru's instruction. The sadhu escorted them to the proper place, and the ago, in Benares, he had personally initiated that swamiji into Kritya on the organised by a swami whose name was well known to him. Some time with one of them. It transpired that this sadhu was staying at the camp the pilgrims began returning from the river, and he fell into conversation became a real ordeal, but once dry he felt magnificent. Toward evening suspicious for that rite. The water turned out to be icy, and bathing they hurried to the river to make the bath in time: the day was the most ...At last they found the right camp, and after a brief flurry of settling in

in the material world, spiritual progress depended only on motive.

body. Tamed and pacified, they could turn the prison into a palace. Here, if not pass) prolonged the duration of the prisoner's stay in the cell of the labyrinth of fates. The intensity of urges and longings (often pedestrian, Time, and human desires were wandering echoes through the rooms and fragrance of the soul, of consciousness. All these bodies were sentences of attachments — and the draft of Time caught up and carried away the habits, or innate predispositions,] unfulfilled desires, sorrows and tendencies, karmic impulses, subconscious impressions, the makings of or a subconscious sense of necessity to act. Samaskaras manifest as particular individual in the future as hidden expectations, circumstances,

consciousness and, accordingly, on the events of one's coming life. Of reason the Kumbh Mela bath exerted a powerful influence on human ancient, divine, and power-laden memories of the Ganga herself. For this sacred river at the molecular level, since the person was immersed in the meant also to mix the inner liquids of the body with the waters of the experiences and thoughts. To bathe in the Ganga at an auspicious time fluid is passed on water, and water preserves the memory of previous karmas and odours pleasant or otherwise, is seventy percent fluid. Any chemical reaction occurs. It is known that any physical body, with all its human sweat mingles with the waters of the sacred rivers, a peculiar bitcher of the Kumbh Mela, one can confuse the karmic tracks. When surveillance. By having "washed" both good and bad deeds in the gigantic the righteous. For a time they lose the trail, and then men are free of their messengers of the Lord of Dharma can no longer distinguish sinners from fragrances, thereby throwing the astral pursuers off the scent. And the individual aroma mix with the trails of thousands of other karmic of one's personal karma, deeds, and thoughts. The molecules of one's river together with millions of other pilgrims, one can wash off the smell alignment, and the stars amplify the effect of the bath. By entering the During the Kumbh Mela the constellations stand in a particular disciplines by it.

of the early monsoon. Sometimes the teachers had to track down errant metallic rust; purity and piety were marked by the warm, soothing scent and sour; murderers of men gave off a peculiar stench, like the smell of the human being. Those who took the lives of animals smelled pungent actions. The unmistakable karmic fragrance became a personalised tag of or fate — created a unique scent that accompanied particular karmic reaction in the body. Every thought and emotion — be it anger, lust, love, them were begotten by the mind, evoking a corresponding chemical souls. Whatever acts were committed, whatever thoughts arose, all of book of every fate was read by those responsible for the upbringing of and future acts and intentions — formed an enormous library, and the tag, from which one could not be rid. All human karmas — past, present,

been reserved for him at the Kashi Mummuksha Ashram, where at noon a danger. With that the official part of the trip was finished. A room had with the dean, satisfying himself that the disciple's career was in no train. On arrival in Kashi he went directly to the University and spoke visit Benares again, and in the last week of March 1988 he boarded the persuading him to put in a word with the dean. It was a fine pretext to Hindu University of Benares, ran into trouble at work and turned to him. One of the Guru's disciples, who worked as a yoga instructor at the Barahi

life irrevocably.

trip marked a new beginning. So it proved: the coming April changed his The Kumbh Mela left an indelible impression: intuitively he knew that the to Chwalior.

arranged a comfortable car to Chitrakut, from where they boarded a train crowds of departing pilgrims. Fortunately, their hospitable host kindly problem, since the railway stations and bus stops were still backed with ...The time came to set off back, and the return threatened to become a real seemed to be potential seductresses.

were deep in their sixties, but to the defender of his morality they still released him. He glanced at the matrons shivering in their wet saris: they the danger of seduction!" At last, some five minutes later, Shastri ji your hands away only when the ladies are fully dressed and I am out of purity. Please continue to watch them while keeping my eyes shut. Take laughter, he said: "Shastri ji, I am so grateful that you care about my several Punjab women have stripped to the waist!" Holding back "What's the matter, Shastri ji?" — "Please, do not look that way, Guruji — who had caught up with him, suddenly clapped his hands over his eyes. He was already coming out onto the bank when Dvarka Prasad Shastri, ...After the fifth immersion the water no longer felt scalding cold to him.

plausible one.

course, this theory of karmic scents was only a hypothesis, though a quite

describing a difficult technique (the passage of the „knot of Rudra“) important details of the higher Kriya techniques. At one moment that night the Master spoke only of yoga, explaining some very spoke, and he listened, trying to absorb every word.

resonant timbre echoed off the walls, piercing the heart. Only the Guru filled the room, as though they were inside a huge bronze dome, and he began to speak — softly, gently, yet seriously. The deep sound of his voice and tried to master his emotions. He did not succeed very well. Baraji, piercing. Stunned by what was happening, he lowered himself to the floor reflect a lifetime of experience, and Baraji's eyes were ancient and manner. Now he could see the visitor's face more clearly. The eyes usually the platform-bed and crossed one leg over the other in a rather relaxed Guru, not daring to touch them. Entering the room, Baraji sat down on the night guest. Nervous, almost frightened, he bowed at the feet of the the one known to you as Baraji, — and he saw at once the radiant aura of Not trying to hide his irritation, he asked: „What do you want?“ — „I am

light, he was clean-shaven. The visitor appeared to be about thirty or so, not fair, but had a slight golden tint perceptible even in the uneven, faint sleeved shirt and a dhoti in the Bengali style; his skin was neither dark and muscular build but not at all heavily, wore a cream-coloured short-cm tall, a couple of centimetres taller than himself. The stranger, of solid door. The broad-shouldered man standing on the threshold was about 170 switch clicked, and a dim lamp lit up beneath the ceiling. He opened the that hour outside visitors simply could not get into the building. The around two in the morning; the main gates were already locked, and at platform-bed, assuming it was one of the ashram's residents. It was at first hear the knock at the door. Amused, he rose from the concrete The night was quiet; sitting in the lotus posture, in deep trance, he did not time.

at half-past eleven at night. Immersed in deep meditation, he lost track of him. The visitors left rather late, and he was able to begin his practice only large group of participants in the yoga study programme came to meet

door closed with a soft click, and he again slid down to the floor, feeling Babaji turned and, as one might to a child, wagged a finger at him. The yielding to impulse, he rose from the floor and followed the Teacher, but exposure to the sun, the locks reached the Mahavata's shoulders.

thicker than half a centimetre, shaded a dark bronze as if from prolonged then did he notice that the Guru's hair was bound in dreadlocks. No touch was warm, human. The Master turned toward the exit, and only still. He bowed to the Master; Babaji placed His hand on his head — the The conversation lasted about forty minutes, but time seemed to stand we shall meet again..."

Babaji's last words were: "Ishwar chahaga to fir milenge" — "God willing, wonderful, since he considered himself a beginner on the path of yoga. highest levels in the practice," and to hear such a prediction was At the very last, the Guru added: "Many of your disciples will reach the 27th birthday. They were not to be taught to others.

separate, entirely new techniques which he was to begin only after his trying not to miss anything. In closing, the Master gave him a complex of Babaji made him take notes, and he hurriedly wrote down the instructions, a Jewish feast, this knowledge was now fully at his disposal.

levels whose mastery he could not have dreamed of. Like a table set with detailed and meticulous explanation of all the Kriyas, even the highest moving in the right direction! That night he received an incredible gift: a to you correctly," — and the confirmation lifted his spirits: at least he was Then the Master added: "You are performing the yoga techniques given He let these words fully penetrate his consciousness, absorbing them. smashan..."

next level, the passage of the 'knot of Rudra', can be mastered only on a He could not imagine living in a cremation ground. Babaji went on: "The level, it will simply draw him in..." The prediction sounded frightening. Babaji suddenly said: "The smashan awaits every yogi who reaches this

while remaining in unity with Life itself.

mystery of their supernatural abilities: they reached the highest states grasp per mysteries through self-indquiry. Perhaps this was the key to the realisation. Siddha-yogis live in harmony with the laws of Nature and can might sound true if it were not one of the hardest attainments of self-being which they have known through meditation and tapasya. This time filled with power. Realised beings act according to the essence of original codes. Baraji's behaviour was strikingly simple and at the same the frame of "acceptable standards," forcing them to shed Nature's accordance with their own nature, because society drives everyone into Him there was not a trace of pretension. Most people rarely act in ...The confidence the Guru radiated was captivating, contagious, yet in

revealing to him the most secret particulars of the higher Kriyas.

in the very same place where Baraji had been sitting moments before, everything he had heard and seen. Going through the notes, he even sat would press forward. That night he could not sleep at all, reliving ...and to begin to apply in practice, for the parampara expected that he

information had to be consolidated, arranged...

successor of the line possessed potential, had a goal. All this new through the experience of samadhi. Baraji had come because the present connection with the tradition, but also because he had already passed been granted to him not only because of his persistent practice and his Trying to gather his thoughts, he understood: this incredible audience had

the heights of yoga are attainable, that the miracles described are real.

meeting and conversation with the Guru strengthened his certainty that practised sincerely and devotedly, those worthy of teaching. The personal watched over every disciple! And He could personally meet those who reality! All that was described in Yogananda's book was true. Baraji Guru of the parampara — not in a dream or a vision, but in waking The rightness of the chosen path was confirmed: he had just met the first

at once empty and brimming with faith, enthusiasm, and contentment.

scolding and reproach worked on his nerves; he was continually reminded with relatives was becoming more and more explosive; the constant aimabhi, a yogin must try to live in seclusion. The forced daily contact With every passing day he was more convinced that, after attaining no longer secured the family's means of subsistence.

reasons for it, including a declared bankruptcy. His father's pension fund of time. Moreover, the atmosphere at home was bleak; there were many aspirations; yoga was simply an impractical hobby, and sadhana a waste. The members of the family cared little for his strange encounters and immortal Master, but no one attached particular significance to the story. excitement. At home he told his relatives about the meeting with the After meeting Babaji he left Benares inspired, brimming with joy and

On the Farm

a conversation of Shailendra Sharma with his disciples

* "...the book of life is never too long and ought not to be boring." — from

Places and Books

month after the meeting with Babaji, May 1998.

completion of the work on the commentaries to the Gita, May 1992. A After being declared successor of the line, the Fifth Guru, 1986. After the days before leaving the body.

Shri Satyacharan Lahiri, Fourth Guru of the Lahiri Mahasaya line. A few

Satyacharan Lahiri, 1902–1987 Shri Shailendra Sharma, 1927–

Shri Lahiri Mahasaya, 1828–1892 Shri Tinkori Lahiri, 1863–1934 Shri

ladilya, Sarvabaman Johari, and artificial-intelligence technologies.

by Sh. Sharma. The image was produced by the joint efforts of Summit Babaji A detailed description of Babaji's features and physique was given his life.

became forever the threshold of the most inspiring and fateful meeting of The first of April is known as "April Fools' Day", but for him this day

ricks, and within a couple of minutes the pots were ready. Then the broken clay jar, helplessly ending its days in the bushes, was set upon the improvised hearth from two ricks, gathered firewood, and lit a fire. A "Nothing to worry about," — and the workman at once contrived an

the workmen asked: "What's the matter, Curujiz?" He explained.

dinner were becoming frighteningly uncertain. Noticing his worry, one of cylinder — critical to survival — had been forgotten. The chances of in the evening it was discovered that, in the rush, the gas stove and the

place was secluded, far from town, and belonged entirely to him alone.

things and settle in. And although the house was not yet finished, the several disciples, among them his friend Kamparui, helped him move his books, some clothes, and went to the farm, knowing he would not return.

especially stormy. After a fierce quarrel with relatives he took a few

On the 10th of July 1990 he turned thirty-three, and that birthday proved

to explain any of this to others.

peace, and a steady balance of discipline. But there was no sense in trying

proceeded from within: the deep cognitive process required solitude,

Void and Sound, with Spirit, was growing. The recognition of Spirit

The awareness of the body as a unity of the elements of Matter, born of

breath of pranayama, with every movement of Apana toward the heart.

future were laughable. The future as such was being shared with every

The reproaches about the absence of career plans and the worry over the

Kutastha rose every night on his inner sky.

chance of privacy. But the practice was magnificent, and the bright star of

everyone was now living in a rented house in which no one had any

passed before he could move in. Tension in the family was rising, for

demanded far more time and money than expected, and nearly two years

friends and disciples, the construction of a small cottage. The building

Borrowing fifty thousand rupees from a cousin, he began, with the help of

house on a plot of land jointly owned by him and his brother Cyanendia.

But there was nowhere to go. Yet a possibility arose to build his own

that only thanks to the family did he have food and a roof over his head.

disappeared. Cautiously peering inside the ruined foundation, they saw ant-castle. Moving uncertainly, as if in a crowded trance, the snake outside, he saw a great black cobra crawling out of a hole at the foot of the had fallen. He was in the house when he heard the cry: "Curry!" Rushing concrete. The work went slowly, yet by the end of the day the ant citadel entrance to the cottage, whose nearly two-metre walls were hard as village came to demolish the termite mound that stood before the eastern systems of underground labyrinth. A workman from a neighbouring several of these high-rise castles, and the gaze was met by complex everywhere; some reached two metres in height. The workers broke down construction the insects had vanished, but their tall mounds rose season had already started. The territory teemed with termites; during When they began to dig irrigation ditches and plant trees, the rainy the main thing was the luxury of solitude.

their intentions. All the cares connected with the move proved soluble; one could hide from the noise of people's thoughts and the toxic slag of place helped him to recharge, to be rid of the pressure of city life. Here cottage for two years did not leave him. And this was quite well, for the For some reason the unwavering certainty that he would stay in this

Naga

town to cook food and brew tea. The new life on the farm had begun. was the taste of freedom. The next day one of the disciples came from the flavour of tomato and the sweetness of red onion wrapped in hot bread; it Each time he recalled that first night on the farm, he tasted again the and only wait to be discovered; all that is required is to see them.

master-class became one of the new lessons: opportunities exist always waiting; he had simply been blind, absorbed by petty cares. This culminated keenly: everything needed had already been provided by Nature and was had ever eaten. For the first time the power of the earth was felt by him so salt. Dinner was served, and it turned out to be the most delicious meal he unearthed onion was likewise mashed and mingled with chili pepper and workman plucked a few wild tomatoes and crushed them with his fist, an

whoever you may be..." The fragrant sandalwood smoke flowed slowly here only to enshrine this land, and I will not trouble you any more, contact with its occupant. Addressing the red-eyed being, he said: "I am Carefully placing incense before the dark hole, he tried to establish mental directly in front of the entrance to the house was a problem to be solved. But for all his respect for folklore and tradition, the termite mound bower.

country places the termite mounds are venerated as seats of spiritual ant-fortresses one can often see images of Shiva or Vishnu, since in of offering to the deities dwelling there. On the ruined foundations of the traditions hold that cows pour their milk over the mounds, making a kind abandoned mounds live on the bodies of such yogins. Some temple endure the bites of termites. It is said that the snakes which often dwell in samadhi. Remaining motionless for months or even years, the saints could sometimes termite mounds formed around ascetics who had remained in called "Nagmani", can heal diseases and bring wealth to their possessors. magical serpents with precious stones hidden in their heads; such stones, half-human-half-serpent,] to Bhogavati. It is believed that there dwell human with serpents around the head and neck, as ordinary snakes, or as Asia for more than two thousand years. Nagas are depicted as fully Rituals dedicated to the Nagas have been performed throughout South There is a belief that from time to time the Nagas assume human form. superhuman and serpentine qualities and inhabiting the underworld. Hinduism and Buddhism, a semi-divine race of beings, comprising to the underground kingdom of the nagas [footnote 121: Nagas — in most sacred images in India. Villagers regard these mounds as entrances ...The image of a serpent atop a termite mound is considered one of the alone to the remains of the mound that evening.

workman was told to come back the next day, while he himself returned himself, and his masterfully chosen profanities had a livening effect. The at them. He cursed the stupefied workman so as to bring him back to in the darkness of the tunnel a red, unblinking eye looking fixedly straight

warm even during the harsh winter months. By spring the ground near light, almost invisible vapour rose from the earth, and the soil remained. Although the opening in front of the house was filled in, sometimes a wound no longer trouble the workmen.

A peaceful agreement had been reached, and he was sure that the Nagas and began to level the mound, taking care not to destroy the foundation. new portion of curses at the foot wretch, he took up the shade himself came was in no hurry to do anything near the serpent's nest. Hurling a disappeared beneath the base of the mound. Soon the workman who connected with the recent dream, and at the same instant the snake standing behind the door, he guessed that the snake's appearance was without blinking. Brushing aside the thought of the double-barrelled gun whites had a bluish cast. This beautiful but lethal creature looked at him. The snake's eyes were red and glaring, like a human being's, and the rhythmically appeared and disappeared between her half-closed fangs. loops, her throat and underside were white, and her red forked tongue veranda and at once met the steady gaze of a huge golden cobra coiled in elastic and supple. The heat was beginning. He stepped out onto the utterly real, had had a stupefying effect, and his body was strangely. The next morning he woke with a heavy head. The dream, which had felt

children." — "Continue. You are under my protection."

only flying to plant a garden here, and I will not trouble you and your coiled, lay tiny golden serpents. He respectfully answered the Nagas: "I am the earth; there was something resembling honeycomb, only in each cell protect you as one of them..." Then the speaker pointed to an opening in and defenceless. I have always been the guardian of this land and will vertical. The man said: "Please do not harm my children, they are small colour of his eyes was hard to determine, but the dark pupils were seemed glued to his head; his skin was yellow, the colour of turmeric. The almost three metres tall, clad in a silken cloth. The stranger's black hair. That night he had a most strange dream: before the house stood a man down into the dark opening, as though the message had been heard.

to the emotions he had felt after meeting Baraji. The next day two blue-the rapture and awe their appearance had caused were comparable only He tried to find some traces of their presence, but found none. And yet

him. Then they vanished, like a hologram suddenly switched off.

from the other side, "floating" above the ground only two metres from corner of the cottage and, having gone around the house, reappeared rush of inexpressible rapture. Passing him, the couple turned the a sign to her companion. A wave of laughter reached him, and he felt a were less than ten metres away, the woman noticed his presence and gave beings, the flowing grace of their motion, was impossible. When they describe in words the serene bliss radiating from these splendidly made flashes. Naked, without ornaments, they were fantastically beautiful. To composed of diamonds; even their hair sparkled with myriads of tiny in the bright moonlight he could see their luminous bodies, as though they did not soar — they walked. The couple "came up" to the house, and human figures, male and female. Moving half a metre above the ground, nearer, and at a distance of thirty metres he began to make out two blue lights to the right of the wall enclosing the territory. The lights grew and the earth breathed with a thousand sounds. One night he saw two moonlight and peace, the divinity of life pulsed in the fragrant darkness, dark sky. Logic meditation calmed thought, the night was filled with went out of the house around two in the morning and gazed at the clear The hot September forced him to do his sadhana late at night. He usually

...And other encounters

seen, but the Naga himself no longer appeared in his dreams.

countless butterflies and humming-birds. From time to time snakes were creepers draped the cottage in lush green and became a refuge for incredible speed. The lawn before the house was cleared, climbing kadamba trees and laid out a garden — and the plantings grew at business. As they went on improving the territory, the workers planted investigate the cause, the inhabitants of the farm minded their own the mound had acquired a strange whitish hue. There was no need to

— Sir, what are you doing here? — asked the astonished brother. — Oh, granted him the loan. The man was washing tea-cups.

the local bank, and the first man he saw was the bank manager who had Gyanendra arrived after lunch. He had recently received a large loan from

collapse and descent into alcoholism.] the hero of the Bollywood film.

grant permission for the marriage, provoking the hero's emotional come back to marry his childhood friend Parvati. The family refuses to Devdas Mukherjee, a wealthy London-retuned law graduate, who has name by Sarat Chandra Chattopadhyay (1817). The film tells the story of drama by director Sanjay Leela Bhansali based on the novel of the same rejected by all. Like Devdas [footnote 123: "Devdas," — a 2002 romantic younger son was living in rags on the bare ground, destitute, hungry, and Gyanendra on a reconnaissance mission. He was to find out whether the in any case, worried about him, the mother dispatched the elder brother

drink your blood!..

to joke: "It is not for nothing that one's kin are called blood-relatives. They aspirations to his mother; even strangers understood him better. He used of their characters created the dilemma: it was impossible to explain his stubbornness was bent on achieving entirely different ends. The similarity and stubborn. As he was, because he was her son, though his one was not to step out of them. His mother loved him but was insistent patterns of social obligation had worked for countless generations, and stable income that would let him start a family. These commonly accepted worried. Like every mother, she wanted him to find a good job with a ...He had not been home for almost six months and his mother was

watching the stream of visitors and listening in on the discussions.

birds sat on them like figures, remaining at their posts for hours, ordered two poles to be set up on either side of his chair on the lawn. The the doors, uttering impatient trills. Clearly an alliance had formed, and he hair began to come every morning, and if he slept in they would flutter at trees right by the lawn, not at all disturbed by the presence of people. This throated lays appeared at the house. Usually shy birds, they perched on

laconically: "It happened," and at once moved on to describe the side-
To his Master he had told the recent incredible experience rather

The Art of Non-Expectation

weeks and months brought only positive changes.

At first this unusual omen aroused a feeling of unease, but the following

landed right on his head, then a moment later flew off.

around, he waved at her, and in that instant the two blue-throated jays
standing near the grazing cows he watched her go. Devanuti turned
their small herd. The next day she was returning to Mathura, and
priestly-visiting cousin Devanuti happily played with the new member of
The playful, charming calf became a kind of household pet, and his
farm two cows and a tiny calf only a month old. He named him Candhi.
Just before the festival of Diwali a disciple from Hariana brought to the
him...

power and the depth of his spiritual insights, people kept coming to
her, and his sadhana reached new heights. Sensing his growing inner
Nature's mighty breathing. The earth was satisfied with the care given to
his practice, and the cycle of pranayamas was tuned to the rhythm of
stimulated deep insights. The land had accepted the calm and solitude of
life on the farm seemed serene, but many subtle, unobvious events
doing very well indeed.

returned home, reporting to the family that the younger brother was
attention. Cyanendra sat quietly for some time, drank a cup of tea, and
discussion was going on, and no one said the newcomer any particular
was ironing the Guru's kurtas. Darsan was in full swing, a feast
including the director-general and the manager. One of the senior officials
he found there the entire staff of the city's department of agriculture,
judge — bringing in a teapot of freshly brewed tea. Entering the cottage,
Passing through the kitchen, Cyanendra met a lady — a well-known town
just serving the Guru...

turmoil. Now, in solitude, he was not troubled by the presence of people, beings in the city and its surroundings, and this had caused a fierce inner his consciousness, and his own mind had scanned the minds of all the. During the first samadhi the whirlwind of others' experiences had risen in flood of others' emotions simultaneously assailing his consciousness. peacefully without a trace of the mental excitement caused by the irritating sensation of breath re-entering the nostrils. But this time the samadhi was slow and uncertain resumption of the heartbeat and the unaccustomed on the first occasion: the numbness, the gradual return of circulation, the realm of Super-Consciousness. The physical sensations were the same as switched, and he again entered the state of non-thought. Or, rather, the repetition of the first experience, when suddenly something inside ...Nearly five years passed. He had practically ceased to expect a of the Lord God.

circus, into a safari park, onto a battlefield, into the personal Disneyland household of the body on an excursion into a vast museum, into a spirit, the inner all-knowing essence, and this spirit could invite the life forever. There, in the Void, the subconscious could at last meet the tunnel that had sucked him into another dimension and had changed his. Samadhi proved to be by no means a blissful contemplation; it was a shown an epic spectacle — he had been made an active participant in it. But it revealed a wholly unexpected production. He had not merely been. Samadhi was a shock; the secret curtain over the stage had been raised, interfered with his concentration.

city and the splashing of the waves of human thought no longer. Now, surrounded by endless fields, he dwelt in solitude. The noise of the from the Teacher.

practising." That was the only counsel and instruction he had received will be repeated, but for that some time may be needed. Just keep them, your first journey, has taken place, but this is only the beginning. It body through physical exercise. Visibly pleased, the Guru smiled: "Well effects of samadhi — the apathy, the inertia, and the rehabilitation of the

siddha, a semi-divine being (or Lord Shiva himself), instructed him to Mahadev close to the city of Srinagar. Legend has it that in a vision a teaching from above. Vasugupta is said to have lived near Mount Vasugupta, who lived in the 9th century CE. It is said he received this known as Kashmir Shaivism. The work is attributed to the sage ॐ aphorisms forming the foundation of the spiritual mysticism tradition meaning of the Shiva Sutras [footnote 123: Shiva Sutras — a collection of samadhi is enjoyment of the world — now he fully understood the fields he revelled in the happiness piercing through him. The bliss of expanded mind multiplies pleasure many-fold. In the middle of the dark mind, the yogin enjoys with fully activated consciousness, and the on. In the ordinary process of pleasure a normal man uses about 5% of the an enjoyer, capable of indulging the senses in whatever his mind focused anything consciousness might wish. He, the yogin, had become a prodigy. The taste of his own saliva could become nectar, wine, milk, or poison — cautious, since the mind could also reproduce the most repulsive ones. Now he could relish the most exquisite tastes, but he had to remain there was not a trace of artificial and conditioned intentions.

animals behaved according to their nature, and in their mental landscapes human beings. Not a single smell of the animal world disgusted him; the beasts and birds could not remotely compare with the mental miasmas of generated by the mental contours of its inhabitants; the vibrations of electric current. The astral fragrances of the animal kingdom were acutely aware of them — they passed through the body like discharges of Already rather sensitive to scents in his ordinary state, he was now Ordinary smell sharpened greatly and became almost unbearable. spasmodic ripples of the mental waves emanating from human beings. peaceful and on the whole serene, in contrast with the bustling, their concentrated grace. The vibrations of the animal kingdom were fox hunting nervous mice, admired a pair of cheetahs in love, regal in felt the hunger of a jackal, for a moment entered the swirling mind of a There were night birds, insects, various reptiles, wild deer and buffalo. He though he sensed thousands of other creatures around him.

happen. Almost five years were needed before he could quiet the mind the thirst for new adventures is so great that it does not allow this to people who have undergone supernatural states crave their repetition, but chief "technical snag."

barrier to be crossed for the first time was impossible, and in this lay the yet to recreate the same mental state which had allowed the invisible unconsciousness that had opened the door into the Void the first time. it actually undermined the mind's ability to return to the state of ...in the depths of the mind, like a rattled chick. seemingly quite harmless, secretive and shy, expectation lived deep [in the mind]...

years. Every day, sitting in his practice, he anticipated a new samadhi. Of course he had waited for results, and that wait had lasted nearly five Anyone who has achieved success is bound to crave more.

already crossed the barrier of action and tasted the flavour of attainment. to results. Expectations still go on living, especially in those who have despite everything the ancient texts say about action without attachment day. The inquisitive human mind wants to see the fruits of every action, wait for the results of one's efforts while still striving for them day after recurrence of samadhi. The most difficult task in yoga sadhana is not to ...The absence of expectations was an important condition for the the principle of entering this state and the rules for leaving it.

of control and balance. Travelling "between" the worlds, he understood suspended animation became regular. Repetition helped him learn the art returned three or four days later. Then, after a brief interval, the state of river. The long-awaited second samadhi lasted about an hour and though he allowed them to flow through him like the waters of a mighty And still all sensations and reactions had to be subdued and controlled, or Agamic tradition.]

Samkhya Dharma. Historically the text is classified as part of the Tantric represent deep philosophical revelations and the great postulates of and the stone on which the shlokas were inscribed. The Shiva Sutras

reverence. To subdue the enormous energy boiling within him he had to ...In those days his aura was golden, and those who came to him felt of the next stage, and he knew it.

had reached the highest state of yoga, yet this was still only the beginning attainment in the practice. The spiritual hunger had been quenched. The confidence came from the incredible satisfaction of progress and on the faces of some of the visitors.

enjoys it." Of course no one said these words aloud, but they were written flying to get somewhere in life, while he lives carefree and obviously so self-assured? He has no job, earns nothing! Whereas we slave away of the happiness that overflowed him: "What is he so jubilant about, why self-confidence for arrogance. They found it hard to understand the cause those who had known him before the transformation took his new found and emotions, and he did not seek to share them with anyone. Some of it was unlikely that anyone could understand all these new experiences and.

photograph — an unforgettable memory of flight, the dream of a wingless experience of Samadhi, until that memory became like a yellowed old He would in all probability have got stuck in memories of the great have made progress, though hardly have reached the subsequent levels. Mahavata and without receiving instruction in sadhana, he would still Most likely, if he had gone on practicing without ever meeting the resides yoga did he desire.

for hours, testing his own capacities and the abilities of his body. Nothing was young, strong, and resolute; he was the next Guru, and he practiced would not have taught him. There were other decisive factors as well: the presence because He knew of the first "journey." Otherwise the Guru He was utterly convinced that Babaji had honoured him with His described as joyful excitement.

consciousness on and off at will. His condition in those days could be and master the subtle process of relaxing it; one cannot simply switch

became perfectly clear. Specific pranayamas stimulated the unconscious, subconscious mind. Now, however, the link between mind and breath in concepts of prāṇa development, in theories of conscious and fragments were astonishing. Before samsādhi he had had no interest at all the nature of Time. It came progressively, fragmentarily, but the All these observations and experiences were followed by the awareness of Life.

And yet people remained unawakened, indifferent to the great mystery of of their bodies and organs, in the atoms of which they were composed. conscious Being who was present within each one of them, in the cavities of the Void: why did nobody know about it? People lived inside a vast frightening at once. Why did they not feel the omnipresent Consciousness existence, and their unawareness began to disturb him — bitter and everywhere. People moved inside the Void without even suspecting Her opening of the night of the Void and Its luminous consciousness. It was The states of suspended animation became regular, leading to a gradual happens." After such a statement, pressing for details was awkward.

rather obliquely: "You will learn and understand all you need when it consequences of samsādhi with him, and only once touched on the subject when speaking with the Guru. The Master had never discussed the one another. Reflecting on all these changes, he did not mention them was. Divinity manifested in the body as Spirit, and the two recognised former times one would have called it supernatural and divine. Perhaps it his head, and this was an altogether different kind of strength — in He began again to lift disciples, holding them on outstretched arms above live.

survived yet another meeting with death, now commanded the body to exercise as through the stimulation of consciousness. The mind, having awakened mind. His physical strength rose sharply, not so much through balance and muscle tone — the changes had been set in motion by the hundred times a day. Regular samsādhis began to affect his normal swing the heavy Indian clubs — the mudgats — no fewer than five

he programmed himself mentally to remain in the logic trance for 9
The longest samadhi was not spontaneous but planned. Preparing for it

The Longest Samadhi. Parikrama

being experienced, is pure Consciousness."

of both, as well as the cause of their being manifested and capable of
so-called worldly pleasures and the bliss of samadhi, because the source
(samasa) and sustains it. After this, the yogin sees no difference between
which, having 'clothed' itself in Matter, manifests the entire world
thought and having known the self, the yogin knows the conscious Void
Shailendra Sharma gives the following explanation: "Established in pure
samadhi is the enjoyment of the world."

[footnote] Shiva Sutras, Shambhaviyoga, shloka 18 reads: "The bliss of
their consciousness. And then communication began on the subtle level.

have dared enter their realms, and he learned to perceive the currents of
The inhabitants of the astral planes always know about the mortals who

of consciousness moved like tsunamis, and he moved with them.

direction, dimension, and the synergy of the channels of space. The waves
moments were like vivid dreams beyond images; the mind could change
they were grasped through the displacement of consciousness. Such
of consciousness. These entities were perceived by him not visually —
beings he encountered from time to time did not affect his concentration
Kriya Yoga, they were its indirect effect; even the most terrifying astral
about him. And although such interactions had no direct connection with
limited to those of living, organic beings. Their inhabitants too learned
together with fearlessness, and ever new worlds opened up — worlds not
yet each "journey" gave him ever greater confidence. Awareness grew
He made no attempts to perceive the whole world during samadhi, and
subconscious; merging, they became pure Consciousness.

the nervous system. The intellectual, logical mind changed places with the
sleeping mind; the mind, awakened by breath, strengthened the body and

for a set time: an invisible inner timer can return consciousness to the exists a regulating mechanism that allows the body to remain in samadhi days. The observation of all these nuances led him to conclude that there forty-seven beats per sixty seconds. Full physiological recovery took three per minute, and over the next twenty-four hours the pulse did not exceed. Even at the height of training his breathing was only one or two breaths wooden handles of the clubs, and it was good to feel alive again.

release, the skin broke into sweat, the palms felt the smoothness of the remainder of its earthy, gross nature. The muscles began to contract and came to his aid again, and the body responded to the exercise as a evening remained undigested, causing severe discomfort. The mind gave the intestines to resume function. Everything he had eaten the previous problem was with the digestive tract: it took almost forty-eight hours for symptoms were nearly the same as after a shorter samadhi. The greatest myriad needles were piercing each organ. And yet all the physical excruciating sensations. The inner itching drove him mad, as though microscopic rivulets began to flow once more in the body, causing unbearably. At last the streams of blood penetrated every pore and vein, and joints, echoing inside the internal organs. The whole body ached than an hour for the blood-flow to return; then came a tingling in the skin stabilisation of metabolic processes took far longer. He had to wait more breathless state, had put excessive strain on the nervous system, and the he greeted him with a nod. The long hours without circulation, in a kitchen. The disciple who came to cook looked in on him: unable to speak, red and simply lay in the room, listening to the clatter of utensils from the animation for seven and a half hours. The next day he could not get out of familiar to him, into another dimension and remained in suspended in the first week of December 1991 he entered, by the bath already and numbness lasted far longer.

shorter samadhis of one-and-a-half or two hours, while the sluggishness that the "spiritual" effect of long immersion was equivalent to that of. Afterwards he never tried to repeat this experiment, since it turned out definite period — and emerged from samadhi as if by an alarm clock.

it was centuries ago, the Hill existed here long before all the gods...the Brīhasis. Although the cult of Krishna is as popular in this region as with Krishna, the Vedic age and the Mahābhārata.] worship Him...

Mathura respectively). Braj is the principal pilgrimage centre associated (according to legend and scripture they were born in Barsana and Vrindavan. The Braj region is associated with Radha and Krishna is said that in the state of Uttar Pradesh, the centre of Vraj is in Mathura on the banks of the river Yamuna, about 120 km from the capital, Delhi. It (or Vraj, Vraja, Brj, or Brj Bhumi) is a region situated in the north of India Ruler of Mountains, and most of the inhabitants of Braj [footnote 124: Braj them with peacock feathers and flowers. The divine Hill is called the from cow-dung, in the image and likeness of the holy Hill, decorating Govardhan. By tradition, the devotees mould miniature models of Citra]. Meanwhile another great festival was approaching: the puja to the Hill of

Whatever it was, it worked.

Consciousness sending its answers through an established channel; from. Was it the work of his own consciousness, or was the Universal he had not the slightest idea where exactly a particular thought had come was always the light of Truth. Sometimes, listening to his own answers, and sometimes as a mighty explosion of consciousness, but the revelation clarification for himself. Sometimes it came as a slow wave of awareness, replying to someone's question, he could receive an unexpected wholeness and completeness. Even in the daytime, outside of practice, in — or rather, the information — came naturally, with astonishing was no need to put questions or to focus on particular topics. The answers As for the state of omniscience usually associated with logic trance, there routine.

needed support, so daily physical exercise became part of his daily recovery did not take long. But even in this gentler regime the body and-a-half proved optimal: the effect on the body was less traumatic, and accordance with the setting of his internal clock. An interval of an hour-body on schedule. Each time he came out of trance naturally, in

His cousin joked: "No idea: we sat down here fifty years ago and have not led by their guide: "How far to the end of the barikrama?"

were frozen and dead tired. A group of pilgrims drew level with them. December went on lashing their bare bodies with whips of icy wind: all

stone wall. Their whole bodies ached and throbbed. He swore.

three other companions decided to take a break and sat down on a low divided: some walked ahead, some lagged behind. He, his cousin, and dressed only in dhosis despite the biting cold. After some time the group of thirty-five disciples arrived in Govardhan and set out on the long road, the Teacher-progenitor of all the schools of Tantra.) Puranima) some thirty first guru-founder of the tantric Agnori tradition: he is also venerated as Vishnu, and Shiva. A divine sage, yogin and samyasa, Dattatreya is the of the mystical deities considered an incarnation of the Trimurti: Brahma. On 21 December (the night of Dattatreya [footnote 156: Dattatreya — one

present.

walking the barikrama, and the idea was met with enthusiasm by all even the calf seemed delighted by the occasion. Someone suggested brown body of the Dark Ruler. The mood of everyone was joyful, and regarded as the supreme Avatar.] Hill and led the calf Gauri around the mounted as one of the most important deities of the Hindu pantheon in Hinduism was initiated by Krishna himself, and ever since He has been deities to worship on the spiritual plane. This evolution of consciousness Hindu philosophy — the transition from sacrifice and the prohibition of food. The hill also symbolises the fall of Indra and a new beginning in Krishna lifted the Govardhan Hill, sheltering the inhabitants from the about Lord Krishna. To avoid the floods sent by an angered Indra, of pilgrimage in Uttar Pradesh, associated with one of the many stories [footnote 157: Govardhan (also called Giriraj) — the most famous centre At the farm his friends and disciples sculpted a figure of the Govardhan Hill is especially attentive to His devotees.

considered especially auspicious on this day, since the Dark Lord of the Barikrama — circumambulation of the Hill in the clockwise direction — is

powerful manifestations of life-energy, and its redistribution is important constructive way of solving a problem. But compassion is one of the sympathies. The balance was a delicate one, since Bity was not at the physical level, he nonetheless allowed his heart to be filled with his yoga. Trying to suppress this newly acquired feeling of compassion at heart all the suffering in the world, and they substantially interfered with particular sense in all these flashes of shared pain: they certainly could not him for a time; struggling against compassion was futile. There was no smearing vibrations of pain and despair came uninvited and stayed with himself from the worst cases — only it proved impossible. The sharp, Having understood the nature of this phenomenon, he tried to distance waves, and the body reacted automatically, absorbing them like a sponge. Logic practice. Another's pain or grief might roll over him like piercing Heightened sensitivity to the pain of others is one of the side-effects of others began to manifest in his body spontaneously and uncontrollably. Samadhi had so sharpened his sense of empathy that the sufferings of began to appear on his own soles. It was not surprising.

Healed her wounds. Lowering his gaze, he saw that bleeding blisters had she walked lightly, perhaps thinking that the Dark Lord of the Hill had rose with surprising ease and went on, no longer leaving bloody traces. exhausted woman. For some time everyone was silent. Then the woman and every step must have caused her pain. They too sat down near the let out a moan. The burst blisters on the soles of her feet were bleeding, walking with great difficulty, sinking onto the shoulder of the road, she footprints on the road. Soon they drew level with an elderly woman. The moon shone brightly, and in its light he noticed dark bloody

winter night by a cremation ground;

ghosts — for who, except ghosts, would sit bare-chested in the middle of smashan, and because of the chance lest the pilgrims had taken them for expecting pursuit. As it turned out, they had been sitting on the wall of a Hanuman and hurried away in panic, glancing nervously back as if got up since..." The pilgrims suddenly began chanting a hymn to

and the richness of human settlement, the Hill resembles a huge half-for kilometres, still partly covered with the remnants of once-lush jungle (Govardhan Mahatal, as this long rocky formation is called. Stretched out circumambulating the hill for spiritual purification, in the name of Thor).]. Millions of pilgrims perform the sacred ritual of tales of Indo-European deities (such as Jupiter, Perun, Taranis, Zeus, and war. The myths and legends of His power are in many ways akin to other sky, lightning, the weather, thunder, storm, rains, the flow of rivers, and Indra as surpassing the other Devas (gods). He is associated with the [footnote 127: Indra — the lord of the Vedic gods. The Rig Veda describes Krishna like a giant shield to protect men from the wrath of Indra. The Govardhan Hill is considered a divine being, raised millennia ago by grace of the God of the Hill can be poured out upon anyone.

marked him out precisely because of this, deciding to alter his life, for the anything but a peaceful mood, and perhaps the God of the Govardhan Hill adventure. Almost naked and frozen, with his feet torn open, he was in prayers, was loudly cursing the person who had dragged them into this ...Probably he was the only yogin that night who, instead of reciting pious bhaktas, but this episode seemed rather strange.

inhabitants of Govardhan paying respect to pilgrims walking the silently disappeared behind the gates. There was nothing unusual in the blood-stained feet, the man bowed low before him, and then just as shoulders, was indistinguishable. Almost touching his head to Shama's feet of the stranger's face, hidden by the blanket thrown over his head and language betrayed advanced years, his large moustache was dark. The blanket appeared. The man's age was hard to tell, and although his body rusty gates when those gates opened and a tall, lean figure wrapped in a his disciples, swearing fiercely from time to time. They were passing some The remainder of the road had to be walked leaning on the shoulders of spontaneous sympathy for the elderly pilgrim woman to overtake him. One way or another, that night, having lost vigilance, he had allowed And sometimes quite effective.

Covardhan and live there, daily covering her body with the sacred dust of sand and suffering from leprosy. A bandit had advised her to move to turned out that she was the only daughter of a millionaire from Cusarat. Driven by curiosity, he sent one of the disciples to make inquiries. It mysteriously could not have been the consequence of blind religious devotion and guarding her. Clearly the girl belonged to a wealthy family, but her an entourage of four or five servants who were obviously accompanying burning-hot road. Behind her followed slowly a large expensive car and beautiful girl who was protesting with weak persistence on the dusty, own ordeal was still fresh. At one moment he noticed an unusually he watched the passing pilgrims with sympathy, for the memory of his in Covardhan. Much time had passed since that cold night baktams, but ...In July 1993, after many unexpected events, he stopped in a guest-house absolutely impossible.

would himself settle here, in the lab of the Dark Lord, was at that time although it certainly produced an effect. To predict that very soon he sensed the extraordinary power of the place. Describing it was difficult, pain of the blisters and the general irritation at the whole undertaking, he walked, feeling the burning cold of the road under his feet. Despite the That night he had no particular requests of the Deity of the Hill; he just Krishna Yoga and helped him find his Master...

sadhana, a spiritual disciple.] in Puri, had recommended him books on elderly sadhak [footnote 128: sadhak — one who practices a particular this similarity had helped him — then Shailendranath Mukherjee, an Mountain." It was one of the many names of the Covardhan Hill. Once combination of the words "Shaila" and "Indra" meant "King of the Walking along the endless road, he recalled that his name, Shailendra, a out by divine power.

Sometimes it even alters fates: the previously written destiny is crossed "causeless mercy." It may come from God, from the Guru, or from both. kripa, and some do not, but all hope for it. The term "kripa" means submerged submarine, lost in the ocean of Time. Some receive His grace,

Empty robes were weeds that bore no fruit. Not robe, but faith, is the own bath of yoga awaited awakening.

their spiritual spring. And in just the same way, fed only by faith, their own destinies. Devotion and faith slumbered in every heart, awaiting robe, passing their aspirations and requests through the filters of their themselves, determining the nature of the differences between faith and The disciples had to discover the subtlety of all these connections for

success of any undertaking, and especially of a spiritual search.

connection, but blessing and plain luck are reliable ingredients in the how all this related to yoga. Perhaps in the literal sense there was no Telling these stories to Western guests, he knew they did not quite grasp

barikrama to anyone who asked for advice.

person's life with a snap of the fingers, and therefore he recommended the visible cause. It is impossible to foresee the specific magic that alters a granted mercy. That is why kripa is called causeless — it is given without There were no objective reasons for any of these events; he simply was

found him.

weeks. And he found the palace he was looking for. Or perhaps the palace even properly finish a single essay in college, he wrote four books in a few circumambulation changed his life. A scattered student who could not distribution of grace, but the fact is undeniable: the first The God of the Govardhan Hill is selective and unpredictable in His completing her third barikrama.

her face and body within a year. On the day he saw her she was The resolute girl kept her vow, and all traces of the disease vanished from thousand prostrations.

and takes eight or nine days, during which the pilgrim makes eleven prostrations, the Dandavat Barikrama. One circle is twenty-one kilometres that, in case of healing, she would complete seven cycles of full the barikrama road, and to vow before the Deity of the Govardhan Hill

system. Once, "observing" this epic scene on the verge of morning, he electrical discharges throughout the whole body, charging the nervous. Numerous lights flashed in the brain, and this hidden power-station sent the inner dark.

the body through the eyes, mouth, and ears; it was at once swallowed by unceasing motion. Amid all this darkness there was also light, entering heart an ancient power was hidden, and it kept the engine of life in darkness was held, slowly pumping invisible blood through itself. In the ...in darkness, and the heart was a chamber where condensed, perfect pulsations. The colossal body resided...

heart was the noisiest part of the body: its resonance created thousands of nerve impulses travelled, with power lines installed alongside them. The phenomena. The energy channels, the Nadis, were the paths along which heavy artillery. It was the mind, not the hearing, that perceived all these the intestines were thunderous and at times resembled the sounds of digestive system was a whole Universe in itself: the movements of gas in genuinely strange to witness the working of one's own mind. The sounds of electrical discharges indicated brain activity, and it was brain's neurons sounded like incessant explosions of fireworks. The electrical impulses created a peculiar noise effect: the crackling of the and plateaus, the blood-flow humming loudly and insistently. Myriad heartbeats, rivers and streams of blood flowed through the dark caverns. The pitch-black darkness was shaken by the strong, slow sound of the the sounds of this inner universe were loud and powerful.

emerged: he sensed, "saw," and "heard" his own body from within, and knowing and experiencing of everything around, another strange aspect to notice side-effects. Besides the now familiar feeling of simultaneous. After the second phase of samadhi became more or less stable, he began

The Inner Symphony

and Time.

necessary factor for success in this yoga. Well, that and grace, and luck,

can be mistakenly taken for hallucinations or psychoses, but mystical wrapping him in itself. Attempts to share such experiences with others can completely distract the one who lives through this experience. All these sounds were different notes of the Void. Transcendental reality mightily symphony.

discharges throughout the body formed the general background of this intestines. The reverberations of the cracking of electromagnetic beats and the sounds of the percussion instruments of the orchestra of the cracking of the brain's neurons was accompanied by the rolls of drum-resumed its triumphant surging current, and its sound was hypnotic. The When he came out of trance, the heartbeat was restored, the blood-flow restriction to any form and become truly infinite.

inconceivable galaxies of the greater world, the mind could overcome its sense of selfhood. Witnessing the immensity of the body, surrounded by expand, the mind must come to the "source of its own origin," to a sharp comparison with the forms of life that inhabited it. For consciousness to the inner Universe enabled him to grasp the colossal scale of the body in "visible," and this investigation of the structure of the building blocks of upon the microbes themselves. Now protons, no longer atoms, became examining, as under a microscope, ever smaller forms of life that lived was fixed on the microbes, consciousness began to advance deeper, a new, hitherto unexplored aspect of the body's life. As soon as attention The awareness of the vast variety of forms of life allowed him to focus on "host."

some extent the consciousness of these beings affected the mind of the viruses and bacteria, lawful inhabitants of the Universe of the body: to millions of living beings: among the red and white blood cells moved the movement of neurons. He also became aware of the presence of skin is thinner, and all of it stimulated electrical discharges, accelerating light poke through between the fingers of the hands and feet, where the absorb the diffuse shimmer of dawn, and this dawn was beautiful: rays of discovered a sort of "sunrise" right beneath the skin. The body began to

of so-called "normal" waking consciousness began to seem coarse, almost reality in the state of samadhi was sobering, and the dream-like character dismisses the "unreality" of the dream. The full awakening to the higher Awakening from sleep a man usually enters the "reality" of waking and phenomenal world experienced in ordinary states of consciousness. Once unveiled, the final nature of being was more real than the beyond all concepts and words.

transcended, replaced by infinity and eternally, and this experience was with the wholeness of the world. Ordinary time and space were a boon. This mystical journey gave him the sense of inner and outer unity and yet the awareness of the body's splendour was a necessary education, limits of that very body had been transcended. He knew he was outside. To perceive the body as a Universe was astonishing, especially after the world in its broader sense.

body: the awareness of one's own "I" became commensurate with the Cosmic consciousness, logic self-identification was not bounded by the "seen" during his expeditions into the depths of his own shell. Drawn by easily be classified as fantasy, but it was extremely close to what he had were depicted abstractly, even lifelessly. This hallucinogenic art could in some pictures the basic human functions — birth, sex, and death — were of neutral threads, and the organs were lit from within by electricity. detailed in vivid colours, objects and spaces were connected by a dense through a wild colourful X-ray machine. Every bone, organ and vein was cosmic consciousness. The transparent human figures were as though in language of psychedelic realism and had created an anatomical atlas of Alex Grey, who had expressed the symbolism of the New Age in the ...Almost twenty-five years later someone gave him an album of the artist in his own private box.

the show. He no longer stood at the entrance of the theatre; he had a ticket willing participant. Calm acceptance was the key to the continuation of labelling all these experiences. It is enough to be a reverent observer, a experiences always have a personal transformative effect. He was far from

him from the bhakti itself and now took up residence near him. The
a feeling of invisible presence, as though some great force had followed
Returning with relief to the farm, to the serenity of the cottage, he sensed
astral planes could wait; first he had to understand gross reality.

laws issuing from the very nature of those elements. The mastery of the
Matter, and everything in this visible material world lived according to
structure of the interrelation of the primary elements that gave rise to
quickened, and now he somehow understood and "saw" the vast
Cosmos during the spontaneous bhakti. The flow of thoughts
This absorbed and assimilated knowledge reached its apogee at
such interlocutors in his immediate circle.

beyond their own bodies could appreciate them — and there were no
purely intellectual comprehension; only those who had already journeyed
his monologues with bated breath. Yet the themes were too grand for
strong need to discuss these discoveries; disciples and friends listened to
aspects, drove him mad and pacified him at the same time. He felt a
innocence and simplicity of Nature, manifested even in her most "cruel"
incredible complexity of life and the great logic of its cycles. The
understanding went hand in hand with the realization of the vastness and
birth to all this Matter, including his own body, was conscious. This new
came together with the understanding that the Void which had given
of the nature of Matter that composes the surrounding material world
his efforts. The sadhana brought breath-taking discoveries. The awareness
practice. Now, possessing the technique, he could advance, and he tripled
The higher brahmanas which Babaji had taught him required diligent

Commentaries on the Cits

accurately defining the state in which he now permanently dwelt.

statements were true, since they described the nature of non-duality:
"Form is Void, and Void is formless form," "I am That." Yet both
Reduced to verbal descriptions, these experiences sounded paradoxical:
grotesque.

entities, looking like plumes of light-grey smoke, never entered the disciples who took dictation saw a variety of spirits, but the transparent he dictated commentaries to the Bhagavad Gita daily. In those days the sun's entry into the sign of Capricorn, the festival of Makara Sankranti), beginning from the 14th of January (which coincided with the day of the structured, finding their connection with the chapters of the sacred book. All the thoughts of recent months and years began to fall into line, to be Evidently, the answer had sounded like a quotation from a published text: beautiful and concise — what book is this? I would like to read it." had finished his explanation, the disciple inquired: "This commentary is the inner dam holding back all the thoughts, images, and words. After the Arjuna's fear before the battle is spoken of. The first reply seemed to open waiting for the question. It was the 50th shloka of the first chapter, where shloka from the Gita, he answered instantly, as though he had been Therefore, when one of the disciples enquired about the meaning of a had already been visiting him.

commentaries on the Bhagavad Gita." Strangely enough, this very idea Devahuti, he said: "Tell your brother — the time has come to begin the regarded man, resembling a Siddha, sat under a large tree. Addressing mental message: "Close your eyes," — and saw the same thing: a grey- The cotton curtains stirred as if charged with electricity: they received a presence: "We would like to see you: please give a sign of your presence." entered the room, and Devahuti asked for confirmation of the spirit's ritual. All three of them simultaneously felt that some force or entity had another friend, the three of them sat down on the floor and began the Devahuti, interested in spiritualism, proposed a seance. Together with ...Once, when he was visiting his aunt in Mathura, his younger cousin to a practical solution that always worked. He had no idea how.

listeners with the precision of definition and simplicity. The analysis led question, his angle on the problem was unexpected, and the style struck truth that lay at the core of any question. Whenever he replied to a not a property of the logical mind: it was a subconscious certainty in the intellect acquired depth, becoming more analytical. But this depth was

disciples over his head, holding them on outstretched arms, and after and discharge this energy. In addition to regular weight-lifting, he lifted feeling the ever-growing inner force, he exercised daily simply to subdue

...it was not a hallucination.

means sure that it was not a hallucination.

apparition, visitors carefully commented on this phenomenon, by no became almost opaque. Rubbing their eyes, unable to shake off the flow of thoughts was especially intense, the silhouette densified and visible until the very end of the work on the book. Sometimes, when the energy, as though a double stood behind him. The shadow remained golden shadow appeared to his left, resembling a cluster of luminous weighing every word he uttered. On completing the third chapter, a continued to dictate for hours. The birds listened attentively, as though turned blue.] — daily perched on the poles behind his chair, and he swallowing it, kept it in his throat. From the poison the neck of Mahadev Shiva drank the poison of the entire world, the Halahala, and, without roller, literally 'blue throat', one of the names of Lord Shiva. It is said that lays — the milkamhi [footnote 129: Milkamhi — blue-throated lay, Bengal were rising there in spite of the approach of night. The two blue-throated something resembling the aurora borealis appeared, as though the sun luminous points scattered from the sky before sunset; in the north Nature herself gave favourable signs that supported the work: like rain,

did not affect the work on the Gita.

performance. Yet however irritating all these petty unpleasantnesses, they with such persistence that one could not help suspecting a stage-managed. Sometimes the disciples, relatives tried to prevent their visits to the Curn occurred: unexplainable indispositions and other interferences happened. taking the dictation had sudden nosebleeds; accidents of varying severity sudden whirlwinds rose; lightning struck out of nowhere; the disciples someone wanted to obstruct this work, creating all manner of hindrances: spirits, representatives of demonic realms. It seemed that something of territory and usually gathered beyond the gate. Mostly they were dark

no other thoughts to intrude on the course of the exposition. Yet between While dictating, he was extremely focused and self-contained, allowing The Yogis' March

marking the arrival of spring.

one day and completed on the eve of Vasant Panchami, the festival The Logic Commentaries to the Bhagavad Gita were written in twenty-else, was the method of knowing Creation.

know the Creator: every body was a counter of time. Yoga, and nothing of the Primordial Cosmos, in the Void. Each had the instrumentation to and these bottle-bodies with encoded soul-messages floated in the ocean Everything around was placed in various vessels and countless forms, various types of time and the limits within which It is contained. fleeting and transient nature of the world is possible only by knowing the the Primordial Creator, a part of the all-generating Time. The grasp of the spirit which made it alive. Spirit was the principal alchemical component. Time came the desire to know this body, to discover the origin of the ...The Matter of which the body is built arose from Time. From the same

birds, found the skies of human minds.

of the truth demanded verbal embodiment, and his words, like liberated knowing one's own spirit. The themes raised were grand, the immensity and death, about death as the greatest aim of life, about life as a means of He dictated words about the unrepeatable splendour of the union of life striking.

the supreme truth, and now He spoke to him directly. The message was Deity, even though the sacred book called Him by name: Time. He was practicing yoga). But not one of these authors mentioned the principal commentaries written by respected scholars and even saints (some were must be read every day — it is part of yoga sadhana. There existed many According to the traditions of his line, a chapter of the Bhagavad Gita such diversions the dictation went more smoothly.

city, where everyone knew everyone, an absence in a piece of cloth on dhootis. For places of pilgrimage this would be quite normal, but in the over the choice of dress. It was assumed that being yogis, all should but always, all wished to take part in the march, although some hesitated among householders.

he elevated, to demonstrate that real yoga is alive and that yogis still live painful that he wanted to remind people of the unity of the material and aspirations were ridiculed. His own experience at the ashram had been so more and more like convenient camouflage, while sincere and true had always been so, but conversations about spirituality were becoming aspects of life and the longing for self- and God-knowledge. Of course it spiritual awareness pointed to the widening gap between the practical demonstrated the opposite. The pragmatic approach to the very notion of people of the unity of the earthly and the divine, but pushing reality heroes of their own stories. The subconscious continually reminded possibility of such a striving, inspire the ordinary citizens to become disciples were part of society, and their example could illustrate the very worldly life there is a place for spiritual search. He, his friends, and his utopian. But the march of yogis could become a statement that even amid awakening of the town's people, no. To hope for that would have been too Not that the procession was meant to bring about a spiritual or religious

trampled ring where the daily battle with everyday life was fought.

the tender shoots of spiritual search had little chance of surviving on that understandable. For many, life was a duty, an overwhelming task, and occasion to dress up, eat well, and enjoy kirtans, and this was life; for most of the inhabitants religious holidays were merely an devotion, sadhana, and discipline — of yoga. The town lived its everyday honour Lord Shiva; it was to remind people of the value of spiritual supported it. The idea of organising such a procession was not only to completely. He discussed the plan with the disciples, and they fully Kali to the shrine of Subteshwar Mahadev. This thought seized him resolve. On the great Night of Shiva he was to walk from the temple of sessions a vague idea continued to visit him, which soon turned into

waters; part of dikhars in some traditions. The ritual symbolises the first Abhishek [footnote 130: Abhishek — ceremonial bathing in sacred alcohol. The disciples brought milk in an iron pitcher, and he began his giddiness as of intoxication, although he had never in his life tasted. He was overflowing with a feeling of rapture, experienced a slight for the night celebration watched their arrival with surprise and curiosity. temple was now entirely at their disposal. Hundreds of people gathered thought that the bare-chested men were going to seize the temple. The — the priest fled, exclaiming: "The Nagas are coming!" Probably the temple of Shiva. Mistaking them for fierce naked ascetics — naga-paras. Reaching the hill, they began ascending the hundred steps that led to the was needed.

unusual lightness and being in a half-trance state. Something "grounding," "Har Har Mahadevi," as he scarcely felt his own body, experiencing an garlands around his neck. At one point he asked his companions to chant out into the streets, briefly stopping the march and hanging flower way. Along the road, disciples who had not joined the procession came refreshed themselves with drinks offered to them and continued on their crowd. Halting at his old house, where his relatives still lived, they had to stop the traffic to clear a passage for their group through the pandanas on his head leading the bare-chested men in dhootis. The police at the broad-shouldered young man of powerful build with a red procession the townspeople froze, craning their necks to get a better look euphoric. This was their first "public appearance." At the sight of the was preparing for the holiday. They walked quickly, and the mood was kilometre march. Cavalier, jammed with festival-eve traffic and crowds, the temple of Kali on the hilltop, from which they began the nineteen-participants of the march. Several cars carried them to Kali Mata Mandir, perched on the tops of the poles on either side of the path, seeing off the gathered at the cottage. Like trained bodyguards, the two blue jays again. On the morning of the day of Shivaratri about forty disciples and friends perceived as a challenge. In effect, the whole undertaking was a challenge. wrapped around the ribs would cause a sensation and might be

Time and Void

strategy.

in selecting their company, and he saw no reason not to follow the same choose the place, time, and audience. After all, even the gods are choosy did not object to this role, but he wanted to keep for himself the right to translators for the transmission of messages from the subtle planes. He instead of trying to speak with the Divine directly, people kept seeking slightest desire to become a mummy charred by the flame of blind belief, uncontrollable and burst forth like a forest fire, and he had not the crowds at any cost. Collective manifestations of faith and devotion are worshipping the power he was radiating. From then on he tried to avoid nails were gone. Too many people had beaten their heads against them, returning to the farm did he notice that the big toes were bloody and the forming a dense cordon, the disciples escorted him to the car, and only on cries of "Har Har Mahadevi!", and the heads beating against his bare feet. By the force of the ritual, he hardly noticed the outstretched hands, the spontaneously prostrating before him, trying to touch his feet. Charged gathered around: hundreds and thousands of people began staircase leading down to gather his thoughts. A great crowd had the rite, he stepped slowly out of the temple and stood on the steps of the Almighty," or "adoration to Lord Shiva." — and he uttered it. Finishing mantras of Shaivism. "Namah Shivaya" means "Oh, Glory to the — one of the most popular mantras of Hinduism, the most important mantra resides "Om Namah Shivaya" [footnote 131: Om Namah Shivaya rituals, but who could read the future then? He had no specially prepared In the years that followed this event he would conduct thousands of such euphoria.

earth itself, and the ritual was hypnotic, enveloping, suffusing him with The white liquid poured over the black stone, Shiva drank the juice of the (sometimes even liquor) over the image of a God or Goddess.] in his life. offering prayers in which the devotee pours an offering (water, milk, bathing of the deity to whom worship is offered. A religious method of

compiler of the Vedas,) is a central figure in Hindu traditions. He is [footnote 135: Veda Vyasa (Krishna Dvaipayana, known as Vyasa or 'the was timidly' in passing, alluded to in a few texts; the Veda Vyasa particularly many. The concept and philosophical significance of Time Although the Gita was a book about Time, mentions of It were not signal-lights.

of revelation, and the lines of the sacred text were the lane-markings, the knowledge at break-neck speed. The journey was accompanied by flashes the project, but the dictation swept the mind down the highway of work on the commentaries he had not foreseen the scale and ambition of magical catalyst that directed the flow of his reasonings. At the start of had to find an outlet, to take the form of words. The Gita became the meanings. To bear the grandeur of the new knowledge was not easy: its depth and multidimensionality of the text began to disclose hidden stimulated the development of consciousness, and after some time the faithfully kept this vow. The reading of the Gita and the practice of yoga promise to read the Bhagavad Gita daily, and for several years he had ...By the rules of the parampara, during initiation every sadhak gives a

slightest idea how to clothe these experiences in verbal form.

awareness of the nature of Matter, Time, and Void. But he had not the him through new and uncharted spaces, and this journey gave him sharp particles of everyday impressions and memories. The Ancient Spirit led nuclear what was left of the logical mind; perhaps some fragments and living force pulsing in the Void that surrounded his true "I." It was Nothing which was Everything. Time ceased to be a concept; it became a with non-anticipation, were the magic key that opened the portal into "the Void." The new Krishna techniques accelerated progress and, coupled radiant infinity of the Absolute in the darkness of the majestic abyss called mind would not be smothered by bliss and awe, while gazing at the non-being while not regarding the passage as an attainment — so that the capsule of the body. The trick lay in flying without flying, in passing into but routine. He had learned to enter the Void and then return to the The samadhi that had become a part of his nightly "routine" was anything

a deity. In modern Hinduism it is most often associated with Vishnu. The Vishvarupa ("universal form") — an iconographic form and theophany of the 11th chapter of the Gita, "Vishvarupa Darshana Yoga," [footnote 134: capable of giving the description of Time and space the way it is given in resides him, did it reveal its true face? Only a universal consciousness is Who, resides Arjuna, could have received Time's revelation: to whom Bhagavad Gita. Could it be that this book was written by Time itself? mortal beings. The limited human imagination could not have created the other records exist of direct communication or meeting of Time with Although every living being can be regarded as an expression of Time, no the Avatar of Lord Vishnu, declared directly: "I am Time."

to the stunned Arjuna. The lotus-eyed, dark-skinned disturber of peace, words spoken by Krishna while demonstrating the splendour of His form Krishna. In fact, no other text could compare in importance with the few Bhagavad Gita Time spoke of itself, revealing its might through the lips of was absent in the well-known philosophical or religious texts. In the ...Apart from these stray and rather sparse fragments, discussion of Time indefinite terms...

and royal rituals and duties of court priests.] Veda spoke of it in priest and rituals of initiation into learning (upanyasana), weddings and funerals, religion, encompassing not only the formulae of magic but also the daily scholars consider this description incorrect. It is said to represent a 'folk Atharvaveda is sometimes called the 'Veda of magical formulae', but most hymns and around 6000 mantras are divided into 20 books. The Vedic Sanskrit, preserving pre-Vedic Indo-European archaisms. 230 to the Vedic scriptures. The language of the Atharvaveda differs from 'procedures of everyday life'. This text is the fourth Veda, a late addition meaning 'knowledge') is the 'bank of knowledge' of the atharvans, or [footnote 133: Atharva Veda, Atharvaveda (from atharvans and veda, the Brahma Sutras. He is one of the seven immortals.) and the Atharva Vedas. Vyasa is also considered the author of the eighteen Puranas and scriptures, and the one who divided the Vedic mantras into the four considered the author of the Mahabharata, the compiler of many

human mind cannot hold the splendour of Truth for very long. When in a metaphor to explain the indescribable. What was truly astonishing: the required many limbs — and Arjuna used these descriptive epithets and arm was a unit of measure for space. To embrace all directions at once scale that which lies within reach. Thousands of years ago an outstretched comparative terms accessible to mortals. By extending one's arm, one can him. Bewildered, astonished, unable to classify what he saw, he used human. Therefore Arjuna could not clearly explain what stood before side of existence, although his perception of reality remained altogether description. As the son of the god Indra, Arjuna was aware of the astral and hands are everywhere!" — and this was correct, if not detailed, filled and pervaded space, the stunned Arjuna exclaimed: "Your mouths limited in their means of expressing such concepts. Seeing how Time Re-reading these lines, he thought that the ancients had been somewhat was constant, eternal, and continued, never coming to an end.

went on creating new beings and entities. Being the Lord of all changes, It "lick", "taste", and devour material worlds. And at the same time, Time was a terrifying revelation. Its countless "mouths" never ceased to "eat", was staggering. For the human mind the omnipresent true form of Time existence was finite. The portrait of the Universal Being given in the Cita gross elements came into conflict with the astral planes because its In the womb of Time lived all beings and inanimate objects; the world of form of Time would be beyond any mortal.

communication became possible, since to perceive and endure the true stunned. It seems that Time entered the body of Krishna so that such Lord.]. When Krishna revealed His Universal Cosmic Form, Arjuna was vision and the ability to behold all creation in the body of the Supreme Krishna to reveal His universal cosmic form. Arjuna is granted divine is the eleventh chapter of the Bhagavad Gita, in which Arjuna asks interprets this form of the Absolute as Time. Vishvarupa Darshana Yoga universe is contained in the body of the Deity. Shailendra Sharma Vishvarupa is considered the supreme form of the Lord — the entire most famous description of the Lord's form is given in the Bhagavad Gita.

through It: the Master of the parampara is one with Time, and such unity was confirmation of His ability to merge with Time, to travel within It and could happen only by the grace of the Master. Baba's own immortality that expanded his consciousness. The awareness of Time and the Void transformations, he was firmly convinced: it was the meeting with Baba! the commentaries was finished. Analysing his own long-term The realisation of the Cita's message took years, even after the work on dialogue the guest disappeared for a long time.

us?" The man became alarmed: "What?" — "The Void!" After this priest Once he addressed one of the visitors: "Do you know what lies between prepared.

describe them. But, as it turned out, the listeners were not entirely deepest meanings, embedded in the very Universe, so that people could essence but not fully grasping it. And yet he felt the need to set forth these grandeur of these ideas. People listened with reverence, catching the meaning to friends and disciples, and they were enthralled by the Matter," — and this was a fantastic revelation. He tried to explain its realisation: "From the union of Time and the Void is born conscious ...The conception of the arising of Matter came to him as a clear

boundary between them exists. Yet with their separation Duality begins. separately they are the continuation of one another, though no sharp astonishing, for Time and the Void were conscious beings. Even taken but that Shunya was conscious was nowhere mentioned. This was itself sustain space? The Void was mentioned in logic and Buddhist texts, It pervaded the Void, but what was the nature of this Void? Or did Time chief property: no one could escape It until Time itself permitted them to. Having realised the nature of Time, the mind went on to recognise Its the body of Krishna, and the lesson was over.

cannot repeat: at that time I spoke being in a logic state..." Time had left teaching he had forgotten in the heat of battle, Krishna answers: "That I later chapter of the Mahabharata Arjuna asks for a repetition of the

had neither beginning nor end. Probably for this reason He is worshipped in many texts, but the birth of Shiva is nowhere mentioned, as though He simultaneously. The birth and death of various gods are described in the Vedas — and they represent aspects of Time, existing within It. The creator, Vishnu is appointed caretaker and preserver, and Shiva is the destroyer. Each of the deities performed his role. In Hinduism, Brahma is the creator, but he ceased to be worshipped. Forgotten by men, the gods dissolved into Time, created by God. It itself begot the gods and destroyed them when they became impossible, however he concentrated on this phenomenon. Time was not a bounded space, but to draw a sharp boundary between them was measured as the boundless space containing temporal forms. Time is perceived the Void as infinite space filled with forms; eternally was inside and outside human bodies.

Traces of this process are everywhere — on man-made things, in nature, of Matter were born, existed for some time, and then disappeared again. can be grasped only through its effect on the material world; many forms of its own, and even produced another object. The manifestation of Time Without having form, something had a name, existed without coordinates not to insist on an explanation, though the argument seemed weak. written in the textbook!" — the teacher was visibly irritated. He decided "How can something formless form a line?" — "Because that's how it is infinite straight line is made up of a multitude of them. He was puzzled: always forming a line: a point has neither form nor volume, and yet an Once during a geometry lesson the teacher spoke of points supposedly

The Great Clockmaker

they were destined to meet again.

realisations linked the birth of the spirit with the infinity of Time, where Selfhood, and of its Origin, slowly strengthened his sense of being. These the past bound the supports of the present. The cement of Knowledge, of Sadhana built a bridge between the present and the future. The mortar of could be allowed only by Time itself.

The nature of Time did not yield to direct cognition, but its influence was what I say about Time?"

Looking at me, seemingly limited in Time, will anyone pay attention to long can I alone call upon people to know Time? Who will listen to me? In the preface to his commentaries on the Bhagavad Gita he wrote: "How understanding the nature of Time — it had to take... some time.

power and immense potential of the Void could bring people closer to Time and the Void are Siamese twins, eternal lovers. Awareness of the and their properties.

to understanding the phenomenon of Time lay beyond material forms Time by observing physical objects — it is a long detour to Truth. The key in time. He almost bit the physicists trying to understand the nature of accumulation of property. Time did not interest those who were limited food, reproducing, and multiplying their own vanity through the the owners of these vessels were busy with other urgent matters: securing endless — only it has been stuffed into a vessel with an expiry date. And through the human mind. And the mind is truly beginningless and temporal limits were the very laws of being to be studied and known into Time we are destined to return..." Yet the forces existing beyond The Bible was worth occasional paraphrasing: "From Time we came, and

an intestinal bacterium might take a human body for an eternal universe. rational ones, it is hard to imagine anything beginningless and endless. 20 stretches of time imply eternity. Therefore for beings limited in time, even limited and exhaustible resource of time, people are convinced that larger something that lasts longer than a human life, no more. Possessing a constantly. The very concept of "infinity" is rather limited, defining illusory, temporary, since the matter of which it is made changes From the moment of birth everyone moves toward death; any form is in the nature of Time, which destroys in order to recreate.

flow runs through everything, in everything. There are no contradictions as Time, taking various forms. Time is Death, and simultaneously Life. Its

mortem experience came quite naturally and was passed on the
of his nightly out-of-body "sorties." The decision to describe the post-
commentaries to the Cita, he was still digesting the incredible impressions
weeks the apprehensions diminished. Beginning the work on the
brief anxiety before "immersion" was part of the process. After several
To get used to repeated samadhi experiences also took time. Even the
The Art of Dying. The Alternative Way of Escape

moment.

hands. The self-knowledge of the Great Clockmaker did not cease for a
Void was Its dial; the changes of the universal cycles were the hour-
The life of beings and inanimate objects was a millisecond of Time; the
self-knowledge for It, for Time has no sense of time.

Its own nature, to study and experience itself. There was no other path of
of living bodies and incarnating itself in them as souls, in order to know
them expired. Tirelessly and methodically Time went on creating myriads
were programmed only for a definite time, and then the warranty granted
and software allowed: physiologically, karmically, and mentally they
Its perishable fruit. People limited in time lived as long as their hard-drive
was present in every one, and the human body itself is a sentence of Time,
measured by It, had its term. Eternal, indestructible, It betrayed all and
space and is connected to nothing. Everything that related to It, that was
again vanishes into Time — and only Time remains. It exists outside
Time and was born from Time. When the time of Creation runs out, if
creation of the world, he replied: Creation was always in the womb of
Answering the question of what exactly was happening before the
concepts beyond the mind.

spirit and body, of Life and Death. Yoga is the compass in the world of
results led to the realisation of the great union of Time and the Void, of
vanishes again into It. Not was logic sadhana an exception. And yet its
time. And then everything that ripens, that is created and realised,
phenomenon, or understanding, and results become evident only... in
felt continually. Time is necessary for the growth of any organism, idea,

Time. Knowing this once, the soul no longer accepts birth and is not they know the essence of indestructible Brahman, the consciousness of Commentary: "All souls in this universe are born again and again, until 8, shloka 10.

Kaunteya! There is no rebirth after attaining Me." Bhagavad Gita, chapter "O Arjuna! All worlds, including the Brahma-Loka, recur, but O inhabits various "houses" and "estates."

the temporary nature of ownership and understands that the spirit always the loss of property is always traumatic, unless one has been taught to see with the most ancient form of possessiveness and the pain of separation, mental imprint of death — the "extraction" of spirit from body — is linked (or what was left of it) was anxious over the possible loss of refuge. The Fear was perfectly understandable and even appropriate: the logical mind animation, whatever the scientific term may be.

probably for that reason he continued in the trance. Or in suspended was pierced by an acute fear, yet astonishment was stronger, and gone, but the body still remained the anchor, the foothold of the spirit. He of life in the numb, motionless bodily shell. The other signs of life were trying not to forget its purpose. These contractions were the sole indicator — at which the heart still slowly and irregularly contracted, as though brief panic caused by the absence of breath. And the absence of heartbeat because he himself had lived through these emotions. In particular, the describing personal experience. The narration was so deep and powerful read the commentaries attentively could understand: the author is shock. The symptoms were described so meticulously that anyone who dizziness and confusion. Then, realising the obvious, he enters a state of realise that the body is no longer a refuge to him, and experiences the post-mortem state: the just-released spirit is bewildered, he does not The most vivid of the commentaries spoke of the immediate sensations of homeless souls.

practitioners and seekers. They were to know exactly what happens to supposition that such explanations might serve as a useful guide for

Anahada Nada, Anahad Naad — the primordial cosmic sound dead person hears the sounds of the 'anahada nada' [footnote 132: vision of the consciousness of the Void. Looking at this great Light, the dazzling golden circle with a centre of dark-blue colour. This is the direct Radiance resembles a pure shimmering light in the form of a ring (sometimes earlier) he again sees the Higher Radiance. This time he begins to understand that he has already died. At this moment ceremony and the last rites being performed over his body, he gradually no one hears him. All his attempts are fruitless. Looking at the funeral realise that he has died. He sees his loved ones, tries to speak to them, but experiences a sense of emptiness. Until this moment the person does not At this time his consciousness, having lost the support of the body, will at once disappear, and the person will find himself outside the body. radiance, the person is frightened and tries to hide from it, the radiance person has a chance of merging with It. It, at the sight of this dreadful created his physical body, and the whole of Creation as well, then the confuse the person, and he remembers that it is this great Radiance that time and is suddenly brought out into bright sunlight. It this does not experienced by someone who has been locked in a dark room for a long people are frightened. This brief phenomenon is similar to the feeling Not having (or remembering) such an experience in the past, ordinarily receives a brief experience of perception of the great radiance of Time. the period when consciousness leaves the physical body, the person the dizzy sensation can last from a few moments to three or four days. In person leaves the body. Depending on the individual level of spirituality ringing of little bells are heard. At this time the consciousness of the dying sets in when the heart stops, and sounds like whistling, rumbling, or the death there arises a sense of lightness. A very strong feeling of dizziness When the breath slows at the moment of death, together with the fear of at the moment of death, he too will be liberated from the bonds of birth. It, knowing of them, the ordinary person is able to maintain fearlessness Time, a description is given of certain states that follow soon after death. practised yoga and have not been able to know the dazzling radiance of limited by a body. Moreover, especially for people who have not

the ancient Egyptian funerary text the "Book of Coming Forth into Day" is written somewhere at the start of the New Kingdom (around 1550 BCE) karmic predispositions.

The soul is eventually "drawn" into a womb according to individual as forty-nine days of wandering in various worlds before the next rebirth. The "Bardo Thödol", describes the post-mortem journey of consciousness and hell are also included in the package. The Tibetan Book of the Dead relies on a quite different system of credits and points, although heaven and peace in exchange for a righteous life. What actually happens to souls Various religions describe the afterlife differently, but all promise bliss music of liberation.

experienced practitioners can hear the roar and rumble of the Nada — the breathlessness and the sense of separation from the physical form. practices Krishna Yoga meet death every night through the state of but the reaction to this experience is strictly individual. Those who everyone equally. sooner or later every person must pass through death, identical algorithms; the Creator (whoever He or She may be) treats ...Physiologically any death from natural causes proceeds by almost radiance of Time."

death. Through death the yogin merges with the Light of all light, the experience while alive, in the physical body, therefore they do not fear compel them to be born again and again. Yogis acquire such an to their level of consciousness. They remain bound, and these bonds again. Those frightened by this experience go to heaven or hell, according the Radiance and be liberated from the agonising duty of being born radiance that manifested my consciousness, — then he can merge with able to keep the firm conviction: "This is my form. It is precisely this simultaneously from a thousand clouds. If the person is not afraid and is centre of the circle. They resemble the rumbling of thunder issuing sound — the sound that gives rise to everything.] proceeding from the the Void, the sound of the creation of the Universe; the sound beyond experienced inwardly in the higher states of meditation. It is the sound of

Prolonged oxygen-deprivation in the practice produced the sensation of
of the next incarnation.

transition into death — fear, protest, or anger — could affect the "quality,"
with the greatest transforming power. A negative reaction to the
acknowledging its inevitability, and even gave a feeling of joy of merging
trained the practitioner to meet the transition without fear,
...Nowhere was the art of dying taught better than in Kriya; this yoga

marking the path to liberation.

commentaries he explained this method, giving readers a road map and
rituals have been performed, the spirit can break out to the light. In the
between the moment of physical death and the funeral, before the last
they priest-intermediaries or god-intermediaries. In the short interval
themselves. A bold soul can refuse the patronage of intermediaries, be
the source. To the place from which everything came, even the Gods
may refuse the invitation to the next cycle of rebirths and try to return to
Erebor]. But there exists also a window of opportunity, when the soul
community or even a nation. The term "collective entity" is a synonym of
of people. Sometimes it is regarded as the collective mind of a religious
physical entity arising from the collective thoughts of a particular group
Erebor [footnote 130: Erebor — an esoteric concept representing a non-
subsequent transformation depends on the "customs" of the receiving
to a specific Deity. The last rites determine the destination, and the
burial, sky-burial, or water-burial — directs the spirit into a specific realm,
the last rites are sacred. What is done with the body — be it cremation,
many versions of "heaven" and "hell," but all religions agree on one thing:
Christianity and Islam, Judaism and the various tribal communities offer

which accompanied the deceased to the gods, to a new birth.

guarantee a smooth passage and assimilation. The spells were instructions
travel documents necessary for the journey — "visas" intended to
or sarcophagi. These records were issued by the priests and were the
called the scattered fragments of manuscripts placed in burial chambers
known to Western scholars as the Egyptian Book of the Dead. So are

after time, the memories of death are wiped clean.

Leaving the body, the soul forgets the trauma until the next journey. Time effective. Death leaves no memory and erases the details of every passage. door, a programmed safety mechanism — purely physiological, not very maximum benefit. And therefore the fear of death was an emergency difficult, and those to whom it was issued must use the prob with completion of an educational institution. To obtain a human body was educational prob, and the earthly experience was obligatory, like the playing in the astral jungles. Physical form fulfilled the role of an would want to leave the body and return to the astral world to keep mechanism. Without it the soul would not stay in the flesh for long: it At some moment he understood: fear of death is a safety buffer, a control

level;

making death part of the already known, even if on the subconscious retain some memory of it? And overcome the "phobia of death," by if the soul has experienced death countless times, shouldn't the mind horror of separation from the body anew. Quite naturally one might ask: of previous deaths are erased from the database, the spirit re-lives the registered by memory: fear is caused by the unknown. Since all memories People are not particularly afraid of what has already been processed and boat at the pier, the body awaited the return of the spirit...

of each samadhi was only another stop in a long journey. Like a sleeply Entering the logic trance was a return to the promised land: coming out ancient and forever new, anciently known and forgotten at the same time. metamorphoses of life was growing: the passage from body to spirit was understanding of the refined complexity of the various aspects of the light and remain there, but he kept at a respectful distance. The invisible, like a laser beam, the edge beckoned, inviting him to cross to the instinct, although the boundary between death and life was always near. gates of samadhi his apprehensions diminished, becoming a shadow of evoked the acute sense of being, of "I AM." With each passage through the separation from the body, death seemed inevitable, and this feeling

September, property disputes in his family intensified to such an extent public readings were held during the Jannashtami celebration. Around The Logic commentaries on the Gita were published in August 1995, and Arindham. Yoga Darshan. Shiva Sutras

For everyone needs a chance, and all deserve the right to choose. destinies – and therefore he wrote commentaries on the Gita for everyone. Even those who did not choose the path of yoga could change their discrimination, Krishna gave all souls a chance to complete their education. origin of life and the roots of the self. Compassionately, without examinations. The cycle of rebirths must lead to the realization of the cycle consists of tedious or engaging lessons, excursions, and formless state and merges with the source. Each new educational life The rotation of karmas continues until the soul overcomes the fear of the stand in line for the next birth.

and the soul will once more inscribe its name on the "waiting list" and preferences. In the end, the pull toward embodiment will again prevail, to which it is bound, through the faith of its ancestors or its own for a hint or a sign, until the final rites again direct it into the astral realm development. Life after life, it will remain in intermediate states, waiting Light means the soul will miss the chance to ascend to higher levels of ...the next "spaceunit" makes rebirth inevitable; refusal to merge with the losing the body and the need at once to obtain...

consciousness identically for all; only the destinies differ. The fear of The primal fear of separation from form is programmed in the how to act, not to react.

fate, and for that reason his commentaries to the Gita were instructions on with them or to return to the embodied state. Reactions always determine signs of Time, Light, and Sound, on the readiness of the soul to merge new life-cycle is assigned in dependence on the person's reaction to the individual karmas and prepared the next educational plan for souls. The But what exactly drove souls into new bodies? Time itself evaluated

Brhmaschari Aitrag Zwarub, who had so generously opened the ashram aspects of spirituality, this was a rarity.

the motley assortment of bandits specializing mainly in the religious engaged in logic sadhana and taught what he himself practiced. Among humor, and gave deeply meaningful answers. Moreover, he constantly unanimously agreed that he expounded the truth squarely, often with captivating and inspiring, not allowing visitors to doze off. Everyone author of commentaries on the Bhagavad Gita; his discourses were community, he became a sensation: young, charismatic, well-educated, exercises in the evening, sadhana at night. For the local spiritual endless tea, fresh topics for conversation during the day, physical tasks. At first it was entertaining, sometimes interesting: new faces, Vinodavan, and soon the ashram began to be visited by sadhus of all ... News of the arrival of the young yoga guru spread quickly through

firmly believed that higher forces would help their Guru survive.

within a day the money was spent on food and fodder. The students saga began. The budget for the foreseeable future was 5,000 rupees, and prepared dinner, the animals were settled, and the next chapter of the Doremans and four cows. Devahuti was already waiting for them with a They arrived in Vinodavan in the evening, in a truck, with two On October 2nd, about a dozen students and friends came to see them off.

as well as himself and several students.

to receive them. The place was large enough to accommodate cows, dogs, Nagar, and Brhmaschari Aitrag Zwarub, the owner of the ashram, agreed retired Colonel Mr. Shrivastava, knew of a vacant ashram in Cozhal and something materialized – very timely. The wife of his student, a put his cousin's approach was more practical. She made several inquiries, even if temporary. He continued to harbor hope of finding "his" palace, Devahuti was determined to find a refuge for both of them in Vinodavan,

mildly, did not support this yoga lifestyle and aspirations.

unbearable. Unlike Yogamandya's family, some of his relatives, to put it that further stay on the farm in the cottage became problematic, almost

It was believed that noble sadhus, alien to ideas of enrichment, occupied potential donor at first glance, he held no interest whatsoever.

have a single tube with him, so for the beggars, capable of identifying a definitely had cash in their pockets. The Jungs had no pockets; he did not formal "namaste", but stretched their hands toward the sadhus who dressed only in a Jungi, and the beggars respectfully greeted him with a themselves in woollen shawls. He was the only logi bare to the waist; participants in the parade were warmly dressed, additionally wrapping shawls from the passing sadhus. The winter day was quite cold; most. Walking through the crowded streets, he observed the beggars asking symbol of the future – at least, that is what the event organizers thought. representative of a new generation of spiritual leaders, he embodied a members of the holy community. Perfectly photogenic, an exemplary charismatic, the logi presented a striking contrast to the elderly "Acharya Shailendra, come forward...". Athletically built, young and in the front row of the procession; a loudspeaker insistently called out: pilgrims of all kinds and sympathizers. The organizers asked him to walk sadhus took part in the event, and the streets were flooded with crowds of campaign to rebuild the Rama temple in Ayodhya. More than 10,000 participate in a march of Hindu religious leaders in support of the One way or another, the owner of the ashram persuaded him to radiant flashes of Absolute Consciousness in practice.

and promises, mentally anticipating the silence of the night and the without giving direct consent, he politely listened to the effusive praise Parishad (World Hindu Council) party. Without refusing, but also politics awaited him. They even promised a position in the Vishva Hindu and the new acquaintances assured the young Guru that a great future in considered an indispensable condition for a successful election campaign, well-known. In India, the blessing and support of religious leaders is politicians and businessmen from the capital, some of whom were quite the Bhagavad Gita written by the guest, he began to bring prominent involved in political life. Impressed by the depth of the commentaries on doors for them, possessed excellent connections and was actively

bhanda would now pass to another recipient.

apologies – understanding that all the spiritual merit from conducting the merchant who had driven the beggar away came out into the street with braising Krishna, crowded around the ragged philanthropist. The wealthy tubers. The first event came to a halt because no one went there: people, various sweets and food, he spent, according to the vendors, over 200,000 dirtily rag, announced that he would conduct his own bhanda. Ordering down right opposite the tent and, pulling crisp new banknotes from a he looked too unrepresentable for a glamorous charity event. Then he sat beggar tried to get free food, but the event organizers drove him away – food is distributed to the poor or to anyone nearby. That day, a certain philanthropists as an offering to the deities. After the rituals are over, the food distribution, a bhanda. Usually, this is done on holidays by wealthy famous Banke Bihari temple, someone was conducting a free charitable with religion and politics, but certainly interesting. One day, near the ...Be that as it may, Vrindavan was a peculiar place. Filled to the brim

an unforgivable extravagance.

required precious time, and spending it on meaningless gatherings was participate in any future events. He had far greater goals. Sadhana The worthlessness of such public events made him flatly refuse to very far from the interests of enlightenment and illumination.

discovered that the true motives for creating spiritual organizations were talk. He felt like an outsider, just as he had in the Karat Ashram, when he easy it was to catch the "beggar syndrome", artfully disguised by spiritual of religion in the name of enrichment. Gradually, he began to realize how atmosphere was saturated with corruption, greed, and the shameless use not everyone was driven solely by mercantile motives, but the donations. Spirituality was a phantom, a convenient slogan. Of course, meals at lavish religious festivals, real estate deals, and collecting wore orange robes, but their thoughts were mostly occupied with free successful and prosperous beggars. The venerable saints of Vrindavan the top of the invisible hierarchy of alms-collecting, being simply more

and this eliminated all doubts. The knowledge growing from within supreme knowledge, assimilated and confirmed by practice, is invincible, Guitas had already been realized by him in the process of sadhana. unfolding and revealing its essence, the stages described in the Yoga poetic and inspiring. While dictating, he felt the depth of the text, the infiniteness of logic wisdom. He knew this work perfectly, priest yet philosophy. The text consists of four short chapters containing the of the logic tradition, one of the six traditional schools of Indian Guitas of Patanjali, also known as Yoga Darshan, is the foundational text four days wrote a series of commentaries, one chapter per day. The Yoga about the Yoga Guitas was asked. He answered, and over the following was served, the conversation was in full swing when the first question ...A few days after moving to the ashram, several students appeared. Ten during these months.

became merely the backdrop for the giant inner work that consumed him to prove that karmic justice still exists. Yet all these events and episodes students, and collecting some money, they gave it to the beggar – simply moralist cowered in his seat. He chipped in with the accompanying this scene, he shouted at the expert on the laws of karma, and the fat himself, tossed another portion of salted nuts into his mouth. Outraged by handout, I will disturb the Lord's plan!" – and the fat man, pleased with reaping the fruits of your karma, and I am reaping mine. If I give you a hand toward the open car window, but received a sharp rebuke: "You are self-satisfied. Hoping for alms, an emaciated beggar timidly reached his salted dried fruits, lounging in the passenger seat. He looked extremely with Delhi license plates. A man with a protruding belly was chewing. Another day, passing by the same temple, he noticed a parked minivan left an indelible memory.

siddha, giving others a lesson in true charity? Whoever this man was, he on scattered plates made of banana leaves. Was this man a disguised ragged man had vanished, and only stray cows melancholically chewed catch a glimpse of the disguised millionaire. But it was too late, the someone mentioned this incident, and he himself hurried to the temple to

brahmas. It is in Him that the brahmas of the great man who has known Him himself in the body in the form of brahmas. He is the Brahmas of all existing comes to an end, destroys it. Shiva Mahakala, the Great Time, manifests "...It is Shiva who creates the universe, sustains it, and, when its time mysteries of existence.

compare with the Shiva Sutras in their profound knowledge of the been Shiva, Shakti, and perhaps Dattatreya himself. Nothing could own experience, each expounding one chapter. The authors could have It seemed as if three great beings had gathered together, recounting their encoded in the original text, and he followed the flow of the sacred words. this lay the meaning of the great Path of life. All answers were already the body, inseminated by the mind, gave birth to consciousness – and in determining the sequence of the commentaries was surprisingly simple: precise words flowed, describing the most complex shlokas. The idea masterpiece surmounting in the imagination of a sculptor. Lascivious and their power, like music in the heart of a composer, or the form of a future nor uncertainty; the thoughts were whole, complete, and simply awaited its peak in the exposition of the Shiva Sutras. There was neither hesitation was a kind of building up of a philosophical culmination, which reached record his thoughts. The work on the commentary to the Bhagavad Gita whom he conversed with visitors, taking breaks during which he would day. More precisely, in seventeen hours, during which

He began to write commentaries on the sutras and completed them in one the most significant text of Shaivism.

short but multidimensional, and since then these 27 shlokas have become consisting of concise aphorisms about precise methods of realization, was discovered a huge stone with sutras carved upon it. The sacred text, spiritual knowledge bestowed by Him. The next day, Vasugupta Shankara Hill. Mahadev commanded him to study and disseminate the which Shiva himself commanded him to find a large stone in a cave on ...About 250 years ago, the Kashmiri Brahmin Vasugupta had a dream in echoed the text. Then the discussion turned to the Shiva Sutras.

was worried: the ashram was only a temporary refuge, and there was no household chores, preparing food, and replenishing supplies. Devanuri even a hint of the materialization of the palace from the visions. Busy with But from a practical point of view, things were going so-so. There was not sadhana in which the answers to all questions were contained.

stretched, and cracked his joints: the time for night sadhana had come. A beginning. With the departure of the visitors, he rose from the cot, was coming to an end, but his real "working day" was only just recent years and months had been expressed and explained. The long day falling into a state of trance had been described, and the experiences of topics about which it seemed almost impossible to speak without listeners... Having finished the last sentence, he felt immense satisfaction. At last,

Mahakala – or Time...

body-womb and came to know the Prana of all that exists, Shiva gives a hint as to how the great yogis developed their consciousness in the beyond it. He who has comprehended Time and recorded these sutras Time itself, which, although it pervades all that exists, always remains itself remains unchanged. The Prana of Matter and Emptiness is the Great which, being the basis of all movements and actions occurring within it, through the sense organs. The Shakti of the material world is Emptiness, the act of love is conscious Matter, the body of this world, perceived pervades Her. The result of the union of Time and conscious Emptiness in lying at the foundation of the consciousness of this conscious Emptiness, supporting all that exists. Emptiness pervades Time, and Time, the root this Great Time that conscious Emptiness manifests as energy, Shakti, Prana manifests itself and returns to Time, dissolving in Him. It is from connected with this highest Tattva – Time. Having emerged from Time, one with Him. Prana – the Breath of Life of all beings – is naturally consciousness, having comprehended the essence of Time, can become beyond all sensations and experiences. Only he who fully develops his world as Time. Although we constantly feel the flow of time, it remains the One Who, while existing, seems non-existent, who is perceived in this through death dissolves. Everything is naturally connected with Shiva –

was over. They politely took their leave and exited the hall, leaving traditional white scarves, said a few kind words, and with that, the visit significant. A pleasant elderly man, the Dalai Lama presented them with arrange an audience for them, but the event itself turned out to be not so joyful places of India. Lal Bapa managed to persuade certain lamas to Lama, who had recently received the Nobel Prize and was traveling to the enthusiastically took on the task of organizing a meeting with the Dalai become my Guru. Over the following days, the new disciple prostrated himself on the floor and requested initiation into yoga: "Please, momentous visit of Bapa! Upon seeing him, Lal Bapa immediately introduced in Sarnath in April 1988, just a couple of days after the ...Lal Bapa's real name was Gurbeshwar Singh Shastri. They had been and provisions were dwindling.

more and more fodder; students and visitors drank tea by the bucketful, there were no funds, their small herd had increased, and the cows needed Sarnath and stay as long as he wished. The offer was worth considering. Bapa persistently urged the Guru to visit the newly built ashram in A telephone call from a disciple was the prelude to a new beginning. Lal Sarnath, "Thorns and Roses," "The Wanderer,"

they were caught up by another wave of events. dissolved into the pale sky. The monkey-man kept his promise: very soon Pushing off from the wall, he flew into the air and, crossing over the river, "Yogi! don't worry about anything, I will make sure everything is fine." river. Suddenly this strange creature laughed, as if from being tickled: of a langur sat casually and relaxed against the wall of an old fort above a At night he had a strange dream: a monkey-like man with the black face further survival became more acute than ever.

poetry. There was little money, or rather, none at all, and the question of situation was difficult and hardly conducive to conversations about him, her Guru. She decided not to show him this poem, since their about her despair and uncertainty, and about the support she found in certainty about the future. During these weeks, she had written a poem

...Located just 10 kilometers from Varanasi, near the confluence of the Devanuti boarded the bus to the station. He did not look back.

Vinodavan was shrouded in milky-white February fog when he and Three disciples departed on the truck with the belongings and animals: possessions of refugees.

several crates of books, heavy mudgats, and kitchen utensils. The belongings were again loaded onto a truck: two Doremans, six cows, another move was depressing. But the decision was made, and their a cry for help. Constant homelessness was unsettling, the necessity of let is unlikely that the Dark God perceived his words as blackmail; rather, as completed, otherwise wishes and prayers will have the opposite effect. It to complete this barikrama... "It is believed that a barikrama must be me find a permanent home, otherwise I will not return, I will not be able only half the way, he addressed the Deity of the hill: "Gururaj, please help around Govardhan Hill. He was in a foul mood. And, having covered before leaving for Garma, it was decided to perform one more barikrama company, volunteered to pack all their belongings.

materialized, and one of the new disciples, an employee of a transport There were no funds for the move, but suddenly 50,000 rupees allowing him to focus on sadhana.

could be a welcome break from the daily worries about money and food. In the end, he and Devanuti decided to accept the invitation. Garma... After Lal Baba's telephone call, tense discussions lasted almost a week.

pocket of his kurta – and this was his most precious possession.

records of the kriya techniques dictated by Baba! was safely hidden in the valued souvenirs of a completely different kind. A small notebook with Master. The white ceremonial scarf was given away to someone; he than sadhana and the desire to explore the new techniques given by the impression from the meeting with Baba!; nothing had greater significance friendly head of Tibetan Buddhism. He was under the strongest behind the lamas in their ochre robes, the scent of incense, and the

these interests were not mutually exclusive.

India attracted both sincere seekers of truth and rashish lovers; often great disappointment such an item was absent from the ashram's menu. seeking not only wisdom but also a good bull from a chillum. To their logic of modern times. Sometimes among them were Western tourists, tourists to the ashram. They were promised an audience with the greatest official in the tourism department in Varanasi, began sending buses of gurus, a disciple of Shri Satyacharan Lahiri, now a high-ranking follower of an ordinary spiritual teacher. In addition, one of his curiosity: such a respected and powerful man as Lal Baba could not be a and villages, attended the dargahs daily. Everyone turned with and politicians, as well as hundreds of people from neighboring towns. Members of criminal groups, renowned sadhus, heads of other ashrams. News of the arrival of Lal Baba's spiritual mentor spread like wildfire.

people.

large halls and a reception area could accommodate several hundred was built for holding political symposia, seminars, and meetings; two hand man of the then Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar Singh. The ashram Benares and even the mafia, was involved in politics and was the right- Lal Baba, materially well-off and highly respected among the elite of

meditate in sacred but extremely noisy pilgrimage sites seek in vain.

from the city, providing the seclusion that all who have ever tried to and quiet; an ancient dried-up lake conveniently shielded the ashram. Located near a busy railway station, the place was surprisingly isolated. Baba built a Shakti temple there, the ashram became extremely popular. The place they were heading to was called Ashram Shakti Peeth. After Lal

people and sacred vibrations.

Jainism. Overall, this place is much quieter than Kashi, oversaturated with village of Singhpur, is also the birthplace of the eleventh tirthankara of Gautama Buddha taught the Dharma. Samath, or more precisely, the the town is well-known and visited, especially the Deer Park, where Ganga and Varuna, Samath is not as popular as its famous neighbor. Yet

an outlet.

Moved and filled with gratitude, he felt his emotions surge, demanding step into that future alongside him, no matter what.

faith, and the unknown future that awaited them. Devanuti was ready to devotion was pure and strong. Her poem spoke of uncertainty, destiny. Unable to find suitable words, he sat in silence for some time. His sister's

She handed him a folded sheet of paper with a poem she had written.

Shortly before the celebration of Holi, Devanuti, embarrassed,

Wars and battles over territory and influence were common.

illustrated the state of affairs in the spiritual world: unfortunately, clan complications, but the episode itself was quite unpleasant. In fact, it sacred book, backed by Lal Baba's reputation, dispelled all possible existent problem was resolved. The authorship of the commentary on the credential, the best of recommendations and business cards: the non-the Bhagavad Gita. The sacred book always acted as an excellent officers entered. He introduced himself and handed them each a copy of ashram was suddenly surrounded by several police jeeps. Two police Gaurang Nath by radical Hindu fanatics. When they had already returned, the monastery called the police and complained about a possible invasion of The event also caused some problems: the abbot of a nearby Buddhist

drums and saffron-colored flags – symbols of victory and strength.

necklaces on his bare chest and long, loose hair. The participants carried see the unusual march, led by a broad-shouldered yogin with rudraksha gathered. Along the procession route, people came out of their houses to just like the one a year earlier in Gwalior. More than 300 participants Gaurang Nath Mahadev temple; this was meant to be a symbolic procession. ...On Shivaratri, he proposed conducting a march to the famous

attention and sudden fame seriously interfered with his sadhana.

dreamed only of a quiet place for practice, but still found none. Unwanted He had no intention of becoming a crowd-pleasing commercial guru. He

both for himself personally and for those whom he "healed" from the in the decades to come. The bath of knowledge was also a bath of healing. Poetic, often sentimental words described what he would continue to do here...

with others. Let this be my farewell message when I am destined to leave. The thing I regret is that I could not share the pleasure of all that was done with flowers. I accepted the worst from others and gave my best. The only me, always removing thorns from wounded hearts and adorning them away all the best that I had. I gave all my treasures to those who came to The collection, titled "Thorns and Roses," began with the words: "I gave unrelated reflections on life and love deserved publication."

bagged and scraps of paper, until both realized that these seemingly fragments of thoughts, and Devanuri diligently collected these scattered ...Over the course of several months, he constantly recorded random

that he was not gathering followers, though he welcomed fellow travelers walking the same path. There were many of them, and to each he said "Traveler,"—it became a manifesto and a source of inspiration for seekers. Fifty-two poems appeared in three days. He named the anthology "The of his life."

the horizon symbolized logic heights, and this was the goal and meaning secondary. The true meaning of the seemingly impossible task of touching intention predetermined the outcome of the journey: everything else was intention to reach the goal, to touch the boundary between worlds. This marked by refined rhythms, yet they were created by the most powerful also romantic; he knew many by heart. The words that came were not Bollywood songs were filled with deep philosophical meaning and were the exquisite poetry of Kabir, Omar Khayyam, and Rumi. Some old ambition, he had never attempted to rhyme words, though he admired distant horizons a traveler strives toward. A stranger to any poetic feelings, and that same day he composed the first 10 poems—about the Devanuri's poem offered a possible format for expressing his own

Babaji could initiate a raja or a noble prince. But, given social restrictions logic knowledge was to be transmitted to descendants of royal blood. Humble householders were still monarchical. According to the scriptures, The times when Babaji decided to bestow this mystical yoga upon a vision and experiences of his sadhana.

his night samadhi around 4-4:30 a.m., Lahiri was still intoxicated by the "Look at this Bengali, already drunk since early morning!" Emerging from he walked to the Ganges to bathe in the pre-dawn hours, would joke: and joked, belonged to a merchant who, observing Lahiri Mahasaya as changed at all in the last hundred years. A small shop nearby, now empty ... The narrow lanes leading to the old house of Lahiri Mahasaya had not

his teacher, and Banamali's father was Abhaya Charan Lahiri.

Taracharan, Umacharan, and Satyacharan. Shri Satyacharan Lahiri was Tinkori Lahiri raised six sons: Kalicharan, Abhaya Charan, Ambikacharan,

Banamali Lahiri's, who still lived in the old house of Lahiri Mahasaya.

relationship was friendly, and he was always a welcome guest at Lahiri, the nephew of the late Guru. They had met before, their Samadhi was not far from Varanasi, and he sometimes visited Banamali

The Beginning of Spiritual Democracy. Another Life of Yogananda

called "Siddhanta."

but he knew: actions leading to a meaningful, lasting result were also specifics and scope of these duties were not yet fully appreciated by him, hesitation: a Guru of yoga, a guide appointed by the parampara. The ... If anyone were to ask about his occupation, he would answer without

name of a well-known text attributed to Siddha Gorakhnath¹³⁸.

one of the six main philosophical traditions of Shaivism, as well as the interested in Kriya. The name came of its own accord—it is the name of Academy¹³⁸," as he was certain that more and more people would become Around the same time, he registered the "Siddha Siddhanta Yoga

poison of illusory or real reality.

where Lahiri Mahasaya usually sat. Then he bowed to Banamali Lahiri shoes of the Teacher and to his folded dhori lying on the wooden cot. The newcomer was very serious. The visitor bowed to the pair of canvas toty.

and handsome man appeared in the doorway; he looked to be just over most interesting discussion was in full swing. Suddenly, a tall, well-built ... He and Banamali Lahiri were sitting in Lahiri Mahasaya's room, and a

snaps; the disciples apologized.

In this way, he demonstrated the equality of the logic brotherhood to the grew until one day Lahiri Mahasaya invited this disciple to sit beside him. into yoga and objected to his presence at group meetings. The tension Lahiri's circle expressed displeasure at the initiation of a low-caste Jaiswal winemakers. Due to the rigid caste hierarchy, the prahmin disciples in many centuries ago; some people of this clan became traders, others to the Jaiswal caste, which had branched off from the Kshatriya caste between classes. Unlike some of his disciples. There was a man belonging bath. Being a high-caste prahmin, Lahiri Mahasaya made no distinctions caste, gender, and age were not to become limitations on the spiritual. The stigma of caste still existed, but yogis treated everyone equally—

could now discover the divine principle within themselves.

sought blessings. Thus began a global spiritual awakening—everyone social status. And yet, he became a spiritual giant, from whom even rulers Lahiri Mahasaya was an ordinary man, a petty clerk with no particular accessible to all. Although he was a yogi in a past life, by all standards Lahiri Mahasaya proved: spiritual evolution within a single lifetime is tradition, a humble family man became a significant spiritual figure. rulers who left their kingdoms to perform austerities; in contrast to this a husband and father, was initiated into yoga. Ancient texts spoke of democracy was expressed in the fact that a middle-class prahmin, a clerk, history was approaching a new cycle of irreversible change, and spiritual able to continue transmitting the art of self-realization to others. Human and caste affiliations, members of the royal family would not have been

are always determined by Baraji himself and no one else."

"You see, the task of the subsequent birth of any Guru of the Paramhansa lineage;

Yoga... What is the meaning of this birth? Had he not attained spiritual seclusion, anonymously, in complete obscurity, concentrating only on his seekers. And yet he was reincarnated in a human body, living in the Western mentality and changed it, opening new spiritual perspectives. Undoubtedly, Yogananda was the greatest yogi who gently challenged world-famous, many new Kriya teachers gained recognition.

After Yogananda popularized Kriya Yoga, making the lineage of Baraji discipline of that group..."

not learned to endure any weather, he cannot follow the lifestyle and some special training; as long as a person is not free from disease and has become a companion of the immortal Master. Perhaps he is undergoing join that group. It is unknown what 'examination' one must pass to of immortals of Baraji. Banamali Lahiri smiled: "He is only preparing to completing his great mission, Paramahansa Yogananda joined the group. This was a staggering revelation. It had always been believed that after comes here..."

friend. As is his sadhana. Sometimes he just walks along the Canals and not married and has little contact with people. It seems solitude is his best inherited a good fortune. Finally, he can devote all his time to Yoga. He is incarnation, he lives in a house on the banks of the Canals, having Mukunda Lal Ghosh. Later he became known as Yogananda. In this new who that is?" — "Please, enlighten me." — "In his past life, his name was After the door closed behind the visitor, Banamali asked: "Do you know

the room, without losing his focused gaze and straight posture.

quiet. After five or six minutes, the man stood up, bowed again, and left. Lahiri Mahasaya himself, ticked with a rustling sound, the house was and quietly sat down in a corner. The large wooden wall clock, bought by

although they did not exchange a single word, both knew of each other's ...In 1997, under similar circumstances, he saw this man again. And

logi; memory of his past personality—was this not the highest reward for a His new life was devoid of obligations to society, he fully retained the spiritual realization, unburdened by responsibility for the fates of others. of. He was given what he so desired: obscurity and complete freedom for seemed Mukunda Lal Chopra had finally found the balance he dreamed life on the banks of the Ganges, filled with reflection and meditation. It autobiographically, where the author spoke of a strong desire for a peaceful They sat in silence for a while; he recalled lines from Yogabandha's himself.

intervention always has personal karmic consequences for the Teacher he can help them burn karmas, even if the smoke proves quite toxic. Such A spiritual teacher cannot change the direction of a disciple's destiny, but heroically fulfills the role of a connecting bridge between them and God. Banamali was right. The Guru takes on responsibility for his disciples and haven't you?..

Being a spiritual leader is hard work. You have already felt this yourself next tasks. A new life is necessary for working out accumulated karmas. —and Yogabandha succeeded. He accepted a new birth to prepare for the journey to America and his mission were a direct instruction from Babaji surrounded by the direct disciples of Lahiri Mahasaya. As you know, his disciple of Yuktiswar Giri, and he developed and perfected himself a Guru. He remembers everything he was taught. Yogabandha was a Banamali Lahiri replied softly: "On this earthly plane, he no longer needs guidance;

both in this reincarnation—since he continues his practice and may need needs to be a teacher. – Does he have a Teacher guiding him on the Kriya become a Guru of Kriya yoga in this, his current life? – No, he no longer about his past life? – I am sure he remembers everything. – Did he not He paused for a moment and asked Banamali: – Does this man know

During samadhi, the sense of individuality never dissolved or them to itself.

plane to the astral. Time itself calls out to them by name, summoning pronounced only in the astral worlds. After souls pass from the earthly. The name of the soul is given by its astral parents, and it can be introduce itself.

call out to him from the subtle plane. Definitely, the spirit was trying to unpronounceable, but someone or something persistently continued to phonetics. For some reason, the name of the spirit remained recreate either the amplitude of these notes or the specificity of the but the limited speech apparatus failed: his vocal cords simply could not fine, elusive, impossible to reproduce. He tried to repeat the motif aloud. The sound lasted about six or seven minutes; the variations were subtly came: this persistent melody signified the name of his own spirit.

that had been pursuing him for several days, until a sudden realization. Occupied with these thoughts, he paid no attention to the "white noise" about the future again hindered concentration.

contend with the predators of the astral expanses. The present uncertainty and will. Only steadfastness of mind and the strength of logic will could spoke in the dialect of the subtle worlds – and it was a language of power inhabited by friendly fairies and cute unicorns. Fierce ancient spirits necessity of solving everyday tasks. Moreover, the astral worlds were not The splendor of the inner cosmos could not fully compensate for the mention a palace) in the foreseeable future weighed heavily upon him. of money and prospects for finding a permanent place to live (not to The uncertainty was dragging on. They were still in Samadhi, and the lack That evening, while rotating the heavy mudgears, he was in a foul mood.

The Name of the Spirit. Devanuti's "Discovery,"

bound him to itself and held him for the subsequent 30 years.

bath and destiny. It was his last trip to Kashi. Soon, another city firmly

acquire the shamshan as property, at least not legally. Furthermore, the alterations to the existing structures, which was why no one wished to and architectural monument. This meant a ban on any changes or Archaeological Research had declared the complex a protected historical for sale, but the broker did not bother to mention that the Department of shamshan in nearby Govardhan. A large plot of land with buildings was inquiries was answered by a broker, who casually mentioned the royal continued her search for a house that might please them both. One of the she was furious, but upon returning to Mathura, she stubbornly becoming unsuitable for a young unmarried woman.

send Devahuti back to Mathura: the atmosphere in the ashram was and the necessary seclusion. All these factors influenced the decision to difficult to maintain the strict daily regimen that supported his sadhana individuals began to frequent the darsanas. It was becoming increasingly was increasing with alarming consistency. Even outright shadly expected miracles and personal blessings, the percentage of idle onlookers interested only in religious rituals and philosophical debates, some visitors began to gather whose interests were far from yoga; most were energies were becoming quite turbulent, often negative. Groups of ...Meanwhile, the dynamics of life in Sarmath were changing, and the mystery, he believed: one day it would be revealed.

certainly be its echo. And although the very birth of souls remained a were generated by the universal sound, the name of each soul could a melody or vibration. And this was not surprising: if physical bodies beings "on the other side," he knew their names, which could resound as But what did the name of the spirit mean? Sometimes, encountering astral and pivot of any living being. He always remembered his earthly name. sense of "I" was the worst of all possible ideas, since the "I" is the core aspirations. Contrary to some "spiritual teachings," getting rid of the helped preserve and maintain the sense of "I" with all its memories and own essence, and that essence was his soul. Atma, or spirit, whose power disappeared, he clearly knew what and who he was, felt the power of his

Raja's secretary, who arranged a visit to Govardhan. One sultry evening stayed at his aunt's house. A couple of days later, they contacted the the deal. While the legal procedures for the purchase were underway, he together to the heat-scorched Mathura to inspect the property and finalize Devahuti came for him in Samath, and in mid-May they returned

Arrival

The Land of Liberation

commentaries

Sharma lifting disciples during a break in the work on the Cita Abhishek at the Gupeshwar Temple, Mahashivaratri 1995 Shailendra

March of the Yogis, Cwalior, Mahashivaratri 1995

1995

"I found your palace..."

confirmed, and Devahuti called Samath to announce the news.

After fairly short negotiations, the preliminary decision to sell was memory of the Bharatpur dynasty with respect.

only wanted to be sure that the new owner would treat the history and rather than a trader or businessman, was the right decision. The Prince considered that transferring the ancestral cremation ground to a logic educated and possessing a sharp mind, the heir to the ancient dynasty from all the academic and religious expositions known to him. Brilliantly impressed: the logic interpretation of the sacred text differed radically Kumar Vishwendra Singh. He read the book with great interest and was poor health, and all financial affairs were handled by his son, Prince The owner of the shamshan, the old Raja of Bharatpur, was alive but in commentaries on the Cita written by her brother.

Devahuti sent the Crown Prince of Bharatpur a copy of the logic later. Meanwhile, having chosen an unconventional negotiation tactic, place was believed to be haunted, but all these details came to light much

your home."

cool breeze, and the voice of his heart whispered to him: "Now this is and memories. In the sultry darkness, they suddenly felt the touch of a night: this place was a kingdom of twilight beings, a refuge of mirages owl, glided against the palace walls. The shadows were a product of the forth, and the silhouettes of a flock of bats, pursued by the shadow of an At that same moment, a welcoming chorus of invisible peacocks burst the spirit of this place.

simultaneously realizing that the stranger was an astral being, perhaps disappeared into the darkness. He and Devanuti exchanged glances, teeth, and placed a garland of jasmine flowers around his neck – and be clearly seen. The laughter almost soundlessly, showing white, even uneven light, the stranger's dark face, her beautiful, cow-like eyes, could streetlamp dimly illuminated a small area near the gates, and in this details, he instantly absorbed all the nuances, forgetting to be surprised. A antique shoes were adorned with precious stones. Always attentive to below the knees, gold embroidery glittered in the dense twilight, and her meet them, dressed in a traditional red Rajasthani dress. The hem fell just suddenly, from the lower colonnade of the palace, a woman ran out to darkness; they entered the courtyard before the first building when The outlines of the palace were barely discernible in the thick, scorching intend to accompany them himself.

open. The secretary invited them to enter and look around, but he did not fence, pushed the key into the rusty lock. The heavy iron gates creaked answer. The secretary sent for the caretaker, who, slowly approaching the gates. Who was that man? The place was uninhabited, and no one could had come out of the gates to bow to him. They stood at those same rusty first barikramas, and the tall, gaunt stranger wrapped in a blanket who A sudden memory brought vivid images of a cold December night, the up to the gates of the shamshan, it was completely dark.

the car set off. When, after winding through narrow lanes, the car pulled around 8 o'clock, the secretary picked them up, and in the gathering dusk,

will have to visit both various heavenly worlds and the underworld, protect from the cycles of rebirth, and even the most pious, after death, prosperity to 13 generations of your lineage. But a royal title does not respect shown to me, and for the recognition of the Divine power, I grant the honored guest. The sadhu turned to the Raja: "For the honors and the shroud, the Raja stopped him, deciding that the hard work would be honored to dig the first handful of earth, but on the thirteenth stroke of new construction – to be performed at the chosen site. The saint was traditional ceremony of purification and worship of the earth before any of the fort and royal residence, the Raja ordered a Bhumi Puja – a from Govardhan, today it is called "Dig." Before starting the construction The sadhu showed a good place for the fort and palace, just 50 kilometers indicate a place suitable for the construction of the future structure.

The Raja bowed to the saint with the greatest reverence and asked him to nearby, a leopard and a cow were peacefully drinking water. Seeing this, place to build a fort, he noticed a sadhu sitting under a tree by a pond, the land of liberation. When the first Raja of the dynasty was seeking a Raja," but to the rulers of Bharatpur, it was known as Moksha Bhumi – The locals called this place "Rajawali Chattri" – "the memorials of the

The Legend

about to begin, and it promised to be interesting.

became the new owner of the royal shamsan. The next chapter was authenticate the transaction – and all formalities were completed. He ink imprint of his thumb on the document next to his signature to went smoothly and without any complications. The old Raja placed the suspicious sign. And so it was. The signing of the deed of ownership Rajputs, and he thought that encountering this grand procession was an legendary Maharana Pratap, the 24th ruler of Mewar from the Sisodia they had to stop due to traffic jams. It was a celebration of a folk hero, the of richly decorated elephants and fifty-two horses was crossing the city, documents. The streets of Mathura were overcrowded, a huge procession On June 6, 1993, he and Devshuti went to Bharatpur to sign the final

exclusively for him, as no one had ever lived in it before.

ancestors. He, however, preferred to think that the house was built
planned to stay there while visiting the cremation grounds of their
house had been built on the shamshan. Perhaps members of the royal family
was there that he and his sister took up residence. No one knew why this
Built in 1853, two memorial palaces neighbored a large white house – it

Ciphers.

unveiling.

which the drama of his own future was to unfold. And it awaited its
former grandeur of a bygone era; they were becoming the stage upon
Built for the Bharatpur royal dynasty, the palaces not only symbolized the
possible in this place.

that vision a projection of the future? It seemed that anything was
the message about the need to begin work on the Cita commentaries. Was
from under this tree that the sage (whoever he was) had conveyed to him
white-bearded old man sitting beneath it during a spiritual seance. It was
familiar. Quite recently, in Mathura, he and Devahuti had seen it and the
The old tree growing in front of the huge white house also looked
visions – everything fell into place.

Barahi about practicing at the shamshan, his own “fantasies” and recent
Satyacharan Lahiri about the crowds passing by the gates, the words of
describe to his laughing relatives as a child. The predictions of
the autumn of 1982. These were the very buildings he had tried to
mausoleums, he recognized the place he had first seen in meditation in
...In the daylight, looking at the majestic silhouettes of the palace-
for thirteen generations.

sadhu had predicted, the cremation ground served the Bharatpur dynasty
Govardhan and indicated the boundaries of the future shamshan. As the
cremated there will attain it.” The ascetic led the royal retinue to
However, I will show you a place of true liberation: anyone who is

and the earth itself plays its ancient hymn on the strings of bodies and means conductors, but merely musical instruments of a great orchestra, trackers, each individual is "connected" to the planet. People are by no earth element present in human bodies. With the help of these CBS silent melody is born not only from the planet itself, but also from the ...Often, people carry within themselves the vibrations of the earth, its song here.

Not everyone could live here permanently, and not all photographers could respect the Guru, but here, on the swastana, special energies reigned. The wall. Gauri Mahasaya and the paramhansa were always with him: he incidents continued until he simply ordered the photo taken down from. Numerous attempts to repair or remake the photo were in vain: the broke for no reason, or the photograph simply tore loose and fell, but something kept happening to it: either the glass cracked, or the frame in the upstairs room, they hung a large photograph of Gauri Mahasaya, wooden doors were restored and replaced.

erected for kings, and they could afford much. Gradually, all 108 heavily built with so many entrances, as doors are costly, but this building was almost all the doors had been stolen or broken. Houses in India are rarely. They counted one hundred and eight doorways in the house. Of course, some special, unknown idea.

right in the middle of the paramhansa around Govardhan Hill, certainly had architect who placed the large white mansion in the center of the swastana, internal, however, people might try to classify them. In any case, the are places for the distribution of various energies, both divine and friendly forces, the creative energy of Shakti dwells there. 20 crossroads other worlds. Indians believe that, along with other, not necessarily. In many cultures, crossroads are considered magical places, portals to there was a certain metaphysical meaning in the location of the building, exactly in the middle of the room he had chosen for himself. It seemed kind of crossroads of internal roads, and the center of these roads lay large, with elements of colonial architecture, the white house stood at a

Upon reaching the abode of Drona Giri, Pulastya
The mountain was a powerful conscious being and a great ascetic – a
visited a mountain called Drona Giri on a special matter.
The son of the Creator Brahma, the wise Pulastya once
Pulastya placed Him on the land of Vrisha...

Govardhan Hill turned green again, as in the days when the wise
surroundings: human worship and devotion generate tons of garbage.
enjoyed this hum. The fence prevented the relentless littering of the
of pilgrims on the hill did not affect his solitude at all, and he almost
one else lived on Girish permanently. Strangely, the noise of the crowds
kilometer perimeter of the hill – now he remained on the Hill alone, as no
peaceful, even subtle. A new fence was installed along the entire GI-
However, the harsh vibrations of Govardhan changed, becoming more
these sadhus went after the eviction remained unknown.

cities that had sprung up over the last two hundred years or so. Where all
the campaign to demolish illegally built ashrams and temporary tent
after he and his sister arrived in Govardhan. The most radical of all was
long-awaited improvements in this area began almost twenty-eight years
the police.

lived on the Hill until recently were evicted by officials or driven out by
current "spiritual lodger" of Girish. The other sadhus and holy people who
worth telling this story once more in the context of the biography of the
Mountains, as he is also called, is known throughout India. And yet it is
The story of Govardhan Hill, Govardhan Girish, or the King of

Girish

swelled into a crescendo. He came here to become part of the symphony.
continuous hum and vibrations of millions of bodies – this overture
the melody of the ancient hill was nourished by the powerful and
of bhajans, and the falsetto of mantras. On auspicious days, at full moon,
with loud music, the high voices of bhajits and street vendors, the tunes
hearts. For millennia, the melody of Govardhan Hill sounded, mingling

grew heavy: the tired Bhasya forgot his promise not to place Citra! Krishna will appear. Beholding Him, I will attain perfection." The hill himself: "I must not leave this place: here, on the banks of the Yamuna, time until he reached Vraja. Remembering his past life, Citra! said to Moving slowly and carefully, carrying the hill, Bhasya traveled for some bowed in prostration at his father's feet and sat on the wise's right hand. Kashi: "Only promise that you will stay where I place you...": Citra! Bhasya replied: "My dear, come into my arms, and I will carry you to my height two volumes, and I am heavy..."

me; My length is eight volumes, <sup>I&\sup> my width five volumes, of liberation." The young hill asked the wise: "How will you lift and carry Citra!": "Go with this sage to Brata-vatsha, the land of karma, the land "My son is very dear to me, but I fear your curse." And he addressed pierced by fatherly love, and tears flowed from his cave-like eyes. He said: Hearing Bhasya's words, Drona felt a surge of sorrow: his heart was

performing continuous austerities on the Hill, miracles would occur.

Bhasya knew: if he brought Citra! to Benares and worshipped Shiva, your son's divine body."

Kashi: I desire nothing other than to perform asceticism on the slopes of there is no mountain there. Therefore, I would like to bring your son to and the Lord Vishwanath himself has chosen this city as His abode. But Shiva. Sinners who die there are liberated: the holy Ganga flows there, prolong life. I have come from the eternal city of Kashi, the abode of gods worship you, you are rich in hearing herbs, you hear people and Bhasya bowed to Dronacharya: "O great Drona, lord of mountains, the

themselves from the samsara cycle of births and deaths...

revelation: this hill would grant liberation to all who seek to free peacocks danced among its greenery. At that moment, the wise had a streams murmured, caves darkened, birds sang, deer grazed, and birth to hills. The child-hill was beautiful: garbines bloomed on it, mention her name, but it is quite natural to assume that mountains give wise saw the hill Citra! playing on his mother's lap. Legend does not

At last, and the best thing about them was that sometimes they came true. restrained. Legends were everywhere; they nourished the very soil of long as the hill stands, the power of Kali. Yudha<sup>I48<\sup> is rise of the new cult of Krishna. Another, less known belief held that as triumph. This victory symbolized the decline of the Vedic gods and the forced to retreat, and Govardhan Hill became a symbol of Krishna's seven days like an umbrella, protecting the cattle and people. Indra was Vinodavan with torrential rains. Krishna lifted the Hill and held it for power struggle between the new and old gods, Indra tried to flood without a doubt, made a terrible mess of this world. As a result of the gaze on the Hill, Brahma's karma also diminishes, for the Creator. The name "Govardhan" means "nourisher of cows," and as long as they

30.

Creator gave the mountain the name Govardhana." Yogini Tantra 12:27-cows. Eating this grass, the cows were satisfied and happy. And then the sub> and raised a mountain, neither high nor low, abounding in food for the Creator sprinkled them with water from his kamandalu<sup>I48<\ "Having gathered the ashes remaining from the body of the quipya Keshin. Another peculiar and less known detail is mentioned in the Yogini Tantra:

geological research.

downward by a quarter of a millimeter per day, a fact confirmed by disappear entirely". Since then, Govardhan Hill has been steadily sinking submerging yourself daily by the size of a sesame seed, until you follow me to Varanasi. Therefore, you shall sink into the earth, the hill: "Presumptuous pillock, you did not fulfill my wish and refused to abandoning all attempts, with lips trembling with anger, Pulastya cursed ground, and I will not move from this spot, for such was my vow." Then Citra said softly to Pulastya: "O sage, you have placed me on the

gently coaxing him, the son of Drona Citra did not budge an inch.

it again using mystical powers. However, despite embracing Citra and the hill down on the ground, and it moved no further. The wish tried to lift anywhere except Varanasi. Exhausted by the heavy burden, the sage set

carved colonnades. From these choice specimens of primitive folk art, he systematic vandalism. Obscene graffiti adorned the walls and intricately everything that had not yet been stolen or broken was subjected to by local gangs as a base for overnight stays and illegal trade, and state of decay and desolation. For many years, the palaces had been used Bharatpur, seemed majestic only from a distance; the territory was in a Bharatpur Rajoon ki Chhatri, the Royal Memorial Palaces of the rulers of peace and meditative for several more long and harsh years. The neither running water nor toilets... Life on the royal summer was far from of necessary facilities; the place had been abandoned for many years, with on Badha Kund, overseeing the clearing of the land and the construction permanently. Throughout the long, hot summer, he lived in a guesthouse. It was only in September 1993 that he was finally able to move

The Battle of the Latrine Fields

liberation.

him here, to the most powerful summer of northern India. To the land of austerities on the holy hill. Something greater than mere luck had brought for it was he who was fortunate enough to live and perform logic thing could be said with certainty: he was luckier than the wise Pulastya, learned about his past lives, he decided not to draw any conclusions. One and old for that. Analyzing other stories about the Hill and what he had The Jats were not trying to flatter or play up to him; they were too wise

Covatghan Hill would stop sinking, and the curse would be lifted.

there where his body was consigned to fire in his past life. Then would find a Shivalingam and install it at the site of his own cremation, Hill – then in his next incarnation he would become a yogi. This yogi Pulastya's curse would be lifted if a king were cremated on Covatghan certain wise, whose name history did not preserve, predicted that about the Jat dynasty, but that day they spoke of an unusual prophecy: a silence, sipping tea. The old men remembered many stories and legends elders visited the summer. They sat in the summer hall for some time in In 2002, after the cremation of the Maharaja's cousin, two 80-year-old Jat

authorities. The show was repeated almost daily; he acted as the main being natives of Bial; they did not need complications with local arguments. The guards he hired watched the battles from a distance; to the territory; only the strength of muscles and a stick were weighty on local hoodlums. However, there were no other ways to defend the right using choice curses while slapping, kicking, and landing tangible blows. Western spiritual seekers may find it difficult to imagine a Yogi Curu with his fists.

him poured out. Almost daily, he had to defend his right to this territory began to challenge the new master of the swastika, the anger that filled everyone else it was to become the same. When the local shit-stirrers giant latrine. The past did not exist, the present was shitty, and for showing of obscenities, and the perception of the rest of the world as a could spur them to nothing but the regular production of feces, the continued to relieve themselves on the swastika. The wretchedness of life it an ideal place for morning evacuations. Nearly 800 local residents still territory was ungaurded, and therefore belonged to no one, which made The wall surrounding the swastika was broken in several places, the memory.

life in the North Indian province prevailed over any sentiment, feeling, or for the memory of the former rulers of Bharatpur. The harsh realities of did not care about historical monuments, they felt not the slightest respect literally symbolized the state of consciousness of the contemporaries: they past, which the majestic palaces recalled. Defecating on the king's grave territory symbolized an intention to destroy and defile the very idea of the repulsive as the filth left by humans. Perhaps the aggressive marking of desecrated. Cow dung, monkey feces, and dog droppings were not as a public open-air toilet, and even the cremation site of the Raja had been he felt a cold anger. Excrement was everywhere: the territory was used as Assessing the scale of the devastation and the vileness of the barbarism,

and the sexual preferences of the local inhabitants in particular.

learned much that was previously unknown about humanity in general

Instead of buying off the raiders with money, he chose to fight and wait to be located in the very heart of Govardhan.

He constantly had to prove his right to own the desirable plot of land piece of paper, even if signed by the previous owner, the old Raja himself. Indian towns are always complicated and troublesome. No one believed a attempt to provoke him. Selling land and real estate transactions in small demands for money and quickly turned into outright mockery and an impression at all. Dialogues began with absurd claims or insulting. For most inhabitants of the holy city, the sanctity of the place left no gate and demanded a meeting with the owner.

the same way: the guards would report that so-and-so was waiting at the possession of the most famous "haunted place" in Braj. All conflicts began bandit-priests, tried to pressure the newly arrived outsider who had taken the locals. Bandits of all stripes, together with the so-called mafia of lack of water and funds, but also because of the unceasing problems with Cultivating the land was practically impossible, not only because of the

Prisoner of the Dark Lord

difficult campaigns.

the Battle of the Lattine Fields won. Ahead of him lay many other, no less work. It took them several months to clear the nine acres—only then was the neutralizing alcoholic elixir and muttering curses, the sweepers set to Wrapping their faces in rags, slightly staggering under the influence of began daily to buy several liters of local moonshine for the cleaners. smashan was defiled in the literal sense. In the end, a plan emerged: he because the place was desecrated and befouled beyond all measure. The prejudices or frightening tales of the evil spirits of the smashan, but untouchable sweepers refused to enter the territory. Not because of operation to clear the territory, was about to begin. But even the Meanwhile, the epic "Battle of the Lattine Fields," as he called the other rite, changed constantly.

hero, while the rest of the cast, consisting of provocateurs, murderers, and

ordered Devanuri to back their page, as they were leaving immediately. backwater right now. Let's see who would try to take him prisoner. He place itself was hopeless and befouled—and he would leave this shitty the message made no sense, soundbites disturbed his peace daily, the Vaidji's excited story. Still not cooled down, he listened with half an ear: his brow, still in a rage, and this was by no means the best moment for boxing ring for receiving malicious visitors. He was wiping sweat from stood at the gate: the dusty area had already become an improvised ...At that very moment, another skirmish had just ended. The new owner convey the strange message.

were quite loud and unusual words, and Vaidji hurried to the smasman to go. This yogi will remain here forever." For a usually silent saint, these Lord of the Hill. And once it takes someone prisoner, the deity never lets dialect, he delivered his verdict: "This man is now a prisoner of the Dark the City. The saint had it read to him three times, and in the pure Brajvasi of the Pandit and once brought him a book with logic commentaries on doctor who often visited the new resident of the smasman, was a follower Govardhan. Vaid ji, or Gangadhar Upadhyay Vaidji, an old Ayurvedic ji," a respected man and, by common opinion, a true saint, lived in ...In those years, the renowned Pandit Gaya Prasad ji, or simply "Pandit was determined to stay.

home is not under siege. A lone stranger in these inhospitable lands, he should be adhered to as long as your family is not threatened and your Logic अहिंसा_{120} , that is, non-violence, is an excellent principle, and if him, the property was acquired legally, and he intended to live here. physical strength and the rage pulsing in his veins. The land belonged to or overtired opponents, and he offered no arguments other than brute fistfight. He was in excellent shape and much stronger than his emaciated A heated exchange of insults and threats was usually followed by a extortionists will return again.

to yield. He knew the unwritten rules well: if you pay even once, the see what would happen next. There was simply no money, not any reason

will not live long..." The voice sounded so distinct that it could not be a when an inner voice said: "Do not go now; after meeting you, the saint A few weeks later, he decided to visit the saint, and was about to do so staying and will accept whatever is destined to happen..."

coincidence. He turned to Devanuti: "We are not going anywhere. I am all four vehicles had broken down simultaneously could not be a simple something) was indeed trying to prevent him from leaving. The fact that By that time, his anger had cooled, and he understood: someone (or and fell silent.

in comfortably, the motor made a few coughing and growling sounds— Their luggage was loaded into the car for the fourth time, everyone settled promised to do so at Mathura station immediately after a successful trip. please bless the new car. I plan to start a tourism business..." He arrived from the car dealership in a brand new Maruti van. "Curly, There, an acquaintance from Agri was waiting for him, who had just of his car—and strode back to the swasthan.

curse from the last few months, he told his cousin everything he thought jeep and auto-rickshaw. Using his considerably expanded vocabulary of unclear. Emitting a screeching grind, it stopped right behind the ill-fated them to the station immediately. What happened to the car next was hoping to show off his recently purchased car; he was ordered to take At that same moment, his cousin drove into the swasthan courtyard, the transmission was broken.

jeep's gearbox emitted a dry crack—the vehicle stopped dead in its tracks: up to the temple, where the broken auto-rickshaw still stood, when the while, the watchman stopped a jeep, and they set off again. They drove He cursed the driver, and they had to walk back to their gate. After a temple, located just 100 meters from the swasthan, the auto's chain broke. the railway station in Mathura. When the rickshaw reached the nearest one dared to reason with him. They loaded into the auto and headed for green, rattling shell appeared almost immediately. Seeing his anger, no The useless gatekeeper was told to call an auto-rickshaw, and the yellow-

on.

against the insolent local bandits who harassed him almost daily, he held as well as a farmer, contractor, and boxer. Continuing to defend himself juggle numerous responsibilities, remaining a Guru and practicing yogi, clearing and repairs on the territory proceeded apace. He managed to the stars watched them through the gaps in the roof. The large-scale the evenings, they tried to warm themselves by a smoking fireplace, and woollen shawls under thick blankets, drinking endless cups of hot tea. In The first winter on the swasnan was cold and harsh, they slept wrapped in

The Last Confrontation

the present and let go of the past.

tendencies. The time was coming to support and preserve, to hold on to Shiva here, and this would create a new dynamic, giving rise to other to new energies and influences. In a few years, he would begin to worship the land, connected for millennia with the name of Krishna, was opening settle on the swasnan. Times and places were undergoing radical changes: true saint of Braj had given the last darsnan to the first yogi who dared to Recalling the farewell visit, he gradually realized its symbolism: the last

But what exactly was this grace?

nothing other than the grace of the Dark Lord of the Hill, Giriraj Maharaj. widespread belief that a peaceful death at this age near the Holy Hill is 4 o'clock in the morning, Ganga Prasad Ji left his body. In Vrindavan, there is a bowed to the dying man and returned to the swasnan. That same night at house. The saint was unconscious. There was nothing much to do, he It was early evening, around five o'clock, when they came to Pandit Ji's sounded: "Pandit Ji will not attain liberation until you come to him."

When Vaidji suggested visiting the dying man, the same familiar voice Several months passed; the saint fell seriously ill and slipped into a coma. of the place, Govardhan Maharaj himself. The visit was postponed. fragment of the imagination; its only possessor could be the ruler and deity

office searching for the fugitive, the doctor sent them on a false trail. With the doctor was certainly risking his life. When the gangsters burst into the scene from a Bollywood film, except the blood and knives were real, and three sides by heavy oak panels, crouched at his feet. It was a perfect and calmly continued filling out papers, while the gangster, enclosed on The doctor hid the unexpected "patient" under a large table in his office house.

Mathura, pursued by assassins, and tried to take shelter in a doctor's bloodied and wounded, the monster had fled through the streets of uncle had saved the life of the gang leader, her husband. That day, came up – and the wife of the mafia boss heard it. Some time ago, the When the gang was discussing the raid, the name of his uncle somehow investigation.

would gain the property: they were certain there would be no not think of putting up resistance. Having finished him off, the bandits relatively easily, since he lived alone, except for a few guards who would new plan – simply to kill the new owner. The plan could be carried out planned attacks and provocations ended in failure, the things matched a transaction was completed – but not for the gang. After a series of property to a young lord. All legal formalities were observed, the To acquire the royal cremation ground, but the old raja had sold the of many unfortunate over property deals. Some time ago, they had tried In Mathura, there was a gang of raiders known for the merciless murder came. A couple of days later, the whole story became known.

being prepared against him, no less. They waited all night, but no one confirmed rumors were spreading that an assassination attempt was One day, his sister returned from Mathura with alarming news: sharply with the coarse, angry tension of the days.

and the grandeur of death, and these pacifying energies contrasted of pranic energy filled his heart with wonder at the preciousness of life At night, during sadhana, the essence of the Universal laws and the power

...Carefully carrying a heavy rifle as if it were a shovel or a broom, the
murder. Even the police took precautions when entering their area.
native of this glorious place could be hired for extortion, robbery, or
"criminal" village, whose inhabitants "specialized" in various crimes. Any
Most of the local thugs and hired bandits came from one notoriously
language of brute force. Here in Covadour, it was exactly the same.
primitive, and the only language they understood and respected was the
of sustaining constant rage. The motives guiding these people were
ruthlessness and toughness were cultivated, contrived. No one was capable
and showdowns" – they were the most ordinary people, and all the
and manners well, he was not particularly impressed by their "posturing
"tough guys" when they came to work out. Having studied their behavior
...In Covadour, while visiting the gym, he often observed the so-called

alone and felt not the slightest fear, only irritation and disgust.
when he had to defend his right to this place, to live here. This time he was
perseverance and will. Besides, they had nowhere else to go. Just as now,
fistsights. Back then they were outnumbered, yet they survived through
him; he was no stranger to conflicts involving threats, shootouts, and
The time when he helped his brother manage a large farm had toughened
confrontations continued nonetheless.

Certain notions of honor live even in hardened hearts. Through
cremation ground is the doctor's nephew;" – and he called off the pit-
scoondrel!" The mobster was genuinely surprised: "So the logs from the
saved your worthless life! Woe is me, I am married to an ungrateful
a rage: "You bastard! You're going to kill the nephew of the very man who
Realizing who the target of the assassination was, the mafia wife flew into
of his savior.

legendary. Now this same gangster was planning to murder the nephew
left empty-handed, and the story of the miraculous rescue became
not breath of the man hiding under the table on his calves. The bandits
restrained dignity, giving explanations to the uninvited guests, he felt the

one upon seeing a dog or cat run over on the road, though he could not. The news was rather sad. A sadness of the kind that usually comes over

hit by a bus right in front of the police station. Crushed to bits...

news: ten minutes after the bandit had left the cremation ground, he was

Meanwhile, it grew dark. Around seven o'clock, the watchman brought

with hardened criminals, and yet waiting it out was better than fleeing.

useless guards and a few hired workers. This "guard" could not compete

reason for concern: they were just the two of them, not counting the

he calmly replied: "Let's see what happens next." There was plenty of

happen when these bandits show up." Trying to disbel her nervousness,

Hearing about the threats, Devanuri grew seriously worried: "What will

sway.

"Come, I'll be waiting." Growing opacities, the beaten gangster jumped

tractor trailers and break every bone in your body!"

tonight I'll bring all my men! We'll storm this place with four or five

ground: "You think you're so strong, but you're all alone here – and

shots. Crowing with pain and wiping blood, the bandit rose from the

thorough beating, making sure the blows landed on the most painful

opscene abuse, seasoning the fight. He gave the uninvited visitor a

gate. To begin with, they exchanged a few introductory words, then came

Enveloped in a cloud of his reputation's glory, the monster waited at the

reputation, and he insists on meeting you."

"Please, sir, hurry! This is a very dangerous man with a terrible

the "privilege" of the employer.

being a local, the guard could not stand up to local crime bosses. This was

all? Why am I paying him?" The answer, of course, was well known:

protect the owner from uninvited guests. "Why keep this useless idiot at

yet another brawl was delivered by his employee, who was supposed to

has come to fight you, waiting at the gate..." Just like that, an invitation to

guard entered the room with an apologetic look: "Sir, there is a man who

known about any other kind of spiritual practice: pranayamas and in the local slang, "brajan," meant any kind of religious worship. Little was

visitors, and at night he was occupied with "brajans" until dawn.

The workers only knew that during the day the master held darshans for no consequence. Yoga was an exotic craft of wandering fakirs, a whim. What this yoga was and exactly what the new owner did at night was of

He was certain the newcomer would not stay long.

did not consider the young, broad-shouldered yogi to be anything special. entire life in Braj; he had seen enough sadhus and so-called swamis and he was clever and tenacious. The cowherd was born and had lived his stretched Shyam's thin lips; his narrowed eyes looked out with mockery; he was the same age as his employer. It was hard to tell. A smile never relentless sun in the winter cold, and in hard labor. It was quite possible young; his appearance fully matched the number of years spent under the Even when he was first hired, the cowherd did not look particularly

Krishna.

separated from their calves – such was the custom of Braj since the time of gradually grew. They gave as much milk as they wanted, they were not continued to pick up injured homeless bulls and cows, and their number Vrindavan. At first there were few cows, but Devadutt persistently ever since the small herd had arrived at the cremation ground from Shyam, the chief cowherd, had worked for them for twenty-nine years,

Saving the Worker Fater

with him disappeared for a long time. Almost forever.

after others' property diminished, and those wishing to "settle scores," incident added spice to his reputation; for a while, the number of murders problem had turned to ashes on a funeral pyre and vanished. This corpse. Flattened by the bus wheels, rolled in blood and dust, the recent still ached from the blows to the cheekbones of one who was already a even remember the bruised and bloodied face of that man. His knuckles

For the inhabitants of Braj, the manifestation of supernatural strength in the first time as a sign of respect. The cowherd bowed before him first doorway. That day, all the workers, one after another, touched his feet for workers rushed to help, and in a single surge, the beam was laid over the load alone, he shouted: "You bastards, where have you gone!!". The workers stood motionless. Realizing he was holding the 320-kilogram expecting to be crushed to pulp. Sensing the impending tragedy, he above his head without hesitation, supporting the beam. Father froze, rush: throwing his ever-present walking stick aside, he stretched his arms. What followed next could probably only be explained by an adrenaline stone block, afraid they would be crushed.

shouted, it's going, it's falling!..." – and everyone recoiled, dropping the perfectly aligned. Suddenly someone shouted, people shouted: "Oh! It's stuck his head under the raised beam to make sure all the angles were had to be raised and placed over the doorway. One of the workers, Father, guiding one end onto a supporting column. The other end of the beam using ropes, wooden blocks, and bars, the workers began to lift the beam, we do this."

be present during the most critical work: "Cuntaji, please just be here while labored under the direction of the chief mason, who always asked him to be placed onto the load-bearing walls of a doorway. About 12 workers on the lawn in front of the house. That day, a large stone beam needed to and ceiling beams weighing around 320 kilograms were stacked outside, internal partitions were erected, forming new rooms. Huge stone slabs building to its original state. Some picked-up doorways were reopened, house needed major reconstruction, and he intended to return the Repair and restoration work continued through the winter of 1990: the worship the Dark Lord of Govardhan Hill.

Braj the "specialization" of Krishna's followers, and true Brajwasis For the last 400 years, love for the Divine, bhakti, has been considered in meditations were considered quirks, side effects of religious fervor.

officers – and from time to time, officers with heavy carbines would come. Sidha Sidhanta Academy, and dormitories were built for the batra. The coolers with water were installed at the local police station of the clean the road.

plantation, cleared lands, planted trees on barren soil, and hired people to special pretext, he provided farmers with access to water from his bions, if impractical, deeds. During a drought, and later without any several years later, his presence in Govardhan began to be associated with this lifestyle was common among the local „poor scholars.“

prescribed to random simpletons who wandered in for a cup of free tea – before this incident, the workers thought the master only ate, slept, and the grace of the gods.

in the face and remain unharmed. All this could only have happened by had happened to be in a place famous for spirits and ghosts, to look death and resides, the story was told by an eyewitness and participant, one who listen. And the townspeople listened, because creating death is not easy, divine intervention and the superpowers of Curly to anyone willing to. Whenever in a good mood, the worker Father would tell the story of millimeter.

stacked on the lawn in front of the house – and could not move it a single few days later, he opportunely tried to lift one of the stone beams still have convinced the Brahmins of the authenticity of his spiritual power. A was unconditionally accepted as a true saint, since no other proof could superhuman strength of their taciturn employer, and from that day on, he everywhere. That day, people saw the manifestation of His power in the any low-caste sweeper or child will say without hesitation: God is. These people never sought God, knowing exactly where He was. In India, observe conspiracy and purity, could explain the reason for such a miracle. alone, and only the patronage of Hanuman, merciful to those who people knew: only a true prahmaran could hold such colossal weight reminding them of the fragility and transience of life. These „uneducated“ life-and-death situations confirmed the divine presence, while also

ball to his chest, lost consciousness. This man never fully recovered from had tried to stop a penalty kick and, receiving a powerful blow from the famous sports club in India and Asia, the Mohun Bagan Athletic Club, he asked for help. Once, a successful goalkeeper for the oldest and most come to see the new Club – this man was one of the visitors. He had seen only once. Back then, in 1987 in Assam, hundreds of people had The next day, an unexpected visitor arrived from Bengal, whom he had was part of a larger plan. With these thoughts, he fell asleep.

money would appear, and the people would be paid – because all of this involved in the process. He was merely a manager, an intermediary, the the work of improvement and clearing would take care of everyone forces that had brought him to the mansion and compelled him to begin over the situation, he could not sleep. Until it dawned on him: the same indefinite payday – they had families to feed. From the stress and anxiety funds. It was naive to think the day laborers would agree to wait for and remained until the appointed date, but there was nowhere to obtain the workers were hired, promised payment at the end of the month, two days irrigation ditches still needed to be completed. More than a hundred dilapidated buildings demolished, and the system of internal roads and The stubborn cactus growing everywhere had to be uprooted, the

On Visitors, Prophets, and the Fruits of Karma

of changing the existing state of affairs.

Govardhan Hill, he could count only on himself, and he had no intention well-wishers. Apart from the support of the barampara and the grace of Depts and bills were paid on time, he was dependent on no one, not even in the last thirty years – and this in itself was astonishing.

truly religious man, who had not abandoned his sadhana for a single day Gradually, he built a solid reputation in Braj as a philanthropist and a teachers, bakers, and visiting Europeans.

hall. They blended perfectly into the motley crowd of peasants, lawyers, to pay their respects and drink a cup of tea in the coolness of the darsan

seminars. He had no intention of going anywhere to give talks; he had payment for initiation into yoga, gave no paid lectures, and conducted no seminars. His invisible accountant was making sure the show went on. He took no cash money, they barely scraped together enough to cover expenses, as if miraculously, although somehow he managed to pay wages on time. At the end of the month, he paid the workers. "This is how we manage..." jokes aside, times were paid. Money was into his wallet and handed over the requested sum. He accepted the note: He signed: "Give me fifty rupees." Caught off guard, the uncle reached manage the finances;

"Share me all that spiritual nonsense, answer honestly – how do you manage the grace of Lord Govardhan Hill, Barahi, and the barabaras..." financially speaking;

longer, the retired uncle demanded answers: "How do you manage wages, and the volume of work. Then, unable to restrain himself any longer, calculating the possible expenses, the number of workers, their food, he carefully observed the activities on the campus, spending whole days. Around the same time, an elderly relative visited him. A former military officer, he had been paid to the workers. Sometimes the laws of karma worked perfectly. donation, and the sum was mysteriously equal to the amount that needed savior. On that miraculous June evening, he arrived in Govardhan with a money he had received as compensation for medical expenses to his merciful healed the goalkeeper. The footballer decided to give all the he kept under the tongue. Within a few weeks, the alchemically processed the visitor: "From today, everything will be fine." The magical pill was to felt in the pocket of his kurta for a pellet of solid mercury and handed it to this vision, the goalkeeper was back on the field. Obeying an impulse, he heard, followed by an instantaneous flash of a vision of the future, and in Having heard the story, he felt a hot wave of compassion rising to his no improvement.

covered the costs of his treatment in Germany and England, but there was consciousness. Since he was an excellent goalkeeper, the club paid fully the injury: he continued to cough up blood and occasionally lose

blossoms of the trees, the quiet whisper of the harvests, and the serenades the land currency of the ever-changing beauty of the seasons, the house, and the plantation. The land paid him generously for his care with came in was invested in the repair and maintenance of the farm, the the large estate required constant financial input, and every rubee that were no other sources of income. His personal needs were minimal, but received a share as an inheritance. Apart from voluntary offerings, there After selling the land that had belonged to his deceased father, he had never been on his list of priorities.

marriage to an unemployed man – and this suited him perfectly. Marriage “necessity” of marriage. No family would agree to give their daughter in balance. Moreover, the lack of a steady income saved him from the the most famous unemployed man in Cwajior who happened to own a Having never worked anywhere, he often joked about it, saying he was the art of yoga seemed impossible.

themselves. He followed the same principles, and putting a price tag on voluntary offerings from students, allowing each to determine the amount Satyacharan Lahiri was very strict in this regard and accepted only None of the teachers in this lineage ever charged for knowledge. But everyone ends up there at the journey's end.

smashans are avoided due to superstitions and gloomy thoughts of death, infrastructure, as it provided final, one-time services. Although in India, the smashan, the cremation ground was still part of the social loosen its grip. And even despite the minimal contact between society and participate in any schemes of enrichment, the system may reluctantly society objectively only by severing all ties with it. If a person does not contradiction of the logic code. In ancient times, yogis managed to look at For someone living on the smashan, any commercial activity would be a the nightly sadhana required complete focus and presence.

knew enough about each other. He had plenty of other things to do, and seen the world, and the world had seen his best and worst sides, and both

was impossible to measure or classify.

"open," pouring out a stream of compassion and blessing; however, it And this was indeed happening: sometimes his heart would involuntarily that he felt an immense energy flowing from the teacher to the devotee.

...Watching the disciples prostrating before the Guru, this visitor declared tours, and seminars. In other words, he would become an employee.

catch: the organization would take full charge of organizing his schedule, residences and private jets were only a matter of time... But there was a success and popularity of the new "spiritual messiah": luxurious research. Skilled PR managers and promoters were to ensure the crushing The officer promised him considerable fees for participating in the real people...

prophets. Who knows, perhaps the film's characters were "sketched" from the famous science fiction film The Matrix, directed by the Wachowski It is worth noting: all this took place in 2001, two years after the release of nothing.

of a kind..." This statement was intriguing, though it explained absolutely possesses the most powerful earth energy. Connected to Jupiter, he is one Shiva? This man's Muladhara chakra is the brightest on the planet; he chief oracle, like in the film The Matrix. She said: "You are asking about mediums, a ninety-three-year-old African American woman, a kind of photograph of the young guru and showed it to me, or rather one of the information about Kiyra Yoga on a website, the officer printed out a assemble a team of fairly strong mediums. Having stumbled upon for people with extrasensory abilities. Over time, they had managed to phenomena. This man represented a government-funded group searching foreign state, who was involved in a program for researching paranormal with newly converted yoga adepts) came from a high-ranking officer of a quite unusual. For instance, an invitation to go abroad (to fill stadiums Over the years, he received various "commercial offers," and some were of the birds.

galvanized coverings. Getting rid of them was problematic: they the roofs of houses, their toxic droppings corroding even plastic and The vultures were a real scourge of the area: they persistently occupied his wings, headed northwest. The flock followed him.

Taking only three sips, he rose again into the air and, powerfully beating the others. The leader slowly strode to the water, and the flock parted. the king of the vultures. He was at least one and a half times larger than electricity. The last to descend majestically, slowing before landing, was had subtly changed, as if the summer heat had become charged with shade of the tree, sheltering from the scorching sun. Something in the air Having quenched their thirst, the birds nudged in a tight circle in the their wings, and hurried to drink from the puddles and irrigation ditches. brownish birds landed in the northern part of the garden, leisurely folded gather under a huge bival tree. One after another, more than 300 large. At the end of June 1992, around noon, hundreds of vultures began to

The King is Dead, Long Live the King

exactly where he was supposed to be.

interesting. But leaving the assassin was out of the question. He was The visitor returned three times, and conversing with him was quite employed in all sorts of scandals.

people trying to profit from spiritual teachings almost always end up yoga. He valued his independence. Moreover, he was well aware that the end, can become an obstacle to the only thing that concerned him – inevitably creates a web of financial obligations and dependencies, and in “enlightener,” held no interest whatsoever. Any commercial scheme For him personally, the role of a “business guru,” an advertised of the organization he represented were not particularly original.

psychic: yoga was a secondary subject. Upon closer examination, the goals revolved mainly around paranormal abilities and their impact on the demonstrated his radiant aura. The officer was astounded. His interests As a courteous host, he tried to entertain the guest and once

properties. Raj is famous for sorcery and black magic, and he used in certain rituals, as they possess the most powerful magical parts of the royal remains. In India, it is believed that such relics can be This custom has its basis: sometimes tantrics try to obtain bones or other By custom, the royal family left four or five guards at the funeral pyre. princely state of Bharatpur from 1859 to 1897.

121 Maharaja Brijendra Singh (01.12.1818 – 08.07.1892) – ruler of the funeral pyre was still smoldering, the atmosphere was eerie. From the terrace, the amber glow of the embers was visible; the raja's disciples from Bengal joined them from Devarahi; dinner was served. ...The cremation ended, the visitors dispersed. It was quite late. Several him as a true ruler and a worthy man.

fulfilled. Although they had met only once, the Maharaja had impressed would be cremated on the land of his ancestors, and this agreement was new owner, the parties had agreed that the last Maharaja of Bharatpur. When signing the documents for the transfer of the royal smashtan to the the smashtan.

evening, the solemn procession reached Govardhan, and crowds flooded people accompanied the deceased raja on his final journey. Towards military escort and a ceremonial gun salute. On July 8, 1892, thousands of The old raja was accorded a state funeral, with a guard of honor, a finite.

echo of the past fell silent. The era of kings was over; like any era, it was reminder of the past glory of Indian kingdoms, and with his passing, the Singh₁₂₁, duly anointed upon his ascension to the throne, was a fading last ruler of the Bharatpur dynasty died the next day. Maharaja Brijendra could mean bad news for the royal family – and he was not mistaken. The dome of one of the palaces cracked and fell. He immediately thought this Five days after this event, a small stone canopy adorning the spire of the invariably returned. But that day, they were seen for the last time.

idle rumors and gossip dissipated.

character, now lived on the royal shamshan. The prince's plan worked—educated author, a spiritual seeker, and not some shady random was meant to defuse the atmosphere; everyone was to learn that an were reasons for this: the distribution of 100 copies of the Bhagavad Gita among the guests who had attended the last rites of the old Raja. There commentaries on the Gita, written by the new inhabitant of the shamshan they became friends. The prince expressed a desire to distribute the logic they and the prince had time for a substantial conversation, after which ashes from the funeral pyre, as custom required. And for the first time, On the third day after the cremation, the prince returned to collect the undesirable complications, including reputational ones.

aftertaste; some formed a bad impression—and this could lead to various perform tantric rituals, or worse? Rumors and innuendos left a certain and looked so self-assured? What did he intend to do here—perhaps Who was this stranger who dared to become the owner of royal property Baba, as some called him, with open curiosity and undisguised suspicion. given to a stranger, an unknown logic. The guests examined the Agni knew that the original resting place for the ashes of the last kings had been gathered to bid farewell to the Raja were influential people. And they all real chances for a bright political future. Many of the VIP guests who had ...Prince Vishwendra Singh had extensive connections, as well as very

rounds of the shamshan.

decided that Bhairava himself, with his fearsome rounds, was making his accompanied by terrible creatures with burning eyes. Perhaps they the sight of the broad-shouldered figure emerging from the darkness, owner remained in the house, yet they could not overcome the terror at fled in panic, jumping over the fence. Yes, they had been told that the new in the darkness like red coals, rushed towards the pyre, and the guards and were now whining impatiently. Two Doremans, with eyes burning The time came to walk the dogs, who had been locked in the house all day precautions were far from superfluous.

royal lineage in past lives; people could believe what they wished. And completely dismissed as tall tales. He did not try to refute belonging to a theories about his origin were not encouraged, though neither were they whose features bore an incredible resemblance to his own. Rumors and His double was captured everywhere: a handsome, smiling young man the turn of the century, and an old, black-and-white documentary film. Once, his disciples obtained old photographs of the royal family, taken at expressions, especially if they were sincere.

stories were told. Never neglecting devotion and faith, he respected their gazing at him. Tea was served, some legends were discussed, and new They were invited into the dargah hall, and for some time the Jats sat has returned, the King has returned!..

the stone terrace of the palace, whispering among themselves: "The King Being devoted to the ruler of Bharatpur, they prostrated themselves on ordinary appearance made an unexpectedly deep impression on the Jats. as usual, he was inspecting the improvement works, but his quite taken place. In the distance, they noticed a man in a white kurti, that day, abandoned and desecrated, and now rejoiced at the changes that had admiring the lush greenery: they all remembered the shamsan as the pilgrims onto the grounds. The Jats wandered through the garden, visitors, learned that they were from the same village as himself—and let The guard, Digambar Singh, who struck up a conversation with the the neighboring city of Diga, where a large Jat community still lived.

his royal palace was located just twenty kilometers from Govardhan, in Bharatpur was founded by Raja Suraj Mal in the eighteenth century, and rulers, and they had been here before. The prosperous kingdom of not random pilgrims. The royal shamsan was the resting place of their the gates of the shamsan. There were about fifty of them, and they were Ten years after the death of the old Raja, a group of elderly Jats entered already dwelling among the echoing colonnades of the memorial palace. Canga, and his spirit joined the ancestors of twelve previous generations. The ashes of the old Raja were taken to Haridwar and scattered over the

divine incarnations of the Nagas—descendants of the sacred serpent practitioner of yoga) for their ability to tame snakes, which are considered call the Sabers "logis" (the term usually means a royal man, not a the word "Kalbelia" itself meant "catcher of black (snakes)." Villagers often The Sabers were originally from Rajasthan, a branch of the Kalbelia tribe:

Bhram Nath, who belonged to the Sabers clan.

this "tail" stirred slightly. They decided to call the local snake charmer, was a tiger's tail lying between the columns of the arcade; then the tip of of the palace, and he went to look at the reptile. The first thing he saw One evening, workers informed him of an unusual snake spotted near one

The Snake Charmer's Mantra

earthly plane, but also in the astral spheres.

societies were spreading rapidly. And this was happening not only on the new forces were coming into play, new trends in the development of general. Not only on the Indian subcontinent, but throughout the world, decline of royal lines, and the disappearance of monarchical power in disappearance of the virtues symbolized the end of dynasties, the directly connected to the passing of the last Raja of Bharatpur. The He was certain that the last sip of water taken by the king of virtues was laws of spiritual evolution and predestined karmic justice.

just and great deeds, he becomes a yogi. This is an ideal description of the performs great tasks, he becomes a king; and if, being a ruler, he performs The ancient proverb meant roughly the following: when a person down to a saying: "Tajeshwari so tajeshwari, tajeshwari so yogeshwari," yogis. As for legitimizing the theories of his royal lineage, he narrowed it was an ideal sanctuary for legends and forgotten tales, for the magic of All fairy tales have roots, and even fairies need a refuge. The shaman

well who and what he was in this life—and that was enough.

fragmentary memories of previous incarnations, and he knew perfectly coincided with theories and guesses. Yoga provided access to let he preferred to keep the knowledge of past lives to himself, even if it

they immediately set to work, scattering salt in all directions and reciting ...The next morning, Bheem Nath arrived with his younger brother, and warming themselves with the heat of their bodies.

them, and in cold winters the snakes sleep in beds with their "employers", snakes as guests: they are well fed, sprayed with water in summer to cool the snake is released at the Ganga, often in Rishikesh. The Gahers treat the and the possible consequences of breaking the oath: on the appointed day, The contract is never broken, due to the sanctity of the laws themselves perform a special ritual, taking a vow to release the captive after one year, traveling all over the country. Upon bringing a snake home, he would Usually, Bheem Nath searched for new snakes during the rainy season, heard of its unusual coloring, was eager to obtain the rare specimen. ...The snake disappeared before Bheem Nath arrived, but he, having

venomous reptiles from peasants' homes.

inhabitants earned a living by playing at weddings and removing from Govardhan, there were eight or nine Gahers villages: their life. Some Gahers clans remain nomads, others lead a settled life. Not far reptiles, with healing from bites and the like: "snake charming" is their connected with preparing potions and antidotes from the venom of these will all be snake charmers." For centuries, the life of the Gahers has been Gorakhnath cursed the descendants of Kanit Nath with disgust: "They snakes and scorpions be served. Offended by such provocative behavior, demonstrate an absence of disgust, Kanit Nath demanded that roasted refreshment you desire will be served." To shock Gorakhnath and the immortal yogi Gorakhnath. Gorakh received the guest cordially: "Any ...It is said that once Kanit Nath came to a lavish feast hosted by his rival,

reflect fragments of the teachings of the great yogi Matsyendranath.

people preserve a part of ancient knowledge: their folklore and traditions. Despite this, in some states they are still called Nath. In any case, these belong to the Nath sampradaya of yogis or to any other yogic clan. the ascetic and saint Kanit Nath as their Guru, they themselves do not Vasuki, depicted coiling around Shiva's neck. Although the Gahers revere

They made another deep, half-centimeter cut; a few drops appeared, but there was no blood—the venom had already begun to take effect, thumb so that blood would flow. She hesitantly followed the instructions, have that knowledge, that victory.” And he asked Devanuri to cut his Nath told everyone to calm down. “I will remove the venom myself. I workers frantically tried to find out which hospital to call, but Bheem to shake with convulsions. No one knew what to do. Devanuri and the and tied it tightly; within a minute, his skin turned yellow and he began thumb. Ignoring the wound, Bheem Nath shoved the snake into a mat bag long, furiously writhing body. Wriggling free, the cobra bit him on the ... The snake moved swiftly, but the Sabera reacted instantly, grabbing its

at work was even more interesting.

inanimate object. Bheem Nath had plenty of such tales, but watching him snake becomes a werewolf and can take on any form: human, animal, or paralyzed. In addition to these charming abilities, after 1000 years such a said that if such a snake lies over someone's head, the person can be through mental power arising from a high concentration of venom. It is years, they develop the ability to fly. Not with the help of wings, but cobras live for more than 250 years. And after reaching the age of 200 whisks are found only on very ancient snakes, and they grow when color, standing vertically like antennae. The Sabera believe that such turned out later, the snake had thin, pipe-like whisks of a gray-green the sought-after “tiger's tail,” but a strange subspecies of cobra. As it appearing from nowhere, lunged at him with incredible speed. It was not Bheem Nath had been playing for just under 10 minutes when a snake,

that could have come to the snake-catchers only from the Nath tradition. flow of breath. This pranayama is nothing other than a logic technique can play without interruption, sometimes for hours, without breaking the Sabera use continuous breathing, *nakosans*. After inhaling, the musician practice and preserved as a tribal tradition. While playing the flute, the to attract snakes. This thousand-year-old art was perfected through long holding it almost to the ground so that the sound would create a vibration a mantra. Then Bheem Nath began to play a special flute, the been brought

sent, and after some time, a response came: "You may teach this yoga somewhere in Orissa or Bengal, could grant permission. A request was extraction. The snake catcher replied that only his Guru, who lived. He politely asked Bhinnath if he could teach him the art of venom were eminently practical.

to save themselves from accidental premature death. The ancient sages people must be able

removed so that a person can approach the stage of liberation—for this, one might live long enough for the great liberation. Obstacles must be of practical wisdom could free one from dangers and obstacles, so that that the guru spoke of deliverance from immediate problems. The depth "knowledge that liberates from rebirth." But on that day, he understood "Knowledge liberates." Usually, he interpreted this expression as Sanskrit sutra from the Vishnu Purana states: *Jā Vidya, ya vimuktaye* — knowledge of his ancestors—that is what saved Bhinnath's life. A are impractical and useless in matters of life and death. The secret of the immortal spirit, Bhinnath would have been dead. Spiritual clichés to convince the snake charmer that he was not a body but an embodiment danger, all philosophical discontents are useless, and if someone had tried him, this incident became a moment of truth. In a situation of mortal venom. The gathered onlookers watched the act with amazement, and for Then Bhinnath drank 20 or 100 grams of ghee to reduce the heat from the and thrown away: apparently, they had somehow absorbed the poison. arm, as if drawing out the venom. The used leaves were tied into a bundle the words of a mantra, he began to move the brought leaves along the Meanwhile, Bhinnath sent for neem leaves. Then, carefully enunciating it even more effective.

charmers use nagmani—a stone extracted from a snake's head, considering They always carry this natural antidote with them, and some snake large toads. The snake-catchers...

wound, a so-called toadstone, which is sometimes found in the heads of Bhenn Nath pressed something resembling a piece of black resin to the

special kind of cobra. It is said that these snakes are descended from and the guards called out to him, having just noticed a Bakubanshi, a weeks later. One day, the sava was cycling past the gates of the savasava, Bhimnath reluctantly left, but the plan came to fruition two or three been preparing for the inevitable. Disappointed and not at all convinced, breathed a sigh of relief and relaxed a little, especially the woman, who had for certain that I truly possess this knowledge." Everyone present He addressed the sava, trying to make his words convincing: "I know dangerous.

know that you truly possess the vidya." The cobra looked seriously demonstrate his newly acquired ability to heal. "Otherwise, how will you insisted that the snake must bite the woman, so that Gurji could ritual implements and a basket with a huge black cobra. Bhimnath Two days later, he appeared again, dressed up in a red turban, carrying the results of the ritual and, upon hearing of the vision, was very pleased.

The next day, Bhimnath came to inquire about

dark pupils were vertical in shape.

thin. Without blinking, the women looked at him, and he saw that their tribe appeared in his room, one quite stout, and her companion young and Exactly at midnight, he had a vision: two coal-black, silent women of the accepted into the tradition. Everything happened just as it was said, and exactly at midnight, he was to receive confirmation that he had been ancient Hindi. The mantras were to be recited a certain number of times, in one of the corner rooms of the palace, teaching him two mantras in Bhimnath personally chose the day of initiation and performed the ritual

where justice is dispensed by a council of elders.

over criminals from the tribe to the police, but conduct their own courts, both its secrets and customs, and its members. They do not even hand As a rule, sava do not pass on their skills to outsiders; the tribe protects therefore he is worthy of the knowledge."

Living on the savasava, he has severed his connection with society,

snakes, which clearly wanted only one thing—to be left in peace. The lower levels of the palace. One of the rooms was simply teeming with unexpected places, including the

venomous snakes capable of moving faster than a horse, hid in the most people, flooded the swastika. Giant copras and “horse-chasers,” super-invasion, and hundreds of reptiles, disturbed by the heavy machinery and establishing a plantation. The snakes inhabiting the jungle resisted the Shikha Shikha Academy, active work began on clearing the area and When the forestry department allocated an additional plot of land for the very soon began to chew its food.

the mantra: almost immediately, the huge bull struggled to its feet and was clearly unwell. Putting the lethargic giant on the withers, he recited to the bull's great weight, the snake venom acted slowly, but Candhuri and by these signs one usually determines that an animal is unwell. Due was a favorite haunt of snakes. He would not get up and would not eat, tied up in an old building that later became a Shiva temple, and this place showing all the symptoms of a venomous snake bite. The bull was usually ...Several months later, workers reported that Candhuri the bull was

with the captive Baktawanchi.

knowledge worked; Bhimnath drank some ghee and left, carrying the bag shown to him, and it seemed the venom was successfully neutralized. The Nervously, he began to recite the mantra and applied all the techniques “Curly, now that I am bitten, you must remove the venom! Begin!”

rate, with a red hood, a red tail, and a yellowish belly.

holding the angrily writhing copra. The specimen was indeed bite him on the finger. Triumphant, he ran towards the house, still caught this descendant of the King of the Nagas. He then made the snake confirming its royal lineage. It fought fiercely, but in the end, Bhimnath Nagas. Of course, the reptile in question could not produce documents Kuru clan, Parikshit. They are considered the most venomous of the Takshaka—the lord of copras, who in Vedic times killed the ruler of the

ek ka nahi," and only then would he proceed to the business he had come traditional greeting: "Dekho, Curry! Curry hai kisi ka karta nahi, aur Curry kisi Every time Bhimnath came to the snakecatcher, he would begin with a way inferior to any snake.

revealed to outsiders, but Bhimnath considered that his friend was in no of honor and the rarest of rewards. Such secrets had never before been power of Kanit Nath—the Guru of the snake tribe. This was an unheard-shared some secrets with him, one of which was the invocation of the Their acquaintance grew into a strong friendship, and the snake catcher of his tradition and ancient wisdom.

his dharma, his life and destiny, determined by the blessings work, Bhimnath was confident and calm, almost relaxed. This work was would follow the character's actions. Focused, completely absorbed in his recitation of the mantra, the cobra would freeze, and only its black eyes Observing Bhimnath's work, he saw again and again how, after the accompanying battery, as Bhimnath's village had no electricity.

fee for teaching. The miracle mantra cost a portable television with an agreed to teach him on the condition of paying dakshina—the traditional effective, and the price for the knowledge was not so high. Bhimnath Overall, the science of venom neutralization proved practical and since then, he had worn it as a ring.

Fortunately, Bhimnath had given him a piece of black fossilized resin, and the bitten man, reciting a mantra, and the actions again had an effect minutes. Hurrying to the scene, he applied a tona stone to the wound of venomous cobra, after whose bite the victim usually dies within six snake that had attacked him as a Panna Man, a small but deadly Pale and already beginning to sweat profusely, the snake identified the bitten on the leg the moment he stepped inside the room.

at the door, but despite the precautions, one of the snake catchers was snake charmers were called again. As a warning, a loud noise was raised

again acquire its usual brownish hue, remaining transparent. One could days later, the pond could become turbid, and then the water would sometimes the dark water changed color, becoming milky white. A few The majestic palaces were reflected in the sleeply surface of the pond: money.

horrors discouraged superstitious locals from appearing there even for kinds of unclean spirits, was practically impossible. Stories of all sorts of Hiring someone to work at the famous swam, known as an abode of all ill one after another, and then refused to continue the work altogether. algae and settled duckweed ceased when the hired workers began to fall partially drain the pond and clean the steps of centuries-old growths of resolve or the resources to verify the truth of this assumption. Attempts to the boat Varaha, the *varaha*₁₂₂ of Lord Vishnu, but no one had either the seen. There were rumors that at the bottom was installed a golden idol of narrowing steps descended to the deep bottom, which no one had ever built only two hundred years ago. More than a hundred gradually The ritual pond was over five thousand years old, but its stone steps were

The Royal Guardian

in the “twilight language.”

the form of a dialogue between Coraknath and his guru Matsyendranath ₁₂₃ Corakn Boddh – a little-known ancient text of the Nath yogis, written in

the snake charmer knew the hidden meaning of this wisdom.

bodies in which he temporarily dwells. Although it is quite possible that mind. The Spirit-Guru belongs to no one and is attached to none of the suspect that he was speaking of the Spirit who was the mentor of the words of the great Guru Matsyendranath. Perhaps the guru did not even Nath text, the Corakn Boddh₁₂₃, he understood: Bhinnath was repeating the Years later, while working on commentaries to a little-known ancient

possess the Guru, and the Guru belongs to no one!”

for. In this phrase lay the greatest wisdom: “Listen, Guruji! No one can

and some visitors asked about its origin. Birds were being found dead smasman's wall, especially in the evening hours. The sound grew louder, notorious place. Locals began to avoid the road that ran along the ...stirring up unease and deepening the already grim reputation of that couple of months, causing

such signals. The sound did not disappear; it continued for another nature, and those who worked at the smasman were doubly attentive to clearly frightened. Village people are generally very sensitive to signs of black, a large tree growing nearly withered. Some of the workers were surroundings. Something was changing: the water in the pond turned sunrise, and it seemed the inaudible resonance was beginning to affect the barely perceptible but continuous, the sound lasted from sunset to direction of the pond, resembling the hissing of a steam locomotive. One day, someone mentioned an unusual sound coming from the

his back with his legs crossed in lotus, just to cool down somewhat.

degrees Celsius, and he would drift for long periods in the kunda, lying on help for household needs. That summer, the temperature rose to 22 here. At first, when they had just moved to the smasman, the pond was a view, it was good to have at least some reservoir with water supplies. Palaces were built near bodies of water. From a purely practical point of five primordial elements, and therefore Indian temples, memorials, and Water, the embodiment of purification and eternity, represents one of the presence and divine blessing.

Bra) was considered the land of Krishna, and milk symbolized His important. Just another sign of the presence of something supernatural. algal spores affecting the color of the water, but all this was not so changes by temperature variations, underwater currents, or the release of means of transport.

which carries or pulls.” This term denotes a being used by a deity as a 122 Vahana – a mount (bird, fish, insect), literally meaning in Sanskrit “that explain these

He absorbed the creature's mental transmission: "I have lived here for
Without moving and without attempting to analyze what was happening,
adorned with a fiery-red goat's beard, water dripping from its tip.
several meters. Moreover, the jaw of this anaconda-like serpent was
head was about a meter across, and judging by its size its length stretched
gigantic serpent silently rose above the surface of the water. The creature's
He hurried to the pond; a few moments passed, and the upper body of a

"Come alone. Tonight I will speak with you."

That same evening, around eight o'clock, he received a mental signal:
turned out to be of great importance for the samashan and its inhabitants.
found before the gates — and this seemingly unrelated incident later.
On 27 January 1992, a small bronze statue of a nameless goddess was
couple of months.

inhabitant of the pond: "Please, speak with me..." This went on for a
dark, motionless water, he lit incense and mentally addressed the unseen
where the two towers connected by a small bridge stood. There, above the
sunset he began coming to the pond, to the lower level of the palace.
There was no way out other than to find the source of the sound. After
such a creature lay far beyond their abilities.

The only explanation he could pull from them was that the capture of
be an enormous serpent. Then they departed without taking any action.
while. They knew their craft excellently and agreed that this could indeed
— snake chambers. Sitting by the pond, the sapers listened for a long
gigantic serpent, which prompted the thought of summoning specialists.
The closest association with the "melody" of this sound was the hiss of a
owls were buried.

corpses, not any foul smell. The blackened, mummified remains of the
three or four months no signs of decay appeared on the small bird-
intact for a long time due to the preserving action of the venom. After
death. In Brazil it was believed that, when a snake bites, the body remains
gardener hung their carcasses on the trees to determine the cause of
along the perimeter of the pond. After discovering eight dead owls, the

preferred the spontaneous unfolding of events to guesswork — if alone. Musings over these mysteries was entertaining but led nowhere. He

fresh air. Guardian of the smasphan had risen to the surface of the pond to breathe the surface, accompanied by a peculiar sour-vinegar smell; this meant the allowed himself to be seen and smelled. A wide tunnel would appear on in any case, the missing stopped. From time to time the pond's inhabitant see what would unfold there.

for the skeptics — they could be advised to find their own smasphan and the gods and spirits of the place did not object to a yogi's presence, and as entrance, and the Nagas was one of the deities of that locality. It seemed smasphan was a portal into another reality, yoga was the key to that than the so-called realists, with all their logic and healthy skepticism. The different understanding. The spirits of the smasphan were far more real making reality — only the nature of that reality was different, requiring a had never planned to live inside them. The encounter had happened in for fourteen hours straight. Yes, he loved comics and ghost stories, but he vanished beneath the water, and he, barely dragging himself home, slept — half an hour, forty minutes. Without a single splash the serpent The meeting was over. He could not say precisely how long it had lasted poisonous.

the serpent "told" him to keep at a distance, since his breath was simply absorbed the "narration," feeling a slight dizziness. Noticing this, resembled a science-fiction film, yet his logical mind switched off and he "speaking" of the secrets of this land, of its spirits and its living. It all and destroy him, they perished themselves. The serpent went on tanks and black magicians knew of this ancient Nagas, trying to catch The giant serpent listed the names of the people it had destroyed. Some guard you as well."

my invitation, for I am the guardian of this land. From now on I shall prosperity to the dynasty of the Bharatpur rulers. You have come here at more than four hundred years; my blessings granted power and

and the so-called holy men who usually sing prayers in the name of
body without bothering with formalities; the doctors who refused to help;
the reaction of the local police, who had suggested simply cremating the
What stayed with them was not the stranger's miraculous recovery but
travel, and he left with a bow.

unconscious remained unclear. In the end they gave him a little money for
come from Shivpuri, but the circumstances under which he had fallen
had happened to him: he remembered only his name and that he had
three weeks, until he began to stand and walk. He could not explain what
stranger regained consciousness. He stayed on the campus for another
someone brought intravenous saline and medications. After five days the
cot was set up next to the guard post, in the lower arcade of the palace;
ran out, and she shouted to the gatekeeper to carry the stranger inside. A
scruples wanted to approach or touch the dying man. Devaputi's patience
prayers, or any rites suitable for such a case. But not one of the venerable
Then they called the local bandits, hoping for the power of mantras,
admit him. The limp body was returned to the same spot before the gates.
At the hospital they said the patient could not be saved and refused to
your gates..."

answer: "If the unknown man dies, just cremate him. After all, he came to
looked to be over fifty. They notified the police and received a laconic
skinned, bony man covered in sticky sweat and dust, in an old cloth,
who he was. Devaputi came to look in on the new patient: the dark-
dusty bag, and the few objects found there gave not the slightest hint of
witnesses who could identify the victim. There was no identification in his
blazing summer heat had emptied the parkrama road, and there were no
In the summer of 1997, an unconscious man was found at the gates. The

Absolution of Monkey Sins

The Dying Man, the Wounded Bull, and the

wait for the mysteries to reveal themselves.

could yield the keys to the secrets of the past. Nothing remained but to

beneath the warm skin, the whole enormous body of Bhola radiated the sincere love. Scratching the heavy head of the bull, he felt a fine pulsation penetrate. The scene was undeniably sentimental, but these were tears of joy and tears would stream in rivers, soaking through the kurtas of his Bhola Shankar Tewari would lay his massive head on his master's belly, they entered the shed, the bull would weep from love and gratitude, attached himself to his new masters with his whole great heart. Whenever her. The bull survived, was given the name Bhola Shankar Tewari, and trouble her. Prolonging life for life's own sake seemed entirely logical to her. The unwarranted expense of feed for yet another being did not gravely wounded before the gates and ordered him brought onto the Once, returning from Mathura, she found a large brown bull lying nature and her dharmas, with them her bath was bared.

household chores. Healing, doctoring, and caretaking were part of her. He called her "Dr. Dolittle"; she smiled shyly and plunged back into her shard of glass was a precious, necessary part of the great mosaic of life.

existential kaleidoscope, to be part of the magic of being. Each colored summer. Everyone had the right to remain in the mosaic of the turning the refreshing monsoon, the cold of winter's foggy embrace, the heat of someone's return to life, to a world full of sounds, smells, and tastes — to suffering and the sick. And she always rejoiced when she witnessed and fragility of every breathing life, Devabuti continued to care for the change their convictions. Knowing the value of every life, the kindness receive it, and everyone deserved a chance. They were not about to unchanged. Mercy was the natural response: those in need of help should current circumstances were difficult, but their core values remained. He and Devabuti could not accept the cynicism of such an attitude. Yes, preachers.

victims of robbers, impostor-bandits, greedy merchants, or dishonest empathy is considered an impractical weakness; pilgrims often become than adding to their compassion. In many "sacred places of power," divine love. As a rule, places of pilgrimage madden their inhabitants rather

put it and carried it to the plantation, where they laid it in a shallow pit or the curious dogs. The workers placed the almost weightless body on a bamboo pole before the gates, paying no attention to the people passing at three evening hours. On the fourth day the monkey could not stand; he was told not to drive the visitor away, and the giant animal was present climbed into the Hanuman temple and sat quietly in a corner. The priest And what was one to make of the case of the old male macaque who had

officially appointed them representatives of the funeral bureau...

Devanuti, as if asking her to take care of it. It seemed the animals had climbed the tree, the monkey placed the tiny body on the ground before met a pair of monkeys: a mother had brought her dead infant. Before breathed his last. That same evening, on a walk with the dogs, Devanuti as if performing rituals, then sat down on the kitchen terrace and trees, an old female monkey walked around the house several times. In the hot noon, when all beings were hiding in the vanishing shade of the motionless in one place for several days, until life left them.

They came here to die: usually these were enterprising old ones who sat bring the bodies of their dead to this very secluded corner by the pond. where it had been found, and from that day on the monkeys began to and examined. The rather old and unusually large skull was buried right mounters simply left the skull on the steps of the pond. It was picked up large skull, passing it from one to another. At some point the distracted workers noticed a small procession: a group of monkeys was carrying a 5000 the scandalous primates behaved unusually quietly. One morning Usually herds of monkeys invaded the territory in spring, but in April beginning could appear (in one form or another).

could receive a chance at healing, a last wish could be fulfilled, a new cremation ground was the final destination, yet in rare cases here one

smashan in which the laws of society lost their cumbersome meaning. The despite their unrepresentable appearance, they separated from the world and The entry gates were rusty, the adorning metal panels needed paint. But high frequencies of love.

stirred the stalks of dry grass beside the motionless body.

With his head to the south, the monkey gave up his spirit: a light breeze distant melody of bhajans hung in the still, thick air. An hour later, lying prone, he thought to make such a comparison. It was quiet and only the hum from a teaspoon. It was like a final communion, but no one nearby would put his lips into a tube, the monkey drew in the mixture given to him. Candra and a basket of indrasana and offered it all to the dying animal. An hour later, Devanuri returned to the plantation with water from the grass that hung from the corners of the monkey's mouth. A couple of pairs of peacocks, and a white cow indifferently chewing the same dry legs. The witnesses to this scene were few: Devanuri, several disciples, and the monkey closed his eyes and, with visible relief, sank back on his hind

Your last wish has been fulfilled. Go in peace."

Now, not what you are guilty of in this life or the past. But I forgive you. walls of the irrigation bit, trying to hold itself upright: "I do not know impulse, he addressed the weakening animal, which was clinging to the. They were witnessing a desperate plea for final forgiveness. Opening an mercy..."

sacrificial cow. I have nothing left but dry grass, and I surrender to you.

Grass in the mouth meant: "I am a silent

that he was surrendering to the mercy of the one he had wronged. Dry the suppliant was to hold several stalks of straw in his mouth as a sign almost forgotten ritual described in the Puranas. Pleading for forgiveness, wheeze and fell silent. In the ensuing silence he recalled an ancient. The ever-screaming loudspeaker on the neighboring temple gave a

with his lips, and held out a paw to them, as if asking for help.

The monkey lifted himself up with effort, tore several stalks of dry grass. Devanuri went to visit the dying creature, and seeing them approaching, animal's suffering. The next day the sufferer was still alive. He and irrigation well, so the water might cool the insect-bitten skin and ease the

weight, but the witnesses of these games were convinced of the Guru's master's shoulders. Of course, the hind legs bore most of the enormous his hind legs like a circus horse and placing his front hooves on his the time he behaved peacefully. He loved to wrestle and play, rising on and jump at the "transgressor," often tearing his own chains. But most of attempted to touch him in his presence, Candhari would fly into a rage effortlessly. If anyone dared to address his master in a raised voice or punch and bat his neck. Rising with heavy grace, he carried the rider bend his knees, allowing his master to mount behind the huge white ready to do anything for his friend. Lowering himself, the bull would smash. Bulls rarely allow anyone to sit on their back, but Candhari was the southern variant, like a melancholy white ghost — the spirit of the animal would slowly trudge through the whole house and out through barbell. Sometimes, entering from the northern terrace, the enormous living-room floor, and watch as his master, lying on his back, pressed the house, and the bull would wander into the main hall, sprawl on the completely free. There were as yet no doors on the ground floor of the When they first arrived at the smashan, Candhari roamed everywhere the long, drifting sound stirred nostalgia in him.

Sometimes he flew into the room, simply out of sentimental impulse, and the upstairs room, gleaming with the tarnished silver of its setting. time they began to use another vessel during puja, and the old room lay in was cleaned, hollowed out, and filled with milk each night. After some mockery or disrespect. Fourteen years later, after the bull's death, his room bull-calf was named after the great leader of the nation — and this was no disciple. Born on October 2nd, the birthday of Mahatma Candhari, the The tiny calf, along with his mother, had been gifted to them by one of the ornament and symbol of manhood for the ritual.

Candhari, who had lived with them since 1991, had donated his own offering to Shiva had been given to him by a friend. The huge white bull The room through which milk was poured during puja as the Abhishek-

Candhari

Large tents with food and drink were set up; a garlanded post in the pond Academy welcomes all spiritual brothers and sisters."

advertising board at the entrance reading: "The Siddha Siddhanta Yoga clearing. And further, no leaflets, posters, or banners — only an several conditions. After the festival, ISKCON was to organize a thorough Covadman, and because of the significance of the event he agreed, on celebration was to be the first international summit ever held in Consciousness, known as the "Hare Krishna Movement." The planned gathering to honor the founder of the International Society for Krishna thousand guests from one hundred and nine countries. They were all safe and sufficiently large place capable of accommodating more than a century of Sriya Prabhupada's birth. The organization needed to find a a request to use the territory of the zamshan for the celebration of the In the summer of 1990 the ISKCON administration approached them with

his laugh — unless some sarcastic ghost happened to be nearby. watching her try to extricate herself from the bundle, and it was definitely saw Candhuri, gazing at Devahuti with a peculiar expression. The bull was laughed with a deep, rolling laugh: "Ha-ha, ha-ha!" Looking back, they balaces!" Shivering in the mud, she fell, and suddenly someone behind her sound of thunder, and Devahuti hurried: "Get all the cows inside the the cows were being driven to shelter. On that day they woke to the season arrived, they had to undertake a hasty evacuation of the herd, and verandas of the palaces, tied to walls and columns. When the monsoon He had a sense of humor. For several years the cows remained on the from beneath half-closed eyelids quite serenely.

primordial beauteous strength, the bull watched the surrounding world stroke, or feed him. But mostly, resembling a white mountain, full of cowherd who tended him, the giant would let no one else approach. The bull recognized only Devahuti, his master himself, and one more sons, and breeders sought them out to continue the bloodline of giants.

breeding bulls in the district, Candhuri became the father of many mighty ability to tame and even lift the gigantic animal. The largest of all the

that truly moved him, since the innermost can be realized only in the test of "marriage proposals," exhausted itself. Yoga was the only thing the persistent attempts at matchmaking began to irritate him. In the end consideration of the Master. Devanuti giggled, they exchanged jokes, but he had to repeat that the decision about marriage was still under the proposals would be forthcoming. Some of the "candidates" persisted, and must be given by his Guru, and that no immediate answer to their bridegroom. Politely and patiently he explained that permission to marry many were more enchanted with the real estate than with the potential marriage ceremony. There were more than fifty interested candidates, but of marriage to requests for cohabitation without the obligations of a most varied propositions began coming his way. They ranged from offers was not only the owner of a magnificent estate but also a bachelor, the yogin — so different from the shaven-headed "brahmins" in pink robes — some of the female ISKCON devotees learned that the attractive silent. As always, the crowds of devotees were extremely heterogeneous. When unprecedented sight stunned those present.

their eyes filled with tears, and the bull began to lick their faces. This girls surrounded Candhi, rubbing his neck and stroking his huge head. You. Otherwise, he is dangerous." Before anyone could stop them, the them: "If your hearts are full of devotion to Krishna, the bull will not harm correct. The girls wanted to pet the animal, and one of the guests warned he answered shyly: "This is the husband of cow," which is technically Indian escorts: "What kind of animal is this?" Forgetting the English word, for them he looked no less exotic than an elephant. They asked one of the had never seen such an enormous creature with a protruding hump, and A flock of Bulgarian girls from ISKCON timidly approached Candhi; they the grandeur of the architecture and the lush greenery of the garden.

steps of the pond and strolled through the garden; all were astounded by for VIPs. Hundreds of devotees dressed in pastel-pink robes sat on the they watched the festivities from the upper terrace of the palace, reserved depicted a scene from Krishna's life. Together with friends and disciples

arrested on charges of negligence and abdication of responsibility: he had simply left a thousand cows on the outskirts of the town. He was later then brought the herd to Govardhan and abandoned them. The "baron," the "relocation of sacred animals," from Rajasthan to the land of Krishna. It turned out that some "philanthropist" had collected sizable funds for greedily grazing, putting to fill themselves.

who had entered the amaran grounds through the broken fence, were have guests, and they need to be fed." About three hundred stray cows, cold darsan hall, talking with someone, when Devanuti entered: "We in the winter of 2001 unexpected visitors arrived. He was sitting in the

The Magic Barons

evening, until the next call of the horn.

slowly trudges back to the cattle yard, to remain there until the next pongainvilles. When the bull ends, the ghost of the enormous white bull while floats over the rooftops, lodging in the branches of the rich smell of dung, the sound of the horn reaches the cowsheds and for a in the evenings the intoxicating aroma of night flowers mingles with the grave, stylistically depicting Candhi in his prime.

lived his whole life. Several years later a stone statue was erected on his 2002 he died. He was buried right there, on the cattle yard where he had tumor that had developed right beneath the broken horn, and on 22 May the wound would not heal. Candhi was diagnosed with a malignant hands and followed her like a puppy when she led him by the chain. But months, changing dressings and applying salves. The bull licked her until Candhi's horn had broken off, and Devanuti tended to him for meters from Candhi, all four legs broken, and had to be put down. In the the workers rushed to the cowshed, the attacker lay on the ground, six bodies turned into deadly torpedoes, and the animals locked horns. When bull attacked him — one that had somehow broken free, their massive Candhi was standing in his usual place, tethered to a post, when another solitude.

developed subtle mental abilities and learned to view any idea from the jungle, eating nothing but roots, wild fruits, and milk, the seeker the number set by the Master. Several years would pass. Tending cows in with several cows, and he could only return when the herd had grown to in ancient times, when a seeker came to a sage, he was sent into the jungle ridiculed, and the essence of the tradition could very rarely be explained. proverbial Indian love of cows. Sometimes this strange attachment was Looking at the small herd in the cattle yard, he sometimes mused on the became accustomed to their new home.

next several days he and his sister had to stay with the cows until they weeping subsided, though the animals were under heavy stress. For the Finally, the herd was led into the new sheds: the anxious jowing and the street with the cows, and their presence calmed the animals a little. the herd continued to wail and balk. He and Devahuti had to go out into drawn-out sobs shedding real tears. Despite coaxing and encouragement uneasy. The panic spread to the rest. The cows bellowed and wept, with animals rescued by Devahuti added to it, and these were the first to grow driven out into the street again. The herd had grown, with several stray The animals received the relocation with alarm, deciding they were being palace and onto the street, then through other gates into the new pens. When at last the cowsheds were built, the herd had to be led out of the continued to arrive for several more years.

from the cow restaurant,"

had to borrow to ensure an uninterrupted supply of fodder. The "bills exhausted "guests." The food for each cow cost 300 rupees a day, and they be cut down for firewood. The fire helped to warm the pen and the palace. The nights were so cold that two large tamarind trees had to she went. In the end, all the animals were gathered and tied up by one of and treated their injuries, and the cows followed her gratefully wherever had become guests of the samasana. Devahuti stitched up their wounds happened, more than three hundred emaciated and wounded animals cows were taken to a state shelter in Vrindavan, but before any of that

prosperity. Those who had a patrona never lacked for anything: neither dualities: it was said that they granted their owner peace, wisdom, and pairs formed in the throat of a cow, patronas possessed mystical and only a few old men knew of their properties. Composed of entangled in the local dialect these small oblong oval objects were called "patronas". From time to time the cows brought a truly magical gift to their owners: remained unchanged.

of the palaces. Almost tangible, meditative, earthly serenity and peace with quietude, nested in the house, invisibly waiting around the columns were happy. A special atmosphere of stillness and peace filled the garden sunset, and the melancholy cows, he saw that the animals and people opened. Watching the cowherds who labored from early morning until The cows had a very specific quality: in their presence the human mind increased, and he could feel the essence of any idea on which he focused. he began to take care of them. Telepathic perception developed, intuition He first noticed the strange effect upon the arrival of the first cows, when for success on the spiritual path.

gradually understood: contact with cows was one of the basic conditions since he had begun to live in Braj, the land of cow-veneration, he man into a sage.

grasp the meaning of a single phrase. The blessing of Mother Cow made a underlying the manifestations of Nature and her creations could instantly wisdom. A person capable of understanding the subtle abstractions disciple, whose ripened mind had prepared to absorb the highest — and this could be one short phrase. But these words enlightened the When such an ascetic returned, the Guru gave him Ubadesh — teaching mind of the man who served them.

simple thoughts, their peacefulness and deep humility, influenced the their hidden nature. The mental waves of the cows, their meditative and single system, to recognize the subtlety even of gross material objects, aspirant began to perceive animals, plants, insects, and people as part of a different sides, to see the essence of truth. Living with a herd, such an

karma and inclinations. To have the right of choice in such matters is the the next birth is usually made in advance and is determined by a person's or surroundings. This is a very rare possibility, since the decision about determine the next incarnation, to choose birth in particular circumstances. With the baroncha was associated another belief — that it helps to bedroom, where they filled the space with a soothing silence.

vanished. So he kept the gray-brown woolly balls upstairs in the his mind became so motionless that any desire to speak completely. When he put a baroncha in his pocket or wore it on his neck as a pendant, the cow.

different properties, and it formed not in the stomach but in the throat of magic for controlling people, especially women. But the baroncha had India it was known as gorochan, and it was used in Vashikaran, black pezoar placed in a glass would neutralize any poison poured into it. In properties. They were used as a universal antidote, on the belief that a in medieval alchemy, pezoars were thought to possess magical curative ball of hair extracted from the stomach of a cow or bull. They were prized husbandry. Some alchemical manuscripts described the pezoar, a calcified. The baroncha was not mentioned in any of the books on animal extremely unusual.

light-brown balls were "gifted" by two young bull-calves, which is caught up in mutual tenderness. There were also exceptions: two small in her throat, it came out in these rare moments when the cows were was simultaneously licking her daughter. If one of them had a baroncha emerged when a mother-cow was licking her calf and the calf's mother grew to 16 balls of slightly varying size and color. Usually the baroncha and the smashan's herd "gave" two baronchas a year. Their collection baroncha had ever been found. It was a symbol of attachment and love, commercial dairy farms, where animals are simply a product, not a single. However, cows gave a baroncha only if they were happy and loved. On on the material nor on the spiritual planes.

and the narrative itself, reminding him of the Old Testament. "In the
There was something completely biblical about the style of the records.
The reading of thousands of ancestral names began, taking several hours.

code known only to the keepers of the archives.

archivist. The words on the yellowed pages were recorded in a special
kilograms of books were delivered to the ambassador, accompanied by an
existing records. The trip was a success, and soon about a hundred
some time) was tasked with visiting the archivists' village to request the
Zahar (as everyone called the man who had been working for him for
it was time to make inquiries. In June 1992, his manager and adviser Vakil
from the man who kept their family's archive for more than ten years, and
connection with the archivists had been lost. There had been no news
Possibly because their large family had relocated many times, the

Court of India.

livelihood: the ancient records were recognized even by the Supreme
newly arrived members. This was both their sacred occupation and their
whose data they preserved, to read the names of ancestors and register
Following age-old custom, the keepers of the archives visited the families
Bharadvaj lineage. They had been doing this for five thousand years.
their catalogues all information about living and deceased members of the
of the family was tracked by a special clan of archivists who entered into
were high-born Brahmins belonging to the Bharadvaj gotra. The genealogy
It was known that their family line descended from Ashvathama; they

The Keepers of the Archives

for all the love she had shown them.

Who knows — perhaps the cows gave her this precious pass to earthly life
ticket that allowed Devahuti to book her desired incarnation in advance.
return to the place she loved so much. Perhaps the patroncha was a lucky
this animal played an important role in her next incarnation and her
Devahuti often carried a small brownish patroncha with her, and perhaps
luxury of only a few souls.

The Shiva temple (right) after the installation of the Shivalingam, 1999

Vultures in the Shade of the Tree

of the Universe and his personal Ishta Devata.

Less than a year remained before the arrival on the smashtan of the Lord family. His worship has not ceased in your clan since time immemorial."

The keeper of the archives also confirmed: "Shiva is the deity of your matter.

progenitor of seventeen different lines, which for a rishi was no difficult departed from him. Ashvattthama married several times and became the venerable sage, and remained immortal, unlike his wives, who gradually Then the hero had married. By that time he had already reached a blessing of Shiva and become a Brahmarishi, one of the immortal sages. clan was indeed descended from Ashvattthama, who had received the found all the names of the ancestors on the pages of the old books. Their generations of the family were known, and the keeper of the archives joined his brother Kusha, heading into the fertile valleys of Kashmir. Five death, some of them followed Rama's son Lava to Lahore, while others forefathers belonged to the tight inner circle of Lord Rama. After His The family roots of the lineage were traced to ancient Tibet, the if.

crowded. The air in the room thickened with the karmic mist enveloping long-departed ancestors who silently entered the room until it grew stories and nicknames, tales of former splendor, glory, and adversity of As if in a trance, he listened to the names, remembering half-forgotten twentieth century.

every generation were known: the reader slowly approached the Their family's genealogy went back to the days of Creation: the names of Brahma, Vishnu, and Shiva, and from Brahma came the first rishis..." beginning there was nothing: then the formless God incarnated as

special ritual is required, not mantras — only the most intense. There exists a certain method by which one may summon any deity: no 1990, around noon.

(completely insane, terrifying, but absolutely real) took place on 19 June experiences

too real to be dismissed as mere brain hallucinations. One of those however fueled by faith. His own mystical experiences, however, were plots of spiritual experiences often betray the poverty of the imagination, generally inclined to take the imagined for the real, but the predictable dreams, and they usually sounded extremely romantic. People are. There were plenty of stories about gods appearing to people in their considered a play of imagination.

or the divine can be experienced only empirically; otherwise it is to experience anything of the kind. Any manifestation of the supernatural are eagerly used by those who have never experienced and have no plans usually considered hallucinations, visions, or mystical trance. Such terms aside his initial skepticism, he became acquainted with logic states the personality — must recognize unexplainable phenomena. Getting become part of lived experience. The subconscious — the intuitive core of in them. In order for the logical mind to accept the incredible, it must. Only one who has personally lived through miracles can sincerely believe

Games of the Gods

Gods, Avatars and Forces of Nature

Applying an antidote

Mathura, 1990

Devahuti gives Gangā water to a dying monkey. August 2010

Gmashan, 1992 With the bull Candhuli

The memorial palaces of the Gmashan after the flood of 1990

Shiva was sweating. When Mahadeva tore him out of Vishnu's hands, the moment, however, this had no significance.

of different epochs, and somehow he discovered their names. At that had thrown a switch in his brain — that the skulls belonged to the avatars the smooth surface of one of the skulls, he instantly knew — as if someone adorned with a garland of skulls. Accidentally pushing his elbow against wears the hide of the demon-elephant Gajasura. Mahadeva's neck was wrapped in elephant skin. Later, in some old texts, he read that Shiva broad-shouldered Vishnu. His bearing was regal, and His ribs were tall and lean but not overly muscled, Shiva looked slender compared to fighting dizziness, he tried to concentrate on details. Light-skinned, very

Mahadeva's hands.

suddenly as He had appeared. There was a brief pause. He was still in spreading its hood, lunged toward Vishnu. He dematerialized as serpents: the black cobra coiled around His neck slid lower and, Preserver's arm. The locks of Mahadeva'sjata waved like entangled with a monstrous roar, like a rag doll, he snatched him out from under the his left hand to his right, Shiva pointed the weapon at Vishnu, and then in the room — Shiva. He was furious. Tossing the black iron trident from only the beginning. Another participant in the bhantasmagoria appeared his right arm, and he felt dizzy and terrified. As it turned out, this was for a split second, and then immediately seized him, holding him under beautiful, magnificently built, the Preserver of the Universe looked at him central room where the whole spectacle unfolded. Astonishingly invitation. The deity's head almost touched the 2-meter ceiling of the It worked. Vishnu appeared at once, as if He had been expecting the work.

of pure curiosity, on impulse, simply to see whether the method would and far-reaching consequences. He later admitted that he had done it out most powerful gods of the Hindu pantheon had absolutely unexpected logic no longer need mantras to call deities. The address to one of the concentration and the summons itself. Upon reaching a certain level,

days after the appearance of Shiva, Govardhan was flooded, and completely utopian dream: there was not a drop of groundwater. But 10 casti and thorns could grow on the calcified soil. The garden was a this incident the land around the smashtan was barren and desolate: only changes, the appearance of Shiva set in motion external processes. Before someone gave a positive impulse to the present: besides the inner mean that the apocalypse was approaching; However, all these events the end of the world is near. Why then was the Deity's eye open? Did it Destroyer lift the heavy lid of His dark, destructive optical sight when or the destruction of the god of Love. It is commonly known that the third eye. And each time it brought either the birth of a demon or auras' eyed — but only three "cases" are known when Mahadeva opened the As for the third eye of Lord Shiva... He is called "Tryambakesh" — three- an experience completely.

and even then he was not sure that it was possible to recover from such traumatic. Emotional equilibrium was restored only after several months. This incident can scarcely be called a divine revelation: it was, rather, body to the prism.

crept across his skin, and a new, strange energy was slowly filling his scratch on his wrist was bleeding. He was shaking slightly, gooseflesh his bedroom. His forearm was still damp with the Deity's sweat: the tiny scratched his wrist... He must have lost consciousness, for he came to in the Deity carrying him under His arm. A thorny bougainvillea branch if one can consider normal the rhythmic swaying in time with the steps of toward the pavilion of Raja Jaswant Singh. Everything felt almost normal. The Destroyer left the house, still holding him in his hands, and headed paralyzed him.

frighten. Fear — a much stronger instinct than curiosity — almost described in romantic and elevated tones: the actual events can stun and third eye, and was portended. Usually meetings with the divine are own skin. Lifting his head, he met the gaze of the Destroyer's half-open felt the momentary burning touch of the Ambitious One's sweat on his

her presence — and only later did he realize that the invitation had been Yamma to come, to revive the smashan with water, to honor them with surprise the white streaks vanished instantly, as if swallowed. He asked summer. They poured milk into the waters of the river, and to their the river herself were sweating, suffering from the scorching breath of was unbearable, and even being close to the river brought no relief, as if disciple from Delhi, Umashankar Sharma, he went to Vrindavan. The heat quite reasonable, and on 22 June 1990, together with Devanuti and his an offering to the river Yamma and asking her for help. This seemed medium: "What is to be done about water?" The medium advised making water question was the most acute. So much so that he even turned to a building, and agricultural work. Of a million pressing problems, the thoughts were focused on purely practical tasks: clearing the land, budget. Besides reflections on the miraculous appearance of the gods, his were emptied weekly, costs were steadily rising, eating into a non-existent Water for domestic needs had to be bought: six cisterns of fresh water

The Coming of Yamma

before the owner moved in.

smashan was His home, and any home needed a thorough inspection. Perhaps the Destroyer had come to inspect the property in advance. The Two years after the appearance of the gods, the Shivalingam was found.

Just the fantasy of the narrator.

Shivalingam, a sign of Shiva. Otherwise all the words would have been appeared to a mortal was the finding by that person of a natural pointed to an undeniable fact: the only confirmation that Shiva had northern India. Some wise people with whom he discussed the events miracle. These climatically sensitive trees never survive on the plains of Where Mahadeva had stepped, rudraksha trees grew, which was a true

and birds. Even the faces of the locals somehow softened.

the soil: it became fertile, fresh greenery grew quickly, attracting animals remained underwater for three months. The flood affected the quality of

gripping the chains, they pulled the bull toward the house, and with great the bull tried to lead him to safety. Already chest-deep in water, stood before the ramp leading to the upper level of the palace, and he and The water rose quickly. Looking around uncertainly, the bull searched reservoir for the furious flow.

their good fortune, the completely drained pond became an excellent and swirling into whirlpools, the current rushed toward the pond. To irrigation canals located a kilometer from the smashan, angrily seething through the northern gates, water poured in from the overflowing dikes, Candhi and Madhav, remained below. It was almost dark when palace, and this rejoicing continued all day. By evening only two Everyone rushed to milk the cows and lead them up the ramps to the reason for concern. While they were arguing, a heavy downpour began. up immediately — they tried to protest, saying there was not the slightest level of the palace. The stunned workers were ordered to lead the herd and the cows had to be evacuated from the lowland at least to the second The next morning he woke with absolute certainty: a flood was coming, but the rain did not start.

flying branch-fragments and whirlwinds of sand. The wind died down, to the ground. Rushing to the house, they fell several times, dodging feasible, but a few seconds later a strong gust of wind almost threw them Climbing the wall, they looked around and judged the task entirely plans to bring water to a spot that was destined to be flooded.

it became clear: the gods of the place themselves were laughing at the froze, and Mohan whispered: "Curly, who is that?" He had no idea. Later heard loud laughter, as if a giant were laughing behind their backs. They assess the possibility of such a solution. Approaching the wall, they both smashan on his own land. They went to the wall enclosing the territory to Mohan Khandelwal, offered to install a pipeline from the well to the a water well located nearby. The owner of the plot adjoining the smashan, That same day a local resident came to him to discuss a recent purchase of accepted literally.

Lifting himself with effort on the bed, he tried to focus. The deity's face from blood loss hallucinations had begun. But then the figure moved. Understood that before him stood Hanuman, and the thought flashed that human, emitting a golden radiance. Seeing a long, lion-like tail, he. At that very moment, a huge figure appeared in the room, not entirely a couple more times, and the bleeding will stop."

to live — please help..." Baraji's voice answered at once: "You will urinate allow me to leave the body in the proper, logic way. But if I am destined come to depart, I will sit in padmasana and raise prana and apana — Mentally turning to Baraji, he prayed: "Give me a sign if my time has minute, his head spinning violently.

that his nails had grown white from blood loss. He weakened with every and the blood did not stop. Pressing a towel to his stomach, he noticed must have been serious, since he continued to urinate every 5–3 minutes, a strong urge, he urinated, but only blood came out. The internal damage depression, had soaked his clothes and was dripping on the floor. Feeling upstairs in his bedroom, he saw that blood, seeping from the umbilical staying outside was unsafe.

to drop everything and return to the house. They had done all they could, swimming away. The pain was unbearable, and he shouted to the puari with a flash of lightning he saw the tail of an enormous yellowish python blow to the abdomen. It was followed by a powerful clap of thunder, and standing in the middle of the seething current, he felt a sudden painful their throats.

almost swam in the direction of the kitchen. The water was already up to left outside and asked the puari to try to save something — Mahatma! nowhere to be found. He remembered that the kitchen supplies had been was slightly shorter than Gandhi and clearly needed help, but he was rushed back into the swiftly rising waters to look for the other bull, who motionless, the bulk of his white body gleaming in the darkness. They down. Towering over the terrace like a huge wet mountain, the bull stood difficulty made him climb up onto the veranda, where Gandhi calmed

Yamuna was unfolding here and now: pain, destruction, and healing treated as long-awaited guests. The drama set off by the calling of the forces that had answered his call had every right to expect to be and disappointed the beings recently arrived or already dwelling here: smasman. His absence would have interrupted certain subtle processes trying to avoid. Even in an extreme situation, he could not leave the must take you to the hospital at once..." That was exactly what he was present began with one voice to lament: "Why didn't you call us? We to his room. Of course he had to tell of the python incident, and those the time, came upstairs and saw the bloody trail on the floor, she rushed When Devanuti, with the other guests who happened to be in the house at

vanished. The bleeding stopped, the pain almost passed, and he felt relief. But now everything will begin to settle." With these words Hanuman Yamuna herself to come here, and such an outcome was to be expected. "You called great powers — and they answered the invitation. You asked Hanuman appeared in the room again, and His voice was reassuring.

the "gathering" of dark spirits, but he was sure of what he had seen: enormous great vanished. He could not explain how he had witnessed began to lay themselves into a bundle, like brushwood. Then the from somewhere a large robe loop appeared, and the objects (or beings) made another motion, and another cloud of black shadows appeared, resembling firewood, began to gather around Him. The Lord of Spirits stick. He brandished this object, and hundreds of black shadows, staff, standing on the roof and holding in his other hand something like a holding onto the flag-

vision. In his head flashed swiftly moving frames: here was Hanuman rooftop, but he continued to observe the Deity through a kind of tunnel. It is hard to say how exactly Hanuman moved from the room to the photo.

clearly saw the gleaming, intricate ornament of His belt, adorning a red was indistinct. Hanuman was standing with his back to him, but he

In 1995, a visitor came to him at the ashram in Vrindavan. The son of a

Path to Hanuman

everything around.

Gods too were part of the highest Deity, Nature, whose breath sustained normal (and expected) as any other natural phenomenon. After all, the to doubt reality — it tested him daily. The appearance of the gods was as What had happened quickly became part of the past. There was no need from the well.

the pond filled with fresh water, and there was no need to hire water positive; in the following months the quality of the soil improved sharply, absorb all the moisture. But overall the consequences of the flood were The water receded slowly, and the earth needed almost three months to

only the frame reminded one of the events of that stormy night.

then hung for a long time in the covered. With time the image faded, and body of the python across his shoulders and took a photograph, which a proper introduction. He weighed 40 kg. Someone said the heavy yellow The next day, subdued and sleepily, the 4.2-meter prisoner was brought for tonight furiously, tearing the bag into which they were flying to put him. him in the abdomen. Local snake-charmers were called. The giant serpent head as if in shame. Most likely it was the same python that had struck the palace, then, abandoning attempts to flee, coiled into rings, riding its seeing people approaching, the snake tried to climb to the upper level of once, calling him: among the columns of the palace lay a huge python. of the palace, where the herd now resided. But she came running back at of the bull Candhi, and Devahuti carried sweets up to the upper terraces Several months later, on October 2nd, they were celebrating the birthday had climbed the ramp to the other cows on his own.

praised. The young bull Madhav was found safe and sound: it seemed he In the morning he felt almost well, except for a swollen belly horribly were part of this play.

it." He pondered. Asking a medium to prove his abilities was unwise; resolutely, he announced that he had brought "a message from Hanuman. And now the astrologer's son sat in the darsan hall. Nervously but intervene to protect the interests of other spirits.

do not get involved in human affairs, although occasionally they probes, and giving another chance. Usually astral inhabitants and deities humbly, relieving people from pain and grief, restoring shattered became his duty. The spirit itself was obliged to work for the good of would proclaim His will. Providing a "direct connection" with the Deity who became the new channel for the spirit through which Hanuman powers), the old medium transferred his abilities to the astrologer's son. Two weeks before his death, out of gratitude (or at the insistence of higher consequences.

interference with the karmas of ghosts and people always has brought the medium good money and fame. And also illness, since were conducted in remote places of northern India, and these events and the medium usually pronounces the verdict. Such trials of ghosts with other complications caused by ghosts (and sometimes by people), which cases of possession by spirits are reviewed and resolved, along medium during the so-called *chirpats*, special spiritistic gatherings at whose body was used by a powerful spirit. The astral being "entered" the relatives. He had been a devotee of Hanuman and a powerful medium, been caring for a dying old man who had been abandoned by his rather unusual. Out of the kindness of his heart, the astrologer's son had that Hanuman Himself wished to speak with the Guru. The story was In October 1992 he arrived unexpectedly, visibly excited, and declared was not only *Kṛiṣṇa*.

three years later, this man's life changed radically, and the reason for this the astrologer's son began to take his first steps on the path of yoga. About and mind, and an equally agile character. His request was granted, and was most amusing: with monkey-like grimaces, lively facial expressions well-known royal astrologer from Cwalior asked for initiation. The man

required a secluded place, preferably near a large body of water, since ritual was to attain long-term prosperity and well-being. The ceremony they conduct a special puja dedicated to Hanuman. The purpose of the In December 1996 a learned shastri suggested to one of his disciples that laws rather than human beliefs.

The patterns of karma opened up to him anew, in the light of universal of the afterlife, the journey of souls, and the principles of reincarnation. These "sessions" expanded his horizons, for Hanuman spoke of the secrets during this time he had several remarkable conversations with the Deity. Almost a year had passed since the first contact with Hanuman, and sweating profusely before him.

the current Kali-yuga, and that His will was announced by the man Hanuman, one of the eight immortals remaining on Earth until the end of medium. This forced him to acknowledge that he had indeed spoken with occurred that confirmed details mentioned in the conversation with the the medium and the spirit within. But within a few months several events At first he refused to believe that the Deity itself was speaking through but not on that day.

speak with you without an intermediary. Directly." The wish was granted. Fixing his gaze on the medium, he addressed the being within: "I want to sounded strangely muffled — it was the spirit within him that spoke.

minutes. Because of this, the voice, deprived of the circulation of air, When the spirit inside him spoke, the medium's breathing stopped for 2-3 swaying, he imitated the movements of a rider.

his arms at the elbows as if holding reins, and sitting cross-legged, slightly clapping them over his head. In a half-trance, from time to time he bent eyes, he rhythmically and mechanically raised and lowered his hands, of unusual vibrations passed through the medium's body. Closing his short, enigmatic phrases interrupted by pauses of heavy breathing. Waves He nodded to the guest, inviting him to begin, and the man spoke in since to summon such forces without a valid reason is simply dangerous.

lipsticks, combs, powder-cases, and other cosmetic items were lowered. One part of the ceremony greatly puzzled some Western guests: mirrors, religious part of the rite.

priest had to be found, and Pandit Janardan ji from Cwalior took on the December. Two months after the first puja, the old shastri died; another. For the next twelve years the puja to Hanuman was performed each forces — the promise was too serious to be broken.

The sankalpa had been given on the smashtan in the presence of powerful warned him about this, but after a brief hesitation he decided to continue. will have to conduct these ceremonies for the next 12 years!" Nobody had visit learned of the peculiarities of the ritual and exclaimed: "Oh, now you The ritual became his duty. Several months later, a pandit who came on a out and completed.

then informs the logical mind of the specific decision that must be carried depths of that essence which determines who a person is. The sankalpa intention is not formed by the intellect; it comes from within, from the striving for the highest truth, resolve, intention, and promise. Such an The general meaning of sankalpa is a vow, an obligation to maintain the

the puja to him, rather than to the disciple who had initiated the ritual. some reason, consciously or not, the old pandit passed the sankalpa for the ritual would become an annual event for him for the next 12 years. For offerings. Absorbed in the rhythm of the mantras, he did not suspect that balconies, monkeys and birds patiently awaited the remains of the sacrificial watched and listened; ghosts peeped through the dark arches of the were pale and almost invisible. It was still and windless; the smashtan priest began the puja. In the bright sunlight the flames of the oil lamps joined them. After initiating them into the complex parts of the ritual, the disciple and several of his friends, settled on the steps of the pond. He arrived in Govardhan, and all of them, together with the aforementioned ceremony, received consent. On a sunny, cool day a group of pandits place, the royal smashtan, and having asked for permission to conduct the water played an important role. The disciple thought of the ideal secluded

colorful and serene.

reflected off the surface of the water. The celebration turned out solemn and the vaults of the lower arches of the palace caught up the prayers, exclaiming "swaha" at the end of each name pronounced by the bandits' grain into the fire.

names of Hanuman were read aloud; those present threw handfuls of thirteen Brahmins, and the fire sacrifice lasted several hours. The 1,000 became a solemn event. More than 600 people were invited, including The final, carefully orchestrated bus, which took place in December 2008, continued.

and effective alternative to the sacred Lake Pambra, and the bus "legalization": by every measure the water at the smashan was a powerful this mattered. The choice of the place for the ritual needed no king," and on Google maps it was marked as "Brahma king," but none of The archaeological archives named the bond of the smashan "Vishvram episode."

"overlaid" itself upon the Govardhan smashan, reproducing the Vedic Govardhan was called "Lake Pambra." The landscape of distant Hampi on the day of the bus to Hanuman, the bond of the smashan in possibly because nearby is Anjaneya Hill, the place of His birth. Therefore "Pambra"). The Ramayana states that this lake is also dear to Hanuman, magnificent ruins of ancient Hampi (whose very name derives from His wife. The lake still exists, located in Karnataka, among the by Her devotion, Shiva offered Her any boon, and She chose to become Parvati, meditated on the lake created by Her father Brahma. Impressed It is said that the Goddess Pambra, one of the many forms of the goddess worshipped as Lake Pambra, one of the five sacred lakes of India.

was a woman, even if Divine. In this bus the bond of the smashan was Shakti. She was given everything that might please the Goddess, for She water was worshipped as yet another form of divine feminine energy, into the water. But there was nothing unusual about this: the body of

before the Jangui, who unpurifiedly ate it, and the ritual was completed in
approached, carrying an orange, the monkey waited. The fruit was placed
the grains and crumbs of sweets remaining from the bus. The
male with a black face and white beard sat by the pond, lazily picking up
morning she saw the same monkey, now back to its usual size: a large
a gigantic gray Jangui, watching her intently and seriously. In the
The bus was over. The next night one of the female disciples dreamed of
fruits. The rest depended on Time and Destiny.

and the carrying out of the mission, helping him patiently to await its
their own incarnation. In his case, incredible events stimulated awareness
of life and marched into oblivion without ever learning the reasons for
if people tried to attain it. More often, they were unaware of the meaning
souls had simply no other mission. And the smasman supported this goal
cycle of rebirths was created for the achievement of this single goal, and
ambitious — though hidden from themselves — goal: self-realization. The
shorter than that of landscapes and buildings, yet humans had a truly
since there was a limit to all resistance. The duration of a human life was
smasman, had been built to withstand time. Not, of course, indefinitely.
The elements themselves, however, were unchanging. This place, this
beings, the combinations of basic elements that composed their bodies.
thought about how everything was temporary: inanimate objects, living
Looking at the majestic palaces, at the gleaming surface of the pond, he
inner peace in the daily feast of yoga.

but not defeated by Maya, the disciples grew wiser, and each had to find
including ordinary logic, was inverted and called into review. Battered
once more into the world of spirits and legends, where everything
them. They had to return to the ocean of worldly life, only to come back
the next day. They were all his spiritual children: he supported each of
disappeared, people took their leave and dissolved into the amalgam of
Colorful silhouettes were reflected in the gleaming mirror of the pond and
watched them, savoring a long-awaited and always short-lived solitude.
paying their respects to the power of Shakti. Sitting on the steps, he
At the conclusion of the ceremony people circumambulated the pond,

was learning confirmed the inviolable law of balance between the world. This communion deepened his perception of the scope of events. What he Guru Paramhansa.

Hanuman entrusted to him, all of them were, no doubt, sanctioned by the gods could not stand between Guru and disciple, and whatever missions Did Hanuman know about Baba? He had no doubt about it. Even the baths of karma are unathomable.

surprise... 33 years ago he had been a student at college... Truly, the "Hanuman ji said that he has known you for the last 33 years." Such a mission. After discussing the principal matter, the medium added: Hanuman. Hanuman instructed him to visit the samashan on a delicate was originally from Kanpur and also maintained a connection with Quite strange information came in 2002 from another medium. This man

without attempting to evaluate or measure them.

days, shifting the focus of attention from one plane of reality to another, with His back to him. After such meetings, he could remain silent for to time Hanuman appeared in His traditional image, but always standing not to speak at all and made no attempt to summon the Deity. From time clarity of inquiry, though he never asked any questions. Honestly, he tried place on the mental plane and required complete concentration and he tried inconspicuously to narrow his eyes. Their communication took The silhouette looked like a hologram and would not vanish, even when same place, an indistinctly outlined figure of an old man would appear. darsan hall early. Upstairs in the bedroom, in the corner, always in the medium. On such days he would receive a mental signal and leave the After some time Hanuman began to speak with him directly, without a born, where the rites came from.

worked on the mind. Now the mind knew where the mysteries were not only the nightly samadhis but also the daily puja and yearly rituals traumatic events of the past arrived. He too noticed changes in himself: outer transformation: memories surfaced, the parting with painful and yet another way. Many participants in the rite reported signs of inner and

decided to perform an annual Prayaschitta for the new initiates, and if by all means do so. Recognizing the powerful effect of the ritual, he lineage, and that if he could ever conduct it for his own disciples, he must that Prayaschitta was an important part of initiation into the Logic dark water, he remembered the words of the Guru, who had once said ritual of purification — bathing in the pond. Standing knee-deep in the Before the Puja to Hanuman, the bandit made everyone undergo the

Prayaschitta. Abhishek. Milk

energy.

expanding consciousness was charging the darkness with thunderous man they knew as "Yogita." By midnight the gathering storm of his hidden in the thick darkness began to feel the rising mental waves of the The fragrant plume of incense smoke rose to the starry sky, and the spirits foreheads, sealing the blessing, and then walked away into the darkness. priestly passed their palms over the flickering flame and touched their flowers, sprinkled grains of rice, and lit incense. One by one, people promise of blessing. Standing over the dark water, the puja ritual a ceremony in honor of Shakti was filled with power, peace, and the The puja at the pond became part of the daily evening ritual. The short astral bodies and those who dwell in human ones.

ruler of the world of spirits, Hanuman helped both those who lived in some took on human births, others had never had a human nature. As the Over time he became convinced that the world was governed by spirits:

connected with the gods themselves. Yes, even the Gods had karma.

did the gods assist certain mortals, if their karmas were somehow but they maintained the balance between the worlds. Only occasionally with the welfare of humanity. Divine beings had entirely different goals. Otherwise, the gods kept their distance and were not at all concerned when angry, offended, or harmful spirits acted upon the lives of people. of men and the realm of spirits. Hanuman and his helpers intervened

from within. From this day on, the mind began to work differently, and the long-forgotten but eternal essence of self triumphantly emerged. Invisible karmic fossils and slag cracked and dissolved in the dark water, anticipation of change and a newfound faith in destiny.

The next signal from the bandit. The sun was bright, the air filled with the emerging with childlike smiles and shining eyes, they laughed, waiting into the water, leaving rose petals and oily yogurt stains on the surface. Hesitantly and then with growing enthusiasm, people dipped themselves flowers, grain, cow dung. Smearing these substances on their faces, first approaching each new initiate with ritual offerings: honey, milk, yogurt, and laughter died down. Behind him appeared the bandit, methodically variegated crowd accompanied by Devanuri. The cheerful noise, chatter, serious and focused, in a saffron-colored kurtas, he walked through the discipline.

and the clean page of the future was to be filled with sadhana, will, and many memories accumulated in it. Each participant hoped to start anew, had their heads shaved. Hair was considered "a carrier of karmas," too to the lower tiers of the palace, where, right by the pond, men by tradition of the exotic action, students took photos and cracked jokes. People came serious, others seemed animated and excited. Trying to get the most out to be surprisingly warm. Some of the new disciples were silent and When the initiates lined up on the steps of the pond, the water turned out in February 2008.

March, after the celebration of Shivaratri. The last prayaschitta took place transformation. The ritual was usually conducted in February or early changes were painful and radical, but always led to spiritual that occurred over the following year or two. More often than not the beginning of yoga practice, prayaschitta brought about global life changes some had a mild fever, but almost all dreamed vivid dreams. Timed to the intoxicating happiness and lightness, some withdrew into themselves, human destinies began to change. Many of the initiated felt an filled people with calm and peace. Set in motion by the ancient mystery,

was located across the road, it was hard to believe that temple offerings and the temple received the name "Canga of the Mind." Although the lake the Canga by the power of his own consciousness. Thus the body of water might on their way to the Canga, and in the morning Krishna summoned Shri Krishna's foster parents Nanda and Yasoda stopped here for the According to local legends, Lake Manasi Canga came into being when visible, peaking up from somewhere on the bottom.

water never became completely "milky," only separate white streaks were another well-known place — Radha's pond. Although these bodies of famous lake Manasi Canga, and sometimes white jets were seen in 30 years streams of milk would burst from underwater springs of the underground springs. In Braj this phenomenon is known: once every 50- was seeping into the pond of the smashtan through a system of he suspected that the milk used for offering in the temple across the street particular significance to what had happened. When it happened again, pond turned absolutely white, but at the time they had attached no Two or three months after their arrival at the smashtan, the water in the anyone's sins.

completely filled with human karmas and could no longer accept white, as if chalk had been dissolved in it. He joked that the pond was the water of the kund was clear, but from time to time it turned milky- endless, and each was certain that he had erred at least once. On that day they listened to the long list of sins that the pandit read out. The list was Resembling clumsy seals, the disciples crawled out onto the steps, now down by the heaviness of regrets.

out and immunity, so that mind and heart might no longer be weighed rather, they were paused, put away into a distant drawer, allowed to dry. Of course, the effects of past events and deeds did not vanish completely, doubts about the future.

subconscious. The ritual washed away the burden of the past along with transformation, intellect developed rapidly, purifying after the rerooted awakening spiritual sensitivity and intuition. In the process of difficult

and it filled oil lamps, boiled on kitchen stoves. Turned into yogurt, it were transformed into milk, and then it was offered to the fire as green soil. Filtered through the stomachs of cows, grass and the force of Nature Milk came from the earth, when rains and the heat of the sun fertilized the and everything was destined to reach Him.

sometimes he did try: everything returned to the source by various paths, try to explain to people the logic of the Great Equilibrium of things, but whether the milk could be donated to the poor instead. It is pointless to accept. Agnostics were amazed at such wastefulness and wondered one chased them away, since this was a sign that the offering had been that marked their path, and stray dogs unceremoniously licked it up. No Hill with pots of milk, pouring it on the earth in thin streams and droplets making the offering. That is why countless pilgrims walked around the intentions, the Abhishek could favorably influence the destiny of the one itself, performed in the name of righteous purposes and with benevolent acceptance of all beings. The offering of milk was as ancient as the earth Milk was love and life, a manifestation of the Universal Mother and Her place.

thousands of pilgrims would have begun visiting yet another miracle-decided to keep it secret, cherishing their hard-won seclusion. Otherwise However, they had been fortunate to witness this phenomenon, and they events or religious holidays, the logical conclusion was simply absent.

be tied to any particular

temperature shifts, or the level of oxygen released by algae. It could not no scientific explanation and was not connected with a change in weather, previous one. Braj was generous with miracles, but this phenomenon had days, then suddenly, within two months, changed color again to the In November 2016 the water in the pond remained milky-white for fifty showed a high level of lactose. Further investigation was pointless.

of pure curiosity he sent a sample of the water to a laboratory, and the test the dark, transparent waters of the pond slowly became milky-white. One could somehow fill the pond of the smashtan with milk. After some time,

strictest performance of logic practice; only then could consciousness be in the development of consciousness, one could succeed only by the extracting ghee was akin to logic discipline.

was obtained as a result was the immortal essence of milk. The process of stage churned. The freshly extracted butter was heated again, and what Milk must be heated, then cooled, turned into yogurt, and at the next potentially contains ghee.

manifest; Everyone has a body and a soul; every cow gives milk that general. How could one see this omnipresence, realize it, make it immortality of the soul. The statement of its omnipresence was too complex logic subtleties, no one could understand or experience the like ghee, the human soul symbolized hidden potential. But without substance in milk, raw milk spoils and turns sour.

does not spoil for hundreds of years. Despite the presence of an immortal transformation. It just needs to be processed and extracted, and then ghee Butter is always present in milk, as invisible potential, a variant of

substance still continued to die. What then is immortality?

its omnipresence and immortality. But people possessed of immortal and all these conversations usually ended with the general statement of Over the years he heard many discussions about the nature of the soul,

dairy farm was working excellently.

time was right; moreover, thanks to the grace of the sacred Hill, the new There was no particular reason for the offering; he simply felt that he received about 10 tons. When the soil ceased to absorb it, the ritual ended. 101 liters were poured over the Shivalingam, and the soil of the samashan In 2017 they performed the milk offering for almost a year. Every night element belonging to Earth herself.

soil, becoming rain. Such was the great cycle; milk was yet another sacred completed its service, the substance of life and love returned again to the became a ritual offering, was fed to great and small. Then, having

was cold, but he felt his face burning. The notorious fierce Doreman another man on the floor: dark-skinned, covered only with a loincloth. It the Guru. Learning his back against the wall, beside the fireplace, sat he nonetheless managed to bow and lowered himself to the floor before legs crossed, Baraji was sitting on a wooden cot, facing north. Stunned, stepped through the door.

the words sounded far more offensive. Enraged, ready for a fight, he open, and someone said loudly: "Cretin, come inside." In the local dialect large Nerali knife, he went downstairs. The door of the central hall was dogs were more reliable than hired guards. But tonight... Cribbing the were a common matter; confrontations with the locals continued, and the the room. The first thought that came to mind was a break-in. Invasions sat up on the bed, wondering how the Doreman had managed to enter usually locked from the inside, and it was the only door that locked. He kisses on the second floor, in his bedroom. The door leading upstairs was But now the dog was abruptly greeting him with disordered wet night one of the two huge Doremans was left downstairs for guard duty. Almost all the doors in the house were broken or missing entirely, and at licking his face.

followed, around three in the morning, he woke up because someone was indistinguishable from others. In the pre-dawn hours of 25 December that Dattatreya. Otherwise it was just a cold December night, 21 December 1992 fell on a full moon; moreover, it was the birthday of

The Second Meeting with Baraji

of the mind, obtained from the cow of the body.

and the Guru oversaw the extraction of the grey of the soul from the milk discovered. The aim of Kriya was the unveiling of the essence of the self, recognize itself as its own immortal substance. But first it had to be identification with the worldly "I," consciousness slowly came to the mind so that the seeker could realize its nature. Freed from considered a separate entity. This was the sorcery of yoga — it "churned"

meaning and significance of the yantra, instructing him in detail about the it in detail. He had to listen attentively to the Guru. Baraji spoke about the brass, it was rather heavy, about 50 kg, but there was no time to examine a bulky object, and he recognized a Shri Yantra. Made of metal resembling stood up and handed him a heavy bundle wrapped in puri. Inside was about 100g. The stranger who had been sitting motionless by the fireplace Baraji described the "tasks" he was to perform, and this time it was not was never mundane.

instructions, directions, or assignments, but the purpose of the meetings conversation. Yes, such beings could appear before a mortal to give power emanating from the Master was not conducive to casual lucky ones were fortunate not to soil their pants," he thought. The ancient advice on diet and career success. He kept his face impassive. "These described long spiritual discussions with the Master and His detailed He had heard tales from people who claimed to have met Baraji. They and excitement.

every thought of his, and this produced in him a strange mixture of guilt second time brought no relief at all. Now he sat before the one who knew seeing emotions. The fact that he was seeing the immortal master for the fear, caution, delight, and curiosity, and he tried to control all these laws were playfully touching his face. He was overwhelmed at once by become nervous. He felt as though the velvet pads of a powerful lion's nervousness. When a mighty immortal being cracks jokes, anyone would The Guru was clearly in an excellent mood, and this only added to his why iconography differed so sharply from the original.

widely depicted among practitioners of Krishna — and again he wondered the Master's appearance had nothing in common with the slim youth Mahavatar did not resemble the body of a bodybuilder, at the same time, white cloth. The strong, muscular, and completely hairless body of the On that cold winter night, Baraji's hips were wrapped only in a piece of crawled under the bed and fell silent.

put into the room and, like a butterfly, began to lick Baraji's feet, then

not try to decipher all the details of the information he had received in the scale of the predicted events was not entirely clear, although he did sense of mission. What had been said was to remain a secret and besides, The second meeting with the Guru opened new perspectives, granting a silence.

sounds helped collect their thoughts. For some time they drank hot tea in effect. Devanuti silently walked to the kitchen; the familiar morning never considered himself particularly sensitive) the strongest physical immortal Guru for more than two hours had produced (in him, who had left his body. He slid down to the floor. Being in the presence of the accelerating truck, and his legs turned to rubber, as if all the energy had in a half-trance. Then the realization of what had happened hit like an He looked at Devanuti. Her mouth was half open, and both of them were from view.

for a brief moment, then waved his hand in farewell and disappeared in front. Climbing the stairs to the roof of the structure, the Guru paused toward a half-ruined old building. Mahavata's silent companion walked on the threshold, watching the immortal yogi slowly walk along the alley beginning to emerge, radiating a dim milky light. He and Devanuti stood The winter night was slowly melting, and the outlines of the trees were out the door.

made a pranam. Babaji smiled, raised His hand in blessing, and stepped Babaji," and gestured for her to bow. Trying to contain her emotions, she astonishment, staring wide-eyed at the visitors. He whispered: "This is came down to make morning tea and let out the dogs — and froze in be going." He followed the Guru to the exit. At that moment Devanuti "Well, the time has come for you to attend to the assignments. And I must The visit lasted almost two hours; around five in the morning Babaji rose. but he had no right to discuss this with anyone.

suspicious position, and the ritual had several layers of meaning at once, in the afternoon, when the necessary constellations stood in the time of its installation. It was to be consecrated a few minutes before five

At the end of Diwali 2019, Babaji left Benares, and after that the vivid inhaling Time and exhaling the souls leaving the earthly plane.

was batched and repainted. The invisible Kashi remained unchanged, temples were discovered. However, the outer shell cracked and split: it the inner courtyard of unknown and previously unseen shrines and were demolished, and to the surprise of archaeologists and historians, in front of the Vishwanath temple were cleared of debris: some old buildings replacement of sewerage and water-treatment systems. The old streets in reconstruction affected more than a thousand acres, including the Kashi (united). The scale of the transformations was enormous, and the Kashi (safe), Samyukt Kashi (organized), Nirmal Kashi (pure), and Ekikrit Samanya Kashi (picturesque), Samanyat Kashi (progressive), Samakshit Benares was undergoing significant changes: the city was to become rather loud sounds of nearly construction.

"message" was clear as high-resolution video, and the audio carried the anonymity. Babaji's Jata had vanished. His hair was cut short. The visual dwelling apparently provided the immortal Master with complete. With two tiny rooms, a tiny kitchen, and a toilet, this rather modest than two years, in a small rented house on a narrow street in the Old City. 2019. Babaji let it be known that He had been living in Benares for more. The last time he "viewed" a news summary from the CNN was in autumn.

was the constant sense of mighty force, confirming its own existence.

the visions: they were already imprinted in consciousness. The main thing strong feeling could last a couple of weeks. There was no need to recreate transmission, he fell into a state of ringing detachment, and this unusually before his inner sight, and this could happen at any moment. After such a voice-over. Words sounded simultaneously with images that flashed deemed necessary: the messages came as visions, detailed scenes with a Babaji sent him mental messages, "showing" and "transmitting" what He. Once every four or five years, without any visible logic or regularity,

go through the initial levels.

one sitting. It was all like Krishna: in order to take the next steps, one had to

such mystery? One of the many suppositions about the identity of the Who then was this immortal yogi, and why was his name surrounded by provoked possibly irreversible reactions from the Guru.

coming from his son's room and intervened before Tinkori's summons presence. Lahiri Mahasaya had instantly felt the powerful vibration meant only the absence of maturity. Familiar with the signs of Baba's satisfy a friend's curiosity. Such requests were a sign of disrespect and Mahasaya himself for the same thing, when he had summoned Him to demonstrate miracles. Once, the Mahavatar had reprimanded Lahiri disturb the Guru with requests to appear in bodily form, much less to Tinkori received a stern rebuke: the father ordered him never again to doing! Never repeat this!!!

floor and, gasping for breath, burst into his son's room: "What are you was interrupted. Lahiri Mahasaya hurriedly descended from the upper Baba appeared, but the details remained unknown, since the meeting before him. He spent 14 hours in meditation, and his desire was fulfilled. vowed not to move from his place until the Mahavatar Himself appeared irresistible desire to see the great yogi, the 18-year-old Tinkori Lahiri remembered too well his father's experience. Overwhelmed by an personality of the Guru of their parampara. Perhaps because he not interested in the mystery of the origin and formation of the Satyacharan Lahiri never met Baba in person; it seemed the Master was

The Identity of Baba!

Mahadeva, had not been accidental.

accidental, just as His visit to the royal samashan, the country residence of The presence of the Mahavatar in the city of Shiva could not have been world, having chosen Benares as his temporary headquarters?

years? Did the immortal yogi influence significant changes throughout the staying in touch. But what kept Baba in the eternal city for almost two let him know of his whereabouts at all: perhaps it is simply His method of images and mental messages "switched off." It is unclear why Baba had

was unimportant — except for one circumstance: a son of mortal parents, mention that the Mahavata spoke Hindi, not Tamil or Bengali. But all this. The diaries of Lahiri Mahasaya and the memoirs of Yogananda also trace of southern softness in him.

Pradesh and was fair-skinned, with rather sharp features. There was not a trace of a southern accent. He looked like a native of western Uttar spoke Hindi as it is spoken in north India, and in his speech there was not interesting, but when he had met the immortal Guru in person, Baraji supposedly migrants from the Malabar coast. Reading about all this was his parents belonged to the Nambrudi caste of Brahmins and were celebration of Kartikai Deepam, on the night before the new moon, and had been born. The future immortal came into the world during the child was born under the same rising star Rohini, under which Krishna where the river Kaveri flows into the Indian Ocean. As it happened, the born on 30 November 503 AD, in a small coastal village in Tamil Nadu, and in a former life his name was Nagara. It was believed that Baraji was Agastya and Bogamatha. Allegedly Baraji was one of the Tamil Siddhas, stories told about his childhood, abduction, and training under Rishi India. Books were written and published, lectures given, fascinating. There also existed detailed "testimonies" that Baraji was a native of south different.

whistle). Definitely, both legendary yogis were great — but absolutely to 32, and wore none of the Matha accessories (earrings, pasclets, Corakmath as a 12–16-year-old youth, while Baraji looked older, from 52 lightning." But there was a catch: all the known texts describe Baraji. Years later, S.K.S. even wrote a book about it — "Baraji: Frozen various suppositions about the connection between Corakmath and friend masterfully developed the most interesting parallels and made Enchanted, almost obsessed, with the personality of Corakmath, his Siddhoji Rao Siddhi would discuss Krishna yoga and its masters for hours. Remembering Cwalior in the seventies, he smiled: at that time he and Mahavata said that he was Corakmath, one of the immortal Mathas.

intentions and projections, too offensive and suffocating for an immortal. Overcrowded urban areas emitted the mental miasmas of human occasionally. He visited big cities as well, but these were one-off cases. That the Mahavata appeared at the Kumbha Mela was well known.

the world of men was simply another alternative reality.

different level of intelligence and perception of reality. Perhaps for Him was clear: He was an ancient mighty being possessing a completely Baraji's playful disposition and the entire informality of the meeting, if Baraji was a laughing lion and he himself a helpless child. Despite Curu, which had not entirely disappeared at the second meeting either. He remembered the searing touch of fear at his first meeting with the

beat the mighty energies of the Mahavata himself for any length of time. Moreover, however advanced they might be, they would not be able to would not have endured the constant presence of "spiritual followers," live in groups, much less perform common daily rituals. Baraji himself. Those who have attained the highest steps of development could hardly resembled some sort of kindergarten for the realized.

most amusing. No, it was not disrespectful, but... the description feet of the Curu. The description of a group of immortals seemed to him. After bathing in the cold springs they were allowed to row at the Lotus Himalayas, and every morning Baraji's sister led them to morning rituals. laugh outright. Allegedly, enlightened yogis lived near the Master in the. Another story about a group of immortals chosen by Baraji made him dietary recommendations. The narrators simply lacked imagination.

you..." Immortals who have lifted the veil of eternity do not hand out dry smile. "My son, you should eat two eggs a day; the protein is good for elevated descriptions of their dialogues with Baraji, he could not hide his. Some authors claimed to have personally met the Mahavata. Reading the himself had succeeded in this.

His teaching definitely helped to prevent old age and death, since Baraji Baraji had attained immortality. Sadhana had granted Him eternal life.

noted the striking similarity between Barahi and Svaminarayan, the author in 5014, working on commentaries to the "Hatha Yoga Pradipika", the influence of his diksha guru.

Indian philosophical school and society could have been inspired by the ideology of this yoga. The transformations that Shankara brought to the himself since the common philosophical concepts were closest to the initiated him into Krishna yoga could easily have been the Mahavata. The chandal who met Shankaracharya at the ghats of the Ganga and untouchable was Shiva himself, but he could just as well have been Barahi. Shankaracharya fell prostrate before the chandal. It is said that the reality, the illusory state of multiplicity and differentiation melted, and shattered all his dogmas. As well as belief in a single eternal unchanging Advaita Vedanta, Shankaracharya instantly realized: these words from Brahma." Philosopher, theologian, and famous propagator of is real, this world is unreal, and the Jiva, or individual soul, is not distinct Brahma Satyam Jagat Mithya Jivo Brahmaniva Na Aparah... "Only Brahma

To the all-pervading Jiva, or to this illusory body?,"

exclaimed: "Get away!" and the chandal asked: "To whom do you speak? Chandals live in smashans surrounded by dogs. Shankaracharya not cross the road of a Brahmin. More despised than the untouchables, people of this caste were considered so impure that they literally could Ganga, and right in front of him a dirty and ragged chandal passed by. Shankaracharya is well known: once he was returning after bathing in the Shankaracharya. And this too was quite possible. One case from the life of Lahiri Mahasaya spoke of Barahi as the secret spiritual guru of Swami Keshavananda, Swami Pranavananda and others had stated that Barahi. Why not? Sri Yukteswar maintained that Swami Keshavananda, Shankara, and many other religious and spiritual figures were disciples of There were also speculations that Sai Baba, Jesus, Guru Nanak, Adi and had to appear in the megapolises.

still synonymous with sadhana. Unless He was carrying out some mission Of course, Barahi could endure anything, but seclusion and solitude were

latter asked: "Did you not see Babaji when you entered here?" No. When Yuktेश्वar visited Lahiri Mahasaya after the Kumbha Mela, the latter said: "I saw him in his 'Autobiography'." Yogananda described an interesting episode.

control? The body can be left at will or remain in it forever.

they wished, control life and death. But what is the meaning of all this could decrease or increase the mass of the body, fly, enchant, obtain what eternal life. The Nine Siddhas of antiquity, the nine immortal Nathas, invisible. But this was only a side effect. Control of the elements granted air, ether, fire and earth made his body translucent or completely body, the Mahavatar cast no shadow. Brought to equal proportion, water, with the mystery of his origin. Fully controlling the basic elements of the Babaji possessed something else, and this something was not connected

Siddhis, Small Miracles and Magic Tricks

the mass only gods and immortals were invited.

were put ornaments on the stained glass of the Temple of Time. And to layers of history and time. All the interwoven episodes of human history unnoticed among people, to observe changes, moving easily through the Obscurity remains the greatest luxury for immortals: it allows them to be

of the secret of His origin change?

to tell his story, He will do so Himself. Besides, what would the disclosure reasons for the secrecy maintained for hundreds of years. If Babaji decides reveal his identity was to be respected. There must have been serious hypothesis of the secret origin of the Mahavatar. Babaji's unwillingness to As the theories multiplied, he decided not to add to them yet another

Master, and it was not a coincidence.

highest representative of Hatha Yoga." That is how Mahasaya called the nothing at all. But Lahiri Mahasaya recorded in his diary: "...Babaji is the Babaji had given him. Of Svamarama little is known. More precisely, content linguistically echoed the explanation of the higher krias that interpretation of the shlokas, the more obvious the parallels became. The of this most enigmatic of all logic texts. The more he delved into the

recently, and Pythagoras's theorem was used by Einstein in the Special Scientists recognized the proofs of Newton's discoveries comparatively and improbability could become probable.

surely have turned him as a sorcerer or a vampire, but this was India, and almost invisible in daylight. In medieval Europe the Inquisition would disappeared almost entirely, like the luminous "nimbus" over his head, brightness of his logic and diluted the density of the shadow. If compared to the shadow of his companion it was light and pure. The sometimes, standing next to someone, he observed his own shadow, and become less dense, and in the end will "disappear" completely.

the rays of light rather than reflect them. Gradually the shadow will and then the shadow will not be noticeable: the body will begin to absorb proportion of the elements can reduce the density of the atomic structure, any gross substance, including the tissues of the human body. An equal increasing the content of air and ether. This can lead to the translucency of decreasing the percentage of earth and water elements in the body, and Through the practice of yoga, the basic elements can be balanced. The physical world consists of the same five elements as the body.

disassembling the particles of Matter.

sometimes to be transported into other planes, assembling and allows the body of a highly developed yogi to become invisible, and an object, at best. Balancing of elements at the cellular and atomic level same time, the eyes can simultaneously distinguish only three surfaces of human sight, objects are visible only because they reflect light. At the illusions are mostly optical in nature. Because of the limited spectrum of combination of numerous illusions. Or rather, the world is real, and the made him unable to see the immortal Guru. The material world itself is a However, it was not Yuktेश्वar's lack of perseverance in meditation that meditate more. Your sight is still clouded..."

Baba ji. Seeing Yuktेश्वar's astonishment, Baba ji said: "Now you must behind a veil of the brightest light, blinding as the sun, he recognized Yuktेश्वar had not seen the Guru, but when his vision unfocused,

proved and embodied by science, they were already taken as a given and scientists, and the boldest suppositions and theories became reality. Once cinema, computer games, and comics, they stimulated the imagination of Miracles formerly regarded as fairy tales were now finding reflection in dimensions, and other mysteries of life.

Even after physical death, the transfer of consciousness into other came to be drawn to the cases of "zombie cells," of the brain continuing to "rediscovered" by modern science. Gradually the attention of researchers What until recently sounded like science fiction was now being metaphysics is no easy task even for advanced practitioners.

broader picture of creation, and yet not to confuse physics with light were one. Logic consciousness is open to the perception of the light and accept it as a physical parameter, but for him the outer and inner. It is difficult for the logical mind to recognize the existence of the inner light. Anyone can see external light, but logic strives to discern the inner. In the nucleus of every atom there is contained an enormous quantity of pure consciousness, a network of neurons.

the logic body, such electrical currents can transform the body itself into tissue can burn out and turn to ash. In the case of the balanced elements of "switched on" at full capacity produces such strong currents that muscle but only 5% of the voltage is used. Perhaps for safety, since a brain The human organism works on electrical impulses generated by the brain.

The next step — the miracle of the electric body.

structure of a diamond: a body not subject to destruction became eternal. muscle tissue and bones could be transformed into the crystalline confirmation of someone's actual achievement. The cellular structure of electric) body, and this was not just an entertaining hypothesis but a trust. Some texts spoke of a vajra body, the diamond (or, rather, the therefore he studied the treatises of the ancient logic with respect and postulates were known long before their proofs were recognized, and discovery of Pythagoras, applied to three spatial coordinates. All these Theory of Relativity only in 1905. The metric equation was actually a

uneven light of the lamp a large snake stared at the petrified spectators' experiment with the skull of a cobra, he obtained the same result. In the illusion reinforced by the power of mantras. Performing a similar radius of the lamp's light. This was not hypnosis at all, but an optical the experiment saw him in the guise of a furious wolf, but only within the and body underwent incredible transformation. The invited witnesses of this cotton and placed in an oil lamp. In the light of such a lamp any face certain mantras. When the plant gave a cotton boll, a wick was made from of a wolf had to be watered daily with milk and water while repeating a A cotton seed planted under a certain arrangement of the stars in the skull the realization of the intention — were equally important.

Pronunciation of the mantras, and the sankalpa — the willed impetus for particular arrangement of the necessary constellations, the correct they required precise adherence to the instructions. Time, perhaps, the some of the "miracles" described in the book were simple tricks, but even not surprising results.

entertainment, he followed the instructions and obtained impressive, if written by the lord of the rakshasas, Ravana. Out of curiosity, for Uddhava. The full text was called "Ravan Samhit", since it had been recommendations and fragments of the tantras of Dattatreya and rituals and the use of medicinal herbs; the text contained astrological written in ancient Hindi. It was a manual on the art of mantras, tantric Somewhere around 1991 he came across an old book, "Puran Indrajala",

were kept secret, but every secret has a shelf life.

Discovered in the solitude of thousands of sadhanas, yogis discovered sadhanas, and in all times yogis have possessed varying degrees of this art. if they were Lego bricks. Such abilities are a side effect of advanced could with a single effort of will easily assemble the elements of matter, as means creating an optical illusion. As a Siddha of the highest level, He When Babaji showed Lahiri Mahasaya a golden palace, He was by no simple — accepted logic.

no longer subject to doubt. Youthful imagination ran ahead of the limping

entirely predictable career results, he was studying the forgotten art of There was plenty of time for experiments. While his peers were achieving again for quite a long time, more than twenty years.

irregularities of the plaster. Frightened, Gavi Puri fled and did not appear neighbor had just been standing, and saw only the scratches and astonishment, stared at the concrete wall behind the place where his smiling, he answered: "This..." — and vanished from sight. Gavi Puri, in doing — what is it that you do?"

endless visitors. Finally Gavi Puri dared to ask: "What exactly are you young logic — he did not work, hardly went outside, and received parcels. The young man was intrigued by the strange lifestyle of the who usually came onto their rooftop terrace to train with dumbbells and The effect of sutra dhyan he decided to test on his neighbor, Gavi Puri, mind.

eyes. For this, not physical silence was important but the stillness of the immediately switch off, they would lose focus and not trust their own blocking any thoughts. The mental radar of other people would mental waves, drawing in all impressions of the external world, and One could stage a complete disappearance by stopping the projection of or rather guessed, another amazing phenomenon, called "sutra dhyan." Having mastered one trick, he moved on to the next, and so discovered uninvited guests and possible murderers.

the radius of the lamp's light. Sadhus used these tricks to frighten off effect — a person could appear dismembered, his limbs scattered within A paste made from a certain herb could create an unusual and frightening and those nearby would see a mighty predator.

image of a panther, it was enough to place these seeds in the mouth — and covered with silver, gold, and copper. Now, in order to appear in the plant grew in the skull of a panther. When it ripened, seeds were collected herb was required, the process was almost the same, only this time the flicking its forked tongue. For another experiment a seed of a particular

such impostors had to live with their conscience, knowing that they shaman? The masses willingly worshipped "messengers of the Divine": Tantra and Yoga, or was he gradually turning into yet another spiritual seekers into silent followers. Was he sincerely interested in the secrets of the experiments? The demonstration of magic tricks could easily turn easily bring him money and respect, but what were the true motives of "accomplishments," until he was visited by a revelation: all this could impression that he was a great miracle-worker. For a while he enjoyed his Ordinary people were impressed by these tricks: people had the miracle was Prana, the life-force animating everything around.

and then would fly away. The revival was magic, and the key to this After two or three minutes the insects began to move their legs,

the tiny bodies of the drowned females, mentally repeating a mantra. minutes, then placed on the ashes of the drum, and he concentrated on interfere with them. The insects were lowered into water for 12-20 animals or birds possessed individual karmas and one should not humor. Large creatures did not suit the purpose, since warm-blooded life, and he treated the practice with simultaneous seriousness and Another fascinating experiment consisted in bringing dead flies back to his view, to show such things to an adult audience.

Cat, amused by the reaction of the teenagers. But it was not advisable, in in the air, displaying only teeth. For some time he played the Cheshire "Again." This time he did not vanish completely: only his smile hovered obeyed, and he was sitting before them again, smiling.

rang out: "Close your eyes again, count to five, and open them." They second ago. The sofa was empty. Before they began to panic, his voice "Now look" — and they stared at the wall by which he had been sitting a "disappearance act." Obeying his command, they all closed their eyes. Once in Garma he entertained a few teenagers and his niece with the taking and sadhus. The practicality of such skills did not concern him.

why the Shivalingam was found only the next day, after Shivaratri, was not particularly auspicious for new beginnings, and perhaps that is why you should find a natural Shivalingam." As it turned out later, this day casual tone: "Begin to search not far from here, at an intersection of paths, on the Hill. Turning to those present, he tried to give his words a sudden, he saw a certain locality, a crossroads of paths somewhere close voice spoke: "I have waited for you a long time. Send someone for me." purification continued until dawn. When it ended, the same low rolling for a horror film, the smasman did have a grim reputation. The ritual of The small pavilion built on the cremation site of the raja resembled a set possible reaction to an explanation that began "a voice told me to do this." He without explaining the reason for the request, well aware of the the ritual of purification of the earth." He asked two bandits to begin the rumbling voice: "Go to the Red Samadhi and perform there a Bhumi puja, everyone felt peace and serenity. Exactly at midnight he heard a low, right in the house. When the sacrificial offering of milk was completed, On 22 February five bandits arrived from Cwalior, and the ritual was held decided to celebrate properly, with a night vigil and puja.

gathered for puja, and at night he practiced as usual. But in 1998 it was smasman passed without particular pomp: in the evening the disciples for several years in a row the celebration of the great night of Shiva at the

Shivalingam

Avadhut and Devi of Braj

Shivaratri, 2008

Puja to Hanuman, 2008 Conversations with disciples, 2018

power of Brahma, in order to become witnesses of the indescribable.

perform miracles themselves, combining will and intention with the him to study yoga were not seeking thrills; they had to be ready to These thoughts made him stop the demonstrations. People who came to deceived people in the name of God or yoga.

became a temple. On 26 June 1998 the Shivalingam was installed right on the site. After some time the pavilion once erected on the raja's cremation site became the cremation site of someone.

There is nothing comparable in importance to the ritual of Shiva puja at a great honor for the entire royal family. According to Hindu traditions, Shivalingam at the cremation site of his great-great-grandfather would be to come in person. His Majesty considered that the installation of a Shivalingam was unexpected with his son — upon receiving the message he had decided to come. The next morning, around 6 o'clock, Maharaja Virendra Singh arrived at the cremation site, and any innovations were a delicate matter.

Permanently bound the living descendants of the royal dynasty with their own owner of this place, formalities had to be observed. The smashtan inquired whether the Maharaja would object. Although legally he was the owner of the cremation site of the late Maharaja Daswant Singh, and asked him to inform the secretary of the place to install a Shivalingam at the cremation site, and chat with the new owner. During one such visit he asked the smashtan to light oil lamps in memory of the raja's deceased ancestors. The Maharaja of Bharatpur had a secretary who occasionally came to the cremation site. The instructions had been correct: the voice in his head had been real.

It dawned on him: what had happened was not a hallucination: the stone had been kept for several months. The significance of the find gradually began to dawn on her shoulder and carried it upstairs, to his bedroom, where it was kept. The stone weighed 30 kg; the surface was smooth, as if polished. Devanuti hoisted the stone. The dark oval stone was washed, dried, and measured. It weighed exactly 30 kg. He found it.

The disciples approaching: they were almost running, exclaiming: "We have triumphantly carried it to the smashtan. Standing on the veranda, he saw another member of the search party they dug out the stone and carried it. One of the disciples, Ravindra Dwivedi, noticed it first. Together with the petals, it lay near the intersection of three paths on the Govardhan Hill. Around 11 a.m. Half-covered with earth, sprinkled with dry bougainvillea

anyone who dares to install a Shivalingam at a cremation site will die intuition turned out to be right. Among the Mathas there is a belief: omen. There was a feeling that this death was no accident, and his the incident was unfortunate and sad, but he did not take it as a bad mystic. The dog's body was buried in the garden without much pomp: was already dead, and the inconsolable children were sobbing in and bawling more and more... When Devanuri ran upstairs, the dog himself. The dog spun wildly around his own axis, choking, wheezing, room upstairs, began desperately to twist out of his collar, trying to free suddenly a young male German shepherd named Robin, tied up in a During the bus, several children with dogs remained in the house.

no one noticed precisely when.

ceremony was over. By that time the golden snake had disappeared, and priest pronounced the last words: "Now Shiva is present here," — and the flee, but he stopped him, ordering him to finish the ritual. Finally, the undulating movements were swift. Recoiling, one of the bandits tried to golden-colored, with red eyes, the snake appeared from nowhere, its began, a real snake suddenly slid into the pavilion. About 22–30 cm long, serpents, from the southwest corner. As soon as the recitation of mantras corners, and the bandits began the veneration of the naga, the sacred By tradition, worship in a new temple must be performed in all four invisible current.

the cool surface under his palms. It seemed to him alive, pulsating with an placed the heavy oval stone, the body of Shiva, on the metal base, feeling The five priests began the ritual: mantras were not recited. He simply echoed the insistent beat of millions of hearts.

musical instruments came from everywhere, as if the drum-rhythms suddenly flooded with toy damru drums. The sound of Shiva's favorite installed at the cremation site of the Bharatpur ruler, Govardhan was souvenir shops along the road, but on the day when the Shivalingam was Usually toy flutes, the symbol of Krishna, were sold by the hundreds in the samadhi of the ruler.

Mantras during the ritual he did not recite; most are intended for services visible.

whiteness of milk, priestly making the not-made-by-hands microscopically invisible cracks. During the ritual the tiny hollows would fill with the clearly distinguishable "Om" sign was discovered, formed by almost petals that adorned it every night. At the top of the stone a small pot of milk poured upon it, the honey rubbed in, the flour, yogurt, and flower. With time, the Shivalingam changed color, becoming darker from the they had seen this phenomenon, did he believe in the reality of the beam.

several people who had attended the puja at the early hour swore that of reflections from the flickering flame of the oil lamps, and only when light, and he felt it penetrating his heart. At first he took this for the play from the apex of the black conical stone there proceeded a beam of blue nature, to the timid accompaniment of birds. To the sounds of drums, The first service began at 2:00 a.m., together with the awakening of

Shiva-worship throughout India said that this puja was the most unusual. gave him remarkable energy. Visitors who had seen many other rituals of The puja became for him a kind of addiction; the uniqueness of the ritual

appearance would eventually become known.

this was no coincidence, and he hoped that the reasons for Shiva's during the last millennia Shiva shrines had not manifested here. All of inhabitants attracted entirely different energies, other deities — and the land of Krishna, where the vibrations, beliefs and mentality of the event. Of course, geologically oval stones could form anywhere, but one been found on Govardhan Hill, and this became a truly extraordinary. For the first time in the entire history of Braj a natural Shivalingam had learned quickly.

His innocence in these matters had nothing to do with ignorance. He believed that with the passage of time all secrets would become known. dog compensate for his own? Being unversed in such matters, he firmly within twenty-four hours... Was this superstition, or did the death of the

the famous mystic poet Kabir Das, but first and foremost it is the city of birthplace of the Buddha and of Paramahansa Yogananda, the home of the Gorkhpur. Relatively small by Indian standards, Gorkhpur is the In October 1998, accompanied by one of his disciples, he boarded a train Shivalingam.

strict rule: no one but himself and the priest was to touch the perform the ritual of worship properly." Before leaving he established a Go to Nepal, and the old priest in Pashupatinath will teach you to night meditation. It came from everywhere at once: "I came only to you. Hoping for guidance, he felt relief when he heard a low voice during

fever and the most violent vomiting — this was rather alarming.

Shivalingam began to fall ill. After a few hours visitors developed a high the end of it. Until people who came by tradition to touch the performed aarti in the temple, the fire ceremony, lit incense, and that was and he had no idea what to do next. Together with Devanuti they No one could give him advice on how to properly perform Shiva puja.

Nepal. Ritual

this land and its gods.

However, everything that was happening confirmed him in devotion to events was too vast for a summary assessment or a single conclusion of the mind in colors." Reality seemed with juicy colors: the palette of powers? In Hindi "entertainment" or "manorajan" translates as "coloring Were all these events simply the entertainment of card-shuffling higher essence part of their inner "I."

and contemplation; truth revealed itself to those who could make its required of him personally? He waited for signs. Yoga taught patience The story of the find was significant, but unclear. What exactly was

drum — and Mahadeva could choose any mantra from those sounds.

because every word of every language originates from the sound of His outside cremation sites. But the damru drums were beaten loudly,

For even respected spiritual communities with well-established realization was an unspoken logic practice.

practicing logic among them is not easy. In his view, the sole criterion of And although the Nathas are distinct from other sadhus, finding a few logics in the Natha sampradaya still possess the true knowledge. not always mean that logic practices are maintained within them. Only a The Natha matha-monasteries still preserve old traditions, but this does the tradition.

expected to keep themselves apart and to follow the rules prescribed by vows. As a rule, interaction with the world is curtailed; ascetics are renunciation of society is a part. Few modern seekers can follow such of the Nathas is rather complex and demands a discipline of which realization are branches of the same great tree of Knowledge. The practice tied to the Natha tradition, strict discipline and devotion to the goal of down into the Natha sampradaya. Although Kriya Yoga is not directly And yet one could still trace the roots of Hatha-Yoga, which reached by-product of past greatness.

mattered most was fundraising, not Yoga. Now it had become a relic, a organizations in modern India, the Nathas had to survive, and what forgotten, pushed into the background. Like many other religions enough, but the essence of the teaching had nearly vanished, had been land and real estate. All these practical aspects were understandable distribution of sacred texts for profit. And certainly not cunning deals in management of a vast network of ashrams, not the printing and to have remained their priority — not political games, not the that the very Yoga which had raised the Nathas to spiritual heights ought filled the courtyard of the temple complex. Looking at them, he thought Dozens of Natha-logis in saffron robes, with the great kundala-earrings, ...to visit the famous temple of Gorakshanatha.

perform sati, the ritual of offering fire to deities.

the great Gorakhnath. Before the next leg of the journey they decided to

Bhattas and the Rajbhaddari. The Bhattas — highly educated Vedic
All rituals at Pashupatinath are performed by two groups of priests: the
yogin from Govardhan moved the old priest to meet the author.

the chief bandit no longer received visitors, but the Cita brought by the
...Bhatt-ji was already 88 years old, and very weak. Owing to his health
behind the temple.

and returned after almost an hour. He was invited into the living quarters
Pashupatinath). Taking the book carefully, the priest asked him to wait
to see the old Bhatt-ji (such was the title of the religious head of
him a copy of his commentary on the Cita. He explained that he needed
Pashupatinath, where he introduced himself to the chief bandit, banding
The next day they entered the main building of the temple complex at

The highway grew smoother, and he fell asleep...

breakwaters of the mountains and the narrowness of the green valleys.
hard seats. After a while the rhythm of the road shifted, softened by the
dozed for the next ten hours, though they were periodically jolted on the
formalities. In the nearest town they boarded a bus to Kathmandu and
driver's license, but at that time travel into Nepal was not hedged in with
any delay, simply waving them on. He had no documents, not even a
ticket to the checkpoint. The border guards let them through without
Cotakpur is located not far from the Nepalese border, and they took a
somber, half-questioning, half-rejecting.

at his long hair. He did not look back: the energies of the place were
fell silent, staring openly at the strings of rudraksha around his neck and
...They walked out of the temple, and the Mathas seated in the courtyard
own tabs.

taught in words: they can only be earned in person, in the course of one's
personal attainment. Practice unveils aspects of knowledge that cannot be
any organization. The immense effort required for realization comes from
the authority and reputation of a saint are not based on membership in
hierarchies cannot carry the essence of the teaching into the future, and

Lord Shiva. [Footnote] Grateful for the opportunity to be married to the supreme God or supreme Being. In Hinduism it most often refers to Parameshvara Himself, a form of Lord Shiva. [Footnote] Parameshvara — explanation. During a Hindu wedding the husband is regarded as color with tantric ceremonies, but Bhakti gave an altogether different unexpected recommendation, he asked: "Why red?" Hindus associate this ordered him to wear red clothes during the ritual. Bewildered by this surface of the dark oil. Then Bhakti began to dictate, and for a start studying an unlit lamp, confidently sinking its propolis into the viscous was silent for almost ten minutes. No one moved. A solitary fly was that the story was being told by someone else. He finished, the old priest. The words came clearly and distinctly, yet he had the strange impression of the voice that had sent him to Pashupatinath.

afflicted all who touched it, even of the death of the dog. But, most of all, and its installation at the cremation site of the Raja, of the illness that do you want?" And he told everything: of the finding of the Shivalingam in a cracked but still authoritative voice the priest asked in Hindi: "What ... The old man lay on the bed; beside him sat two rather ancient servants.

allowed to perform puja; they are mainly assistants and caretakers.

requirements before they may touch the idol. The Bhadarti caste is not Pashupata Yoga and the Shiva Agamas, they must satisfy many death is foretold by the temple astrologers. [Footnote] Initiated into the misdeeds that may have worsened their karma. The exact day of those who die at Pashupatinath are reborn as human beings regardless of death, in order to be cremated on the bank of the river. It is believed that Hindus who come here to spend the last weeks of their lives and to meet inscribed as a World Heritage site. The place attracts hundreds of elderly edge of Kathmandu and is dedicated to Lord Shiva. In 1979 it was The complex stands on both banks of the Bagmati river on the eastern Pashupatinath is the oldest and one of the most sacred Hindu temples. dispatched to Nepal to perform the daily rituals. [Footnote] The temple of Dravidian Brahmins from Karnataka — are carefully selected and

standing in front of the Shivalingam. The child apparently belonged to a caste of a drum. Going to investigate, they saw a boy dressed as Shiva. A voice came from the temple: "Har, Har, Mahadevi!" Then followed the cry ... That day, around noon, they were sitting on the terrace when a child's nature.

Devahuti and Mahatma-ji helped him until the ritual became second nature through which the offering was made was rather awkward, but to confuse the sequence. To hold simultaneously a pitcher of milk and the bowl twice a day, and for the first two weeks he was a little nervous, trying not to follow the instructions he had received, the puja was performed ... Worship of Shiva began on the first day of the Dussehra festival. In

he was inclined toward philosophy rather than metaphysics...

trip to Nepal. Religious and esoteric subjects interested the professor little; he decided not to mention either the Shivalingam or the purpose of his trip to the Master. As usual, the conversation was warm and engaging. Even so, of Gauri Mahasaya to see Banamali Gauri, the great-great-grandson of In Benares, after visiting the Vishwanath temple, he stopped at the house

place smelled of cardamom and old newspapers.

photograph: "In this photograph it is I, Shailendra Sharma...". The small the porter guard the spread of the Bhagavad Gita with his own The next day they flew to Benares, and instead of a passport he showed

tubes into the donation box at the entrance.

The old priest refused to accept money, but he nevertheless dropped 200 rupees and walked out of the dark room, carrying the precious notebook. Diligently, trying not to miss anything. When the dictation ended, he wrote every aspect of the ritual took almost an hour, and he wrote it down for fortune, of gratitude, and of devotion." The long, detailed explanation of a mortal. When you worship Him on a smashana, wear red as a sign of a natural Shivalingam, Parameshvara, is a great fortune and an honor for Bhatt-ji tried to raise himself on the bed, looking intently at him: "To find

Divinity itself in the image of her husband, the bride puts on a red sari.

call the Shivalingam just "sign" or "marker" — and perceive Him depends on the level of development. In South India the Tamil Shaivites discerning seeker, it is a symbol of the presence of Shiva-Time. Everything for some, the Shivalingam may mean a part of Shiva's body; for the more creatures display the quality of Nature.

Rutana states that all beings possess the attributes of Shiva and Shakti; all creation — different yet united elements and principles. The Skanda Shaivism, in which the lingam-yoni stands for the dual principles of Shiva. This crude interpretation contradicts the higher meaning of literature) described the Shivalingam as a reproductive organ, the phallus. From the nineteenth century onward, various sources (mostly in Western metaphor of spiritual truths and faith.

process of creation and rebirth. For the Shaivites, the lingam-yoni is a micro- and macrocosm, the union of feminine and masculine, the eternal platform — the yoni. This installation symbolizes the merging of the carved, the Shivalingam is usually installed in the center of a disc-shaped worshipped as Mahadeva Himself. Of varying size, natural or hand-...In every temple dedicated to Shiva there is an oval stone that is had been consecrated once again.

as this small incident was, something had shifted, as though the temple bowed respectfully to the Shivalingam. And left. Sweet and unremarkable him a few coins, and accepting them with dignity and gratitude, the boy up that day — the birdsong, the light, everything around him. They gave fragrance. Not trying to pose or to act, the child-performer simply soaked trident in his hand, and the incense smoke filled the air with a thick with a lit stick of incense somehow fixed in his hair, he held a slim iron around his slender neck hung a necklace of rudraksha. Bathed in sunlight, asked permission to enter the temple. His thin body was painted blue; the smashtana, the boy had made friends with the unwilling guard and While his companions rested in the dharamshala in front of the gates of pilgrimage in costumes of Indian gods.

troupe of wandering performers, who usually beg for alms at places of

Across the Indian subcontinent 21 Shakti Pithas are counted, by other loss, and eternal union.

still revered by millions of pilgrims, symbolizing the force of love, bride, becoming a part of it, and these ancient sites of eternal creative power are [footnote] The feminine force of the Goddess passed into the Earth, various places. These sacred places became known as the Shakti Pithas. [Vishnu severed Sati's body into 21 parts, which fell upon the earth in Her. This might have led to the destruction of the world, and so Lord overpowered Shiva. He carried His wife's body, refusing to part with the Shakti Pithas. [footnote] Shakti Pitha — when Sati ended her life, grief after another, they fell to the earth, and so the sacred places were born — body with the sharp disc of the Sudarshana-chakra into 21 parts. One march of mourning, and the Preserver of the Universe severed Shakti's magnitude of the loss... The gods asked Vishnu to halt this terrifying body had disintegrated entirely — such was the depth of His love, the carrying Her corpse. Mahadeva vowed not to stop until His beloved's performed self-immolation, grieving Shiva began to wander the world, married against the will of her father Daksha. [footnote] When she Sati — one of the aspects of Shakti. The first wife of Shiva, whom she The very first story of true love was the story of Shiva and Sati. [footnote]

The Heart of the Earth

soundless voice of Shiva-Time spoke with him through the lips of Prana. The unconscious expanded until no mind remained at all, and only the together by yoga and worship, became a silent witness to the mystery. Him. In his sadhana he felt a power ripening within him, the will, bound simply felt the presence and the breath of Shiva. And he became one with Without trying to decode all these intricate metaphors and words, he radiated something that could only be described as the energy of eternity. Each night, touching the smooth oval surface, he felt that the stone creation, the passage from one reality to another.

devotees of the Destroyer, the Shivalingam symbolizes the axis of exclusively as a spiritual symbol, without any sexual implication. For

Yamuna could not hide her surprise: "Do you not see Him? He is here!" —
— do you not feel the pain of separation?"

despondent, and the other widows wondered: "Why are you not grieving
widowed queens mourned Krishna. But Queen Yamuna did not look
kingdom of Mathura. Inconsolable, their hearts broken by grief, 1010
His mission, Krishna left the body. His grandson Vaisnabh inherited the
journey of the queens — the widows of Krishna. When, having completed
hints as to the origin of the name "Moksh Bhumi" in the legend of the last
A portion of the Skanda Purana, the text "Bhagavad Mahatmya," gave
The very name of the locality was a key to the riddle of the Shakti Pithas.

take the modest guise of alternative hypotheses.

is generally considered that disputed facts ought to remain veiled or to
become an undisputable postulate, signed and catalogued like a fossil. If
facts being challenged. Once approved and documented, history must
to constructive conclusions. People do not like to see widely accepted
Such revelations could not lead either lay people or academic researchers
but, whatever his conclusions, he kept them to himself.

data so that it could become wisdom. That is precisely what he was doing,
had been fermenting for years; one needed to digest and assimilate all this
anthropological evidence, religious convictions, intuition, and mysticism
into a single fabric was almost impossible. The mixture of myths,
smashana appeared too often to be ignored. Yet to weave all the events
Both physical and metaphysical signs of the Goddess's presence on the
goddess of creative force, desire, and fertility.

material. In it Govardhan is named as Kamakhya, the important tantric
the worship of Kali and Kamakhya — contains some startling historical
religious and philosophical themes, this voluminous work — devoted to
...tantric text, the Yogini Tantra, there is a curious mention. Apart from
the ancient...

Odisha, Assam, and Bengal, and Braj is not on this list. Nevertheless, in
reckonings 108. The four most important and sacred are situated in

"official" place where the heart of Sati is believed to have fallen. The site is Jharkhand, the temple of Jayadurga in Baidyanath is held to be the parts of Sati's body, and each locality has its own meaning. In the state of ...The numerous Shakti Pithas across India are dedicated to different unmistakable grace. And of peace.

produced an indescribable effect — a sense of pure, inexplicable, but nourished this land, and in combination with the energy of the holy hill release from rebirth. Powerful ancient feminine energies guarded and on thirteen generations of the rulers of Bharatpur a priceless gift — the boundaries of the future dynastic cremation complex and bestowed. Aware of the powerful energies of the place, an unknown sadhu marked connected with this story.

liberation." Most likely, the origin of the name "Moksh Brumi" is known as Shaktitara, which means "the place where wives obtained smashtana and the lake Kusum Sarovar. In the local dialect this area is All 10,107 queens were cremated on the plot of land between the royal fact means that they left their earthly bodies. There the chapter ended.

everywhere. As it is said, they attained "Krishna consciousness," which in Bhagavad Gita for a whole month. And they all began to see Krishna golden ropes, strikingly resembling Krishna — read them the Maha Kusum Sarovar, and Uddhava — dark-skinned, radiant, dressed in queens pitched a luxurious camp between lakes Manasi Gangra and Gita, which would help them to find peace. Following the advice, the could endow them with the hidden knowledge of the Maha Bhagavad friend Uddhava lived. As the Rishi explained to the widows, Uddhava the shore of lake Kusum Sarovar — there, where Krishna's immortal The Rishi told them to hold festivities at the foot of the hill Govardhan, on queens, hope of seeing Him again.

interrupted His divine Gita — and so there was nothing unusual in the Krishna died (what a base thought). It is believed that He simply help the queens to be reunited with Krishna. No one in Braj ever says that and she advised them to seek guidance from Shandilya Rishi, who could

the planet too, depending on the course of events, its trajectory and floats. Perhaps the heart of the Earth shifts its position within the body of whole Earth is an enormous temple, consecrated by the Void in which the heart may connect with the primal source, the heart of the Mother. The valleys and mountains beneath the domes of the open skies, where any miracles, people are born to believe — and they are given temples of exclusively in the eyes of the believers. Human hearts always thirst for Of course, the value of any shrine and the multitude of its meanings exists and charged with the power of the earth.

tribes — reflect human sensitivity to events of the past, filtered by time Islam, down to the hills and rivers honored by apocryphal and primal sites of the cradle of Christian and Jewish faith and the holy places of has enduring meaning. All these spatial markers — from the significant objects, for only faith rooted in legends that were once someone's reality nature. Only human cultures can confer such statuses upon natural ...Sacred places are territories where religions and beliefs interact with

within all living beings beat in unison with the heart of the Mother.

to work in harmony with the rhythm of Creation, and the tiny motors birds, people, and inanimate objects. Invisible, the great Heart continues strongly. Coming from all directions, it passes through trees, animals, The heartbeat of the planet vibrates everywhere; in Braj it is felt especially the body of the Earth.

their thoughts and crests, and this resonant "heartbeat" pumps brains into surface of the planet but produce a kind of standing waves, pulsating in upper layers of the atmosphere, these waves do not race across the electromagnetic waves in the atmosphere. Held between the earth and the waves are regulated by electricity. Lightning striking the ground creates called Schumann resonance — this is the "heartbeat of the Earth." These As is known, the planet pulses with a particular kind of resonant waves Earth is felt everywhere.

Hridaya Pitha). Yet the pulse of the metaphysical, mystical Heart of the widely known as the land of the sacred heart (Baidyanath Dham, or

the significance of the events to which the consecration of a Shiva temple done quickly and without trouble. But no one could then have foreseen The repairs were discussed and refined so many times that the work was building.

"backyard," they took it as a sign that the time had come to rent the sacred river Narmada. When the symbol of Shiva was found in their own and install a Shivalingam (more precisely a Bamalingam) from the and in this way considered many variants. He had initially planned to upper level of the palace, discussing the reconstruction of the structure, worked in metal but also understood building. They often sat on the The priest, who had moved with them onto the amashana, had previously household.

had her hands full with endless practical matters of setting up the new would be turned into a temple. She listened in silence, asking nothing. The conversation with Devadutt he shared the thought that the pavilion right here." There was no clarity about the origin of this idea, but in a sudden revelation flashed through him: "The Shivalingam will stand single palm tree. When he saw the pagoda-like structure for the first time, structure stood in the midst of the deserted, scorched earth, guarded by a Singh was erected in 1893. Half-ruined, covered in flaking red paint, the The dilapidated wooden pavilion above the cremation site of Raja Jaswant Devi of Brij

continued to carry all Her children.

grace of the chief Shakti, the Earth, was meant for everyone, and she continuing to be charged with the energy of millions of pilgrims. The new hypotheses and legends. The Shakti Pitha of Brij remained invisible, Hill has been worshipped for many centuries, and there was no need for and people are not destined to learn of it. Here, in Brij, the Cowardham Wherever it may be, the exact location of the planet's heart is unknown, destination;

The workers themselves, however, showed no surprise: it is well known
opidne, evasive, possible theories and explanations varied.

literature, but could not decipher the hidden meanings. The answers were
consulted with archaeologists and reviewed a great deal of specialized
upper room. Trying to understand the meaning of these finds, he
collected. The stones were washed, cleaned of clay, and gathered in the
weeks more than thirty pieces of different sizes and shapes had been
made by human hand. They continued to be unearthed, and within a few
though grown into the stone, and all these fragments were patiently not
long. On the stone breasts nipples appeared with reddish areolae, as
copies of female reproductive organs, breasts and the birthing organ,
to come upon strange stone fragments of a peculiar configuration — exact
December 1, 1994, during routine earthworks, when the workmen began
surface — literally. The signs of Shakti's presence were discovered on
That this place was a Shakti Pitha he understood when broods began to
forward to meeting them.

gmaashana were well acquainted with the strange energies and looked
liquor confused and disoriented many, but those who often visited the
skin to intoxication. The sensation of intoxication without the aid of any
intense vibrations, which made newcomers giddy and gave them a state
When Shakti came to Braj. Her presence filled the surroundings with
in mysteries.

inhabited Braj. Saturated with their mighty energies, the locality was rich
feminine spirits (besides the souls of Krishna's wives cremated here) had
the true mistress of this land. From time immemorial various ancient
His intent to remain here, and Her presence had always been felt. She was
Gmaashana because of Shakti. The discovery of the Shivalingam pointed to
events had no particular meaning, but he was sure: Shiva had come to the
routine. Perhaps his unawareness was a blessing. To outsiders all these
he began performing puja to Shiva, fully immersed in the new daily
getting aside his reflections on the nature of this thoroughly tantric ritual
at the place of the Raja's samadhi would give rise.

only later. Testing and guiding him, the Deity explained the reasons for and this happened because of Shakti's arrival. But he understood that in October 1992 Hanuman spoke with him personally for the first time, upheavals in the astral spheres.

So far as he could tell, all these descriptively chance events caused great sweetness of a sharp sense of being.

to anyone. She simply filled the whole locality with the intoxicating but the Goddess Herself did not intend to prove the fact of Her presence. The statuette and the strange stone fragments were tokens of Her arrival, mightily sadhana.

from that day the Goddess silently, though attentively, watched his development. The statuette was placed on a shelf in the upper room, and Devi held a sword, a cup, and a strange round object resembling a armed goddess seated upon a great cat, distantly resembling a tiger. The flame. Soon the wax melted, revealing a small bronze statuette of a four-Devalpiti placed the rest of the object in a large pot and set it on a low. Convinced that this was not stone but fossilized wax mixed with sand, bronze face peered out from the broken surface.

dropped it on the stone floor, and the upper part broke off. A small centimeters long, it was surprisingly light. Yielding to an impulse, he half-buried object found at the gate. An oblong oval stone about 30 ... Two months later (on January 27, 1992), the guard brought a strange,

sadhana had a quite different, undeniably "feminine" nature.

base, and worship them... But the stone fragments found on the age-old tradition people draw eyes upon them, about orange sand (kilometers) from the places where they had been marked. According to known here — stones did indeed move, some could be found meters (or moving along and around the Hill. The legend-like phenomenon was well permits and ages performing thousand-year tasks in this disguised form, unpredictable manner. Some stones are even considered to be holy that in Braj the sacred stones of the Govardhan Hill behave in the most

spheres: a new stage of his training began. It was then that it became Shiva became the occasion for beginning communication with the subtle qualities beyond mere teaching and personal practice. The daily worship of the gods) after that, the Shivalingas were found, which expanded his unfolded slowly. Less than two years (a fraction of a second by the time of The events that followed gave some answers, though the divine play meant going beyond the body.

himself to the limits of the mind, since precisely the breaking of limits reality is divided into many channels, and he had never tried to confine putting touch of His sweat on his own skin. Sadhana had taught him that fall. The unimaginable event was piercingly real: he could still feel the ...Six months passed, and in June Mahadeva Himself stood in the darshan

enough to set the locals making ambiguous jokes at his expense.

stone breasts, then lions, and now menstruating trees? That would be the lunar cycles. Devanuti noticed it first and pointed it out to him. First unusual phenomenon occurred in particular months, as if coinciding with "bleed": from them oozed a dark, viscous, resin-like substance. The soon the forked trunks of trees in the garden of the samasana began to proclaiming it with all the passion of feminine energy.

was no longer shyly presenting "evidence" of the Divine — she was simply to wave aside, to dismiss as random natural formations. The Earth Imagination had no part in the discovery: there were too many fragments stone fragment resembling a female reproductive organ was found. ...On January 4, 1990, while the bond was being drained, yet another at all.

brought here the symbol of the Goddess, the Sri Yantra, was no accident and, most likely, influenced many of them. That the companion of Baba! course the Mahavatar was well aware of past, present, and future events And then, two months later, Baba! himself appeared at the samasana. Of some of the astonishing events.

their curiosity, to draw them out of the ordinary.

the stories of the smashtana only in moderate doses. Just enough to kindle and he gave all this, willingly fulfilling his duties and telling newcomers came to him to study yoga, to receive teaching, technique, and inspiration, prized as the bulwark of safety and the guarantor of daily stability. People improbable was set aside as the whim of imagination; the ordinary was The practical aspects of life eclipsed the tales of miracles; everything

legends, catch the meaning of various events, and try to analyze them.

and some of the students could grasp the intricate interweaving of many while and could look behind the thin veil of reality. Only close friends such stories were meant for those who had traveled with him for a long

intelligible to human beings, were now together: "breast," "loin," "navel," symbols of the creative feminine power, translated by Nature into objects milk and water and placed beside the other "body parts" and yantras. The pulsing. This was the navel of Shakti. The stone was carefully washed in into the dimple — about a centimeter and a half deep — he felt the stone dark, the size of a small grapefruit, with a dimple. Inserting his thumb to the COVID quarantine), a new stone fragment was discovered. Rather On October 28, 2020, during another round of bond-clearing work (franks filled the surroundings.

the room, which was carpeted in red. A new, dense, honey-like energy enormous as the Goddess gazed silently with diamond-inset eyes upon The statue was installed in the southern hall of the house, seated upon an

Goddess, had been reunited with Her.

smashtana; the Mahavidyas, various personifications and aspects of the documents. By that time ten different yantras had already arrived at the She personified the Sacred Feminine and required no credentials or the gate. The Devi still had no name, but it did not particularly matter: In 2016 a well-known sculptor made a large copy of the statuette found at

clear: Adi Shakti Herself had called Her beloved here.

One of them at once lay down and did not rise again; his companion stood opposite the gates of the assembly, three pilgrims had settled in. Amid the festive activities, beneath the canopy of the dharamshala that and on July 8, 1998, hundreds of thousands of people flooded Govardhan. Guru Purnima usually falls on the full moon of the month of Ashadha, ignorance." Cu is darkness, tu is light.

translation of the Sanskrit word "Guru" means "the one who delivers from Hinduism: the Puranas, the Mahabharata, and the Vedas. The literal birthday of the sage Vyasa, the author of the most important texts of mentors, including spiritual ones. The festival is also dedicated to the honoring teachers, thousands of people express their gratitude to all Guru Purnima is celebrated annually throughout India; on this day of

The Three Mathas

Goddess held Shiva-Time firmly and tenderly in Her embrace.

Kali was in excellent company — standing above his tomb, the eternal components of the tantric mystery were actively engaged. The spirit of the funeral rite of the ruler of Bharatpur had been performed — all three a place. Now Shiva and Shakti stood on the very spot where the last forces always needs a "launching pad," and the Ghashtana provided such of a Shivalingam-and-Yoni over a Shava-corps. The union of the great dead bodies, no known instance had ever been recorded of the installation. Although the convulsions of Indian history have provided a great many foundation, supporting the Shivalingam.

In Hindu temples Shakti is represented as the Yoni, which is the base, the Tandava, so that Creation may continue.

awakening. In this way She prevents His dance of destruction, the The Dark Goddess either takes the mortal's soul or holds Shiva back from is usually a shava (any dead body) or even the sleeping Shiva Himself. fierce form of Shakti, standing on a motionless body. Under Her feet there conclusions. Traditional Hindu iconography depicts the Goddess Kali, the Gradually the very sequence of events reshuffled the deck of plausible

his thoughts, the Natha mentioned with cheerful ease that he and his moment he thought the visitor was about to ask for money. As if reading began to praise him for carrying on the tradition of the Nathas, and for addressing him as "Badda Natha" — "Elder Natha" — the guest at once looked entirely self-assured and somehow recalled a friendly him. Darsaninatha, and the sleeping man was their teacher, Chandnatha. The mentioned his companions: the silent chillum-smoker was named [footnote] introducing himself as Gangnatha, the visitor briefly Jivatha (soul-spirit), and Paramatha (Highest universal spirit). [\\ Siddhanta Baddhat" states that "Adesh" means the unity of Atma (soul), [footnote] Adesh — a common greeting among the Nathas. The "Siddha bow to no one; their traditional greeting is limited to the word "Adesh." The Natha bowed in pranama, and that was strange, since these yogins material resembling bone, did not seem heavy at all.

followers of Gorakshanatha. The large kundalas, made of a light-grayish inserted not in the earlobes but through the cartilage, in the manner of the round kundala earrings, the distinguishing symbols of the Nathas, were turban and a lungi wrapped around his muscular, lean thighs. Large could guess: he was a Natha-yogi. The guest wore only a sun-bleached stranger's eyes. Looking at the dress and accessories of the ascetic, one Approaching the visitor, he caught a flicker of instant recognition in the smashtana).

the pilgrim asked to meet the "Elder Natha" (so he called the owner of the installed in the sanctum, often had a similar effect on people. Coming to, was not especially worried, since the force of the dark oval stone, recently floor, he lay senseless for a few moments, but the man accompanying him temple, where the visitor suddenly fell unconscious. Collapsing on the of the installation of the Shivalingam, and the gatekeeper led him to the temple of Shiva. He told the gatekeeper that he had heard from the locals appeared at the gates of the smashtana and asked permission to see the corner and conversing there with the vendor. The next day the third one passing crowds. The third sadhu kept visiting a refreshment stall at the settled beside him, continuously smoking chillum and watching the

Suddenly the guest spoke of the appearance and meaning of the signs of new era.

and now Shiva-Aghora had awakened, which meant the beginning of a sleep, one is awake, influencing the events and changes of the Universe — Destroyer, in which He meditates upon samashana. While the other heads three heads embodies Shiva-Aghora, the fierce and beautiful aspect of the mystical three-headed Guru revered by the Nathas. One of Dattatreya's once in a cycle of creation, Gangamatha was speaking of Dattatreya — the Raja had awakened the Avadhuta, and that such an event occurs only saying that the installation of the Shivalingam at the cremation site of the nature of the highest reality and of themselves.

gone beyond quality, or the saint who teaches seekers to realize the true called is the master who shows the way of liberation, the mystic who has title of Lord Shiva, and in India such coincidences trouble no one. So Both Shiva and Dattatreya are called "Avadhuta" — most often this is the layered cosmogony, in which different deities and forces took part.

years and events that followed disclosed a more complex and many-speaking exclusively of Shiva, for whom else could one call "Guru"? The manifestation." Listening to Gangamatha, he was sure that the guest was states, becoming like Rishi, but the Guru never honored them with His grounds, trying to call forth the Avadhuta. Some attained the highest trial. In the past many Natha-yogins performed tapas at cremation the Natha of all Nathas. For any mortal this is a great honor and a great "You installed the Shivalingam on the samashana — and therefore you are turned out to be precisely what it was — incredible truth.

hints, allegories, and metaphors, but in time everything the guest told him The Natha spoke of most interesting things, and he could not catch all the his jaincloth, a money belt stuffed with new banknotes.

importance. With these words Gangamatha demonstrated, hidden beneath they were going to build an ashram there, and the price was of no companions had come on business, looking for a suitable plot of land.

been taught to him by Gmashana Kali herself, the fierce dark Goddess, that he possessed the secrets of attaining the immortal body, which had records mentioned that Chandanatha was several thousand years old, and disciple of the ancient immortal Gopakshanatha. The surviving archival his sway. Their Guru, Chandanatha, controlled politicians and was a direct media: television channels, journalists, and internet bloggers came under surprises. Datananatha possessed the gift of influence over the mass. An excursion into the history and hierarchy of the Mathas brought further somehow seemed plausible.

had recently come to the Gmashana? Absurd as the guess might sound, it tomp, a site of logic samadhi. Did it belong to that very Candanatha who inquiries. The local people led the major to a local landmark — an ancient intriguing that he asked a relative, a major serving in Bhatinda, to make anyone — everyone there knows me." This visit and conversation were so ... Candanatha had mentioned the town of Bhatinda in Punjab: "Ask lines vanished with the coming of the monsoon.

someone had outlined his silhouette in chalk: the faintly visible discolored haze. The stone floor where Candanatha had lain had turned white, as if The next morning all three Mathas simply dissolved into the hot July palace, where the guest remained for a couple of hours.

the crowded streets, and the puari led him to a secluded veranda of the rest somewhere on the grounds of the Gmashana, away from the noise of reflection. To round off the conversation Candanatha asked permission to statements alternated with veiled hints, leaving room for further. Their exchange proved intriguingly many-sided: obvious conclusions and working out the same version.

manifested..." That was a striking declaration, but he himself had been "Mahadeva came here because here, on the Gmashana, Shakti had already aware of the find of the stone fragments.

for the Matha could not have known of it: only a handful of people were Shakti recently found by the workmen, and to hear this was astonishing,

ceremonies and rituals, they may be drawn on metal plates, paper, or correspond to a great variety of deities, principles, and planets. Used in on the path to the highest reality. Hundreds of different yantras liberation. A multi-purpose piece of training equipment, a guiding thread contemplation. Briefly put, it is a device that helps one to attain spiritual bonds and fetters." A yantra is an instrument of meditation and or "support" — and "tra" comes from "trans," which means "release from. The Sanskrit root of the word "yantra" comes from "yam" — "instrument," iconography and its symbolism.

level of awareness, than to plunge into the deep waters of sacred means..." Better to let people speculate, make inquiries, and raise their most often be summed it up laconically: "I have no idea what all this riddle for a long while. Visitors put forward various hypotheses, and purpose was well known, but the reasons for their appearance remained a circumstances, eleven yantras manifested on the royal smashana. Their Over the course of several years, in different but equally strange

The Yantras

among the living.

eternal witnesses of the Dharma, the immortals continued to wander nameless, forever merged with the vastness of the subcontinent, the the smashana mixed with hundreds of other pilgrims. Unrecognized and somewhere very near — watching, waiting, perhaps passing the gates of From time to time he had a fleeting sense, as if the Mathas were confirmation of the rightness of his actions — and yet...

less blurred, more distinct. Not that he needed encouragement or a strange certainty, as though the navigation chart of events had become not every day that an immortal being bows to you. This incident gave him ...Recalling Gangadhara's bow, he always felt a certain quiver — for it is ...the Kaya Matha-yogins, possessors of the secrets of eternal life.

These three wandering Mathas belonged to the branch of...

Baraji's silent companion on a December night in 1992, she was the first in Yantras needed no mantras at all to radiate her power. Delivered by feminine deities represented by the other Yantras. But the queen of all. The Shri Yantra worked like a magnet for the entire trinitate of Indian mystery.

energy is and what the consequences of its release might be remained a accumulated energy, like electrical capacitors — and stored it. What that strong vibrations, like a stout protective shield. But it seems they chiefly oxymoron. After they had been installed, the Yantras began to produce Here, on the smashans, the very notion of worldly success was an of worldly life.

only for certain ends and tasks — chiefly oriented to the practical aspects Yantra is the human body. Yet this complex tantric ritualism is important Various images may be used, but by common acknowledgment the best

the energy takes the form of the deity associated with the mantra.

accumulates that energy until it begins to radiate of its own accord. Then set in motion by the energy of a specific mantra — and the Yantra transformation of an herb, mineral, animal, or human soul takes place is foster the maintenance of peace and prosperity. The crucible in which the Yantras, made of precious metals, mountain crystal, coral, or lapis lazuli, aim of the ritual) is used to draw the required image. Three-dimensional implement (of gold, wood, iron, or the form of a plant, depending on the coated with paste (of sandalwood, saffron, or aloë), and on it a sharp used for destructive and harmful rites. Sometimes the metal plate is copper ones are meant to attract wealth. On iron, leather, or bone they are are usually used for healing and beneficent rituals. Gold, silver, or may be made of mountain crystal or drawn on birch bark. Such Yantras "charged" Yantra becomes a sacred object. Depending on its purpose, they vibration of a deity and its energy, and so a connection is established. A then "charged" with mantras. The object is then "tuned" to a specific rituals a Yantra is imprinted on a square copper, silver, or gold plate and wood, they are made from flower petals, ashes, rice, or sand. In Vedic

Examining the yantras, he recalled the case of one powerful tantrika instructions.

usually used in potentially lethal and dangerous rituals. He left no person bearing the yantras of Bagalamukhi and Dhumavati, which are whom he had had the most interesting conversation earlier, came in. Another heavy parcel was delivered two months later. Gangadhara, with beside the Shivalingam seemed entirely fitting.

the Shiva temple: installing the symbol of the fierce aspect of Mahadeva late and disassemblable into separate parts. They decided to place it in Rudra Yantra was made of bronze or copper, scrupulously turned on a heavy peg weighing about 50 kilograms. Also three-dimensional, the The next yantra was delivered in 1998. Someone simply left at the gate a him as though the object had been made... in the future.

At times, looking at the dark three-dimensional sculpture, it seemed to of the Goddess somehow be tied to the place itself, to his own logic but; practical understanding of the meaning of this yantra. Could this symbol subtle aspects of non-duality. And yet he still needed pointers for a more realization. [Footnote] symbolize the cosmos, the human body, and the acknowledges and seeks to ensure both material well-being and self-transcending the cosmos which is her manifestation. The system Shakti theology of Shri Vidya the goddess is the supreme form, "knowledge," "learning," or "science") — a tantric religious system. In the interlocking triangles of the yantra [Footnote] Shri Vidya (in Sanskrit In the Shakti cult of Shri Vidya, the Shri Yantra has many meanings: the idea what to do with the information he had received.

directly upon the sand. Yet for all the mystery of the subject, he had no Parasurama, the ascetic had mentioned a yantra drawn in red powder before he left the body. Then, describing the ritual of summoning first mention of the Shri Yantra — the Agnori had spoken of it on the day After the initial excitement of Baba's visit had subsided, he recalled the this unique "collection."

Kamala Yajna arrived by what was by now a familiar method: an In October of the following year, during the Navaratri celebrations, the since the smell vanished.

any possible negative consequences. Evidently the prayers were heard, settled in the house, and he turned to Shakti, praying for deliverance from unknown odor as the smell of fresh blood. A heavy, oppressive energy the whole space. Nihar Mukherjee, a disciple from Bengal, identified the everyone began to feel a strong, slightly metallic smell, which soon filled forms of Shakti and were installed in the house, but after about a week parcel. The Yajnas of Gmashtana Tara and Gmashtana Kali embodied fierce people said: "Give this to your guru," and without any explanation left a silversmith, where the puja had happened also to be present. One of these with a highly unpleasant character. The visitors went to the shop of a local Gmashtana, but they were refused reception because of their connection. Another two years passed, and in January 2000 two visitors arrived at the vigilant.

have power to be reckoned with — they were lethal. And he remained proved too destructive for a mortal. These two Goddesses did not merely supernatural powers and devotion: the might of the awakened Goddess Bagalamukhi, after which he did not live even six months despite his of Dhruvavati. [Footnote] He had dared to install a statue of successful. Two months before his death Dattā Mahārāj installed the murti war of 1962 and to save India from foreign invasion. The result was times of the Mahābhārata. This ritual was meant to stop the Sino-Indian organizing a Brahma Yajna, a Vedic ritual conducted only during the his death on June 5, 1979. He is also known and remembered for he installed the principal deity Bagalamukhi and observed penance until goddess Bagalamukhi, Dattā Mahārāj performed many miracles. In 1932 goddesses Bagalamukhi and Dhruvavati. It is said that, as a devotee of the is known as the stronghold of the most fearsome and ferocious tantric Peth Dattā temple complex near Cwalior in Madhya Pradesh. The place Mahārāj) — an ascetic who lived until his death in 1979 at the Pitambar known as Dattā Mahārāj. [Footnote] Swami Ji Pitambar Pita (Dattā

ritual, Prayashchitta, for new disciples. A substantial portion of their laconic message: it was no longer necessary to perform the puja in a small piece of bhupatra (tree bark) on which was written in red ink a premises. Right on the dusty floor stood four yantras, and beside them lay to call the puja. He poked the lock with a crowbar, and they entered the not been opened for nearly five years, the lock had rusted, and they had It was almost dawn when they approached the building; the room had structure now remained.

house — once a palace pavilion had stood there, of which only a one-story The room in question stood in a half-ruined building not far from the garden and unlock the room on the left side. Take everything you find." at the back of the campus; an imperious voice had said: "Go into the to go there right now — I saw it in a dream!" She had dreamt of the ruins excitement, was shaking him by the shoulders: "Get up quickly, we have Early in the morning of June 6, 5000, he woke because Devanuri in great ... To obtain the remaining four yantras took another nine years.

also represent all the directions of space.

followed Him. Besides being various aspects of Shakti, the Mahavidyas whether He flew into the sky or tried to hide beneath the earth — they ten sides of space. Wherever He went — north or south, east or west, the enraged Sati turned into the Mahavidyas, surrounding Shiva on all angered. After vain attempts to convince Shiva to allow Her to join Him, to a ritual without His first wife Sati, and She was both saddened and The story of the origin of the Mahavidyas is rather curious: Shiva went off formlessness.

rebirth and liberation. Devouring Time, She is reborn in Her dark She is revered as Mahakali, the fierce Goddess of time, life and death, The Divine Mother Adi Shakti is represented by ten cosmic personalities: Universal feminine energies.

a unique combination of six yantras, representing six special forms of the unknown person left it at the gate. Now the smashana was adorned with

meditate in a secluded place. Matsyendranatha will meet him there." approach the head priest of Dattatreya's temple and ask permission to Yogiya — he must arrive at Mahurga on June 10, at noon. Let him not received the order to meet the Elder Natha..." And he added: "Tell the Gangadha refused: "Badha Natha se milne ka mukam nahi" — "I have took the barcel and asked whether he wished to see Gurji, but carrying two lanterns, tightly wrapped in cloth. The bhairi who met him Bhumi two years earlier walked through the gates. Gangadha was in the last week of April 2000, one of the Nathas who had visited Moksha flesh and blood.

The touch was entirely human: the immortal's hand was undeniably of touching his head as one would a child, with a gesture of fatherly blessing. had wished to bow to the great Gurji, but Matsyendranatha stopped him, had been the warmth of the immortal yogi's palm touching his head. He Recalling the events of that day, he could attest: the sharpest sensation

Matsyendranatha

working control panel.

the Hill. Now the gigantic submarine of the Hill had a new and fully smashana, fed by the vibrations of millions of pilgrims circumambulating symbols of the Universal Mother now dwelt in the silence of the surrounded by a human ocean and yet hidden from curious eyes, the

Bhuvaneshwari were reunited with the rest of the Mahavidyas.

by a single master. So Tribhva Bhairavi, Chinnamasta, Matangi, and Roughly the same size, the lanterns looked as though they had been made

they have appeared in a locked room? There was no one to answer.

beside them was another print — much larger, nearly 42 cm. How could long, as if a dwarf had been stamping around the sacred objects, but On the dusty floor they noticed a few footprints. Tiny prints, only 7 cm

directions or explanations were in the note.

karma was to be cleansed in the presence of the Gurji. No other

The first direct disciple of Shiva, who passed yoga on to mortals, an instantaneous transformation, and the fish became a human being. out of compassion sprinkled it with water; the "baptism" was followed by instructions on yoga — and became enlightened. Shiva noticed this, and Other legends maintain that originally the fish itself heard the secret and the whole adventure was reflected in his name — "Lord of Fish." twelve years Matsyendras emerged into the light an enlightened Siddha of yoga and began performing sadhana inside the fish's womb. After Matsyendranatha answered in the affirmative. Thus he learned the secrets And to Shiva's question, "Are you listening, dear?", the young teaching the secrets of yoga to His wife Parvati. The Goddess dozed off. One day the fish came to lie on the bottom of the lake where Shiva was swallowed by a fish, and grew up inside its belly.

and prospects of a new life that had hardly begun. The infant was well-being of the clan was more important than the probable scenarios by such radical means before misfortune could overtake the family. The Sheshnag in the mountains of Amarnath. Obstacles were often removed astrologer somehow persuaded his parents to throw him into Lake ...It was said that the boy was born under an unlucky star, and the Matsyendranatha on the Indian spiritual landscape.

century, though many references point to a much earlier presence of the Natha tradition are almost certain that the cult itself arose in the 10th Siddha who learned the secret of yoga from Shiva Himself. Historians of The founder of the Natha tradition, Matsyendranatha, is an immortal Sometimes logic only got in the way.

pushing aside logical conclusions and so-called "common sense." allegories, he had to make decisions based on the strangest truths, about 38 to 40 — was one of the immortals. Possessed of hints and vague Canganatha — wiry, smiling, with even slightly yellowish teeth, a man of made about the three Nathas, and were it not that he knew that This might have sounded like a hoax, were it not for the inquiries he had

the temple of Dattatreya. After a brief dashan, he told the priest he
Arriving in Maharashtra about 11 in the morning, they went up the hill to
way contradicts one of the titles of Shiva, who is also called Adi Guru.
Guru is revered by the Mathas as the First teacher of yoga, and this in no
Vishnu, and Shiva, together known as the Trinity, the Trimurti. Datta
considered the incarnation, or Avatar, of all three Hindu gods — Brahma,
The most mysterious deity of the Indian pantheon, Dattatreya is
mother Anasuya.

Parashurama, on another stood the temple of Lord Dattatreya and His
there crowned with temples; one was dedicated to Kenuka, the mother of
three points the famous mountain ridges opened before them, here and
mountainous landscapes of Maharashtra into Maharashtra. After about
they were already in the bus that bounced over the potholes through the
where they spent an unremarkable night in a hotel. Early in the morning
disciple Rajendra Sharma, they took the train from Agra to Mandu,
ignore it would have been reckless and disrespectful. On June 12, with his
powers only of supreme beings. The invitation had to be accepted; to
it it was a mystification, mystifications of this caliber were within the
And now this immortal was inviting him to a meeting in Maharashtra. Even
developed mind.

why and how to use this priceless gift — herein lies the task of a highly
only a side-effect of yoga. Having attained immortality, one must know
makes Him immortal. Yet for a great Siddha eternal life is not the goal but
essence, he continues to pass from one body into another, and this skill
and to assume other forms, remaining in them for long periods. In
some legends speak of Matsyendranatha's ability to leave the body at will
outstanding disciple and simply watch over the triumphs of Gorakhnath.
Guru." All Matsyendranatha had to do was to give the world one
Gorakhnath. Adepts call Him Dada Matsyendra Natha — "Grandfather-
as the Teacher of the other great founder of the Natha Sampradaya,
other worthy yogins. In the tradition of the Mahasiddhas He is honored
Matsyendranatha stands apart, as the most outstanding figure among

heard. The little room was so small that even seated the yogin seemed tall, slender, with black hair cut just below the ears, and a short-trimmed clothing was a jaincloth of white cloth. He was light-skinned and rather. The Matha sat before him on the dusty floor. The only article of his had ever spoken to him with such warmth.

"No, no, relax — all yogins are equal, you do not need to bow..." No one him of the reality of what was happening. Matsyendranatha said gently: reason it was precisely this gesture that at once and irrevocably convinced him with a gesture and touched his head as one would a child. For some simply does not exist. He tried to half-rise to bow, but the visitor stopped him of conduct to choose, since etiquette for dealing with higher beings feeling in which nervousness is mingled with fear. There is no "correct." Those who have had the chance to meet gods or immortals know the stooped man entered the room, accompanied by two women.

pounding heart. About ten minutes later an unusually tall, slightly sole criterion was seclusion. Sitting on the floor, he tried to slow his The two tiny dusty rooms had no furniture, but none of this mattered; the Covardhan is going to meditate here."

firmly woke the two pilgrims who were sleeping inside: "The Mathara! of structure perched above a high precipice. There the escort politely put grounds? The attendant led him to the back courtyard, to a small might one find a secluded spot to meditate, somewhere on the temple When the exchange of courtesies was finished, he asked the abbot a favor: always warmly received.

the Ananda Margis revered Sri Krishna, and pilgrims from Braj were sacred book. The mathant was very well-disposed toward him. The sect of Citsa, explaining that he was the author of the logic commentaries on the yogin from Covardhan and presented him with a copy of the Bhagavad the rooms. Greeting the orange-robed abbot, he introduced himself as a bandit led him to the back of the temple and opened the door of one of temple, which was managed by Agnoris of the Ananda Margis sect. The wished to see "Dattatreya Yogi" — the honorific title of the mathant of the

pending their heads under the low doorframe. After a moment's
rose together (he hurriedly sprang up) and one after another walked out.
Matsyendranatha said: "We are leaving; you too may go..." The Nathas
The meeting was dense though brief; not half an hour passed before
that Devanuti was standing right behind his back.

sitting in the tiny room above the presbytery... And yet it seemed to him
though physically this was impossible; only he and the three Nathas were
It should be noted that at some moment he felt the presence of Devanuti;
tried not to miss a word.

dhuni and the rite itself contained a multitude of technical details, and he
naming an auspicious time to begin the rite. The aspects of laying the
explained in detail the particulars of the dhuni, the logic ritual fire,
smaashana and conducted logic sadhana there. The Guru of the Nathas
discipline was obligatory for anyone who lived permanently on the
same earrings that pierced his own earlobes. This symbol of logic
Matsyendranatha instructed him to wear large round kundalas — the
smaashana marked the beginning of a new count of the cycle of Creation.

fifth wrathful form of Shiva. The installation of the Shivalingam on the
regarded this event as the summoning of the Avadhuts, Agoras — the
nations and states, many factors had to come together. The Nathas
mystical ritual to set in motion irreversible processes, fateful for entire
the cremation site of the Raja presented no technical challenge. But for the
nothing in the act itself was difficult, and the mere placement of a stone at
completed this ritual, and those who dared had not survived. Outwardly
Cangamatha's words: for centuries no one had ever successfully
consequences of installing the Shivalingam on the smaashana, confirming
Matsyendranatha spoke of matters connected with the meaning and
ask who they were. All three had dark kundala-earrings in their earlobes.
silently. Matsyendranatha did not introduce them, and he did not dare to
of brick color, such as sadhvis usually wear, the women-ascetics smiled
knots on the crown of their heads sat down behind him. Dressed in dhotis
Two tall, stately, very beautiful women with long black hair tied up in

at Mahurqad. The preparation took nearly a year, since certain technical
The laying of the dhumi began at once, following the instructions received
Dhumi

only by yogins... Every encounter was a test.

Therefore vigilance, caution, and courtesy must be developed by all, not
disguise — asking aims, granting blessings, or capable of cursing.
involved. Practically anyone may turn out to be an all-powerful Deity in
 guise of an old beggar; abhorrences are descending when divine bliss is
return was following the Guru. Sometimes Guru Datta could take the
making His usual midday halt there, and Matsyendranatha with his
blaze around noon, and that might mean that Dattatreya Himself was
Why had he been summoned precisely to Mahurqad? The meeting took

dictated to him were entirely concrete.

unduestionable, and at the same time like a miracle. But the instructions
the look in His eyes, the touch of His hand — all of it was real,
remembered with piercing clarity the sound of Matsyendranatha's voice,
had come out of the courtyard; his companion had seen no one. He
front of the entrance to the temple complex, and he asked whether anyone
agonizingly not the temple had emptied. Rajendra was waiting for him in
Everything was utterly ordinary, mundane; the noon was becoming

and head. [\footnote] a certain type of brain, leave no traces.

vayu — one of the five brahas (vayus), residing chiefly in the hands, feet,
guitas, those who have attained control of udana-vayu, [\footnote] Udana-
their physical sheaths... Everything was possible. According to the Yoga-
ethetic bodies or simply left no marks because of the different structure of
were no prints at all, and one could only guess whether they had been in
footprints on the dusty floor. Where the Mathas had been seated there
Returning into the room for his travel-bag, he noticed only his own

the temple in the white-hot sky.

empty, and only the orange flags shifted slightly above the sharp roofs of
hesitation he looked out of the room, but the courtyard was already

She dwells in the various forms of dreams, lost memory, fantasies and the universe, the seer-poets call her the most glorious and elder, Dhūmavati. sunk in the sleep of the highest Reality, having devoured the entire "Perceived as Void, a dissolved form of consciousness, when all beings are bore of Her body, like smoke.

husband Shiva while He sat in deep meditation, but He came out of every consuming hunger that overcame the Goddess made Her devour Her "the smoky one," indicates this link. According to legend, the all-Dhūmavati is directly linked to the dhūmī and its powers. Even her name, worship of the Mother. One of the ten Mahavidyas, the goddess dhūmī symbolizes the yoni, the birth-organ of Shakti. It is a place for the a door into another dimension. A sacred depression in the earth, the logic travels. Its flame may be used only for the purpose of cremation; it opens cooking; this is part of asceticism. But the fire of the smāshana never the fire from a dhūmī with them, kindling it only for worship — not for The logic dhūmī differs from other fires. Wandering sadhus usually carry

and the subtle, between the night of the mind and the noon of the heart. unbroken primordial bond between the causal and the astral, the gross countless past adepts. The sound summoned the invisible, confirming the merged with the inaudible echo of the long-vanished logic notes of itself, he kindled the dhūmī; the puṣṭi blew a horn, and the pure sound In September 2001 the order of the ritual changed: now, before the puṣṭi with care.

communication with the subtle worlds, and its secrets had to be handled not superfluous. The dhūmī was too powerful an instrument of anyone could try to build a copy of the dhūmī, but the precautions were components were ordered from different places and workshops. Not that order to keep the peculiarities of the construction secret, the necessary yantras, in accordance with a specific positioning of the stars and time. It required. Three rows of low stepped tiers were laid above a particular prescribed size and shape; specific material and secret ingredients were aspects demanded high precision. The foundation had to be of a

there are so many beautiful places in the world. Maheshwara replied that grounds, filled with corpses and virtues, demons and jacksals, when ...Once the goddess Uma asked Shiva why He preferred cremation

Lord.
them a railway station, a transfer point. It was also the dwelling of their of their coming remained a mystery. Quite possibly the smashana was for incarnation as the homeless and grieving human souls do. The purposes human ghosts among them, and therefore they did not crave bodily earned by these spirits through centuries of austerities. There were no the cremation site, beside the place of Shiva worship, was an honor depending on the status of its creator. To enter here through the portal at in the material world consciousness could assume various forms, dark whirls with a rainbow sheen.

triangles and squares, from green, brightly fluttering bird-like shapes to each night and varied from transparent spheres to melting, indistinct ghyasaks, manushyas, and vidyadharas — regions of bhautas arrived [footnote] nagas, yakshas, brahmas, bhishakas, raksha-ganas, vinayakas — a ghost, also a name for the basic elements and a state of existence. [servants of Lord Shiva, members of His retinue. Bhutas, [footnote] Bhutas arriving spirits were most diverse. The majority were Shiva-ganas, the door between worlds opened anew; the missions and motives of the realm providing entry into this world for various beings. Each night the who gave birth to these spirits. Her womb was only a tunnel from another entering this world. Her womb lay deep in the earth, but it was not the the logic flame, the myriad ancient spirits — mostly bound to Shiva — consecration of the dhuni the Smoky Goddess Herself welcomed, through brought by Gangadhara was already on the smashana, and with the When the foundation of the dhuni was being laid, the Dhumavati yantra

Gabaram 38)

undoubted Samadhi (death and liberation from it).“ (Gangadhi Muni, Uma among yogins she becomes the force destroying all thought, the misunderstanding of beings immersed in the illusion of the world, but

with humanity out of cruelty or short-sightedness; they played their
of causes planted by the Cardener-Time. The gods did not experiment
events themselves the dwellers of higher spheres already knew the seeds
human history are mere indicators of emerging trends. Long before the
always, the gods and immortals watched. For them the great events of
however, the reshuffling of an unseen deck. But only for humanity: as
11th became the beginning of a redistribution of the world's balance of
America of its belief in its own invulnerability and superiority. September
— the skyscrapers — were destroyed with the merciless intent to deprive
past, present, and future. The mighty symbols of capitalism's permanence
connections, but the logic mind sees beyond the three-dimensionality of
human society. Realists and pragmatists tend to ignore ambiguous
the influence of hidden forces and mark the beginning of new cycles in
somewhere in northern India? Large-scale tragedies usually occur under
this terrible event somehow be linked with the kindling of a logic fire
the destruction of the World Trade Center towers in New York. Could
the house, the television, which was on, was broadcasting the moment of
bowing in greeting. It was about 11 in the evening. When he returned to
it hovered above the fire, then rose higher and dove downward, as if
great ultraviolet sphere shot out of the leaping flames. For some moments
When the dhuni-fire, fed for the first time on sacrificial grease, flared up, a
he felt like a doorman.

entertaining; now he saw these beings every night. Watching their arrival,
Before he began to live on the smashanas, such legends sounded
passion and fear, can be near the "Lord of Ghosts," as Shiva is called,
unworthy. Only true devotees, who have defied death and are free of
the Shivasanas, His servants, guard Shiva and do not admit the
grounder. In His presence the spirits did not harm people. It is held that
without His return, and so He decided to remain at the cremation
He had grown accustomed to their company and did not wish to wander
demons, but His terrifying entourage could only dwell on smashanas. Yet
meditation and could not find a single one. In despair He created various
He had wandered the world in search of a fitting, clean place for

Among other factors, rhinoceros horn was preferred for its durability. In disturb the bodies of ascetics.

Samadhi-burials promised nothing but misfortune for those who dared hoped that the finds were chance, since the deliberate desecration of logic similar earrings were occasionally found in ancient burials, and he always can endure such discipline."

of your life. Without kundalas made of rhinoceros horn or hide, no one Mahurghad: "You will soon begin a special ritual, and it will become part Matsyendranatha wore, who had said to him during the meeting in Adorned with golden mounts, the earrings were an exact copy of those made of animal hides or metal (sometimes wootz steel). [footnote] or curved. Such shields were widespread from India to Persia and were Dhala (or dhal) — a round shield up to 80 cm in diameter; it could be flat rhinoceros, taken from an ancient Rajasthani shield-dhal. [footnote] The first pair of kundalas was cut from the very thick hide of a black

Accessories of Sadhana

could see the gleam of this flame from wherever they were.

game. The immortals who had ordered the portal of the dhuni opened the fantastic beings bursting out of the abyss were to take part in a new ...The tongues of flame danced before him, constantly changing shape, complex.

more ancient, and the life-cycles of astral beings are non-linear and meager historical experience of humanity. The kingdom of spirits is far world of men are marked by the predictability and limitedness of the than what surrounded him here, on the Land of Liberation. Events in the What was happening beyond the gates of the samadhi was no more real ruined castles and cities new ones were inevitably built.

civilizations. The planet was the gods' sandbox, where on the sites of in the world. And these games lasted far longer than any so-called heavenly games for pleasure and amusement since they had all the Time

"opening" of Sushumna, [footnote] Sushumna — the chief energy channel optimal level. Prana became perfect, since Prana stimulated the change in the flow of energy refined his logic practice, raising it to an these channels, "closing the circuit" and redirecting pranic energy. The body, ending in the great toes. The weight of the kundalas stimulated Prana. Beginning in the earlobes, they cross diagonally through the entire ending at the left ear. [\footnote] Nadi, ensure the unimpeded flow of channel of splendor," issuing from the great toe of the right foot and [\footnote] and Ashwasini [footnote] Ashwasini Nadi — the "energy energy channel" running from the great toe of the left foot to the right ear. Two fine channels, called Pusha [footnote] Pusha Nadi — the "nourishing mystical effect of the kundalas began to be felt at once.

noticed the impression they made on visitors. But the practical and that great heavy earrings were now constantly hanging in his ears, and lobe of his ear seemed to him disgusting. At first he was acutely aware pain was quite slight, but the sound of the needle passing through the group, he had to set the example and had no right to show hesitation. He asked a few disciples to join in for company. Surrounded by a support the darsan hall. Not being sure of the outcome of the procedure, he had His friend and disciple Praveen Bhatacharya pierced his earlobes right in warrior for logic accessories seemed entirely fitting.

darkened hard rhinoceros hide of a shield once belonging to a Rajput Mr. Verma of Cwalior, managed to find an antique shield. To use the the search reluctantly. Yet luck smiled on them, and one of his disciples, topped the list of protected species. Even black-market dealers undertook To obtain rhinoceros horn was practically impossible; these animals logging lived.

life and the stoicism associated with the hermit's way. The same way that mount of the goddess Dhavdi, and was honored for the secluded mode of nearly sacred — something like a magical unicorn. He was the vahana-antiseptic for wounds, and the rhinoceros itself was considered pious, antidote the ascetics used the powdered hide of this animal as an

latter „kundala.“ With them fate marks those who have chosen the path of earthings are either flat or cylindrical. The former are called „darsana“, the earthings changes as the Natha-yogi advances in the practice. Usually the the weight is borne by a cord thrown over the head. The material of the were made of clay or even of glass. Some Nathas wear gold kundalas, and into the holes. Novices wear kundalas of plastic; in former times they them into the openings. When the wounds heal, the earthings are inserted central parts of the cartilage of the ear-shells and inserts wooden sticks of a specially trained guru cuts with a razor or a double-bladed knife the traditionally put on in the final stages of initiation into the order. Usually ...The symbols of belonging to the Natha tradition — the kundalas — are ...mental equilibrium.

maintain...

charged mind and body. Plainly speaking, the earthings were necessary to sadhana, the rituals of worship, and the ancient place itself constantly Or of a lightning rod, redirecting the mighty energies with which logic emotional waves, and the kundalas played the role of the balancing pole. tightrope. It was necessary to keep one's inner equilibrium, to level the seemingly uneven life on the samasana also resembled walking a A tightrope walker carries a bamboo pole for balance — and the this flow was a genuine delight.

main channel. [\footnote] — and to feel, to observe, to experiment with physical imbalance and prevents the Kundalini energy from entering the Prana cannot flow through Sushumna. Such blockage leads to mental and Kundalini. If pollution or blockages obstruct other nadis of the body, the Sushumna nadi is saturated with the pure creative force called the body, through the spinal cord. The kind of energy that flows through Sushumna is the most important nadi, passing through the central axis of Sushumna, corresponding to the left, right and central lines of the body. 25,000 such channels, only three are principal: Ida, Pingala, and called nadis. Although in the subtle body (sukshma kosha) there are of the subtle body. The life-force energy, Prana, travels along channels

called themselves was not essential. Yet, the line of succession was the transformation of spirit and body — and what particular followers he had always considered yoga a monolith, the indivisible philosophy of principles of Natha discipline regardless of formal initiation. To be frank, others — all this was the purest and strictest yoga, corresponding to the Shiva, the strict sadhana, and the inherited responsibility of teaching controlled samadhi, the installation of the Shivalingam and the worship of seemed to determine further events on the samasana. The steady state of memory always strayed from the course; still, certain facts of his life sometimes he tried to arrange all events in chronological order, but not prevent Canganatha from addressing him as "Elder Natha."

He had no formal initiation into the line of the Nathas, though that did hang from the lores, in the old style.

ears." And yet many ancient statues of yogins were made with earrings. Perhaps this is why such ascetics were nicknamed "kanbhata" — "split-in the earlobes, and not in the middle cartilages as modern Nathas do. claims. Incidentally, the legendary Guru of the Nathas wore his kundalas. Having seen Matsyendranatha's kundalas, he no longer disputed these them become immortal.

the kundalas. There was also the widespread opinion that those who wear. Those whom he had met spoke of acquiring certain abilities by means of of kundalas activates the nadī-channels and improves the pranayamas. Some Nathas still remember that the piercing of the ears and the wearing removing the kundalas is tantamount to renouncing the highest grace. subject to decay. The yogin becomes "one with the Absolute," and — the earrings protect their wearer from everything corruptible and wearing of the kundalas. The yogin is born anew, in a transcendent sense journey — and that is why some of the elder Nathas speak of an inner dashani develops, grows, and remains with the ascetic throughout his others. With practice and discipline the inner force called kundali or A Natha who has received the kundalas may become a Guru and teach asceticism and faith.

Urbanishtaḍ," "the divine force, Kundalini, shines like the stalk of a young describe Kundalini. According to the medieval "Yoga-Kundalini transmigration of souls. In the Indian tradition this symbolism is used to and rebirth, just as the shedding of skin by the snake symbolizes the symbol is interpreted as eternal cyclic renewal or the cycle of life, death. The term itself comes from the ancient Greek for "tail-eating," and the biting its tail. In alchemy it is a symbol of gnosticism and hermeneuticism. Ouroboros — an ancient symbol depicting a snake (sometimes a dragon) The bracelet was a symbol of Time, the ring of Ouroboros. [footnote]

simply an ornament, and only rarely went into details.

constantly asked about its symbolism. He would answer that it was biting its own tail. The bracelet drew the attention of visitors, and he was silver and depicted a cobra with a pair of ruby eyes. The serpent was The heavy bracelet around his wrist was made of an alloy of gold and

parts, factors, efforts, and conditions into one.

inexplicable results. All of this too was yoga — the joining of different smashana. The combination of these factors yielded important, sometimes between human destinies and the gods, stood out clearly here on the the metaphysical, between place and myth, the invisible filaments serpent biting its own tail." The alchemical link between the physical and of all this symbolism, since even Vedic rituals are compared to "the Time, the endless renewal and alchemy of Creation — he was well aware The coiled Kundalini and the cycle of Samasara, the circular motions of Shiva and Shakti, dhuni and the Avadhuta, kundalas and Kundalini...

took his words quite seriously, and many began piercing their ears.

eatings, he smiled slightly: "No kundalas — no Kundalini." The students depth, becoming more refined. Receiving compliments on the new carved. The pranayamas became still more intense, the practice acquired Chinese sub made of rhinoceros horn, and from it new kundalas were 2010 one of his disciples from Germany bought at auction an antique Time passed, and the hide of the kundalas faded, becoming brownish. In

important. But faithfulness to discipline was even more important.

were entirely different: the practice of the higher Yoga, the worship of the over others (whether spirits or living beings). His own goals and tasks for the attainment of particular results: power, material wealth, or control some tantrikas and black magicians perform rituals at cremation grounds. His own practice he preferred to call *Gamasana-sadhana*. It is known that Agnora, "the Most Beautiful,"

mother of Creation.

awaken its brother. Both of them were children of Universal Thought, the symbol of the unconscious bitten by its twin — the logical mind, trying to. Once, taking off the bracelet before his, he thought fleetingly of it as a know itself anew — with joy and trembling.

nothing more beautiful than endlessly to conceive, to bring forth, and to within itself the potential of myriad emotions. For Spirit there was earth, of the body and the microcosm; it lived in everything and contained conscious and unconscious, of masculine and feminine, of heaven and first matter. Alchemy itself, undoubtedly, arose from the merging of matter, comparable to chaos, the quintessence, or aether. [Footnote] — philosopher's stone. It is described as the primitive formless basis of all required for the alchemical "magnum opus," and the creation of the material, *materia prima*, or first matter is the undivided original substance *Materia* [Footnote] *Prima Materia* — in alchemy and philosophy, *prima* again. The serpent was the symbol of non-dual unity, the secret of *prima*. The Ouroboros could fertilize itself, and also kill itself and return to life. bracelet symbolized renewal, immortality, and the Alchemy of Creation. The symbolism of the ornament was layered, and he liked that. The Time.

samsara, whose recurring movements reflect the eternal pulsation of strike... The coils of the curled *Kundalini* correspond to the cycle of with its hood spread. The serpent awakes it only when preparing to. Nathas wore similar serpent bracelets, but this one depicted a king copra lies in a half-sleeping state at the base of the body." [Footnote] Some lotus, like a serpent coiled in rings, she holds her tail in her mouth and

were secondary and mostly unlearned.

understood that he was a yogin and a Guru, and the other associations alike. But ordinary people, so to speak, visited him rarely. Most All this could startle the imagination of ordinary townsfolk and foreigners Bhairava, the fierce form of Shiva, surrounded by formidable black dogs, the ghuni against the backdrop of tiled palaces, making the offering to sacred undertakers, with the heavy black earrings, he blew the horn before impress anyone. Dressed in red robes, adorned with massive necklaces of Needles to say, the unique brand arose by itself; he never even tried to popular in "logic" systems.

incomprehensible logic, so far removed from the simple physical exercises buta to Shiva at night. In addition, he practiced some strange and footnote] on his forehead — the mark of an Agnori — and conducted the particular mark on the forehead, usually made with sandalwood paste. [\\ smashana without leaving, wore a black tilak footnote] Tilak — a Come to think of it, the name suited him quite well: he lived on the this label made the situation more or less comprehensible to lay people. ISKCON called him Agnori Baba, the nickname stuck for a while. Indeed, were the Agnoris. Perhaps that is why, when one of the members of society. The only people who lived permanently on cremation grounds fit the frames of the generally accepted cultural codes and algorithms of a smashana and remain there for many years without leaving. It did not lay person could not understand why anyone would voluntarily settle on too many frightening stories and legends were tied to the smashana. The of the broad public life at a cremation ground was inconceivable, since the methods and means of realizing these aims. Nevertheless, in the eyes The manifesto was short but biting, and time only polished and sharpened had sheltered him and all the others.

inner spirit and the Universal Mother, honoring and serving the land that supporting those who asked for help or knowledge, in the name of the teachers of the parampara. He performed sadhana, guiding and highest Teacher and first Guru, Shiva, along with Baba! and other

another state of consciousness has a sacred significance: they enter total For the Agnori, everything connected with death and the passage into Tantra.

all Tantra was Agnora, but all Agnora was permeated with the spirit of heart (perhaps the most difficult and most rarely fulfilled condition). Not and use who possessed sufficient determination, perseverance, and a pure utilitarian interpretation was only a technique that anyone could study not be linked exclusively with "darkness" or "light." Tantra in its ordinary, Both paths, Tantra and Agnora, arose in the pre-Vedic era: they should cognition of the nature of Shiva — that is, the nature of Time itself.

the members of these cults were engaged in one and the same thing: movements in Shaivism, Vaishnavism, and Shaktism. Strictly speaking, all originated with Dattatreya. In time this Deity inspired many monastic The tradition of Agnora (like that of the Nathas and the Keralikas) nothing higher than knowing the true nature of the Guru."

"The name of Agnora is the mantra surpassing all mantras. There is "Agnorama paro mantrō Nasti tattvam Guru param."

of celestial singers, the Candharvas, the "Shiva Mahimna Stotram": most ancient texts — contains a hymn composed by the chief of the clan the edge of the Void, on the rim of Time. The "Shiva Purana" — one of the the one who dwells on the Smaashana, at the entrance to infinite reality, on Shiva is known as Agnor, the most powerful aspect of Mahadeva. He is ...The very name "Agnor" had ancient origin. One of the five faces of among their participants begin to yield to any analysis.

chewing over. Only after years did the events and the strange links epithets the locals showered upon him, nor in the gossip they kept Devahuti had had to hold their ground. So he was not interested in the the first years on the Smaashana were given exclusively to survival. He and with the path of Agnora. There was neither strength nor time for it, since Paying no heed to the rumors, he rarely denied the tales of his connection

the literal sense) forces. In places where portals into other dimensions impossible because of the effect on the human psyche of otherworldly (in extremely rare. Permanent residence on a samskara is considered such rites, and those who can perform them with guaranteed result, are sacrifice of an animal. Some call this process the transfer of karma. But another person, and in some cases the successful healing requires the "transforming healing." However, the impurity must be transferred to It is believed that Agnors are capable of removing illness in a process of this is the main message of the rituals they perform.

selfless service. The Agnors often heal sufferers through purification, and personal practice of the adept. It must include both sadhana and seva — morality have become less radical. Still, Agnors insists on a balanced years. Practices traditionally condemned from the standpoint of social The cult of Agnors has been greatly transformed over the last hundred inhabitants is primitive sorcery, not the path to liberation.

...the path of Agnors. To obtain material gains by enslaving astral them to serve. This is not...

Sometimes the tantrikas may take these beings into "slavery," and compel goddess or a powerful astral being who can grant the initiator's desires. dualities and reciting a secret mantra, one can summon this or that manner upon the corpse of a girl or a man possessing particular physical them, "possessing" the body. In certain rituals, sitting in a prescribed or moonshine, so that the spirit may contact them directly or even enter drawn to intoxicating substances. That is why the tantrikas drink whisky extensive use of alcohol and meat, since it is known that dark spirits are catch and control certain spirits by means of tantric rituals, which make intimidation or to attract clientele. Such people visit the samskaras to Some black magicians and tantrikas call themselves Agnori for the sake of is used as an altar for summoning Samskara Tara.

surrounded by death and decay. For example, in shava-sadhana a corpse approach to be the most effective, the Agnors perform somber rituals darkness in order to see the light of self-realization. Holding this

Satyacharan Lahiri was one of these rare ascetics.

Apparently the man whom he had met in Benares at the insistence of finding them was incredibly hard, since they did not wish to be found. India there were probably no more than five or six true Agnis. And so in the twentieth year of his life at Govardhan he understood that in all of practicing the lowest sort of black magic.

interesting, unlike the sour, stale, and dismal energy of the swindlers impostors. Conversation with the true Agnis was refined and these people belonged to known lines and orders; others were simply those who called themselves followers of the cult of Agni. Some of He knew of their rituals, had heard many stories, and had associated with "satvic" Agni, even though he did not follow the traditions of the order. permanently at the place of cremation. But if it came to it, he was the only Yes, in the broadest sense he was an Agni, because he lived trials.

old alcohol, sex, money, or power — the mightiest of all temptations and who had fallen into dependence on any intoxicants, be they drugs, good blocked. Many times he had watched spirits "attach themselves" to those weakens, and clear understanding of the true nature of things plus or is a state of intoxication the mind clouds, the capacity to make decisions that any stimulants which directly affect the mind weaken the sadhana. In performed daily the rituals considered satvic — "pure." It is supposed He, who had never in his life smoked, was a teetotaler and a vegetarian, using a human skull as a cup.

paint the image of a ragged, dishevelled, dull-eyed and stupified ascetic place of cremation, beside death and darkness, is impossible. Stereotypes frightening and the unknown. Therefore it is held that to remain pure at a associated with the dark side of reality. People link death with the pure worship at a samadhi is considered impossible, since Agni is and strange occurrences, happen there without any visible cause. Satvic always happens. As a rule, possession by evil spirits, as well as sudden open and the line between worlds is thin, something out of the ordinary

the parampara said literally the following: "The sadhak ready for the "knots" in the subtle channels are awaited by the smashanas. The Guru of Babaji declared: those who have passed through and united certain Agoras" only at a place of cremation. During the memorable meeting Mahavatar himself that an advanced practitioner can attain the "stage of In his faith there was a personal element as well: he had learned from awareness of Time.

and purity in the most difficult situations, and to remain in constant embrace the state of non-Darkness, to act with absolute meaningfulness helps one to get foot on the path of knowing the dazzling Light, to considered Krishna yoga the preparation for true Agoras, because yoga sectarian creed or cult. As shocking as this may sound to some, he For him, it was one of the highest stages of the soul's development, not a The state of Agoras is the opposite of the dark inertia of a sleeping mind.

overcomes the state of sleep.

"A-goras" — dazzling. When the dormant subconscious opens, it horror and ugliness. "Ghoras" meant "the concentration of darkness," and its very essence was "pure beauty," not "darkness." The full opposite of Agoras;

through the stages of evolution of the mind, but why did it precede incomprehending looks. Of course yoga led the adept step by step From time to time, when he called yoga the prelude to Agoras, he met

ugliness or impurity: life and death are sides of the same shining coin.

a world originally beautiful by its very manifestation, there could be no of death, there was nothing terrible in Creation: there was only beauty. In judge, the immortals themselves were fearless. For them, lacking the fear liberated consciousness is ready to receive the Divine. So far as he could Mahadeva's return. The overcoming of fear means liberation, and other, not the most peaceful and not at all benevolent beings of home of Shiva and Shakti. There they must coexist with a multitude of being closer to the Gods, since the cremation ground is considered the True followers of Agoras live on smashanas for the single purpose of

hallucinations; the mind simply slowed down, sinking into dreams, and the intoxicating fog. Fortunately it did not cause delirium or coma, fell into a semi-comatose state until the hot midday sun evaporated hundreds of flowers released a stupefying fragrance; people, dogs, and suddenly grew thick with black datuna. Early in the morning and at night the monsoon came, and when the rains ended the whole locality the stingy sadhu the choicest epithets.

seeds!!! The doctor steamed for quite a long while, continuing to award empty-handed and furious. "That bastard refused even to share the mercury, Vaid-ji went to Barsana hoping to buy datuna, but returned who had this plant. Wishing to see the results of the experiment with doctor Vaid-ji, learned of a sadhu from the neighboring village of Barsana qualities, and he wanted to see the results. An old friend, the Ayurvedic Mercury boiled down and "evaporated" in this juice acquired certain trumps") and its seeds and flowers were potentially psychoactive. Juice of the flower of black datuna. Both this "moon flower" (or "devil's For experiments with mercury he required a rather rare ingredient — the

Psychedelic Flowers, Divine Trees, Astral and Other Creatures

period.

Himself can permit anyone to remain in His home for an indefinite component is obligatory: the grace of the First Guru of yoga. Only Shiva bring a yogin to such a destination. Besides luck and destiny, one more at a place of cremation: only the mighty undercurrents of destiny can so that he may advance further. It is impossible simply to come and settle destined to be drawn by the samasana; this place will be "allotted" to him stage. A practitioner who has succeeded in approaching this level is Muladhara (also called the "passing of the Knot of Rudra") is the highest pranayama the yogin "passes through" these stages. The passing of the and removes the "locks," sealing the centers of energy. By means of special At various stages of the practice of kriya the student "unties" energy knots cremation." That is why fate had brought him here.

passing of the Muladhara Granthi Bheda can do this only at the place of

smashana. At least, that is how it looked.

His emissaries and security service began personally inspecting the spreading part of the garden. And, on the eve of the coming of Guru Datta quickly, and by the time of Dattatreya's arrival their crowns were already when planted, but your land was chosen by them itself...". The trees grew directly connected with Him. Being extremely thickly, they rarely survive before him: "The great grace of Dattatreya is with you: these fig trees are short walks through the campus. On the seventh day the visitor bowed tantrika. For seven days this man silently absorbed tea, occasionally taking ancient Indian science of architecture and spatial design. [footnote] and a connoisseur of Vastu Shashtra [footnote] Vastu Shashtra — traditional Once an acquaintance from New York brought along a guest, a ground.

fig-tree, which suddenly began to push insistently through the hard intrigue. In the summer of 1997 hundreds of tender shoots of the red river through someone were staging a play that maintained an unending Kate plants, exotic creatures, and ghosts continued to appear regularly, as crawled away.

leatherly limbs poked out from under the shell, and the airfare slowly lay motionless, and they thought it was dead. But after half an hour storm. The burial went to check on it: shocked by the flight and the fall, it which flopped down to the earth right in front of them during another. The apex of the heavenly gifts was a medium-sized brown water turtle. The surviving worms loosened the soil, making it more porous and fertile. abundant feast for the feathered and scaly inhabitants of the smashana. birds. Another thunderstorm delivered myriad worms, providing an rained down upon the earth, enthusiastically welcomed by snakes and new inhabitants as well. Once, with a downpour, hundreds of tiny frogs From time to time the rains brought not only the needed moisture but sadhana.

scents, and the effect of the datura assisted a gentle entry into the night the contours of reality blurred. No one protested, he personally liked the

utmost attention firmly fixed on the object of concentration, so that no
Cangas and performs laba and qlyana. [footnote] Dlyana — a state of
morning. He leaves Ciruar and goes to Benares, where He resides in the
About the wandering Deity it is known that daily, around four in the
of the temple. It was the immortal Guru Himself — Dattatreya.

the Shivalingam. Two of the three heads turned slightly toward the center
toward the qrun, the silhouette floated slowly back and stopped before
Behind the columns of the temple a transparent figure appeared, passing
had switched them off. The sensations were strange, almost uncanny.
died down; the sounds of the approaching night vanished, as if someone
and spinning the bright petals into miniature whirlwinds. Then the gust
shook the flowering bushes of bougainvillea, moving along the ground
and around him. The moment he noticed this, a sudden gust of wind
felt the presence of a certain force that produced a numbness both within
Soon after the installation of the Shivalingam, during the evening puja, he
times.

them, let's go on..." They saw these semi-transparent beings several more
"What are they?" "Only Datta Guru has four black dogs... don't look at
Turning to his sister, he whispered: "Do you see?" Devashuti nodded:
time with the heavy breathing.

staring straight at him. Pale, ash-colored tongues moved rhythmically in
Two of the dogs went on sniffing the ground, the others stood motionless,
resembled those of German shepherds, but were somewhat flattened.
powerful jaws, a wide chest, and saber-shaped tails. The muzzle's
color of wild honey. They were the size of two-month-old calves, with
slightly blurring, enormous black beaks with short curly fur and eyes the
trees. Focusing his inner sight, he discerned four semi-transparent,
dense shadows abruptly changing direction, moving right through the
evening walks for several more evenings, until at last he made out dark
animals around. The sounds continued to accompany them on their
someone's heavy breathing, but apart from the dogs there were no other.
In the evening, when he and Devashuti were walking the dogs, he heard

has come, to be seated at the cremation site of the Raja." At the time it had words: "One of the sleepers, Rudra, has opened his eyes... The Avadhuta Recalling the conversation with Gangadhar, he continued to analyze his eavesdropping was simply impolite.

the human psyche is too fragile to bear the presence of Gods. Besides, their experiment, he said that to dance before a moving train is unwise; disoriented and bewildered, they could remember nothing. Hearing of switched off their inner metronome. Coming to halt an hour later, in the darkness, and both young men fell into a trance, as if someone had in the temples the bells of bulas began to ring. Some movement took place "night queen" flowers. The smell of burnt straw drifted in from the fields; slowly drawing on its dark garments, saturated with the fragrance of The stone floor of the temple was still warm; the approaching night was [footnote] and began to wait.

[footnote] Mandi — the ashana, or bull, the mount of Lord Shiva. [Anticipating an adventure, settled behind the marble statue of Mandi smashtana, two foreign disciples decided to await His arrival and temple. Having learned that the Avatar of the Trinity was visiting the was moved to a later hour, and at those hours no one approached the Shiva on the way to Citrat. Out of respect for the Deity, the evening bulas in His permanent route. Now He stopped each night at the temple of However that may be, from that moment Dattatreya included Govardhan

or a combination of all the above factors?

the Avadhuta — the magic of the royal smashtana, the presence of Shakti, everything had been prepared for His arrival? What precisely had drawn installed there? Could the lighting of the dhuni have been the signal that Dattatreya come to the smashtana because the Shivalingam had been the food collected in Kolhapur and rests before returning to Citrat. Did the Avatar of the Trinity goes to His birthplace, Mahurghat, where He eats ...and asks for alms in the guise of a wandering ascetic. From Kolhapur

Kolhapur in Maharashtra...

other thought or object enters the mind. [footnote] Then He goes to

respect for the aspect of Shiva-Aghora... The onset of a new yuga had not the very fact of His evening visit to the smashana, by the testimony of His Dattatreya. The Avatar of the Trinity confirmed Mahadeva's presence by Shivalingam, and this was followed by the arrival of the Avadhuta — already begun: Shiva appeared here first in person, then in the form of the What had happened on the smashana suggested that a new era had awake, Vishnu and Shiva sleep, and so on.

particular yuga is ruled by one of the Gods of the Trinity: when Brahma is itself a part of the duties of its sleeping companions. It is held that each beginning of the next universal cycle, and the wakeful head takes upon other Deities slumber. "Switched off," they are "in standby mode," for the aspects of the Trimurti. Only one of His heads can be awake: the two simultaneously Creator, Defender, and Destroyer. He embodies all the untouched by maya and yet fully immersed in life in all its totality. Being Dattatreya is the highest of the Avadhutas, attached to nothing, neither born nor unborn.

who has appeared from nowhere — without roots and without causes, itself spontaneously, naturally. In a wider sense the Avadhuta is a seeker and spiritual practice. The decision to attain a state beyond mind comes of intellectual effort; it is a conditioned state of mind, the result of physical attachments is not exclusively a personal decision or the result of celibacy in the name of attaining liberation. The renunciation of worldly a title emphasizes certain aspects of the chosen path — the keeping of becomes an Avadhuta, "the unattached," or literally "without pride." Such "to shake off," to cast off worldly bonds — and that is how a person linguistically the term "Avadhuta" comes from the roots dhu and ava —

the manifestation of the Deity...

datura flowers — all of this had been signs by Nature herself, announcing trees, the appearance of huge astral dogs, the sudden invasion of black heads. Other events too acquired a new meaning: the lush growth of rare Candamra was speaking of Dattatreya — only Guru Datta had three seemed to him that the Natha was referring to the arrival of Shiva, but

greeted before the rite of Shiva, and this greeting became part of the puja world and remained invisible. Now the Guru revered by the Nathas was Datta, Guru Datta! — the invocation of Dattatreya, who gave yoga to the — but a few days later new words suddenly burst from him: "Alakh For about a week the evening rituals began with the call "Alakh Niranjan"

imitations and to attain freedom from all obstacles, including death itself. beyond the carbon-based Universe, to overcome physical and mental call to the higher powers, the declaration that he, a yogin, was trying to go origin of the Universe itself. For him personally, "Alakh Niranjan" meant a find its roots, in order to continue the journey and reach the point of of terms and forms, every soul tries to return to the source of its origin, to essence sustaining all Creation. Rising above customary representations and not the ego. [^footnote] invoking the formless, invisible, single [^footnote] Atman — the concept of the individual "I," which is not the soul describe the characteristics of the Creator, the Self, and the Atman, "Niranjan" — "free of impurities," — and the Nathas use this term to The Sanskrit term "Alakshya" means "the one who cannot be seen," and drum to begin the puja, and he did not resist the impulse.

Niranjan!" These words burst out involuntarily when he first lifted the yet now every ritual at the smashana began with the words "Alakh Basubhadracharya never once mentioned the ancient call of the Nathas. And ...Teaching him the sequences of the Shiva puja, the old bandit of shudras (servants). [^footnote] of Yoga.

brahmins (priests), kshatriyas (warriors), vaishyas (merchants), and extended far beyond the Indian subcontinent. The four varnas are the was specific to a particular period of human history, and these tendencies with the yugas the four Indian varnas (castes). In his view, each varna Treta-yuga, Dvapara-yuga, and Kali-yuga. Shailendra Sharma associates describing the evolution and involution of the Universe: Satya-yuga, the yuga [^footnote] Yuga — an age, an epoch. There are four yugas new era for the Earth and its inhabitants. He believed that this would be been recorded in any calendar, but it had already begun, and meant a

consciously to seek the guidance and support of enlightened teachers. In a certain stages of life, after certain primary realizations, did people begin. The majority strove for worldly success and prosperity, and only a demanded survival skills; enlightenment is sought only on a full stomach. pursued only by some. The land is harsh, and the harshness of life. The concepts of realization and liberation are known to many, but spiritual seekers was not so great, and great saints and sages even fewer. Bharata was (and remains) the cradle of spirituality, but the number of strictly speaking, ancient India was never a spiritual paradise. Yes, symbolizes Nature.

dogs accompanying Him personally the four Vedas, and the cow, mysterious deity of the Hindu pantheon. According to the legends, the divine origin. Accompanied by dogs and a cow, Sri Dattatreya is the most Himself from conditionings: He was deprived of them by virtue of His the help of a guru to attain enlightenment. He has no need either to flee. The divine wandering ascetic and great yogin, Dattatreya never needed the doctrine of non-duality.

Avadhuta Gita, the "song of the free soul," which discloses the essence of timeless texts and treatises, such as the Tripura Rahasya and the scholars and academic researchers. To His authorship are attributed assertions do not always find support from contemporary religious mutual influence and integration of the Vedas and Tantras, although such secondly as the Gita of Yoga. It was Dattatreya who stimulated the first of all as the incarnation of the three mightiest Gods, and only millions worship Him. In the mass consciousness the Deity is perceived. Outside India Sri Dattatreya is almost unknown, although in Bharata

Guru Datta

answer the call.

of the Shivalingam only a few years would pass — and Dattatreya would deep and too embracing to be split into components. After the installation He did not try to find any logical explanation for it: this logic was too

obligations; social ostracism should not be feared, one simply had to step
the essence of wisdom that frees a person from the sticky web of social
were not propagated and not opposed to sins; instead, Dattatreya taught
woven into the stifling cocoon of dogmatic religious thought. Virtues
Christian ideals: there are no commandments and no didactic penalties
In the teaching of Guru Datta there are only a few direct analogies with
theory of liberation was not realized in practice.

own "I." Book-wisdom about yoga they held to be meaningless if the
and decoding the universal laws, reflecting them in the mirror of their
concepts comprehensible to laymen. The adepts succeeded in knowing
Often the motives and way of life of the ancient yogins lay beyond the
conventions.

the clothing-mask fell away, the mind soared upward, overcoming all
stripped of all superfluous ornaments. When from the onion of the soul
limitations, and the body — the house of consciousness — also had to be
the soul was preceded by the liberation of consciousness from all
first one had to overcome the very fear of losing all that. The liberation of
that hindered liberation: conventions, attachments, and dependencies. But
and independence. They began their austerities by renouncing everything
doomed to lose his roots, to lose his natural power, character, freedom,
convinced that, by acquiring the skills of urban survival, a person was
avoided cities long before they grew into megacities. They were
always been the engine of social development — and the naked ascetics
became centers of attraction for commercial activity, for commerce was
well as an objective view of reality. Civilization gave birth to cities, which
helped them preserve the free, elemental nature of their own essence as
ideal was a life in the bosom of Nature, outside society. Such an attitude
ascetics merged effortlessly with the world around them. The highest
unnecessarily worldly conventions: "clad in the sky," the wandering
particular sense in clothing and possessions. For them these were
Guru Datta wore nothing but a loincloth, and His followers too saw no
word, the situation with spirituality was the same as it is today.

disputes around the philosophical contradictions of the concepts of wisdom from the tiniest insect or the mightiest ocean. Centuries later the develop his awareness to a level on which he could learn the great ...surrounding world. The yogin had to become a disciple of Nature and spontaneously and effortlessly, children come to know the...

knowing of *Matra-yoga* is called "*sahaj*," learning without teaching. Thus, meanings and attempts to explain them. The simple, natural way of concepts and ideas, since conflict and error were already inherent in any *sahas*. The method of knowing reality He reduced to the denial of any. The jewel of Dattatreya's doctrine crystallized in the fire of His logic the people, and the bee.

raven and the child, the maiden and the snake, the blacksmith, the spider, honey-gatherer, the elephant and the deer, the fish and the courtesan, the innumerable lessons of wisdom were given to Him by the python and the fruits. Other teachers of Datta were the five elements and the planets, and endures all wounds on its surface and yet gives forth harvests, trees, and Teacher, and he learned to do good from the earth, which humbly and entities, of which only some were people. Nature herself was His that he had gained wisdom by observing 54 different beings, elements, Dattatreya (for it was He) said that his Teacher was the Atman, but added secret of this blessed state and inquired about the name of his Guru. Seeing the bliss-radiating 15-year-old boy, the king asked him about the blessed with the teaching of Dattatreya.

Krishna worshipped the Hill as the place where His ancestors had been but it might easily have been the hill of Govardhan. Perhaps that is why ancestor of the clan of Krishna. The name of the place was not mentioned, Krishna and His greatest devotee Uddhava. [Footnote] to King Yadu. 11th book of the Shrimad Bhagavatam. The text is a dialogue between teaching of Dattatreya to king Yadu is described in the Uddhava Gita, the Once, on a nameless hill, Dattatreya gave the teaching [Footnote] The and to live by Her laws, renunciation came naturally. over it. To those who gradually learned to listen to the voice of the Earth

Pratimical era of the rule of priests and scholar-pratims was marked century. Absolutely everything was accelerating. The end of the Yugas had also undergone change long before the start of the twentieth annas of the ancient Vedic world order, the Vedic concept of the four methods of tyranny and oppression. Together with changes in the four yet democracy meant unquestionable progress, a victory over the old corporations became the new empires, the symbols of a new reign. And the old impulse to suppress competitors and rule subjects — and Capitalism was only a continuation of monarchy, a modernized version of concealed the inborn deformities of the collective body of humanity. Individual freedoms. Democracy was tailored so that its newfangled cut to become better tuned, to establish true respect for personal choice and be built around this fact. A newfangled social gadget, democracy still had power of capital remained sacred, the new construction of society had to ideas of individual freedom and the notion of human rights. And yet the ...The newborn democracy greeted the fall of monarchies, it carried the

quality and non-quality become for him only meaningless words.

simply to leave them entirely. When a person truly comes to know unity, it is not really important whether to solve these unsolvable problems or the same time, Creator and Creation already imply quality. For the logic complete delusion of the mind, since It takes place in relative reality. At applied to it. What is called Creation or Its manifestation cannot be a Truth cannot be classified or defined, none of the definitions can be Dattatreya considered them both at once true and untrue. The Highest of the questioner. [Footnote] quality and non-quality, continue. one and the same reality. The difference lies in the level of self-realization careful analysis shows that they represent only different points of view on Although at first glance Dvaita and Advaita look very different, a more Consciousness. From the Dvaita point of view, the world is quite real. When the soul is freed from this illusion, it merges with the Universal emotions are false impressions. In essence, the soul and God are one. non-quality. Advaita maintains that the world is illusory. All actions and Dvaita and Advaita, [Footnote] Dvaita and Advaita — denote quality and

The Grace of Devi

those who would receive the wisdom of this highest Teacher — the Earth. Her favor, together with the grace of Dattatreya, would extend also to consciousness of the enormous eternal Goddess. It remained to probe that daily from Her. Every creature around him was an expression of the ... Whatever the future might be, he relied on the grace of Nature, learning

life-cycles. And, accordingly, every being had an equal right to existence, and to none in particular: the Earth itself set the algorithms of collective logic had always said that the planet belongs equally to all living beings. Dattatreya's route meant that a new act of the Divine play had begun. The was only a moment of eternity, and this was barbaric. The change in would not continue to feed the mechanisms of the old system. The future megabolizes had already begun to disgorge those who could not and The next round of the Divine play was called "Equality." The

vibrations in unison with the heartbeat of the Earth.

development of the human race, and harmonized the divine and human three Gods embodied the harmony of the forces stimulating the preservation — as well as equality among all beings. The Avatar of the elements, the equilibrium of the forces of creation, destruction, and Dattatreya embodied universal equality, symbolizing the balance of the But what did the Avatar of the Trimurti have to do with all this?

is developing so swiftly that all the signs of the next transition are evident. service will become accessible to all and everyone. At present this sphere 5020 the era of the Shudra-servants will be in full swing; any kind of By his reckoning, the new period would last 120–120 years, no longer. By time of the merchants.

defeated by businessmen, vaishyas — which became the beginning of the rule of the East India Company but an end to the era of kings: they were years. The era of the warrior kings-kshatriyas lasted 5 million years. The by the death of the legendary king Ravana, who reigned for 3.11 billion

the trust of the Supreme Goddess.

their Higher Self. And precisely for this reason the parampara had earned mastery, granting them, without any discrimination, a chance to discover. Because precisely this tradition initiated women into the art of spiritual coming, she was blessing this logic line, expressing Her approval. answer to this question lay in Her recognition of the tradition of Barahi. By But why, in all of vast India, had Adi Shakti chosen this very place? The

to show the way to Her eternal companion. And Shiva followed Her.

innermost, unmistakably feminine symbols in the form of stone fragments gods. Appearing first in the form of a small statuette, she had left Her incarnation. The Goddess spoke through signs and symbols, spirits and Adi Shakti. The Universal Mother was the magnet, the source, the important pieces of the puzzle, and yet the central figure of the story was The pill of Govardhan, the old smashtana, and the logic sadhana were was He who ordered the search to begin: it was His voice and His will. The discovery of the natural Shivalingam was a direct grace of Shiva. It

hidden meanings, and the truth was at once majestic and sobering.

composition. It had taken him more than twenty years to uncover the picture? Perhaps he was standing too close to make out the whole means a matter of chance. Perhaps all these events framed a much vaster the invitation to meet the head of the order Matsyendranatha was by no had found it. All right, the visit of the Nathas could have been chance. But smashtana to see the Shivalingam and then asked to meet the man who the Nathas had formed from the moment Canganatha appeared at the All these years he had reflected on the sequence of events. His link with

attempt it, and those who tried often did not survive to tell their stories.

Today the summoning of the Avadhuta is mere folklore; no one dares devaluing the ritual and turning the sacred into another "convenience," excluded that someone might try to do so for practical considerations, probability of an amateur attempt to call Him is small, and yet it is not Avadhuta are classified and for the most part masked under legend. The In the tradition of the Nathas, the particularities of the summoning of the

began the housecleaning, clearing space for the coming of the Master. The many dwellings, the *grihastha*, was waiting for its Mistress, and she life. She walks eternally beside Time and Death. One of Mahadeva's *Adi Shakti* is the invisible force, the life-giving *Prana*, the one who gives world of *loga*.

same techniques. And this was a rarity in the predominantly masculine *Mahavata*, men and women were given equal opportunities and the the first *Curu* openly to show respect for women. In the line of The more he reflected, the more sense this hypothesis made. *Babaji* was preparatory college.

managed to open the school, and it continues to function today as a the house without escort was a risk. *Lalini Mahasaya* and his companions *Rages* and abductions were so common that even letting daughters out of allow girls to attend lessons in state schools because of various dangers. the end of the 19th century, in India, even middle-class families would not despite considerable resistance from the conservative-minded public. At education: together with his comrades he opened a school for girls, daughters. *Lalini Mahasaya* was a fierce champion of universal *parampara* became a refuge for female students: it protected its spiritual *Kriya yoga* together with their husbands, fathers, brothers, and sons. The that the wives, mothers, daughters, and sisters of *logins* could study teaching to all, the real state of affairs was far from ideal. *Babaji* took care Although the *Bhagavad Gita* spoke of the accessibility of spiritual *bandits*, confined within rigid frameworks of religious rituals.

women remained in spiritual isolation, given over to the mercy of insults in unfamiliar places, etc. Apart from a few unique cases, Indian dangers awaited women at every step: the harassment of false saints, independent search for a spiritual teacher was simply unsafe. Too many tradition without the consent and support of family and relatives. The women. In the 19th century they could not receive initiation into any occult art of *Kriya yoga* opened the doors for the spiritual development of *Babaji's* initiation of the householder *Lalini Mahasaya* into the almost

god. Kula corresponds to the notion of "family" or to modern notions of people who follow similar cultural rituals, often worshipping the same. His arrival, Dattatreya — the Kula [footnote] Kula — a community of and to worship the Avadhuta. When everything had been arranged for immortal Siddha helped him both to continue yoga-sadhana successfully entirely practical considerations. The special instructions given by the Guru Matsyendranatha had decided to summon him to Mahurga for. It seemed that, having confirmed all the facts gathered by His scouts, simpler to declare women evil so as not to stray from the path of virtue.

beginning Matha-novices worldly temptations were too great and it was everything feminine had to be trimmed, uprooted, expelled. For was sought after: She is the companion of Mahadeva. But in real life in many logic lines the abstract grace of the Great Goddess was valued, for without Her there could be no Shiva either.

Yet, as followers of Shiva, the Mathas could not ignore the role of Shakti, honoring women instead of condemning any connection with them. And Matsyendranatha had earned a bad reputation among His followers for the Mathas turned the very subject of feminine force into taboo. Even time, yoga and femininity became antipodes. The orthodox doctrines of regarded primarily as an obstacle on the path to enlightenment. With The Mathas followed a centuries-old tradition in which women were installation here of the symbol of Shiva.

by accident, but to the Fifth Guru of the tradition of Baba, chosen for the Gangas were addressed not to the man who had found a sacred relic come here to see this with their own eyes. The words of praise spoken by world and among mortal and immortal Siddhas. The three Mathas had ...Shiva followed Her, and this caused a great resonance both in the astral marks, just as the foot leaves a trace in the sand.

self-promotion, the concentration of such energies still leaves certain no means an accidental find. Although ancient eternal forces care little for discovered stone fragments, the signs of the Goddess's presence, were by

the method of knowing the soul's immortality, and every unfolding event bridged the trust between the body and the one who animated it. Yoga was presence within the body, to find the eternal path. He was building a path to know his own spirit and strove to help it find a voice, to recognize its wanting only one thing — to find true yoga. Pursuing those aims, he came ... He was simply trying to walk the path of spiritual development unnoticed.

"Walking" among immortal beings was too great a rarity to remain astral beings acknowledged its outstanding dualities. A mortal capable of time it was an anchor for a consciousness so powerful that even mighty the human body was cumbersome, almost burdensome, and at the same consciousness and converse with phantoms without fear. In those worlds needed a mortal yogi who could enter the astral worlds by the power of process for events yet to come? It seemed that all these forces and beings initiation into the world of spirits was another part of the preparatory spirits — and introduced him to the secrets of his realm. Perhaps northern India Balaji is revered as the ruler of the spirits.] the lord of swallow the sun and Indra struck him with his thunderbolt sword. In mother's lap at Mehendipur after the child (Balaji) Hanuman tried to is considered the son of the wind, Vayu. His father carried him into his Madhya Pradesh, Haryana, and many other regions of northern India. He Hanuman, worshipped in Mehendipur, Rajasthan, and in the states of the Deity, yet Hanuman appeared in the form of Balaji.[footnote: Balaji — The same was true of Hanuman. It had never occurred to him to summon had to play along, continuing to fulfill the duties laid upon him.

even asking for it. Everything was decided and predetermined; he simply of his room, himself gave instructions for new levels of kriya, without him Him, but never tried to call Him. The Master himself knocked at the door danger of such attempts. Yes, he worshipped the Mahavatar and admired will. He had never tried to summon any of them, well understanding the ... It is curious that all these great forces and beings came of their own free

"clan." [footnote] guru of the order of Mathas — came onto the scene.

received from the sages, the rishis.

produce pure alchemical gold, Siddhas and Yogis used knowledge alchemically processed mercury, which turned base metals into gold. To secrets of Indian Ayurvedic science, in the descriptions of producing gold come from? This is the first riddle, and the answer is hidden in the for its own reserves of precious metal. Where, then, did India's legendary for some reason historians never noted that India had never been famous was also called *Sone ke chilva* — "the golden bird" — for its riches. Yet kingdom of Bharata, where the descendants of Bharata lived. The land in antiquity India had several names: *Jambudvipa*, or *Bharatavarsha*, the two secrets of the Indian subcontinent.

that had changed the history of mankind. In particular, He mentioned ...He could not remember exactly when Hanuman had spoken of events

The Golden Bird

Secrets of the Golden Bird

Puja to Hanuman

Puja to Shiva

Puja to Mahavatar Babaji

Puja to Shiva

Child-actor in the guise of Shiva in the temple, 1998

Stone fragments — the precepts of Shakti

spiritual merits of the Masters of Babaji's lineage.

had graced the smashtan with Her presence, thereby confirming the claims might seem to skeptics, the facts were plain: Adi Shakti Herself lineage was watched over, recognized. No matter how grandiose such

The progress and development of every teacher and disciple of this and phenomenon supported his sadhana.

of the mind that grasps it. Those without imagination will not know how. The meaning and purpose of eternal life depend, of course, on the nature of those who possess wealth have thirsted for immortality.

Things no pleasure, desires vanish. That is why, from time immemorial, draws to a close, former pleasures become dull and joyless functions, food and worldly temptations no longer impress a sated mind. When life strength to taste the pleasures of the flesh, the taste for life fades over time. Pleasures, and much can be bought with gold. But the aging body has no logic, for human nature itself is founded on an eternal chase after. Possessed of enough gold, the desire to keep enjoying wealth was quite whole science of alchemy was built around this aim: for a person interwoven with the secrets of alchemical gold that grants eternal life. The of eternal life. Immortality was encoded in the very history of India, other sages, rishis, yogis, and kings who seem to have "cracked the code." The legendary emperor Vikramaditya ruled for 1,000 years; there were for that circumstance, Krishna could have lived far longer.

Longevity to an end was merely part of the divine plan. Had it not been sign of aging. The hunter's arrow that brought Krishna's undeniable Krishna played the divine lila for 125 years without showing the slightest. Valmiki mentions in the Ramayana that Lord Rama lived 11,000 years. Sri legends of immortals were taken as entertaining tales. Yet the sage From the end of Vedic times the human lifespan shortened sharply, and Modern science, of course, has never considered these myths credible.

the development of societies, "churning" human history.

Rishis travelled across the subcontinent, teaching people and stimulating until the end of the current yuga, the nine immortal Marhas and the many immortals: the eight immortals, the chitranivis, were to remain on Earth and ruled for hundreds and thousands of years. India was a land of performed austerities for centuries, about kings of antiquity who lived history of the subcontinent. It was full of legends about saints who had mythology had always been regarded by Vedic scholars as the genuine. There was also another secret, which moved him even more. Indian

understanding of what this knowledge meant. Instead they kept clinging not been open to all before, but even educated Brahmins lost the site became blurred and unclear. The essence of the ancient secrets had disappeared continued, but the significance and importance of each holy Shantarascharya also "placed locks" on all twelve Jyotirlingams.

vedas.

and Shringeri Sharada Peetham in the south became the cradle of the Yajur Sama Vedas, Govardhan Peeth in Puri carried the wisdom of the Rig Vedas, the Atharva Vedas, Sharada Peeth in Dwarka preserved the essence of the subcontinent. Badrikashram Jyoti Peeth was honored to hold the light of ॐ BCE, four apples were founded in four parts of the Indian "sealing" Indian society. It was under his direction that, between 200 and played an important role both in preserving ancient knowledge and in laid down for each of the four philosophical streams. Shantarascharya sects, four mahavakyas — "four great sayings of the Upanishads," — were giving them the form in which they are known today. To unite the various systematized the principal currents of Hindu philosophical schools, A theologian and philosopher of the eighth century, Shantarascharya was delegated to none other than Adi Shantarascharya.

the utmost care, and the task of "sealing" the secrets of the subcontinent parbatians, the immortals resolved to guard the secret of eternal life with India, though most of the raids were rebelled. Seeing moths of foreign worship of these gods ceased gave invaders the opportunity to conduct. They were benighted off, and the very fact that the millennia-long ancient gods, Brahma the Creator and Indra the king of all the devatas, ended after Sri Krishna closed the Vedic era, ceasing the worship of the alchemical gold and the secret of eternal life. The age of the old gods very particular secrets drew conductors first: the secret of inexhaustible India had always been a land of treasures and ancient knowledge, but two an eternal body.

enjoyment itself through yoga can savor the magnificence of the world in to use unlimited time, and only one who has grasped the nature of

Babaji initiated Lahiri Mahasaya into the knowledge of Kriya Yoga. Until Around 1857, after the disintegration of the Mughal Empire, Mahavatar the shadow of a greater secret that continues to live.

work or not is another question, but the fact remains: this knowledge is and they even know how to make them. Whether these remedies actually and its stabilization in the state thus reached.] an eternally youthful body, dietary guidance; it leads to the rebirth and rejuvenation of the organism soul through therapy with herbs and minerals, vital breathing practices, around 3000 BCE, kalya kalya cleanses and nourishes body, mind, and purification, an ancient system of rejuvenation. Originating in India granting kalya kalya.[footnote: Kalya kalya — an intensive practice of golden pills of immortality made from processed mercury and capable of power of mercury to create gold. Some wandering sadhus know of the most remote villages of India, people have some general notion of the continued to live in the shadow of Ayurveda. To this day, even in the and the mlechha barbarians could not gain access to them. Alchemy yet the seals laid down by Shankaracharya preserved the sacred secrets, were eclipsed by the shadows of wars, conquests, and destruction. And on the contrary, temples were desecrated, and ancient wisdom and science The conductors who burst upon Bharata unleashed monstrous calamities any effort not directed at daily survival.

That, evidently, is why India looked frozen in time, dozing, indifferent to slowed development, induced a hibernation of mind, will, and progress. But all of them were set up and depicted inverted, overturned, which walls, others were buried in specific spots or simply drawn in the sand. More precisely, Sri Yantras. Some were found as bas-reliefs on temple installed yantras of prosperity in the most important places of pilgrimage. this "sealing of the secrets"? As Hanuman explained, Shankaracharya What exactly did Shankaracharya do, and were there any peculiarities to twenty-first century.

but forgotten; only their echo, distorted in the tunnel of time, reached the to the prescribed rituals and mantras. Yes, the secrets had been preserved,

prosperity in many respects. Yoga itself became extraordinarily popular, contrived that may sound. India was once again entering a bath of and cultural changes began after his journeys, however, amorphous or democratic freedoms, societies were waking up. These political, economic, becoming clear even to those who had never dreamt of civic rights and to harbor at all, why did it matter? The true meaning of democracy was The last "unsealing" took place in 1998. Why did these "unlockings" have the utmost concentration he felt drained.

Recharging was important, since after performing rituals that demanded return to Govardhan to restore his strength and rebalance his sadhana. these journeys. Between all these trips there were intervals: he had to south... Only a few companions accompanying him knew the true aims of west, Govardhan Pith in Puri in the east, and Kanchni Kamkoti in the Badrikashram Jyoti Pith in the north, Sharada Pith of Dwarka in the Shankaracharya's "seals," awaited their hour.

then, one by one, he went to all twelve Jyotirlingams and the places where across India. On the first trip he visited Jageshwar in the Himalayas, and concentration and physical strength. So began his string of journeys detailed instructions, the rituals and techniques required enormous logic one refuse in such circumstances? He only asked, "How?" — and received such a charge. All this sounded utterly unreal, yet he agreed. And could to him, explaining that only a person who lives on a smasana could carry spell and free the sacred knowledge." Hanuman was entrusting this task altogether unexpected: "The time has come to undo Shankaracharya's of the history Hanuman recounted. And then He said something Absorbing all of this information was not easy, but such was the essence began to unfold from 1944 of the twentieth century.

to all strata of society, it hastened the arrival of the fifth yoga, which The yoga granted by Mahavatar changed mankind. Becoming accessible publicly known, and whose life testifies that eternal life is possible.

with humanity. Babaji is the first immortal whose existence became then, only myths and legends had spoken of immortals and their dealings

In May 1997, together with Umashankar Sharma and Rajendra Sharma, he journeyed to the North. Meetings and Blessings

and the wind of change ruffled her feathers.

covering the ancient supercontinent, her eternal nest, with invisible wings, contemporaries who dared to seek it. The golden bird — Bharata — was obscurity. Eternal life was to become not a curse but a reward for the awoken in themselves a vision of the future, to come out of the twilight of nature of Time was still to be understood. To that end he taught others to that the churning of the elixir of Time should remain unsolved. The see the long-term perspective of history had been deliberately cut short so thinking and acting within the limited span of their lives; their ability to casing of an indestructible body remained a tempting legend. People kept scientifically savvy modern person, the eternal life of the spirit in the guidance and hints. Immortality remained out of reach; even for the close to uncovering the riddles of being. And yet they still needed elixirs. Modern alchemy was being rediscovered; mortals were drawing biochemical wonders and were determined to extract new, miraculous. People were already churning the ocean of digital, nuclear, and knowledge of immortality.

inspire, to encourage the development of society, to give hope, to share would once again be able to appear to people from time to time. To Potter. Hanuman explained: as a result of these rituals, immortal beings forces, though there was something in it like the adventures of Harry. This story was not about deciphering ancient secrets or releasing dark "seals," new seekers could gain access to ancient wisdom.

wander across it or to abide in deep meditations. With the lifting of the mysteries that most rishis and yogis never left India, continuing to existential mysteries, and it was precisely because of these mentioned. The very land on which he walked was steeped in primordial the Indian peninsula concealed more riddles than the two Hanuman had throughout the world, spreading with the speed of a forest fire. Of course,

utterly empty. Ordering tea, the women sat down at the next table. One of time as they did, they had not been seen in the temple, and the town was Two elderly women appeared from nowhere and entered at the same

restaurant of the nearest hotel, which stood not far away at a crossroads. temple to the town, the rain grew heavier, and they stepped into the morning service the next day. As they crossed the bridge that links the however, peace-restoring dargah of the Deity. They decided to attend There were at most a dozen visitors, and they had their fill of the When they entered the temple, the snow had already turned into drizzle.

style resembled a Tibetan temple rather than anything else.

columns, the heavy wooden doors and upper galleries, the architectural them with bright colors. Thanks to the intricately painted arches and "Nar," and "Narayan," and built by Shankaracharya himself, welcomed The views were stunning. The temple, set between the twin mountains to the town center, leaving their luggage there, they set off for the temple. case, a bungalow as well. The bungalow was preferable, as it stood closer Authority, managed to book them a VIP room in the hotel and, just in Umashankar Sharma, then working in the DDA, the Delhi Development Because of the weather the normally busy town was almost empty. They arrived in the afternoon. Badrinath met them with a light snowfall.

but their small group had a very different mission.

Dhams. It was believed that travelling there one could attain liberation, in Badrinath, one of the four principal places of pilgrimage, the Char The next ritual of "breaking Shankaracharya's seals" was to be performed

would have dared to ask about it anyway.

burdensome business, the details not meant for disclosure, and no one Amarnath to hand over to the Shiva Ganas. It was a tussle and mighty spirit caught in Kedarnath whom they were transporting to Amarnath, and not only because of the weather but because of one were still trapped in winter. The trip was hard, especially Kedarnath and plains of northern India were already heating up, though the Himalayas set out from Govardhan, via Delhi, on a long automobile journey. The

"You will become world-famous. Like Hanuman" — and, still seated in his marriage brocade sari. Looking at him intently, she pronounced: who was preparing to remark, she said, "You will enjoy family life," and resolved," — and so it happened, just as the woman foretold. To Rajendra, who had certain legal troubles, she said: "Very soon your difficulties will be solved, then she blessed each of them, one by one. To Umashankar, who spent ten minutes they listened with reverence to the flow of Sanskrit one could compare with this woman in pronunciation and diction. For years he had heard various Vedic Sanskrit scholars and pandits, and not many in Vedic Sanskrit, and it was an incredible recitation. Over many he had never encountered anything like it. Then she began to recite a grasped her right shoulder with her left hand. It was an unusual mudra. Clenching it in her right fist, she tucked it under her left armpit and blessing filled with the resolve of fulfillment: Give me a coin, one rupee!" "A formal blessing is meaningless, but I shall create a Shakti Ashirvad, a

visibly, becoming serious, and she sank into the armchair next to him. and said: "Ammā, please bless me!" The expression on her face changed were about to leave, he impulsively held out 500 rupees to the tall woman dignity. The disciples volunteered to escort the ladies to the hotel, as they the bungalow. The women were offered lodging, and they accepted with the hotel, where they booked an extra room: they themselves already had grandmothers, treating them to a VIP reception and putting them up in money, not warm clothes..." They decided to help the two pilgrim Rajendra came back: "They're from our parts. They seem to have neither shoulders, as if the thin cloth could warm her.

here." She pulled the trailing end of her sari more tightly around her friend insisted that we set off for Badrinath at once, and that's how we got "Where are you from?" The shorter one replied: "From Shivpuri: my characteristic of Cwalior, and Rajendra Sharma, passing by, asked: and just as lightly dressed. The women spoke with the accent in a thin sari with a cotton blouse. Her companion was shorter, plumper, back, looked regal. She was dressed quite inappropriately for the weather, them, very tall and pale, with shoulder-length grey hair and a straight

is followed. The Rawals are usually chosen by the former rulers of one of the few temples in the north where the ancient Tantra-Vidhi Yuga. The Namrudini tradition was begun by Adi Shankara, and Badrinath is are traditionally Namrudini Brahmins from the southern state of Kerala. ...Although Badrinath is in northern India, the chief priests, or Rawals,

a bell broke his concentration; the chief priest had begun the puja. him at his first meeting with the Immortal Guru in the flesh. The sound of radiating from the stone image. The same stream of energy had struck convinced of it, recognizing the powerful and barbaric heavy energy this temple it was Baraji, not Vishnu, who was worshipped — he was under half-effaced stone eyelids, and that gaze was riveting and intent. In statue depicted Baraji. Imprinted in stone, Mahavata looked at him from He was not ready for the keen, dagger-sharp instant recognition: the but that hardly mattered any longer.

Shankara Purana says that this idol was retrieved from a pond, not a river, of the caves near Marada Kund, and then installed in the temple. The statue kept reappearing again and again, and at last it was placed in one find thrown back into the river, then tried his luck again. But the same that faceless idols are inauspicious — and Shankaracharya ordered the almost entirely effaced by the flow of the river and time. It is well known pose typical of canonical statues of Vishnu. The features of the face were depicted seated in meditation rather than carved in the half-bent standing by Adi Shankaracharya in the river Alaknanda. The unusual idol was One of the eight self-manifested images of Vishnu, the statue was found Vishnu in the aspect of Sri Badrinath seated in padmasana.

might behold the meter-high black stone, the Shaligram, depicting Lord deity — springar — covering the murti was removed so that everyone in a specially designated place. Crowds of the faithful kept arriving; the reserved VIP seats the evening before and could now sit beside the altar ...The next morning the temple was overflowing. Luckily, they had

bowing low before her.

the armchair, lifted both her feet: "Now bow before me!" All three obeyed,

down with the stick six or seven times, and the blows were paid. The infuriated him. He struck the chief priest of the Badrinath temple lower. "Hit harder! Properly!" — the rawal was now grimacing, and that him with the stick.

calm a man who was clearly mentally unbalanced, he symbolically rubbed buttocks. Realizing the absurdity of the scene, and thinking that it would "Whack me here!" The priest bent over, insistently pointing at his waiting closer to him and then away again.

brance, ducking into another small chamber and bobbing back out, want to beat me with your stick? Go on, hit me!" And the rawal began to and the atmosphere in the room rang with tension. "Well then, do you swallows... Flushed and gripped by anger, he rose, restraining a cane, and, before the eyes of all, drained the water meant for the deity in long. With a haughty smirk the priest exclaimed: "I shall drink it myself" — to the Lord of Badrinath — and handed the small canister to the rawal. come from Govardhan and would like to offer the sacred Yamuna water. Introducing himself and his companions, he told the priest that they had attention, full of his own importance.

parliament and other important guests — and the rawal was enjoying the from Maharashtra and Nagpur were already in the room — members of offering to Badrinath. When they came in, certain high-ranking visitors chamber, bringing with them a canister of water from the Yamuna as an customarily received visitors, and they made their way to the Rawals were other and deeper. In any case, after the bus the chief priest and rudraksha malas struck the rawal as menacing, or perhaps the cause hostility. Perhaps the muscular, broad-shouldered logi with long hair immediately took a clear dislike to him, openly displaying sudden. The priest who conducted the ritual singled out their small group and was more than strange.

royal family of Nepal. Given all of the above, the incident that followed governments of Uttarakhand and Uttar Pradesh and are revered by the Garhwal and Travancore; they are accorded high status by the state

form of a tall, elderly woman of regal bearing who had not looked at all bothered to think that Adi Shakti Herself had come to bless them, in the never wrote off even small incidents as ordinary or accidental. And he trying to take in a wider spectrum of signs and hidden connections, he had slept in them.

one was in the room, and the beds remained untouched, as though no one out the manager was also looking for them. The door was locked, but no went to inquire whether the guests were still in the room, and as it turned room where the elderly woman had stayed was wide open. Umashankar... Driving past the charanashalas, they noticed that the window of the season, he died of a heart attack in Krishikesh.

live long. A few months later, after the temple closed for the winter the dancing sawal. After his memorable performance the priest did not restrain the watchful yogi from Govardhan, the very one who had hogged even once heard a version according to which ten men had been unable to Over the years the story became a local legend and grew new details. He

they could turn any established reputation into a shameful grotesque.

tag dolls in the hands of immortals with a very specific sense of humor — story: a swollen ego led to madness. High-ranking priests were merely then thank him for the punishment? There was a presumed moral to the defiantly throw down a challenge to an unknown yogi, get a beating, and masks. Who else could make the chief bandit behave so arrogantly and drawing out the best and the worst in them, tearing off pseudo-spiritual certainly an example of the Guru's dry humor: Baraji could test people. What was that? He was sure: the show was organized by Baraji. It was get their car out of the parking lot ahead of the dance and they retreated. arrested..." But nothing of the kind happened. Umashankar managed to a very important man and may call the police, complain — and you'll be them toward the exit whispering nervously: "You must leave at once, he's silence until the guard assigned to accompany them grows began to nod and ducked into the next room. The stunned bystanders sat in dead sawal straightened up, admonishing: "Thank you, thank you very much" —

"What butterflies?" The old man knew nothing. Of all assumptions and many butterflies here in the daytime?"

who was already backing away his clinking glasses and pots: "Are there It was time to head back to the hotel. On the way they asked a tea-seller, darkening air.

the dazzling show. Then the butterflies vanished into the rapidly bursting forth from the restless waves, he and his companions watched its blossoms. Hypnotized by the sight of identical black silhouettes shoulders. There were more than sixty of them, and they resembled living wing-tips, they surrounded him, fluttering and lightly pushing his ocean. No less than 17-22 centimeters across, velvety black, with golden between rolling waves, black butterflies were flying straight up out of the visible stones of the ridge. Suddenly he noticed that with each interval Twilight was thickening swiftly, high tides were covering the last barely the sand itself.] which links the Indian subcontinent with Sri Lanka. maintain that the stones on the surface of the sand are in fact older than until a powerful cyclone destroyed it in 1480. Some archaeologists Ramanathaswamy say that Adam's Bridge stood entirely above sea level deepened the seabed. The records of the ancient temple of depth. In the fifteenth century it could be crossed on foot until storms visible; the sea level in these places rarely exceeds 1 meter (3 feet) in and then crossed the bridge to India. Some sections of the "bridge" are the place where the biblical Adam fell to earth from the Garden of Eden Sri Lanka, Adam's Peak, is mentioned in several early Islamic sources as of a former land connection between India and Sri Lanka. A mountain in Mannar Island, Sri Lanka. This 48-kilometer chain is geological evidence Rameshwaram (Ramban) Island off the coast of Tamil Nadu, India, and Rama Setu, is a chain of natural limestone formations between famous Adam's Bridge.[footnote: Adam's Bridge — Rama's Bridge, or That very first evening they went to the beach, to the starting point of the

kilometers around there was nothing but ocean.

windows; it seemed the train was sailing across water, and for several

water from different wells had a particular effect, and the impact of the This was not an ordinary ablution but a kind of benediction: mixed together, the waters gave way to a sharp sense of completion of a particular stage. was poured over him: his body went numb, yet the ritual was worth it: ...Wet from head to foot, he stood in the temple courtyard while icy water symbolized old sins which, one hoped, had already been forgiven.

Old clothes shed by people, mixed with black, clayey sand: their expectations, and pure faith. Walking toward the water, he stepped over with a prayer. He caught hundreds of thoughts full of hopes, old woman shared something like a small lingam and offered it to the sea or quietly whispering sacred words. Taking handfuls of damp sand, and prayers for their departed ancestors, performing ablutions, loudly reciting. They came out to the ocean shore. Countless pilgrims were offering his case, the ablution was obligatory before the ritual he had to perform. was poured over them. This ceremony was believed to wash away sin. In then, in the temple, a bucket of water from each of the twenty-two wells. Most pilgrims went down to the ocean in front of the temple for ablutions: for centuries.

Monkeys or not, the heroes were heroes, and their names had been kept monkey-generals of Hanuman's army, and he liked that very much. stories of the Ramayana. Some of the books had been named after the The twenty-two sacred wells within the vast temple complex were tied to "So many Rudrakshas..."

"No, from Coimbatore. Why do you ask?"

asked him: "Are you from Kerala?"

knives. Seeing the heap of heavy Rudraksha malas on his chest, the bandit God." It was a southern custom, and they obediently removed their priest: "All men must be bare from the waist up to enter the house of ...At the entrance to the temple grounds they were stopped by a Tamil

theories, the simplest was to take this small event as an auspicious sign.

Then there was Rameshwaram, the temple of Mallikarjuna in Srirangam, to Shiva.

spot where Vishnu had given his sister and bride Meenakshi in marriage peacefully, powerful energies. The building had been raised on the very ...The Meenakshi temple in Madurai struck them with its beauty and had been singing for millennia. The vibrations were soothing.

subtle body, and the honeyed, syrupy duality of the lullaby that the South melodies of Rajasthani ragas and the piercing dhams still echoing in his contrast between the intense vibrations of the North, its meditative ...Having finished the ritual, he sat motionless, sensing the striking Goddess.

red saris and green lamps — repeating the thousand names of the around the inner altar, bringing offerings to the Goddess — traditional In the temple of Kumari Amman there were few people. Visitors walked lasting embrace.

their fill of each other, and dusk was already beginning to hide their with the breath of the earth, as if these two great beings could not have Ocean, the Arabian Sea, and the Bay of Bengal; the salt breeze mingled poured liquid red gold of the sun into the merging waters of the Indian into the ocean, and the incredible panorama was lit by a sunset that and the Tropic of Cancer, the gigantic ancient ship of the continent thrust peninsula, Kanyakumari. Having dropped anchor between the equator The next day a taxi took them to the southernmost point of the Indian

sight of everyone, this fabric of being was open only to a few.

into a complex mosaic of life, stretched out under the eternal sky, in plain history, rituals, faith, and intentions of gods and mortals fused together Hanuman, who had sent him on the journey. Here, in this place, the powerful avatars of Vishnu, was felt very strongly, as was the presence of In Rameshwaram the presence of Rama, the seventh and one of the most life was so strong that after the trial he slept for two hours.

one of stone, with images of a spider, a cobra, and an elephant, which in corridor, they came to the main sanctuary. There were two Shivalingams: inside through a VIP entrance. Passing through the famous colonnaded long queue dispirited them, but a temple trustee they knew led them decorated with intricately carved images of celestial beings. At first the and "the Kailash of the South," and the seven-storied gateway tower is Dedicated to Shiva in His aspect of air, it is called "the southern Kashi." The famous Trikalanasti temple turned out to be stunningly beautiful.

deviations.]

five temples are located on the same longitude, with only minor these temples, with each lingam named after the element it represents. All ether. It is believed they are embodied in the five lingams installed in manifestation of one of the five elements — earth, water, fire, air, and "elements," and "sthala" means "place." Each temple represents a the five temples dedicated to Shiva. Pancha means "5," "bhuta" means elements, the Pancha Bhuta Sthalams.[footnote: Pancha Bhuta Sthalams — obligatory. The place lay next to one of the temples representing the five paying respects to the great forefather and founder of their clan seemed place of the samadhi of Bharadwaj Rishi was not far off. He agreed, since itinerary, but Mr. Pawar persuaded them to make the detour, since the ...Trikalanasti, the temple city in Andhra Pradesh, was not on their devotion, as he could see for himself.

unobtrusive; southerners were polite, well-read, and full of sincere was a television actor, a Bollywood celebrity. Their attention was polite, a small crowd would quickly gather around them. People thought he him during the rituals. But along the way, whenever they stopped for a rudraksha malas drew visitors, although no one ventured to come near rare, and yet he often drew attention. Broad shoulders, long hair, and complexes. In the south the sight of meditating yogis in temples is not always managed to find solitude in the spacious courtyards of the temple invocation, and all this had to be done in a quiet place. Somehow, he rituals required concentration, visualization, and sometimes a silent and Hyderabad... He meditated for long stretches in all these places; the

That was precisely how it worked, and that was one of the reasons why mantra recitation.

mantrin means "the one who recites a mantra." who receives the boon of used to denote various government posts. In the Shaivite tradition, grace of Shakti rests; the mantrin.[footnote: Mantrin is a Sanskrit word the blessing always goes to the shaktiman — the one with whom the participants may enjoy the spectacle and feel the force of the moment, but The benefit of any ritual always goes to the one who performs it. The

Making Mother Happy

believe were all-pervading, like the air they all breathed.

What did these people see in him? Human faith, hope, and the desire to filled with devotion and hope, made a staggering impression on him. him, chanting praise to Shiva; the hands stretched out to him, the eyes queue was instantly set in motion. People prostrated themselves before inappropriate, but the chain reaction had already begun, and the whole his feet. To worship a mortal in the presence of a deity is utterly "Har Har Mahadevi!" and prostrated himself on the stone floor, touching who had been staring at him intently for some time suddenly cried out: The meditative state was suddenly broken. A middle-aged Tamil peasant state, the effect of the presence of higher forces...

lasting permanence. The thoughts had no precise formulation — rather a and invisible like Time-Shiva, air symbolized both constant change and consciousness, of spirit, servant and consort of Life, powerful, infinite, symbolism of the element of air opening up to him. Beater of Prana, of material, he felt the deepest

Here, standing on the invisible edge between the spiritual and the

A draft, coming from nowhere, swayed the flames of the oil lamps.

invisible Shivalingam, set up in a closed chamber and "consisting" of air, and properly initiated could perform the rites. There was also another, was forbidden to touch. Only bandits belonging to the Bharadwaj gotra

plantation had been with him for a long time; the incident only wounded — a sight that was unbearable. The idea of planting a new nests, chicks and eggs. After the fire the trees stood scorched and heart-rending: nesting birds tried to dive back into the flames, to their carelessness or deliberate arson is hard to say, but the sight was truly One day the jungle behind the smashan caught fire. Whether it was

highways and roads. But that did not mean there was nothing left to do. obligations to provide amenities, allocating a hefty budget for new all its history. After nine years the government at last began to fulfill its Kadha Kund smashan itself was transformed, perhaps for the first time in ditch was cleaned, mountains of refuse were carted off, and even the the delight of the residents of Kadha Kund. Every street and drainage Over nine years that team accomplished an enormous amount of work, to

"Now that you're dressed so stylishly, work in style!" with uniforms, given new jeans, red jackets, baseball caps, and shoes. the Govardhan Hill, and we will pay you." All of them were provided mess!" He and Devabuti hired a team of fifteen workers: "You will serve cursed the city authorities for years: "Why won't anyone clean up this left mounds of garbage behind them every day, and the local people had barikadas road. No one else was going to do it. Thousands of pilgrims Academy was asked to "take patronage" of a 3-kilometer stretch of the the disciples spoke to the local administration, and the Siddha Siddhanta with rubbish, and had not been cleaned since the days of Krishna. One of whose surroundings were appallingly filthy. The whole area was strewn It all began with the clearing of the neighboring pond, Kadha Kund, factor, funds always materialized, and the work continued.

endless Lila, the play of life. A shortage of money was never a lasting could remain an idle observer — or become an active participant in the Often, life in the immediate vicinity of the Divine Hill felt like a trial. One rewards, the blessing of the land itself gave him colossal satisfaction.

land of Braj was a sacrament and an honor. Beyond the perfectly obvious he kept beautifying the smashan and the areas adjoining it. Service to the

not belong to him. This at first made the neighbors declare him an ascetic since he financed the clearing and irrigation of stretches of land that did not belong to him. All of this required money and effort, but the enjoyment of the general equilibrium and calm spurred him on to go on at life and at being in the moment. The same sense of all-embracing feelings after a night-time sadhana, when the spirit is at peace and rejoices in obtaining satisfaction. That was the essence of any inspiration, like the Over the years he had learned to do everything only for the sake of easy matter. Yet those troubles brought him satisfaction.

of workers kept tending the area: keeping everyone on payroll was no looked idyllic, but required constant care and funding. A sizable brigade during the monsoon peacocks danced among the trees. The plantation surface with their roots. Birds returned, wild antelopes were sighted, and the trees grew and gained strength, drawing underground water to the fertilizer, and the second attempt was a success. At first thin and fragile, stubbornly, he planted again. This time the holes were filled with the first batch did not take root — the soil was too acidic and too dry. water tanks were bought for irrigation. But even with regular watering leveling the soil. Trees were planted in the pits that had been dug, and excavators worked for more than 200 hours, clearing the territory and truly titanic battle with giant cacti and thorny bushes. Two huge JCB Clearing the area for the plantation began in October 2004, and it was a anywhere anyway.

decided to plant trees instead of buying a car. Besides, he never went generous donation of 21,000 dollars to buy a car. Thanking the sender, he It so happened that at the same time a disciple from the USA sent him a acres of land was at last issued.

about the desired result, and permission to plant trees on twenty-five a fatal intervention by an official from the Ministry of Labour brought adjacent stretch of land. The negotiations dragged on for a long time, until department: the Siddha Siddhanta Academy offered to look after the strengthened his intention. Negotiations began with the state forest

survival...

land without a drop of drinking water and the long, exhausting battle for remembered well his own first months on the smashan: a sun-scorched supply came to him — and he gave water to those in need, since he ...Local hospitals, cowsheds and farms, peasants without a stable water

Hill, Govardhan Maharaj himself.

doubt, behind the success of all these efforts stood the Dark Lord of the triumphant, protected the wildlife and nourished the soil. Without a felt the long-awaited sense of deep satisfaction. The trees, survivors and on the roof of his house and looking out at the ocean of lush greenery, he greenery of the trees replaced the dry, desolate landscapes. And standing Barana road, as well as in the poorest neighborhoods of Govardhan. The bright, ever-blooming bougainvilleas were planted along the Mathura-feeding all corners their berries. Kadamba trees, bushes, and thousands of dry summers, and soon 20,000 fruit-bearing jolora trees were already reforestation succeeded, the trees that had been planted survived several irrigation water supply for the plantation. The long-term plan for knowledge of the local plumbing network, and he was able to provide an supervising and maintaining the waterworks gave him exclusive

well as the birds and monkeys of Baraj, no longer suffered from thirst.

animals were set up along the Barikama road: stray cows and dogs, as gained access to drinking water, and somewhat later, drinking troughs for electricity bills. Several cisterns were installed, and local residents at last Academy, and he began to maintain the plumbing system and pay the water-supply project was handed over to the Shikha Shikhantra Yogi care of the water bodies along the whole length of the Barikama. The cemented his reputation that the local administration suggested he take another's intentions. And not always. All this work for the community so with praise; only persistence and time can convince them of the nobility of initial skepticism. In the countryside (as everywhere) people are stingy. Over the years bewilderment gave way to respect, just as silent as the impractical spendthrift, and then watch his progress in astonished silence.

once again he experienced relief and satisfaction, since he was repaying on people's faces was the greatest reward. The problem was resolved, and the authorities about six months to carry out similar work. The happiness significant portion of the floodwaters. After previous floods it had taken month workers hired by the Academy were able to divert and drain a The success of the operation was nothing short of a miracle. In less than a flood other farms, which required the installation of additional pumps, worked the water out without interruption. But that very water began to undertaking. Foreign disciples again came to the rescue, and the pumps large water pumps were rented, which proved a rather expensive

balance of subtle energies of the area — and that reflected on his practice. grief of homelessness. The discomfort of people affected the delicate the waves of despair and homelessness coming from people, the pumping the drainage. But the houses were flooded, property damaged, and he felt There was no way back, although he had not yet even decided to take up are doing such great work: thank you for pumping out all that water..." neighboring houses. Suddenly the local people began to praise him: "You forty kilometers. The famous temple was submerged, as were many and water inundated the surrounding area within a radius of twenty to During a flood, the lake Manasi Gangs next to the smashan overflowed, Academy and Sri Shailendra Sharma.

plaque with the names of the sponsors, the Siddha Siddhanta Yoga completion of the building was marked by the installation of a stone equipped with bathrooms, showers, and water-treatment facilities. The donations of foreign disciples the Academy built a hostel for sixty people, and the last thing the town needed was disgruntled policemen. On the came to him for help, since officers were living in unsuitable conditions, rooms to the newcomers. For all sorts of reasons. So the police captain there was not enough space in the hostel, and locals were not eager to rent Govardhan. The old police station was rebuilt to house the new staff, but town was growing: more and more policemen were being transferred to budget was truly limitless, for there simply was none. Meanwhile, the However limited the budget, he always tried to help. To tell the truth, the

One day, coming across an old book, he presently read the words everything had become a state of his soul.

existential equilibrium and the general interconnection of everything with alive, interconnected, and conscious. A global understanding of natural catastrophes and weather phenomena, sounds and words, were sensitivity extraordinarily, and he knew: all animals, plants, stones, rivers, essences, in close interaction with his own. Sadhana had developed his This place and the beings inhabiting it were entities with spiritual bureaucrats... He did not earn a single rupee.

organizing workers and equipment, theedium of dealing with Why did he bother with all this work at all? The expenses, the hassle of that her story would also inspire people.

to all kin." Chummun became a celebrity overnight: one could only probe inscription: "11,000 jamun trees kindly donated by the monkey Chummun trees, putting up by the new plantation a sign with a short but intriguing sooner said than done. They bought and planted more than 11,000 jamun relish that he decided to plant berry trees for her relatives as well. No day someone brought jamun berries, and Chummun ate them with such living with them for nearly thirteen years, Chummun the bandays. One The idea of planting jamun fruit trees came from a monkey that had been kept coming. As did inspiration, from the most unexpected sources.

the smashan to Badha Kund. It was an enormous task. Fortunately, funds He kept on planting, and 120,000 trees took root along the roadside from grew.

maintenance, of course, but the watering system worked and the forest where irrigation pipes had been installed. They needed systematic Siddhanta Yoga Academy looked after 1.2 km of the Govardhan Hill, gossip. Respect had been earned by hard work. Now the Siddha He once again became the talk of the town, this time without sneers and the debt owed to the land that had received and supported him.

years ascetics have continued their austerities around the Govardhan Hill in Braj every tree is considered sacred. It is believed that for thousands of lush green canopy...

direction of his armchair, sheltering him from the merciless sun with a shade? Over the next few months the tree turned its branches in the addressed an old neem tree: "Could you lend me a little more of your was still scarcely fit to live in, he used to sit outside, and once jokingly property, and they were clearly aware of his presence. When the house lower, stretching out their branches. Many "female" trees grew on the on the path to the Shiva temple were "trying" to touch him, leaning over... As sadhana sharpened his sensitivity, he began to notice that the trees communion.

sindur paste applied, and the Deity was ready for worship and Hill, or Hanuman. A pair of eyes would be drawn on a stone, a tilak of routinely worshipped as Radha and Krishna, the Lord of the Govardhan road, under a tree, in a field, or on a narrow lane, stones lay that were the stones, the trees, and the animals of Braj. Sometimes by the side of the animistic codes, and these beliefs were still alive and breathing through Puranas. Long before Hinduism, Jainism, and Buddhism, people lived by as well. Being part of Hindu traditions, they are reflected in various polytheistic, and partly shamanic religions had existed in pre-Vedic times the very land; they only needed to be heard. Traditional animistic physical world. At a subtle level these beliefs had rooted themselves in ideas of the absence of any distinction between the world of spirits and the "animism." It is just another scholarly term, but at least it captured the Anthropologists who had tried to classify such beliefs called them could accurately describe reality. The world is far larger.

no longer rely on outdated postulates that social and cultural references Coming to know a world much vaster than the merely human, he could is always lived in relationships with other objects, places, and beings."

some are people, life

summarizing this concept: "The world is full of inhabitants, and only

earth will carry the memory of us..."

"There will be no kings, no queens, not even life itself, but the dust of the

And the words of another song echoed in his mind:

remember me,"

there will be those who listen better than you. Why should anyone

"Others will come tomorrow; they will speak more colourfully than I

roads. From a famous Bollywood song he liked the line:

blooming bushes and trees, fountains and water bodies along well-paved

barren. They would think that there had always been a multitude of lush,

scorched fields and dry, barren hills would remain in the memory of their

Govardhan residents would remember their native land as green; the sun-

It is well known that human memory is short, and new generations of

service to the Earth.

widespread religious charity of Braj, but something much greater —

was still considered unthinkable. But what he was doing was not the

incredible. To spend private funds on the improvement of public lands

wrong. Perhaps because they themselves regarded these stories as

Shiksha Shikshanta Yoga Academy, but journalists kept getting the facts

to time local newspapers wrote about the great work being done by the

All these labors of love were rarely mentioned, only in passing. From time

bodies.

those trees, too, would develop further, taking on other forms, other

souls that came here to continue their long transformative journey. And

Every time he planted a new grove, he knew: new trees would take in

insects, birds, and animals.

mercilessly tested for resilience by extreme temperatures, winds, rains,

beings with weathered trunks and rough, cracked bark, their bodies

mere trees: to him they seemed to be living, breathing, meditating

was inclined to believe these legends. Some of them hardly seemed to be

in the form of trees. Watching the miraculously surviving old trees, he

took us — and we go. We did not arrive of our own will, and we leave not melancholically reported: "Life brought us here — and we came. Death meaningful there. At the gates they were met by an Urdu inscription that the visitors. Somehow conversations sounded deeper and more afternoons he would usually head to the smashan for a walk with one of stood. The place was quiet, with a large, well-tended garden, and in the closest local landmark, the Morar smashan, only a few residential houses again — to a rented house on the outskirts of Cwalior, where, near the ... When the period of the "battle for the farm" was over, the family moved sometimes frightening.

sharpened sensitivity, and the new sensations and realizations were keen, coin of being were coated with a patina of struggle and desire. Zadhana and what they saw was the bare underside of existence. Both sides of the but they were more afraid of these new skills. To see was to believe — their origin. Similar abilities developed in some of the disciples as well, telling spirits apart, but then lost interest and did not bother to classify previous lives, others had not... Over time he had become rather good at populated by various phantoms. Some of them had been people in was even amusing, especially during visits to cremation grounds behind or to the side, never appearing directly in front of him. At first it Dark and bright shadows slipped past the periphery of his vision, hiding of other, almost transparent, yet quite real, inhabitants of the astral realm. him quite unusual abilities: he could discern the airy bodies of spirits, and long hours of meditation and vigorous hathikas gradually developed in

Land of Phantoms

Spirits and All the Rest

With the Kottweiler Jimmy, 2000

whispered of eternal life.

memories of the past. But the Earth had the longest memory. It softly People were busy with dreams, with the cares of the present, not with

Several female spectres lived in a half-ruined building behind the house, surprised by his ability to see them without showing it.

were not offended by his lack of attention. They were, rather, shocked and he simply could not afford the luxury of idly watching the spirits; they since the repairs and clearing of the land continued for nearly three years,

company. Here, on the ancient smashan, only the strongest could remain and were not about to become so. The spirits of people kept to their own Shivaingam in an ecstatic round dance. They never "belonged" to people flame, sometimes diving back into the qiumi or soaring above the nighttime ritual, myriad translucent spheres emerged directly out of the. After the qiumi was lit, new spirits began to appear. Drawn by the

months, and some stayed forever.

beings. Catching sight of him, some fled in panic, others lingered for a few and his sister settled in Govaqshan. They were strange and at times eerie ... Encounters with other inhabitants of the smashan began as soon as he

souls he was the most mature phantom.

into the crowns of the trees. Perhaps among the shocked and homeless trying to notify anyone of his presence, simply floated away, dissolving hesitated for only a moment, then looked at the mountains and, without sky with sharp volleys, scaring up a flock of pigeons, the brigadier military men were present at his cremation. When the gun salute split the honored with the highest military distinctions. Many high-ranking one of them behaved with dignity — an army brigadier who had been had almost the same shapes and sizes as their former bodily shells. Only one heard their cries. As far as he could tell, the airy bodies of phantoms inhabited only a moment ago. But they simply passed through, and no their "own" bodies and throwing themselves on the dead flesh they had screamed soundlessly: "Don't burn me, I'm alive!" — trying to re-enter the attendants of the smashan from cremating their bodies. Some Sometimes, during last rites, he watched terrified souls trying to prevent of our own desire." It sounded believable.

than ten. Rushing through the garden, she would throw herself into the desperately and moaning, would run through the house — a girl no older. And there were the spirits of a mother and daughter. The first weeping 1003.

He stayed in the house for several months, apparently until December direction and avoiding direct collision. After their arrival at the smashan. Whenever he caught sight of him, the raven-man "dived," aside, changing in a strange rhythm, the phantom made sudden ducking movements: backwards, his heels facing forward. Moving with a peculiar dancing gait, thin, bony legs were turned inward, his knees and feet pointing like a giant raven, but under all those feathers he was humanlike. His centimeters tall, in a robe of black feathers, with a thick long beak, he was yet another peculiar phantom, a bhuta, lived in the house. More than 180 wanting nothing other than peace and quiet.

They had accepted their status and were reconciled to their new form; phantoms of devotees did not seek new bodies, did not crave new births; ancient spiritual lineage ensured spiritual progress even after death. The These spirits were "living examples" of how a connection with a genuine, the power of Moksha Bhumi, where they could attain final liberation, fervor. They belonged to the Bengali line of Krishna devotees, drawn by would often sit on the stone wall, reciting mantras with rare religious. Five or six spirits had chosen a secluded spot beyond the pond, and

Hollywood thriller "Predator." It seemed they were peaceful.

They belonged, but later he saw similar translucent forms in the not interfere — at least, not openly. It is hard to say to what class of being they observed the new inhabitants of the smashan and their lives, but did in front of the house seemed to be made of bundles of air. With curiosity. Quickly moving, iridescent translucent beings that lived in the large trees, their blurred twenty-foot figures were far from playthings.

Hats and long robes and recalled illustrations from children's books, but dusk. The Witches, as he nicknamed them, wore pointed wide-brimmed and their translucent silhouettes, like weeping willows, could be seen at

mustache... Whoever her creator was, he had chosen the most repulsive tattered undershirt draping bony ribs. Yes, and "she" also had a big filthy blouse, torn at the front, out of which withered breasts spilled, and a teeth, she dangled in the dark corners. The creature haunted a horribly bony fingers. Bald, red-eyed, with black skin and large, lang-like yellow ceiling fan, crawling across doors and shutters, clinging to them with her slowly drifting through the air, this Churel hovered, dangling from the perhaps that was why bhaintoms had chosen it as their "country club." The old white house stood on an inner crossroads of the smashan, and grounds, abandoned battlefields, on house thresholds, and at crossroads. with unfulfilled desires, usually loitering around graveyards, cremation creature looked terrifying. Churels are the spirits of women who died ... The house was often visited by one female bhaintom, a Churel, and the the dust of the earth.

planet's eternal primordial matter. The body's ash is destined to become combustion.] and return to the earth as yet another constituent of the alchemical plasma[footnote: Plasma — ash, or any powdery product of of creation is at once simple and complex: burnt bodies turn into ash, one of the five basic elements that make up the human body. The alchemy

element of Earth is

last particle of organic tissue disintegrates, dissolves into the earth. The believed that the soul continues to remain near earthly remains until the a quiet cremation rite was performed, guaranteeing the last peace. It is cowsheds, workers found another eight or nine female skulls. Once more soon after this incident, while digging an irrigation channel by the related rite of cremation gave their tortured souls peace.

been killed. In any case, they had fallen victims to some tragedy, and the a woman and one of a child. Perhaps both had died in an accident, or had followed her usual route until two skulls were found in the garden, one of vanished, but the spirit of the girl was seen for several more years — she could ever make out. After some time the bhaintom of the woman bony, and the mother would follow her, calling out the name no one

permanently on the Holy Hill. Stretching from the royal mansion to the
the Lord of Death, Yama. Only He could allow anyone to live.
Although the land was officially in his ownership, de facto it belonged to
The God of Death

objection: the snakes were noble and silent neighbors.
mostly coming from the local people, so the presence of corpses was no
verus quing. In those days he and his sister had had enough of both,
defecates in the house it means a blessing, as opposed to a rite. Venom
chambers said the sign could be considered suspicious: if a royal corpse
was hung over the front door for the amusement of visitors. Snake
later, the long shed skin of the reptile, found by workers in the garden,
possible effect of the venomous waste was unpredictable. A few days
improvement works. The carpet had to be taken out and burned, since the
that was now the Nagas expressed its opinion about the noise made by the
the eye, defecated on the carpet, and slid leisurely back outside. Perhaps
quietly commanded: "Don't move..." The snake stopped, looked him in
as thick as an anaconda, moving with graceful fluidity. Everyone froze: he
open when a royal corpse slowly slid there in, almost 4.2 meters long and
garden, and one even once turned up in the darsana hall. The door stood
Nagas. Huge serpents inhabited not only the old legends but also the
...The Land of Liberation — Moksha Bhumi — was also the land of the
was the only compliment a Churel had ever been paid.

cure had been lifted, who knows. But one can say with certainty — that
recoiled as if from a powerful blow and disappeared forever. Maybe some
lokingly called to her: "Hello, beautiful! How are you?" The phantom
Once, when she was peering at him from outside through the window, he

constantly nearby: perhaps she was drawn by the smell of new life.
creature. The Churel had become attached to the puppies and was
disciples — who had given them newborn puppies — saw this charming
die. But this particular phantom was silent. He, Devanuri, and one of the
with a fatal illness, and that whoever answered her nocturnal call would
ballette. It was believed that anyone who saw a Churel would be struck

his long, mighty arms, with their magnificently outlined musculature, and dark-skinned, the God was clothed only in a red dhoti. The palms of before him stood Yamaraj, the God of Death and of Dharma. Mighty, tall, make out the face.

bracelets on the arms and legs, a massive belt — and that was enough to ornaments glimmered in the darkness: a tiara, earrings, necklaces, made out a faint glow and someone's silhouette. The stranger's gold features, only the heavy breathing of the buffalo could be heard. Then he found himself dismounting in pitch darkness. The place of arrival had no The surreal journey was almost soothing, even if it might be his last. He a drop of curiosity or nervousness.

huge, slightly damp body of the buffalo. His mind was empty; he felt not felt the movement of powerful muscles and the heat radiating from the one did not feel that they were moving at all. And yet beneath himself he gold, intricate gold ornaments adorned its huge neck. The ride was short; enormous animal. The hooves and horns of the black giant were painted fell dream from trance, he found himself sitting on the back of the The buffalo suddenly sneezed, and the huge head swayed. Still unable to bluntly, an imminent demise.

believe that to see a buffalo in a dream means a visit to Yamaraj. To put it huge eye, like a wet black cobblestone, narrowed, and he froze. Hindu when the enormous head of a black buffalo appeared in the window. A ...He was dozing, half-reclining on the bed in the second-floor bedroom, unexpected official permission to remain on the ashram.

candidates. In the first week of November 1993 he received an Dharma, the God of Death and Justice in Hinduism.] sanctioned the Yamaraj.[footnote: Yamaraj — also known as Dharmaraj, the lord of Lord of the Hill himself, Govardhan Maharaj, and the God of Death, places or other worlds. In most cases, the residents were chosen by the one stayed for good. At some point everyone had to move on, to other habitation. Some ashrams had been built there, sadhus lived there, but no like Kusum Sarovar, this stretch of the Hill had never been meant for

desperate.

cremation site, and stories like that would have scared off the most unwise. It was already hard enough to find people willing to work at a mysteriously emptied — to tell them the real reason would have been puzzled cowherds complained that the cistern of water was once again animal had nowhere to quench its thirst in the realm of the God of Death. Giant buffalo often came down to the cowshed to drink. Probably, the There was no doubt that the smasman was in the hands of Yamatai, whose to discuss what had happened with anyone but Devanuni.

smell of the smoke he had breathed there in the dark. He was in no hurry the buffalo still lived, and his nostrils were filled with the bittersweet in the tips of his fingers a distinct tactile memory of the hot, oily hide of all: he simply found himself half-reclining on the bed in the bedroom. But recollections of the return journey: perhaps there had been no journey at place — and that was the keynote of the meeting. There were no ...He was being permitted to remain on the smasman to look after the soon come to His consort."

the exact words, catching only the general sense that Mahadev "would Dharmas said something about Shiva, but he was too nervous to remember inhabiting it, of the past and of the future. At some point the Lord of The God of Death spoke of the meaning of Moksha Bhumi, of the spirits and had known each other across past... deaths.

was pierced by a lightning flash of realization that they had met before. Rising, he realized that he came only up to Yamatai's waist — and then the intricate gold ornament of the deity's sandals, woven from thin straps. Bowing hurriedly before Yamatai, he had a fraction of a second to admire dead.

neither mace nor noose, with which He usually catches the souls of the features was framed by a fiery red beard, without a moustache. There was were bright red, as if painted, and his grim, serious face with sharp

when, but it seemed to work. After a successful darbar people chanted his exorcism sessions. He did not remember who had taken this snapshot and straight into the camera without a smile, became the main accessory of the young, broad-shouldered yogi with a red bandana on his head, looking. Having thought it over, he agreed, and soon a large photograph of a hall. And your name must be chanted aloud by all present."

"Yogiraj, Balaji has commanded that your photograph stand in the darbar victims. And there was a particular condition stipulated by Balaji himself: cause of each case of possession, exorcise the evil spirits, and heal the spirits..." Appointed bhagat, the medium was to diagnose the nature and affairs, or a ceremonial assembly,] at which people will be freed from evil meaning "court"; it can be the council of a feudal state for the conduct of to lead a darbar.[footnote: Darbar — a term, in Urdu (from Persian), lifting his hands above his head, he spoke quietly: "Balaji has ordered me ... The medium sat on the floor with closed eyes. Then, rhythmically

his messengers. They (possessed or "normal") are known as bhagats.

that people possessed by benevolent spirits (gustas) are servants of Balaji. Balaji-Hanuman also relieves pain, suffering, and misfortune. It is said enormous strength (bal), which no demon can match. Full of compassion, called Balaji. According to belief, He tames evil spirits and possesses In northern India Hanuman is worshipped in the form of a child (Balaj)

case, the way one is introduced matters in any society.

were of Muslim origin — these beings were older than Islam itself. In any Shiva. Some of the spirits called him "lord," "master," or "malik," if they to an advanced yogi, but it is also the title of the first guru of yoga, Lord addressed him as "Lord of Yoga," Yogiraj. Usually this honorific is given Hanuman various astral beings began appearing at the samashan, and all phantoms knew him by that name. Soon after his first communion with that the Deity had introduced him to the world of spirits, since all It was Hanuman who first called him "Yogiraj." Apparently it was thus

The Trial of the Spirits and the Tamers of Phantoms

his name, the stream of human gratitude and devotion stood in sharp
who had received relief from suffering through his logic abilities changed
way of life, and their dismissive attitude hurt. But when dozens of people
phantoms but because of the living. Some relatives were still critical of his
For him personally this period proved rather difficult, not because of
was no less important.

work. People were of course helped too, but the "rehabilitation" of spirits
"rectify" it, to help it find peace. That was the most important part of the
malevolent spirit and extract it from the body of the possessed, but also to
astral offenders. However, the task of the darpas was not only to detain a
difficult; there were many exorcists who specialized in apprehending
receive protection and ask for justice. To catch a phantom was not
Any soul, regardless of whether it dwelt in a physical or astral form, could
and the spirits who had been wronged by people.

help to all without any discrimination: those suffering from possession
spirits. The Prem Darpar took place regularly three times a year, giving
power of the higher Guru helped maintain a balance between people and
and all souls needed support at various levels. Personal devotion and the
action. The world was severe and realistic, human bodies were fragile,
made these words his personal slogan for difficult decisions and swift
Shakti" — "My devotion is reinforced by the power of the Guru," and
He recalled the words of the great yogi Gorakhnath: "Meri bhakti, Guru ki
"clients."

had approached a thousand, but no one bothered to count the astral
onward. By summer, the number of those possessed by spirits and healed
was operating successfully from December 1990

his power to fulfill the new duties, and the "Spirit Rehabilitation Program,"
through him, helped everyone without exception. He did everything in
session — were quite enough. The power of the logic lineage, manifesting
photographs and the lakara — the chanting of his name at the end of the
power of healing. There was no need to attend the darpas in person. The
name: Yogiraj Maharaj, ki jai!!! praising him and the grounding, liberating

known as the most powerful and effective, thanks to its link with the yogi gatherings that conducted exorcism, but it was this dharbar that became inhabitants of the astral world and decided their fate. There were other the name of "Yogiraj". Rajkumar successfully summoned offending mediums duties were more than serious. Over the next ten years, using introduced as a ghost-hunter, and everyone laughed willingly. But the ...European disciples of the master, Rajkumar Sharma, were often

incinerated the weak in spirit.

and turned them into erupting volcanoes of desires and temptations that first rule of survival. Phantoms snuffed out human weaknesses splendidly law and order had to be filled with humility and modesty; this was the spruce of authority and of the traps of the ego. Anyone dealing with astral photography during the "court sessions." He warned him of the dangers of bowing respectfully, the bhagat asked his permission to use his name and

say the medium went to Govardhan.

form of a yogi whom, as it turned out, they all knew as "Guraji." The next died down, the participants of the ritual said that they had seen the astral the book were being leafed through by impatient hands. When the wind Cita (which the bhagat always brought with him to the proceedings), as it courtyard where the dharbar was being held and threw open the Bhagavad one day, during a ritual, a most powerful gust of wind burst into the long wanted to meet the author, but had kept putting off the visit. Until had been given a book with yogic commentaries on the Cita, and he had holding small trials over spirits on his own for many years. Long ago he 5000 a new visitor appeared at the samashtan. This medium had been left town, and the dharbars stopped. Several years passed, and in March withdrew His grace. Let us say the medium was dismissed. He suddenly temptations, which in the end corrupted and devoured him. Balaji power, sex. And the astrologer's son had no immunity against often wait for an opportunity to break out, to shake the thirst for money. As for the medium, things did not work out for him. Suppressed desires contrast to philistine gossip and the condemnation of relatives.

with family life or brides unwilling to marry, while at other times varied. Sometimes they were the inventions of housewives disillusioned name of Yogi's and spirit or phantom could be summoned. The cases recognizing the benevolent power of the dweller of the smasman. In the having beheld the astral image of the yogi, submitted, instantly the Guru grew with it, since he repeatedly witnessed phantoms who. As Rajkumar's ability to control spirits grew, his awe before the power of for bodily experience.

deviations, "evil spirits" are for phantasms and humans real entities greedily existence of demons literally. Manifesting themselves as mental "demons": psychological traumas, painful memories. Exorcism takes the there. Modern psychotherapy is the secular treatment of metaphorical proper psychoanalysis and psychopharmacology are rarely available remote villages, doctors cannot diagnose the most seriously ill patients: people in need of healing, the precision of terminology does not matter. In cases are usually placed in the category of medical anthropology, but for "dissociative identity disorder" or "multiple personality disorder." Such rarely mentioned in medical literature. Western medicine calls possession possession is a well-known archetypal phenomenon. The term itself is society regards exorcism as an archaic form of psychotherapy, since "arrested" and punished until they agreed to abide by the rules.

the end incline most "criminal" phantoms to cooperation. Some were polite and calm discussion of the reasons for the "occupation" would in possession. Negotiations would begin with the inhabiting spirit, and a were not signs of schizophrenia or psychic deviation but a side effect of people shook, writhed, and uttered gibberish, but for Rajkumar these the possessed, were for him only familiar sounds of the lower worlds. bulging eyes and protruding tongues, the curses and threats grew by sense of humor even in the most difficult scenes. Screaming women with on his forehead matching hisenna-dyed hair, Rajkumar did not lose his Young-looking and trim, always dapperly dressed, with an orange tilak from the royal smasman.

Some foreign disciples simply ignored discussions of bhautams and Mehandiapur

or pandemic.]

"Mahamari." [Footnote: Mahamari — Sanskrit/Hindi for a great pestilence but once or twice the spirits whispered a long-forgotten name — expected. Some muttered something incoherent about a new world order, interrogated bhautams did not specify what kind of problems were to be astral world would worsen — and would affect the world of men. The was approaching, and many spirits reported that soon the problems of the new cases of possession. The twentieth year of the twenty-first century holidays, gossip about political and other scandals gave way to rumors of life went on as usual: seasonal harvest festivals alternated with religious private.

listened attentively to Rajkumar, sometimes instructing the phagat in of Yogiraj. He himself never commented on these stories; he simply attended the darbars before instantly recognized the familiar astral form someone's airy body that they had noticed near Balaji. Those who had people with sufficient sensitivity sometimes asked Rajkumar about near the altar of Balaji — neither in human nor in astral form — but ash from the never-ending fire rite cured possession. No one could remain whose source was unknown. It was believed that water mixed with the Hanuman had been installed, from whose chest sacred water flowed temple of Mehandiapur, where in one of the halls a stone image of Balaji. From time to time the darbar organizers sent "patients" to the famous after all, rather dangerous.

spirits. And this gave the ghost-hunter strength, since his occupation was, power was again and again confirmed by the testimony of the penitent current affairs in person, but the phagat wanted to see the man whose Govardhan regularly. There was no need to report to the Guru about Together with two other helpers and his wife, Rajkumar came to intervention required extreme caution.

persists." Beliefs in demons and evil spirits, who once populated the
The famous psychoanalyst Carl Jung once remarked: "What you resist
are just as real as illness, madness, and inexplicable life tragedies.

another reality in order to get an idea of the infinity of life. Astral forces
did not object. Every serious seeker needs to come into contact with
sadhuns and avatars; now they wanted to see the rites of exorcism, and he
rested on a thick mixture of logic texts and legends about mystical
famous "temple of phantoms" in Mehrangir. Their perception of India
In February 2008 two Russian disciples asked his permission to visit the
the process.

famous phantoms, although he was well acquainted with all the details of
discussed publicly. As a Guru of yoga, he did not officially specialize in
been able to provide. There were enough such cases, but they were never
of the long-departed grandmother nor the apartment's renovation had
liberation, comfort, and the necessary guidance, which neither the prayers
brought to India. After a particular ritual the boy's soul received
quietly roamed the apartment until he was "locked" into a coconut and
faraway country many years before, invisible but still suffering and lost.
The phantom of a seven-year-old child who had died in a car accident in a
spirits as well."

repeated: "If you walk the spiritual path, you need to know the world of
duties to direct students toward new discoveries; more than once he
other "agnostics" simply tried to ignore the topic. It was part of the Guru's
the paranormal did some accept the existence of a parallel reality. The
incontrovertible scientific facts, and only after a personal collision with
foreigners consisted of well-grounded logical conclusions and
powers they encountered had no analog. The mental database of the
experiences, skepticism gave way to bewilderment and confusion, for the
magic and the implantation of entities. Yet after several personal
was hard for them to digest snippets and fragments of stories about black
confirmed by Google and Wikipedia, or had no connection with yoga. If
spirits, the pragmatic mind pushed off everything that had not been

hello."

children who began busking at their sleeves: "Give ten rupees, sir, hello." They got out of the car and were immediately surrounded by ragged or to prevent them from getting out.

It was unclear whether this had been done to keep spirits from getting in, sprinkled with bird droppings. Some windows had been picked up, and smoke-blackened stone with streaks of rain damage and cobiously slowly approached the massive temple, set between two hills, built of main street draped the mishmash of people, cars, and mopeds. Their taxi with cars, rattling buses, and ox carts. A thick veil of dust on the narrow the Aravalli hills. The road into the outskirts of Mehrangarh was clogged scorched trees, whose thorny trunks darkened against the background of The bare and rather grim landscape was broken by occasional sun- by pusily.

marched independently along the dusty roadside desert; thin dogs trotted on their heads. Children in clean school uniforms or picturesque raggedly passed by in bright saris with bundles of brushwood and pitchers awakening. Heavily laden camel carts floated past; women defying ... Getting out at dawn, from the car window they watched the countryside

that guarded the world of the living from the invasion of spirits.

localized, tamed, and even "healed." And Mehrangarh was the fortress hemisphere. And in certain particular places these energies could be darkness manifested itself in ways long forgotten in the Western remained. Wild, indescribable in words. In India, the denial of inner linguistically. And yet the suppressed energies of the unconscious have Western inhabitants are populated by archetypes recognizable only in exchange for the loss of medicine men and sorcerers, the psyches of gladly use the world of people as their hunting grounds.

dwelling on the periphery of the human unconscious, some spirits still Modernity labels possession by spirits as mental deviation. And yet landscapes of human cultures, are written off as "primitive" traditions.

Darkar, Lord Hanuman's assistant, who punishes brantoms." They saw a
The driver who accompanied them pointed at another hall: "Pret Raj
unpredictable force.

was the shrine — here Hanuman-Bajaji appeared as an untamed, raw,
stone obelisk painted gold, with a monkey mouth beneath two black eyes,
trying to eat the sticky sweet smoke rising from the white-hot coals. A
offerings into the fire. People's mouths were half-open as if they were
stood before the altar of Bajaji, and inside the enclosure attendants threw
ceaselessly, bandits muttered mantras. In the dim, reddish light they
A bronze bell hanging from the low ceiling, blackened by ash, rang
endless cycle of movement.

me alone!"), unaware of anything around her, she was caught in a looped,
something dark and unknown. Whispering, "Mujhe chhor do!" ("Leave
hair pushed the shoulder of one of them, sending an impulse of
though catching the next wave. As she passed by, a stray strand of long
one tried to catch her. Standing up, the woman climbed the steps again, as
boneless, slipping between people like an eel, and no

the stone steps. Lightly and elastically gliding, she flowed downward as if
the top of a high staircase, she lay down on her stomach and slid down
did not matter; her movements were measured and precise. Climbing to
...The woman cleaved the crowd like a knife, as though her surroundings
cries echoed down the corridors.

was tied, his head rolling and bouncing on its surface, while deafening
several men were carrying a large plywood board to which a young man
themselves against the wall, giving way to an entering procession —
arm, her white teeth flashed. Stunned by what they saw, they pressed
was comforting her, smoothing the tangled hair; when she tried to bite his
slid along the stone floor like living serpents. A man kneeling beside her
eyes were bulging, her ribs moved in a furious rhythm, her loosened hair
in from all sides at once. In a passageway lay a woman on her side; her
distant voices bounced off the walls; a torn cacophony of sounds bounced
Entering the temple, they adjusted, adjusting to the dim light. The echo of

the edge of the opening again and again, and her cries of anguish carried quivering the woman's head into the abyss: she struck her forehead against the depths. The men began to pull and release the rope, as though loosened hair became a continuation of the darkness disappearing into was quickly suspended head down over the opening in the floor, and her. Meanwhile a group of men carried in a woman bound with chains, who Kotwal, the general of Hanuman's army.

could understand and surmise was that this aspect of Shiva is also the the origin of the deity's name, but he lacked the English words. All they Captain Kotwal. In a hissing whisper the driver tried to explain to them punishment," whose court was held here, had yet another strange title — unwaveringly at a round hole in the floor. Mahakal Bhairav, the "god of frightful of Shiva — had been set up beside it. The painted eyes stared were painted on it too. A small trident, smeared with sindur paste — the Another stone peeped out from a heap of flower garlands, and black eyes emaciated body of the man.

a pleading tone, negotiating with the phantom that had taken hold of the surrounding smoke. One of the companions stroked his arm and spoke in shuddered, as though he were trying to shake off the clouds of surrounded by a group of several people. His head and shoulders A thin man in a yellow-stained kurta squatted in a corner of the hall, this noble undertaking was at once dreadful and pitiful.

supernatural. Here the healing from madness and despair took place, and not a tourist spot. Rather, it was meant to awaken the sense of the visible agitation and obviously not themselves — the place was definitely on the men and women sitting on the floor. Some were in trances, others in heavy, oppressive energy, and they quickly left the hall, trying not to step king of phantoms, was not mentioned in Wikipedia. The stone radiated a but had been unable to find information about this deity. Pret Raj, the gold squares. Before the journey they had tried to read about the temple, covered with silver paint or foil and decorated with strange patterns of large, irregular stone with piercing black eyes, whose flat surface was

looking out for elusive prey.

above the dwellings of the spirits, like phantoms in dark cloaks still irritated. The hillside was studded with these slabs, and ravens perched people," replied the driver, who looked notably tired and seemed then the pretz must remain beneath it: it will no longer trouble these "No, those are markers for abandoned spirits. Some buy such a stone, and "Are those gravestones?"

terrace they could see vertical stone slabs on the hillside.

was full of shadows that shifted their outlines and meanings. From the were damped with sweat. Clouds floated by, covering the sun, and the noon They felt drained, exhausted, clothes clung to sweaty backs, their faces died down, her lips parted, her breathing grew hoarse but even.

stone on her buttocks, and began chanting softly. The woman's groans floor. Another carefully placed a stone slab on her lower back and another two bandits laid her face down, binding her ankles and shoulders to the middle-aged woman with a drawn-out howl collapsed to the ground, and and brown lumps of crushed sweets. The respite was short. Merely a from what they had seen. The floor was strewn with flower petals, dust, themselves on an open terrace, they tried to catch their breath and recover lattice fence on the other, and bore little difference from a prison. Finding wall. The space was enclosed by the rear facade on one side and an iron in the courtyard they came upon several people chained to the temple looked exhausted but peaceful.

her into his arms, carefully rocking her. Her eyes had rolled back, she At last, they lifted the woman high above the floor, and one of them took leave," said the driver. The men seemed to be gently exhorting the spirit, departed, and cruel creatures.] speaking, not her — and he refuses to phantom. It is believed that pretz in their past lives were greedily "That is her pretz[footnote: Pretz — a supernatural being, a pungrily through the hall.

before a mortal lord, recognizing the power that stood behind him. the laws of subsequent incarnations. Dangerous astral beings now bowed about the stages of the "otherworldly" journey of the soul and to grasp The smasman offered unlimited opportunities to observe spirits, to learn

Calya Kshetra

misty winter fields of Braj.

nested in his heart had flown back to Mehrangipur, gliding above the he felt better, as though the unexpected melancholy that had briefly in the end he fell into oblivion, but slept little and badly. In the morning disciple lay sleepless for a long time, filled with an inexplicable sadness. Unable to think of anything in particular, with a puzzling head, he to." He advised the disciple to return to the hotel and rest properly. Some spirits want to see me personally, and sometimes they are allowed reported the incident to the Guru, who said: "Yes, you brought a visitor. a child had been let onto the smasman. Returning to the darsan hall, he gate. The disciple was too exhausted to chase him or to ask the guard why emerged. The figure quickly scrambled up the steps and dashed for the small gusty whirlwind from which a half-transparent figure of a boy burst below his left shoulder blade. Fighting nausea, he turned and saw a he felt himself losing consciousness, and at that very moment he felt a and tired. Sitting on the stone steps by the pond, still warm from the sun, the pond, right now. Surprised, he got up and went out, feeling broken suddenly the Guru suggested that one of them check the water level in where arriving spirits waited for the next carrier...

that the temple of Mehrangipur resembled a huge transit point, a station place so characteristic of Indian places of worship, both disciples agreed atmosphere of the temple, the complete absence of any blessedness or Guru. He did not seem impressed by their accounts, recounting the eerie word. On returning, they went to the darsan hall to bow before the the car with a sense of relief; the whole long way back no one spoke a and not to look back, and they followed all instructions. They returned to ...They had been told to eat nothing and drink nothing in Mehrangipur,

to shake off the bonds of "obligations." The love and devotion of the person had done only good, and yet he suffered even after death, unable to get out of inertia, by inherited tradition. During his short life this faithful, the majority of whom believed in Him not out of purity of faith. Moreover, he was "immobilized" by the heavy karmas of millions of the remains were preserved, he was doomed to remain bound to the existence prevented the spirit from going on to higher spheres. As long as parts kept as relics. Though almost decayed, these tokens of his earthly The body of the former messiah was not cremated but buried, with certain souls.

his name was used for the consolidation of funds, property, power, and spirit was a trademark feeding a ramified network of organizations, and rotation was not supposed to stop. Liberation was out of the question, the continued to grease the wheels of various religious corporations, and that The blurred facts of this messiah's life and the legends of his death the lower worlds.

this spirit, burdened by old and new crimes of mankind, he was stuck in responsibility for their deeds. There was no end in sight to the suffering of were automatically purified, and now only the prophet himself bore the flock to the name of the messiah. It came to be believed that sinners then, with the help of a powerful ritual, bound all the sins committed by landscapes. His followers founded a whole institution of worship and carried out a colossal mission of rethinking religious and cultural person had been the messiah of one of the largest world religions and had nothing remarkable in itself, but the case proved unusual. Once, this liberation ritual. The phantom of a thirty-year-old beardless man was One day Hanuman appeared in the company of a silent spirit needing a human being could resolve certain problems.

connected with the affairs of the world of phantoms; in some cases only a gave were carried out successfully. For the most part these tasks were were on good terms. Contacts had become rather frequent, the tasks He Hanuman had shared a particle of his power with him, and by 1998 they

these Brahmins still live in southern Gaya, on the banks of the Ganges, specifically to carry out the rites, and about a hundred families of destruction of the demon Calasura. The Creator made fourteen clans, or supposedly created by Brahma to assist in the fire sacrifice after the Gaya there live hereditary Brahmins belonging to the Calawaj clan, the sins of the departed and grant their souls liberation and peace. In of shradddha was meant to dispel

here to perform rituals for the deceased, since the performance of the rite possess the power of purification. For millennia people had been coming into the rocky hills that formed the landscape, which was believed to most holy place on earth — here the body of the demon Calasura turned to numerous legends, the Pancha Koshi Gaya Kshetra is considered the Pret-shila, and Kam-shila, and some of them had to be visited. According ... The city of Gaya is surrounded by three well-known hills: Brahmagom, organized all the logistics, they set out for Bihar.

August 1999, together with the disciple and friend Mr. Javalakar, who lethal, and the observance of certain precautions was mandatory. In physical strength, lifting the spells laid upon him could turn out to be death, these rites required enormous concentration of attention and danger of such intervention. Akin to walking a tightrope between life and with the exact time and place for the rituals, and warnings about the inquired about the technical details and received instructions, together could one refuse such beings? Suppressing his astonishment, he merely there are no distinctions of rank or creed. He agreed to fulfill the request, spirits of other faiths? And then he understood — there, in the Light, Who would believe that Hanuman is engaged in "post-mortem affairs" of expressed mentally.

gods and spirits no conversation is required, since any thought is astonishment he could not speak for some time. But in the company of The pale spirit gazed at him impassively and yet expectantly, and out of cure-all. It is a heavy burden and an excruciating existence. masses can be wearing, especially if your name is constantly used as a

sunset.

evidence of the presence of spirits is best not sought at all, especially after whispering sounds. Shadows appear where they should not be, and moving from one world to another, and their movements create strange the hill Pret-shila. Many people believe that spirits pass through the rocks, of ancestors come to Gaya Drama to receive offerings from the clefts of only for rituals for the deceased. The "Garuda Purana" says that the souls The place turned out to be deserted, as the temple of Preta Raj is visited accompanying them, who had never been to the top of the hill, agreed. hundred steps lead up to it. He insisted on the ascent, and the bandit temple of the Lord of Spirits, Preta Raj, is on top of a steep hill, six place for the rite of repose of the souls of the departed, bind dana. The About 8 kilometers northwest of Gaya, on the hill of Pret-shila, lies the and allowed himself only occasional sips of water.

morning until late evening, performed the rituals. That day he had to fast They contacted one of the Dharmi bandits, and on 10 August, from early still responsible for the rituals performed in the five sacred sites of Gaya.

Vishnu temple. A branch of the Gayawal clan, known as the Dharmi, is size of a brook wandering across a wide sandy bed.] river and around the hiding in shame. To this day, for most of the year, the river shrinks to the them all, except the tree. Thus the river was doomed to run underground. All except the tree said that Gita was lying. The angered goddess cursed and questioned the witnesses, they all lied, hoping for repeated offerings. Brahmin, and a tree to be witnesses to the ritual. When Rama returned believe her, she asked the sacrificial fire, a cow, the river, a passing offerings, Gita offered him sand. Fearing that her husband would not ceremony be performed without delay. Instead of waiting for the wait. Suddenly the spirit of Rama's father appeared and asked that the of food to the ancestors, Rama went for provisions, and Gita remained to rest on the sandy banks of the river. When the time came for the offering other than Rama's wife, Gita. During her exile, Rama and Gita decided to Bhargu[footnote: Bhargu (Bargu), the river — the river that deceived none

were mighty and barbaric everywhere, but truly knew about them only a themselves to mortals. In places such as Gaya Kshetra, the ancient forces become truly free, astral beings had to come down to Earth and entrust mankind to the dry riverbed, contemplating the irony of the divine play. To herself. When it was all over, he stood on the steps leading from a small an offering, bringing to the Goddess the fruit of the ritual, named after Gita performed a memorial rite for her father-in-law. There they had to make bank of the river Brahma, at Gita Kund, where Gita Devi had once. By now they were all rather tired; the last stop awaited them on the other back, and the sound followed him for a long time.

Hurrying away, he struggled against the overwhelming desire to look by the walls of the well, pierced his ears with a dull, furious force. pushed the coconut through the slit — and a desperate weeping, reflected. The well had something like a lid, opening from one side, and he simply advance not to look back, since the ritual would have to be started again. spirit had to be thrown into the well, and the bandit had told him in strange process. At the end, the coconut used as a vessel for invoking the and fire while remaining in continuous concentration — a tiring and exhausting. At the well of the dead, Pret Bhut Baori, he had to use iron. One of the rituals turned out to be quite peaceful, another extremely they had to hurry down the slope, to be in time for several more rites.

Lord Brahma — but they only briefly glanced at the hollow in the stone. On a boulder nearby was another famous landmark — the footprint of until the rite was over.

some indistinct mantras. The air did not move, but the sound continued resembling distant singing, as though a chorus of spirits were reciting soon as the ritual began, a whistling sound of a strong wind rang out, squating against the wall stared at them intently and unwaveringly. As were only four people at the temple, a dark-skinned middle-aged man little flour made of various grains. The place was eerie. At noon there marked the place for the offerings. They walked around it, scattering a. A large boulder, named in honor of the daughter of the Lord of Death,

had stepped on the scales out of sheer curiosity. Before leaving, he ... At the beginning of the trip, on arrival at the railway station of Gaya, he

onslaught of the astral entities and forces that opposed him there.

the living into the abyss of nothingness, he could withstand the furious breath, heat, and impulses. Familiar with the transition from the world of who had passed through many death-samadhis, who possessed mind, precisely why spirits of all ranks kept coming to the samashan, to the yogi India, where the efficacy of the ancient rites was still effective. That is hemisphere rather rarely. They preferred to carry out what was needed in entered into contact with sorcerers or mediums of the Western Powerful phantoms could communicate their wishes directly, but they

famous than Hitler?

wild, but had they not just performed a rite for the spirit of one even more similar but for the former leader of the Third Reich. The story sounded sleeplessness, the businessman set off for Bihar, where he commissioned a demanded that a ritual of liberation be performed for him. Worn out by than Hitler had begun insistently appearing in his dreams. The Führer Germany had once come to Gaya to perform a similar ritual — none other shared with them an unusual story. One Indian businessman from the archives. Reading the name, the priest was visibly shaken, but then he the deceased had to be entered, as each puja of this kind was registered in After supper he had to fill out a special certificate in which the name of else were swallowing along with him... or through him.

could not stop. He finished every crump of forty chapatis, as if someone The bandit smiled: "If you can't, you'll leave it..." They began to eat and

"Who is going to eat all this?"

He stared in astonishment at the preparations for the feast.

mountains of rice, towers of flatbread, bowls of dal, curries, various sweets. In the bandit's house an abundant supper was laid out for them:

few.

Umashtankar remained inconspicuous and modest, and channeled investments or guarantees of victory in elections. Becoming famous sought by many businessmen and politicians who looked for luck in and had become his medium. From that time the favor of the teacher was somehow begun to commune with a particularly powerful astral being — Umashtankar Sharma, a reserved Brahmin from Kanpur, who had in 2000 the smashtan was visited by a modest schoolteacher named Brahmarakshtas

future survival.

people. This was by no means an idealistic utopia, but rather the law of responsibility was to grow in geometrical progression to the ambitions of compassion was to gain the upper hand over cruelty, and personal "Era of Earthlings." As the awakening of the human mind accelerated, changes "Judgment Day," but to view them as a gradual transition to the offroaded. Or they kept silent. He himself preferred not to call the coming were no longer prophets onto whom collective and personal sins could be the fermentation of collective and individual karmas accelerate, for there As the world beyond the gates of the smashtan continued to seethe, so did he had.

about the long-term consequences of the ritual, although certain guesses extraordinary case is in order, but he could not arrive at a conclusion results. He had simply solved the problem, that was all. To analyze this phenomenon logically, was impossible, and no one informed him of the To foresee the outcome of the ritual performed, or to explain its

Now this spirit was liberated from all obligations.

people's hearts and along the way had changed the history of mankind. had at least tried to help the soul of a person who had come to change though he did not regret what had been done. He was, rather, glad that he he felt that the sacraments performed still exerted a certain effect on him, to recover from the mental aftereffects of the intense rites. Even years later kilograms. It took quite a long time not only to regain the weight but also decided to do the same. It turned out that in a single day he had lost 2.2

before the Lord of Death, Yamaraj, every Brahmin becomes a The murdered priest became a powerful and vengeful spirit. Standing seized the temple land, but they did not enjoy the spoils for long.

employers for "services." After the death of Chote Maharaj the thakurs not take that money, since they had been generously rewarded by their him. The bandit had only twenty rupees in his pockets, but the killers did the village. Several bandits hired by the thakurs ambushed and killed Hanuman, he was returning alone from the temple home, to the edge of the land, but the bandit was unyielding. One day after the festival of times influential landowners — the thakurs — tried to take possession of that land that became the cause of the priest's premature death. Several The temple adjoined a vast tract of agricultural land, and it was precisely down by his gun. He was a very pious man.

unmarried brahmachari priest, following the strict discipline handed devout bandit, he did not take samnyasa but simply remained an devoted all his time to the upkeep of the temple. An educated and very Hanuman. Being devoted to the deity, he renounced family life and Maharaj lived in a remote village, looking after an ancient temple of The story of the phantom was extraordinary. A Brahmin priest, Chote demon.

after death, and there is nothing more dangerous than an educated initiated into powerful mantras during life retain subtle ties with deities and remember all the Vedic texts and the complex rituals. Some who were drive them out is hard, since they have knowledge of their previous lives phantoms of Brahmins are extraordinarily powerful, to fight them and to master). "Brahma" means a Brahmin, and Rakshasa is a demon. The a Brahmin who in his previous life had been called Chote Maharaj (young astral being turned out to be a Brahmaraakshasa, the powerful phantom of The spirit spoke up as soon as Umashankar entered the darsan hall. The himself.

came to the samashan at the bidding of his astral "friend," to introduce generous donations toward the construction of a temple of Hanuman. He

prahmaraksasas, like the other 10,000 spirits that had followed him all and the royal shaman were for sale, the place was waiting for them. The months' Devanuti brought news of an incredible discovery: the palace came from Vinodavan and had no plans to go back. However, after two you, and you must be in Braj." This stunned him. He had just moved to "You must return, we will follow you. Our liberation is there and with Pandey suddenly and categorically declared that he must return to Braj: In February 1993, in Ganesh, Bhola Shankar Tewari and Jata Shankar

times, to the horror of those who wronged her.

introduced them to Devanuti, and she availed herself of their help several unwise, but like obedient quills, they read mental signals. He even problems, one only had to ask. Commanding the ghosts directly was invisible, they helped resolve both astral troubles and quite earthly been delegated from above—to follow him, observe, and help. Silent... Six years passed. Gradually, he understood that both prahmaraksas had

him, they must have sufficiently serious reasons for doing so.

their own volition. But he did not object. If they wished to accompany category had no need for "carriers," and could move about on their own, of them to a place of liberation. This was rather strange, as spirits of this ghosts proved quite straightforward and declared that he would lead the power of intention and resolve. Although their forms were vague, the contact was mental, yet the visitors, woven from condensed air, radiated Tewari and Jata Shankar Pandey: both were devotees of Shiva. The The ancient prahmin ghosts introduced themselves as Bhola Shankar

As the Doms used to say: "One should fear the living, not the dead."

experienced during his investigations of the "other world" had worn off. particularly impress him—he was even and polite. The initial excitement He was able to make out figures on the embarkment. Ghosts did not of premeditated murder,

spiritual discipline (as Chote Maharaj had) dies a violent death, as a result "verdict." But if a Brahmin who had observed the strictest religious and prahmaraksas, a phantom: this is the usual result of the post-mortem

young, but no longer a man) told his story, and it was both depressing heartbreakingly sad and begged for help. The young man (now forever him in the ghost of a young man of about twenty. He looked recall the youth from his friend's photo studio, struggling to recognize posthumous ritual for his father was a complete surprise. He could barely suddenly saw a ghost. The appearance of another soul during the deceased according to Hindu tradition. During the tarpan, rite, he saw, and the Guru instructed him to perform the proper rituals for the ...Several years passed after he left Cwalior, in 1984, his father passed the numerous baths of fate.

gradually they became acquainted. It was a casual, fleeting crossing on learn photography. Occasionally, he would speak with the lad, and time. A teenager, a sad and withdrawn boy, came to the studio owner to The friend's business was not particularly thriving; there was plenty of couples whose faces showed no enthusiasm but were still full of dignity. studio cluttered with portraits of newlyweds, smiling babies, and elderly friend for tea, and they would have interesting conversations in the tiny became his disciple. Whenever he was nearby, he would drop in on his In Cwalior, he was friends with a photographer, even before the latter

The Saddest of Spirits

astral namesake objected.

by Devanahi was named Bhola Shankar Tewari. Neither the bull nor its any case, in memory of the "collaboration," the large brown bull rescued servants of Shiva, Shiva Ganas, having moved up the career ladder. In were released from the obligations placed upon them and became bulas became regular, the praharaskshasas disappeared. Possibly, they the shrine. Perhaps their duty was to ensure his safety... Soon after the destined to find the Shivalingam—and were present at the installation of their baths with his destiny. Somehow they had foreseen that he was ...These two ghosts clearly knew the future, for they had decided to link beginning.

these years, were happy. They were all returning home; a new stage was

despair of wounded female vanity is one of the most dangerous poisons, possible way. The human mind is incredibly complex, but the dark her, and poured all her rage onto him, tormenting her son in every deliberate became pregnant bore the child of the man who had rejected him to take revenge on her lover in a belated and disgusting way. She love with some rich man who refused to marry her, and she conceived a it. He learned that he was not his father's son: his mother had fallen in mother, and this secret was so shocking that the youth could not survive. One day, he accidentally uncovered the secret of the woman he called unclear to him, yet he suspected they grew in all mothers.

unfathomable side. The roots of the supposed invisible darkness were incomprehensible to him: it seemed to him they had another, dark and glowing with love and tenderly kissing their offspring, they were too youth tried not to photograph mothers. Smiling, dressed in bright garb, that only pretended to be simple. Enjoying photographing children, the textures, the hidden logic of intricate things, and the complexity of beings light and shadow, in the magic of colors and forms, in landscapes and must still be a place for him in the world. He believed in the harmony of world could reject its children. Yes, some mothers could do that, but there photographer. He refused to believe that such an amazingly beautiful tried to somehow endure all this, and at some point decided to become a rest of the world also considered him useless and unworthy. The youth never good enough for her, and she managed to convince him that the temporarily quench the flame of his mother's endless reproaches. He was displeasure. A couple of times, he had to sell his blood for money to When the boy grew up, money became the subject of her attacks and she tormented him with the inventiveness of a professional torturer. a battle-axe, a stinging wasp, a biting dog, pursuing him day after day, him, he constantly and unsuccessfully tried to please her. The mother was hated. From early childhood, his mother mercilessly found fault with not loved. Moreover, for his mother, he became an object of smoldering Despite being a desired son in an Indian family with four sisters, he was and frightening.

Mohan Babu casually mentioned that he knew the village of Mitani, but this story surfaced again. In 1994, a disciple from Bengal, Madan, with no intention of going in search of the woman from the dream, but at some point, these words—Nirmala Devi and Mitani—stuck in his memory. He had walked through a tunnel, he saw the street and a very old house where she lived. He wanted to tell you something important. Please visit me in Mitani." As if the ground, deftly catching her balance. "My name is Nirmala Devi, and I am standing on the low canopy over the entrance to a cottage, she jumped to get up with a red border and reading glasses was flying towards him. One night, he had a strange dream—an elderly woman in a white Bengali

Nirmala Devi

the spirit of the young man finally found peace.

his own soul to break free from the nightmare of the past. He ensured that he never known a mother's love, who had been unable to trust the light of day. Having heard the story, he did everything possible for the ghost who had

pain and could not move on towards the light.

consciousness. Stuck between worlds, the sad ghost could not forget the past. Existence, or mental impressions, continue to live in any man's heart. Only if it did not disappear even after the physical body ceased to exist. Learning the truth, the young man committed suicide to silence the pain in his heart for the neglect of a father who did not even know he had a son. Upon his death, "Hell has no fury like a woman scorned." This mother made her son a whisper of the heart reminding her: "He is also your flesh and blood." offender, in her bitterness and hatred, the mother refused to listen to the voice of this cruel and senseless revenge was a small, helpless copy of the victim. This sounded wild, yet no one was supposed to know about it. The victim's long vendetta against the lineage, soul, and well-being of his father. All as a result of violence, but the birth of this boy was planned. It initiated a chain of victims of rape sometimes direct their hatred towards children born from this "child of hate," requires a special, almost demonic resolve. It is known that to deliberately bear a child from a man you hate and then torment whose strength only intensifies while remaining in the vessel of a broken

the dead. They were once high-caste Brahmins but lost the favor of the
1 Doms – a low-caste community exclusively engaged in the cremation of
entire life in isolation, reciting the mantras of Chinnamasat.

sophisticated mockery of purity and innocence. Nirmala Devi spent her
mere justification for cruelty, and wounded bride can degenerate into
months and years... Cruelty can be long and elaborate; some customs are
from the world, to continue reciting the mantras and watch days turn into
Was this a curse or a blessing? To remain alone, childless, and isolated
will continue to perform the sadhana given to you."

live together as husband and wife. I will marry another woman, and you
provide you with a house and everything necessary, but we will never
"Very well. Continue practicing what your Guru taught you. I will
"My Guru."

innocent and pure-hearted as a child, and therefore answered sincerely:
asked: "Whom do you love and respect more than me?" She was still
her age. When they first found themselves in the bedroom, the husband
...At the age of fourteen, Nirmala Devi was married off to a man twice
curious.

situation became less tense. Then these people told him something
managed to explain that his guru had asked him to find Nirmala, and he
sent a couple of tough guys after the stranger. Fortunately, the disciple
learning that someone was asking about his wife, the wealthy landowner
woman. It turned out she was the wife of a local mafia boss. Upon
him that by order of her husband, no one was allowed to speak with this
country. Then two extremely unfriendly men approached him, warning
from a distance, he saw a woman in a white sari with a red border in the
obtain Nirmala's address and went to her. The house was guarded, but
expressions and quickly fall silent. Still, Madan Mohan Babu managed to
However, upon hearing her name, the locals would change their

Devi. He carried out the errand.
located near Asansol, and he asked him to inquire there about Nirmala

years, this woman lived in total isolation, obeying the will of her husband, house, and no one could visit her. She remained a virgin. For nearly sixty Her husband appointed guards over her; she was forbidden to leave the austerity.

symbolism and metaphor of the image of her Deity—through her own Ahead of Nirmala Devi lay years for comprehending the deepest This paradox symbolizes the cycle of creation, destruction, and recreation. one who receives the sacrifice. Her severed head is an offering to Herself. rare. Chinnamasta herself is both the sacrificer and the sacrifice, and the worshipped in the Kali Kula, but temples and public worship of Her are family kuladevata, the deity of their clan. In Shakthism, the Goddess is the mantra of a wrathful Goddess; Perhaps Chinnamasta was Nirmala's learned; it is only known that he was a samnyasi. Why did he give the girl which her Guru had given her. Who this teacher was, no one ever divine couple.

beheaded herself, the Mother Goddess usually stands or sits upon a
‡ Chinnamasta – one of the ten Tantric goddesses, or Mahavidyas, having

Congreve. The play is written in the grammar of early modern English.

woman scorned," in the 1607 play The Mourning Bride by William
"Heaven has no rage like love to hatred turned, Nor hell a fury like a
3 "Hell has no fury like a woman scorned" – the phrase first appeared as

5 Tarpan – a ritual performed for ancestors.

alternative means of livelihood.

fairly well-off, but being untouchables, they can very rarely find touch corpses, or adjust them during cremation. Members of this caste are Doms are the only ones who have the right to watch over the eternal fire, Shiva assigned them to watch over the eternal fire used for cremation. The the Doms the lowest of the untouchables. They begged for mercy, and keep it for himself. An enraged Shiva cursed his entire lineage, making earning fell to the ground, and one of the Brahmins picked up the jewel to gods. As legend has it, while Sati's body was engulfed in flames, her

return to this world and live a new life, full of warmth, love, and these very specific details—apparently, it was time for Nirmala Devi to hands will become your daughter.” He could not say why he gave them visit the orphanage, the first girl who smiles at you and tries to catch your visiting him, and he suddenly said: “You must adopt a child. When you several years passed. One day, a childless couple from Bengal was her and took care of her.

the masters of the parampara in her meditations. In any case, he found it is quite possible that she learned of the lineage of Lahiri Mahasaya and asked him to take care of her soul. And also for initiation into Kriya Yoga. request was described: knowing that the end was near, Nirmala Devi himself did not reach Mitani, his student found the ascetic, and her still alive was the blessing of the goddess Chinnamasta. Although he next Guru. Perhaps the fact that Nirmala was able to contact him while plane. And she was able to find him, because she recognized in him her develop supernatural abilities—and she sensed his presence on the astral tabas, amplified by the harsh circumstances of her destiny, helped her soon became ordered and regular. It seems that the power of Nirmala’s the astral body, he began to experience repeated series of samadhi, which in the autumn of 1991, around the same time that Nirmala visited him in devouter, considered cruel, she can be merciful to the devotee.

symbolizes the entire world through this act of devouring and the and recreation. The Goddess, herself both the eater and the food, transient essence of all things, and destruction, as well as life, immortality, Chinnamasta grants life and takes it away. She embodies death, the her own severed head, drink it. A Goddess of contradictions, streams of blood flow from her neck, and her two attendants, as well as holding her severed head in one hand and a sword in the other. Three Nirmala Devi died.

that fateful wedding night. A year after the student’s visit to Mitani, for her freedom back and never regretted the words she had spoken on who, even as he aged and grew frail, remained relentless. She never asked

and by the end of the journey, more than 500 ceremonial scarves weighed people continued to place white shawls on the pier as a mark of respect for Gauri Ji Manasi Ganga," in honor of the Guru's mother.

praised Shiva and the Lord of Govardhan Hill: "Har Har, Mahadev, Shambho Gwalior's history, instead of the traditional Ram Navmi Satya Har, people pier, an urn, and carried to the smasana. Perhaps for the first time in Mother's body, wrapped in white cloth, was placed on bamboo funeral hundreds of students, relatives, and friends gathered for the cremation. shocked him. When he reached Gwalior the next day, January 3, and entreaties. Her time had simply run out; nevertheless, the new mother simply left her body, thereby precluding all possible objections. Devi passed away suddenly, but peacefully. She had no known illnesses. On January 5, 1999, at around 4:30 PM, at the age of 85, Shrimati Gyan

Mother

Guide.

Chinnamashta abides with her, and for her new journey, she has a reliable the girl must surely possess special abilities. The grace of the goddess keeps the details to herself. The influence of past karmas is unknown, yet observes the girl's progress. Even if she does remember her past life, she soul. Once or twice a year, the family visits Govardhan, and the Guru life and are glad that their daughter was and remains a highly developed sincerely and regularly. Her adoptive parents know the story of her past past incarnation. Having received initiation into Krishna Yoga, she practices work is supported by the spiritual strength so painstakingly earned in her adoration of her parents, she is extraordinarily talented, and her creative studied cinematography and photography. Basking in the love and girl grew up and graduated from the Calcutta Academy, where she ...The beginning was excellent, and to this day everything goes well: the immediately understood—this was their daughter.

grasped their fingers with such determination that the couple month-old baby girl. Bestowing upon them a toothless smile, the girl opportunities. At the orphanage, the future parents were shown a seven-

in the ancestral village of Shivram-ki-Carhi on the banks of the Yamuna. Married at the age of 16, she lived for some time with her young husband and the women he knew.

respect for herself: respect came naturally, for she was one of the strongest Jodhpuri army, and the wife of a respectable judge, she never demanded colonel in the Cwalior army, the daughter-in-law of a colonel in the of the clan remained cordial and warm for many years. The daughter of a Pradesh. They were all good people, and relations with the maternal side an official in the archaeological department of the state of Madhya became a renowned Ayurvedic doctor; there was also an uncle who was another an IES officer, a third was a railway station master. Another adults. All her maternal uncles were successful: one became a colonel, confidence. As a mother, she knew how to manage both children and brothers, and she commanded her small troop with unyielding ...Gyani Devi Sharma was the eldest child, followed by five younger

thing, regardless of the thickness of our skin.

alive. This primal, ancient possessiveness makes the loss as sharp as a we belong to them just as they belong to us, as long as we or they are preferences reflect tiny bits and pieces of mothers. We are ourselves, but memories. First reactions and impressions, body language, and even food mother into her child's bloodstream flows forever, sealed by the earliest could not be broken even by death, for the elixir of love poured by a with the woman who had brought him into this world. This connection the initial numbness. His mother's death meant the end of the connection Deep sorrow slowly settled within him, seeping through the thickness of of attention.

with the attention shown. She was accustomed to always being the center would have been irritated by all this fuss and yet simultaneously satisfied organized beautifully. And yet he could not shake the feeling that she closing of the life cycle, and the "last sacrifice" or funeral rite was departure was impressive. The cremation was the final samskara, the more than his mother's body. Without a doubt, Gyani Devi's final

Bonaparte, the mother of Napoleon. At his coronation, Madame told him, "Well-read, she reminded him of the story of Maria Letizia students into Krishna, Cyami Devi insisted: "You must teach me too, for I am When her sixth and youngest son became a Guru and initiated his first

entertain; excellent mimic, capable of imitating anyone. Oh, now she could addition to all this, she possessed a refined sense of humor and was an above would have been enough to call her an extraordinary woman. In Devi entered college and earned a degree in Arts— and all of the the wheel was exotic, a rarity. Already the mother of four children, Cyami A skilled horsewoman, she also drove a car; in those days, a lady behind wisdom of the heart.

unpredictable. But these were not mood swings, but a deeply intuitive generous flow of her sympathy; these processes were always her style. No one could ever predict the onset of a storm or a sudden and clear. No one contradicted her; she led, allowing others to follow. That was the chief authority among the cousins, aunts, and sisters-in-law of their everyone and everything, invariably victorious in her rightness, she was triumph of truth, leaving it no choice but to prevail. Protective of someone complained of injustice, she could do everything possible for the she feared nothing and no one and possessed a keen sense of justice. If Cyami Devi was impossible, and no one ever tried. Always self-confident and decisions. The red planet was so strong in her chart that dominating house, which influenced her character, driving her towards bold actions Cyami Devi's horoscope showed an exalted ascendant Mars in the first and all that which outraged the patriarchy of the time.

was open rebellion, symbolizing the impending changes, emancipation, followed her example. Even today, this sounds like a feat, but back then it the veil and never covered her face, and the other young wives of the clan Brahmin households, even in the absence of strangers. But she cast aside face with a veil for married women was a mandatory tradition, even in until her spouse obtained work in Calicut. In those days, covering the

smashan, where his mother's spirit might finally manifest. Perhaps now to him again began to flow. He longed for the solitude and silence of the another house, where an endless stream of people wishing to pay homage ...The rite was over. After several long hours, the students led him to for everything.

upon his own, in anything but a softened version. He was grateful to her also an iron will. The inflexibility of his mother's character was imprinted respect. He inherited from her not only remarkable physical strength but even when their opinions diverged, he treated his mother's position with Mats and forged by generations of ancestors, warriors and Brahmins. But and conflicts. Yes, they argued a lot. Such was her character, fueled by used her authority in many matters, which often caused contradictions In India, it is believed that the mother is the first guru, and Gyan Devi a decisive, supportive role in many of his endeavors.

either would have cared to admit. Strong feminine energy always played different branches of the clan, these women had more in common than possessing the same ardent and loving heart. Although they belonged to trouble them. In many ways, his cousin Devaputi resembled her, relationship, valuing confidentiality, and the opinions of others did not and she never came to the smashan: they preferred not to discuss their and it was a comfortable and dignified life. She never visited Govardhan. By tradition, she spent her last years living in the family of her eldest son, shlokas, counting them on the folds of her finger segments...

during siesta, he would watch as for several hours his mother recited having learned all the chapters, she could quote any shloka. After lunch, others. Her remarkable memory allowed her to recite the Gita flawlessly: perfected her explosive character, sharpening some traits and softening regular: she was the mistress of her given word and kept her vows. Krishna ...He was always proud of her. His mother's practice was exceptionally

"I am still your mother!"

Napoleon said to her: "I am the Emperor, Madame!" Letizia replied: "And Bonaparte arrived at court but did not curtsy to the entering emperor.

unwilling to wake up, and no one disturbed them. Enlightenment was a lives; such souls would live out their new birth in a state of hibernation, everyone had a mission. Some took incarnation to rest from previous its unique nature and, at times, its mission in this life. Although not Meeting someone for the first time, he would see the essence of the soul.

Love for everything that had a chance and a right to life.

Learning, evolving, achieving its goal in this particular life, in this body. unconditional love. Love for the spirit that had a chance to continue in personal resolve, in the Guru's duty. But most of all, this force was in need. It was impossible to classify this force, but its nature was rooted unyielding will, generated a certain ray of force, directed towards the one him. And then it would happen – a mental concentration, created by an what was happening, the situation itself, and the person calling out to suddenly shift, and as if in a trance, he would see fragmented frames of As a rule, he knew when he was being asked for help: the mind would

push with death.

marveling at the second chance given to them, feeling purified by their medical facts, or general logic. The survivors would tell their stories, the positive outcome a miracle, often contradicting the laws of physics, would begin; in short, help arrived in a timely manner. Many considered individuals would develop positive tendencies, a turn towards recovery showing him back into his body. After such an event, the rescued Guru scolded him with the choicest of words, literally kicking and be in a humorous mood. One person recounted that during clinical death, was often clad in red robes, silent and serious, but at times he could also state of extreme stress, or in the face of grave danger. In these visions, he seen the Guru or communicated with him while in a coma, in visions, in a incredible, almost supernatural, would occur. Some claimed they had Every time disciples found themselves in dangerous situations, something

The Guru's Power and a Curious Case of Sex Change

she would not mind paying him a visit.

sacred texts, including the Kama Sutra, but this fact did not ease their ancient times, the history of the Hijras has been described in various 'Kinnaras', magical, mythological beings skilled in song and dance. Since is a rather derogatory term): they themselves prefer to be called women. They are often called Aravan, Jogappa, or even Chhakkas (which Officially recognized as a third gender, Hijras are neither men nor family ties, and such a child has no hope of a normal life.

eventually gives in. Life in the closed community of the Hijras severs all persuasion or force, they persistently get their way, and the family eunuchs, learn of such a birth, they try to take the child. Through to the family. If the Hijras, the community of transgender individuals and The news was sad: in India, a third-gender child is considered a disgrace infant was a hermaphrodite, whose genitals were neither male nor female. Parents were happy. For only a few minutes, until the doctor said that the mechanic, his wife had just given birth to their first child, and the young In Cwalior, there lived a modest family: the husband was a refrigeration heard its echo.

winked at him playfully. Nature had whispered a mantra, and he had occurrence that seemed to stand out. He felt that Shakti herself had sight regained, miraculous escapes from fatal incidents. But there was one their abilities. The cases of help varied: lives saved, heartbeats restored, probability for changing destinies, and the successor was a transmitter of accumulated by previous Teachers created a powerful field, a sphere of seemed the parampara sustained this most potent energy. The merits external forces. The Maths called this ability the power of the Guru, and it his conviction grew that the mind seemed to receive signals sent by the efforts and pain of lives lived. With each story of miraculous rescue, of the difficult and long path the soul had already traversed, a reward for help it prosper and fulfill the tasks set before it, was an acknowledgment inhabiting temporary bodies. To support the existence of the spirit, to The Guru's help and blessing were a tribute to ancient beings – souls hard-won privilege, not a mandatory course.

people followed him, exclaiming "Jogiraj Maharaj!" Women held out
When he finally walked down the narrow lane to the car, hundreds of
his feet, but a garland of flowers around his neck, receive a blessing.

homeowners were pushed outside the gates. People kept arriving to touch
private house, but at one point the crowd became so dense that even the
there, having come to pray for a cure. The Darbar was held in a large
pleasant, yet he could not avoid this duty. The child's parents were also
spiritual courts, held in his name. These events were never particularly
almost by force, he was led to a Darbar, one of the many so-called
him to their homes, and huge crowds gathered at every place. Finally,
was performing the final cremation rites for his mother; disciples invited
for a miracle. And it happened. That day he was in Cwalior, where he
...The baby was given a female name, and the parents continued to hope

conceal the child's indeterminate gender for as long as possible.

socio-cultural circumstances, parents of such children usually try to
Hijas. Being completely ordinary is the greatest blessing, and given the
have little to do with the reality of life in the closed communities of the
symbolizes the awakening of kundalini. But all these semi-folkloric stories
arising from mixed, inert sexuality, or rather, inert energy. Bahuchara
head of the snake rises to Zambastara²¹⁸. Being a goddess of innocence,
goddess sits on one end of the snake (or in Muladhara), and the other
the Shri Chakra, and her true vahana is a snake with two mouths. The
There is a version of the goddess's origin that she is one of the Shaktis in
herself...

swapped with Vashoda's daughter, that daughter was Bahuchara
symbolizes innocence. When Devaki gave birth to Krishna, and he was
Bahuchara, or Bala Tribhuta, usually depicted sitting on a rooster, which
their own Gurus and perform special rituals, worshipping the goddess
language, Hija-Farsi, derived from Persian and Hindustani, they follow
perform at weddings and work in the sex industry. Speaking a secret
recognition, their communities still face severe stigmatization. Most Hijras
daily life in any way. Despite the slow conquest of some freedoms and

percentage of male and female within them. Ardhanarishwara, the one hundred percent men or women. Every person has a certain There existed a secret, well known to yogis: in this creation, there were no an easy fate, and he was glad the child had managed to avoid this destiny. menstruating. Some time after that, she got married. Being a Hindu is not The family visited him periodically, and a few years later, the girl began herself had decided to manifest in this child.

uncontrollable compassion had passed through him then, as if sharp pain in his heart, unconnected to anything else. A wave of involuntarily with their daughter to tell this story. He could only recall the stabbing of all that was happening until the happy parents visited him together organs appeared fully formed and indisputably female. He knew nothing the past five years was astonished to see that all external and internal female characteristics. The doctor who had been observing the child for A week after this, the hermaphrodite child began to manifest undeniable and he sighed with relief.

reach the car. The old 'Ambassador' started moving, the pain vanished, that he took it for a heart attack: holding his breath, he still managed to sharp pain in his heart, as if he had been stabbed with a knife. So intense mothers. Some little one was brought to his feet, and suddenly he felt a avoid the outstretched hands and the expectant, pleading eyes of the ...The street he was walking on was so narrow that it was impossible to dense, grey sadness would envelop his heart.

serene. At times, a glimpse of a child's future could be so bleak that a karmas would be revealed to him, and they were not always happy and sadhana. As a rule, he avoided touching children: sometimes their past rather toxic than intoxicating effect, and all this influenced his nightly cocktail of suffering, desperate desires, and unfulfilled hopes produced a overwhelming emotions affected his own consciousness and mood. The usually tried to stay away from large gatherings, as the depressive, India is considered a blessing, a divine blessing. Intolerant of crowds, he their children so they could touch his feet – the dust on the feet of saints in

Yogi's soul requires a place where sadhana can be continued in a withstanding any weather and needs neither clothing nor food, but the in a quiet refuge. The air body, ideally suited for Yogi, is capable of only him, but also the ghostly return. Both he and the spirits needed a of city vibrations and the exhausting chaos of human energies drained not places and the frequent moves clearly made them nervous. The intensity and even sometimes offered help. But the temporariness of all these moved with him to Vrindavan and Sarathi. They caused no disturbance years they nested around a cottage on a farm, and just as imperceptibly from Benares, the spirits followed him to Cwalior, where for a couple of obligations, he was in no hurry to initiate new disciples.

of his duties. Subsequently, weighing the responsibility of such threshold of death, but no one had warned him about this peculiar aspect well-being of his disciples continues even after they have crossed the successor. He keenly felt their presence. The Guru's responsibility for the births, and with the passing of Satyacharan Lahiri, they followed the and a center of attraction for all these spirits who had not taken new suitable place to live. The home of the late Guru in Benares was a refuge entourage of these souls was one of the factors spurring his search for a for over 10,000 souls of discarnate disciples. In fact, the invisible devoted disciples, but also passed on to his successor the responsibility Upon departing, the Teacher left behind not only grieving relatives and

Additional Responsibilities

Her will.

transformation was a smile of Shakti, and he was merely an expression of had not even known of the child's problem. One thing was certain – this It was difficult to say what exactly had caused the changes that day, for he accepted norms.

shaped by society, and social stigmas are cruel to those who differ from energies of the universe; however, human sexual identity is largely famous form of Shiva, represents the synthesis of the male and female

The human body is both a gift and an obstacle. For the soul, bodily fullness.

arising in Vayu Shakti, they could know the essence of Prana in its defined and complete, and their mental faculties were preserved. Now, energy channels—nadis—were purified. Their air bodies were clearly were far better prepared for the journey than non-logis, because their Nevertheless, logis who had honed their pranayama skills during life devices were not intended for the proper distribution of Prana. doing "pranayama" with the help of a pair of lungs, and these clumsy perform the pranayamas. In a human body, they were only capable of entirely of the element of air, animated by consciousness, they could spirits continued their sadhana. Now that their new bodies consisted Once a disciple—always a disciple, there are no former logis. And the

come closer. Those who saw them kept their observations to themselves. congregants. The younger one cowered timidly near a tree, not daring to enormous torso and bald head towered above the heads of the one always tried to get close to the people beating the drums; his ghosts, phantas, and even two giant jinn thickly covered in ash. The elder left their bodies, other astral visitors were present at the puja—ancient Not every spirit could enter the samashan; besides the disciples who had rhythms of the drums.

the living congregants, and their outlines trembled, responding to the the edges put with visible complex patterns—hovered over the heads of luminous, translucent spheres—sharply defined or amorphous, joined at puja together with other astral entities. Hundreds of large and small After the installation of the Shivalingam, the spirits began to attend the stage of the journey.

bodyless spirits needed a secluded environment to prepare for the next Moksha Bhumi. The process of the soul's liberation was long, and even disciples, this place was excellent, and 10,000 spirits followed him to the samashan, he rejoiced. For himself, and for the souls of his Guru's measured way. When the coveted palaces turned out to be memorials of

with a certain degree of confidence, surmise what lay ahead. In the future, people thought they understood the present, and the wise could foresee, and they continued to watch him closely. The gods knew the attention of the forces inhabiting the smashtan. He observed these dead and living members of the barampara did not escape either him or supported his sadhana. The complex symbiosis of the existence of the duiet, and their wish was granted. The Guru cared for them, and they also those who refused a new birth: such souls simply wanted peace and Among the spirits—the "long-term residents" of the astral worlds—were prey.

world is cruel, and newly arrived, defenseless souls could become easy prey, his help was even more important than for the living. The astral provided invaluable support in the post-mortem journey, and for the inexorable for all, certain exceptions and special cases existed. The Guru the air body. For a time. While the process of transformation was imprint on the psyche of the departed, the soul might choose to remain in it a prolonged illness or a sudden, agonizing death left an indelible the Guru could facilitate it.

freshly disembodied soul whether it wishes to accept a new birth. It so, kleshas, and unresolved samskaras. And on the Guru, who might ask a incarnation always depends on a combination of karmas, disentangled preparing it for the next round of learning. The chance for another passed through their air bodies, nurturing concentrated consciousness, could continue their tapas. Prana, no longer limited by Matter, easily Nevertheless, in the presence of the new Guru, the spirits of Krishna logic was unlikely.

but paradoxically, further spiritual development in a disembodied state ceased. In air bodies, acquired knowledge was polished and perfected, a Teacher. After death, any spiritual progress achieved in the past life exist for as long as possible, for within it dwelt a spirit that could become body must be turned through constant discipline. The logic body needs to incarnation is a chance for development and education, and therefore the

village, you will die right here on the spot." Did he have a choice; replied: "I will spare you and your family. But if you do not take me to the camp, become the instrument of such a terrible deed..." The woman "introduce" it to others... Overcome with terror, the bandit implored: "I invite me!" An epidemic always needs a first carrier, someone who will "I am Mahamari, the great epidemic. You must take me to the village.

I do for you, Mother?"

temple rites, and only then respectfully addressed the woman: "What can being a learned and quick-witted man, the priest first completed all the dangerous.

no ornaments or any other visible markings. She looked insane and matted hair covered the upper part of her naked, withered body; she wore dark-skinned woman squatting in a corner. Her eyes were red, and long. One early morning, upon opening the temple, the bandit saw a naked, temple in a remote village near Lalitpur.

priest, and Dwaraka Prasad's grandfather had once been a bandit in a Kali who was already over ninety. "Ghastri" is a title denoting the rank of a this incident, he recalled another story told by Dwaraka Prasad Ghastri, considered effective for getting rid of all epidemics. In connection with moved on. Superstition or not, in bygone times this method was effective; livestock mortality almost always began in the other village and between the peasants were inevitable. The procedure always proved run back. If the residents of the other village learned of the ritual, clashed the borders of another settlement, then all participants in the ritual would out the disease, turning the contagion out of the village and leading it to ritual, quite common in Braj. When livestock fell ill, farmers would drive shouting something. He explained to the guest that this was an exorcism road, and then a group of men carrying torches passed by; they were the way to Govardhan. First, he saw small bonfires burning right on the One day, a visitor mentioned a strange procession he had witnessed on

Mahamari

mesmerizing beauty. She bowed in prostration, and he asked: "Who are
were gathered into a tail. The woman was beautiful with a frightening
of her large eyes were reddish. Thick, black, matted strands of her hair
chocolate, large teeth protruded, baring her cracked lips, and the whites
white and without a plume. Her gleaming skin was the color of dark
A tall, big-boned but not stout woman was approaching him, dressed in a
judging by the position of the sun, it was about 9 o'clock in the morning.
saw himself standing in the corner of a Shiva temple, dressed in red robes.
returned to the house and began his morning routine when he suddenly
addition to the evening worship. That day, having finished the puja, he
...In the summer of 2015, he was still performing the morning rituals in

acted with the consent of the Dark Goddess.

grandfather's story, Mahamari was found in a Kali temple, meaning she
whom the order to begin the "clean-up" came. In Dwarka Prasad's
worship, in crowded temples, in close proximity to the deity through
of the cleansing. Most often, epidemics began in ancient places of
ruling goddess, the Earth. It was she who determined the time and place
were both local and global, but in all cases, they were directed by the
deity whose duty it was to cleanse the earth of human refuse. These tasks
epidemics continued to easily take lives, and each disease had a supreme
Middle East, North Africa, Eastern Europe, and Russia. In those times,
the lives of more than 800,000 people in India and went on to ravage the
All this happened around 1910, when the sixth cholera pandemic claimed
settle in a new place.

dead. The bandit's family, having survived the plague, left the village to
to die like flies. Within a day, more than half the village's inhabitants were
with cholera anyone who fell within her field of vision, and people began
frightening. Or perhaps she was invisible. Nevertheless, she "rewarded"
of the villagers to approach strangers, especially those who looked so
down, observing the passersby. No one reacted, as it was not the custom
there was a platform for sitting, there the dark, naked Mahamari sat
in the center of the village, at a crossroads, under a large banyan tree.
The priest said quietly: "Mother, come with me"—and she followed him.

listening to the news about political elections, military conflicts, and nature.

analyse, compare, create, improve, and sustain was also part of human domination was part of the human genetic code; however, the ability to with Nature or with each other. The drive for suppression and He had never been overly optimistic about the ways humanity interacted grossly component of intellect, and all this stimulated self-indulgence.

became popular. People's self-awareness grew, awakening intuition, the reality. For a short time, at least, the art of enjoying one's own company prolonged solitude mandatory for all gave people a chance to awaken to than the marketplace; silent contemplation replaced loud parties. The quickly. The traditional Indian greeting "Namaste" became more popular died. Illness and death became the best teachers, and people learned nobles' and passivity. The new virus was dangerous, but not everyone impending disconnection from the cable television of illusions, false In 2020, Mahatma presented the world with its bill, announcing to all the clearly in question.

and ecological disasters... The state of health of human civilization was diseases and psychological trauma to political and social crises in society world was shaken by various ailments—from the rise of oncological would be wrong to claim that the following eight years were calm. The for developments, yet there was no hint of a major epidemic. However, it obvious she knew the way well. After this vision, he waited for some time Turning around, Mahatma walked through the garden, and it was demanded nothing.

pointless; moreover, she did not need to be invited anywhere, and she What else could he say? Arguing with such a dangerous being is "Very well, go and do what you must..."

"I am the great disease. Allow me to begin my work."

you?"

prepare for departure, for death was near. But the bath of yoga was long, that the body had taken the state he had experienced as a signal to colors, tastes, and smells. Noticing gray hairs on his chest, he understood around with an equally even layer of invisible pigment, absorbing all indifference and inertia that overcame him seemed to cover everything anything, even to practice, was replaced by a steady abasity. The experience, he initially paid no attention to them. Then any desire to do inevitably, but, being in a state of excited semi-trance from the recent rapid aging and mental inertia began to manifest with relentless turned into the delight of achievement, but it was short-lived. Signs of Everything changed with the first experience of samadhi: astonishment understood that the bath ahead was truly infinite.

Yoga. Observing his own bodily and mental changes, he gradually marveling at the new perspectives, the depth, complexity, and diversity of was on his list of interests. The mind awakened gradually, evaluating and transformation of the mind or eternal life. At that time, nothing of the sort Upon entering the bath of yoga, he did not think about such things as the

The eggs of the golden bird

Shailendra Sharma, "The Upanishad of Immortality"

'Self', which shows us that the goal and the source are one and the same." subtle—into the indestructible. Both lead to the discovery of the inner been divided. This is the union of opposites—male and female, gross and "Both Yoga and Alchemy aim at overcoming duality, reuniting what has

*

Alchemy

Holi Festival, 2020

messengers of the coming changes.

about to touch the Earth, and Mahamari was merely one of the first survive and continue its creation. Changes in the world of spirits were predicted economic chaos, he knew: Nature will always find a way to

Upanishads, and even the Quran. The awakening of the spirit, the with the process of the Great Work: the Bhagavad Gita, the Vedas, the and New Testament. Other sacred books also had numerous analogies understood that alchemical truths and allusions were described in the Old Being an insatiable reader, he compared Eastern and Western texts and wide open to the curious and the brave.

presented itself as a giant and fascinating laboratory, and its doors were people, situations, logic techniques, and substances. The entire world same time, he learned to discern the seeds of truth in everything: in formulas from a sea of texts was a practically insurmountable task. At the The information was so vast that extracting the correct essence of awakened his interest in alchemy, and he began to study and experiment. inevitably surface. A series of seemingly random meetings and events the accumulated memories destined to lead them through life will pay attention to indirect, implicit, but recurring signals of fate. However, complex transformational processes. Of course, in your, people rarely new dualities of various ingredients that acquire healing properties after about medicines made from plasma, the ash of burned metals, about the surrounded by Ayurvedic doctors, it is impossible to miss conversations His indirect acquaintance with alchemy began early. When you grow up results were impressive.

alchemy, beginning to experiment. Mostly by trial and error, but some stopped, and he decided to support the body with Ayurveda and maintaining physical fitness. After a year and a half, the aging process antiquity did not visit sports clubs, but surely used some methods of there must have been other auxiliary means. After all, the ascetics of effective remedy against aging. At the same time, he began to wonder that a training regimen, he followed it zealously, as the exercises were an about three months to overcome mental sluggishness. Having established Vigorous strength training helped halt the rapid decline. It took him

Otherwise, there would be no one to practice yoga.

and it was necessary to keep the body and mind in a "working condition."

mature mind, driven by intense meditation. The consciousness-altering discern the play of the Creator. Such a unique desire could only visit a why? The answer was simple: for the attainment of self-realization, to The logic quest for eternal life raised an extremely important question: elixir granting immortality was of far greater interest.

labor-intensive. Nevertheless, for a select few, the idea of an alchemical attainable and practical goal, and the process itself less complex and alchemists and Ayurveda experts, preparing medicines was a more The ambitious goal of creating artificial gold required resources. For most protected, guarded by the earth itself.

of body and spirit and the transformation of matter remained well chicks from these eggs in other incubators, the secrets of the immortality nest of the subcontinent. No matter how many tried to hatch magical golden bird—Bharata—hatched the eggs of supreme knowledge in the art of alchemy and the concept of immortality were born in India: the into Ayurveda. This theory did not trouble him. Quite the opposite: the Greeks brought with them some alchemical ideas that were integrated that during the invasion of Alexander the Great into India in 325 BCE, the transmutation of base metals into gold. There were numerous hypotheses manuscripts from roughly the same period also reported the "Material Gain," spoke of a vital alchemical ingredient, mercury. Buddhist As early as the 4th–3rd centuries BCE, the Arthashastra, the "Science of Vague descriptions indicated a connection between gold and longevity. The Vedic texts were interpreted with references to alchemical secrets.

reworded looks.

with like-minded people, so as not to evoke incomprehending and almost meaningless. It continued to exist, but it could only be discussed changed greatly, making talk of "alchemy" as a timeless, coherent science practices, and participants, but over time, the cultural spaces it occupied eschatological contexts. Alchemy encompassed a vast diversity of ideas, incarnation—all of this found resonance in alchemical, zoetrological, or transformation of the body, redemption, death, resurrection, and

mercury, an element with 80 protons: a neutron struck the nucleus with high-energy neutrons. In one experiment, the target metal was Maryland studied the properties of various metals by bombarding them. In the late 1960s, physicist Judith Templey of the Edgewood Arsenal in besides the ingredients, the process required extreme patience.

mistaken, and that ordinary metal could be turned into gold. Simply reaction, the famous "cold fusion," proving that the alchemists were not contemporaries. The scientific explanation was a low-energy nuclear vast alchemical knowledge passed down from the ancient times to in May 1945. The memorial plaque on the temple wall reminded of the one tola) was conducted by Krishnabai Kasavaiya in New Delhi earlier, similar alchemical experiment with a smaller amount of mercury (only was documented, and the gold was tested and found to be the purest. A in the presence of Pratab Singh of the Benares Hindu University, and this fund 25,000 rupees in proceeds. Shri Kasavaiya repeated the experiment the Samadharan Dharma Pratini Sabha in Punjab, and it brought the said the presence of all the aforementioned people." The gold was donated to Birla. Mercury, presented by Desai, was transmuted into 18 kg of gold in Mahatma Gandhi, Mahadeva Desai, Goswami, Ganesh Datta, and C. K. Kasavaiya, conducted an experiment in Bishikesh in the presence of P.A. (according to the Indian calendar, 1943), a bandit from Punjab, Krishnabai plaque with the inscription: "In the month of Chaitra, Samvat 1999 On the walls of the old Birla Temple in Varanasi, there is a memorial Kasavaiya, or the Treatise on Metallic Preparations.

the principles of alchemical transmutation, such as the 15th-century 1300 CE, several significant works appeared indicating the influence of painstakingly woven into the fabric of Tantric philosophy. Around 1100– possibility of changing human destiny. Alchemical principles were alchemical transformation of mind and body and, most importantly, the Around the 11th century, Tantricism adopted the radical ideas of in an eternal body could lead to simple madness and decay. means, the elixir of yoga, must be taken constantly, for an immature mind

spoke of alchemy and even made him write down some formulas. In this seasoned with technical terms. Besides many interesting things, the sadhu trusts were unlikely to understand. This man's speech was correct, interlocutor looked like a vagabond, but spoke on topics that ordinarily away the words, as if trying to hide their meaning. The chance waves crashed against the shore, and the gusty wind caught and carried talk, and these conversations lasted for hours. Days merged into weeks, nearly, and probably studied him unnoticed. Eventually, they began to spot every day, as did he. For five or seven days, the sadhu sat motionless sadhu (in India, any homeless person can be a sadhu) came to the same overgrown man he encountered on the beach in Puri by that name. The occupation. Hardly anyone would have dared to call the ragged and The first true alchemist he met could not possibly be suspected of his

The Formula

contained all answers, and he learned to ask the right questions. database of Universal Knowledge. The dazzling darkness of the Void their goal. Whatever the inquiry, samadhi opened access to the vast were accessible to those who set the development of consciousness as processes, and goals, the layers of meaning and the essence of knowledge, the shell of secrecy. The metaphysics of alchemical and logic concepts, time, the knowledge was kept safe in the nest of the subconscious, within The precious eggs of the golden bird had no expiration date. Dormant in providence.

Plutonium-239. It is a matter of technological breakthrough. And of another, as is done in our time, in the conversion of uranium-238 into ancient, who asserted that one element could be transformed into legends and fairy tales. Modern science agrees with the correctness of the ago in India, they knew how to transform metals, and these were not just 1,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000,000 years. And yet many centuries obtain gold from mercury in this way would take about result was an atom with 29 protons, making it an atom of gold. Well, to causing the destruction of a proton in a process of "electron capture." The

alchemical mystery to a stranger was a blessing and an extraordinary
To meet a person who would willingly and voluntarily impart the secret

alchemical formula to him? One thing could be said

Who was this sadhu, and why did he decide to pass on a wisdom
for the first time in their lives.

had practiced Ayurveda for over 30 years, they had seen solid mercury
presentation ended in complete silence. Although the respected doctors
solidified. The next day, he presented the sample to his relatives; the short
market, he treated the mercury, without even bothering to bury it, and it
worth testing. Having purchased the necessary ingredients at the local
sarcastically, and he took it as a challenge. The sadhu's formula was
volunteered to make solidified mercury. The relatives laughed
with the notes made on the beach in Puri was still with him—and he
He had no deep knowledge of the subject, although the small notebook
During a casual conversation, the topic of alchemical mercury came up.
several relatives, quite well-known Ayurvedic doctors, were present.
When one of his aunts died, he attended the family memorial rites, where
the surrounding world.

marveling at the daily (or rather, nightly) changes in consciousness and
several eventful years passed, during which he diligently practiced Krishna's
sullen, until the Guru forced him to abandon the dangerous knowledge.
he had mastered brought brief satisfaction but made him irritable and
ingredients or equipment was not entirely alchemical. The Matsya mantra
The only experiment he could perform at that time without any proper
spontaneously as they had begun.

the sadhu simply disappeared, and the daily conversations ended as
mercury. All this was interesting, but completely useless. And one day,
methods. One such formula was a step-by-step instruction for solidifying
beach anyway, and he obediently wrote down the components and
the slightest interest in alchemy. But there was nothing else to do on the
subject, the sadhu was clearly knowledgeable, unlike him, who had not

and seemingly minor technical specifications, it worked with astonishing accuracy. When the formula was applied in accordance with these nearly invisible details of a formula—the “insignificant” details that were not revealed to others. At times, while reading Alchemical texts, he could grasp the very essence of the process, but the methods always differed.

Each had their own approach to the process. The procedure itself was the same, processing mercury, sulfur, and rare aspects of the alchemical craft. Each Over many years, he encountered adepts who knew well the secrets of the craft but were preoccupied by more pressing concerns.

He patiently waited for alchemical gold, until their expectations were met. In the house was prepared with mercury, and for several years the family pieces of mercury he placed in the kettle in the kitchen. From then on, the rejuvenating properties of solid mercury, she even ordered that dull silver mother held a degree in Alchemy and was well acquainted with the process. His family regarded his experiments with considerable favor. Since his interest in alchemy.

A remarkably well-informed customer was writing a doctoral dissertation on alchemy. The bookstore owner in detail, and the owner would think that this was sometimes, in search of a rare copy, he would interrogate a bewildered clerk on Alchemy ever published, and he read them from cover to cover. The relatives gladly agreed. The unique collection contained nearly every book on alchemy as scrap paper. He offered to take everything at once, and the the pages marked by streaks of rain—his cousins were planning to sell all under a tin awning. The bindings of the folios were covered with mold, but he saw that his uncle's precious books were stored in the open air, what to do with the mountains of books. Several years later, during a specialized literature. After the doctor's death, no one in the family knew the renowned Alchemical physician had left behind a vast collection of everything he could find on the subject. One of his deceased relatives, a One way or another, after the experiment with mercury, he began to read stroke of luck...

fire burned away the slag of karmas and the sheaths of ignorance, the immortal spirit. The body must be processed by Prāṇāyāma, and its embodied the alchemical process of extracting the precious substance of The soul is the concentrated essence of the living body, and sādhanas boundless fields of process and method.

toward perfection. The bath of any essence to perfection lies through the rejuvenate the body also denotes the striving of the very essence of Matter. common Ayurvedic term for techniques to increase lifespan and The Sanskrit word "rasāyana" literally means "the bath of essence." This source of life, it ages.

without assimilating it. Burned by excess oxygen, oxidized by the very preciousness of the metal. Thus the human body greedily absorbs Prāṇa, devoured it greedily, in vast quantities, as if intoxicated by the silvery balls of processed mercury were fed with gold, and the mercury initially, he used mercury as a rasāyana, a rejuvenating agent. Small, and he meticulously followed them.

discoveries came as concrete instructions, not merely metaphysical hints, mercury. Mercury is like Prāṇa-Dīva, and sulfur acts as Āpāna-Sakti. The Yogis, uses Prāṇa and Āpāna just as Alchemy itself uses sulfur and might continue to hold the mind. The alchemy of the spirit, discovered by Both Yogis and alchemy sought to grant the body eternal life, so that it treasure obtained through the alchemy of sādhanas, to remain in the body. sole purpose: to persuade the developed consciousness, that magical body into an immortal one, strengthening the abode of the spirit with the many, but not to Yogis. They pursued the goal of transforming the mortal concept of transmuting base metals into gold seemed utopian to many. To increasingly evident. Like the idea of a perpetual motion machine, the the Great Work, as alchemists called their eternal quest, became The parallels and similarities between Yoga-sādhanas and the process of the transformation of substances: alchemy extracted the essence of Matter. Driven by simple curiosity, he began to uncover the profound meaning of precision.

one by one, the students awakened from the slumber of ordinariness to themselves from various limitations, confront their own samskaras, but He patiently observed their transformations. Seekers had to free inevitable.

acknowledging a new worldview was achieved with difficulty, but was for some, uneven and difficult for others, the progress of accepting and Maya, no longer distorting the true nature of things. Steady and gradual worldly illusions gradually faded from the stained amalgam mirror of continuously began to perceive reality in all its vastness, and the web of predisposition, and the Guru's blessing. Those who practiced by a combination of factors: ambition, motive, perseverance, karmic younger and more energetic. Their progress in sadhana was determined. Disciples who received small silver pills of mercury from him looked translated into scientific terms.

of the experimenter, but not all transformations could be described or process and its product change both the psychological and physical states experimented with it for over 37 years, he knew that the alchemical capable of being in a liquid state at room temperature. Having Considered the semen of Giva, mercury is practically the only metal about the specifics of this method.

to the cooks and the food they prepared, yet no one dared to ask him dough for flatbreads. The solidified mercury imparted certain properties kept mercury under their tongues, adding spices to the dal or kneading bottom of the pot. When preparing his food, the women in the kitchen addition of solidified mercury: several small lumps were always at the The thick Indian tea he had drunk for years was prepared with an needed support.

produced the nectar of the spirit, and during this process the organism led to tangible results. Slowly, drop by drop, the Matter of the body Closely intertwined, the physics and metaphysics of yoga and alchemy revealing purified consciousness.

temporary camp and arranged for the delivery of the necessary
...On the outskirts of the neighboring village, the sadhus quickly set up a
to alchemical work.

thought it was some kind of trick, he became, for the first time, a witness
—the sadhus planned to turn tin into silver and gold. Having first
village, he agreed. What they were about to do was too interesting to miss
when they invited him to walk with them for company to the neighboring
intrigued. These two radiated serenity and peace; their speech was gentle;
in India, but now were these sadhus going to accomplish all this? He was
village to build a temple and feed the needy. Such charity is widespread
character. It turned out they were planning to stop in a neighboring
about the locality. Then the conversation took on a more interesting
stopping and leaning on their staffs, the ascetics spoke with him, asking
confidence.

awkwardness, as if nakedness were a kind of uniform that gave them
nudity of the sadhus looked very natural; they showed not a trace of
proportionate, without any fatty deposits, yet they did not look thin. The
puns, the sadhus walked slowly. Their dark, sun-withered bodies were
their necks and wooden bracelets, with long, matted hairs gathered into
particularly old, completely naked except for garlands of rudrakas around
he thought it was a play of light and shade. Neither young nor
the road. The remnants of the shadows were indistinct and blurred, and
the area of their heads, which were clearly visible on the cracked clay of
some reason, sharply outlined only down to their chests, ending around
sadhus walked by; the shadows of their moving silhouettes were, for
softer, and the "hour of cow dust" was approaching. Two naked
in the afternoon; the sharpness of the daytime shadows was beginning to
courtyard of the house, enjoying the weather. It was around four o'clock
The winter of 1982 was unusually warm, and he was sitting in the

The Naked Alchemists

design and course of their own destinies, and to perfect them.
fulfill the most arduous task: to see their true nature, to understand the

understand the hints and grasp the essence. However, most of the time coded phrases, but he had already read enough about alchemy to discussed details of the alchemical process in his presence using short. Usually, at the sadhus' camp, he was offered tea; sometimes they mentioning relatives who supposedly wished to sell their savings.

elaborate on the origin of the precious metals, only occasionally let the local buyers thought he had found a treasure. He preferred not to gold was not so expensive; it seems it was about 800 rupees for 10 grams, was tested—and it turned out to be purest silver or gold. In those days, shops of his jeweler acquaintances. Each time, the substance he brought alchemical metal, and he faithfully carried the resulting product to the acquaintances. Someone was needed to help with the sale of the becoming a regular intermediary, he continued to visit his new

at least, it all looked as if they were simply smoking while the tin melted. liquid lava. The sadhus did nothing more; they added no ash to the pot—was half smoked, the melting metal had already turned into a golden adding something that looked like crushed dry herb. When the chillum (unleavened flatbreads) denoted silver. One of the sadhus lit a chillum, was called dal—a traditional Indian soup made from split beans—and roti soup or roti flatbreads? How about some hot dal? In their slang, gold addressed his companion: "Swami! what shall we make this time? Dal The sadhus communicated in some secret jargon, and one of them experiment.

he visited the sadhus' camp again, where he witnessed another bought as purest silver. All this was quite intriguing, and after some time would happen next. In the shop, the substance obtained was tested and jeweler acquaintances and set off for the city market, wondering what mightest purity, the sadhus asked him to arrange its sale. He had several could it become silver? Insisting that this was alchemical silver of the melted, turning into a silvery lava; undoubtedly, it was a metal, but how other lit a chillum and, after a while, shook the ash into the pot. The tin ingredients. One of them placed a pot of tin on an improvised stove; the

siddhis, they fed the poor and built temples. Devoid of all possessions
world, but cared only about serving the needy. Possessing incredible
the bare ground. They could have become the wealthiest people in the
domestic comforts, eating only chapati with rice and dal, and sleeping on
turning tin and copper into silver and gold, voluntarily renounced.
He also understood something important. These ascetics, capable of
mercury, especially since the sadhus had shared some formulas with him.
The encounter inspired him to continue his own experiments with
they were headed...

spiritual support, and were preparing to continue their mission wherever
the plains of Madhya Pradesh. They had given people food, robes, and
...simply vanished, dissolving into the veil of the eternal haze that covered

When the construction of the temple was finished, the sadhus left.

etiquette.

were older, and so such questions would have been a breach of unspoken
These naked alchemists were not inclined to idle chatter; moreover, they
asked them where they had come from or where they planned to go next.
the life of the body, in which the spirit could remain longer... He never
The practical magic of alchemy not only brought wealth, it could prolong

the alchemical process. Why did they trust him, a chance stranger?

construction with outsiders, but they deliberately allowed him to observe.
The sadhus, of course, did not discuss the sources of funding for the

batch of precious metal.

necessary sum to continue the work and set about preparing the next
construction. After brief reflection, the sadhus would usually calculate the
residents or contractors came to them to discuss the progress of the
villages, organizing free food distribution. From time to time, local
quickly. The sadhus also fed thousands of people from the surrounding
the construction of a temple to Hanuman, and the builders worked quite
stillness. With the proceeds from the "magical cooking," the sadhus began
the ascetics spent in silence, and he enjoyed this powerful and meaningful

some secret rejuvenation procedure, Kalya Karbaḥ,

youngly and why do you look so young? Perhaps you have undergone biologically brain to biogenesis in your sadhana. Tell me, how did you achieve practice of yoga at a very mature age, at ninety-six years, and you He studied the new discipline for some time: "You are beginning the express my appreciation,"

offer you money as a token of gratitude. Is there anything by which I can initiated yogi addressed him: "Curly, being a wandering sadhu, I cannot the initial techniques excellently. On the last day of the visit, the newly The "young man" received initiation without further delay and mastered old..."

is so. He is a friend of my elder brother, there is no mistake, he is 80 years It was impossible to believe, but Shivananda Saraswati confirmed: "Yes, if When the newcomer was asked his age, he replied: "I am 80 years old..." . dharma."

his companion be initiated into Kalya Yoga: "Curly, please give him also dressed in the ochre robes of a sadhu. Swami Shivananda asked that visited Swami again, this time in the company of a man of about thirty, sincere, and therefore received initiation into Kalya. Some time later, he introduce him to Yogiraj. Shivananda Saraswati was very intelligent and yogi with many black kundala earrings. Swami asked an acquaintance to was then that he first saw a photograph of a young, broad-shouldered In 1982, Swami Shivananda Saraswati of Jhansi was 88 years old – and if

The Ever-Young Sadhu

wealth was the freedom of choice.

new home for the soul. Or never to be born in a body again. The greatest known privilege was the ability to leave the body at will, or to choose a Yet the logic concept of freedom was even broader. The greatest of all to leave everything behind was their greatest luxury.

and attachments, they continued their mystical journey, and the freedom

would usually fall asleep; he saw no dreams and would wake up with a dark, thick, and bitter-sour to the taste. After each dose, the disciple resubstituted the substance on the disciple. The pleasantly scented liquid was the herbal oil took several months. Then the sadhu began testing the pot object – he had no other business anyway. Extracting and processing and filtered it. This painstaking work seemed endless, but the novice did the plants. The sadhu meticulously extracted oil from the collected herbs waiting for the correct alignment of the constellations to cut and process River and spent entire days searching for the necessary seeds and herbs. After many weeks, they finally reached the floodplain of the Yamuna needed an assistant.

reason why the sadhu had nursed him back to health became clear – he but he did not explain the specifics of the formulas to the novice. Soon the various Ayurvedic substances, trying to decipher the code of eternal life, disciple. It turned out that his benefactor was actively experimenting with back to health, and he joined his savior, becoming his self-proclaimed to give him warm milk to drink. This man nursed the marbleless pilgrim exhaustion. Upon waking, he saw an elderly sadhu bent over him, trying the jungles of Uttarakashi, he lost consciousness from hunger and gradually grew weaker. He was ashamed to beg for alms. Somewhere in one of those wanderers. Hungry and destitute, he kept walking and lack of choice, rather than because of a spiritual calling. And he became Himalayas: most often such people became wandering sadhus due to a village. In those days, everyone who left home and family headed for the One day, after another family quarrel, he was so offended that he left the idleness: "You are good for nothing, a useless bum..."

while his brother's wife constantly nagged her brother-in-law for his about nothing much. His elder brother was a farmer, working tirelessly, suited him well; for pleasure he practiced freestyle wrestling and worried Pradesh, and until he turned 30, he lived completely carefree. Village life speak. He was born in a village lost among the endless fields of Uttar The sadhu was silent for a long time, almost a minute, and then began to

After the swami had mastered Khechari Mudra, he came to the asram at the right moment to collect and process the herb...

have to live for months in the jungles by the Narmada River, waiting for the formula for the medicine, but to find the necessary plants, one would earlier. In farewell, the swami handed him a folded piece of paper with signs of aging, having taken the last dose of the elixir about 80 years... The story was incredible, but true: the 80-year-old swami showed no changing with the years.

form; moreover, no one could notice that the wandering ascetic was not wandering. In such a short time, attachment to people and places cannot stay in one place for longer than three or four days and must continue took a vow of non-attachment: those who have taken such a vow cannot the end, he had to leave the asram and go far away from Krishikesh. He for healing from illnesses and sufferings, but he could give none of this. In inevitable complications: people began asking him for blessings, begging spread rumors that he was a Siddha, a miracle worker, and this caused covered in wrinkles and stooping under the burden of time... Someone to notice that he was not aging, while they themselves were becoming ascetic, a simple and pure life. However, after a few years, people began of the Ganga. He was familiar with the lifestyle of a sadhu and lived as an eventually settled in one of the many ashrams of Krishikesh on the banks. What was the former disciple to do? Continuing the journey alone, he

The goal had been achieved, and the sadhu no longer needed an assistant. every last drop. The painstakingly collected ingredients were gone too. free, but his companion had disappeared. He had also taken the elixir, plate of rice awaited him by the makeshift hearth under a large banyan morning, he woke up with difficulty. As usual, a pitcher of milk and a any signs of aging. The day came when he took the last dose. The next prepared properly, with its help one could live up to 300 years without only unsalted rice and drink milk. The sadhu said that if the elixir were For forty days, the teacher kept him on a special diet, allowing him to eat heavily read.

and simple, clearly in a difficult situation. He intervened: "What some youth of about 18 or 19 years; he looked like a mere boy, unboiled walking, he heard a heated argument between the ticket collectors and station, they stepped onto the platform to stretch their legs. While and one fine evening they set off for Ujjain. During a stop at Jabalpur expedition, he immediately booked their tickets on the Malviya Express, escape. Enthusiastically volunteering to accompany the Guru on the Ghastri, was known for his love of adventure and readiness for any. Despite being in his seventies, one of his disciples, Dwaraka Prakash Swami," had spoken of:

India. Judging by the description, this area resembled the one the "ageless he found in a rather remote place, near the Narmada River in Central India, he became truly interested. The problem was that it could only experienced Ayurvedic physician, confirmed the plant's outstanding specialists, many of whom praised its properties. When his uncle, an plant became the subject of lively discussions among Ayurvedic stories, and signs spoke of it. One just had to be attentive. In 1989, a rare proportions... The formula for immortality existed – texts, legends, The right plant, the right time, the right constellation, and the right

The Search for a Rare Herb

butterfly's wings.

must have seemed to them like nothing more than the flutter of a that often accompanies physical decline. The lives of ordinary people could contemplate their life experience without falling into the depression possessed the priceless treasures of ageless bodies and longevity, and teacher continued to wander across India. These unknown people since then, there has been no news of him. Most likely, both he and his he turned one hundred years old, but he had not aged a single iota.

secret herbs had done him good. The Swami's last visit was in 1994, when looked young and fit: apparently, the combination of Krishna Yoga and the to receive the next level (it seems this was in November 1995). He still

providing the souls of the Kanjars with excellent edification and hand-rolled cigarettes usually complete the "posthumous kit," soap, and a few rubbers. A couple of bottles of homemade liquor, tobacco, Kanjars leave jewelry, a mirror and comb, towels and clothes, hair oil, food – for the soul, if it wishes to visit this world. Inside the mound, the ashes under a special mound, and on top of the tomb they leave a small stone present as brass. After cremation, the Kanjars usually bury the memory of the dead, and then distribute the remaining alcohol among alcohol and treat the deceased. Reciting prayers, they raise a toast in Amavasya, some Kanjar tribes gather at the smashans with bottles of secrets to this day. During the celebrations of Holi, Diwali, Rakhi, and songs, coded words, and gestures, and this closed community keeps its The language of the Kanjars, Marai-Parsi, consists of animal and bird such stories.

rooftops was, so to speak, the cherry on the cake. There are a great many from wedding rituals of worshipping the Goddess. Ritual defecation from knows of their strange practices: from training wall-climbing jizards to of alcoholic beverages, prostitution, and petty theft. In India, everyone subject to significant social stigma. This is linked to the illegal production "criminal tribe," called "despicable" – and to this day, the Kanjars are freely through their territories. During British rule, they were branded a The offer proved invaluable, as the Kanjars do not allow outsiders to pass presence will protect you from possible problems...

your safety. My tribe lives there, and my father is the village elder. My for the rare herb, naming their destination. "I will guide you there, for protégés asked about their route, and they told him about the expedition The youth was invited into their carriage. In the morning, the sleepy "Don't worry, I will pay for your ticket from this stop onwards."

"I lost my ticket..."

happened,"

Was all of this merely luck, a series of coincidences? An unfamiliar young

Ullain, they safely boarded a train to Cwalior.

where luck smiled upon them—a local bus arrived in just ten minutes. In
deeper into the thicket. A few hours later, they emerged onto a road
whether the chief's son's charm had fully worked, and they blundered
agitated villagers with calm confidence. They had no desire to verify
seemed quite friendly, and the smiling young man spoke with the
swords and spears had surrounded their guide. But the conversation
shorter, they looked back. Nearly a hundred clearly battle-ready men with
into the thick of the forest, which provided an ideal, though temporary,
through the dense jungle. Having penetrated about four hundred meters
Danger gave them strength. Like a wild deer, Bhastrii ran ahead, weaving
muu.

them. I am the chief's son: nothing will happen to me, but you must
gathered what you wanted. Leave. I will hold them back and speak with
accompanying them did not look worried at all: "You have already
with swords and spears, headed toward them. However, the young man
in the village, news of the strangers spread, and the entire tribe, armed
them that...

emerged from the forest. Out of breath from running, the Kamars told
and the large sack quickly filled. Suddenly, several local residents
Despite the tiring journey, Bhastrii was full of energy and enthusiasm,
delay, getting to the valuable roots.

the plants were at their peak of maturity, and they began digging without
abundant. The constellations were in a favorable position for harvesting,
reached the desired place. It was worth it: the required herb was
Baranagar, from there they walked through the jungle all night until they
somehow not thought of this beforehand. Then they boarded a bus to
purchased the necessary equipment: small shovels and a sack; they had
...Arriving in Ullain early in the morning, at the youth's insistence they

pastimes...

"Tryambaka" is one of the names of Shiva (pronounced "tryambakam" in

Bandhanam Mritam mukshya mamrtam

Om tryambakam yajamahe Sugandhim Pashtonidhanam Uvataranam
him.

manuscript at the time, such a realization would hardly have occurred to
And yet, if he had not been reading yet another thick Ayurvedic
illness. It is believed to cure disease, and he himself had witnessed this.
As a rule, the Mahamrityunjaya Mantra is recited in cases of serious
understood: this mantra was an alchemical formula, a recipe for healing.
But on the tenth or eleventh day, something clicked, and he suddenly
Gmashan.

almost immune to the cacophony of sounds tearing apart the silence of
had grown accustomed to the incessant din of religious festivals and were
night. This no longer irritated him: by that time, both he and Devanudi
recording of the Mahamrityunjaya Mantra from morning until late at
In the autumn of 1997, loudspeakers at a neighboring temple played a
scattered everywhere, and an attentive mind could decipher them.

the essence of the transmitted information. Clues were generously
remedies and encoded healing formulas. One need only listen and discern
...Before the "expedition," he had been interested in little-known natural
from this herb proved effective there as well.

days. Treating serious heart diseases took longer, but the medicine made
within four days, and acute jaundice in one student passed in just three
The collected herb proved truly magical: it eliminated liver problems

The Encoded Mantra

their results.

pendulum of Fate is always suspended from a chain of links of trials and
lives. Nothing was a coincidence; all events had a hidden meaning. The
them straight to the right place. And on top of that, he literally saved their
man had lost his ticket; he paid for his fare, and in gratitude, the boy led

perceive the idea of an elixir of eternal youth as a fairy tale.

"Average Joe" was never programmed to achieve immortality. People possibly contradicts the "generally accepted" average lifespan. Consider the concept of eternal life extravagant simply because its very whim, an impractical hobby. The overwhelming majority of people judges borders on madness. Describing ancient mantras seems like a ...For pragmatists, the very idea of gathering magical herbs in distant

pharmacological facts, but the results outweighed any arguments.

increased the effectiveness of the preparation. Such claims contradicted all medicine was prepared at the smashan, in the "house of Shiva," which acquired as a complication of tuberculosis. Among other things, the samples produced cured two women with tuberculomas of the brain substances. The proportions were unknown, although several trial ancient recipe, and he began experimenting with the mentioned of the Mahamrityunjaya Mantra revealed the essence of a very practical. He loved to get to the literal meaning: the direct significance of the words capable of curing anyone, even a person on the verge of death.

himself "in the jaws of death" could escape it. That is, the remedy is "Mrityur mukshiyā mantitā" meant that even one who has found resembling a small watermelon with pinkish flesh.

The next step was the processing of the mixture "utarakamiva," a fruit was believed to increase vitality.

processed sulfur. In Ayurveda, "sugandhim" was the name for sulfur; it combining all three "kinds" of Shiva (mercury, shilajit, and datūra) with these substances, studying and processing them. The second line spoke of Thus, the first line indicated the necessity of understanding the essence of substances called "Shiva" in Sanskrit: mercury, shilajit, and black datūra.

Shiva") refers to the three incarnations of Shiva, as well as to the three "Tryambakam yajaimahē" (translated as "We worship the three forms of the mantra), literally meaning "the three-eyed one."

presumably an analogue of the Western "lapis philosophorum," interactions. In India, the Philosopher's Stone is called Paras Pathar—medieval alchemists to study countless variations of ingredient substance. Almost until the end of the 17th century, its quest drove Stone to be a rather ordinary and widespread, though unrecognized, the soul into the jewel of the higher Self. Medieval mystics considered the was also the result of inner evolution: the transmutation of the essence of An instrument for the transformation of Matter, the Philosopher's Stone these principles.

centuries before Jung, yet the Western scholar was the first to systematize between alchemy and logic metamorphoses of consciousness several understand the human psyche. Jung had discovered the connection describe its rich allegorical symbolism, believing it would help aspects of the Self. By investigating alchemical science, Jung sought to foundation for studying the integration of conscious and unconscious modern psychology, and it was alchemy that provided him with the For Western philosophers such as Carl Jung, alchemy was a precursor to perfection.

and with this transformation, the immortal soul would attain true Alchemists believed that wondrous substances could grant eternal life, enrichment was banally materialistic, wealth was not the only goal. to transmute base metals into precious ones. Even if the desire for Western alchemy sought the Philosopher's Stone for its supposed ability

The Philosopher's Stone

personally, a limitation of imagination was like Death.

such an existence lies beyond initially programmed expectations. For him of life and its goals. No one plans to live forever, since the meaning of As a rule, limited needs and beliefs significantly narrow one's perception

modern pharmacology and medicine, which support the average lifespan. In general, society expects ordinary people to rely on the achievements of

nothing of the sort—and yet he becomes a conduit of divine energy by sometimes Shaktipat is bestowed upon a person who has asked for knowledge and divine energy from a Guru, sage, ascetic, or deity. The concept of Shaktipat means the transmission to a seeker of spiritual from Guru to successor, ensuring the immortality of Truth. In Hinduism, The tradition of logic parampara implies the transmission of knowledge dualities.

initiate transformation. And yet, the seeker had to initially possess certain sincerity, zeal, or devotion, this could arouse the Teacher's interest and tactile influence. If the disciple was able to "touch" the Guru with virtues, purifying the optics of the seeker's inner vision without any transform ordinary human "material," enhancing his dualities, revealing Working with the disciple's consciousness, the spiritual teacher could worked even greater wonders. In yoga, the stone was the Guru himself. coveted ingredient turned any base metal into gold, then knowledge metal; a magical catalyst was required—the Philosopher's Stone. If the Alchemical gold itself could not transmute other substances into precious unusual souvenir in person.

heirs. His colonel grandfather often visited the palace and saw this whirlpools of history and time, which took the form of the pockets of palace for public viewing—until the gold dissolved in the numerous This incident was widely known, and the chain was even displayed in the time it took for the cavalry and baggage trains to reach the opposite bank, altering its properties and atoms within 40 minutes. That was exactly the of unknown components caused a natural transmutation of iron into gold, the sweat running down the elephant's back. In any case, the combination gold. Perhaps something was in the soil of the riverbed, in the water, or in Morar River near Cwalior, the iron chains on one elephant turned into end of the 18th century, when Maharaja Scindia's army was crossing the phenomenon transmuted base metal into gold. Somewhere around the Some historical records speak of instances where an unknown Sometimes it was found raw, in its natural state.

Kinaram was making a pilgrimage to holy places until he came to Girnar. ...After prolonged austerity, the future founder of the Agnori sect encountered such cases, although legends abound.

could bestow Shaktipat from a distance. He had never personally and become a part of it. Sometimes a flower, a fruit, or a sip of water force, since superconsciousness must penetrate the soul of the recipient **a messenger of divinity**. This grace cannot be begged for or seized by

grace, and whoever transmitted this energy was

One thing is absolutely certain: Shaktipat was a manifestation of supreme Universe and begin anew.

and the causal world ceased to exist. Mahadev intended to destroy the described, only hinted at. Shiva opened his third eye only once or twice, convenient symbolism, an allegory. What actually happens is rarely eye has also gained popularity in mass culture, but this is more a to the possibility of attaining enlightenment. The opening of the spiritual represents a concept in which a specific part of human anatomy is linked pineal gland, which is quite possible. The "Eye of Consciousness" Theosophists suggested that the third eye is actually a partially dormant

all praise.

to sell and consume. In any case, interest in spiritual vision is worthy of spiritual vision through the third eye is an ideal New Age paradigm, easy entrance into the inner cosmos, opening a portal of higher consciousness. higher being) can activate someone's third eye, and it becomes an transmit knowledge, divine vision, and grace. A spiritual master (or a person's eyebrow center (ajna, agya chakra, or third eye), it is possible to esotericists and spiritual seekers, it is widely believed that by touching a glance, and even through a mental impulse. Or a touch. Among Western transmission are known: through a secret word, a mantra, a simple "pata"—"to descend, to bestow." Many methods of conducting such a The term "Shaktipat" itself derives from the word "shakti"—energy, and

virtue of destiny.

assimilated divine power that remained with the fortunate recipient for gift could change a person's inner life. Bhaktibat was an internal. Certainly, abstract grace of the Gods and the Guru existed; this precious

transmit their abilities to others through a stream of direct knowledge.

who knows. These holy men could curse or bless, but they could not none of these ascetics could transform another person into a human – one during his travels possessed certain powers and mystical abilities, yet incentive for seeking and self-perfection. The sadness he encountered satisfaction with the mere fact of initiation deprived them of further significant progress or expansion of consciousness in the initiated. Give initiation-Bhaktibat to those who desire it. But he never saw any In India, there is a great multitude of spiritual and religious groups that possessed.

years. Guru Datta merely activated the abilities Kinarani already Guru, but before this Kinarani had performed intense austerity for many and do good." This was an obvious case of Bhaktibat, the grace of the Dattatreya said: "Your pilgrimage is over. Return to Varanasi, stay there, away.

logic power. It allowed one to see events occurring a thousand miles touching the grass." This was a test of clairvoyance, attained along with rides on a black horse, and a beautiful ghawl falls from his shoulders. The beggar began: "The Emperor in Delhi..." And Kinarani continued: "...

form of a beggar to test Kinarani.

immediately he attained a divine vision: Dattatreya himself had taken the without hesitation, taking the offered "treat," he bit into it. And attraction, beauty and ugliness, defilement and purification – and Agni and a realized yogi, Kinarani knew the nature of aversion and out a bone with scraps of meat, offering him refreshment. An experienced dog's leg. Kinarani sat down nearby to catch his breath; the beggar held Guru Datta, Kinarani noticed a disgustingly filthy beggar crawling on a Climbing the famous 8,000 steps to the summit of the hill, to the temple of the abode of the mystical Guru of the Agnis and Mathas, Dattatreya.

change. The Alchemist and the Stone became one.

an enlightened Master. It could become the catalyst for irreversible descent of Shakti through the touch of the supreme mind or the mind of deep meaning of the Guru's words would begin to unfold. This was the sound simple, but never banal, and if the disciple practiced sincerely, the combined with self-inquiry and purification. The Master's wisdom could continuity of knowledge – through reflection upon the received teaching help but admire the grandeur of Indian philosophy, which ensured the Observing his disciples and recalling his own experience, he could not murder. Miraculous changes did not occur overnight.

Sadhana became even more intense and demanding; he had to work even confidence in his own strength that influenced his subsequent practice. awakened the desire to attain it. It was this incomparable inspiration and touch, it did not guarantee instantaneous spiritual realization, only a gesture of blessing. However great the grace of the Guru's physical Babaji did not touch his brow, although he placed his hand on his head in inspiration: "Yes, I can achieve this!"

Mahavatar explained the subsequent levels of Kriya, he felt a wave of The meeting with Babaji, of course, was Shaktipat. Listening as the goals.

was merely a vehicle, a container for an astral entity pursuing its own simply began to use the medium's body for communication. The person Shaktipat. But in such cases, no knowledge was transmitted; the spirit would receive the astral lodger, and this too was a certain type of were "possessed" and with which they cooperated. The new "bearer," death they would transmit to another person the spirit by which they the meaning of what was happening quite accurately. Sometimes before called Shakti-Dhari in India, "spirit-possessed" – and the name described ...The mediums through whom Hanuman communicated with him were

life.

short; they wanted to know more and refused to succumb to the merged with Time. For these ascetics and sages, human life is insultingly crossed His threshold, realized His essence and non-linear nature – and Driven by a thirst for higher knowledge, the pioneers of immortality Time itself.

these legends are not just a collection of fairy tales, but testimonies of nothing but pieces and fragments of retold and rewritten legends, and significantly exceeded the modern statistic of 75-plus years. History is measured in various time scales: in the past, the average lifespan exclusively Indian theme. The events described in the Puranas were bious kings who performed tapas for thousands or millions of years – an speaking of the immortality that yoga bestows. Stories of yogis, sages, and bird of Bharata. Nowhere else in the world are there ancient texts immortality is a feature of the Indian land, the precious egg of the golden Rooted in yoga and sealed by the sacredness of alchemical processes, why;

preservation of the organism by alchemical means. The question is only – consciousness transfer. Today it seems quite possible, as does the more or less reconciles the general public with the fantastic theory of the body and have no limit to their lifespan. For now, this hypothesis taught, until science learned that brain neurons differ from other cells in nervous system – how could it be otherwise? This is what everyone was Individuality dies with the death of the brain and the destruction of the immortal body can be considered hopeless. Creation itself is against it: birth, perhaps even more. In other words, the hope of living forever in an Nature herself. The world needs the death of each one just as much as its free up living space for others – this unbreakable script is established by it is impossible to make the body eternal. A biological being must die and cleaner: it will break down anyway. Even if you constantly change parts, beyond the body's expiration date are like repairing an old vacuum As one popular contemporary author writes, attempts to prolong life

Alchemical Parallels

many texts as holding an unblinking gaze directed into emptiness, but non-quality arises. The technical execution of this mudra is described in steady, as if seeing everything and seeing nothing. In this state, a state of focused, holding consciousness and breath unwavering, and the gaze (Shiva). When performing Shamdhavi-mudra, the yogi remains inwardly Shamdhavi is one of the names of Shakti, striving towards Shamdhava ॐ Shamdhavi mudra is one of the highest yogic attainments. Also,

continuation of knowledge through the path of spiritual practice.

exclusively for the knowledge of God. Eternal life is meant for the trial. In India, the goal of longevity is well known: it is intended they spend their time? An unprepared mind could not cope with such a What would a worldly person do upon becoming immortal, how would who dedicated their lives to it.

nectar of Shamdhavi Mudraॐ or Omkar Kriya was received by those practitioners, the first fruits of yoga could come quite quickly. The pure karmas and austerities, the result of life's efforts. For some fortunate the prism of logic samadhi, and this attainment is the result of individual appeared in all ages. Merging with Time, they came to know it through magicians, became immortal. There were few such beings, yet they Those who cast an unprecedented challenge to death, ascetics and Nature and karma, and returned back into the non-existence of the Void. Non-believers and skeptics lived out the meager years allotted to them by immortals, complete anonymity is merely one aspect of the grand play. an attitude suited those who wished to remain unknown. For the Of course, all this sounded like fantasy, an unattainable dream – but such no reason to leave its breath.

lifespans must increase, and if the body serves longer, the spirit will have liberation in one lifetime, and their approach is quite practical: the goals were far grander. Truly egocentric, these people sought to attain business plans, and did not retire at the age of 62. Their ambitions and loans, did not burn themselves in the flames of urgent projects and blackmail of Time's limitation. These seekers had no mortgages or student

and Shakti are the most important tools of yogi-alchemy. Will the such a metamorphosis was both the goal and the means. Ichchha, Kriya, set by Nature, and to see how substance overcomes the need for form.

out of the desire to overcome the limitation of form, to test the boundaries transmuting metals into gold are similar and go hand in hand: they grew logic goal of transforming consciousness and the alchemical goal of both to techniques of knowledge and to the transformation of matter. The perfection and assimilation of acquired knowledge are equally applicable no longer bound to a narrow list of earthly affairs. The processes of attaining immortality forever changed the consciousness of the siddhas, know perfectly well how to spend unlimited time. The very process of Pastime is a problem exclusively for mortals, whereas the immortals unworthy of such a gift.

life – for the continuation of spiritual development. Other goals are granted a long life to a person who had sufficient means for a comfortable rulers of Rajasthan – perhaps this was one of those cases where a siddha sensation. It is known that the Matha yogis were spiritual mentors to the did not want their patriarch to become an object of attention and idle asked the bank management to keep the information confidential. They the identity of the long-liver, the bank granted the loan, and the family was still mentally and physically active. And quite alive. After confirming principality in Rajasthan had long since withdrawn from royal duties, yet the property was still alive and well. The 180-year-old raja of a small discovered that the applicant's great-great-grandfather and the owner of been issued 120 years ago. The bank sent an inquiry, and it was papers. All certificates were in perfect order, but they turned out to have and provided the necessary documents of ownership along with other longtime disciple: one of the bank's clients submitted a loan application ...An interesting case was once told by Harish Sharma, a banker and his

the outer and inner, the level of jivanmukti, the liberated soul.

the level of siddhas, when the yogi abides in unity on the subtle level of with simultaneous inner awareness. There is another level of Shambhavi –

well-cooked rice is also called "siddha"—that which has been brought to
In the Bengali language (as in ancient Sanskrit), a fully baked potato or
would transform the mortal shell into the eternal body of a siddha.

called "siddha." If it turned copper into gold, it could be ingested—and it
mortal body into an immortal one. In Indian alchemy, such mercury is
"steamed," "killed," and finally "revived"—only then could it transform a
Alchemical mercury, fed with gold and precious stones, was "sweated,"

Time.

and feelings, and it was these that quenched the insatiable hunger of
Life. The immortal essence of each soul contained the seeds of memories
All living beings were that very prima Materia, the building material of
of spirits, "snacking" on myriad emotions supplied by countless souls.

above all other altars and temples. Time nourished itself on the life force
emotions are sacrificial offerings upon the altar of Time, which towers
But what does Time feed upon? As far as he could discern, human

The "emotions" of these substances are transferred into the mercury.

and minerals, the essence

essence and spirit of gold. In the process of treating it with various herbs
the essence of substances. Alchemists say that mercury acquires the
disciplines work with the predispositions and patterns of the mind and
Nature herself undergoes transformation through yoga and alchemy, both
drinker – such is the nature of this liquid metal.

swallow a huge amount of precious metals and stones, like a binge
The hunger of all-devouring Time is insatiable. Mercury, if allowed, can
alchemy: although it could be "killed," it never completely "died."

of Matter. It was not without reason called the main ingredient of
seed of Time-Shiva – mercury – embodied the magic of the transformation
in either yoga or alchemy. As in any art, mastery is honed over time. The
ability to act inner and outer power – without them one cannot succeed

the concepts of purity and impurity are themselves limiting. The seeker the past and present must be purified by the fire of yoga. Nevertheless, giant web of Samsara. To escape the endless cycle of rebirth, all the sins of and the memories of them (samskaras) constitute the main part of the into a new body after death. Past, present, and destined karmic actions Samsara is the central concept of metempsychosis—the transmigration spirit seeks to find liberation from the bonds of past actions.

of the next life. According to the conclusions of Indian philosophy, the fragments of a shipwreck that the soul clings to as it is carried to the shore Samsara is that which "flows around." Samskaras, however, are the should not be confused with samsara, although they are part of it. imprints). The basic building material of karma is samskaras, which pure samskaras (mental impressions, memories, or psychological striving for development in the process of yoga sadhana, the mind must using the properties of human nature: perseverance, curiosity, and desire. This rather ambitious goal consisted in the transformation of the mind from it.

mind as to crystallize the essence of the mind by removing impurities principle, yoga itself is an attempt not so much to change the nature of the the privilege of the practitioner—the sadhu—is knowledge. It required no proof. He simply knew it. Conjecture is the lot of the worldly; immortals. This understanding was based on personal realization and which he had once written yoga commentaries, was a manual for Years of reading the Bhagavad Gita convinced him that the book, to

The Alchemical Gita

must become worthy of each other.

subjects the spirit itself to trials and perfections. The rider and the chariot by time and karmic factors into an imperishable chariot of the spirit. Yoga intention. Properly processed, mercury can transform a body conditioned Ultimately, the entire alchemical process is a test of willpower and the proper condition and is completely ready.

person is able to stabilize mercury and stabilize the mind, nothing the mind that sets the goal and makes the decision to achieve it. "It is an ingredient of alchemy, and consciousness is the key element of yoga. It is mercury, the mind is uncontrollable and fickle. Mercury is the main preliminary purification of the body for the purification of the mind. Like complex purification procedures. Similarly, yoga insisted on the before the main alchemical process begins, mercury must undergo acquired magical power, are also called "Samakarsa."

journey, the various stages of "taming" and "purifying" the metal before its transformation of mercury. Incidentally, the milestones of the alchemical chapters of the Gita correlated with the eighteen stages of the text with the various stages of the alchemical process. All eighteen Bhagavad Gita as an alchemical manual, explaining the parallels of the ... In 2018, while answering students' questions, he began to interpret the selflessness, an understanding of the goal, pure luck, and longevity.

absorbing vast knowledge. This ancient science demanded effort, fantastic formulas, but their realization requires a whole lifetime, literally results. The cousin of alchemy and yoga—Ayurveda—describes truly alchemical and Ayurvedic experiments, and had time to enjoy their Most likely, they lived much longer, could conduct the most complex possible only in antiquity, when those who knew were also practitioners. pursued the goal of liberation through yoga. Such a combination was adherents, experts in rare medicines and complex rituals, but no one any true yogis. There were truly great scholars, diligent religious ... Unfortunately, among modern Ayurvedic physicians, he had not met by both yogis and alchemists.

polarties are enslaving and binding limitations—and this was recognized of purity and impurity, good and evil, black and white. All fixed overcoming quality. Not to conduct, but to go beyond the very concepts antiquity left descriptions of alchemical processes as a guide for Along with detailed descriptions of yoga practices, the adepts of must overcome even these, going beyond the boundaries of these states.

properties of the various herbal and mineral additives, imparting their ingredients are repeatedly heated. This causes the mercury to absorb the mixing it with various crushed herbs and acids; the vessels with all these steamed mercury is made into a paste-like substance, grinding and mercury is made to "sweat," and then the stage of Maridana begins. The immortal, the eternal spirit did not leave it. In the purification process, work of the yogi-alchemist can bring it to an end. If the body became The dualism of the concept of "soul-body," seems endless, but the Great field, is that very immortal substance dwelling in every body.

human body is called the field, and the self, the "I," which knows this explains two categories: the "field," and the "knower of the field." The this preliminary preparation is called Kshetrikarana. The 13th chapter and other substances, it is prepared to digest and assimilate them, and is like preparing the soil for sowing. Before mercury is "fed" with mica meltings, and roasting, called Shodhanas. "Creating the field" in alchemy stages of mercury processing echo this process: various washings, able to "cultivate" the seed of developed consciousness. The alchemical various methods. Without proper preparation, the field-body will not be before the body can receive the seed of supreme wisdom, it is purified by "field"—and Atma is prepared to receive the highest teaching. In yoga, The second chapter of the "Gita," speaks of the creation of a kshetra, or purified and freed from old impurities. As does the mind.

super-element, it must surpass its own nature, die and be reborn again, ingredients, mercury is tamed by the wisdom of Nature. To become a its purification. "Bombarded" from all sides, exposed to diverse be "purified" before it can absorb the essences of each substance used for other than impurities of the mind. Toxic and uncontrollable mercury must first chapter, Atma is plagued by moral dilemmas, which are nothing connection with the alchemical process of the soul's transformation. In the One after another, the chapters of the Bhagavad Gita revealed a hidden summarized.

remains that cannot be achieved," the Hatha Yoga Pradipika succinctly

In the 10th chapter, Time shows the stunned Aritama the myriad of its continues to live.

the dead." The point is that nothing actually dies; the essence of all Matter burned from gold, silver (any metal) were revived, "brought back from He himself was a witness to the most incredible experiments, where or Mahasamadhi 226.

mercury; it merely passes into an unconscious state, Mahamurchchana. Some alchemical sources assert the opposite: it is impossible to "kill" its density, fluidity, and luster. It is "stunned," but no longer "overexcited," incineration to the state of plasma. The result is "dead ash." Mercury loses "swooning" and "killing" of mercury comes the most difficult part: its mercury leaves its previous form, leaving behind a residue. After the transformation. Just as the soul leaves the dead body, the essence of transformation. Life and Death are merely states of transition, another form of life. All this directly relates to the next phase of mercury. The eighth chapter speaks of the end of one state and the beginning of knew how to resurrect and revive it again and again.

state. Now mercury experiences death without dying. Siddha-alchemists "unconscious" phase of mercury processing resembles this highest logic. The fifth and sixth chapters of the Cita speak of samadhi. The doubts, he is ready for battle.

evaporates. When Aritama "strengthens" his emotional state, taming his solidification, or bandhana, stabilizes the mercury; it no longer of herbs and substances (their "emotions"), it can be stabilized. evolution. Now that the mercury is filled with various kinds of essences. This stage is difficult, yet it prepares the practitioner for further spiritual all animals, trees, insects, and people—on whomsoever the mind is focused. of each emotion in all beings and becomes aware of them: the feelings of emotions develops a very special type of empathy. He absorbs the essence in the course of his sadhana, a yogi observing all kinds of human essence and "emotions."

told in the final chapter. Without reading all the chapters, some proceed
A common misconception is that the entire Bhagavad Gita is supposedly
attaining an immortal body.

called "Brahmanical mercury," is considered the most potent substance for
Hinduism. This may be a "low" or a "noble" caste. The purest mercury,
in accordance with the class-based structure of society accepted in
Alchemical metal is also divided into varnas, in

psychotypes, its own path of spiritual development is prescribed.

Gunas determine a person's character and destiny. For each of the three
everything in various proportions. The "dosage" and interaction of the
and activity, as well as ignorance and inertia, exist in everyone and
present in all beings. Goodness, calmness, harmonious balance, passion
worldview, the Gunas have always been present and continue to be
(rajasic, tamasic, and sattvic), formed by the Gunas. According to this
The 10th chapter of the "Gita" describes the dualities of human nature

mercury can cure diseases—or help conquer the main ailment, Death.

was carried out will determine the outcome of the experiment. Processed
next transformation. At this stage, the intention with which all the work
eight processes-samskaras purified the mercury. Now it is ready for the
igniting in the substance a desire to "devour" other metals. The previous
intensified. Dibana, or "kindling," enhances the power of mercury.
At the next stage of processing, the "digestive fire" of mercury is

horrified by the universal form of Time, watching it swallow Universes.

the liquid metal fills the alchemist's heart with fear. Thus Atma was
mercury devours everything. The uncontrolled and insatiable hunger of
its own weight. From gold to precious stones, from beans to mica, greedily
processed mercury "swallows" offerings without the slightest increase in
Creating and destroying everything around, it remains unchanged. Thus,
hunger of Time, devouring everything: universes, elements, and essences.
month" of mercury. The next, 11th chapter, vividly conveys the insatiable
faces and facets. In Alchemy, this stage corresponds to the "opening of the

...Having first read about it, he persistently sought those who knew and trick, yet Khechari is a key condition for progress in higher yoga.

practice, for several hours. For the uninitiated, it is a bizarre and strange upper soft palate, it had to remain in this position throughout the entire had to be "curled back" and inserted into the throat. Guided behind the Of course, to outsiders this mudra seemed more than strange. The tongue

Khechari, the Key to the Inner Heavens

own words and realities.

Knowledge is infinite, and in the process of learning, one can create one's Creation and the Creator, His (or Her) roadmaps and blueprints, for eternal life. A life that can be dedicated to the ultimate knowledge of and discarded the superfluous, the processed mercury acts as a catalyst to various stages of transformation. Having absorbed all that is necessary with the same perseverance with which Siddha-yogis subjected mercury the divine state, the sadhaka must pass through all stages of Kriya Yoga "digestion," are equally applicable to both mind and matter. To approach The refinement of nuances in acquired knowledge and the process of its pure Brahmanical mercury.

person cannot withstand the properties of the final product of Alchemy – mercury, without admiration and reverence for the mysteries of Nature, a chapter that summarizes them. Without the painstaking processing of chapters of the Bhagavad Gita will never understand the concluding sentences. Impatient readers who have not mastered the preceding the experience and realizations of an entire lifetime in a couple of of the conversation. What more could be said? It is impossible to express uncle exclaimed with satisfaction: "Ha! I knew it!" – and that was the end achieved in yoga?" Without hesitation, he replied: "Not much..." The nephew had become a Guru of yoga, he was blunt: "And what have you ... One day, a distant relative visited him. Still unwilling to believe that his reach supreme knowledge by a shortcut.

directly to the 18th, which is fundamentally wrong. It is impossible to

thoughts, and perceives taste. What would happen if this organ did not? The tongue is important: it governs speech and communication, expresses the digestive fire.

and Khechari prevents the precious drops of nectar from being ruined in yoga. During the practice of kriyas, the brain secretes certain hormones. The tongue acts as a receiving device, delivering amrita to the heart of the interpreted as a connection with Brahma the Creator.

metaphysically. "Brahm" means "mind," but this word can also be mudra connects the lower and upper centers, physically and the Brahmachandras, or fountain at the crown of the head. Perfected, this "bridge" between the lower centers and the "entrance door" of the soul, refined of all existing pleasures. In Kriya Yoga, Khechari mudra is the satisfaction of desires has many forms, and Khechari Shakti is the most power, desire, hunger, the thirst to attain, absorb, and assimilate. The Shakti, and Her help is necessary to attain the state of Shiva. Shakti is of the names of Shakti. It is believed that Shiva cannot exist without Interestingly, the name for the tongue, "Jihva," in Sanskrit also means one

answers he discovered during his personal sadhana.

the yoga path? Certain hints were contained in old books, and some karma? Why did this particular organ play a decisive role in continuing of Khechari, but now is this strange position of the tongue connected to karmic predisposition played a major role in the successful performance practice and usually master it after some time. It was also believed that heard of Khechari before, the most ambitious would begin intensive He usually demonstrated it to new students during initiation. Some had

difficulty, he mastered this mudra after a year and a half.

about its properties, and few practiced it. Initially disheartened by its practicing yoga, this mudra was almost forbidden, and little was known before the more complex phases. Considered mystical even among given to students only after mastering Khechari; it had to be mastered sadhana and the key to yoga. All subsequent stages of Kriya Yoga were practiced Khechari and could teach him. It was the criterion of steadfast

All logic texts agreed on the uniqueness of Khechari: it is Shiva's favorite. Without them, the tongue could not "stay" in place. stretching exercises, practiced for a long time before the procedure. the mudra. However, all this was useless without special tongue-incision only 5 millimeters long, but this was usually enough to perform would appear, and a slight swelling might develop the next day. A tiny the incision and how deep. Two or three microscopic drops of blood had ever taught him this. Somehow he instinctively knew where to make the next stage of kriya... All procedures were successful, although no one tongue from stretching, and only cutting gave people a chance to move to steadfast sadhana. Sometimes certain anatomical features prevented the in cases where they could not progress in practice after many years of In 37 years, he himself cut students' tongues perhaps seven or eight times, technically complex and was used only as a last resort. despite their practice of Kriya Yoga. Furthermore, the procedure is "circumcision" to achieve Khechari, and both agreed with frightening speed, damage to the nervous system. He knew two people who underwent decline indicates that something is going wrong, a possible serious an indicator of positive progress in this yoga. Conversely, rapid physical the tongue must remain untouched. The factor of slowing down aging is irreversibly damage the most delicate nerves in the tissues of the organ. "Cutting" the lingual frenulum and forcibly stretching the tongue can Mahasaya, it is not encouraged. desired result can be achieved this way, but in the tradition of Lahiri thin connective membrane under the tongue. It is believed that the existed rather extravagant methods of achieving the mudra by cutting the unattainable. "Karmic predisposition" was mentioned above. True, there practice, finding it strange and difficult, and the mudra something Those who could not perform Khechari would eventually abandon the transmitted by ancient masters to those who wished to practice true yoga. transformation of the soul. The encoded meaning of Khechari was secretly exist? In yoga, the tongue is a magical instrument, literally leading to the

human bones or the teeth of a black donkey, combined with reciting Alchemical manuscripts also recommended wearing necklaces made from texts gave no explanation, but emphasized this condition as mandatory. with physical deformities during this process was forbidden. Why? The the Khechari mudra and a specific mantra, and the presence of people mercury. The liquid metal had to be processed exclusively while holding Alchemical texts noted Khechari as an important condition for processing

number of cases, including those he personally experienced.

protection from any possible physical harm, which was confirmed by a the body. From a practical standpoint, the mudra provided powerful reality. Physical limitations lost their significance; the yogi transcended absorbed higher knowledge and brought him into a completely new consciousness of the Void. The expanded consciousness of the yogi As a result of persistent practice, the yogi could achieve union with the

Khechari mudra, worshipped by all siddhas."

ether (khe), because the tongue moves in the void (khe): this is the Another treatise, the Govakshasutaka, summarized: "The mind moves in the of their own mind.

entered the Void. Everyone who attained Khechari moved in the heavens The Hatha Yoga Pradipika described Khechari as a state of mind that has was more of a metaphorical comparison than a description of a process. capable of flying with the help of Khechari, and assumed this statement the state of 'Khecharatva', – "moving in the sky." He never met a person One secret logic text said: "He who attains perfection in Khechari attains seemingly impossible condition, Khechari, seemed quite fair...

could one obtain the magical elixir of eternal life. Performing the which yielded the precious nectar, and only by becoming a magician this mudra, could avoid aging and death. The tongue "milked" the brain, successfully mastered. Then the yogi, drinking amrita with the help of was a subtlety: results came if all ten mudras mentioned in the text were written about Khechari in the Hatha Yoga Pradipika is true. Although there mudra, bestowing protection and the power of clairvoyance. Everything

same rules applied to Ayurveda and Tantra, where success depended on means general recommendations: they are a guarantee of survival. The words about the meticulousness of performing techniques are by no means about the necessity of strictly following all instructions. The Teacher's duty also included warning those on the path of higher yoga about the dangers of the path.

through them without causing harm. The Khechari mudra had saved but the participants miraculously survived, as if the explosion passed bushes and trees within a radius of 3 meters were burned to the ground, intensified the fire. The pale flame of the explosion was visible from afar, and all the ingredients were destroyed: the remains of the mustard oil time to stop Ayasa-ji. An explosion occurred: the cauldron, the cylinder, specific requirements of the alchemical process, and besides, there was no mercury processing. At that time, none of them knew anything about the absolutely unsuitable for participation in the process of alchemical his head. According to the texts, physical imperfections made him He was missing one finger and, in addition, had some kind of growth on his head, announced, wanted to join the ritual.

working on obtaining alchemical gold, Ayasa-ji, who had arrived they noticed an elderly man running towards them. Convinced they were their tongue in the Khechari mudra. The liquid was half evaporated when around: himself, his friend Ram Babu, and two other students. Each held under a huge cauldron: all four participants in the experiment stood the substance was already at the 6th stage of processing. A fire was lit boiled in 40 kg of mustard oil until the liquid completely evaporated, and various herbs, preparing it for the final steam bath. The mercury had to be months, he and his students continuously processed mercury with alchemical experiments, and there was no shortage of volunteers. For nine in those days, he lived in a cottage: there was plenty of space for the mantras could spoil everything, and any mistake could be fatal.

experiments, he used nothing but Khechari. The slightest error in reciting certain incantations during the "work" on mercury. However, in his

– the secret ingredient, the key to the success of invoking the Deity.
chosen few. The sacred energy of Shiva and Shakti in its pure, sattvic form
the specific aspects of summoning the Avadhut was a privilege of the
this secret was known only within narrow logic circles, and knowledge of
to find confirmation in legends and myths yielded no results. It seemed
then dare to interrupt his interlocutor to clarify this statement. Attempts
flashlight in his face. There was ample food for thought, and he did not
smashan." This was as sudden as if someone had unexpectedly shown a
following: "For the Avadhut to come, a brother and sister must live on the
communicated during their memorable meeting. Nath said literally the
ground (or to any other place) – this is precisely what Gangadhar
smashan ensured the success of summoning the Avadhut to the cremation
Apart from other factors, the presence of a brother and sister at the
Devadhut

strongest bond." — Devadhut Babbar
spouses: people not bound by blood ties can become examples of the
"...True relationships are not of blood, but of the heart. Like lovers or

*

Sister

exploring the heavens of the Self.
transform a seeker into a siddha, one who reaps the fruits of achievement,
intense process. The secret alchemical element of yoga, Kriechari, could
main element of Life, and its distillation and refinement is the most
by him from the volumes of the Universal Encyclopedia. Spirit was the
All these disciplines carried a vast amount of Vidya, Knowledge, gleaned
sadhana yielded tremendous results.
correct alchemical ingredients and effective tantric principles, yoga-
was yoga, but Alchemy and Ayurveda aided in sadhana. With the help of
combined with the right intentions. Yes, the main focus of his interests
the precise dosage, correct preparation and administration of the remedy,

maintaining his sadhana at any cost, she selflessly fulfilled his unspoken wish from intrusive visitors. Having taken upon herself the task of mind and jokes, which always lifted his spirits; for periodically shielding with which she managed to feed endless crowds of guests; for her sharp the palace she found; for the food prepared without any outside help, everyone and in everything. He was grateful to her for many things: for in life and people. Wherever she found herself, her presence was felt by pressure, she displayed persistence and indusiveness, taking an interest from early childhood, she was impossible to ignore; without any domed in the world, she was soft-hearted and compassionate.

cloth as his own; yet he always knew: beneath the thin steel armor she heightened sense of justice. Devahuti's character was cut from the same belonged to the warrior caste, were persistent, often stubborn, with a like his mother, but softer, more "domestic." The women of their clan short and laughter-loving, she was the strongest woman he had ever met.

her lot was service to the Teacher, the Guru, and the brother.

confident in the rightness of their chosen path. Yoga was his destiny, and the lens of the samasana, their destinies were seen quite clearly; both were magic, life itself compelled the acceptance of this theory as a given. Under these assumptions are speculative, and yet, intertwining with subtle herself watched, breathed, softened sorrows and illnesses. Perhaps all fragile balance of hidden forces, to ground them, through her, Devi Brahma messages and blessings. She was destined to be by his side to maintain the samasana. Various Gods and astral beings came into her dreams, sending intuition of the heart, and it was she who found their future home, the large-scale changes, mystical premonitions were reinforced by the phenomena, a condition for many events. Her prophetic dreams foretold circumstances. It seemed her presence was the key to many inexplicable abilities that manifested themselves under the most unexpected. The ninth daughter and twelfth child in the family, she possessed hidden

the key participants in this phantasmagoria, there was nothing surprising. And yet, in the fact that the "little sister," as he called Devahuti, was one of

came out of the operating room told the relatives that she was gone. disappeared entirely, followed by her breathing... The weary doctor who urgently put despite all measures taken, her pulse weakened and soon room, during a family dinner. At the hospital, her stomach was pumped. It turned out to be chloroform. She lost consciousness right in the living space from a familiar bottle, only fleetingly surprised by the strange taste. medicines. That day, suffering from a severe cough, she swallowed a health matter, and Devashuti was well-versed in symptoms and various boxes of pills. Doctors, children, as is known, are saved about little pharmacy was cluttered with jars of ointments, bottles of syrups, and Indian doctors, her father experimented with various remedies, and their father's home laboratory – and died a completely real death. Like many she was in middle school when she mistakenly drank poison from her – and she could summon anything she wished, even as a child.

and Devashuti visited them quite often. Her name meant "call of the Gods," formed between them, and when his family moved to Cwalior, the aunt followed him everywhere she could crawl on her own. A strong bond vulnerable being completely dependent on his guardianship. She mentor. For the first time, he felt responsibility and cared for a small, tiny cousin gave him a chance to become an older brother, protector, and was the youngest among his brothers and sisters, and the appearance of a an aunt visited them with her daughter, seven or eight months old. He was unremarkable. He was nine, and they were living in Shivpuri when ...The first meeting with his future companion, friend, and confident managing all of this, including him, as he liked to joke.

harvesting, and fodder supplies. She was a poor manager, skillfully constant upkeep: a large house, kitchen, cow sheds, farm chores, sowing, continued to materialize daily. The vast household required attention and summer, black in winter, the kurtas were ironed, folded, washed, and they Devashuti was responsible for his immaculate clothing: snow-white in burdening himself with worldly concerns.

obligation – so that he could remain on the path of yoga, without

the summer, in inhospitable and unfamiliar lands, they laughed and mood was most often quite cheerful. Sitting in the huge white house on about the day's events. Her voice was high and clear, like a bell, and her when everyone had left, she would sit down at a low coffee table and talk calling him Curly, like the other students and visitors. In the evenings, in 1990, she asked for initiation into Kriya, and after initiation began confront grief, difficult situations, and painful conflicts.

taking place within him. And yet she tried to encourage him, to help him difference prevented her from understanding the nuances of the changes Devanuri, even as a child, sensed his state of mind, although the age of life filled him with heavy sadness, and at times cold anger – and made him abandon any career plans. The naked, blatant meaninglessness almost demonstrative disregard of some relatives for their family's grief. The shock caused by the death of his elder brother Mahendra, and the plans he shared, she considered righteous, truthful, and perfect.

other's company. The path he had chosen, the stories he told, and the ...As they grew older, they remained friends, still feeling at ease in each breathing stopped.

lasted only a few minutes, but more than an hour had passed since her up disoriented, with a bitter taste in her mouth. The astral adventure "Stay with her. When the time comes, we will return for you." She woke stay with her mother for a while longer, to comfort her. The sage said: moment, she heard her mother crying and replied that she would like to asked her very gently: "Child, do you wish to come with us?" At that intended for her. One of the wisns, with a white beard and kind eyes, ancient sages, wisns, were already seated there. The seventh seat was and she ran out of the house. The flying vehicle had seven seats, and six spaceship resembling a giant marigold flower was landing on their lawn. ...Sitting in that same parental home, she was looking out the window: a

Having fully recovered, she told an astonishing story.

astonishment of the medical staff and the relief of the shocked family. However, about an hour later, she suddenly began to breathe, to the

He warned her: "Think carefully. This path is not strewn with stardust the logic path. The same one her cousin followed.

changed her attitude towards life, and she declared that she would follow refused any further matchmaking proposals. Initiation into Krishna Yoga proposed betrothal and a search for a suitable groom. But she hastily In 1989, when Devanuri's elder sisters were married off, talk began of her the most unexpected place.

the strength of her will and devotion to her brother-Cun led them both to North Indian province demanded nothing more from young women. But Braj, she was supposed to marry and start a family; the society of the suggested no deviation from the expected course of life. Like most girls of She was born into a most humble family, and her unremarkable youth

The Sadhana of Life

seriously ill.

hereditary medic. And she nursed him back to health when he fell workers, sang songs, and healed everyone with the firm hand of a festive meals, dealt with financial troubles and disputes among the unfinished business here. She arranged marriages and prepared lavish kingdom. Those visits from the spaceship could wait; she had too much At the foot of the sacred Hill, she founded a just and prosperous antelopes, and monkeys.

she was always surrounded by a devoted company of dogs, bulls, workers. But her most sincere friends and admirers were the animals, and that land, into the people who became more her family than hired Having moved to the ashram, she poured all her energy and love into unsmiling boy with deep, dark eyes the color of lagoon berries.

ago, on the day a chubby little girl began persistently following a both loved and sang, cemented their friendship, which had begun long and anecdotes they exchanged, the songs from Bollywood films that they joked, although the situation was not conducive to merriment. The chatter

abilities: it turned out she could command snakes, and they did not harm her. The hardships of the early years in Govardhan revealed her hidden strength and character. And so it was.

not succeed in yoga, but I will do everything in my power to support her. She spoke of this once and for all in a casual conversation: "Perhaps I will leave my work, my responsibility, my family, and my Teacher. Once, I will be free. My practice was unwavering, and my faith in the Guru was unshakable."

Life on the ancient Ganges, amidst magnificent but crumbling palaces.

The predictability of the modest but secure future she had renounced for a common sense into this new, strange life. And she did not at all mourn of regret or doubt, always finding ways to bring healthy, practical improvement or stability were absent. And yet, she showed not a shadow of despair. Funds were perpetually insufficient, and prospects for quick success was not at all like a fairy tale: there was an abundance of hard labor and initially hostile attitude towards newcomers... Life in enchanted palaces always took the initiative into her own hands. A new, unfamiliar place, and the beginning was not easy: overcoming numerous difficulties, Devanuri

other family members simply did not dare to object.

Her mother believed in them both and supported their plan, while the unusual life, rarely granted to householders. "And she chose that very life. Honor you for entirely different achievements, and you will live an out with me, you will become a spiritual mother to many. People will marry, you will have a husband and perhaps several children, but setting When it became clear that Devanuri's choice was final, he said: "If you

their own terms, regardless of society's expectations or censure.

unspoken pact was sealed with mutual readiness to go through life on she only wanted to follow him and support him in every way. Thus, the criticism." Devanuri replied that gossip did not trouble her in the least: even if he is a yogi, is an excellent target for the worst gossip and tongues. A young man living under the same roof as an unmarried sister, people are by no means filled with lofty thoughts and have poisonous and rose petals. In the countryside, even on the holy land of Krishna, most

physical ailment became more and more evident.

though he moved with his former confidence. With each day, the signs of from the sharp weight loss, his face became gaunt, his cheeks sunken, dramatic that friends and visitors became convinced he was seriously ill. the celebration, his body began to change, and these changes were so leaders (and they especially) cannot avoid certain social obligations. After would have been impolite to deprive them of that chance. Even spiritual people sought to express their respect, love, and admiration for him that it organized in Cwalior: long, rather exhausting, but obligatory. So many in the summer of 2002, he turned fifty, and a grand celebration was

The Mantle of Change

and she could not stop the inexorable decline.

however as the doctors they consulted. He was losing weight rapidly, doctor, helped her heal them. But when he fell ill, her clairvoyance was as diagnose illnesses, and the knowledge she had gained from her father, a returned the feeling. Her unerring intuition usually allowed her to Hospitable, open, fond of a sharp joke, Devashuti loved people, and they were, above all... alive.

background observe her with genuine respect... For her, all living beings snake is coiled around her neck, while several snake charmers in the trance, her eyes slightly upturned, her face serious and serene. A large in one old photograph, Devashuti stands before the palace in a semi-

would freeze, and after some hesitation, the snake would turn back.

the cobra to return: "Come here!" The long, undulating grey-brown body reptile would glide away. Sometimes, for amusement, she would order clear that she could command them, simply saying: "Be gone!" – and the bite their offenders, yet Devashuti remained unharmed. Then it became away. Cobras, as is known, do not tolerate such treatment and usually merely spread its hood, staring intently at Devashuti, and then either overseeing the work, she accidentally stepped on them. The snake would her. The area was teeming with enormous cobras: several times, while

More than anything, this strange illness resembled a planned
their friend and who might now need any help at all.

knowledge of the eternal, primordial Dharma. To the Teacher, who was
gratitude to the Teacher, who had opened new depths for them in the
small chorten, at the highest altitude accessible for climbing – as a sign of
circumnavigation of the holy mountain, they left his photograph near a
pilgrimage to Mount Kailash. Having completed the ritual
later, in September 2008, when several Russian disciples made a
He was also tormented by a constant thirst, which suddenly passed a year
forcing himself to complete the series.

poisoning, and he struggled painfully and persistently with his body,
darkness. These exercises were known to be effective in cases of
mushrooms helped him keep from sliding into the abyss of despair and
a heavy, debilitating depression. And yet, certain logic postures and
trial for him was not even the loss of muscle and increasing weakness, but
carry him on her back, helping him climb the stairs. The most difficult
After some time, he became so weak that Devahuti had to practically

illness. Although he had theories about the nature of the malaise.

categories, but he preferred not to share his thoughts regarding his own
or popular neighbor. Hypothetically, he did not fall into any of these
than to witness the suffering and death of a more successful, prosperous,
restraining factor. For the worldly person, there is no greater pleasure
black magic is still widely practiced, and even blood ties are not a
intrigue, conspiracy, and envy flourish everywhere. In villages and cities,
any other land. Nurtured by the worst qualities of human nature, ill will,
The cradle of enlightenment, India, was in many ways no different from
there were grounds for such conjectures.

poisoning, as other hypotheses were refuted by test results. In general,
tests came back normal. Some doctors suspected prolonged arsenic
manner of specialists could not determine the cause of the malaise, as all
inward into his ribcage. The changes were strange, inexplicable. All
The corset of muscles weakened, his lower ribs seemed to have collapsed

plantation. The approaching dawn was slowly adding rafterones to the Devahuti was persistently leading him along the new road towards the night cicadas had finally put away their bows, he had a vision. In it after the practice was over, when the house had grown quiet and the the Hill had taken root, and he was satisfied with the results. One day, several months passed. The trees planted along the road laid out beside perhaps he was ready.

become part of his own story. Whenever this initiation was meant to about the great warrior-ascetic, but he had never imagined that he would the old Agnori many years ago, and since then he had learned much. Of course, he remembered the story of Parasurama's summons, told by significant, as Parasurama was the spiritual Teacher of their clan.

"Tell Shailendra that the time for his initiation has come." The dream was perception grasped both the meaning of what was said and the subtext, any expression, yet his voice sounded soft. As is usual in dreams, mental The Avatar's gaze was fixed upon her; his eyes were black and devoid of Devahuti saw herself handing him a folded cloth, something like a towel. locks of his hair; the falling drops were heavy and viscous, like honey. after bathing. Standing on the steps, he was wringing water from the long In her dream, the great immortal was emerging from the shamshan pond

It was Parasurama;

room, and then began shaking him by the shoulders: "Wake up, wake up; begun to fall asleep after his night practice, she knocked on the door of his Devahuti had a dream. Around three in the morning, when he had just slept little, in snatches. On the night after the roadwork was completed, There was little time, or rather, no time at all for anything but work. They a kilometer-long stretch of the future road; the days were full and long. began expanding the plantation and earthworks. Bulldozers were leveling shamshan to the management of the Siddha Siddhanta Academy, he ...After the Department of Forestry transferred the land adjacent to the

with the mysterious mantras he had received on January 10, 2002.

transformation, rather than the result of black magic, and he associated it

initiation. A yogi who has reached a certain level in his sadhana can physical plane, but some advanced seekers can receive an astral form of Enlightenment of Corakb), he wrote: "Most teachings are given on the Years later, in his commentary on the ancient text "Corakb Both" (The waking. It became part of his sadhana.

"Swarna mantra" – a formula received in the state between sleep and golden skin was his astral Teacher. What he had received was called a since anyone who transmits a mantra is a Guru – and this yogi with the mantra yielded no results. One thing was clear: this was a Guru-mantra, until they became a part of him. Attempts to discover the origin of the The vision dissipated; coming out of the trance, he repeated the words him.

Yet the mantra was not connected with any tradition or deity known to repeating this Isha." The words were in Sanskrit and had a deep meaning, imprinted on his memory. The ascetic said: "Eso Isha Karo" — "continue was) repeated an unfamiliar mantra three times, and each syllable was youth gestured for him to sit, and he obeyed. Then the yogi (whoever he shoulder, pushing him forward towards the fire, she stepped back. The flames tinged his skin a golden color. Then he felt Devanuti's hand on his ascetic stepped towards them directly through the fire, and the bright curly hair reaching his thighs, the youth radiated beauty and peace. The a ritual water vessel made of coconut. Slender and tall, with very long, white loincloth, no older than sixteen, carrying a staff and a kamandalu – straight out of the hillside, a young ascetic came towards them, wearing a stone.

shape of a cobra with its hood spread. A fire was burning before the immediate threat. Following Devanuti, he approached a large stone in the directly at them, but somehow it was understood: they posed no hands folded across their chests. Silent, dark-skinned giants stared enormous gorilla-like ghosts, about 10 meters high, with huge, clawed darkness clung to its folds. Along the road on the slope stood several ballet of night: a gentle veil of mist enveloped the hill, and the melting

over him. And in a difficult moment, they would take care of him, that Shri Satyacharan Lahiri, Babaji, and the paramhansa were watching did not attempt to establish mental contact with the teachers, knowing. During these events, which could be called nothing other than a trial, he blame, he would have feared such an effect.

that the mantras would bring about such dramatic shifts on the physical depressed he felt. At times he understood: if he had known in advance serious change, but he did not cease his sadhana, no matter how ill or perceived the pain as a sign of the transformation that accompanies any and the weight loss, he himself could not identify any other anomalies. He otherwise, there were no abnormalities. Apart from the pain in his legs definitive diagnosis. Only his blood sugar level was above normal. The doctors performed complex tests, but were unable to make a consulting ever more specialists in search of a diagnosis and treatment. who was far more worried about him than he was himself, insisted on. By January 2008, his weight had dropped from 100 to 65 kg. Devanur,

began from the very day he started reciting the new mantras.

pleas his initiation in person. In any case, the physical and mental changes Paramhansa – perhaps that is why the Guru of their clan (kula) came to ...He and Devanur belonged to the Bhargava gotra, to the lineage of waiting, everything necessarily eventually comes.

remained undisclosed, but he believed: to those who know the value of. He was describing his own experience. The identity of the astral Guru revealed, and this signifies the realization of the Guru."

astral world. After many years, the true identity of the astral teacher is guide him there, as well as provide the disciple with protection in the on the earthly plane should be able to lead the disciple into the astral and physical and astral guru are one and the same. Ideally, a teacher present comes to help the worthy practitioner advance further. Sometimes the sadhana remains his guru until the appearance of the astral master. He without revealing himself. The teacher who initiated the seeker into receive initiation from an astral teacher: he gives him a special mantra

Devashuti, who had never been particularly religious, began to "see" and impending transition. Moreover, she intended to pray for him as well. can she travel while Guraji is so ill?" — but the journeys were part of the organized a series of short trips. Some whispered behind her back: "How preparing for her departure, she was to visit several holy places, and they although no precise deadline was set, they felt there was still time. smiling. She was advised to begin preparations for leaving the body, and composite and appeared to everyone else as before: cheerfully, wittily, and When he told her of his conversation with Babaji, she did not lose her was ripe, tangible, and demanded constant attention.

never spoke of it. There was no need to discuss the future, for the present Devashuti had long known that she would not live to see fifty, yet they is entirely different, and he did not dare ask for exact dates. She and live. "Little time," could have meant "decades," as the gods' concept of time conversation, Hanuman mentioned that Devashuti had little time left to know certain things, the gods will reveal them themselves. In one such trouble the Deity with questions about his health. If a mortal is destined to Even when his communion with Hanuman became regular, he did not

Preparations

and his intuition usually did not fail him.

certain way — and the body simply had to cope. Such was his assumption. The mantra received on the astral plane affected the physical body in a improvement was fading, he perceived this as a promise for the future. survive. In moments of extreme weakness and depression, when hope for everything, and would hardly have taught him if he were not meant to of his 27th birthday gave him courage. The Mahavatar had foreseen The very fact that Babaji had told him to begin a new practice on the day that his life was not in danger.

already undergone serious trials several times, and was now confident removing obstacles, sending relief, as had happened before. He had

life was in progress. Devanuti turned away, and compassion pierced her were tethered to stakes, their glossy coats still wet from ritual bathing. A red brick wall, in a designated sand pit, several sacrificial black goats afternoon, she immediately went to the temple. To the left of the entrance, worshipped as a mother nursing Shiva at her breast. Arriving in the Tarapith, a famous pilgrimage site in West Bengal, where the Goddess is In August 2008, after visiting Bhubaneswar and Puri, she also reached hoped to receive blessings and final instructions.

Shiva, deities dancing in the darkness, awakening the light... Devanuti lineage, and the Fierce Goddess was the Kuli Devi of her family. Kali and temple built by her mother's clan stands. Shiva was the Kuli Devata of his She also went to Chuchura, a place near Kolkata, where an ancient Kali been heard.

no one, but certain signs after her return indicated that her prayers had blessing to meet death without fear. She shared the details of the trip with surrounding Amarkantak. Devanuti resolved to ask Ashwatthama's including their clan's ancestor Ashwatthama, still dwell in the vast jungles rivers, the Jorila and the Zong, also begin. There is a belief that immortals, Amarkantak. This is a powerful place of Shiva, from which two other reservoir known as Narmada Kund, located in the pilgrimage town of in the state of Madhya Pradesh. There, the river originates in a small In the autumn of 2007, she journeyed to the source of the Narmada River,

Would she depart with dignity?

significance. Would her dying be painful and humiliateingly prolonged? everyone, but the transition from one life to another held great the Deities could give. Of course, she knew well that a new birth awaits She felt a need for some hope or promise that no one but the ancestors or reject it. Such things can only be lived through.

both experienced something incredible, and that it was wrong to judge or conversing with Krishna, he chuckled. Then he thought that they had hands. It was then that the visions began. When she first claimed to be "hear" deities in meditation after Shiva snatched her Churn from Vishnu's

Shakti Peethas. Here, the right pig toe of Shakti fell from the heavens. The Kali Temple in Kalighat is one of the most important and powerful more stop was necessary, in Kolkata.

return home immediately, to the comfort of familiar daily life. But one woven from all of this at once. A pang of nostalgia stirred a desire to inseparable from each other, as if the very inevitability of life's flow was presence: the gentle movement of the water and the sounds of the city, possess supernatural powers, and Devanuti suddenly felt the Goddess's with her companions... In India, it is believed that rivers flowing north Crossing a bridge over the sleepy Dwarka, she headed back to the hotel landmark. Devanuti's own giashan awaited her.

with human and animal skulls. There was no need to inspect this puts and shelters right among the cremation platforms, adorning them had long been favored by ash-smeared tantrics and sadhus, who built Bengal, were visible. Surrounded by forest, the ancient cremation ground funeral pyres of the famous Maha Giashan, one of the most mystical in just a few hundred meters from the temple, beyond ancient trees, the

Akhanda Mata ji." And the sadhu lightly touched Devanuti's forehead... Idiots! The Goddess is present here in Her whole, undivided form — sister, everyone thinks that the third eye of Devi fell here from the sky. dressed in the black robes of an Adhori, suddenly turned to her: "Look, She was already heading for the exit when a middle-aged woman, concentration.

appropriate to request. The temple was empty, no one disturbed her Mother Tara for blessings and for certain other things she deemed Shiva, could be seen only by priests during secret rituals. Devanuti asked covered by garlands of yellow flowers, and the large dark stone, the Devi not the main sacred image. Invisible to all, the true idol is completely the silver mask of Kal Beshwa, concealing the Goddess's face, yet this is In the darkness of the temple, the flickering light of oil lamps reflected off as the animal was killed with a single blow of a curved knife.

and they felt relief only inside the temple. The entrance to the small the protective shade of the temple complex. The sun blazed mercilessly, Mathura. That day, Devahuti and her small group hurried up the hill, into place where the Goddess chose to remain after Her birth in the prison of Krishna's sister, also known as Mother Vindeshwari. Vindhyaachal was the too had landed, but in truth, another goddess dwelt there, Yogamaya. Cunderbooks claimed the temple there stood on the spot where Sati's pig Mirzapur, on the banks of the Ganga, in the state of Uttar Pradesh. ...A few months later, she undertook another journey to a place near sura shone like a flame.

heard her words. Those who accompanied Devahuti that day said her sign, a manifestation of Ma's grace and confirmation that the Goddess had crimson bundle gleamed on the dark stone floor — it was an auspicious dancer, suddenly rolled from somewhere, shattering right before her. The of red ritual silt dye, usually applied to the hands and feet of a bride or from the long journey almost dissipated. At the temple exit, a small bottle that she could and deemed necessary, felt a sense of peace, the fatigue grace-filled energy, Devahuti bowed, and having said to the Goddess all breathing in the fragrance of flowers and incense, absorbing the heavy yet everyone without exception...

gesture of Abhaya Mudra, the All-Beneficent Mother of the World blesses which must be destroyed to attain liberation. With the fear-dispelling symbolizes Divine Knowledge, and the severed head represents the ego, gold hold a scimitar and the severed head of the asura king. The scimitar pilgrims, Ma's long tongue is extended, and four hands made of pure Dakshina Kalika temple is unique. Three enormous eyes gaze intently at Unlike other depictions of this Goddess in Bengal, the image of Kali in the existence.

giving people the will to live and celebrate life by the very fact of their Yet it is they that fill these places with the powerful force of creation, significance, as most true Shakti Peethas are hidden, unknown, forgotten. though some Puranas claim it was the Goddess's face. Theories are of little

stored. Her new passion was photography, and she enthusiastically a silver bell. The dogs were walked, the cows and guests fed, surprises sing old Bollywood songs, and her high voice was as clear as the sound of origin of the spirit. Sometimes in the evenings, she and Devanuti would addressed: the consciousness of the Earth, the nature of particles, the New students came, and discussions touched on topics never before heavily, more joyful. At least, that is how it seemed to visitors.

situation improved, and the next few years were almost serene, less started exercising again: muscle tone slowly returned. Overall, the in the summer of 2008, he began to gradually gain weight: in October, he

friend, and she intended to continue as long as she had the strength.

efforts were part of her continuous service to the Guru, brother, and energies, and joyfully immersed herself in her usual tasks. The daily Devanuti returned from the trip restrained, composed, filled with new

"Sister, he will be healed. Guru Datta Himself watches over him."

the Math: "My brother is a yoga Guru in Covaldhan. He is very ill..." stood in a niche by the entrance, and after taking a few sips, she turned to the temple gestured for her to approach. A clay water pot for pilgrims temple, contemplating the breathtaking landscapes. A Math yogin tending mountain's summit by noon. For some time, Devanuti sat before the She began the ascent at 4 a.m., climbing 8,000 steps, and reached the

were built on the Indian subcontinent.

themselves, Girnar was an object of worship long before the first temples on the highest peak of Mount Girnar. Older than the Himalayas ...That same year, she went to Girnar, to the Dattatreya temple, located

accept the coming trials.

Mashtini. Whatever awaited her ahead, she was filled with resolve to body. This was a place for the removal of suffering and sorrow — Dark Deity was so great that Devanuti felt waves of energy passing through her to stoop. Although the inner space was tiny, the power of the presiding chamber before the altar was narrow and cramped, forcing those entering

their feet stooping. Only the chipmunks and birds, usually fed on the visitors. Burdened with grief, they shuffled as if underwater, dragging it was difficult; nothing moved either, except for the endless stream of open wound. The fog of loss was tangible and thick, and moving through. The pain was both sharp and numbing, his entire being buried like in the garden of the house.

rising only to attend the cremation, which was conducted right there in last, he collapsed with fever and weakness and slept for several hours, crumpled sheets, was endless and terrible. When Devanuti breathed her

The night when her spirit departed, leaving the motionless body on

already busily entering the house, making its way to Devanuti's room.

him, to preserve their own crumbling world, but very real death was cylinders and useless medicines. Students and friends tried to support floor, sat in the rooms, wandered through the garden, bringing oxygen people who had only recently learned of her illness. Visitors lay on the gnawing into it. In the final days before her death, the house filled with feeling of impending loss, but it tenaciously held his heart in its tentacles. Witnessing her departure was agonizing; he tried to shake off the chilling

tried various remedies, and from time to time, glimmers of hope arose.

all. Her melodious, cheerful voice disappeared, becoming a whisper. The months of her life, she ate little, and at times could not swallow food at and was determined to continue serving the Guru until the end. In the last whether sincere or feigned sympathy. She did not want anyone to pity her almost untreatable. Devanuti hated any manifestation of self-pity, she decided to stay home and meet her fate. This type of cancer was the doctors' insistent advice and agreeing to chemotherapy in a hospital. Devanuti learned of her illness in the spring of 2013. Instead of following

Departure

and both hoped there was still time.

mastered a brand-new digital camera. Devanuti did not appear worried,

where his sister now was.

brainkiller. And yet, practice was the only connection to that other side could he ask of them now? Zaynana is a bridge to knowledge, not a which he belonged. The Teachers had always provided support, but what attributed this almost occult magic to the power of the logic image to themselves in such a way that obstacles dissolved on their own, and he never turned to anyone for help. People and events had always arranged the night she looked deserted. He realized for the first time that he had given quiet in her cage, when he gave her the traditional water bottle for silence. Even the scandalous monkey, who considered herself a princess, in the evenings, after the visitors had left, the house filled with a frozen

only correct reaction to such news was to wait. And he continued to wait. growing, and her soul had the opportunity to choose new parents... The and sisters already had children and grandchildren, the clan was steadily likely, in her own family. By the time of this prediction, all her brothers message: Devanuti would be reborn here, in Brai. Quite soon, and most A few days after the cremation, a well-known astrologer sent him a seemed impossible.

no central information service in the astral realm, and finding Devanuti about newcomers, who needed time for "debriefing" and rest. There was this. Moreover, the unspoken code of astral etiquette forbade inquiring vanished to; spirits occupied with their own affairs could not help with were trying to mark the path her soul had left behind. But where had she the house, on the carpet in the teacups. Perhaps the roses and margolds before the oil lamps, and flower petals were everywhere: on the steps of a Bollywood film star. Hundreds of flower garlands formed mountains black-and-white photographic portrait of Devanuti, where she looked like came and went, offering condolences, bowing to him and to the large the empty room from which all the furniture had been removed. People For thirteen days, leaning his back against the wall, he sat motionless in energy, but even their chirping and twittering seemed muffled.

batch of ground before the kitchen, scurried about with their former

respectfully saying: "Oh, I have heard your name so many times, and assigned to Devanuti as a servant. Seeing him, the ghost was overjoyed. In the room was a thin, dark-skinned ghost dressed in white garments,

voice she answered: "In a little while..."

contain himself: "When will you return?" – and in her melodious, clear comic books. Seeing him, she gasped with joy, and he could no longer. Devanuti was sitting on this enormous bed; beside her lay several open over 2 meters high; wooden steps were placed against it.

countryard. Examining the entire width of the room was a giant wooden bed. There were no windows, only a huge door slightly ajar leading to an inner copied from Alice in Wonderland, revealing a sudden change in scale. long, and everything in it was disproportionate. The interior seemed. The room they entered was vast, perhaps 20 meters across and 100 meters wide.

giants, and now stood empty, inhabited only by the muffled echo of the outside and from within. These palaces were built by giants and for of 12–18 meters. Somehow he could see the buildings both from the enormous halls, some covering 600, 1200 square meters, with high ceilings. The image shifted, and he saw an intricate system of inner courtyards and plaster.

very ancient, built of yellowish basalt finished with a thick layer of style was neither Indo-Graeco nor Victorian; the structures were clearly saw a gigantic complex of magnificent buildings, whose architectural tree or blade of grass in sight. Reaching the sun-scorched plateau, they stumbled under his feet. The landscape was sparse and deserted, not a ...He found himself climbing a steep hill; the dry, yellowish earth

the corner: "You won't need that there..."

they "left" the room, his divine companion nodded at the old bicycle in familiar guise as an old man. The deity was in excellent spirits; before. One night, while he was still in samadhi, Hanuman appeared in his now-

the workers and servants, and the first months after her departure. The routine once established by Devahuti was meticulously followed by somewhere in the subtle worlds.

greeted them at the gate. Absorbed in thought, he was absent, dwelling ended in a pause that dissolved into the same deafening silence that had oppressive. Some visitors timidly began a conversation, which most often physical heaviness of the hours and minutes; the silence of the house was All who visited the swamian in those days and months felt an almost satiety.

indistinguishable, and he ate automatically, feeling neither hunger nor the fine bhishma this time, who had served lunch. The taste of food was winter jacket. He did not remember who had wrapped his shoulders in Devahuti usually took out of the cupboard in winter was draped over his warm air were unable to warm the entire hall. The woollen shawl that The days were still cold, and two small heaters emitting weak streams of

The Return of Shakti

incarnation were unknown, but already planned.

circumstances of her birth and the exact date of her forthcoming their magical island, the old swamian, awaited her. The possible incarnation. She deserved joy and a life without adversity and sorrow, for for the opportunity to guide and protect Devahuti in her next earthly might be. Of course, returning to the past was impossible, yet he prayed This brief astral meeting gave him hope for a new beginning, whatever it see Devahuti again.

The emptiness gave way to a fragile but growing certainty that he would the night were soft and soothing, his heart no longer bound by numbness. found himself in the bedroom, in the house at the swamian; the sounds of should not stay here too long. It is time to return." And he immediately It seemed only moments had passed when Hanuman said to him: "You today I am fortunate to receive your darsanam!"

neither a hologram nor a ghost.

cheekbones. A strand of black hair was tousled by the wind. She was could make out the stitches on the fabric, saw tiny pigment spots on her favorite attire: a cream-colored kurta with maroon salwar and scarf. He transparent not plumed, and looked quite material. Devanuti in her very one who had given him the Guru mantra. Their bodies were neither its hood spread. Beside her, slightly stooped, stood the young ascetic, the ...Devanuti stood before a large stone resembling the head of a cobra with confident.

along the edges of the bath, and the voices of the birds grew more was still foggy, yet the sleepy monkeys were already listlessly settling vision, Devanuti had led him there; now he went alone. The late morning very place where he had received the mysterious mantra. Then, in the Mahavastu commanded him to go immediately to Govardhan Hill, to the His reflections were interrupted by a low voice, belonging to Babaji. The special...

watched over her in the astral world. Whoever her spirit was, it was The Master knew of her, she had seen Babaji, and Hanuman himself he had ceased to "see" her.

immediately after death, literally throwing herself into his arms. And then only his sister but also his disciple, Devanuti had come to her Guru nevertheless the first whom these souls met on the astral plane. Being not Being merely an intermediary, a conduit of the higher will, he was wishes of the departed, he could help them attain a new, "suitable," birth. bodies. By the decision of the Teachers, and sometimes considering the parampara, he had to meet the souls of all disciples who had left their on the infallibility of the intuitive unconscious. As a Guru of the demanding company and attention. Immersed in contemplation, he relied Govardhan Hill. The bored monkey in her cage was shrieking upstairs, ...It was around 11 o'clock in the morning. He was sitting alone in the required no special intervention. They tried not to disturb him with trifles.

But after a while, they agreed: Curuji would have the decisive voice in all dreamed of a son. And they wanted to discuss this with their relatives, belonged to him. The young couple was astonished: actually, they had that he would personally oversee the child – in every sense. This girl ... He informed Nebra and Caurav that they would have a daughter, and this.

Nebra was in her seventh month of pregnancy. He had not known about Caurav not to delay having a child – and her urging had had its effect. Before her departure, Devahuti had been urging the newlywed Nebra and her body, but somehow managed to arrange a swift return. A few months and crude joke, a mistake. But there was no mistake: she had indeed left had died, and wanted to hear from her herself that it was someone's cruel thimestone-studded case rang incessantly. Many refused to believe she death, the phone lying on the coffee table in its pink, sparkling, used the one that had belonged to Devahuti. In the first weeks after her them. He never called anyone. He did not even have a mobile phone, and wondered if they had done something wrong, for he had never called Caurav, thinking something extraordinary had happened. They private. Nebra rushed to Govardhan from Mathura with her husband. That same day he called his niece, saying they needed to talk urgently. In made his heart bleed with pain for all these months disappeared.

in a wave of energy that passed through him, and the emptiness that had abruptly turned off a projector. An uncontrollable tremor shook his body smiling slightly, she vanished together with the ascetic, as if someone had remained silent. And then, adjusting her hair with a familiar gesture and on Devahuti's face was serious and somewhat expectant, but she returning to this world again... contact Nebra, your niece." The expression nameless Curu spoke, and the words reached his consciousness: "She is communication first: astral beings knew better when to make contact. The Numerous encounters with spirits had taught him never to initiate pursued by the rustle of dry leaves.

Two frightened peacocks darted past and disappeared behind the bushes,

depression, she hurried back to the house.

months before her birth. Then, looking at the flame flickering in its
housed briefly before the new memorial pavilion built just a couple of
and, having walked past the cowsheds to the fountain in the garden
for many years. The girl headed to the kitchen, then to the cattle yard,
hesitation, the child chose Devanuti's daily route, which she had followed
confidently when her parents placed her on the terrace steps. Without
...Yashashwini was about eighteen months old and walked more or less

through the rooms of the old house.

would be revealed in due time. The echo of the future already wandered
there had to be a reason for this. He believed that the girl's purpose
unknown life mission. Her reincarnation was extraordinarily swift, and
signs pointing to the strong potential of her destiny, together with an
the child's body confirmed the return of Devanuti's soul, along with other
wishing thinking, were fully entitled to their opinion. Yet certain marks on
some, however, who dismissively regarded this entire story as mere
Yashashwini.

consecration, they speculated about the life plan destined for
the story of the magical return

triumphantly rang with the bells of children's laughter, and all who knew
Frequent visits to the child gradually dispelled the depression. Life
leader's qualities in a person.

one of the energy channels of the body, control over which awakens
"Victorious," "Glorious." It was both magical and logic – so was named
knowingly. She was named Yashashwini, the name meaning
arms an hour after her arrival – and she smiled at him warmly and
friend and disciple of the Guru, Deepak Kumar, took the newborn in his
The child was born on April 17, 2014. Delegated to the hospital, a close
guardian.

matters concerning the girl's interests, and would become her legal

not just a trail. It will lead you through exhalation and inhalation into the destiny. Follow me along the path. It simply must be walked. The path is suffocation, free you from suffering. Think of the companion and of longing — I will share your sorrow with you. I will remove the companion... The voice calmed me: "Come with me, and share your considered this wounding and thorny path, this stony path, my sole path, a destiny... That gentle voice frightened me. It was strange, for I now someone could support me, when stumbling itself had become the end of your life and the world." I did not believe my ears, that even Mary one, will you come with me? It is not time to stop. And this is not — only they did not leave me. Suddenly someone called: "Are you tired? me. With empty and hard eyes I sat on a stone surrounded by sufferings. I waited for death, I wept so much that my tears dried up, abandoning the loving embrace of Devi Bai."

the land of liberation, on the lap of the Dark Lord of Govardhan Hill, in never bored, for a new story is being told to it, a story continuing here, on flickers. The spirit, now dwelling in a restless child's body, is peaceful and before the chapel, in which the flame lit in honor of her soul's strength sometimes he shares a silent joke. From time to time, Yashashwini plays and communicates mentally with his sister. Sometimes he offers a prayer. Every evening, having finished the night ritual, he stops before the pavilion ancient ritual.

embodied in new bodies continue to receive support and benefit from the. There is not a trace of contradiction in this tradition. Souls already other desires may be fulfilled after their most basic needs are satisfied. In India, the ritual is considered extremely practical, as the departed one's strength of the departed one's spirit, and the food appeases their hunger. special food for the spirit is renewed daily. Such veneration sustains the lamp fueled by oil burns there around the clock, and a dish of puffed, the birds and chipmunks. Inside, it is serene and quiet. By tradition, a surrounded by several amal trees, whose small, green, sour fruits delight. The small chapel, erected directly on the site of Devashuti's cremation, is ...The white pavilion-mausoleum stands in the midst of a lush garden.

others mentioned in the ancient text were *śiṣyas*, created by the power of mothers. Ordinary people who had chosen an extraordinary path. The All who came to him for knowledge were children of *Āyī*, children of the *loga*.

maintenance, he preferred to hire workers. Students should only practice his own household began to require increasing support and daily the students were part of the *gṛhastha*, his family. But years later, when honor. The Teacher lived alone, and such help was necessary; moreover, other students, sometimes helped with the housework, considering it an it with respect. Visiting the Teacher's house in Benares, he, on a par with performed household chores. This is part of the tradition, and he regarded family, a *gṛhastha*, where students received knowledge and sometimes students who were welcomed into the Guru's house. They formed a The ancient text *Śiṣya Śiṣyanta Brāhminī* enumerates several types of *loga* were called "children of the mothers," "born of women."

but traces of this teaching were evident. Those who could practice this tradition. *Kṛtya* did not require the initiations prescribed for the *Nāthas*. None of the Teachers in the lineage of *Babaḥī* belonged to the *Nāth*

Children of the Mothers

Śiṣyanta Brāhminī Śrī Gorakṣaṁ

possess different qualities." Fifth instruction: *śloka* 43 of the *Śiṣya* the children of the *nāthas*, and the children of *logaśāstra*, and all of them kinds: the children of *āyī*, the children of *vīśvānara*, the children of *vīrṇatī*, "It is said that the children of the *gṛhastha* (the teacher's house) are of five

*

Gṛhastha

with *Neha*, *Caṇḍa*, and *Yashashwini*, 5053

Devahuti, *Diwali*, 5010 with *Yashashwini*, 5012

depths of the soul..." *Devahuti* *Paṭhak*, 1993

tea and varied discussions, exercises in the gym, and short but powerful breathing techniques; the rest of the time passed between endless cups of with the Guru eventually arise in each one? After all, he taught only regardless of age, gender, and nationality, did a close, trusting friendship. Why did all these people want to become his spiritual children? Why, immortality must be hidden in the techniques of His teaching.

Babaji himself had attained the highest of logic states, then the keys to definitely helped to prevent old age and even death. To a certain extent. It by the immortal Teacher bore within it the seeds of immortality, and this The parampara is selective. But one thing remained certain: the kriya given Guru weighed and assessed each one's potential, for not all were ready, carried out individually. Before the beginning of the spiritual journey, the revealed to the uninitiated; the transmission of knowledge was still had so long concealed the teaching. Of course, the practice itself was not initiation of Lahiri Mahasaya lifted the veil of exclusivity and secrecy that centuries, is but one of many experiments on human society. The The experiment of Kriya yoga, conducted by the immortals over desire stimulated a rethinking of their own identity.

and Germans. What mattered was that they all aspired to yoga, and this Chinese, Jews, Ukrainians, Italians, Finns, Brazilians, Russians, French, personnel and engineers, scientists and police officers. They were Hindus, teachers, farmers and merchants, jewelers and politicians, military Academy represented all strata of society: among them were doctors and were meant to be — knowers. The students of the Siddha Siddhanta progress, the awakening of dormant abilities, their becoming what they investigation, including yoga. Observing people, he rejoiced in their providing the components and equipment for any experiment and Mother Earth. Nature herself encouraged all human achievements. He regarded those who came to him for guidance primarily as children of so called because they smeared themselves with ash.

Babas, and the children of wisdom, the Agnoris, Pasrupatas, Nathas, were the Guru. Viseswara were naked ascetics, digambaras or "sky-clad" Naga

hundred years old who still retained a passion for his profession, cast his yesterday's news. Only one royal astrologer from Cwalior, a man nearly a hundred already begun the journey, and the "forecasts" turned out to be not tolerate surplussive moods — that is the prerogative of destiny. He bath destined for him, but all this had already happened. The past does turn, many astrologers spoke of numerous signs pointing to the spiritual tendencies, it is necessary to heed their hints. By the time he had become a positive predictions. Since the planets indicate possibilities and the warnings and recommendations of the stars, people want to hear only that the inquirer can hear and understand. Not everyone pays attention to correct interpretation is crucial. Only a few can "transmit" information so absolute accuracy; this ancient science contains unique information, but unsuccessful. Of course, Vedic astrology cannot predict the future with According to the horoscope, even a military career would have been unrealized opportunities, and similarly disillusioned colleagues.

stupid civilians, sipping whiskey surrounded by shabby plastic chairs. Probably, he would have spent his evenings in the officers' club, cursing turned into a grumpy prigadier, or perhaps attained a higher rank. likely, having followed the trajectory of an army career, he would have result of such a choice remained in the gray zone of probabilities. Most What would have happened had he continued his military career? The

Probabilities and Predictions, Motives and Expectations

rightness of the path once chosen.

turned into the gold of faith. Faith in the Teaching, in the Teacher, in the ingredient in the alchemy of teaching. And then this currency inevitably and the mutual trust that develops over time is the most important student must possess potential, a spark of a certain adventurousness — teacher must be genuinely interested in the person he is teaching. The a sincere interest in people's destiny and spiritual development, the bond was established between Guru and disciple. It is impossible to feign The answer is simple: trust grew out of friendship, and thus a unique nightly rituals.

almost shocking. However, the uncertainty of the state soon gave way to the harmony after two years of practice was a bewildering surprise, whereas, he felt constrained and tense. That he was proclaimed Guru of At first, when the Teacher asked him to answer visitors' questions during advice could be extremely serious for both the teacher and the student. fingertips stretched over a karim spars. The consequences of wrong console those who sought advice or peace was akin to balancing on a the degree of responsibility for each person's destiny. To guide and consciousness were required. Realized consciousness. He was aware of questions varied, and for correct guidance, concentration and clarity of like the late Sri Satyacharan Lahiri, he received visitors daily. The spiritual development.

techniques, and the practice itself is but one of many steps on the path of realize: this role is by no means exhausted by teaching methods and transmitted various techniques, like an instructor. Only later did he non-religious Guru, thinking that a Guru of Krishna yoga was someone who might imply. At that time, he did not particularly understand the role of a to practice to the best of his ability and attain realization, whatever that. Honestly, he never thought he would become a Guru; he simply wanted days were still ahead.

ignorances like you! He will be surrounded by millionaires!" But those but he snorted: "Don't get your hopes up, he won't waste time on the astrologer to read their Guru's natal chart tried to clarify something could have imagined such a development. The students who had asked will study under him..." And this proved accurate, but in 1995 no one an influx of visitors from distant lands: "Numerous foreigners, angels, prediction came true. The period of Babu's transit in his chart indicated "This young man will live in a huge ashram near Mathura" — and the of promise, fragments of a misty future. The old astrologer then said: in Vrindavan, when the palaces from visions were still dreams, a whisper. The horoscope was cast when he, as a homeless Guru, lived in an ashram horoscope with high accuracy, and most of the predictions came true.

"practicing" them, and not the other way around. For some yoga some realized that the practice of Kritya is for life. And it was rather Problems appeared after a couple of years (and sometimes earlier), when muscles and crack the code of enlightenment.

discipline and perseverance, in the determination to develop new asana. Their advantage lay not in superior physical fitness, but in a firm faith in art of asana, the teachers were highly disciplined and worked diligently. of month, they found the path to the asana, to him. Experienced in the Having heard the silent call, learning of it from friends or through word search for a higher yoga.

that beyond the asana there was something more, and they began the achieved the highest results in the yoga of the body, some began to realize peace of mind, to feel the forgotten joy of physical wholeness. Having comfort, yoga teachers were doing a good deed. They helped people find healthier lifestyle, familiarizing them with various ways of feeling bodily instructors. He had nothing against the latter. By introducing people to a both those who had never performed any asana and experienced yoga The collective portrait of the seekers was incredibly diverse and included

a property of Prana: it was diffused in the very air that everyone breathed. an astonishing harvest and shared it with everyone. This knowledge was present, and standing in the midst of this field of knowledge, he gathered a specific person could resonate with the unspoken thoughts of others answer, and through it poured a stream of truth. An answer intended for Shantya and the sought solution. The invisible door opened with each

questions he gave, the easier it became to see the nature of each question. intentions glimmered within the phonemes. The more answers to desires with long phrases. Sometimes syllables hid deep remorse, and People dressed the skeleton of doubt in words, veiling vague, unformed still balancing in the air, they were already forming into an answer. He learned to see the deep causes of each question, while the words were confidence.

striving for yoga, since he himself never considered that the sole purpose so-called well-wishers, he supported all practitioners. Not only in their finding a teacher, the indifference, misunderstanding, and skepticism of remembering the years of his own search, doubts and fears of never. Only a few realized the ultimate goal from the very beginning.

declared the successor.

standpoints were already advanced in years when he himself was personal choice. Initiated by Shri Satyacharan Lahiri himself, their Krishna Yoga practitioners. For them, it was a family tradition, not a some of the Indian disciples belonged to the third or fourth generation of for the torment of reality.

practice and the place itself. And some needed an anesthetic, a painkiller were intrigued by the personality of the Teacher, the mysticism of the about the aspects of higher yoga and came along with friends. Others. The motives that brought people varied. Some had not the slightest idea their intended goal.

did not flaunt their feelings or make plans, but moved slowly towards "deflate" after some time. Those who were truly passionate about yoga. Overly enthusiastic and exalted representatives at the beginning would but what remained of the bubbling liquid barely covered the bottom. campaign: as soon as the bottle was opened, there was abundant foam, depended on motivation. There were people who resembled warm. Observing people over many years, he clearly saw: success in this yoga enough and were ready to enjoy its fruits.

results, believing they had proven their loyalty to the practice long visible signs of progress, and they insisted on seeing the "promised" being harmonized and balanced. Some were troubled by the lack of were reset to zero. Life seemed to be getting out of control, rather than social connections, habits, aspirations, and priorities changed, and goals success, was not a commodity, and took up too much time. Thinking and passed on to others and, consequently, it did not contribute to commercial instructors, the bonuses began to seem dubious – this Krishna could not be

By that time, I had already left the ISKCON community, received tantaric acquaintances strongly advised me to visit this Teacher.

50 years of living in India, I had seen many amazing things. In short, my with respect. What they described sounded intriguing even to me – and in not schizofrenics prescribing homemade esoteric dogmas, and I treated them trying to inquire about details. These people were serious practitioners, ...Having first heard of him from his disciples, I simply listened, without

Name withheld, Bali, Indonesia

The Artist

false ideas about their own nature.

costumes, and he taught people to get rid of unnecessary coverings and core of the personality was concealed under layers of masquerade such different masks. Like a coat rack completely hidden by clothes, the the future. Each had to discover the essence of their own self, which wore unwavering self-knowledge. Persistent practice changed the contours of But overall, he was proud of his disciples, their steadfastness, will, and sketches before beginning to paint an epic canvas.

on the stretcher, to prime it, to carefully mix paints and make several He taught them, as an artist teaches an apprentice: to stretch the canvas informed them that no one had chakras yet, they must first develop them. chakras... He listened patiently and with interest, and at the end gently Kundalini energy through the Sushumna channel, about piercing the Students spoke of intriguing things read in books: about the rise of the picture was far from glamorous.

again he described the side effects and aspects of states after samadhi, and radically different from the realities of the sought-after result. Again and happen to their bodies and psyche. As a rule, their expectations were state was called, and in most cases had not the slightest idea what could Beginners hoped to experience Samadhi, Nirvana, bliss, whatever that of life. As a rule, no one knew what the achievements would be.

old farmer died after looking at him for too long. Although that was especially newcomers' can feel more comfortable. And also because one later I learned that he always wears dark glasses so that people nervous. But only until I entered the house and saw him.

house surrounded by hibiscus bushes and fig trees. I even stopped being mausoleums, a pond with steps, and a dense garden with a huge white among the trees. The place looked exactly as it did in my dream: majestic almost refreshing, the air smelled of datura flowers, peacocks flashed behind, the greenery of the trees behind the rusty gates was calming and ...The chaos of dusty streets and the noisy bustle of the city were left

visit had come.

own destiny." Stunned, I jumped up in bed, realizing that the time for a Guru suddenly addressed me: "You should learn to read the lines of your of life lines on them. Trying to see his hands, I craned my neck, and the disciples examining the palms of his hands and marveling at the absence Covardhan. In one of the dreams, he stood in a garden surrounded by This Guru came into my dreams twice before I finally made it to of.

wanted to test my limitations and the strength of the material I was made digest exactly as much knowledge as they are allotted to assimilate, and I many begin the next stage of knowledge in this way. Each person can assemble Her puzzle. I know it sounds too general and idealistic – but craved clarity, not new pieces and glimpses of Truth. I needed to and yet understood too little. It was necessary to change the record. I did not crave any exotic spiritual experiences, as I had already seen much, mixture of all four types, I sought above all true knowledge. In any case, I seek benefit others knowledge, and finally, there are the wise. Being a believers described in the Bhagavad Gita? Some are the afflicted, others However, bhakti did not quench my hunger. Remember the four types of devotee, a bhakta, and that is what defined my spiritual essence. strange hunger was growing. No, I was not a yogi, I had always been a initiation, and was zealously performing tantric sadhana, yet a feeling of

assembly in our perception. And I understand perfectly that when I listen, I am no novice to miracles, and I know about different points of – and took something in return...

that filled the presences in the form causal bodies, karmas shaktis, of people everything and saw everyone, they gave some kind of energy or impulses upon outlines, these beings (or entities) watched those present. They knew woven from iridescent light, translucent, luminous, with white, almost beings hovered behind the sofa on which the Guru sat. With many arms, in the room seemed to notice it. Eight or nine fluid, constantly changing surrounded by clots of this condensed light, although no one else present battle scene of life, painted with broad strokes of light. I found myself what I saw in general terms. No watercolor of words can convey the And then I saw... I can only give rough, fragmentary sketches, describing my answer.

And he continued his conversation with another visitor, not waiting for must be intuitive. Tell me, what do you see and feel here and now...". matters. You are an artist, gifted with a special view of reality, and you is truly important. Only your personal experience at this moment in time response to my incoherent tirades: "Dvaita, Advaita, Tantra – none of this unimportant, and he echoed this thought, saying somewhat absently in once: my bath, my search, my motives, myself. But it all seemed in English, and I answered, desperately trying to explain everything at were blurred, forming only a background. He asked a couple of questions. Tea was served. For me, the faces of the Indians and Europeans present Hindi, explaining who I was and how I found him. He listened.

but bowed in prostration and spoke in broken but quite understandable silence. I still did not soil my cloth (although it almost happened later), however he radiated. Tangible, heavy, almost frightening, it cut through the features (or, his features are more than exceptional), but because of the Describing him is rather difficult. Not because of a lack of distinguishing those black mirrored sunglasses.

probably local folklore. In any case, I felt relief not seeing his eyes behind

microscopic in infinite Time and Space. Who can bear the truth of Time? not this naked and merciless, annihilating truth of my own limitations, but

And I prayed, prayed to see the dear and recognizable form of the Lord, concepts with them. I perceive reality in volumes – it is the artist's curse... horrified because I could no longer recognize forms, not associate my it limits the human mind, since our perception presupposes form. I was rather superhuman, but still recognizable forms. Form is called Maya, and always bound to form. Even our Gods are mostly depicted in human, or My interpretations of the vision ended, replaced by fear. We humans are still remain. Nothing can take you away from your self...

witness disappears, itself becoming knowledge. But, disappearing, you known Themselves and had no need for a knower. In their presence, the other worlds. There I saw pure Power and Knowledge that had fully given a darsan, a gift of revelation, I had been allowed to see a portal to I tried to remain calm, knowing this was not a hallucination, I had been floors of the Universe.

of Prana and Light, mortals (certain mortals) could move to different ancient siddhas and sages, leading to different worlds. Using the channels dimensions, if it was permitted. These were channels opened (or laid?) by had maps of the terrain. Walking these paths, one could enter different guiding travelers. Of course, only those who knew the destination and these Shaktis were forms of Prana, the sacred forces of life, guarding and Then the mind fell silent. And without the aid of any logic, I understood:

light, terrifying and wondrous.

subconscious whispered – these are not yoginis, but ancient beings of goddesses, shaktis – and then my mind began to deceive me. The devotee of Lord Krishna, I assumed these beings were yoginis or dakinis, according to their level of consciousness... Being an artist and a practicing perception. First, people see familiar images, things they can identify entering altered states, our attention passes through different levels of

straightforward: my body must be prepared for practice. Lord, now I would initiate me in a year. Giving me a set of exercises, he was. A week later, I came again to the summon, and was told that the Curu and slept for three days.

assured. I dragged myself to an auto-rickshaw, returned to Vrindavan. Life beyond the walls of the summon continued, loud and exultant, self-

Despite what had happened, I decided to return.

however, which must be controlled, having learned to interact with it. wanted to remain in the body. Beyond absolute freedom lay absolute absolute Freedom – from everything. But I myself was not free, and still that terrifying sensation of separation from the body. Yes, I was shown. It was a mistake to show me that radiant eternity. I would like to forget cycling.

surrounded me, licking my tear-wet face. I had not even realized I was who had furiously barked at me at the gate upon my arrival, now I sat for a long time by the pond, unable to think or move. Several dogs, following week, if I wished.

told me to go home, try to eat and get some sleep. And return the did not ask whether I still wished to receive initiation into this yoga. he Perhaps I sobbed and trembled – and even if so, no one reacted. The Curu the cozy, habitual surroundings – just a room, I am just one of the visitors. Returned to the world of familiar concepts and sensations, I rejoiced in confront them...

him because he is the rarest of mortals, able to see them, play with them, was a conductor, catalyzing various forces – and these energies came to powerful beings, these luminescent forms, they were here voluntarily. He deluded about who he truly was. Oh no, he was not the Master of these before the Curu. His form was certainly human, but I was no longer foothold from the tube of the body landed me again on the red carpet took a few minutes, and the same force that squeezed me out like somehow pulled out of the body, I was shoved back into it. The entire trip

state, I would like to continue creating.

would like to continue existing as a ray of pure consciousness. And in that light of Time forever. Do I think of any benefits from this yoga? Yes, I my heart and intend to develop this resolve. I would like to remain in the bhakti, devotion – and this is what is my essence. I carry these words in heaven, but I will be with You for eternity, wherever You are...“ This is A true devotee can say to God: “I do not care where I am, in hell or in after death. He possesses ancient knowledge of the light of Time.

survive that light. And to continue to exist in that state during life and explains not only how to enter the light of Samadhi, but also how to ...You ask what exactly he teaches? Here is what I think: this Guru knowledgeable people still live among us.

think this is a fairy tale. India holds astonishing secrets, and manifesting themselves at will, without leaving their forms. No, I do not Knowledge – they can play with their subtle and causal bodies, of the light of eternal life, living in this merciless radiance of absolute I began to understand why the Guru speaks of immortal siddhas, beaters in the heart.

else – so that the darkness that may crawl out of you does not build a nest purity is mandatory. Sadachara, or piety, is necessary more than anything how terrifying it can be. This yoga is for the bravest. And, as in Tantra, annihilating the sense of “I am.” Many think this is bliss, yet have no idea the strength to endure this light, it will burn everything in you, practically Knowledge contains the residual aspects of your personality. If you lack personified thoughts vanish along with the logical mind. Absolute bright, merciless light of absolute reality, in which all shadows of at least a glimpse of understanding. This yoga is the art of surviving in the myself of bookish notions of Truth. And yes, I received what I asked for, You ask what I hoped to learn? Well, first of all, to know reality, to rid sweated, doing push-ups...

...At the beginning of the book, he compared the Earth to the Goddess moving forward.

higher levels. I had practiced Kriya for over ten years but felt I was not "At the Right Hand of God." I realized that this yoga would take me to At a retreat in Mexico, in Jalisco, after reading a few pages from his book you, so you can visit him in India."

him in person if you wish. We are friends; I will call him and introduce and changes, he said: "I see no problem. Read his books. You can meet sadhana. When I informed my then spiritual mentor about these events time he appeared to me in meditations. He kept making changes to my heart. These positive changes came in leaps, becoming noticeable each now "downloaded" directly, as inner knowledge, filtered through the level of intelligence noticeably increased, I dare say. New information was main sphere of interest and profession. Intuition sharpened. Even my Meanwhile, everything changed: my perception of Vedic astrology, my though different from the yoga he taught students, as I later found out. After that, everything began to change. Practice quickly gained depth.

Although technically he was not my Guru. Not yet.

Yoga know of such cases of intervention by Teachers on the astral plane. anything. He made some adjustments to my practice. Those who practice on the subtle plane, the meaning is crystal clear, though the words may be attention at all?" Or something to that effect. When communication occurs continued meditating until he said: "Are you going to pay me any fingers, I recognized him, as I had once seen a photograph. And yet I what I did – I ignored him. In the end, having made out the rings on his to ignore possible psychoses and hallucinations in practice, that is exactly Several weeks passed before I understood who it was. Since I am trained above my modest home altar, in an astral but distinctly human form. He kept appearing during my nightly rituals, hovering in lotus posture

Michael M., Los Angeles, USA

The Astrologer

clients did not understand that they were already blessed by the Spirit with people and for people, I felt growing irritation, since most often my is right. And I saw, and what I saw was not particularly rosy. Working to see through fire – and be that Fire. To serve for the Good, to serve what ancient knowledge has no right to have distorted vision: he must be able righteous from my point of view. An astrologer working with such I also had another fault: sometimes a righteous anger would boil up. Well, beginning the real practice...

to complete my school education before entering the university, before environment of the healing sessions. Later I realized that I myself needed also learned much about people, observing them in the closed laboratory and evident pain, light, bliss, and liberation was powerful and vivid. I portions, everything I saw and felt, that entire mixture of darkness, false healing plants, immerse yourself in it." So I did. With those plants and me, on the subtle plane, and he said: "This time, try to experience the portions, and it was not a hallucination or a "vision" – yet he was before was quite shocking, since I had taken no mind-altering substances or of sky and water, I received the darsana of Guru Shailendra Sharma. It There, meditating under the bright sun, surrounded by the exquisite blue majestic cliff, resembling the brow of a ship sailing in the Pacific Ocean. time, and one day, going out to the beach, I climbed to the top of a periscopes, read joyously for the seminar participants. I had plenty of time intend to participate in the ceremonies. I simply did what I came for – cast invited to a seven-day retreat in Puerto Vallarta as an astrologer, I did not than awakened.

synthesized melodies of modern spiritual literature, which rather lulled truth, sounding so simple. It is an epic symphony compared to the superhuman intellect. Never before had I read such honest and clear had sought all my life: a Master possessing a mighty, multidimensional, understood what the author was talking about. I knew I had met the one I receive an education. The study of souls is my profession, and I instantly the knowledge of Death and Life. A giant laboratory, a school where souls Kali, and described earthly existence as a closed system, created solely for

sadhana and attained the goal sat right before me.

had passed through all these stages, days, months, and years of this the probable futility of future efforts nearly crushed me. But the man who seemed difficult, unattainable, almost impossible. Honestly, thoughts of was required for the "exit" from samsara, I was disheartened. The goal. Hearing the description of all the levels of this logic practice and what the medicine prescribed to me.

And I received what I wished for, though at first I practically choked on meeting this teacher I expected a miraculous potion, an elixir of new life. motivated only by the hope for the end of the previous phase, from uncertainty. I cannot describe my mood then otherwise. In a sense, I was No, I was not suicidal, but I wished to cease an existence full of pain and emptied by the lack of vision of my own Path, the nuclear prospects... let through various beliefs, spiritual doctrines, and concepts. But I was subconscious over many years. My mind was very pliable, "porous," and experiences, revelations, memories of past lives that had seeped into my Shailendra Sharma, was simply destroying me, despite all the amazing sadhana received from another Teacher, even after the astral corrections of previous format. I was utterly exhausted by incorrect practice of karma. The indefinite, unspoken, hidden from myself desire to cease existence in the arrived in Covadhan after a stay in the Himalayas. I came with an At the end of February 2020, just before the start of the pandemic, I still have been irritated and unbalanced...

had come immediately after seeing the Guru on the astral plane, I would samsara. Part of me regrets that my arrival was so long delayed, but it I passed before I fully realized and heard the call of this Teacher, this work through pride, arrogance, and hidden anger. Another three years why I remained with my previous Teacher for almost eleven years – to to them how to use their own tools, I secretly resented it. Perhaps that is Therefore, while performing the duties of an astrologer, trying to explain already blessed them in this life – and they were blind and deaf, existing within them. The One who lived in their souls and hearts had

I have done so for many lifetimes. I will likely continue to serve It even what I like about It, to be honest. I am a servant of Time, I work for It and works." Time is quite cruel in many respects. Although, that is precisely illusions must die completely and irrevocably; this is how Time itself course, this is a smashan, a place where all old beliefs, perceptions, and that he simply cannot bear right right. To myself, I thought: "Well, of of love and compassion. That is my version, of course. He himself replies wears sunglasses during darkness; so that people do not burn in the gaze deserving of such contact. And the healing begins... Why do you think he idea. Most likely, his own spirit establishes a connection with other souls. How did he do it? How does he continue to do it with others? I have no remains to be done.

would not be a bad way to leave this world, but before that, much work love. Of this knowledge, of life, of the person who opened hearts. It I felt. I swear, there were moments when I thought I would simply die of the chest, the pain and bliss of a heart opening anew, and everything else what the poet spoke of... I cannot convey the sensation of an explosion in about love, devotion, bhakti. Oh, how I realized with my entire being. Having been there, I understood Kumi's poetry to its very core, his words knowing.

illustration of the Unity of all in this world – Knowledge, the Knower, the of the one who has attained heights and the one being taught was an statement revealed itself to me gradually. The mutual, unceasing progress Teacher learns from his students – and the extraordinariness of this so that the disciple perceives the Guru as his own child. He explained: the never before heard

three aspects of the teacher in the Indian philosophical system, but had your teacher, your friend, your parent, and your child." I knew of the you? How old are you? During the conversation he said: "The Guru is I moved closer and introduced myself, answering his questions: "Who are usually sat at the far end of the hall, but obeying a gesture from the Guru... On the second day of my stay, I realized I had finally arrived home. I

the study of electromagnetism against the backdrop of Time, retrofitted to Jewish is incorrectly translated as “the study of light”; it is not that. It is

Not an absence of enthusiasm, but an absence of long-term hopes.

dynamic peculiarity of mine, which is present in my astrological chart... full of hope. I myself am simply not like that. This is a very strange one own gratification – and I am glad to help those in need. I like people are merely conduits of information. We exist to do work for others, not for one's bath is... This is part of the work of oracles. After all, those like me present karma, and try not to judge anyone, knowing how long each Meeting many people, I observed their nature, saw the roots of their and know unity.

may finally understand the absence of difference between all that exists, discard or accept, to grieve and rejoice – endlessly, tirelessly, so that it the soul. It passes through numerous incarnations, learning to discern, to while at the same time giving birth to a deep respect for the many lives of Astrology develops an understanding of the futility of human existence, the planets – not in a Vedic, but in a logic key. I help those in need. God. And I finally began to feel comfortable: through the art of reading Any live, individual consciousness, must have something it can present to forever.

After a week spent at the smashan in his presence, my life changed have to leave all inner rubbish at the gate. This I understood very clearly. So, if you intend to go there, to be in the presence of this Guru, you will own fire will know this.

purifies it during life. In short, those who come to such places of their person: the cremation flame purifies the body after death, and yoga where all worldly gross is removed, releasing the inner essence of a choice. Having seen this there, I believed. Smashan is a special place motivation must be devoid of so-called “practical” justifications for At the feet of this Teacher, one must be pure of heart. Intentions and after this current incarnation.

many years ago, I felt my heart was healed. I was ready for the journey. Reading nearly the same words in verses written by the Guru himself bubble that refuses to burst.

cease to exist in your former capacity, having become a vessel of Time. A another dimension of Time, into the entropy of eternity, where you will walked, you have already stepped beyond time, matter, and space. Into follow him to walk the path that yogis who became immortal have. However, if you are able to find such a Teacher, receive his darsan, and goes all the way...

But one yogi in a million (perhaps even that number is an exaggeration) own capacities. We dismiss things we cannot bring ourselves to attempt. communion of the everyday personality that does not even try to know its merely the muttering of a mind frightened by its own limitations, the eternal life are in many respects unattainable, inconceivable. But this is ...The goal of immortality, as he explains it, and the formula for attaining experience had seemed impossible to them.

mind, which had lived and learned so much that assembling all the sadhana and this Teacher have finally charted a course for my self and that I have solved the mysteries of the universe. It is simply that this come together for me, albeit temporarily. Of course, I harbor no illusions life finally put everything in its place. Today, the puzzle of existence has his logic commentaries, conversations with him, and his presence in my No, I did not read this in the Guru's books. I have always known it. But the world.

world is the final product of these forces – and therein lies the beauty of design of Creation, that very Absolute intelligence. Everything in the of Things give birth to Matter, which is in union with the conscious yet arisen but already require ordering. United, Emptiness and the Order Order or Law, which organizes all causes and effects – those that have not entropy, to decay. Entropy lives within space, bound to the universal

out of great need, but to learn to concentrate in any environment, to persevere, I even performed asanas on broken glass in the streets. Not After the collapse of the Soviet Union, during the difficult times of Having studied Hatha Yoga in the early nineties, I taught and practiced it.

interwoven, interconnected, hidden.

numerous aspects of different teachings and traditions. Too many lines, However, I lacked concentration and simply could not cope with the severe commands, and endured everything I tried to manifest through it. I had not mastered; my body knew everything, carried out the most chaotic and immature, and yet I became a good yogi. There was no asana "record-keeping," an organized file system. Of course, my methods were was impatient and uneducated; it had data but lacked a system of definitively choose one tradition seemed simply impossible. The mind ran along several trails at once to reach a single goal – yoga. To would have died of exhaustion. Therefore, I explored diverse paths and taste of what I consumed. Greed was the main driving force; without it, I indigestion. The hunger had to be satisfied, and I did not care about the greedily devoured pieces of information and often suffered from It was a kind of ambitious crusade. Tormented by spiritual hunger, I

pure and shining like a pearl freed from the folds of the mollusk's flesh.

was meant to coalesce and reveal a single meaning, stripped of tinsel, Vedanta, while simultaneously mastering the yoga of the body. All of this At that time, I was trying to assimilate the main currents of Hinduism and be fatal.

light than 18 years ago – and yet past events, goals, and actions proved to places, and teachings. Of course, today everything is seen in a different changed my life resemble a travel journal I left through, recalling people, snapshot of memory (forgive the cliché). The memories of the search that Everything that happened remains in the past, becoming merely a

Denis S., Moscow, Russia

The Second Coming

education. The intense pulse of the city's ever-changing life, the night studying in Varanasi was certainly different from Western academic traditions of kundalini and Kriya Yoga.

about teachers and living logic lineages, but my main interest focused on from within. I studied Sanskrit and Hindi, sought additional information the opportunity to gain an insight into traditional religious education went on, crowds of pilgrims came and went – and for the first time I had The Math was rarely empty; rituals were performed continuously, buses Sampurnanand University.

the degree of Shastri or Acharya at Benares Hindu University or swamis, langams, live and study there for seven years, and then receive ashram, a guesthouse, and the house where the Guru stays. Future births, sacred places, it contained everything needed: a temple, an practiced. This Math, a center of Virashnavism, was one of the so-called intense three months, I lived in the Langamwadi Math in Varanasi and And answers. I simply needed to ask the right questions. Over the next bomb. This country offered incredible opportunities for spiritual growth. became my first spiritual mentor. India exploded inside me like a time Kasbi Jagadgurur, Shri Chandrasekhar Shivascharya Mahaswamiji, In January 2005, I received initiation into the Vira Shiva lineage, and

such a place. It exists, but it is an inner space, not a geographical point.

widespread among Russians, and many seekers believe in the existence of in Russia. Probably that is why the search for a spiritual Shamshala is so injustice. Too many restless souls dwell there. I felt spiritually vulnerable was born – quite tragic, excessively permeated with violence and Perhaps the answer was hidden in the karmic history of the place where I motives. My goal was known to me, but what was the true motive? Even the most sincere seekers are deceived by their own hidden aims and

India, which led me to Kriya Yoga, would not have happened.

explorations, however naive they were, the continuation of the search in will. Without these early stages, without patha yoga, without the demonstrate the body's capabilities. And to give hope to others, if you

continuation to the foundation of knowledge already built, however. Yes, I definitely needed the help of someone who could give form and sacred texts, a teacher is needed."

understanding. To grasp not the linguistic, but the spiritual aspect of the could not understand. Without a Guru, you will not have complete studied Sanskrit for almost sixty years, but much of what is written in it I One of the professors, after observing me for some time, said: "I have

Knowledge.

needed different codes, different keys, but there were no shortcuts to immerse myself in Hinduism as deeply as those who were born here. I I belonged to another world: my cultural baggage did not allow me to would take me an entire lifetime.

different from reality, and that absorbing this colossal body of material that my notions of learning within the Hindu tradition were strikingly connected to another. Conversing with scholars and sages, I realized knowledge, I understood: each discipline requires time, one topic is became a turning point. Standing before a mountain of ancient level of knowledge. Never. And the realization of my own limitations With practice. It was then that I understood I could never attain the same

with

knowledge through a comprehensive traditional education combined quote books; he practiced all of this, being a monk who had received about Vedanta, Advaita, Brahman, and Atman. This man did not merely Every day, our group of students met with the teacher, who spoke to us first time, I realized its immensity.

were complex, tangled. I gained access to certain knowledge. And for the permeated with the most diverse signals and signs: feelings and thoughts mental and physical state, then crumble it again. Everything was of new information. Daily life would sometimes smooth the fabric of my grates by the river opened something in me, and I absorbed every particle colors, the narrow streets, the smell of smoke from burning pyres on the

something click inside me, and I experienced a flow of strange, heavy
can become a line of communication. Looking at the photo, I felt
person: any image is descriptive. But for one who needs a sign, an image
I had always believed that no photograph can reveal the essence of a
his own Teacher, he realized yogi Shailendra Sharma.

then, at some point in the conversation, he showed me a photograph of
asking a few questions which, in my opinion, were insignificant. And
Tripathi listened to my disjointed story attentively and sympathetically,
my interest in yoga and mentioned that I was seeking a Guru. Mr.
me to K. M. Tripathi, the head of the department of yoga. To him I told of
moved and went to the Benares Hindu University, where he introduced
Math said he knew the person I needed. Without delay, we got on his
...A couple of days after visiting the temple, one of the swamis at the
carried me forward.

existential forces, which took control of subsequent events, seized me and
and asked for a Teacher and a teaching. And from that moment, certain
unfurnished ideas, flashes of various impulses, but I suppressed all of that
that moment, my head was overflowing with fragments of thoughts,
it." It was not a play of imagination, but a valuable and timely counsel. At
voice: "Just think of what matters most. Make a wish, and He will fulfill
sanctum. Approaching the Shivalingam, I heard a soft whisper of an inner
queue for the famous Vishwanath Kashi temple, I entered the inner
First Teacher of Yoga, Adi Guru Shiva. One day, after standing in a long
is believed that a seeker can find a spiritual guide only by the grace of the
For any yogi, personal presence in the sacred city of Shiva is important; it
my request. Yet it was heard.

temples, spoke with various people—and still could not clearly formulate
performed ablutions in the Ganga, did puja and recited mantras, visited
and yet still at a distance. I wandered the streets of the Old City,
anything. I intuitively felt: everything necessary was within arm's reach.
It is true that Varanasi creates a time and space in which one can wish for
carelessly it had been laid.

and I cannot initiate you into Kriya until you obtain permission from your teacher me?” When I finally asked this question, Gururji said: “Guru is Guru, always, repeating the key phrase: “Can I become your disciple? Will you be my disciple? Questions hung in the hot, sticky air. I stayed there for seven days. I was my Guru. But what next? Would he agree to accept me as a student? I was my own restless and learning mind. Intuition had not failed me: the ceiling of the room was often out, but I did not care. What troubled me was the electricity that could have revived the small fan under the eaves of the palace. It was May: the daytime temperature rose above 100°F. Gururji received me warmly and even allowed me to stay in one of the rooms. At that moment was relief: I had come to the right place.

But when I saw him, everything became absolutely unimportant. All I felt was to be with the Guru. Weak, exhausted, a greenish color, I entered the house, reached Govardhan, now I entered the gates of the ashram, or who led continued for a long time. I do not remember how or exactly when I was initiated. I vomited, I sweated terribly, and this brutal cleansing. The journey was far from comfortable. On the train, I was severely ill.

I strongly desired—a map of the route and a method by which I could meet Govardhan, to see, to be seen, to ask, and perhaps to receive what I so ever guaranteed, but one must take risks. With this thought, I set off for initiation. There was no certainty that I could obtain diksha. Nothing is directed to foreigners to Shailendra Sharma, but not one had received. Mr. Tripathi advised me to go to this Guru in person. He had already been given immediately to anyone who asked.

It broadened my horizons. The yoga I was seeking existed, but this teaching was the history of existing logic, lineages and practices, and all of this academic in nature. I listened to lectures on Kundalini yoga, hatha yoga, daily, asking questions and receiving answers. Our sessions were purely for the better. Over the following two weeks, I visited K. M. Tripathi. If you are moving in the right direction, reality definitely begins to change energy—powerful and real.

surprised to see a crazy Russian with a backpack, soaked through, but high-ranking spiritual officials—acharyas—in the hall. Of course, he was protocols (not out of disrespect, but out of ignorance), there were twenty ... When I entered the hall, greeting my jagadguru and disregarding all

locals were very friendly; no incidents or delays occurred.

to encountering an alien, and I was a rare curiosity. But the police and bus. Even in 2003, seeing a pale-faced European in South India was akin journey took about three days: two train transfers and several hours by patience to wait for the jagadguru's return, and I set off again. The and even more followers gathered there annually. I did not have the southern state of Karnataka. All five jagadgurus, about 12,000 samnyasis, Kudala-Sangama, one of the important centers of Vaishnavism in the Arriving in Varanasi, I learned that my jagadguru had departed for

needed to focus better.

indicated that any beginning can be difficult, fortune is fickle, and I talk. Then he helped with a train ticket to Varanasi. All these signs chief, himself a student of Sanskrit, took an interest in me and came to well: the police assumed I was not a drug addict, but a student. The police The Sanskrit textbooks found among my remaining belongings served me to in a hospital in Gorakhpur, and the first person I saw was a policeman. neck. A pity. The drink laced with the drug was so potent that I only came small silver Shivalingam in a tiny pouch that I wore on a cord around my taken, only some small change, along with the money. They also cut off a sedatives, and I lost consciousness. Fortunately, my passport was not grandmothers and grandfathers, offered me juice mixed with strong ... On the train to Gorakhpur, a kind family with children, elderly

I know on an overcrowded train, I made another transfer.

dubious agency. This did not work, and I had to leave Jammu. Reaching where I hoped to resolve immigration matters with the help of some A night train delivered me to Delhi; from there I headed to Kashmir, to extend my visa.

current Teacher." Obviously, I had to hit the road again. Besides, I needed

both Teachers. And it seems I have received everything I asked for: this is eighteen years have passed. Today, I feel an unbreakable connection with outsiders, so this aspect did not trouble me or create particular difficulties. interests lies beyond the secular goals of society. I had always been an "return." They live and often succeed in worldly life, yet the focus of their ticket, and most people who truly immerse themselves in it usually do not not always clear where exactly it will lead. This discipline is a one-way techniques but also motivation. Even after many years of sadhana, it is brahmara, dharmara, dharma, and samadhi. The Guru transmits not only in Kriya, the last five parts of Patanjali's yoga are realized: brahmayama, from the Teacher, far from India.

sure I could achieve the same effects in practice outside the ashram, far everything on their own, and I worked diligently. Although I was not Teacher does not perform sadhana for the disciple; each must achieve of this happened solely due to the presence of the Guru. Of course, the adventures. The integrity of perception and awareness increased, and all being near Gururaj, I was finally able to exhale after all the travels and before.

enter the unknown space of the Self, which I had never encountered new stream of sensations and cleansed all the mental sludge. I dared to transformation. Physical, mental, informational. The practice opened a me the first level of kriya, and this became the beginning of a Govardhana, and on June 6, 2003, Gururaj Shri Shailendra Sharma taught The railway saga continued. A few days later, I returned again to beneficial for me.

proved that the combination of Kriya and Vetschavism was strong and There was not a shadow of conflict between these traditions, and time condition that I would keep the vows in the practice he had given me. the Guru if I could receive initiation into Kriya yoga. He agreed, on the ashram, in a small village not far from Bishpur. On the way there, I asked to stay at the Math, and the next day we all set off for a recently built with an undiminished flame in his red, sleepless eyes. I was given a place

twentieth-century movement in philosophy and literary theory. It usually
The postmodern philosopher [footnote: Postmodernism — a late-
Daniela L., Mexico, Canada

The Philosophy of Healing and the Healing of a Philosopher

clearly, without distortion.

and reflects our mental states, like a mirror — so that we can see ourselves
disciples, Gurji watches over us. Rarely intervening, he simply observes
to my own self. Always present in the thoughts and hearts of his
simply because I must — there is no other motivation than the duty owed
every remaining answer will come from the sadhana itself. I practice
the mind, Krishna dissolved doubt. And if the process unfolds correctly,
My seeking and finding, at last, defeated the initial confusion. By stilling
practice of Krishna.

...greater balance. Perhaps this serenity itself is the highest aim of the
came from a land that still calls to me. But I travel less now and feel
wisdom passed on to me together with blessings, and the grace I received,
understanding flows as one stream, feeding the lake of the mind. The
and today I am grateful for the knowledge gathered. Now, all acquired
reveals itself to me. Spiritual thirst made me drink from many sources,
gurus received, the power of holy places, deities, and teachers slowly
metaphysical backpack. The meaning of different techniques and
enormous baggage, extracting more and more various things from the
After many years of travel and learning, I am slowly unpacking my
confidence in our own strength.

feel. To grow, to move forward, to develop emotional independence and
grace support all disciples, and yet we must learn to stand on our own
special, pure, and powerful creative energies. The Guru's power and his
Gurji. There, at the ashram, everything is saturated with completely
but I do not dwell on it. I would like to be in Coarjahan more often, near
a blessing and an immense gift. I understand the importance of the base

When I chose to study philosophy, I thought it was the right tool, capable
their own self.

talking too much. Fixated on their own, I rather than seeking to know
I observed many like me — wandering, restless, endlessly rummaging and
into a map by which I could trace my own steps. I felt lost, scattered. And
the cause of being. And yet, none of these experiences would assemble
one. That current does not need to know 'Why' in order to be — it is itself.
All these sources bring into a universal current of energy, and in it we are
modern seekers: plant medicines, traditional ceremonies, sacred dances.
I was a wanderer, experimenting with the instruments available to
why I should exist.

from impatience. I needed a signal, a justification for why I should be,
like a hungry chick, waiting for it to turn into wisdom. And I suffered
experimental attempts to apprehend reality. I fed my mind impressions
sensed and the invisible — all of this fed my investigative and
the eternal saga of the feminine and the masculine, the riddles of the
meaning of life. The play of quality, the contrasts of light and shadow,
many different pairs of shoes, driven by the desire to find the secret
paths. Looking back over what I have lived, I feel I have worn down
own traces, telling the stories of their lives, erasing or recreating their.
Am that humans are autobiographical animals, capable of finding their
That Therefore I Am'.) wrote in his book *The Animal That Therefore I*
his best-known works is the book *L'Animal que donc je suis* ('The Animal
philosophy, though he himself never used the word 'postmodern'. One of
authorities associated with poststructuralism and postmodernist
developing the philosophy of deconstruction. One of the principal
08.10.2004) — a French philosopher of Algerian origin, known for
calls them.] Jacques Derrida [footnote: Jacques Derrida (12.01.1930 –
music, literature, and religion can be whatever their creator or follower
another's, a specific work of art is no better than any other. This means art
opinions change and one person's opinion cannot be more correct than
the 19th centuries. But simply, postmodernism declares: since people's
questions the basic propositions of Western philosophy from the 17th to

when it became my new reality. I began assisting in classes, and yoga have considered such a turn absolute madness... right up to the moment Nothing of the sort had ever been in my plans, and before this I would said goodbye to my academic career, deciding to become a yoga teacher. and the new experience changed everything for me. Three months later I yoga, a yoga space, a yoga institute. I met a team of remarkable teachers, means house, dwelling, studio. In the context of yoga, it is a school of In that studio, the Mysore Shala [footnote: Shala — in Sanskrit shala body, however, was in no hurry to surrender its secrets.

far more ancient secrets than the limited intellectual, logical mind. The and their interrelations — to the rigorous discipline of a body that knew myself into another. From intellectual attempts to grasp existential laws hidden nature, the wild and crazy part of me. From one extreme I threw almost martial physical discipline, an ideal method for balancing my another set of metaphysical formulas. This yoga turned out to be an for my inner restlessness. I hoped it would be effective, unlike theory or corrects and assists when needed. Yoga was meant to be the medicine seduction of asanas at his or her own pace while the instructor only style of Ashtanga-vinyasa yoga in which each practitioner performs a set and brings into Ashtanga yoga in the Mysore style [footnote: Mysore is a and, gathering my courage, I finally decided to step into the unknown from the university where I was studying. It was my thirty-third birthday, morning in Quebec. That day I walked into a yoga studio across the street It seems my 'hardening' reached its peak one especially grim, snowy needing help, fighting inner demons, longing for healing.

new — many pass through similar experiences in search of salvation, obliged to 'extract value' from my study of philosophy. None of this is made me 'set'. And again I felt cut off from others, and on top of that end, what allowed me to open up to the world also made me harder, and savored how it calmed the mind with a vision of purpose. But in the philosophy became my life for a long time. Diving into it, I breathed it in consuming feeling of Non-being that had stalked me since childhood. So of helping me overcome the constant sensation of the abyss, the all-

the storyboard of slides of local daily life flashing past the window. unfamiliar speech mixed with the cacophony of the approaching day and opening up a strange new world. The drive was long, the sounds of back seat, embracing my fears, I watched the sun slowly dissolve the mist, version of myself, one that would respond to life differently. Sitting in the of brass, when the impossible becomes real. The only wish was for a new speaking a foreign language to go I knew not where. It was that very shift home and no numbers to call, I climbed into a taxi with a stranger and I felt almost comfortable. Alone, immediately lost, with no working moon was rising, the Indian night threw a veil of mist over my shoulders. Twenty hours later I walked out of the Delhi airport building. A full Quebec were just beginning to turn yellow.

have imagined ending up there. As I boarded the plane, the leaves in Crazy, isn't it? That country had never interested me, and I could never after my ignominious departure from academia, I bought a ticket to India. Deciding to spend wisely the last savings remaining in my bank account again.

nihilism. Though my ideas about the particulars of this yoga were rather absolute faith in the discipline of practice as an antidote to the abyss of beginning to follow me. There was nothing to lose. All that remained was The moment was ideal — the shadow of mid-life crisis was already searching for an effective medicine. The time had come to start taking it. story unfolding around me: consciously or unconsciously I was still The theme of healing ran like a red thread through the fabric of every out for good.

containing my 'madness', but I wanted to unhook the lid so it could come changes that came with it. I listened carefully. Ashtanga yoga was Guru, India, sadhana — but not discussing the practice itself, only the One day I overheard teachers talking about Kritya yoga, mentioning their and movement, even philosophy... began pinning together many things from my past: my interest in dance

physical. I had barely experienced this in dance practices.

subtle bodies, contours or lighting of impulses, both mental and palpable energies or perfectly distinguishable areas, glowing cocoons of Yes, I see certain things, and this capacity is part of me. Sometimes it is My vision began again (or rather, the inner Vision switched on again).

Yoga was the burning arrow I followed through the dark.

or illness, the desire to find a time and place in which I could return to companion. Even if at times practice was impossible because of journeys than suppressing it. Throughout my travels Krishna remained my constant whisper of the everyday, buttressing perception, nurturing creativity rather my responsibility. Sadhana kindles the inner flame, pointing up the direction of the wind or rain. All these concerns lie within the sphere of is skin to building a fire: you need enough wood, you must watch the me, and I do not worry much if for some reason I miss a day or two. Krishna goal of all my actions taken together. Morodiy imposed this practice on responsibility, one I still cannot fully understand. It seems this yoga is the experiment in faith in the unknown. An experiment for which I bear full It so happened that this practice became for me the most engrossing left to lose.

by the words of Janis Joplin: 'Freedom is just another word for nothing many, and I tried to take that in. At that time it was expressed beautifully the Guru said that the very concept of 'freedom' is incomprehensible to and I saw in it a path toward a new perception of inner freedom. Though barely understood, I wanted the new discipline to direct my daily actions, of the difficulties of the path. That suited me — I had to follow a goal I On the day of my arrival I asked Gururji for initiation, and he warned me

coexisted here in a strange, naked, vivid harmony.

insects and bands of purple monkeys. Every bird, plant and animal this ancient portal to death spoke of life and breathed it: stones and trees, Everything here was beyond what is considered ordinary: everything in practice in a slightly dusty palace room that smelled of incense and rats. ...A week later I was recalling those moments, doing my first Krishna

access to the hidden meaning of the Codex and reclaimed this wisdom. have been revived under the guidance of the abuelas, who have gained up, by Catholic priests after the Spanish invasion. In our day these rites descriptions of ceremonies. These documents, or Codex, were gathered millennia into archives preserving images of ritual calendars and of this tradition, and much of what is known now reaches back through women's circles of wisdom. There are differing theories about the origin ...The Mexican abuelas, the elder-women, have long been gathering Moon.

south of Mexico, where the earth was joined by its umbilical cord to the me clues helping me to navigate. At some point the path led me to the on my own. Fortunately, during my wanderings I met people who gave into inaccessible places, providing the gear with which I could then climb summit of the mountain. Substances as healing tools helped me capture a textbook of Hindu philosophy I read about many paths leading to the them to myself as deeply intimate experiences connecting me with life. In justly myself. I rarely discuss these experiences at all, preferring to keep some may argue about the value of such methods, but I feel no need to subconscious level.

to get high and watch colorful pictures, but to receive knowledge at a help of stimulants. The visions allowed me to see different things, not just liberation led me to various healing practices, and not always with the body utterly astonished me, becoming in many ways liberating. And that something heavy, burdensome, and the realization that I was not my shells, and that they are not us. In that period of life the body felt like Then, for the first time, I realized that our bodies are subtle and fragile is breathing!" She answered, "Yes!

of its surface, and I turned to a friend: "Do you feel this? This whole place wall behind my back began to breathe, with every pore, every molecule from clarity to the state in which the medicine (acid) began to act. The a rare, remembering the precise moment when consciousness flipped When I was fifteen, I first experienced an altered state of consciousness at

This yoga drew me because it is what I must do. Not because it is ceremonial healing plants. Now I think Kriya, too, is a kind of medicine. Lights. Earlier I could enter this space only through the portal of always remembering: folding geometric figures, spinning many-colored circle opens many portals; it is never empty there, and something is came from the middle of the radiant Kutasra. The screen of the dark things had previously arisen only in the practice of Kriya, where visions. Why this life?, found its answer in the form of visible energy. Such The mind poured into a multidimensional space, where the question another continent, summoned by other tribes, other traditions.

patron of arts and wisdom.] — it was strange and stirring to see them on and Parvati, elephant-headed, remover of obstacles, god of fertility, [footnote: Ganesh — one of the most revered Hindu deities. Son of Shiva saw a mandala open in the sky, and from it emerged myriads of Ganeshas combined become instruments of transformation. On one of those nights I harmonization. The healing force of movement, dance, song, and fasting elements and switches on the energy needed for healing and dance possesses its own power, each engages various aspects of the drummers seated in a circle, guides the dancers. Each fragment of the and remembers them, and the heartbeat of the enormous drum, played by the ancient Marathi language I do not understand, but the body absorbs woman works with on a personal and collective level. The sacred songs in represents specific attributes and energies of the healing wheel that each intertwining and swallowing each other. Each direction of the circle four directions, folding into geometric patterns recalling four serpents white, dancing under the full moon for four nights. The dance unfolds in part in the ceremony. Imagine two hundred women of all ages, dressed in to, because usually it is the cause of painful changes. Nevertheless, I took And again I followed an insistent inner voice that at first I refused to listen includes fasting and dancing, once a year, at full moon.

...the opportunity for self-healing through nine-year initiations. The ritual Mexican elders have created a space offering women

My goal in Kritya goes beyond the intention to become better. This Goal walk.

I am simply inviting you to smile at the length of the path I still have to pretend, but even if it does, I will not apologize for the pathos. Rather, One day I would like to dissolve into infinity. I hope it does not sound too made, and we all are.

substance. That which lives within me, beyond the matter of which I am responsible for the practice that lets me glimpse my immortal moving, to live. It is precisely that inspiration that made me take full This yoga is not only a healing medicine, but also an inspiration to keep dependable.

than five minutes, the Kritya discipline that the Guru follows is supremely the mightily pure. In a world where any fashion or trend lives no longer might with which he holds and directs energies invisible to others during the practice, in his life at this ancient smashan, and in the unshakable seriously, I feel that Gururaj's super-power lies in his absolute devotion to know no one can be completely sure of that. Anything is possible. But what his super-powers are. Although I do not think he levitates at night, I sometimes I am asked why I practice, who Shailendra Sharma is, and troubles your spirit lies within you. And I feel boundless gratitude.

the courage to see yourself and to keep going. The healing of what gradually allow me to meet myself. The smashan tells me: 'I see you.' have watching the other disciples. The place and the processes it sets in motion every day see Gururaj, drinking in the generosity of his answers and return to Govardhan, where I practice in the dark halls of the palace and Where will this striving toward self-healing lead me? As often as I can, I for the first time.

Honestly, I cannot explain it more clearly, since I am speaking about this draw out of what I have seen, to connect with this mysterious portal. Kritya is far deeper. It helps to dispel my darkness, to focus on what I something I 'consume', or that carries me into a world of dreams. No,

greyish fabric had long since lost its original whiteness. The ensemble was the same well-laundered cloth and an ancient kurtas whose resembled a quilt, though he served no one. In the hot summer months made of the same rhinoceros hide as the Guru's kundalas. The puari thin, wiry, with a smoothly shaven head, he wore heavy black kundalas

The Puari

He perceives this as a healing remedy for the world and for myself.

Practice I see the flame of the Guru's quilt and the grey he pours into the me to Mexico, where I now live, very far from India. But every night in order to heal the past. Then you will find peace. All these revelations led responsibility rests upon you to accept this and to correct your actions, in sacred plant. Mother Aya said: 'You descend from a race of colonizers, the ... This truth rang for me like a bell during a healing ceremony with a change the future.

teaches us to read the history of our spirit. Such understanding can personal past, it is impossible to step into the future — and the Guru disposable containers of bodies. Without an understanding of the leave. Today we continue to carry ancient spirits in the modern we are not responsible are recorded within us and define the imprint we everything that happened in past generations, before us. Events for which Within us lie dormant powerful memories, the DNA of ancestors, tracks, but it is impossible to hide them entirely. Everything remains. 'autobiographical animals', we reinvent ourselves and cover the old freedom. Perfect in my imperfection, I keep going. And yes, we are perfectly imperfect, and accepting this fact has brought me absolute Accepting one's own humanity is the most honest thing one can do. I am spirit, and there is nothing more occult.

Do I think this is an occult practice? Yes. It nourishes the alchemy of may mean.

Perhaps I will meet my true I, though to this day I have no idea what that lies in awakening the subconscious, and it is to transform consciousness.

the ritual twice a day. Afterward, the temple had to be carefully cleaned, gautra blossoms and incense were purchased daily and prepared before Chae, milk, yogurt, honey, garlands of fresh marigolds, roses or jasmine, a temple.

renovated the old wooden pavilion that they had decided to convert into and installed. Narendra took on the preparations for the bus and comrade-in-arms — he worked hard. When the Shivalingam was found months to Sarathi, and in 1994 he came to the smashtan. Heiber, manager, temporarily settled in a small ashram. From there they moved for a few and got into a passing truck to Virudavan, where the Guru had. On the 2nd of October 1995, he tossed the keys to the shop to his brother had not felt in many years.

generally put in the Guru's presence his heart was filled with a peace he man of peculiar disposition, expecting nothing good from life or people in not the last. Narendra Sharma began visiting the yogi regularly. He was a healed him in three days. That was the first problem the Guru solved, but during fits of violent coughing, the yogi gave him some medicine that. Having observed the man with the absent gaze that did not even change by his excessive fondness for smoking charitas, and nothing brought relief. CWalior. At that time Narendra was suffering from a severe cough caused. One day a nephew brought him to a young yoga Guru living near

objects. And he knew that metal is sturdier and more reliable than people. acquainted with all the possible properties of iron, steel, or aluminum in the past, Narendra Sharma had worked with metal and was well was filled with knowledge of human imperfections — including his own. because he was challenging or expressed superiority, simply because he. Those who accidentally did catch his eye felt small and insignificant. Not in his utterly emotionless gaze, grey like the sky in monsoon season. the locals tried to avoid meeting the busiati's eyes, unwilling to be reflected. And although the dry features of his dark face expressed nothing, even for busi supplies had an almost hypnotic effect on pilgrims passing by. completed by heavy necklaces of large rudrakshas. His daily bicycle trips

slowly from the loss. Weekly visits from his niece with her newborn for the period of mourning the bulas were stopped. The Curu recovered clicking softly on the stone slabs.

Gingri stepped back and slowly turned toward the kitchen, his hooves to shoo the animal away. Alone in this country of cows and people, Curu saw sweet flowers of the red hibiscus. Mahatmaji started and waved his hand lived on the estate a couple of years. Devahuti had often fed him the Curu Gingri approached the bulari and sniffed his shoulder. Curu had of the water, and his face was wet with tears. The male antelope known as The day after her cremation he sat by the pond, looking at the still surface other women.

perhaps the only woman he respected. He felt no particular regard for on time, to smile at the gossip. Apart from his mother and sisters, she was Mahatmaji, sometimes teasingly reminding him to change his dhori, to eat smooth running of the mechanism. It was she who looked after behind the daily events, the well-oiled motor ensuring the uninterrupted, the cement holding their life on the smashan together, the joyful force After the death of Devahuti, Mahatmaji fell into a stupor. She had been for old friends.

his feet. For the most part he remained indifferent, saving his rare smiles visitors coming to the Curu began to show him respect as well, touching 'Mahatma-ji', and the nickname stuck. Narendra did not object. Gradually, occasionally wore. It was the Curu who, in jest, began calling him Candhi was deepened by the round-framed reading glasses he prayaschitta, he shaved his head, and his resemblance to Mahatma bulas, since he could not miss it. Preparing for the cleansing ritual of set out for Delhi for the cremation ritual, but returned in time for the night On the day Narendra Sharma received the news of his mother's death, he already a respite from worldly life...

oil lamps. There were no holidays, because every day at the smashan was dhuni, he would blow the bull's horn, then strike the drum and light the and all this was his responsibility. When the Curu kindled the fire in the

'existential crisis' would have been apt, though it would have sounded too devoting him, but no one could identify the cause. Perhaps the term looked at least twenty-five years older. Some strange emptiness was only shoulders. Only two months younger than the Guru, the bull shaving his head, and a mane of snow-white hair reached down to his rasping, as if a sick bird were trying to clear its throat. He stopped. The sound of the bull's horn that he blew before bulls became weak and

preparing for the evening rituals, but mostly stayed in his room.

Like a silent ghost, limping, he made his way around the temple. Summer of 2017 he had grown so thin that his clothes nearly slid off him. talkative before, he was now silent for entire days at a time. By the Meanwhile Mahatmaji withdrew ever more into himself. Not particularly details and causes of the phenomenon...

was so affected by the waves of this power that no one bothered with the because the source now resided in the statue of the Goddess, yet everyone and it was different from the intoxicating energy felt before. Perhaps

A new, powerful presence had established itself on the smasman,

eyes of Devi were inlaid.

was reflected in hundreds of black-and-white diamonds with which the warm air, mingling with the scent of flowers, and the flame of oil lamps main avenue. In the early evening the sweet aroma of incense filled the which the Goddess gazed at visitors approaching the house along the and became part of the house. There they installed a stone altar from on the stone floor, the previously open terrace was completely glazed in brass was installed in the southern hall of the house. A red carpet was laid running about everywhere when a large statue of Devi made of gleaming Nearly two years passed: the little girl had grown and was already

At least, that is how it looked. In the end the Guru began to smile back.

meaningless bubbling grimace of an infant, but the smile of an old friend. would gaze up at him gravely and occasionally smile. It was not the daughter helped the healing process. Lying on the Guru's lap, the child

of the disciples, then wandered for some time from one acquaintance to word to anyone. Surfacing in Cwalior, he first stayed in the house of one Mahatmaji said nothing. The next morning he disappeared without a preferable to stay and face the consequences, however heavy.

could earn a living. The Guru told him that for the puja, it would be life here? Mahatmaji answered that he still remembered his trade and 'What are you going to do in the world after more than twenty years of When the puja finished, the Guru asked a purely practical question: immediately.

pregnant. A scandal was inevitable; he wished to leave the smashan liaison with a married woman of the sweeper caste, and she was Without raising his eyes, he told the Guru that he had entered into a At the end of September, after the evening puja, Mahatmaji spoke. the meaning of the message remained unclear for several months more. and observant prahmashanis, was clearly giving some kind of sign, but attention to the smallest occurrences. Hanuman, the protector of ascetics visitors, but the Guru had lived on the smashan too long and paid close position. This minor event would certainly have gone unnoticed by Rolling by itself from left to right, it returned again to its previous normally rested on the gilded pas-relief of the deity suddenly moved. In July 2017, during the puja to Hanuman, the large decorative mace that and loudly...'. The puja shook his head in silent refusal.

marriage for you? A woman could take care of you, manage the cooking At one point the Guru asked him directly: 'Maybe we should arrange a Guru had to remind him of skipped sequences and forgotten ingredients. to smile weakly. He grew more and more absent-minded; during puja the his food, and for a while the puja would come back to life and even try Sometimes the Guru would play him songs from old Bollywood films on had eaten anything, whether he had left his room that day...

alone. On such days the Guru would ask the workers whether the papa elaborate. Mahatmaji began skipping meals and lived on tea and chapatis

With disciples, 5010

and the thin blade of sound pierced the darkness.

Now before him the Guru himself blew into the gold-inlaid bull's horn and attention.

and the abundance of the harvest depends on the thoroughness of care sown, like dry hay. Motives of action grow from the seed of past karma; accumulated over years of austerity and obedience can burn up in one Human dramas are often as ordinary as everyday feats. Merits as nameless as the others.

to Mahatma's room in the palace was locked, and after a while it became the puja, the Guru gave the same terse answer: 'He has retired'. The door during puja the Guru was assisted by a new helper. When asked about wife. Now the puja's usual place was taken by random visitors, and renovation — the walls and columns of the room again became spotlessly imprint of his nap. But the silhouette was painted over during the next lean still preserved a faint outline of his shoulders and an almost invisible the darsan hall now stood empty. The wall on which the puja used to The place where Mahatma had sat for many years opposite the Guru in money for expenses.

time Guruji arranged a rented room for him and gave him a small sum of lost inside it, or both together. Narendra Sharma went on living. After a life itself befall the former puja. Whether he had lost his mind or was suicide by throwing himself under a train. But nothing more tragic than absent expression. Someone remembered that his brother had committed railway station, gazing through the scurrying crowds with the same smashan, who might reach him even here. Once he was seen at the did not take off the kundalas, explaining that he feared the ghosts of the the thick beard, the worn clothes, and the somnambulist expression. He made an unforgettable impression on visitors with the shock of grey hair, nails. Sitting all day in the little shops of his temporary benefactors, he another. He remained mostly silent. He also stopped cutting his hair and

the first and most ancient link the 'driver' establishes with the 'vehicle',
brain, and the brain sends the body confirmation of its existence. This is
unchanged. Bodily sensations and mental conclusions send signals to the
how a person falls or how high he strives to rise, the sense of 'I' is
takes physical form. Regardless of all achievements, regardless of how
arises with the first breath, but the Self exists before the individual soul.
The strongest feeling in every being is the sense of self, 'I am'. It is said if
his work was to turn it into Knowledge.

questioning had been exhausted, information continued to come in, and
remained an industrious student of life. Even when it seemed that
and boredom, daily service and yoga were the guarantors of progress. He
monotonous diet. Yet sadhana helped him avoid the traps of ego, satiety,
triumph is hard. The mind, having reached its goal, grows weary of the
one reach the goal, but to keep living in a state of eternal striving for
achieved. The adrenaline of dreaming, desiring, and anticipating helps.
It is difficult enough to maintain daily what has already been created and
circumstances were forced to adapt to his schedule.

remained unchanged regardless of circumstance. In essence,
he kept conducting puja to Shiva, practicing, teaching, and the schedule
it is crucial that he does this small thing. Daily, weekly, monthly, yearly,
greatness. What a man achieves in a day may be infinitely small, and yet
The smallness of a man is regarded as the inevitable condition of his

The Guide. The Man and the Myth

Conversations with Disciples

comprehensible to the inner Knower, Shailendra Sharma, From
things and events — elusive but at the same time obvious and
made me who I am. It is sadhana that continues to reveal the essence of
Practice is the foundation and pillar of my life. The practice of Yoga has

*

Discipline

likely the Teachers (Babaji himself or the masters of the parampara) had approximately between 1893 and 1927, seemed deliberately blocked. Most surface of the past hints were absent. Information about his last birth, recent incarnation was hidden from him. However hard he looked at the was made of coconut, of wood, or sometimes of stone. And yet the most with ash, the kamandalu, the ritual water vessel that stood beside him, against his back. Sometimes the body was smeared with clay, sometimes hair was always long, since he could feel the touch of strands of hair often he saw himself by a dhuni; his form changed from life to life. The memory brought him echoes of mantras and the images of deities. Most once sat by fires — in caves, at hunting huts, in nomad camps — but had tended a flame for some ritual. Of course, the ancestors of all people. Whenever he happened to sit by a fire, he was certain that in the past he was no discovery; he had already known it since he was five years old.

confirmation that throughout many incarnations he had been a yogi. This he did so with interest and a certain trembling. Thus came the subconscious that allowed him to explore some of his previous lives, and persistent sadhana, became both Teacher and Knower. It was the to many questions arrived of themselves. The subconscious, awakened by that occurred, the identity of the spirit was established, and the answers be established with that spirit, in the most literal sense. And as soon as it was not the radiant spirit he had met in sadhana. Closer contact had to acceptance of self. And yet he retained the distinct feeling that the present spots, gathered together, this understanding crystallized into a complete own personality, its roots, karmic connections, hidden traumas, and blind ... All these years he had studied and known intimately the aspects of his

the karmic knots of the past and fulfilling its assigned mission.

previous incarnations. And yet it strives to know what is new, untangling. Almost everything has been met, felt, and experienced by the spirit in its so much that it is not surprised by losses, wars, defeats, hunger or plenty. all these stage sets and uses a diverse range of props. It has already seen and again pulls the handle of the door into life. The self travels through Any physical shell inevitably passes into non-being, but the soul again

spiritual swindling could lead to revelation. In a certain sense, he found a Who is guiding whom — and, more importantly, where? In India, even transformation into a spiritual leader did not escape him. The Guide... remembered many passages; the subtle irony of a swindler's utterly charmed by it. Having read The Guide in adulthood, he ...and when he was nine he saw the film made from the novel and was exposed. The book had been published just a year after his own birth, sadhu. The novel had everything: crime, punishment, recognition, and guide, 'Railway Raju', who against his own will became a respected was written by K.K. Narayan. It described the story of a swindler-four... One of his favorite books, with the simple but resonant title The Guide, body, righteous or not, these five are the cause of his actions.

Providence. Whatever action a person performs with heart, word, or the various senses, the various endeavors, and the fifth — Divine five causes that bring every action to completion are the body, the doer, Divine Providence. Everything is just as the Bhagavad Gita describes: 'The results. Karmaic reprogramming requires aspiration, will, and the help of new chains of reactions, and only spiritual education helps to discern the preconditions set in motion the mechanisms of decision-making, create There is no smooth and frictionless spiritual path. Individual karmaic present play.

in the past he had chosen the role (or had been chosen for it) in the of perception. His personal path was predetermined because somewhere the body of a yogi who has attained samadhi, forever altering the settings secondary from the moment the stream of Absolute Mind passes through exert a powerful influence on personality. Only all this becomes Of course, acquired experience, upbringing, education, and worldview the present one, that was enough.

events in the present. What mattered most was that that last life had led to Moreover, memories of the recent life might have restrained the course of present mission without being distracted by echoes of the recent past. decided not to reveal this information so that he could carry out his

of upbringing is difficult, and encouragement is just as necessary as the seeker learns by himself to discern goals and reach them. Such a way shadow of the fear of disappointing the spiritual parent. Like any child of the teaching requires self-discipline, and there is always the faint goes out into the world, the role of the father remains in force. Reception father, regardless of the ages of both. Even when the child grows up and European society realises. The seeker is the child, and the teacher is the The Indian guru-disciple system is far more autocratic than modern possibilities.

one's way through Her labyrinth and emerge onto a plateau of new absolutely all the answers: embodied teachers at best can help one make specifics of culture, time, and place. And only Life Herself knows personality is always permeated by personal experience, coloured by the Her eyes, to listen to Her instructions. The human aspect of the teacher's principal Guru, Life itself. The seeker needs to look no less attentively into spiritual Teacher, people might miss the important meeting with the deification? He thought that, by focusing excessively on the person of the What then would remain if a hypothetical Guru were stripped of all of different people to the same circumstances differed dramatically.

human action. Human nature itself is quite predictable, but the reactions algorithms, and at the same time was struck by the unpredictability of He recognized human archetypes, the repetition of behavioural not respecting people's privacy.

He see through them, read thoughts and the future? He could, but he did manifestation of the divine was received with awe and even fear. Could probe. Recognizing the human sides of the Guru brought relief, while a coordinates, something that could show them the way and give them They needed something with which to align their own social and moral curiosity — all longed to find in the Guru both the divine and the human. Some came timidly and reverently, others insistently and with frank they peered at Raju, who was as a result declared by them to be a saint. likeness to the character in his own story: people peered at him just as

and that someone was the Guru. Regardless of a person's level of literacy, practitioner, the mantra or the technique, someone guided him or her — There is no such thing as independent sadhana. Someone taught the or become the rarest of cases, more like a fairy tale.

Therefore those achievements either remain a product of the imagination (achievements and efforts cannot be verified by any existing criteria: from teacher to disciple) a self-led path is a myth, since the disciple's Guru-shishya concept (the tradition of the transmission of knowledge journey, and some decide to advance without a guide. In the light of the compilation of facts can provide the necessary maps for the spiritual availability of information leads people to believe that a careful must carefully follow the Guru's instructions. The modern variety and so long as illusions and obscurations have not vanished entirely, the logic and the journey may turn into the wrong place,

the most important element in the transmission of knowledge is absent, the spiritual teacher, if there is no acceptance of the Guru's fatherly role, too is human. If there is no friendly relationship between the disciple and needs help and protection, an indirect lesson or a veiled hint. After all, the Teacher helps to solve the riddles of existence, and sometimes himself fact that the Guru, too, is a child, learning through his disciples. Yes, the the relationship between a spiritual Teacher and his disciples lies in the where the Guru is sometimes perceived as a living Deity? The beauty of Guru-disciple system differ from religious dogma? Especially in a culture spiritually in this complicated modern world. But how greatly does the clear coordinate-system for those who are trying to orient themselves. As in earlier times, the personality of the Guru influences the creation of a magnet, anchor, or drug.

the Teacher, whose personality and guidance may become a kind of not seek emotional independence, they feel safe under the protection of liberation. Some disciples advance no farther than a certain level and do attachment or prove personal loyalty, but as a step on the path to severity. Devotion to the Teacher is cultivated not in order to strengthen

Several times he had gone out to see a doctor or to visit a sick aunt, but by any interruption of the appointed order and by his absence.

The spirits invoked nightly by the sounds of the horn would be offended established discipline. The host must be at home if he has invited guests. has begun the daily ritual and lit the fire of the dhuni must observe the and been everywhere. To the most insistent he explained that a yogi who countries. He would answer with a smile: I have already seen everything ask, puzzled, whether he would not like to see the world, to visit different learning that he had not left the ashram since 1993, some visitors would

Sadhana

Teachers was a priceless milestone that changed his life.

appearance of the Mahavatar on the physical plane — the presence of the brought comfort. Like the mental messages from Babaji, and the Satyacharan Lahiri made his presence known, and the Teacher's words was painfully obvious. Then, right after one of the night samadhis, Sri was in suffocating depression and the inevitability of the impending loss Shivalingam. And a few days before the passing of Devanuri, when he Another time the Guru appeared on the eve of the installation of the threats and attacks could at any moment have grown into a full-scale war. body in 1993, when life at the ashram had only just begun and he received the necessary support. The Guru first 'visited' him in the subtle Lahiri he communicated with his teacher only a few times, but he always ...He could confirm this personally. After the passing of Sri Satyacharan

still directs him.

the yogi has become wholly self-confident and self-sufficient, the Guru even the most advanced practitioner does not leave the Guru. Even after and only the Guru can help him through that stage. In the Indian tradition not in cases of independent sadhaks the practitioner reaches a dead end, techniques, nor try to find a shortcut to enlightenment. More often than master. The sadhaks must not compose his own mantras or change practitioner continues to lean on the teaching first given to him by the knowledge of the alphabet remains foundational: year after year the

from the womb, all begin a journey back to a formless state. Hatching of the infant signals the start of a short marathon into nowhere. Emerging confirms past karmic ties between the child and the parents. The first cry. The human body always personifies the past. The very fact of birth through immense worlds extending far beyond gravitational fields.

anticipating the night 'expeditions', during which the mind travelled. The spirit relished daily life through body, senses, and emotions, body still felt the breath of the great Mother.

owls, and he entered Her dreams. When the heart stopped its rhythm, the with closed eyelids to the jollaby of dogs, parking and the tender sobs of swaddled in the cold blanket of mists in winter, the Earth slept listening force that fed the day. Warped in the scent of night-flowers in summer. The sounds of the day fell silent, darkness thickened, fed by the same other way round.

sadhana was the priority. Everything else was built around it, not the day's duties and the intense night yoga complemented one another, but and life itself had become a continuous samadhi of varying intensity. The schedule once established was easy to maintain. Samadhi was part of life, 'Time to get to work'. Practice invariably began at exactly midnight. A After the puja and the evening tea he would say goodbye to those present: samashtan.

in fairy tales, only a pure heart was needed to enter the enchanted least was interesting. Nearly every day someone new turned up, and as life itself constantly renewed the gallery of human archetypes, and that at at paid mass initiations could find their way to him. And they did come. of yoga and were not satisfied with the undemanding techniques taught was no shortage of popularizers. People who wished to find the essence There was no need to spread the good news of Krishna yoga, since there out autographs? He could do that here, on the Land of Liberation.

out there, in the world? Give lectures, receive flower garlands, and hand the night puja proceeded on schedule. And besides, what would he do

timidly to drive out the night. Around 4:30 in the morning the servant ...In the house it was quiet and dark, but the first birds were beginning real — regardless of whether it had astral or gross nature.

phenomena was the beginning of all metamorphoses: all is material and Embraced by Time, the Great Void carried all Matter. The unification of by the fire and alchemy of sadhana, the mind became extraordinary. that many years ago, the realization of the Void began for him. Catalyzed mind through galaxies, between atoms and particles. It was in this way connection with the source. The sound nesting inside him now led the Constant presence in the sound was also an essential part of the consciousness stepping beyond the body.

attainment of the logic state of suspended animation, breathlessness, the non-dual cognition of the world. He insisted that it began only after the of body and mind. It granted total awareness of everything, complete and The eighth limb of yoga, samadhi, was the peak of the difficult evolution shores of probabilities and re-scripting the terrain.

the waves of the awakened subconscious, breaking them against the very moment of the transformation of past into future. Yoga cut through flow of time. To be wholly established in the present meant to observe the wholeness. Samadhi was complete cognition, an absolute grasp of the People kept rediscovering fragments of reality instead of witnessing its the Teachers and to life.

logic sadhana, and he gathered the harvest with resolve and gratitude to sprouting from within him, the shoots of Knowledge rose in the field of life, of understanding the source from which all bodies have come... revelations are the result of comprehending the transformative stages of What does all this have to do with the practice of yoga? Most directly: all spite of them), the present obstinately dreams of becoming the future.

potential possibilities. Perhaps because of infantile memories (or in At first blind and formless, hiding the rudiments of the past, full of from the cocoon of the past, the present becomes the larva of the future.

action'). The second part, niyama, includes virtuous habits, conduct and first limb, yama, includes virtuous self-restraint (non-recommended context. In yoga they are described in the first two of the eight limbs. The attainment of liberation. They have several meanings depending on of activity and habits for healthy life, spiritual enlightenment, and the niyamas and their counterpart yama, are in yoga the recommended kinds principles of Yama and Niyama [footnote: Yamas and Niyamas — the sadhana itself. Usually called the Ten Commandments of yoga, the enough. The remaining moral compasses were honed and reinforced by For practicing yogis the vows established by the paramhansas are quite accelerating modernity.

Promises of heaven or hell seemed too primitive and trivial for the ever-the shadow of guilt even before the action had materialized. So too the of original sin rather vaguely conditioned a potential 'salvation', casting organized religions as the perfect tool for manipulation. The very concept doctrine remained unclear to him. It seemed that sins are necessary to been committed, is there any need to repent in advance? That part of virtually universal. And yet at times he wondered: if the sin has not yet and society ensures their observance. The list of the ten commandments is All religions presuppose strict adherence to morally established codes, burdensome.

sometimes happens in life, even the simplest of duties may in time grow chapter of the Bhagavad Gita every day. This yoga was for life, and as initiated also gave a promise to keep the techniques secret and to read a illness or while travelling, they undertook to practice mentally. The chose to devote themselves to this yoga must practice daily. In case of list was short, and the vows sounded descriptively simple. First, those who By tradition, during initiation the aspirants must give five promises. The

The Five Promises

been.

was there in the room, but needed some time to return from where he had prepared the tea and gently knocked on the door, knowing that Gururji

body, and the alchemy of yoga reveals their essence.

through investigation of their nature. They ferment in the flask of the satisfied, pacified, or dissolved through understanding of their source, an inspired longing or a physical attraction) manifest in order to be desires are ignited by the blazing spirit knowing itself. Desires (whether natural impulses cleans the bath of rubbish, helping one see that all recognizes the dubious results of short-term satisfaction. Discernment of karmas. Observing temptations, the logic mind sees their roots and immature souls: by transgressing the prohibition, the soul multiplied breaking a taboo. In essence, prohibitions are created for the education of more powerful. Continence is the result of logic sadhana, not of fear of torcible — only the mind can transform sexual energies into something refers to the chastity of mind. Control of sexual impulses cannot be senses, but the nature of this state rests on the proper use of energy and Continence, or Brahmacharya, is often perceived as moderation of the

All these moral principles required no commentary.

an alien and disturbing emotion.

absence of greed, is impossible without the inner acceptance of greed as speech, Satya — truthfulness, Asteya — non-stealing... Aparigraha — Ahimsa — non-violence, Shauca — purity of body, mind, intentions, and own self, and that reflection gradually became more distinct.

personality, sadhana became the mirror in which one could study one's preaching tone. There was no need. Yoga itself was changing the logic's Unlike other Gurus, he never spoke about Yama and Niyama in a

happiness could fill the heart with quiet bliss.

half pain, disbel anguish, bring tranquillity. And then a new variety of yoga. Krishna offered the main prize: liberation from rebirth. And it could designation of right and wrong, but the virtues they explained led to realized, liberated state of being (moksha).] were not categorical in their preconditions are considered necessary for the attainment of the self-observance of rules ('recommended action'). These virtues and ethical

existing within it.

and Indian disciples: as part of society, yogis must respect the rules the vow, and he considered it logical. And he repeated it both to Western discipline and not to increase chaos and suffering. That is the meaning of But more simply, practitioners of Krishna yoga promised to respect social put to be born.

personal growth and development: the child simply had no other choice rights: the circumstances of birth are not a punishment, they cannot stop society as a whole. Yet even one born outside marriage can attain spiritual influence of the spirits of a different clan can also affect the structure of those not by blood belonging to the lineage destroys it. The intentions and superstition or not, in India it is firmly believed that the participation of the spirits of foreign ancestors derive no benefit from it. Whether out sincerely or if the performer of the rite does not know of his origin, performed for them by an alien descendant. Even if such a ritual is carried offspring: the spirits of the ancestors do not accept the sacrificial rituals causes had to be sought. Most often the cause turned out to be illegitimate If a chain of inexplicable events destroyed the family's wellbeing, hidden reputation.

ancestral blood, could cause damage not only to genealogy or the family's other complications. A set of foreign karmas, secretly mixed into the children born out of wedlock are a cause of loss of prosperity, along with the lineage's blood ensured its healthy continuation. It was believed that on observing the promises given for very weighty reasons. The purity of vow seemed an old-fashioned prejudice, but the logic tradition insisted steal? And what is the danger of illegitimate children appearing? The is this promise as important as the commandments 'do not kill, do not children in a family: the disgrace of a lineage directly affects society'. Why The explanation was quite straightforward: 'There must be no illegitimate women — they had to relate to every married man as a father or brother. think of any married woman as a mother or sister. The same applied to One of the vows perplexed Western students: the initiate promised to

mathematical method used to prove the truth of certain statements for all mathematical induction [footnote: Mathematical induction — a formula to arrive at a conclusion. For him personally, faith was like supposition: '...suppose that...', and one then had to apply the right remained unchanged. Most mathematical reasoning is based on the with Him had come up in conversations many times, and his answer. The question of the existence of God and of the methods of connecting knew this feeling well.

which the given individual life was born. Having walked this path, he search of consolation, for the longing to find protection in the cradle in inexpressible subconscious pain of quality gives the impulse for the origin, experiencing a sense of loss and separation from It. The one of the terms. Every being aspires to merge with the source of its own the Beyond was expressed in different ways, and the word 'God' was only God, and he related to this aspiration sympathetically. The wish to touch From time to time some of the newcomers spoke of their desire to know

Knowledge

attainment of liberation from births and deaths,

and this can be considered the essence of all religious texts, allowing the into the external world. This is the greatness of the mantras of the Cita, all the energy will be directed inward, rather than continuing to dissipate vibrations of its mantras will penetrate you, and, thanks to your sadhana, Mahasaya wrote: If you repeat the Cita with love and devotion, then the In his book The Bhagavad Gita from the Standpoint of Krishna Yoga, Gauri

body came to know the nature of Brahma.

simultaneously with the practice, and consciousness expanded while the cognition is always inner, not intellectual. The meaning of the text opened Bhagavad Gita revealed their deepest meaning to the heart, since any true brahmanya, in the end engaged the mind, and the mantric rhythms of the built discipline, and then duality became duality. The body, tempered by What good did it bring? Like the daily practice, the reading of the Cita ...And what is the meaning of the daily reading of a chapter of the Cita?

those who are worthy of it.] Patanjali did this beautifully. The 'Sadhanamaharishi' are able to bestow holiness and transmit divine knowledge to state of consciousness on the path of evolution. It is believed that known as 'seers'. This title is intended for those who attain the highest 'maha' — 'great' and 'ishi' — 'sage'). It refers to ancient Indian sages, Maharishi — a Sanskrit term (formed from the combination of the words the timeless Darsanas of Yoga, written by Maharishi [footnote: It is useless to try to come up with a new definition of Krishna yoga, since and that he taught.

of religion and had nothing to do with the aim of yoga that he followed to God — all these notions and aspirations belonged to the nuclear sphere as the available sample of the Divine. Love of God, devotion and service suggested to those thirsting to know God that they investigate themselves and likeness of God. To argue with this proposition is pointless, and he with oneself. According to the Bible, every person is created in the image laboratory material, one ought to work with what is always to hand — of the shortage of time, the fleetingness of life, and the availability of awareness is far deeper than dubious religious revelations. Why? Because Knowing the Creator is only part of self-realization; the real self-each was busy with his own affairs.

conformity to the norms of society. He and God were on good terms, and sounded a little naughty, but he was not concerned with ideological knew about him. For those lacking a sense of humour, this might have Creation. He did not want to know God; it was enough for him that God — it was precisely this that guaranteed an entry ticket to the Colosseum of not the cognition of the Creator, but the recognition of one's own essence widespread, he formulated the aim differently. The aspiration of yoga is Though the opinion that Krishna yoga helps one come closer to God is inevitably follow.

that is needed at this stage is the correct formula, and the conclusion will argument.]: it is supposed that God exists, along with spirit and soul. All natural numbers; a way of proving statements depending on a natural

attainment. It meant to recognise Brahmā as the source of life — since manifestations. To 'see' Him in the heart during practice was the highest phenomena. Vasudeva was the essence of life itself in all. He supporting all Creation. The fundamental principle of all things and was called Param Ātmā, the highest universal soul, pervading and parampara had uttered before him. Vasudeva existed everywhere. He always the same: he uttered the same words that the Teachers of the developmental level of the questioner. Yet the essence of the answers was Vasudeva was. The answers varied, since they had to correspond to the Him in their own hearts. Foreign disciples often asked who and what [footnote: Vasudeva — see footnote above] and he taught people to see spirit of the entire universe.

Vasudeva (because he is the son of Vasudeva and Devaki).] the immortal all beings. In the Bhāgavad Gītā, Krishna is also called by the name all beings dwell in this supreme being and that He Himself is present in Vasudeva is worshipped as the supreme Deity. The term itself means that term. The one who dwells in every atom, every living being. In Hinduism And then there was Vasudeva [footnote: Vasudeva is both a name and a explained the essence of God as Brahmā.

and this hypothesis of the Creator had room enough for all. Kṛiṣṇa And the Lord waited patiently, since He was Time itself and the Void, but of things, an inquiring mind, and a heart yearning for knowledge. The Creator's visiting card, Brahmā, was issued to every being born with a

had to awaken the dormant mind by means of the practice of breath.

alleged meeting with the Creator. Before making an appointment, one Him. That is why he insisted on the necessity of self-knowledge before the consciousness on the Lord, one had to apply enormous efforts to know by means of meditation. Then, having concentrated the awakened practice of Kṛiṣṇa means awakening the dormant, boundless consciousness. Many years ago in his commentary on this śloka he wrote that the

selfless tapas and self-knowledge are Kṛiṣṇa yoga.

bhāṣya, section says: 'Great efforts applied to know the Lord through

material world becomes like a shadow, and the seeker is liberated from it. Human ego and samskaras dissolve, and Consciousness remains. Then the Nirvikalpa samadhi — the highest state of awareness, in which he was said that they had attained the state of Nirvikalpa [footnote: also speak of it. Several times he had personally met people of whom it is not the exclusive feature of Baba's lineage: the Natha Yogis samadhi, which means 'to be active in samadhi'.

samadhi is known as Nirvikalpa-samadhi; another term for it is 'Ja-kriya around him and is able to communicate and react. This second stage of Even while in samadhi the person remains aware of what is happening system can endure the current of energy without switching off the body. usual, without falling into suspended animation. At this stage the nervous While the mind experiences the state of samadhi, the body functions as repetition develops the capacity to withstand the accumulating energy. As constant practice strengthens the nervous system, methodical stage of samadhi.

disappear, and this state of complete suspended animation is the first 'switched-off' body falls into hibernation, the pulse and heartbeat 'switched off' to prevent the burnout of the nervous network. The he damaged by the enormous charge of energy. The body has to be can

suspended animation the subconscious awakens, but the nervous system animation, which is a 'safety technique' for the organism. In the state of physical states. In the initial stage the yogi sinks into suspended describe two specific stages of samadhi, characterized by different ...The tradition of Baba and ancient texts such as the Yoga Darshanam prerequisites and conditions.

garden of his heart every night, and that 'presence' had certain an immeasurable rapture to unfold. From then on Vasudeva dwelt in the When he saw Him for the first time, the stopped heart allowed the bud of Vasudeva is the very essence of Life.

his thirst.

moment, using only *Shvasahita pranayama*, and that was enough to shake ten or fifteen minutes. Now he could open the door to the Void at any *samadhi* became stable, the time interval of 'total immersion' shortened to he would usually 'switch off' the body for an hour or two. After *Ja-kriya* no signals about its cessation were forthcoming. Earlier, while in *samadhi*, not interrupted. Regular practice was part of the vows he had taken, and ... Even after the state of *Ja-kriya samadhi* had stabilized, his *sadhana* was

material world. Like any equipment, it required regular maintenance.

reminder that it was being counted on, that it still belonged to the physical exercises helped him maintain balance; the body needed a daily beside him felt dragged, as though pulled by invisible waves. Regular continuously, drawing him into such elevated states that visitors sitting an additional factor: now the sound 'Om' was sounding evenly and waves; after a while the state became stable and unbroken. There was also unconscious, larger knowledge. At first the *Ja-kriya samadhi* came in he suddenly understood that the answers were coming from a sphere of walks and, as always, reacted instantly to questions during *darsana*, until continued through the day as well. He was in it during conversations and mental state in which he usually was during the night practice now difficult. It happened in December 1990. One fine day he realized that the that to determine the exact cause of the onset of *Ja-kriya samadhi* was appearance of Hanuman. The list of incredible happenings was so backed fantastic events of 1990: the encounter with Shiva, the flood, and the first ... The experiences of *Ja-kriya samadhi* began for him after a series of

state of these people.

well-founded doubts about the truthfulness of the claims regarding the these signs is the sole reliable confirmation of real *samadhi*, and so he had best, their pulse continued to be present. Yet only the absence of both never entered the state of suspended animation, their hearts continued to only the state of infinite peace and bliss.] or *Ja-kriya samadhi*. But they In *Nirvikalpa Samadhi* there is no mind in the form we know it. There is

itself.

past lives, karmic preconditions for realization, and the magic of yoga undoubtedly played its part), but a combination of merits accumulated in subsequent births. And it was no banal stroke of luck (although that yoga, and only a few managed in one lifetime to achieve liberation from unjust: life is too short, it is not enough for cognition of all the depths of immortal essence went on living. To yogis this dubious bargain seemed required constant care and had an expiry date. People died, while their ...The spirit unhesitatingly cast off the worn shell of the body, which solitude and obscurity.

obligations imposed on him by the paramahansa, he would have chosen the night practice. Sometimes he would say: had it not been for the guru and his personal sadhana, the rest of his affairs revolved around understanding and patience. There was no conflict between the duties of and uncertainty at the beginning of the spiritual search, he taught with of it to those who had been initiated. Remembering his own difficulties currents of almost supernatural energy, and he knew how to transmit param sadhana. The austerity that lasted a lifetime changed his body with guru's power, and that power could come only from the guru's personal efforts. This yoga could be transmitted to seekers only as part of the taken the vows prescribing him to practice before he undertook to teach. First and foremost he was a yogi, and only then a guru, since he had followed it.

death. Centuries later the guiding star of Kutastha still shone, and he incredible results, demonstrating the triumph of the eternal spirit over. In the past other ascetics, undertaking the same austerities, had attained had set sail and reached 'those shores' long before his own journey began. charts, but who was still learning. Distant lands existed, since other ships horizon in the boundless ocean of yoga, who understood the navigational experienced and in some sense wise beginner, who had glimpsed the Being a guru for more than 30 years, he still felt himself a beginner, an

What and Why

precisely this method of self-realization that allowed astonishing results
loga that Sri Satyacharan Lahiri and Babaji had transmitted to him. It was
indicating the truth of the teaching — and he taught beginners the same
point of view, repeated controlled samadhi was the only criterion
assessed. Comparative analysis did not interest him personally. From his
original, Krishna loga had gone on techniques being compared and
of the loga varied. For decades the debates about the 'real', 'correct',
Depending on the personalities and motives of the teachers, the versions

Creation, the path to knowing the Creator Himself.

already knew intuitively. It was the key to understanding the workings of
Krishna loga was intended for explorers attempting to interpret what they
anticipating its awakening and transformation into a conscious mind.
meeting, guarding the dormant capacities of the subconscious,
main aim is a meeting with one's own 'I'. And the Spirit awaited that
It is believed that Krishna is done in order to know God, but he held that the
three principal dualities of nature, the Gunas.

perhaps the rarest of states, since in it was attained the balance of the
conception of happiness and sorrow, into a state of peace. This was
are practicing is the art that takes you beyond karma. Beyond the
body. If this explanation sounded too complicated, he added: 'What you
'possessor' of consciousness grasps the ancient contract between mind and
in the body. This loga develops consciousness to the level at which the
recognize and realize one's own immortal substance, the Spirit dwelling
form of loga, revealing the practitioner's potential and helping to
Sometimes going into detail, he patiently explained: Krishna is an advanced

themselves, and simply wished to maintain balance;

suitable for those who were already relatively happy, at peace with
was this loga an antidote to the poison of the everyday? And if so, was it
retention? Was Krishna an anaesthesia, numbing the torments of existence,
measured by the number of samadhis, by the duration of breath
what is its goal? What is the criterion of 'correct Krishna loga', is it
Year after year he was asked the same questions: what is Krishna loga and

journey is more useful than sitting in one place.

ocean of Samasara or keep drifting in it. He held that even the shortest all a matter of will and intention: one can attempt to swim across the in one lifetime, and only the mind could compel the body to do this. It is portion at once. Yet it was presumed that all eleven levels must be passed and satisfaction of any appetite. But not everyone can manage the whole are served on one tray. The food is served in abundance for the enjoyment compared it to an abundant Indian dinner, the thali, where many dishes To help students understand the essence of the Kriya method, he simple but required gradual mastery.

corresponding proportions for the pranayamas, which only seemed therefore it came naturally. It was then that he established the understanding of the limitations and possibilities of the body, and assimilation. This systematization is based on personal experience and teach, and so he divided the techniques into 11 levels for better figuring out the stages came down to him. As a Guru he was obliged to The advanced kriyas were explained as a single, integral system, and sequential levels and the proportions of inhalations and breath retentions. Mahavatar did not give him instructions on dividing the practice into not say whether these higher kriyas should be taught to others. The for the serious test of the next levels. What is interesting is that Babaji did The recipient had already experienced samadhi, his body was prepared the advanced kriyas, individually choosing the difficulty level of practice. 127 years later, the Mahavatar instructed him himself, the Fifth Guru, in for the first generations of practitioners.

laypeople. Whatever techniques Lahiri received then, they were intended yoga, the intentions of Babaji left no doubt: this yoga must be returned to When in 1861 Lahiri Mahasaya was charged with popularizing Kriya had practiced them.

techniques of Kriya in the form in which all the successors of this tradition the body, Sri Satyacharan Lahiri transmitted to him the six levels and to be achieved, and he needed no other 'proofs' of efficacy. Before leaving

specific mudras were added, and all this was called the 'first level' with followed in the techniques, and the student received a new pranayama way to the higher kriyas. After performing Khechari rearrangements others it took years. This technique was the magic base that opened the perform it at once, some mastered the mudra over several months, with key condition of practice and the blessing for success. Some managed to ...The Queen of Kriya yoga was considered to be Khechari mudra — the took hard work.

potential and possibility, invisible and dormant in the cerebrospinal fluid, crossroads of energetic super-highways. To activate the empties of greatly from modern methods. These centres were traffic-lights at the unactivated. The ancient techniques of switching on the chakras differed visualizing the chakras, most people's centres remained inert, Regardless of the number of developmental seminars or time spent speak for themselves.

achievements of those who have undergone the traditional initiation course, this part of the ritual can be received skeptically, but the — thus 'connection' is made to the invisible network of Masters. Of spine at the points of the formation of the potential chakras, uttering 'Om', continuing the practice. During initiation the Guru touches the disciple's knowledge and the impulse of intention, the so-called 'sankalpa', for important; The teacher transmits to the disciple both the energy of This practice could be transmitted only by a Guru. Why is this so exercise had clearly established proportions.

Mahamudras, preparing the nervous system for the higher kriyas. Each the first time meet his spirit. And finally the practice was finished with the practitioner performed Yoni mudra, during which the yogi could for This was followed by Shvasarita pranayama and Nabhi kriya. After this improve concentration on the spine at the points of the potential chakras. Khechari mudra, then mental pranayama was carried out, helping to techniques. Two exercises for stretching the tongue helped one perform The first introductory level of Kriya included seven preparatory

knot of 'Ajita madi' [footnote: Ajita-madi — in Sanskrit means become still more complex. The new technique allowed one to unite the Guru taught the pranayama of the sixth level, and from this stage things physical body and return to it. When the fifth kriya was mastered, the travelling anywhere. This technique allowed one consciously to leave the become ever more refined, capable of concentrating on anything and concentration, the truly deep meditation begins precisely here. The mind The fifth level required time. Dhyana kriya is the technique of absolute order to go further, some managed.

yet the most ambitious students tried to master each successive stage in two years. This breathing technique is complex; it is hard to perfect. And were ready. The mastery of this powerful pranayama took from one to The fourth level was transmitted when the body and the nervous system experiences in Yoni mudra could become deeper and more mystical.

techniques stimulated the development of consciousness, and the Nabhi kriya, the disciple could move on to the third level. Now the set of time. Having successfully mastered pranayama in Yoni mudra and in The body must grow accustomed to the new practice, and this took some must pass for full release from all bonds and merging with the true I.]. The granthis indicate three stages through which human consciousness rising up the spine, Kundalini must pass (pierce) through the main knots: region, and at the brow centre (and also at the throat). It is believed that alternatives. The granthis are located at the base of the body, in the heart are responsible for what limits, hinders flexibility, deprives of of energetic knots in the human body; on the psychophysical level they Granthi Bheda — the 'opening' of the heart knot. Granthis are the names the opening of the heart knot. Hridaya Granthi Bheda [footnote: Hridaya pranayama. The second level was aimed at

technique of certain movements of the head with an additional First an introductory part, then a specific mantra, and finally the A person ready for the second level of practice received it in three stages.

Khechari.

leaves the body consciously, without experiencing regret or fear.

death Omkar kriya transfers the spirit to higher spheres, and the yogi directed solely at the transference of consciousness. At the moment of technique had nothing in common with the state of Samadhi: it was contemplate the astral world and then return again to the body. This between the worlds of the living and the dead. The sadhaka could mudra, the technique of Omkar kriya allowed one to open the door him to leave the body at will. Combined with the final technique of Yoni ...Along with detailed explanations of the higher kriyas, Baraji taught

whole world. These are the Tenth and Eleventh levels.

perform daily duties, while simultaneously experiencing unity with the remain in Samadhi continuously, retaining the ability to speak, walk and followed by the final stage of Yoni mudra. After this the yogi could mudra, beautiful and very complex technique of Omkar kriya was knot of Rudra, perfect Shamdhavi mudra and a special mantra. The At the eighth and ninth levels the yogi must perform passage through the

Cranthi Bheda.

practitioners continued to master the 'piercing' of the heart knot, Hridaya clarity of consciousness. All this time, up to the seventh level, consciously leaving the body at the moment of death while preserving full in combination with a perfected practice of Nabhi kriya. This is the art of The seventh level was devoted to the study of the third-level pranayama other than the kriya technique.

known practices, he had found no effective way of activating 'Ajita Nadi, removed obstacles for the rising of Kundalini energy. Having studied all form for the awakening process.] within the Sushumna channel and proportionate level. Ajita-nadi controls Sushumna and keeps it in proper channel helps maintain the flow of energy in all parts of the body at a the starting point of Sushumna and goes up inside Sushumna itself. This accumulates the body's energy and raises adrenaline. Ajita-nadi begins at Whenever the physical body needs additional strength, this nadi 'thunderbolt': the awakening of this channel acts like a thunderbolt.

acquaintance with Him and the necessary etiquette.

introducibility of each spirit. And he taught people the art of particular attention to age, race or sex, but saw only the uniqueness and creating those entering the darghan hall for the first time, he said no deserved the chance of awakening.

human imperfections. Ideal people simply did not exist, but every one. Evaluating the dormant potential of each disciple, he preferred to ignore no other religion or practice.

mutual ease grows. This process is sorcery, alchemy, and it is taught by communication. As the yogi and his spirit come to know one another, yogi spends waiting for Him or alone with Him expands the channels of 'meeting place'. The spirit never comes when summoned, but the time the knowledge of one's own essence, the practitioner must arrive at the deeper understanding of one's own soul takes much longer. To approach initiation the person begins to see his own immortal substance, although a initiation into this yoga includes something incredible: immediately after of the Creator) the very essence of the practitioner must be 're-cut', before self-realization (self-recognition) and god-realization (recognition predisposition to realization — yoga must become the meaning of life, intention and motivation. And, of course, there is the condition of karmic one lifetime in any of them. Everything comes down to will, discipline, ... The spirit lives endlessly in many bodies, and may attain realization in some practitioners never advance beyond the initial stages.

abandons the practice. Time-framed present an even greater problem: not easy. Although the spirit never sleeps, He can become inert if the yogi. For all the apparent simplicity of the vows, keeping these promises was miles to go before I sleep, And miles to go before I sleep.

'The woods are lovely, dark and deep. But I have promises to keep, And poet Robert Frost:

Explaining the stages of this yoga, he often quoted the famous American

beings live somewhere on the periphery, while most people are quite survival together with software updates. Gods, spirits and immortal Modernity demands practicality and constantly updates the rules of at least for now.

in the digital sphere, where technology is worshipped with awe and hope, is questioned, analysed and at once rejected. Sorcery is welcomed mainly him away from understanding the foundations of existence. Today magic own roots in order to become a projected image of himself. And this fears mythology of places. Modern man often longs to tear himself from his imagination flow from the modern separation of people from the Attempts to suppress the perception of reality through the prism of these pigments — by means of imagination.

mosaic of many lives, and he advised disciples to become the brightest of womb of a world founded on carbon. The fresco of being consists of a imagination is conceived in the amniotic waters of Prana and grows in the Prana feeds equally suppositions and denials, faith and unbelief. The very emotions, mixed by the Pranic force, the breath of Time and the Void, are formed from traumas and victories, images and thoughts, places and events laid out in the Puranic texts. Perhaps because individual universes while the geography of his travels could easily be traced on the maps of personal events of the recent past wove naturally into historical fact, 'Mahabharata', sounded like stories of his own adventures. Somewhat dialogue between Sri Rama and his guru Vasishtha.] and the CE, contains more than 50,000 verses and is written in the form of a the sage Valmiki and dated roughly between the 6th and 12th centuries — a monumental philosophical work on Vedanta. The text, attributed to Sometimes the legends of the 'Yoga Vasishtha' [footnote: Yoga Vasishtha

The Magic of Reality

of awakening.

person. That properly speaking, was the only condition for the beginning interest. The teacher must become interested in teaching the particular What then is needed to begin such a journey? To arouse the Curiosity

kingdom of the Spirit and was considered one of the Guides.

was known as the Guru who helps to find the secret paths into the the search for hidden portals and came to the ashram, to him, since he immediate contact with such yogis themselves felt the temptation to begin transitions are perfectly natural. Sometimes people who entered into and are carried into another dimension. For such seekers of reality such particular effort squeeze through the narrow cracks of the physical world reap the fruit of austerities. Duality does not trouble those who without though the fields of their bodies with complex pranayamas in order to like enchanted farmers, regardless of the season, yogis persistently relentlessly transforming the 'normal' into the paranormal.

alone, for any transformation requires action. Kriya was a method of new worlds. Of course, the future cannot be programmed by intention ensures the change of consciousness, and such consciousness can create the same time remain in the state of waking. The continuity of practice Creating adepts, magic allowed them to enter the world of dreams and at were instructions and maps pointing to hidden treasures.

cognition requires impartiality and naturalness of perception: the legends took root only in unprejudiced minds and hearts. The logic method of contemptuously called such beliefs 'rural superstitions', put the logic the whisper of the Supreme Priestess. Most 'educated' people to them attentively, even with anticipation, since in their stories he heard one's will the actions of gods and spirits.] of the earth. He always listened one believed it possible to change the course of events by subordinating to Theurgy — in Greek 'divine action', 'miracle'. A kind of magic with which elements, they are familiar with the original force and theurgy [footnote: botchers, shepherds, hunters... Living together with nature and its primary to those who tread the earth in the literal sense — peasants, blacksmiths, secrets are revealed to those who live in immediate proximity to nature, one another.

blay matyoshyka, where the magical and the ordinary are inserted into comfortable in the cocoons of supposed truths. Only seekers continue to

supernatural fitted organically into the logic routine without distorting throw the limited logical mind into confusion. The paranormal and the shocked by the inexplicability of emotions or events, which normally the 'real'. The subconscious not-mind knew everything, and was never rainrow-coloured sail erasing the boundary between the 'imaginary' and imagination was the windsurfing board through Samara's, the turns of its the kingdom of the Void, where everything is possible.

Together with applied will and controlled breath, Kriya was the pass into planes

Yoga fed their imagination with pranic energy on the physical and mental invited to accept the strangeness and irrationality of the subconscious, present and future flow in the current of Prana-Time. Disciples were omnipresent Prana, nourishing all intentions, events and thoughts, past, life reveals its constantly changing essence, the astonishing and His own principle of magical realism was simple: daily investigation of

lives of separation, the Cross and the Subtle can truly embrace each other. slowly awakens. Sensing the changes, the body responds. After many logical mind becomes secondary, and its sleeping twin, the subconscious, developed consciousness. In the course of such a transformation the the transformed mind needs rooting in a body capable of supporting the itself into the framework of established norms. Like a flower needing soil, on by yoga is no longer able to maintain linear perception or to adhere outside the laws of Matter, yet the unconditioned consciousness switched ...Everyday life dismisses the subtle, inexplicable phenomena that fall

pilgrims, not package tourists.

thorny and full of traps and ambushes, and was intended for persistent wholeness, and not to dissect Her into degrees and categories. This path is open to people who genuinely wish to understand Life in her astonishing aspects of the logic path to sceptics. The entrance to the higher reality is those who were sincere in seeking, but did not trouble himself to explain would speak of the desire to solve the puzzle of existence. And he taught Those striving to believe but not yet daring to trust the heart, beginners,

who were sorcerers at the resort of the smashan, distilling their own
are able to manage energies of such magnitude — it was precisely they
beings. But who exactly was causing these processes? Only higher beings
waves, these energies were perceived by the mental receptors of living
were caused by the 'churning' of higher pranic energies. Spreading like
world. The strange and bizarre incidents at the ancient cremation site
...What happened on the smashan did not contradict events in the outer

matter of time and intention.

of the developed subconscious with the phenomena of reality is only a
removes the conflict between the 'real' and the 'imaginary'. The unification
heart never doubts what it already knows. The fine-tuning of inner vision
subconscious through the awakened body and consciousness, and the
problem was perfectly solvable: yoga whispers the answers to the
Must I believe in fairy tales? Or treat all of it as metaphors and hints? The
should I treat the stories about talking snakes and appearances of Gods?
here to study yoga, I fully accepted the Teacher and the teaching. But now
Once a student from Canada asked, slightly embarrassed: 'When I came

was never distorted, since reality itself had not originally been 'rational',
the irrational into their minds. The overall picture of the disciple's world
was characterized by the problematic, painful and ambiguous invasion of
not from offered concepts but from empirical experience. And this process
time it had to be consulted. Practitioners should assemble new databases
events and documentary evidence should not be thrown out; from time to
metaphors. And yet the card catalogue with the traditional chronology of
was, with all its forgotten histories, signs, mystical parallels and
As an alternative, he proposed to students that they accept the world as it
a limited number of algorithms in conditioned minds.

The perception of existential aspects is excluded from the matrix that runs
human science, which demands explanation of miracles and phenomena.
Interaction with the 'paranormal' is unexplainable from the standpoint of
its course.

Sound. Void. The Elements. Prana

the placenta of unstoppable life.

so-called Evil. And this potent elixir nourished the Gunas, taking shape in various intentions, Good seeped out of the vessel of Time and mixed with death floated in the viscous albumen of life. Containing molecules of gleams of dawn. Encased in the eggshell of individual karma, the yolk of Hiding its undertone of grey, the blackness of night dissolved in the world.

revealed the watermark of higher Reality, existing parallel to the physical the higher spheres, interrupting the linearity of perception. Such reroots providence, between events and people connected the subconscious with the map of known reality. And then invisible wires, charged by markers, and he taught them to overlay inner vision and imagination on those studying higher yoga in time adapt to the ancient system of road-they offered a convenient and generally accepted coordinate-system. But With traditional, even if limited, methods of cognition, all was in order.

than long sentences.

attention, and an ordinary full stop sometimes conveyed meaning better the past and the question hieroglyphs of the future deserved close words and sentences from the letters of being. The exclamation marks of Book of Fates and the diary of the Spirit, a person must learn to assemble Realization required careful study of the alphabet of life. To read the but such self-definition slightly calmed people.

unintelligible. Was there a touch of coyness in this statement? Perhaps, man living an extraordinary life, surrounded by the unknown and the gone through the indescribable, he characterized himself as 'an ordinary by realistic facts'. Life on the smashan proved the opposite. Even having term 'magical realism', described every person as 'an enigma surrounded The Venezuelan writer Arturo Uslar-Pietri, who was the first to apply the

Prana into the oxygen of intentions and changes.

expressed extraordinary satisfaction: 'Wonderful! You heard Pranaṃ ... Several years later he shared this experience with his Teacher, and he taking root and fastening itself in the body and consciousness.

nature of the transmission. The sound did not stop and did not go away ... Despite his awareness, it took him about a week to understand the destruction of the nervous system.

and only intense physical exercise could prevent the accelerated powerful vibrations of the sound negatively affected the body and mind, the sound, one could attain enlightenment. But nobody told them that the by plugging the ears, fixing the gaze between the brows and listening to they are indivisible.] Śaṅkara. The adepts of this teaching believed that language held that śabda (speech) is eternal, as is meaning, and that word denotes 'the sound of speech'. Classical Indian philosophy of or śabda — sound, word, the subtle element of sound. This Sanskrit sound 'Om'; this kind of practice was called 'śruti śabda' [footnote: śabda, spiritual organization, and the doctrine consisted of immersion in the Nīketan, ashram. This ashram had been founded by a well-known he was acquainted with people attending gatherings at the 'Adhyatma sound and even discussed it with members of a yoga group. And besides, was not yet practicing Kriya at that time, he was, however, aware of the In the following days the intensity of the inner sound grew. Although he

inaudible hum was merely the background of other melodies of the night. sounding drew him in. Not overlapping outer noises, this constant glass beads against each other, and the descending current of this to classify. The sensation resembled the friction of countless invisible tiny monotonously vibrating buzzing came from within, but it was impossible the exercises, he sat for some time with closed eyes. An even experience that occurred several months later. That night, having finished 'Aum' (or Anahada Nada, Om, Pranaṃ), but to the out-of-body these exercises also contributed not only to the recognition of the sound when he was practicing bhastrikas, pushing them to their limit. Perhaps For the first time he heard the sound at the beginning of September 1979,

residing in Her. Matter emerged from the union of Time and Void, from the tricks of Creation. The Void was present in all objects and beings, an element yet the East knew and honored Shunya, or 'space', as one of everything existed. Western alchemy did not even acknowledge ether as inaccessible to tactile perception, although in its all-pervading field subtle (although it could be felt), while the fifth element, ether, was temporarily configuration to the tongues of its flame. Air was even more form; water could take the shape of any vessel; the energy of fire gave a elusive, descriptive. The gross element of earth had a relatively constant properties of the basic elements, but they nevertheless remained mystical, most subtle ether to the element of earth. Science had long explained the the cosmic vibration that gave birth to all the primary elements, from the properties and density differed depending on the degree of intensity of ether manifested out of the primordial Sound of Creation. Their gave rise to all the forms of the material world. Earth, water, fire, air and elements. Countless combinations of the building-blocks of the Universe. Both Eastern and Western sciences acknowledged the existence of basic the elements began to open to him.

Void, from which the Sound issued — and it was then that the nature of moved between atoms and particles of Matter toward their source, the concentrate on it and then release that focus. Led by vibration, the mind Over the years, having grasped the source of the Sound, he learned to since the invisible frequencies were destructive to the fragile human shell, surroundings. But the body, of course, required constant attainment, remaining completely aware of and in control of himself and his could walk, speak and act in the constant presence of Nada, while an effort of will. The Sound did not interfere with daily activities; he with the constancy of the sound, and he no longer tried to 'switch it off' by somehow he managed not to drown or dissolve in It. The mind merged Wholly absorbed in the Sound, he could not stop listening to it, but deepen and bring you new experiences, without even being initiated into yoga! Now, with practice, this state will

strange and quite unconnected with the everyday tasks of survival, but cousin's gaze gave way to visible alarm. Such reflections were impractical, us, and between everything else in this world! The surprise in the know what lies between us? The Void! It fills the space between us, within interlocutors could not be found. Once he turned to his cousin: 'Do you intellect boiled, demanding discussion of these questions, but suitable with the separation of these great essences, with the birth of Matter? His Was this a joint, collective Universal Mind? Could quality have begun All births and changes began in the consciousness of the Void and Time.

conscious, and Her consciousness could be born only by another mind. constancy made possible the movement of Matter within Her. Matter is constantly changing. Only the Void remained unchanged, and this elusive and concealed, since the Matter of which they are made is At some point he understood that the true form and essence of objects are

and the cause of the existence of the very scientists and their discoveries. the phenomenon of the world's emergence: It was the basis of all sciences only to the slaking of thirst. Prolonged immersion in the Sound explained him. Solving the greatest puzzle, he felt incredible satisfaction comparable magnificence of the Void, Time, Sound, and the elements opened up to would shrink to the size of a matchbox. In samadhi the grand the voidness were removed from the Himalayas, the majestic mountains ...Once a scientist who visited him offered an interesting example: if all ceased to grow.

Matter in the world, since the empty space between its components never electrons, and so on. With every new discovery there was less and less to it. Molecules consisted of atoms, atoms were built of nuclei and them: the very structure of Matter was based on the Void that gave birth Void and Sound. The Void filled the space between atoms and within a child. The particles of Matter contained the genes of both parents, Time- Having given birth to Matter, the Void carried galaxies as a mother carries The Void is the mother of the Universe, and the Great Time is its father.

the vibration of the eternal Sound.

being.

accidental, for the time of death and new birth is predetermined for every rose higher, into the astral spheres. The lottery of reincarnations is never womb, such souls take new births in conditions different from those that insects, birds, people, large and small creatures. Drawn into various the rains, the souls enter the soil and feed plants, becoming food for leave the lower atmosphere to reach the higher levels. Drawn down by rains beat the souls in aerial bodies down to the earth, and they cannot preparation for new incarnations. In the rainy season, in winter, fogs and opportunity to rise to the higher layers of the atmosphere for rest and for departure: during the dry season the souls in etheric bodies have the evolution. The Bhagavad Gita gives hints, speaking of periods favourable cycles of planets and seasons, it determines the next stages of the souls the aerial body. The time of death is extremely important. Linked to the the loss of shelter, the shocked soul has no other choice than to settle in by the soul to enter the dead body or settle near the place of burial. After in India corpses are cremated as quickly as possible to prevent attempts the earth, ashes turn to ashes, dust to dust.

of earth, most essential for the existence of the physical body, returns to form an aerial body — and consciousness attaches itself to it. The element cremation: three of the five gross elements burn up, while ether and air. After death the body is freed from the grossest elements in the flame of Hinduism itself. He tried to explain the process as simply as possible:

of their ancestors, through the DNA of continuity of life was absorbed by them through countless incarnations them existence and non-being were in perfect harmony. The law of the the technical side of the process. Indians rarely asked such questions: for after death and the principle of the next incarnations — and most of all in ... Western students were interested in the transference of consciousness their own practice.

comprehend these notions, gradually opening Universal science through for him they were precious treasures. In time the disciples began to

deliver oxygen, she was the elixir of life, the most important ingredient of further transformation of the soul, are all Prana. She did not merely the word 'Prana'. Both mind and pure consciousness, which is the catalyst incidentally, another name for the cosmic sound, 'pranava', derived from might continue the eternal play in a temporary shell.

of five primary elements with a single purpose — that Prana and Apana give the 'carriers' the highest knowledge. In fact, all bodies are composed as Apana, and consciousness as Prana. This perfect union of pranas could almost tragic. He recommended that disciples perceive their own bodies preserving form, he considered their dependence on the shelter of flesh. Observing spirits who continued to change bodies for the sake of exist; it would be homeless.

give the body different dualities. Without a body consciousness could not sound, animated by Prana. Equally balanced, the five primary elements. The human body is nothing but a capsule of Matter brought forth by assimilation of unbroken knowledge.

by the logical mind, but in the process of practice, through the inner the basic elements. The secret art of balancing the elements is grasped not first day of practice, and from this same moment starts the recognition of. For many beginners in Kriya the knowledge of the sound begins from the ultimately, to immortality.

equilibrium of elements leads to the acquisition of the ideal form, and of basic elements is uneven, but yoga can balance them, and such an and determined the sound vibration of each element. In the body the ratio unity of the source. The ancient practitioners recorded this cosmic music score of the symphony of the Universe; all together they personify the vibration. The chakras are nothing other than the notes of the musical numbers of petals. Their number depends on the intensity of the element's specific vibration of a separate element and therefore have different marked by the letters of the Sanskrit alphabet. The chakras symbolize a symbolize the primary elements. Each chakra is depicted with petals. The schemes of human chakras popular among adherents of modern yoga

The seeds of karmas dormant in consciousness await their hour to sprout
You will rise above karma, you will move beyond it.

capable of understanding your own thoughts and controlling them, then
desire or reactions. Therefore he never tired of repeating: If you are
rise to absolutely everything: inspiration, passion, love, pride, vengeance,
the prism of metaphor. The source of all karmas was Thought, which gave
When he was asked about karma, he tried to explain in a clear way, using
wings of an inquiring spirit, reaching it rise higher.

in their own way, and he always answered. His words pollinated the
and these he especially liked. But in truth, all questions were interesting
layer of words. Occasionally questions were sharp, stabbing, like a blade,
saw the essence of the question and the germ of the answer beneath the
stuck, or bounced about like ping-pong balls. And yet he unmistakably
sometimes murky, slippery, poorly formed or simply questions floated,
prolonged effect.

were full of deep meaning, possessed of broad range, and exerted a
into hearts and were absorbed by them. For those who heard, his answers
by their conciseness. Piercing the shields of ordinary logic, the words fell
the soothing breath of night. Usually his answers pinned the truth down
rustle was absorbed by the fires of the carpet, the whisper of trees, and
walls of the dargah hall in the evenings, until at last their soundless
Questions that had sounded during the day continued to bounce off the

The Origin of Karma

become yours. For friends nothing is too dear...

least a little credit. These discoveries I made myself, but now they can
Could you share the names of the books? He smiled: Try to give me at
someone uncertainly broke the silence: Where can one read about this?
Slightly overwhelmed by all these revelations, the disciples were silent.

Alchemist and Yogi

in the cocktail of Creation. Prana Herself was the great Animator,

thought is it?

blood? And if the physical body is the expression of thought, then whose assertion. How can a formless thought turn into form, become flesh and itself in an individual body. Often listeners did not fully understand this of thought. Initially thought has no form, but in the end it can express was both accessible and at the same time profound. Any body is the result physical body is called the karmic body, and the explanation he offered reactions can cause quite real consequences. He was often asked why the are born of the mind (even if the subconscious). Becoming actions, these The so-called 'instinctive' reactions are also considered karmic, since they

is the actor. For this actor the inner 'I' is the stage.

inner 'I' is brilliantly and concisely described in the Shiva-sutras: 'Atman contemplating the stage on which the Actor performs. The stage of the are pacified, the mental imprints may become only silent spectators samaskaras of past lives constantly spin the roulette wheel of action. If they Vasana — desire, aspiration, idea, inclination, mental tendency.] and choose inaction. Like dealers in the Casino of Life, the vasanas [footnote: logic mind can determine cause and effect, initiate appropriate action or consciousness can choose the right path and perform right actions; the the limited mind and meagre human morality. Developed and discerning Are these experiences good or bad? Such definitions are the prerogative of name of learning, of the experience of feelings, of victories and sufferings. Playfully, but quite consciously, the spirit fills the body with life in the Karmas resemble educational courses, an individually tailored program.

something.

samadhi every action or reflection had the potential to teach the soul going beyond most of his karmas was still significant, but even after gathered the fruits they had brought and tasted them. The moment of Having realized the roots of all the actions he had ever committed, he level of karmic deeds and thoughts.

further karmas becomes more refined, and the yogi can rise to a higher or wither. If one manages to activate the subconscious, the creation of

Of course, the planet's time differs from the human system of time-luminary. She will choose another and draw it to Herself.

She has already outlived many suns, and after the death of the next volcanic ash or spray a lotion of hot lava to these blisters at any moment, only a small skin irritation. The Planet may dust Herself with the tale of they had not particularly affected Her. For Her, 'human civilization' is worried about climate change. She had already seen many changes, and melting glaciers, dusted Herself with hot sands, and was not at all with a contrast shower of downpours, hurricanes and tsunamis, bathed in there are no orphans on Earth. Sometimes the Mother disinfected Herself dying within the body. Nevertheless, all beings were Her children — people themselves are unaware of the myriads of bacteria being born and and shifts of mood. Of course, She could not know every soul, just as a living and breathing being, with thoughts, emotions, cycles, seasons, more digestible, at least it can be tied to something concrete. The planet is manifestations of this Mind.], the concept of Earth's consciousness was has unlimited resources at its disposal; it is omnipresent; people must be potential limit of any thing. For If everything is possible. Universal Mind universal consciousness. Universal Mind contains all knowledge. It is the general, the term 'mind' often refers to the organic, human aspect of place in the Universe before the appearance of the concept of Mind. In substance of beings and being itself, with the becoming of being that took supposes an essence underlying the existence of all created things, the Universal mind (or universal consciousness) — a metaphysical concept. It stereotypes. In contrast to the abstraction of universal mind [footnote: scale and to trace any idea or hypothesis — for the sake of destroying change its views. He, however, encouraged students to think on a large called scientific discoveries about the material world and was not about to Of course, humanity was quite comfortably settled in the bubble of so-consciousness.

most varied progeny, and all living beings were neurons of Her this could also be the thought of the Earth, since She gave birth to the It belonged to the universal Mind. But since people are earthly creatures,

actions. The stitches of past karmas in the fabric of the body are reflects the tendencies of the spirit, future intentions, and even inevitable shaped by the soul's desire to acquire new shells. Every human body temporary means of travel. In addition to genetics and DNA, bodies are of a particular person. Creating a body, Time provides for the soul a specific locality, country, and nation, lending concreteness to the destiny. Individual fate is almost always influenced by the totality of karmas of a the future.

temporary bodily forms, Time lays a path through the past, the present, of the body, in myriads of other drops of Time. Passing through these

Mind continues to create the illusion

with Time, together with the seeds of accumulated karmas. The Universal properties of the ocean: so too in every body there is hidden a similarity mind, from it consciousness patches. Each drop of the ocean carries the

Although the body is only a drop of Time, it serves as an incubator of the master.

does not turn by itself; it is set in motion by the bull harnessed to it and its purposes is the creation of new karmas. However, the irrigation wheel buckets under the weight of the water — this is karma. One of karma's irrigation wheel: its continuous turning continues to pour water into the 'Chetanda Samhita' connects the allegory of the circle of rebirths with an new birth together with the potential for new karmas.

body means the absence of karma. The old 'merits' manifested at every simplifying the philosophical allusions, he explained that the absence of a

the product of the combined karmas of the parents.

embodiment of Time, human flesh reflects the aspect of the past, since it is the 2 elements, and that is precisely how the body is born. Being the Time itself spoke through Krishna: "...only a tiny particle of Me attracts of people: they were no different from other beings living on Her surface. human scale of time, and therefore the planet barely 'noticed' the presence measurement. One second of Earth equals approximately 700 years on the

limited human point of view), is superimposed on the endless cycle of and at the same time grand plan, without any exhaustive logic (from a organic if one may put it that way. The blueprint of a complex, delicate The Earth is herself a Creator, and Her creative designs and patterns are

The Kingdom of Death, Mitya Loka

alchemy of sadhana, which burns up all karmas.

to this yoga, to the Guru. Now the time had come to set in motion the happen to them had already happened — they had found their way here, ...Students need not worry about their karmas; all that was supposed to

life, they are dreamed up by the planet, born so that she may dream life. variations of Matter created by Time and Space. Like many other forms of all cosmic beings and planetary bodies. People are only one of countless Time are the Universal Mind, and this great Consciousness gives rise to the Void that dwells in each of its organs, cells, and atoms. The Void and The body is the counter of Time and its sign, as well as the embodiment of them, may return to the source.

dissolve in them. The filters of karma exist so that souls, passing through physical body and can return to the source, to the infinity of Time-Void, to until it has 'ripened'. Once it has become spirit, the soul no longer needs a this takes many cycles. Working out various karmas, it changes bodies. Very rarely is a soul able to develop to the level of spirit in one lifetime;

new one.

outlives the aging body, and after its death continues to wander, finding a that consciousness may hatch from the shell of flesh. The ripened soul and the embryo of the soul ripens in the body and is nourished by it, so the spirit. The body is the maternal womb, the incubator of consciousness, Mind invests in it His seed. Called consciousness, or soul, it grows to meet origin, and cause of birth. In creating the physical body, the universal In his commentary on the 'Shiva-sutras' he explained in detail the cycle, interwoven with the airy, fluid threads of the future.

body the formless, unmanifest and immortal Jiva-Shiva sets off back to its endless compositions of Her vast palette. After the death of the earthly 'appropriated' by the planet. Dissolving in Her, they supplement the Her. The primary elements created by the Void are in the end also the Earth. All births, all that is made of Earth and on Earth, returns to Only souls come from outside, from cosmos; everything else belongs to

because of this in Hinduism the soul-Jiva is also called 'Shiva',

to the Void. Each soul is a form and imprint of Time, or Shiva, and to life in all its forms, yet souls, and the Prana that enlivens them, belong souls and animate them with Prana. The Earth never ceases to give birth 'space-suits of flesh', and the Void and Time place in them the seeds of continuation of their education. The planet creates myriads of bodies, cognition of Life. Again and again they are sent to Earth for the the kingdom of death, and souls come here to experience Death after the Shatma's opinion, Earth is the place where death must be experienced.] Sanskrit 'death', 'Loka' means 'world, space, dimension'; in Shailendra The Earth is called Mritya Loka [footnote: Mrityaloka — 'Mritya' means in veil of the atmospheric envelope that wraps Her.

remains are absorbed by the soil, returning into Her, or evaporate in the everywhere — she is always close. After the death of living beings the follows us: all beings on the planet walk on Her, and Earth extends He told them that the Earth is Death itself. It is held that Death always play of consciousness in imagination.

striving for merger. In the final analysis, absolutely everything is only the their resistance and pushing-away from each other, alongside the eternal driven by the quality of being. To an understanding of opposing energies, awareness of the forces of creation that stand behind the eternal play In his daily dialogues with disciples he tried to inspire them to an organic forms.

Great Spirit comes to know Himself through the life and death of various creation. This process has no other special purpose than exploration. The

of digesting such a revelation. The fright may forever take away the wish Death, but it may also become the last: not very many people are capable death. For some the first experience of Samadhi may part the veil of no self-knowledge can be considered complete without passage through self-awareness arise, the sense of true being manifested in its fullness, and life. Only at the moment of merger with death does the sharp sense of it teaches one to die so as to live, to pass through Death — and to glorify are often too strong, and therefore Kriya Yoga is not meant for everyone. The fear of the unknown and the instinct to remain in the refuge of flesh consciously and, where possible, with joy.

people were hostages of death, and the goal of any life is to live it incarnation and the laying-down of the shell. From the moment of birth Everything else is merely a moment between the important events of duty of accepting death. This is the real duty of all souls coming to Earth. the chief drama, or destiny, of a human being was maran drama. The encyclopaedia of original knowledge: in the ancient texts it was said that Disciples were recommended to read the Puranas, the great Yamajais: all souls return to the lord of Dharma.

and failures of the earthly path of every soul are within the purview of authorized agent, Yamajais. All the lessons, experiences, achievements ...Hinduism held that the realm of souls is governed by Death and Her mind. Such is the path of this Yoga.

instruments or academic explanations, but with their own body and glimpse a flash of consciousness of Time, and not by means of measuring consciousness of the Void (Chaitanya Shunyata). In time they had to Padarthas), he discreetly led the disciples to an understanding of the of Matter (Chaitanya [footnote: Chaitanya — absolute consciousness.] consciousness in its totality. Starting with the concept of the consciousness primary elements themselves, he explained to listeners the nature of ...Moving from the nature of the human mind to the consciousness of the source, to the Void and Time.

incarnation, since certain spiritual attainments are possible only on this
The Vedic scriptures assert that even the gods strive for human
Her, the Father of all elements, all matter, all bodies...

The husband from eternity was the Void, the Earth is wedded forever to
Bodhi. Gorakhnath asks the question: 'Who is the husband of the Earth?',
that Earth could introduce the yogi to the Father. In the book 'Gorakha
speaking of the Earth, capable of opening the deepest secrets. He believed
course, the blessing of the biological mother is important, but he was
Without the blessing of the Mother such a journey is impossible. Of
back, in order to see the divine play of Life through new lenses.

their bodies before the step into the abyss, they must be able to come
this uncoiled energy is too harsh. Therefore students must first prepare
experience of Death awakens the subconscious, and for the unprepared
lead to rupture and collapse of the nervous system. Samadhi as the
to bear the consequences of staggering experiences. Any mistake could
yogi returned to Life. This kriya was dangerous, and required preparation
contemplating what lay beyond, the door was carefully closed, and the
and Death. Carefully opening it, he peered inside, without entering. After
threshold and pull the handle of the door dividing the kingdoms of Life
speaking allegorically, the seasoned practitioner had to come to the
and Death.

Death and discern the point of transition, the fragile edge between Life
complete suspended animation could recognize the precise moment of
passed through Samadhi. Only those who had experienced the state of
dimensions, this highest kriya was taught only after the disciple had
transference of consciousness from one plane of being to other
of them Omkar kriya. The Omkar technique is intended for the
and his disciples were steadily progressing. But he had not yet taught any
practised constantly to maintain a permanent state of self-awareness —
transition from one world to another. The yogis of Babaaji's lineage
Kriya taught constant self-awareness which arises only at the moment of
to repeat the journey.

somewhere. Most listeners usually took these words as poetic allegories, the final point of Her arrival, for She was carrying all Her inhabitants with the consciousness of the planet. This union also meant discovering Earth: through death-like samadhi, developed consciousness could unite. In his understanding, the logic union with death meant union with the temporary evolutionary trajectory.

destination is by no means limited to Her orbit. The orbit is only a those She has nursed. The journey of the Earth is a riddle, since the genetic archives: the fossils of Her 'family album' contain the DNA of all bones of all dead children. Guarding and destroying, She holds the adorns Herself with endless garlands of skulls, carrying with Her the Earth floats in Time-Shiva and likewise wears no clothes. Instead She stands on the body of Shiva. So too, supported by the eternity of the Void, adorned with a garland of skulls, dead bodies hang from Her back, She carrying in the others a sword and a severed head. The Goddess's neck is Dark One. The naked four-armed Kali Ma defends with one hand, Kali, was the embodiment of Earth, and both were called 'Shyama', the For him personally, Earth and Kali were inseparable. The dark goddess, She is mighty and more than tangible.

forces of the planet make Her higher than a multitude of invisible deities. laboratory in which the great infinite cycle of Life is honed. The creative millions of bacteria and viruses, and that is just. The planet is a gigantic beings must nourish others. Living bodies provide for the existence of sciences, discoveries, and inventions. Earth nourishes all and, in turn, all beliefs. Among the toys with which She amuses humanity are the various from various religions and forms of worship to atheism or any other while away the time of earthly incarnations — from sports to politics, journey. The Earth ceaselessly gives people varied things that help them their bodies and teaching them, providing everything necessary for the progress. Bearing the living and the dead, She cares for them, nourishing development here, because Earth provides the conditions for such planet, only in human form. All souls received the possibility of spiritual

properties inherent in people were more or less defined and established; provided constancy and perseverance in sadhana. In general, the Of course, disciples differed, but all were receptive to transformation frameworks meant to step toward non-conformist knowledge.

concentrating on the conditioned "I." To think outside established contemplate different aspects of being, to shift focus, to cease they were excessively fixated on themselves. They had to learn to imagination toward themes they had not yet attempted to comprehend, as guest was all of the above. But... he sought to redirect people's an embodiment of Divinity, directly connected to Her. And of course, the Universal Mind. After all, according to various spiritual theories, man is assurances that he was an expression of the Atman, a particle of the your mother's egg." Visibly taken aback, the guest had expected "I see that you are the result of a combination of your father's sperm and seeker was to receive what would aid him in his spiritual development.

expectantly. The question itself admitted a variety of answers, but each ... "What do you see when you look at me?" The American looked at him

Stages of Evolution

that Earth was their common cradle.

moistened by the first monsoon. This moist, tart aroma reminded souls ... At dawn, emerging from the trance, he caught the scent of earth within themselves a spark and a vibration of the source.

taste of failure is the aftertaste of life, not death, for all failures carry however greatly it has suffered in the very process of life. Even the salty life itself and grasp its meaning. Every living being strives to keep living, and at the same time entirely real goals, attempting to crack the code of — and people continued bravely to pursue these abstract, unthinkable mysteries simply by allowing them to be here, on Her magnificent breast Indiscriminately, the Earth gave the possibility of exploring existential but they reflected his personal experience and contemplation.

genes. Reaching the egg, the spermatozoon becomes still, while the other continues for delivering and spreading the necessary chromosomes and next stage of evolution. Being feminine, Nature creates male beings as differentiate. The feminine energy of creation grants them passage to the and only at later stages of development do the sexual organs begin to mature, all embryos have distinctly (at least visually) female genitalia—Then the embryo develops a spinal cord, a heart, and a brain. In the first

For a time, the fetus resides in the womb, in a tamasic state of darkness.

flesh and organs, the fertilized egg molds the body of the future human. process of development, creating an embryo. Gathering cells and forming mission, the spermatozoon becomes inert, and the egg takes over the the genetic material necessary for transformation. After completing its Only the most fortunate spermatozoon could reach the egg and deliver

know the source and cause of their own origin.

particular class of beings. The spermatozoon and the egg simply cannot knowing neither its sex nor nature, unaware of its belonging to a tamasic state. Any being is merely a combination of sperm and egg. of development, they abide in darkness and ignorance, defined as the are in the second stage of evolution—the state of Rajas. In the initial stage In contrast to this widely held concept, he asserted that all human beings

single lifetime. Everything and everyone had a mixed nature.

created the illusion that a person could pass through all three stages in a inertia. However, he found this interpretation of the gunas too general; it is ascribed activity, passion, and desire; and Tamas, ignorance, darkness, concept of Sattva is interpreted as purity, goodness, truth; the Rajasic state said that the nature of all things is limited by the three Gunas. The represent a coordinate system, a set of criteria, an existential matrix. It is ...The properties of Nature-Prakriti described in many texts—the gunas—

he could employ such methods.

postulates, and at other times the Guru's words stimulated change—and could be provoked by the shock of re-evaluating seemingly unshakable any forward movement required enormous effort. Sometimes progress

energy of Kundalini-Shakti reached the brain. Speaking of the activation spinal cord was the cable through which the voltage of the ascending immortality). Khechari mudra started the engine of the mind; and the was a program that "switched on" longevity (and, in certain cases, the keys to eternal life are encoded in kriya itself. The Narbhi technique At a certain stage of his personal practice, he came to the conclusion that "awakened sperm."

advanced yogis could merge with the Earth, transforming into a kind of comparison was not a metaphor; he quite sincerely believed that resembles the body of a spermatozoon, listeners smiled. But such a ...When he said that the human brain, attached to the spinal cord, spirit with all its baggage of previous karmas and inclinations.

transforming energy is encoded in every body so that it may carry the birth to birth. The binda is an expression of Nature-Shakti, whose of the Antahkarana, the properties of the individual soul that persist from the five forces, five Shaktis, the energies of manifestation and the dualities experience. They defined the bioenergetic channels (Nadis) along with Supreme Reality? The ancients spoke of five Gunas based on personal spirit go? And in what way (if at all) does this binda unite with the awaiting fertilization. Whence does the body come, and whither does the sphere or egg, the cosmic egg of the world, as well as the human egg body, as a model of the greater Universe. Literally, "binda" means a Macrocosm. The "Siddha Siddhanta Padhati" speaks of the binda, the striking accuracy—they perceived the human body as a reflection of the The ancient Maths described all phases of embryonic development with

earthling in active learning and action, in the state of Rajas.

stage, exploration and cognition, seasoned with desire, included every recognize the child, and it can acquire a new worldly identity. At this turn into a child. Only after such a transformation can the "creators." The spermatozoon and the egg can never meet the parents unless they and its tissue dissolves into it after the mission is complete.

competitors (active sperm) perish. The egg accepts only one "partner,"

The story seemed grand, incredible—due to the scale of events and secret of the Three Gunas.

three gunas.” Also known as Turiya, or the fourth state, this is the true transcended the Gunas, becoming *trigunaita*, “one who is beyond the world be the pinnacle of *Sattva* Guna. One born in this way would have egg of the Earth, fertilizing Her with Life. For a *logi*, such an achievement Father, who creates myriad souls to carry His genetic material into the depths of the Earth could become a copy of the Creator Himself. The All-it can be surmised that a *logi* who has undergone transformation in the true Father. As a son (or daughter), he may be His exact copy. Therefore, And, accepted by the Mother, by Her grace, he may be presented to the

Uniting with the Earth, the *logi* acquires a new, as yet unknown form.

Rajas. Then, in the state of *Sattva*, the *imago* transforms into a butterfly, through the darkness of *Tamas*, through the activity and sensuality of changing; therefore, the stage of *Sattva* occurs only after the journey. Passing from one state to another, all living forms are constantly

take control of the process—this was the highest level of *logi* attainment. with the planet; its very presence was a signal for the “egg” of the Earth to expanded consciousness, testified that the person was ready for union that transformed “sperm.” A body untouched by death, with preserved speaking, the incorruptible bodies of ascetics in *samadhi* were precisely because their bodies became inert—simply stilled, not dead. Figuratively in ancient times, highly developed *logis* were buried, not cremated, planet.

developed consciousness, is able to connect with the consciousness of the metamorphosis, and the *logi* body, charged with the voltage of a result of *samadhi*, begins to transform the body for yet another capable of uniting with the largest egg—the Earth. The mind, expanded as which the brain is “charged.” Once awakened, consciousness is fully “sperm-like” state, awakening the activity of the spinal cord, through traditions described the same concept: emerging from the inertia of a of *chakras* and the awakening of *Kundalini* energy, various *logi*

iceberg, triggering an avalanche of new questions and theories. The topic ...The discussions about the three gunas had only touched the tip of the

The Final Transformation

"Why not try to verify it yourselves?"

And if so, can it be achieved in a single lifetime?"

Silence, someone asked: "Is such a union with the planet even possible? consider this concept a fairy tale; it did not concern him. After a long astonishment, and doubt, yet no one was indifferent. Gherics could ...The faces of the listeners reflected varying degrees of disbelief, fittest, but the most intelligent individuals.

become extremely popular. But what survived in this race was not the others conducted "races for peace"; the expression "life is a race" had Everyone was running somewhere; some "chased after the presidency," method—to stop others from unauthorized movements, to limit choice somewhere. But politicians and priests had long tried to use the second trying to hinder the running of others. At least the first method could lead that salvation could be achieved by running as fast as possible—or by mass was no different from the behavior of spermatozoa: people thought At some point, he came to the conclusion that the human mentality in its stage of existence in an airy body.

the soul come to know the continuum of life after passing through the world after transforming into a fully developed human form. So too does and the death of the rest. Gherm could only realize the vastness of the What was the apocalypse for sperm? The survival of one spermatozoon credibility.

legends of gods born of the Earth lent this theory of evolution a level of considerable time to assess it critically. He also believed that the ancient His views on the theory of such evolution developed gradually; it took Proof awaited discovery by practitioners, not by scholarly bookworms. participants; yet this information was obtained by him during samadhi.

embodies Rajas, or the second phase of the great general plan of the soul's embodiment. Incidentally, this is why intrauterine blood is called "Raj"; if for blood is part of the transitional stage of Rajog-guna, which determines. And as long as blood flows in the body, the sattvic state is unattainable, from the darkness of Tamas into the world of sensory cognition, Rajas. transformation from a spermatozoon into human form, all beings are born. The diva had to perform a certain work: after completing the automatically transition into the blissful state of sattva in the astral realm. There was no guarantee that the soul (consciousness) would soul.

history of past contacts with the world remains an integral part of the samskaras follow every soul into the astral world. The indelible, cemented bodies, these spirits were still far from a state of bliss, since kleshas and consequence of their karmas even in their aerial bodies. Lacking physical sometimes he encountered ghosts who continued to suffer as a into a "sattvic" state;

no more? Why does physical death not guarantee an automatic transition constantly in the state of Raja Guna. But what happens when the body is gains an inkling of the state of sattva. In physical bodies, people are being in Samadhi, having transcended the body, from Raja Guna, the yogi assumption, but knowledge from direct experience.

mind was no longer dependent on the elements. This is not a hypothetical tones of absolute freedom from bodily limitations. "Exiting" the body, the everything, although individual memories were preserved, but colored in remained in the bulky chest of the body. Samadhi liberated one from sticky brew of emotions and feelings—all the unprocessed refuse "seen." And in it was everything. Attachments, sorrows, regrets, the thick boundlessness of formless, supportless, pure consciousness could be. When consciousness transcends the body into the state of samadhi, the goodness. This is not at all the case.

leaving the body automatically transitions into the state of sattva, of required deeper explanation, as some students assumed that everyone

of body creation, the nature and the very idea of bodily incarnation. so many souls are sufficiently evolved to perceive the subtle mechanisms bodies, for gradual movement toward higher levels of development. Not only for highly evolved souls. Some lives returned back into human undergoing no changes, renouncing the next birth. But this is possible origin of the gods. And it could decide to remain forever with Earth, discover the essence of life and death, know the nature of divinity and the solely by collective mind. There, in the astral, an indwelling soul could the astral realm there exist diverse worlds, and all of them are created come to understand the meaning of the concepts "heaven and hell," for in consciousness would not be interrupted. Such a soul would inevitably could choose to practice in the aerial body, and the development of this state was not static. If the life had previous logic experience, it and joys were now neatly packed into the continuing consciousness, but worlds," before the next transformation. All its former memories, sorrows, in the newly formed aerial body, the soul hung suspended "between

five elements, sensing, interacting, knowing, and learning to discriminate. physical bodies. Then they would begin to travel through the world of the born on Earth, so that the element of earth would be present in their with a comprehensive education. To attain the highest, spirits had to be present. And, as the keeper of all archives, she provided Her children secret of Earth was that she preserved the past, the future, and the continue their journey, to transition to the next level. Perhaps the greatest Earth is a true magnet for spirits in need of bodily incarnations, to planet.

exist in the astral world, most often in the atmosphere enveloping the the element of air, forming a Vayu Shakti, an aerial body. It will now elements—air and ether—mix with Prana, and the soul attaches itself to burial, or any other method of disposing of the body; the remaining gross elements of the body (earth, water, fire) disintegrate after cremation. What occurs after disincarnation has been described many times: the three development.

When asked about Kundalini, he tried to explain as accessibly as possible.

Earth, Kundalini, Samadhi

desire is never to be separated from the Mother."

this world. A true devotee deserves liberation if only because his soul
to believe this. 'Dying', trees merely change form, like everything else in
perform their tapas here, having taken the form of trees, and I am inclined
considered sacred. It is believed that for hundreds of years, holy ascetics
trees know everything that She knows. Here, in Braj, every tree is
their transformations are pure, and their consciousness is developed, and
plant world. They are directly connected to Mother Earth, the stages of
there is not a drop of karma in them, for there is no blood in beings of the
"Not to my knowledge, no. Perhaps only trees and plants are fully sattvic;
sattvic state not exist?"

...The silence in the room became almost oppressive. "So, does a purely
follow the flow of the Guru's thoughts.

Krishna accelerated the thought process, and gradually students could
overwhelmed by the incredible intricacy of the designs of Creation, but
complex to them. At the beginning of the bath, students were
long before initiation into yoga, such a scheme of evolution seemed
Although most practitioners reflected on the meaning of life and death
bodies) were surrendered to Earth, resting in Her giant ovum.

Ascetics who had entered the state of mahasamadhi (having left their
The continuing living body of a yogin became like a frozen spermatozoon.
To attain the sattvic state in the body is possible in the state of Samadhi.

can they attain Samadhi and unite with the consciousness of Earth.

time developing consciously. Only then, incarnated in a physical body,
must be born and pass through the stages of Tamass and Rajas anew, this
But even for evolved souls, the path to the state of Sattva is long: they

Therefore, not all are ready for the next stage of spiritual evolution.

'Consciousness', for the activation of Kundalini means the expansion of untravel this mystery, the very word 'Kundalini' should equal the full awakening of Kundalini is a long affair. For anyone striving to progressive process, and even after the state of Samadhi becomes routine, experience proves that the awakening of this energy is a gradual simultaneously with Samadhi. Allow me to disagree: my personal There is a widespread misconception that the rise of Kundalini occurs energy, the sequence of processes occurring in each chakra during this.

text nevertheless describes the awakening and ascent of the supreme the awakening of Kundalini: without delving into anatomical details, the The fourth chapter of the 'Hatha Yoga Pradipika' speaks of mudras and method, described in numerous yoga texts.

allegory, but a description of a specific psychophysical process and of Kundalini', and this explanation is by no means a metaphysical this mystery as well. Such is the true meaning of the so-called 'awakening consciousness and energy of Earth, the yogin will be able to understand perfectly aware of the infinity of the Void. Having once 'connected' to the comprehend extraterrestrial phenomena? The planet floats in space: She is essence of the planet. What if this is insufficient, and the seeker wishes to here, in physical bodies, is merely a part of the science of the nature and seeker receives universal Knowledge of Earth. Any wisdom we receive consciousness connects with the consciousness of the planet, and the composed. Thus occurs Prithvi Yoga, union with the planet: thus human rises in the body, activating all five primary elements of which it is connection with the planet. Awakening in Muladhara, the energy of earth body, and a yogin who has 'opened' the muladhara chakra can establish a Earth is encoded in the earth element, a constituent part of the human square with four petals, the symbol of the earth element. The power of energy dormant in the muladhara chakra is usually depicted as a golden the planet itself and its direct connection to Kundalini. The powerful realize the direct connection of the earth element in the human body with "We are all earthlings", of that there is no doubt. But for some reason, few

fantastic texts does not mean it was widespread. It is simply that today
The fact that the phenomenon of the rise of Kundalini is described in
in a thousand years.

the complete and constant 'activation' of this energy occurs once or twice
attained samadhi, only one may awaken Kundalini fully. I can assure you:
energy remains a most rare phenomenon. Of two yogins who have
yogins attain samadhi, the complete ascent and stabilization of the risen
I have met no one whose Kundalini was fully awakened. While some
purpose;

repeated journeys through life and death, in order to finally realize one's
die. Is this not the eternal and unattainable dream of humanity: to stop the
the quality betwixt existence, he is no longer obliged to be reborn and
Kundalini grants immortality: the yogin attains eternal youth, freed from
The original sources of yogic texts mention that the awakening of
acquires its divine aspect.

into the skull, into Sahasrara, and beyond. It is thus that consciousness
'cleared, Sushumna, meeting no obstacles or blockages, and rises upward,
into muladhara, 'unlocking' it. The unified pranic energy enters the
through the 'heart knot', then 'pierces' the navel, or Nabhi, and descend
acts as a fuse and ignition key, and the fused Prana and Apana pass
This process is both simple and divine simultaneously: Khechari mudra
physical aspects of the greatest yogic mystery.

Kundalini, and such an explanation will suit those interested in the
together and redirected into the Sushumna, Prana and Apana form
blockages and obstacles from the path of the ascending energy. Fused
the Sushumna. The preparation of this channel consists of removing
inertia of the subconscious. But before it awakens, it is necessary to clear
'challenged'. The practice of yoga is nothing other than a challenge to the
similarly, consciousness rises and expands when it is provoked.
When a snake is struck with a stick, it rises and straightens like a rod.
consciousness.

wished to see the origins of knowledge always dug deep. The history of Benares, the city of scholars and the cradle of knowledge, those who discussing the famous text from a completely unexpected angle. In light on Hatha Yoga," let that day the mahamahopadhyayas were about the Hatha Yoga Pradipika. Of course, he knew and had read "The of consciousness. It was there that he heard one of the strangest stories extract necessary arguments, the scholars were clearly in an altered state shloka, quoting passages in the purest Sanskrit, turning to Vedic texts to extraordinarily pure vibrations. Effortlessly moving from shloka to sat down on the floor. The atmosphere in the room was filled with discussion, surrounded by seven or eight attentive listeners. He directly appearing around ninety years old, were completely absorbed in a lively one of the houses, he was led onto a terrace. Two elderly people, only led him confidently through the narrow lanes. Soon they knocked at less than a 50-minute walk from Chausatti Chat, and the accompanying and perhaps you will hear something useful..." The required place was "They are the last of the true experts: go to them while they are still alive,"

Teacher knew them all.

British rule. In Benares there were several scholars of this rank, and the titles to experts in the Shastras, and the tradition was preserved under famous "mahamahopadhyayas." The rulers of ancient India gave such Satyacharan Lahiri insisted that he also visit the Sanskrit scholars, the ... A little over a week had passed since the visit to the Ashram, and Shri

Hatha Yoga Pradipika and the True Mahavedha

will help them reach the goal."

primary sources, intense sadhana, and the guidance of a knowing Guru must find a worthy guide and study the road maps. Information from Masters. And yet the complexity of the task should not stop seekers; they adherence to the highest standard of techniques laid down by the ancient esoteric lineage. The seriousness and depth of this subject require discussed, and Kundalini has turned into a 'spiritual commodity', part of knowledge has become more accessible, the term has become known and

He practiced until initiation, and then, with the practice of Kriya, he mastered the basic rules: pranayama, breath retentions. Thus inflexible, but within three to four months he learned to perform most of the book. There were only sixteen of them. At first, the body was stiff and he also attempted to perform the postures indicated in the book. Several group members were trying to directly connected to the teachings of the Natha Yogis, but at the time the manual on Natha Yoga was written by Satmarana, and the text was Pradipika in Hindi, translated from Sanskrit. The classic fifteenth-century In 1885, having joined a Kriya Yoga group, he read the Hatha Yoga

Even the shadow of Truth lay closer to Her than everything else.

the original source, whether it be the original text or the primordial idea. Later became a tool of his own teaching methods: one must always turn to and explanations of certain Sanskrit terms led him to a conclusion that analysis

translate logic texts. This story, together with the extraordinarily deep Both respected scholars agreed that non-practitioners cannot successfully conclusions, and incorrect interpretations.

an academic who never became a yogi set forth only assumptions, false on this text in 1883. From a logic perspective, they were utterly useless: Pradipika." Being a Sanskrit scholar, he published his own commentary asrama, appropriating the original manuscript of the "Hatha Yoga could not accept such a way of life. In the end, Brahmananda left the still unattainable, the daily routine irritated him, and his inflated ego After about five years, Brahmananda began to worry: enlightenment was performed other mental work, and the Natha patiently observed him. You will become a Nath." The novice washed dishes, cooked, and asrama agreed: "Good, you may stay, and if you meet the requirements, Satguru asrama. There he asked for initiation, and the Mahant of the decided to become a Nath yogi and set off for Haridwar, to the Satguru Somewhere at the end of the 19th century, a man named Brahmananda the text itself was quite unusual.

the only thing that mattered, and he did not care about the impression he remained in Padmasana for six to eight hours every night. Sādhanā was respected masters hardly spent long hours in logic meditation. He with worldly affairs and the management of their organizations, these ceremoniously seated at satsaṅgs with crossed legs. Yet, being occupied gurus and swamis, adorned with flower garlands, in ocure robes. His relaxed manner of behavior differed greatly from the style of other they secretly wondered whether this Guru could sit in the lotus posture, and was perfectly aware of what some visitors thought. Looking at him, his legs stretched out on a coffee table, jokingly calling it "Guru-asana"—same thing. For years he perfected a semi-reclining pose on a couch, with and the logic journey into the central channel, into Guḥyumanā, meant the Middle Way, the first teaching given by the Buddha after enlightenment, boundaries of the possible and urged others to do the same. For him, the reach the limits of the possible in sādhanā. Here he went beyond the Moderation in everything was the prerogative, except in the striving to in that interval between exhalation and inhalation.

way to summer heat. One simply had to find a point of support and exist followed exercises with heavy Indian clubs—mudgats, winter mist gave polarities and stability of emotions. Padmasana, the lotus posture, good. Flexibility of the body and steel of the muscles, observation of with kettlebells and barbells developed endurance. Both approaches were isometric principles, strengthening ligaments and joints, while training compensation for the load on the nervous system. They worked on Yet, alongside strength training, some āsanas were an excellent back muscles also increased, and the practice of āsanas became a memory. extent that he could no longer perform padma-padmasana. The lateral routine. The intensified weight training expanded his repertoire to such an and now only mudras, padmasana, and naḥi were part of his logic After his first samādhi, he focused on strength training instead of āsanas,

book. The Hatha Yoga Pradīpikā was the primer of Kriyā Yoga.

gradually developed an understanding of the mudras described in the

Modern practicing yoga specialists believe that Mahavedha activates the distorting mirror of ignorance and ambition.

It is a perfect example of a reshaped truth and of how it can turn into a exist." That day, the students first heard the story of the true Mahavedha. know certain things to save time and effort, and for that, original sources only through practice, through your sadhana. Of course, it is better to the teaching and techniques come from is good, but true discovery occurs need to endlessly seek additional sources of revelation. Knowing where he added: "If you have received initiation into the practice, there is no Babaji himself. No one knew how to react to this statement. After a pause, Svaminama, the author of the Hatha Yoga Pradipika, was none other than no less interesting revelations: one day he casually mentioned that dared to ask in what form and exactly when. Moreover, there were other. When, after a long time, permission to continue the work came, no one details.

will understand the essence of the teaching. There was no need to go into said that the truth is set forth in the original Sanskrit text, and the wise received a signal from Babaji not to do so. The Guru of the parampara an exact translation of the shlokas and commenting on this text, but he course of kriya practice. Twenty years ago, he had thought of publishing Every asana and bandha described in the text was performed in the new interpretation of the Hatha Yoga Pradipika as a guide to Kriya Yoga. seemingly well-known asanas. It was then that the students first heard a dictated progressively and evenly, explaining the hidden meaning of with the magic of knowledge, intoxicated by its taste, perceived anew. He following his explanations in the light of kriya. Everyone was charged pranayamas with Khechari mudra, tying certain postures and mudras, and practicing kriya for several years. Now they were performing they were masters of bodily yoga, performing the most complex asanas to the Hatha Yoga Pradipika. Young, full of energy and inquisitive interest. In the winter of 2013, Ukrainian students began asking questions related made on others.

raised into the nasal passage. Then the tongue begins to "stroke" the brain the breath, and sitting in Padmasana, with the tongue in Khechari mudra, Mahavedha is to be performed with the hands folded in Namaste, holding

can find an image of the frontal lobes of the brain – it resembles buttocks. region." In any anatomical atlas and in every medical reference book, one gives another meaning – "tongue." "With bhūman strike the rib-like bhūman, literally translated as "earth." But the Sanskrit dictionary also hands together," not "place them on the ground." Then comes the word The original shloka of Mahavedha states: samahastayugḍ – "bring the and taught others were grotesque and sad.

seriousness and bombosity of the "yoga gurus" who performed this asana terms, but the translator understood it completely incorrectly. The against the floor. In the original text, the brain was described in precise as... buttocks. And so modern yogis began to lift their ribs and slap them description of two parts of the frontal lobes of the brain being translated as proposed by ignorant translators. The misinterpretation began with the in the practice of kriya) had nothing to do with bouncing on the buttocks, without questioning the meanings. Mahavedha (the second Narhi kriya on the ancient manuscript, everyone began to meticulously follow it, was grotesquely distorted. But since this was the first known commentary manuscript, stolen from the Matha ashram, the meaning of Mahavedha help but laugh. In the translation and commentary on the original compared it with the widely known version of Mahavedha, he could not In 1986, having analyzed the true meaning of the Sanskrit shlokas and

Mahadharma chakra, one is supposed to awaken Kundalini.

cushioning effect in the sacrum. Doing all this and concentrating on the onto the floor in the lotus posture with the help of both hands creates a ground while holding the breath. The lifting and "throwing" of the body themselves up, and begin to progressively slap their buttocks against the instruct students to sit in Padmasana, place their hands on the floor, lift united brain and apana move through Sushumna. Most yoga teachers Kundalini energy at the base of the spine, in the root chakra, and helps the

fragile balance of races and cultures. They did not lose their identity together and united kingdoms and peoples, helping to maintain the countless processes in motion. Perhaps the "Law of Repulsion" held shuffling the cards of human history, this same force of "repulsion" set collide with other celestial bodies, since they mutually "repel" each other and planets at a distance. Such a force could be the reason they do not professor, he suggested that gravitational "repulsion" might keep the stars among hypotheses and secondary topics. To the surprise of the esteemed lecture. Somewhere in the middle, he stopped following the meaning, lost an extremely complex answer, which turned into an almost two-hour planets not eventually collide, crash into each other? The physicist gave inquired: if gravitational attraction is so great, why do all the stars and Once, while discussing the law of gravity with an American physicist, he Samasric wheel. Indeed, what binds and holds this world together? action, that cause and effect are merely the edges of the rim of the reaction. This also means that every reaction causes an equal and opposite Newton's third law states that every action has an equal and opposite

The Law of Repulsion and Shuffling in Time

November 3, 2014.

The commentaries on the Hatha Yoga Pradipika were published on conscious mind became subconscious. And vice versa. waves. Then the yogi could enter a superconscious state, and the exhalation, the brain returned to a semi-active state, awakening theta sky. Brain activity decreased, yet the body remained alive. After death." Absolute stillness of the mind, beautiful and infinite like a clear down, and the practitioner could experience a temporary state of "brain consciousness. The brain waves, stimulated by Khechari mudra, calmed revelation. When performed correctly, Mahavedha had an effect on mercilessly bounded their posteriors against the ground in robes of amusing error crept into well-known logic texts, and thousands of people (the rib-like region – the frontal lobes of the brain). Be that as it may, this

experience the Present in its pure form. Everything, absolutely
The imprints of past and present karmas do not allow the mind to
self-bitly or hated.

personal history of experiences and memories, avoiding deeply rooted
to observe the present objectively, without becoming entangled in the
The body always carries individual karma. Separation from it allows one
stepping out of the physical sheath, overcoming the limitations of form.
The present can be lived in its fullness only under the condition of
everything, getting to the roots, to the very essence.

developed logic mind, and that is precisely how we approached
if all the details of the past are known. This is an excellent task for a
To what degree is it predictable? Only under the condition of objectivity,

states, traditions) originated in the past, history, to a certain extent
postmarks on the sealed envelopes of bodies. So, if everything (cities,
are encapsulated in the living. All previous incarnations are watermarks,
frames and the duration of previous lives. The past karmas of ancestors
past. Human bodies are also an expression of the past, measured by time
Undoubtedly, the Earth is the most ancient being, embodying its own

withing worm, bait on a fisherman's hook.

difficult, but no one can maintain it for too long. Human history was a
history is always written by the victors. Achieving objectivity is not so
manipulated, and conclusions are adjusted by modern historians, since
fit the political and national needs of the moment. Any data is
unique feature of human intelligence, but most conclusions are tailored to
ability to analyze and draw conclusions is undoubtedly a brilliant and
preserved in archives was the greatest joke humanity played on itself. The
striving to survive and begin anew. The knowledge of the collective past
of "Repulsion" created new "centers of attraction" for various communities
Today, the main rule of the new game became decentralization. The "Law

power, and by centralizing, they rejected everything foreign.

because they resisted invasions, gravitating toward the unifying force of

an effect of rejection: the spirit no longer considered the body fit for
are confined in bodies, the present did not exist. Natural death is merely
understanding the laws of the movement of Time itself. As long as souls
the era of the Mahabharata, into the Jurassic period for the sake of
he could see the past, penetrating into the times of Jesus or Buddha, into
could choose any period of time to visit. Having fully known the present,
advanced practice of surfing in Time. Possessing such a skill, such a yogi
could attract the attention of the Masters, and they could teach him the
And yet, a yogi knowing the experience of navigating the subtle worlds
the present was too selfish to be interested in its own origin.

looked upon this conception in disbelief and sometimes with disgust, and
perceived simultaneously: the past conceived the future, the future
which was an expression of the past. Perhaps everything always
future. It freed consciousness from the physical limitations of the body.
For him, Samadhi was the key to understanding both the present and the

past has already determined the future. Everything was possible.

simply moves through the amplitude of the ripples of Time, where the
probable events that are about to occur have already occurred: the world
all notions of time and space. And some philosophers have claimed: the
writers and scholars have asserted that causality metaphysically precedes
chain of events leading to a possible future. Perhaps this is why some
are in the past. The final effect also triggers other processes, building a
the base of any process lie the causal factors that trigger it, and all of them
goes deeper, to the roots of any beginning, to the primordial instincts. At
This is a fairly broad and widespread phenomenon, but the logic mind
intuition is necessary.

world unfolds, and to grasp the truth, to catch a glimpse of tendencies.
The law of cause and effect is merely an abstraction, pointing to how the
humanity is the acknowledgment of the past and its continuous analysis.
experience, and therefore total cognition is exclusive. The ordinary path of
distinguish, evaluate, and draw conclusions is based on previous
everything, is a representation of the past. The human ability to recognize,

forces and universal laws, they inevitably reached a dead end: they lacked did not recognize allegories. But when scientists tried to speak of higher discoveries in mathematics, astronomy, and physics, and these sciences Over the last couple of centuries, the world has developed thanks to continued to seem like flowery poetic gibberish.

words, and even after translation into modern Hindi or English, the text uninitiated, the parallels and metaphors of the text remained a play on discovery, left for future generations of yoga practitioners. For the represented merely a linguistic curiosity. But it was a treasure awaiting its primitive archaic folklore. For most academic researchers, the text The secret language sounded descriptively simple, and many took it for meanings of the "Corakr Bodh" somehow never came up.

Lahiri Mahasaya, and various Puranic texts with his disciples, the hidden Satyacharan Lahiri often discussed the Bhagavad Gita, the diaries of texts could only be explained by a practicing Master. And although Shri "imaginary" worlds that were neither invented nor entirely real, and such inaccessible to the uninitiated. The encoded slang spoke of "real" and Tantrics and alchemists. Such texts were intentionally written in a format texts, the "inverted" language was invented by yogis. They were the first Mathas, was a complete enigma. Often used in Tantric and alchemical The twilight language, or "sandhya bhasa," spoken by the immortal puzzle.

metaphors and hidden meanings presented there constituted a seductive fascinating, simple, and yet complex to understand. The play of poetic dialogue between Gurur Matsyendranath and his disciple Coraksha, about one hundred and thirty shlokas, written in archaic Hindi. It is a entitled "Corakr Bodh" ("The Enlightenment of Corakr") contained rubees for a thin little book whose content proved invaluable. The text More than 40 years had passed since, in one of the bookstores, he paid 5

Twilight Language

further journey.

means discouraged by the lack of recognition, the Spirit continued to wait with its worshiper. Often this waiting was in vain. Undetected, but by no means called "foolish," for it dwelt in the temple of the body, awaiting the meeting of the immortal substance dwelling within the body. The Spirit could safely be put into an ally and the effort of establishing a friendly relationship with the Spirit. Special attention was paid to the necessity of turning the body's physical aspects of the body's capabilities required for the awakening of the awakened. Despite its allegorical nature, the text described the purely logical science of the eternal alchemy of the indwelling mind was the eternal Spirit. Beneath the layer of the twilight language of the text, the highest goals of yoga, the life of consciousness, and the essence of the being continued in a multitude of others. "Cosmic Body" described the body and unstopable, it is like life, death, and breath. Life interrupted in one. For the ancient siddhas, the continuity of Creation was obvious – ongoing body's death also signified the departure of the Spirit.

They were loving spouses, whose separation at the time of the physical elements it generated. While Prana and Apana dwelt in the human body, parents of unborn sound, of the play of sound with the primordial consciousness perceiving this reality of Time and Emptiness – the eternal originated. "Cosmic Body" spoke of physical reality and the vibrations, which created Matter, from which the tangible world multivalent metaphors. They spoke of the condensation of sound and its To explain the origin of the world from a single source, the Mathas used yoga himself into "alchemical gold."

ancestors and teachers. Luck, perseverance, and will could transform the ingredients: life circumstances, karmic predispositions, and the grace of the body and mind of the practitioner himself. Together with other raw material for the experiment is quite accessible – Prana and Apana, crystallize, and distill the Spirit that filled the crucible of the body. The alchemists of consciousness knew that yoga-sadhana could condense, Consciousness dwelling in every living being, the Spirit. However, yoga's knowledge of the fundamental component of being, the Universal

The logic commentaries on the original text were published in 2017 under the conversation allowed.

to them in practice was patiently explained as accessibly as the context of different degrees of their own awareness: what had not yet been revealed listening to words inaudible to others. The disciples' questions revealed the answers poured forth as if he were reading an invisible book or him: years of Kriya practice allowed him to rely on personal experience. commentaries to the book began. The text was no longer a mystery to meaning. Other questions followed, and in 2012, full-scale work on the properties of Prana, citing some passages from the text and revealing their asked about "Corakhi Bodhi" in 2008, and he gave explanations of the structure and format to turn into a continuous narrative. He was first As with the commentaries on the Cita, his thoughts were only waiting for and yogi – offered enough material for the experiment.

someone decided to choose such a path. Life itself – the greatest alchemist transmutation of the material body into an immortal one occurred. And it words of the ancient Nathas, simultaneously with cognition, the was revealed exclusively through sadhana. While the spirit listened to the immortality, no more, no less. The meaning of the intricate metaphors magic of such a union, this was a practical recommendation for achieving the mind, will no longer leave you." For practicing yogis, aware of the Teacher will change places, and the spirit, having become the disciple of and then it will become the Guru of your mind. Then the disciple and the Matsyendranath advised Corakhanath: "...make the spirit your friend – prepared.

developed consciousness could decipher its meanings. And then magic twilight language of the text was such an artful code that only a extracting the gold of knowledge through painstaking refinement. The regeneration. He gave them the necessary formulas, and now they were sublimation, and some of the disciples passed through the same stages of His personal psychophysical transformations were the steps of alchemical move from body to body, settling in different "sanctuaries."

Question: How is yoga changing today as a cross-cultural tradition? How uncompromising?

traditions in the modern world. The answers were direct and tradition, its indestructible component, and the place of spiritual Yoga Shailendra Sharma, was asked about the essence of the logic and informative film, the only one among the film's participants, Guru of Indians, an Australian, a Briton, and an American. At the end of the long filmmakers interviewed renowned yoga teachers from around the world: entitled "Yoga: Traditions Through the Eyes of Modernity." The ...In 2013, a group of yoga enthusiasts released a documentary film

does this mean the freedom to interpret and modify the teachings? fill their reality with its meaning. People tend to analyze postulates, but captured the very essence. Any tradition is alive only thanks to those who preservation of fire." Whoever the author of these words may be, he composer Gustav Mahler: "Tradition is not the worship of ashes, but the There is an excellent aphorism, often mistakenly attributed to the

Tradition

audience?" – "They will become shastras."

do you think about the future of your books, will they ever attract a wider practice and consolidated by knowledge. Once someone inquired: "What and every idea presented in the books was filtered through many years of Right Hand of God" and "The Urbanishta of Immortality." Every word and the Hatha Yoga Pradipika were followed by two books – "At the commentaries on the Bhagavad Gita, the Shiva Sutras, the Yoga Sutras, The collection of his literary and philosophical works grew: the logic as a catalyst for realization.

stimulated new perception – and the metaphorical nature of the text acted immortal teacher in Mahurgha that sowed the seeds of new inquiry, Matsyendranath himself. He believed that it was the day of meeting the that this work would not have been accomplished without the blessing of the title "The Twilight Language of Cosmic Body," and he was convinced

off.

dependencies enveloping the consciousness of the practitioner were cut society. Thus, the tentacles of thousands of obligations, attachments, and this was the only way to break all the threads that bound the yogi to interaction with laypeople was limited to collecting alms and food, and home and family, sever all ties with society and dependence upon it. tradition, has been preserved for centuries. In the past, a yogi had to leave relationships and interaction between Guru and Disciple, the logic disciple, he must make yoga the goal of his life. The system of the disciple is the one who performs it. After the Guru has accepted the disciple. The Guru is the one who gives the teaching and the practice, and Yoga has always been a system of transmitting knowledge from Guru to the Guru-disciple system still lives.

strictest discipline. According to the ancient tradition, in this Sampradaya end, until they attain liberation. To those who are ready to observe the of the true teaching is revealed only to those who are ready to go to the the Maths. The Sampradaya of the Maths exists even today, but the debt by Matsyendranath and Gorakhnath, it is transmitted through the line of Adi Guru, the First Math and the First Teacher of Yoga – Shiva. Continued

Answer: There is only one Yoga, the Yoga of Advaita, the yoga of the in the West originated in the 20th century;

Question: What then is traditional yoga, if all its directions known today understanding of this ancient tradition.

directions of yoga. However, at present, people have no clear parts of one system. The Yoga of Patanjali is the foundation of all other Karma, Bhakti, and Raja Yoga have always been streams of one river and **a complementary discipline.** It is one and only, integral and inviolable.

Answer: Yoga was never merely an ancillary,

Western culture influence modern Indian yoga;

is this tradition assimilated by the minds of Westerners, and how does

First and foremost, we are human beings. From time immemorial, Yoga is a path.

So, when Yoga is not intended exclusively for representatives of only one and agnostics live and die by the same laws, this is indisputable. And it will happen to him after he leaves the body. Hindus, Muslims, Christians, all live. Yoga helps to understand who a person was before birth, and what life is. Through this system, the yogi experiences death while still alive. Yoga is the only thing that can give a person the opportunity to realize one's leaving the old shell behind.

in a relatively similar manner. The spirit that dwells in the body always moves through more or less the same physiological cycles, and then dies in a new body. A teacher must ask themselves: what is it for? People are born the same, live and die the same. Teaching the most important thing, its true purpose. Any honest yoga teacher will give different results. Sometimes I ask myself – are we not missing in this discipline. Therefore, different degrees of immersion in Krishna Yoga yield different results. This teaching is intended for all, but not everyone can follow the strict discipline.

to overcome limitations through the body and mind. They must become new followers appear and disappear, but yoga still has its main goal: to transcend. religious change, new gods replace old ones, messiahs and prophets, as it continues even today. The general principles remain the same. cannot be called true yogis. Nevertheless, the original tradition will live on. ancient, traditional yoga, those who live in society and are connected to it through yoga as a path of self-development. And yes, from the point of view of materialism, people leave home and family. And yet, true seekers should try to follow the path of tradition. Of course, a modern person cannot completely leave society, consumption has become a commodity. I consider this a direct violation of the path. profitability. Today, yoga, accepted and adapted for modern society, everything according to its own needs, as it is based on the principles of yoga, inevitably modified by society for commercial use. Society reshapes yoga in the 20th century. It is well known that any teaching and invention is a process. Modern yoga in the form it is known today in the West was formed in the

saints who created the original system of yoga studied throughout their and algorithms, different goals and sets of moral codes. I believe that the and a different type of thinking; it worked with various mental imprints clients. Traditional Hatha Yoga was intended for flexible Indian bodies more they adapted their methods to the psychology and physique of new

Answer: The more Indian masters came to know Western people, the methods.

developed and supplemented the teachings given to them with their own system. All the famous yogis of the 20th century had Gurus, but they himself and "improved," "added to," and modified fragments of the someone who took the authentic knowledge of yoga, transmitted by Shiva

Question: In many branches of 20th-century yoga, there was always unchanged: he must transmit this knowledge.

utterly unique task of yoga. The traditional role of the Guru remains To know God, first and foremost by knowing one's own Spirit – this is the of the Creator of this very spirit.

Spirit, which is that very essence capable of leading us to the knowledge path. However, no religion teaches one to realize and approach one's own promising the attainment of nirvana, grace, and bliss at the end of the Religions teach following different deities, observing certain rituals, while own Spirit;

How can we call ourselves spiritual people if we have still not met our senses and the mind, trying to know the infinity of existence and itself. Each incarnation, through the physical body, the Spirit learns through the garments and taking on new bodies in the course of endless rebirths. In invisible being living within everyone. With the Spirit shedding old opportunity to become acquainted with one's own Spirit, the ancient spiritual system is more than banal self-gratification. It provides the and the same), yoga imposes the duty to maintain discipline. This integral ambitious goal of self-knowledge and knowledge of God (which are one anyone to receive its grace. Upon those who are ready to achieve the has recognized this simple fact, equalizing the rights of everyone and

evolution: the birth and spiritual quest of Logamanda, his inspiration and levels: scientific, social, moral, ethical, and mental. Let us try to trace the at higher goals, at the development of humanity. And it occurred on all human history can be viewed as a "logic breeding program plan," aimed With a certain degree of pragmatic objectivity, this particular segment of

incarnation of these souls is fulfilled, Krishna Yoga will again leave society. Personal opinion, or rather, feeling, is that when the task of the Krishna Yoga was reintroduced to society. Such was Baraji's plan. My logis were awaiting birth to change the world. That is precisely why fulfill their subsequent missions in human bodies? The spirits of many these new highly developed souls come into the world? How could they families of logis. And if there were no logis among laypeople, how could practiced in the fire of logic practices in previous lives, must be born into practitioners. Why? According to the Bhagavad Gita, advanced logis, logis depended on the current situation in society, on the mental state of ordinary people striving to know the extraordinary. The return of this unchanged. However, the process itself became accessible to laypeople. **Answer:** No. The technical side of the practice of Krishna remained

introducing logis to laypeople. Is this not a change in tradition? permits practiced logis. Then Lahiri Mahasaya took on the mission of **Question:** One hundred or two hundred years ago, only sadhus and regardless of the seeker's individuality.

methods of enlightenment by those who calculate annual revenue the same spoon. Nevertheless, a commercial price tag is added to certain And this is an individual approach, not an attempt to feed everyone from of knowledge and in what volume he can transmit to a particular disciple. disciple is individual. Therefore, the Guru must always decide what level called true Gurus. Of course, the physical, mental, and social level of each change the tradition to suit the needs of the modern "client" cannot be experience and proven by their own achievements. People who try to effective for achieving the goal. They left knowledge tested by their own lives and came to the conclusion that only this specific method was

complete lockdown again circulated. In terms of tension and anxiety, second wave of COVID, a curfew was again imposed, rumors of a The celebration of Ashvini's seventh birthday coincided with the

The Beginning of a New Era

events," from a dialogue of Shailendra Sharma with disciples clearly seen from the future. But it is the past that determined today's the Puranas a thousand years ago with absolute accuracy, as if they were "We live in Puranic times. Why? We are experiencing events predicted by

*

Waves of the Future

With Blackie, 2023

Shailendra Sharma, 2024

French politician Jean Jaurès.

historians claim this is an abbreviated version of a statement by the "Tradition is not the worship of ashes, but the preservation of fire" – some

the shared responsibility of Guru and disciple.

awaken their spirit. And to explore further. This process will always be attempting to realize the body through logic asanas also have a chance to Of course, few strive to know their spirit. Nevertheless, all those

is the eternal connection between body and spirit.

will not lose its significance, no matter how many changes it undergoes. It breathe, to comprehend and consciously know the essence of Prana, yoga teaching of yoga is eternal. As long as people continue to be born and Traces of human evolution inspired by yoga are everywhere. I think the spiritual giants, for it was they who inspired scientists and humanists. The new world in which we now live is driven by the minds of many

subsequent generations. Remember his book on Steve Jobs, ask;

goals of knowing the Divine changed the lives of millions, including

core, India could always survive on its three "C"s: Crat, Crawal, Crasbat. here, in India. Besides, food itself was never a problem. Agrarian to the culture that became popular in the West in recent decades never took root here. No one was ready to live in a punker atmosphere. The survival dwellers, company employees, business owners smiled and nodded bobbed places and stock up on supplies for at least a year. City ...For many years he advised disciples to move away from densely cities."

"Continue practicing, strengthen your immune system, stay away from

"But what to do now, in the face of real danger?"

"This is just a stage, it too will end..."

fleeing. Again and again he repeated to his dejected listeners:

of everything, absolutely everything. Life, death, illness, and health are unshakable ednanimity reflected the deepest awareness of the transience without emotion, but not at all from a lack of compassion. This suffocation. Listening to all this calmly, he replied ironically, almost about sick relatives and friends, messages about high fever and add optimism. The incessantly ringing phone delivered alarming news turned right on the sidewalks next to overflowing crematoriums did not Fear was mainly stoked by the mass media, but the sight of bodies being remain the same.

normal. This he could not promise, as it would be untrue. Nothing could glimmer of hope, the certainty that everything would soon return to over their respirator masks were fixed on the Curu. People needed a the rooms of the huge house with joyful cries, the gazes of all the adults While the children played hide-and-seek and tore open gift boxes, filling emanated from people.

anxiety hung in the darsan hall; dense and suffocating waves of fear however this time the number of sick and dying sharply increased. Stikly April 2021 in northern India equaled the spring of the previous year,

Reaper, the pandemic held up a mirror to reality to show humanity the evolution by her own unique method. A dutiful assistant to the Great over the ruins of civilization. Hired by nature herself, Mahamari stimulated remain the pushings on the wheels of the chariot of world order, joining progress, and increase the resilience of humanity. Epidemics and wars cataclysms bring about changes that mark new epochs, accelerate. There was nothing new under the heavens. It is well known that

standing to her full height, she began to reap a bountiful harvest.

When the Goddess of diseases ceased to hide behind minor seasonal colds, frequent, but were not excessively alarming, until the winter of 2019, Ebola and epidemics of various strains of influenza had become more coming changes, though without specific dates. Since then, outbreaks of specifically to Moksha Bhumi? It seemed he had been informed of the immense to be influenced in any way. And yet, why did Mahamari come their messengers need no approval from mortals: such forces are too Mahamari asked his permission to begin her work. Of course, gods and preparing for its world tour eight years ago, on that fateful morning when Deep in his heart, he was convinced: the current pandemic had begun disease.

solved as they arose. In Brazil, there were almost no cases of the new gather their harvests and tend their herds. In the villages, problems were the genetic memory of epidemics, famine, and drought, continued to batavia that had paralyzed the city dwellers. The farmers, who carried ...its cycles. There, the news of the deadly virus did not provoke the

to live in unity with nature and

yet, in villages, remote jungles, and distant mountains, people continued schemes eating away at the system, from weariness of life and fear. And from the virus, but also from a lack of empathy and hope, from corruption away from densely populated cities, where people were dying not only isolation became a necessity, and it was safer to wait out the uncertainty. But now these advices resonated with the sudden events as never before.

Yes, nice, read...

previous century. The body of the Earth was constantly and compared to the extraction of the same minerals (oil, gas, timber) in the extraction of natural raw materials exceeded all conceivable volumes modernity in the scale of exploiting natural resources: the annual of raw materials. No civilization of the past could compete with breakthroughs of the 20th century accelerated the industrial consumption of the epithelium and deeper tissues of the planet. The technological resources, disrupting the ecological balance and destroying the integrity current problems could be caused by the aggressive extraction of natural ...However strange this hypothesis might seem, in his opinion, the relativity itself was the motto of existence.

stood Matter, Time, and Emptiness. Everything was relative, and this commensurate with the scale of society's interests. And above all this perception, in which the scale of an individual's joys and sufferings was deepened immensely. His assessment of Big History was based on logic. Through logic-sadness, his knowledge of history and philosophy had whole.

the present, whether concerning human society or life on Earth as a any versions and assumptions about the future, about its emergence from one of those who scan the horizon of what is to come—he was open to. Never considering himself a futurologist, a perspectivist, or a predictor—merely trying to describe the stages and cycles of impending change. systems... There was nothing apocalyptic in these reflections; he was before they occurred—of epidemics, wars, sudden reforms of financial thought and spoken of possible cataclysms (natural and man-made) long. The current turn of events neither shocked nor surprised him. He had

role, unless they make a substantial contribution to the entire ecosystem. everyone that people are merely a part of Creation and play no special random mass eviction of souls mattered not. The pandemic reminded methodically and thoroughly: whether it was a planned depopulation or a vices and virtues. The Great Epidemic carried out its mission intricately intertwined roots of the collective unconscious, with all its

implementation of a new ethic. Another possible scenario relied on the general). However, the pandemic forced the development and improvement on all levels of human activity (though this sounded very strange. One path of development could be the refinement and humanity that stood at a crossroads, contemplating the possibility of insignificance. The planet has always managed to save itself. It was human civilization is simply incapable of this due to its own nature, although the participants in the debates failed to notice that Collective discussion and attempts to "save the planet" are, of course, humanity into the ebb before a new wave.

follows the crash of a tsunami, when the current of Time will sweep the end, modern civilization will be forced to undergo what usually spirits, but even they were not immune to hardship and deprivation. In suggested. This would inevitably cause a shortage of new bodies for new. It could (or even should) disappear for a time, as some eco-activists ...The notion that humanity is a virus that needs to be contained is not and governments have managed to do over the last 60 years.

vanished. No civilization of the past polluted the planet as the countries silently screaming soil... Each day, another bird, animal, insect, or reptile name of pain, momentary gain. Polluted air, dying vegetation, the exploitation of the Earth, people poisoned the land and themselves in the died out because of aggressive resource extraction. Besides the mindless peoples have disappeared due to war, pestilence, and famine, but some followed, sweeping away entire civilizations. Of course, it is known that something that could seriously affect the planet's ecosystem, catastrophes were depleted beyond a certain limit, whenever people initiated There existed a recurring historical tendency: whenever natural resources society and immediate, instant profit.

rarely conducted internal audits to assess the balance between the good of exploitation, pollution, and destruction of nature, governments extremely bidding the wave of expansive globalization, accompanied by the unceremoniously cut, drilled, torn apart. Her blood was sucked out.

could cleanse the electoral processes so that decent and qualified people and the protection of citizens. Improved democratic electoral mechanisms expertise could be reduced to maintaining infrastructure, law and order, option. Ideally, in a decentralized future, the spheres of government self-sufficient. Given current trends, this would be the best possible post-apocalyptic at all, but thriving. Secluded, but not isolated; small, but in a couple of decades, people might prefer life in such communities—not harsh times, old ideas were putting down new roots.

businesses and structures will become predominantly local. Tested by communities will consist of neighbors, and the most vital life-sustaining the first signs of a turn towards rudimentary decentralization, in which decisions to ensure the survival of the inhabitants. Perhaps this is one of person. During the pandemic, it was they who were forced to make of elders; they were headed by a sarpanch, an elected decision-making immortal, village affairs have been handled by panchayats, or councils grassroots forms of governance have always existed. In India, from time throughout the world, in most rural, tribal, or indigenous settlements. These thoughts might seem naive, outdated, or utopian, and yet tested for strength and viability.

clearly receding into the past, while familiar social structures were being infrastructure, social initiatives. The days of global governance were easier to maintain (and contain) all necessary needs: services, think about decentralization. Within local, small settlements, it is much If human communities failed to benefit from expansion, they began to profit from any situation. The reaction to the pandemic was no different in death at any moment...“ And yet, it is in human nature to find ways to wear masks, avoid contact, touch nothing with bare hands, fear breathing...News feeds continued to scream of impending danger: “Stay home, human drive for self-destruction were eliminated.

exclusive. They could proceed in parallel, if the notorious factor of the influence, to try out new pastures. Both approaches were not mutually main impulse of human nature: the readiness to fight for new spheres of

point, all mammals cease to depend on mother's milk and begin to forage will learn anew to relate to Nature, rather than plunder Her. At some ignorant of the surrounding world will become impossible, and people all levels would be quenched. And, probably, it is then that remaining gold has yielded profit, the eternal passion for satisfaction and possession on It remained to be hoped that in thirty years, when everything that can be digitalization with lightning speed and incredible zeal.

attention during the pandemic, and they mastered all kinds of from tangible reality. The material, tangible world again seized people's meanings by expanding virtual perspectives, making people look away means. And, like a seasoned card sharp, modernity created new, artificial presented a staggering multitude of new digital applications, tools, and turned into necessary tools for survival. Indeed, the last 10 years have previously created a feeling of invulnerability and total control, overnight world, be heard and informed. The marvels of technology, which had in the midst of total isolation, people could remain connected to the technologies became experts in online interaction and remote work. Even the internet. Those who had previously shown no interest in new isolation could have become a real torture, were it not for the wonders of ...Meanwhile, the helplessness forcibly learned during the times of self-

fast. Time was conceiving itself anew, to give birth to a new era.

embrace, and both looked expectantly at their brother and parent, the radically and irreversibly. The Present held the Future tightly in its toxic must be left behind, amputated, remade. The world was changing forty years. But for this to happen, everything outdated, superfluous, and positive transformations should occur and become tangible in thirty to understood the benefit of change and welcomed it. As far as he could tell, could not come to terms with global metamorphoses, and for those who The coming years promised to be dramatic for everyone: for those who transparent. Who knows, the history of humanity is still relatively short... turning into skeptics) insisted that politics could never become could truly contribute to governance. Although realists (invariably

In any era, the spiritual life of a person is permeated with a special

A Brave New World and the Birth of Spirituality

acquiring memories, so one of its names was Consciousness.

to shed worn-out bodies and move on, expanding experience and and passed through countless deaths, wars, and epidemics. It continued contact with their own spirit. Because the spirit had known many births reminding that objective perception of reality is possible only through experience of life itself. His work was not to console, but to remind. To wondered whether there was any meaning in human life beyond the In those days and months, permeated with uncertainty and fear, many

humanity will preserve its place among other species.

may, the new era was approaching swiftly. And it is unknown whether environment also meant the loss of deep, primordial wisdom? Be that as it intuitive enough to notice that the loss of direct connection with the new (and revive old) methods of interacting with Nature. Are people The question is whether they are intelligent enough to evolve, to refine mindfulness, giving people a chance to become truly conscious beings. ...ness. And this awareness will stimulate the development of

of life as the most precious of all earthly possessions.

He believed that through trials, people would become more acutely aware gift, a secret treasure sewn into the hem of Mahamari.

only a multitude of possibilities and tendencies. And yet, change was a the present. Forecasting models have a large degree of error and outline future is unknown, as it is always perceived through the murky lenses of humiliating and senseless death in overcrowded hospitals. Ultimately, the the moment. In April 2021, people simply wanted to survive, to avoid a view, these forecasts were not directly connected to the urgent needs of reflected in silence that the predicted changes were too far off. In their ...Puzzled by such distant prospects of normalization, the listeners

for food on their own.

Enlightenment, against which Modernity so consistently opposed. Post-post-religious uncertainty, an obvious departure from the program of the and old-fashioned. It is quite logical that postmodernism gave rise to where former moral guidelines and boundaries are declared irrelevant disintegration of ethics pose a real threat to a rapidly developing world "prejudices." The interruption of traditions, general disorientation, and the by readily renouncing spiritual values, modern man frees himself from "old morality" and the newest practicality.

recreated only for the convenience of orientation among the ruins of the of the human mind, the new "hells" and "heavens" of modernity are spaces of uncertainty. Stimulated by the constantly renewing adaptability the ability to perceive symbols and ideas of the divine) has exposed an man does not understand how "rationalism" (which has nearly destroyed on this necessity is quickly filled with social myths and clichés. Modern intellectual need for faith remains, but the niche for thoughtful reflection death and rebirth, human faith is as ancient as the earth itself. The grain of the harvests. Bound to the changing seasons and the cycles of the soil, entered the streams of rain, and lived within the capsule of each primordial rhythm. Rooted in the traditional way of life, it sprouted from hope. Untroubled, it still flourished in villages, in harmony with of city dwellers, to occupy the remaining space between pragmatism and In megacities, faith suffocated, trying to squeeze into the dense schedules for the seeds of faith to take root.

change and shift. Perhaps because the soil had become too dry and acidic which the need for spiritual development and growth rested began to grow in our time. At the end of the last century, the very foundation upon effort, but about the barrenness of the soil in which human faith must the presence of meaningful faith, which requires enormous spiritual religious context familiar to the society of the past. This is not even about world, active spiritual seeking is largely conditioned by the loss of the conditional yet quite real horizon awaits approach, if not touch. In today's unattainable in this life, may draw nearer in the next incarnation. This intuitiveness that sets a course for further development. The divine,

political programs and religious authorities. To question any information revise and deconstruct everything – from image and cultural tradition to through the deconstruction of religion. There is a growing tendency to experiences and metaphysical revelations. Today, it educates itself Being an active state of the soul, spirituality strives for extra-physical suspicion.

The establishment still views uncontrolled and eclectic spirituality with ally – religion. For this is a proven and convenient system of mind control against new ideas, new blood, new players. Therefore, it protects its old bath. Archaic by its nature, statehood believes it must defend itself modern spirituality. And this rebellious child stubbornly chooses its own A product of social development, religion has become the aged parent of interfaces. Tunnel vision replaces panoramic perspectives.

religion assimilates a set of postulates with recognizable and convenient attempt to reach distant horizons. They can only contemplate them. Post-are not actually encouraged to lift their heads from their phone screens or and modalities. Along with the expansion of access to information, people desacralization. Actually, this is characteristic of many things, concepts, This approach makes post-religion the peak of the global process of rarely rises above the second floor.

model of such a concept resembles shopping malls, where the consumer horizontally oriented perception, without delving into details. The very Tradition leading to the Divine. Everything is smeared across a simplified imitation, not allowing the exploration of the verticality of worldview. Today, religion consistently reduces true spirituality to a realities as multiple, subjective, and dependent on the individual's century, are becoming obsolete, and postmodern systems of thought view Postmodernist ideas, which dominated the second half of the 20th offers surrogates instead of Tradition.

claiming the role of spirituality in a globalized and secularized world, it to various forms of imitation and simulation of faith. Successfully religion, modified according to the needs of modernity, constantly turns

portfolios, and form unique individual fashion styles, then they may well their bodies and sexual preferences, manage their personal financial growing cult of individuality. If contemporaries are encouraged to know this knowledge is becoming a priority even from the perspective of the striving to know the spirit, not the Holy Spirit, but the human spirit, and modern cultural landscape. God-seeking is slowly being replaced by the and more people believe that it is spirituality that should inherit the spirituality has never been "organized" due to its abstractness, and more clarification of existential meanings.

require a new and modernized moral goal-setting, along with the rapidly, as if trying to catch up with new technologies, for they too orthodox belief systems (on many levels, on all continents), began to grow new 21st century, a certain spiritual impatience, a thirst for change in ensure a better future for states and nations. In the first decades of the But even then, the periodic "renewal" of gods was a necessity that could Most organized religions arose in times when monarchies already existed.

partitioners question and dissect the very necessity of faith.

the opportunity, agnostics and mainly the new generation of potential aggressively, as fatigue and skepticism grow among consumers. Seizing disguised and carefully thought-out prohibitions: it sells itself less operates through hidden persuasion, veiled suppression, and well-way, appealing to morality and loyalty to long-established values. It elements. Religion resists this process, defending itself in every possible last longer. A wide highway is laid over an old path to withstand the with the ultimate goal of building something new, something that will Deconstruction always has a purpose. An old building can be demolished

individual beliefs.

ethics looks like an attempt at repression, suppression, or manipulation of bias of the mind and may be subject to deconstruction while an appeal to perception of truths, has become popular. Everything is perceived as a collage out of it. Skepticism towards moral guidelines, a cynical or doctrine before discarding it or having ground it into pieces, making a

form of spirituality, Hinduism does not limit the range of beliefs. In India, choice but to profess tolerance towards all forms of the divine. An ancient life, a state of the soul. The multiplicity of Indian gods leaves people no sale. It would be a mistake to view Hinduism as a religion – it is a way of part of the Hindu tradition, no matter how skillfully it is repackaged for (Sankhya, Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Mimamsa, and Vedanta), Yoga remains Rooted in the philosophy of Hinduism as one of the six darshanas needed except a qualified Mentor.

between Guru and disciple, and for this journey, no intermediaries are continuation of the ancient path, maintaining an unbreakable bond connection of the individual spirit with the Supreme Soul. This is a Siddhanta, the taught discipline is considered the science of the the crude and rather disappointing reality. In the Academy of Siddha all are created to believe and dream, to imagine something greater than Being a Guru, he knew: all people carry the seeds of faith in their hearts,

network is located beyond the carbon-based universe.

is a Wi-Fi connecting a person to their own spirit, and the server of this journey ensures a reliable connection with the Divine. Modern spirituality protection is no longer required. Being in the bosom of the church no establishments. There is nothing wrong with this, but today such provided protection for taxpayers who were "regulated" by religious managers of the past who were in the service of statehood. States current religious foundations were invented and perfected by efficient The Spirit no longer needs to force itself into the shackles of religion. The came?

gods themselves arose only after Creation, so who truly knows from where It But who can say, From where this all came, and how creation happened? For the chapter of the Rig Veda hints at this:

The immortal spirit was born even before the gods appeared. The tenth all, few doubt that It is present within every living being. study the intention of their own spirit, its aspirations and desires. After

aging of others and follows established and expected processes, weekly timekeeper exists thanks to the body, which gathers data by observing the

What will it orient itself toward? The internal landmarks. Now, spirituality is becoming the marker of Time's flow. Throughout history, religion has provided the most significant alike. The sensation of Time is blurred mainly due to the loss of traditions, happened long ago, and are therefore perceived as abstractly relevant and events of 60 years ago and 600 years ago are largely similar—they all on historical archives and one's own imagination. For most young people, aspects of change. In the absence of comparable experience, one must rely purely intellectual, since life is too short to contain and understand all person simply knows that history continues to change. This perception is ...The strangest thing about people is that they cannot truly feel time. A

conditions the beginning of a new cycle.

grandeur of many religions; any revision of belief systems inevitably metamorphoses. The soil for spiritual growth is fertilized by the past to adapt to a rapidly changing world, and adaptation stimulates inner investigation of the inner "self" transforms the seeker. A person is forced form, it must cease to be a seed. In the same way, the search and Having united with the soil, the seed grows into a tree, to assume a new respect in order to be transformed through the process of transformation. And be firmly believed that a person must complete himself in every ...it.

find the Spirit within oneself and to realize (or actualize) new bodies had the opportunity to fulfill the purpose of incarnation: to He considered Yoga to be the immortal soul of this subcontinent, where inquiry, not a rigid set of once-established rituals.

Sanskrit Dharma. It is a continuous process of exploring truth through an organized system of beliefs, but the path of dharma is the eternal path, the difference between dharma and religion is never confusing. Religion is

resignations: each new ruler brings his own team. In the time of the shifts in the astral hierarchy are akin to corporate appointments and but even they are subject to radical changes.

their pacification. The laws of the subtle worlds are complex and harsh, relied mainly on the help of living relatives and rituals performed for toward whatever egregore they had been drawn to in their past life. Souls welcome and protect newly arrived souls, and over time they drifted they worked in other "astral departments." In general, there is no one to other realized mortal masters in the astral world proved nothing. Perhaps who pray. The fact that during his time in samadhi he never encountered (collective or individual) exert a therapeutic effect exclusively on those prayers over the planet are exaggerated. As far as he could tell, prayers Assumptions that enlightened masters hold a protective shroud of their

The Lottery and the Prize

universes awaited an awakened mind capable of discovering them.

changing world, new codes of the sacred arose. Myriads of inner awakening is destined to become the dominant trend. Along with the apocalyptic meanings would prevail. One thing is clear: spiritual understanding of reality or whether new religions, mystical, and ...He did not try to guess whether humanity would develop a broader

disassemble the universal construction set.

observes the birth of worlds and new species, continuing to assemble and bloodily, yet Time is least concerned with pain. As a true scientist, it which were the engine of humanity's progress. These cycles are quite struggle of different principles, the battles for resources and minds—all of lens of Kriya, he learned to observe the collisions of old and new, the the continuity and wholeness of Time. Studying the world through the predictable narratives, yoga led him toward a gradual understanding of and chose the path of yoga. Deconstructing habitual patterns and ...Many years ago, he left home, abandoned his accustomed way of life,

allowing time to seep into bone and flesh. And could it be otherwise?

something about this planet that made it a center of unflagging interest. Earth is not merely part of a portfolio of celestial real estate. There was
souls are not uncommon.

worlds. However fantastic this may sound, mass deportations of such natural disasters, so that their souls could be "deported" back to their terrestrial offenders were meant to die during wars or as a result of

to avoid their sentences, were born as humans. These extracame here for various reasons. Some were fugitive criminals who, trying timelines and countless dimensions intersect and merge. Astral beings on human affairs, since the planet is a transit hub where six different The struggle of celestial entities for dominance exerted a strong influence

system of world order, which continued to reveal itself to him. Anyhow, he was content with his personal understanding of the complex these views as extravagant theories. Never trying to convince or impress affected events on Earth. It was entirely unimportant if some interpreted the reshuffling in the hierarchy of astral rulers and how these shifts their motives and goals. Over the last thirty years, he had spoken about ghosts, and their masters. The life of astral inhabitants is as complex as observed and from time to time communicated with various spirits. No, he had not watched too many science fiction films, but merely higher forces.

only by karmas and intentions, but also by algorithms programmed by course of events. The role of the individual in history was determined not scientists, inventors and poets, dictators and dreamers who influenced the era; the ark of civilization remained afloat thanks to murderers and tiny and initiating significant changes in the world. Besides them, in all

Most obeyed the call, fulfilling their desires, representing the interests of the gods consciously (or against their will). In the subtle worlds. Some of these "double agents," knew of their tasks and (such as Arjuna, Karna, Krishna) carried out the will of the rulers of the Mahabharata, avatars and children of Deities born from earthly women.

Wars of the East, the current conflicts marked changes intended to reset it. It cannot be said that this confrontation was so inevitable. Like countless confrontations, and self-defense.

Vigilance over years of prosperity, had nearly forgotten the science of war, fight for survival, attacking a weakened democracy that, having lost ground, without hidden or overt causes. Dictatorships and autocracies, twentieth century. Geopolitical transitions never occur without fertile Europe and the Middle East, grotesquely reflecting events of the early civilizational frameworks began anew, with military conflicts in Eastern when 5055 began rattling quite real, albeit rusty, weapons. A revision of The world had not yet fully recovered from the shock of the pandemic to prove its effectiveness and viability.

exposed, its values challenged. And yet, capitalism as a system continued modern history took place. The vulnerability of Western society was recovery. And then, on September 11, 2001, another turning point in significant shifts occurred, stimulated by people's hopes for healing and... After the Second World War, the world changed, sig-

are always hidden, but the prize is great.

many hints and allusions confirming this fact. The identities of the players inevitably rules the subtle worlds as well. The Indian epics provided departures were faltering. One thing is clear: whoever controls Earth Resources were sufficient, but the logistics of incarnations and timely Recently, however, planned reproduction has spiraled out of control.

program of reproduction, since spirits constantly need new bodies.

subtle worlds, humans are merely livestock carrying out a continuous university, a vast cinema and a torture chamber. For the inhabitants of the the Garden of Eden, a laboratory and a refuge for refugees, a prison and a and revered Her because she was everything at once—a giant womb and allowed even the highest spirits to incarnate. Astral rulers cared for Earth For the gods, she is a deity, a conscious being whose power and energy and attention for immortals, gods, lower and higher spirits, and demons.

of Time indiscriminately ground both the subtle and the coarse, seasoning for the inevitable finitude of bodily incarnation. The relentless millstones into the astonishing diversity of worlds. Of course, this is not a banal concentrated clusters and contours of elusive Time, allowing a glimpse from past incarnations. The magical kaleidoscope of this yoga revealed essence, realizing the wholeness of one's "self" as the sum of experiences dwell. Kriya led to another kind of satisfaction: remembering one's own the ocean of thoughtlessness, where no memories of past personalities. One of the exquisite pleasures of life is to forget one's "self," floating in

Remaining Desires

was filtered through the divine will of Time itself.

actions of individuals, communities, and countries. As always, all of this determined by collective karma, composed of mosaics of intentions and There was never absolute predetermination in history. Its course was

and struggle.

spiritual mentor, he supported all disciples in moments of pain, darkness, changes taking place, and to live through them consciously. And, as a see a broader picture of the world, to realize the global nature of the allowing no multi-variant interpretations. And yet he urged students to spiritual and moral views, the transition of epochs sharpened dualism. Having clearly delineated the foundations of morality, ethics, and

the birth of a new era promised to be difficult.

eight. The birth pangs of the old world were becoming more frequent, and future were spinning again for millions of people, and no winners were in countless combinations in a giant Nintendo. The betting pools of the In the subtle worlds, this organized tragedy was perceived as one of modernity could drag on indefinitely.

relatives killed each other, and the struggle between archaism and moral paradigm. The battle of Kurukshetra began anew: prophets and and accelerate the development of society, to revise the spiritual and

his chin did gray appear. Shaving made this marker of time insignificant. Once made. His hair was still coal-black, and only in the stubble on parbells, and mudgats kept his body in excellent shape, according to a tingling sensation. His gait was steady, daily exercises with dumbbells, subsidize the years spent in the lotus posture resonated in his muscles with ...Straightening his legs from padmasana, he waited for the numbness to remained ridged.

The emerging contours and forms were recognizable, yet the essence garden. The photographic film of life developed slowly, in the old way. German Shepherds chased the same monkey through the overgrown front of the house had grown threefold, and the fourth generation of come with her parents now held her own baby in her arms. The old tree in yesterday was about to retire. The former chubby little girl who used to with grown children, or even grandchildren. The pushing youth of torn cloud-tubes. Years passed, and suddenly someone would appear and grosts sometimes fashioned hammocks or camouflage veils from His ducks pecked at them. Then Time was hung to dry on stone balustrades, nets were left to soak in a pond, where apathetic fish and indifferent ...At times it seemed that swastika triumphed over Time, and His tangled consciousness is ready to absorb the new.

ing explosion of Truth. This usually happens when a mature defocus, only to experience a blind-substances, objects, and seasons: dropping all objectivity, thought would abandon attempts to grasp the meaning of the infinite transformation of familiar and eternally alien to the mind. In the end, the mind would life is insufficient for a full inventory of these concepts, simultaneously every object and being, awaiting transformation, if not recognition. One milestones. All forms are transient, but brass, Time, and Emptiness live in with the same basic force: the reaper and the grain, the miller and the Everything and everyone is created from the same substance, saturated the grind with the bittersweet pollen of emotions and unfulfilled desires.

of the cenotaphs and spread through the intricate network of garden the swashman, and only the nectar of silent bliss filled the stone honeycombs time scale. The existential toxicity of being pierced the invisible shield of inhabitants of the swashman, as if its residents lived according to a different changes in the external world had not the slightest influence on the mentioned, for they were connected with astral events. It seemed that demanded flexibility and timely planning. Other duties were never concentration, disciples needed attention, and household affairs relentless. Zaynana required a clear schedule and unwavering To those around him, his days appeared serene, yet his duties were

flow. But moments of complete peace are brief, even for the renounced. metal in the gold prospector's sluice as a reward for having witnessed its projections. Thus a river glides over pebbles, leaving grains of precious mind through the sieve of the present, leaving behind all memories and of any person. Befriending them is not difficult; one need only pass the ...Peace, obscurity, and the absence of cares are considered the best friends

toward an invisible line. The transition to rootlessness awaited everyone. where this leads us." Any assertions are banal. All living beings moved question of the finiteness of all things remained suspended: "Let's see movement was the most important part of the soul's education. Often the most effective method of knowing Time. Perhaps the awareness of His ultimately submitting to His supremacy. And the process of aging is the through the filters of Time, everything was dissected and studied, combination has a special zest, a unique fragrance. Everything passed between them can be perceived as something repetitive, but each The diversity of human archetypes, events, and the interconnections already seen or experienced.

that from a certain point, everything seems a reflection of something peculiarity of age (simultaneously a curse and a blessing) lies in the fact ...like the changing of seasons, rather than as a destructive force. The

Apart from these nuances, he felt the fluid elusiveness of Time rather

understanding of the global interconnection of things, elements, and at the precision of this science. It burned away illusions, granted and was simultaneously simple and complex, and he never ceased to marvel ...The system of comprehending the world through self-knowledge, Krishna results of their karma, he responded.

segments of recognizable reality in which he could discern the causes and show them the way. Sometimes, if they were somehow connected to Yes, he could feel and hear their pleas; they begged for help, asked him to of thousands of trembling and sobbing souls;

manage to guard his heart from the impact of mass despair, from the pain sensitivity could break even the most steadfast mind? How did he hear their final thoughts—or did he consciously block all this, since such People died en masse and daily. Did he feel the waves of their suffering, literally, with the loss of his own weight and health.

to desperate pleas, he could take on others' illnesses and paid for this pain," while still allowing the flow of compassion to manifest. Responding inexplicable, and he had to learn to suppress these attacks of "shared tearview mirror had split open his forehead. Such sporadic episodes were alarming news: their nephew had just been in a car accident, and the those present. Someone's phone rang, and a family from Bengal received his fingers: they were smeared with blood. In bewilderment, he scanned Once, during darsana, involuntarily touching his forehead, he glanced at

so, did he feel their emotions? Yes, if he permitted himself to.

words just uttered in their minds. Did this mean he read thoughts, and if answers echoed their own thoughts, that they were composed of the very suffering of others? Sometimes people in the room noticed that his —there is too much pain in the world. But how sensitive was he to the them entry. This is precisely why he never ventured beyond the territory and pain and despair would have become so as well, had he allowed Over the years, his emotions became refined, elevated, even exquisite—

baths.

this land, he proved the opposite.

suffering and despair could dwell. By dedicating his life to this yoga and in the last 30 years, he managed to survive and thrive where only sincerity of intention and openness of heart.

vocal cords. All that is expected of people coming to this Teacher is believe, not religious to pray, for the song of the heart has no need for who took initiation into this yoga seriously. One need not be a believer to The teaching received here transformed the minds and destinies of those unconditional compassion for all.

Sakti, the swamian insisted on the most severe honesty with oneself and great swamian ocean stretching beyond the gates. The abode of Giva and the treacherous and murky, yet in many ways predictable, waters of the ground required greater courage and rather discipline than navigating statement, everything was precisely the opposite. Living at the cremation he preferred life on the swamian..."" Despite the playful tone of the "This book is about a coward who was so afraid of the external world that with a smile: "If you decide to write about me, mention the following: In the winter of 2008, in the midst of a lively discussion, he suddenly said

Flame and Embers

Mother forever.

Earth, floating in the embrace of the Void, and to remain with the Great remained, there were few: to continue listening to the lullabies of the toward new incarnations or toward final liberation. As for the desires that to nearly forgotten dreams and memories of their true Self. To lead them preserve the tradition, and to awaken those who sought to give meaning His own mission had long been clear to him—to continue this yoga, to the astral plane.

everyone had its place and purpose—both here, on Earth, and there, on processes of life. It also removed uncertainty, since everything and forces, and an awareness of one's place in the complex symposium of all

detailed questions about the specifics of samādhi. So far, Shailendra astral into the subtle worlds—and return with sufficient experience to ask are welcome here. And yet, no one has yet dared to venture into the inquiry. In essence, any interesting conversations and engaging debates criticism of these narratives are quite natural, as they are part of a greater critics. What happened, happened—that is all. Disbelief, doubt, and admiration, and these narratives have never been softened for skeptics or Time itself. The stories of his adventures need no one's recognition or of public ostracism, and continues to be tested. Not by people, but by to circumstances. His life has been tested and tempered by the acid times. Almost everything in the life of this biography's hero happened contrary souls of the dead and for some of the living.

The place is intended for yoga and discipline, for spirits and gods, for the few can accept the invitation to live there, teach, and worship the gods, a few can activate it. Everyone eventually comes to the samādhā, but only a towards the light of a thousand suns. Śāśmā exists in everyone, but only possesses the potential to open to the ascending splendor of Kṛṇḍālmī. Śāśmā[√] is concealed within the body. This mystical channel The metaphysical aspects of the samādhā are concealed just as right here, behind them.

gates without even suspecting that the greatest modern yogi-mystic lives Mokṣa Bhūmī, is securely hidden from view. One can walk past the old to practice this yoga will find their own way to him. The land of liberation, devotees. Guided by the invisible compass of karma, all who are destined self-promotion. There is no need to attract even more pilgrims and The Director of the Siddha Siddhanta Academy deliberately avoids any

unnoticed in the shadow of far more significant forces and events.

happened before. Meanwhile, both he and the samādhā continue to exist withdrawn, suspended, and its return may take several centuries, as has journey's end. It may be that the authentic version of Kṛṇḍā will be continuer of the lineage, to the samādhā, to the place where all earthly He himself believes that Babaḥ did not accidentally lead him, the last

At some point, people will be unable to move forward in their
is here, on Earth.

human spirit will replace organized religions. The Kingdom of the Spirit
deity lives in everyone, and over time, the power of the strengthened
until the Spirit itself becomes the Teacher for the practitioner. The inner
connection between the soul and its creator, between *Atma* and *Atman*—
The knowledge of one's own Spirit opens the possibility of a trusting

this path differ from religion?

discoveries define the general direction, but many still wonder: how does
increase in the number of practitioners. Conjectures, hints, and personal
evolutionary tool, although its mystery remains unsolved, despite the
the next meeting with Mahavatar? *Kṛiṇā* proved to be a most powerful
Who knows, perhaps the results of the practice are the very condition for
Babaji. The first effects of this yoga may become noticeable after 15 years.
Nine years have passed since he began the special practice prescribed by

thoughts about the future, he keeps them to himself.

Shailendra Sharma prefers to know, rather than to guess. Whatever his
such a spiritual tradition usually ends after three generations. Curu
next Teacher. Succession is permitted within the Teacher's family, but
Only Babaji holds the answers; only the parampara decides the fate of the
command of unknown forces.

still calls those who are destined to come. Or releases them, following the
A ritual is significant only as long as it is performed. This mystical place

this Curu await his disciples there, in the light between lives?

awaken new seekers to the infinity of lives, not necessarily earthly? Will
invoking *Śiva*? Is there someone destined to continue this tradition, to
the mighty *ṛjā*, blow the bull's horn, light the *diya*, and beat the drums,
...What will become of this place in 30, 80, 500 years? Who will perform

(undoubtedly no less captivating than his own).

Sharma awaits the aspiring yogis of realization to tell their own stories

conscious, and one can enter a state of samadhi. Life at the that consciousness will be awakened. Then the subconscious will become Path, he meant Jñāna... Activation of the Middle Path (Jñāna) means or the Middle Path. Perhaps when Gautama Buddha spoke of the Middle spirit, can navigate the astral world. Jñāna is also called Madhya Marga yogi. All spirits will recognize him, because, being alive, he, like any and Ahimsa have entered it), then the astral world will be open to such a awakened to spiritual spheres. If Jñāna is 'awakened' (meaning Prāna attachments are left behind, where you are dead to the world but ready to enter Jñāna, to come to the samadhi, where all worldly Ahimsa is one of the names of Jñāna. When Prāna and Ahimsa merge, they are Jiva and Jñāna dwell. Interestingly, Prāna is one of the names of Jiva, and this assertion. One of the terms for Jñāna is 'samadhi', the place where Jñāna is actually the samadhi, and there are metaphysical parallels in enjoyment), and then one can avoid Death... Advanced yogis believe that passage of Prāna, and the mind becomes free from all bonds (objects of names of the same thing... Jñāna becomes the main road for the Brahma Bandha, Maha Bandha, Samadhi, Samadhi, Madhya Marga – these are essence of Jñāna. Haṭha Yoga Pradīpikā states: 'Jñāna, Jñāna, Pradīpikā and this is a serious topic for reflection for all who seek to understand the Jñāna: "Haṭha Yoga Pradīpikā compares Jñāna with the samadhi – [v]: Samadhi and Jñāna – from conversations with Sri Shailendra

Gratitude

essence of the fire.

die down, but the embers always continue to smolder, preserving the The fire of this mystical yoga, kindled many centuries ago, may eventually revelation for all sentient beings.

described—but the knowledge of ourselves will become the greatest later, the main component of the Universe, dark matter, will be meaning of life. What discoveries will help humanity evolve? Sooner or continue considering accumulation and consumption as the main development without a higher purpose, and it would be too primitive to

Sumit Jadia for the photographs and cover design ideas; Milan Atmanov Kalta and Deepak Kumar for years of friendship and support; and also proofreading; Anastasia Leonova, who worked on the footnotes; Anju Koshrukhova, Zatyagit Chakraborty, and Carly Buford for final editing and first edition of the book; Olga Vafova, Padma Kulkarni, Natalia Avezisova for her invaluable contribution to the design and editing of the fruition; Danielle Gauderville, my first reader and editor; Angelina working on the book, contributed to it, and helped this project come to I would like to express heartfelt gratitude to all who supported me in Gurur's home became our spiritual home.

Devahuti Pathak, Gurur's sister, known as Mataji. With her blessing, the Together with other students, over many years I have felt the support of life, and sadhana continue to guide hundreds of his students and friends. I express my deepest gratitude to Gurur Shailendra Sharma, whose grace, life she gave me.

I am forever grateful to my mother, my First Teacher, for the love and the It seems it happened of its own accord.

of weaving a story from scattered words still evokes bewilderment in me. The mechanism of inscribing glyphs onto paper is simple, but the process thirteen years. All the stories told here are true.

interviews with Gururji Shri Shailendra Sharma, collected over the last The material for the book came from audio recordings of darsanas and windowpane, peach sand, and several palm leaves in Coimbatore were used. notes, two iPhones, two computers, one laptop, one fogged-up silence of the royal swamshan at Coimbatore. For writing these sketches and plains of Uttar Pradesh, in the shade of the trees of Bangalore, and in the along the bumpy roads of the Russian hinterland, on the sun-scorched riverbanks, in the New York City subway, on the back seat of a car racing This book was written on airplanes, at train stations, in trolleybuses, on swamshan provides such a transformation."

shailendrasharma.com Yogirajshailendra.com

Other books and publications are available at the websites:

Curaji with the author, Covardhan, 2008

professor at Christ College in Bangalore.

lived and worked in India. She currently teaches architecture as a visiting
her own logic commentaries. For the last 12 years, Katya Mossin has
Russian translation of the poems of the Kashmiri yogini Galla Ded with
from New York. In 2021, she published *The Song of the Naked Heart*, a
Her stories have been published in the collection *Lost and Found: Stories*

Covark Bohm, *The Unfinished of Immortality*.

Shailendra Sharma: At the Right Hand of God, *The Twilight Language of*
edited (and also translated into Russian) some of the works of Shri
Shailendra Sharma. From 2011 to 2021, Katya conceptualized, structured,
In 2008, she began practicing Kriya Yoga under the guidance of Curaji
countries.

profession and her love of adventure, she has visited more than 20
in numerous projects in the USA, Eastern Europe, and Asia. Thanks to her
she worked in New York as an architect and urban planner, participating
Architecture from the Moscow Architectural Institute. Beginning in 1990,
Katya Mossin was born in Moscow and received a Master's degree in

About the Author

Jai Curujdevi

awakens us so that we may see the infinity of our spirit.

the heart composes silent lines of gratitude to the Curu. To the one who
...In search of the right words, we turn to the inkwell of the mind, while

continue to walk the path of yoga today.

for the layout of the Russian edition of the book—and to all those who
for the retouching and proofreading of the photographs. Julia Yakovleva

Λακωνίερα

Κοσμηκμονα: Editing: Olga Aatova, Irina Vidrelich, Layout: Julia
Translation into Russian: Katya Mossin, Olga Aatova, Natalia

Contributors to the Book